← Previous📚 OverviewStanza 2 →

Stanza 1 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this complex opening stanza from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece":

"FROM the besieged Ardea all in post,"

"From the besieged Ardea": The story begins in the town of Ardea, which is under siege. This immediately establishes a scene of conflict and tension.
"all in post": Meaning "in haste," or "urgently." Tarquin is traveling with extreme speed. This immediately suggests a purpose, a mission driving him forward.

"Borne by the trustless wings of false desire,"

"Borne by": Carried or propelled by.
"trustless wings of false desire": This is a key phrase. Desire is personified as having "wings," adding a visual and suggesting the swiftness and potential instability of Tarquin's motivation. "False desire" reveals the destructive nature of his lust - it's not a noble feeling, but something deceptive and ultimately harmful.
Literary Device: Metaphor (desire as having wings), Personification (desire), Alliteration (trustless).

"Lust-breathed Tarquin leaves the Roman host,"

"Lust-breathed": Tarquin is defined by his lust. He is literally "breathing" it, it consumes his very being.
"Tarquin leaves the Roman host": Tarquin, a member of the royal family, abandons his military duty. This highlights his prioritizing of personal desire over duty.
Literary Device: Alliteration (leaves, lust).

"And to Collatium bears the lightless fire"

"to Collatium bears": Tarquin travels to the town of Collatium.
"lightless fire": This is a powerful metaphor for lust. It's a hidden, dangerous passion that can destroy. The lack of light suggests darkness, secrecy, and moral corruption.
Literary Device: Metaphor (lust as lightless fire).

"Which, in pale embers hid, lurks to aspire"

"Which": Referring to the lightless fire, the lust.
"in pale embers hid": The lust is not yet fully unleashed. It's smoldering, hidden, and potentially dangerous.
"lurks to aspire": The fire of lust is waiting to become more intense, to consume. "Aspire" suggests an upward movement, a reaching for its goal (Lucrece).
Literary Device: Imagery, alliteration (lurks, lightless).

"And girdle with embracing flames the waist"

"girdle with embracing flames": Further development of the fire metaphor. The lust is now represented as encircling Lucrece. The flames will embrace her.
"the waist": A reference to Lucrece's body, foreshadowing her violation.
Literary Device: Metaphor (flames), alliteration (flames, waist).

FROM the besieged Ardea all in post,
Borne by the trustless wings of false desire,
Lust-breathed Tarquin leaves the Roman host,
And to Collatium bears the lightless fire
Which, in pale embers hid, lurks to aspire
And girdle with embracing flames the waist Of Collatine's fair love, Lucrece the chaste.

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"Of Collatine's fair love, Lucrece the chaste."

"Of Collatine's fair love, Lucrece the chaste": This establishes the target of Tarquin's lust: Lucrece, the wife of Collatine, and emphasizing her virtue as "chaste".
Literary Device: Antithesis (contrast between "fair love" and "chaste").

Overall Meaning:

This stanza introduces the central conflict of the poem. It sets the scene: Tarquin, driven by uncontrolled lust (his "false desire"), abandons his military duty and rapidly travels to Collatium. His lust is portrayed as a "lightless fire" that he carries with him, a dangerous force that is hidden but smoldering. This fire is personified and presented as a threat that is about to envelop and destroy Lucrece, emphasizing her virtue and the impending tragic consequence. The swiftness of Tarquin's journey and the intensity of his desire create a sense of impending doom and foreboding. The stanza uses rich imagery, vivid metaphors, and personification to convey the destructive power of lust and the vulnerability of innocence.

← Previous📚 OverviewStanza 2 →

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← Stanza 1📚 OverviewStanza 3 →

Stanza 2 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Shakespeare's stanza from The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, identifying literary devices:

Line 1: "Haply that name of 'chaste' unhappily set / This bateless edge on his keen appetite;"

Haply: Perhaps, maybe. This introduces uncertainty.
"name of 'chaste'": Refers to Lucrece's reputation for chastity. The use of quotation marks emphasizes the word as a label or description.
"unhappily set": Ironically or unfortunately caused. This creates dramatic irony; Lucrece's chastity is the very thing that fuels Tarquin's desire.
"This bateless edge": This refers to the unrelenting sharpness of Tarquin's desire, a "bateless" edge meaning one that is never dulled. This is a metaphor.
"keen appetite": Tarquin's intense, insatiable lust.

Line 2-3: "When Collatine unwisely did not let / To praise the clear unmatched red and white..."

"When Collatine unwisely did not let": This describes Collatine's foolish act of praising Lucrece's beauty. "Did not let" means he refrained from nothing in his praise.
"To praise the clear unmatched red and white": This is a description of Lucrece's beauty – the "red and white" referring to her complexion (red cheeks and white skin). The words "clear" and "unmatched" highlight her exceptional beauty.

Line 4-6: "Which triumph'd in that sky of his delight, / Where mortal stars, as bright as heaven's beauties, / With pure aspects did him peculiar duties."

"Which triumph'd in that sky of his delight": Her beauty "triumphed" or reigned supreme in the "sky" of Collatine's admiration. "Sky" is a metaphor for his affections or gaze.
"Where mortal stars, as bright as heaven's beauties": Lucrece is likened to stars ("mortal stars"), surpassing even heavenly beauty. This is a metaphor and simile.
"With pure aspects did him peculiar duties": Her beauty captivated Collatine completely; her "pure aspects" (appearance and demeanor) "did him peculiar duties" – meaning, they compelled
him to focus solely on her and praise her, almost as if they were bound by some involuntary obligation.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza establishes the crucial catalyst for the tragedy. Collatine's innocent, albeit ill-advised, boasting about Lucrece's beauty to Tarquin inadvertently ignites Tarquin's lust. The "name of 'chaste'" ironically fuels his desire, a prime example of the perverse and destructive nature of male desire in the poem. Shakespeare uses vivid imagery and metaphor, portraying Lucrece's beauty as overwhelmingly captivating, creating an atmosphere where an innocent act of praise sets in motion a catastrophic chain of events. The language emphasizes the power of both beauty and the unchecked, potentially violent nature of male desire.

← Stanza 1📚 OverviewStanza 3 →

Haply that name of 'chaste' unhappily set
This bateless edge on his keen appetite;
When Collatine unwisely did not let
To praise the clear unmatched red and white
Which triumph'd in that sky of his delight,
Where mortal stars, as bright as heaven's beauties, With pure aspects did him peculiar duties.

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← Stanza 2📚 OverviewStanza 4 →

Stanza 3 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece sets the scene and establishes the tragic irony that will unfold. Let's break it down line by line:

"For he the night before, in Tarquin's tent," This sets the context. "He" refers to Collatinus, Lucrece's husband. The location, "Tarquin's tent," implies a military setting, highlighting the power and authority of Tarquin, setting the stage for the later violation of Lucrece. The preposition "For" suggests a causal relationship with the following lines.

"Unlock'd the treasure of his happy state;" This is a metaphor. Collatinus "unlocked" the "treasure" of his happiness, suggesting the revelation or full appreciation of his good fortune. "Happy state" refers to his marriage to Lucrece. The verb "unlocked" suggests a hidden, precious quality that was previously unappreciated or fully realized.

"What priceless wealth the heavens had him lent / In the possession of his beauteous mate;" This continues the metaphor, emphasizing the exceptional value of his wife. "Priceless wealth" and "beauteous mate" highlight Lucrece's beauty and the immense value Collatinus places on her. The phrasing "heavens had him lent" suggests a divine gift, emphasizing the seemingly perfect and blessed nature of his marriage.

"Reckoning his fortune at such high-proud rate," This line describes Collatinus's immense pride and satisfaction in his wife. "Reckoning his fortune" means he assessed and valued his life's blessings. "High-proud rate" signifies an overestimation, foreshadowing the coming tragedy. This is a hint of hubris.

"That kings might be espoused to more fame, / But king nor peer to such a peerless dame." This uses a comparison (antithesis) to further emphasize Lucrece's exceptional qualities. Kings might have greater fame and power, but no one, not even a king or nobleman ("peer"), possesses a wife as extraordinary as Lucrece ("peerless dame"). This is hyperbole, obviously exaggerating Lucrece's virtues to show the depth of Collatinus's love and the magnitude of the loss to come.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: The comparison of Lucrece to "priceless wealth" and Collatinus's happiness to a "treasure" is a central metaphor.
Hyperbole: The exaggeration of Lucrece's beauty and virtue ("peerless dame") emphasizes her exceptional qualities and foreshadows the devastating impact of her rape.
Antithesis: The contrasting phrases "more fame" and "such a peerless dame" highlight the
different aspects of value, showing how Collatinus prioritizes Lucrece's unique qualities over worldly power and fame.
Personification: The heavens are personified as lending Collatinus a gift.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza paints a picture of idyllic marital bliss. Collatinus, having just spent the night with Lucrece, fully appreciates the extraordinary value of his wife, considering her far superior to any other woman, even surpassing the wives of kings and nobles. This profound happiness, however, is

For he the night before, in Tarquin's tent,
Unlock'd the treasure of his happy state;
What priceless wealth the heavens had him lent
In the possession of his beauteous mate;
Reckoning his fortune at such high-proud rate,
That kings might be espoused to more fame,
But king nor peer to such a peerless dame.

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presented with a bittersweet irony. Shakespeare subtly hints at the fragility of this happiness and the impending tragedy, foreshadowing the rape of Lucrece and the devastation that will follow. The emphasis on Collatinus's pride and the extreme value he places on Lucrece creates a powerful contrast to the horrific events that will soon follow, intensifying the impact of the rape. The stanza sets the stage for the destruction of this idyllic scene and highlights the devastating consequences of Tarquin's actions.

← Stanza 2📚 OverviewStanza 4 →

← Stanza 3📚 OverviewStanza 5 →

Stanza 4 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece explores the fleeting nature of happiness and the vulnerability of beauty and honor. Let's break it down line by line:

"O happiness enjoy'd but of a few!" This line opens with an apostrophe ("O"), directly addressing happiness. It highlights the exclusivity of true happiness, suggesting it's a rare and precious commodity experienced by only a select few.

"And, if possess'd, as soon decay'd and done" This line introduces the central idea: even when happiness is achieved, it's incredibly transient. The word "decay'd" emphasizes the inevitable decline and loss. The parallel structure ("decay'd and done") strengthens the sense of finality.

"As is the morning's silver-melting dew" This line uses a simile to illustrate the ephemeral nature of happiness, comparing it to morning dew that quickly disappears. The imagery is beautiful and evocative, painting a picture of delicate beauty quickly vanishing. "Silver-melting" is particularly effective, suggesting a gradual dissipation.

"Against the golden splendor of the sun!" This line completes the simile, explaining why the dew disappears. The "golden splendor of the sun" represents a powerful force (time, change, fate) that overwhelms and destroys the delicate beauty of the dew. The juxtaposition of "silver" and "golden" emphasizes the contrast between the fragile and the powerful.

"An expired date, cancell'd ere well begun:" This line continues the metaphor, extending the idea to a "date" that expires before it's even properly begun. This is a metaphor for happiness, implying its brevity and preordained end. "Cancell'd ere well begun" highlights the suddenness and abruptness of its termination.

"Honour and beauty, in the owner's arms," This line shifts the focus from the general concept of happiness to the specific vulnerabilities of honor and beauty, particularly within the context of the poem’s impending rape. The placement of "in the owner's arms" suggests a false sense of security.

"Are weakly fortress'd from a world of harms." This final line concludes the stanza with a powerful statement. "Weakly fortress'd" signifies the inadequate protection offered to honor and beauty, even within the supposed safety of the owner's embrace. The "world of harms" emphasizes the pervasive dangers that threaten them.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza laments the fleeting nature of happiness, particularly focusing on the precariousness of honor and beauty. Even when seemingly possessed, these precious qualities are vulnerable and easily destroyed by the inevitable forces of time and circumstance. The imagery of the dew melting in the sunlight serves as a potent symbol for this fragility, foreshadowing the tragic events that will befall Lucrece. The stanza establishes a tone of melancholy and foreboding, setting the stage for the poem's central tragedy.

← Stanza 3📚 OverviewStanza 5 →

O happiness enjoy'd but of a few!
And, if possess'd, as soon decay'd and done
As is the morning's silver-melting dew
Against the golden splendor of the sun!
An expired date, cancell'd ere well begun: Honour and beauty, in the owner's arms,
Are weakly fortress'd from a world of harms.

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← Stanza 4📚 OverviewStanza 6 →

Stanza 5 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Shakespeare's stanza from The Rape of Lucrece, line by line:

Line 1: "Beauty itself doth of itself persuade / The eyes of men without an orator;" This line establishes the central idea. "Beauty itself" is personified – it acts independently. The phrase "doth of itself persuade" means beauty convinces or captivates without needing any help. "The eyes of men" are the recipients of this persuasion, and "without an orator" highlights that beauty's power is inherent and needs no verbal argument or advocacy. This is a powerful statement about the immediate and undeniable impact of beauty.

Line 2: "What needeth then apologies be made," This line poses a rhetorical question. "Needeth" is an archaic form of "needs." The question challenges the necessity of any justification or explanation for beauty.

Line 3: "To set forth that which is so singular?" This line continues the rhetorical question. "Singular" here means exceptional, unique, extraordinary. The question implies that something so uniquely beautiful needs no further explanation or defense.

Line 4: "Or why is Collatine the publisher / Of that rich jewel he should keep unknown" This line introduces Collatine, Lucrece's husband, and shifts the focus to his actions. Lucrece's beauty is likened to a "rich jewel," a metaphor emphasizing its preciousness and value. The phrase "he should keep unknown" suggests that a truly precious thing should be guarded and kept private, implying a sense of discretion or even possessiveness.

Line 5: "From thievish ears, because it is his own?" This line completes the rhetorical
question, highlighting the paradoxical nature of Collatine's behavior. "Thievish ears" represent those who would covet or exploit Lucrece's beauty. The final question implies that Collatine's boasting about Lucrece's beauty is foolish because its very possession should be enough. The possession of something precious doesn't necessitate announcing it to the world.

Literary Devices:

Personification: Beauty is given human qualities ("doth of itself persuade").
Metaphor: Lucrece's beauty is compared to a "rich jewel."
Rhetorical Questions: The stanza is built around a series of rhetorical questions, not seeking answers but emphasizing the inherent absurdity of Collatine's actions.
Antithesis: There's a subtle antithesis between the inherent power of beauty and Collatine's unnecessary boasting.
Irony: The inherent beauty should be its own protection, but Collatine’s actions invite danger.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza criticizes Collatine for his boastful proclamation of Lucrece's beauty. Shakespeare argues that beauty's power is self-evident and needs no advertisement. By showing off Lucrece's beauty, Collatine unwittingly invites the very danger that ultimately leads to her rape. The stanza acts as foreshadowing and sets a critical tone toward Collatine's actions, subtly suggesting his naiveté and the potentially disastrous consequences of his lack of discretion. The inherent worth of something

Beauty itself doth of itself persuade
The eyes of men without an orator;
What needeth then apologies be made,
To set forth that which is so singular?
Or why is Collatine the publisher
Of that rich jewel he should keep unknown From thievish ears, because it is his own?

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beautiful should not necessitate excessive, public display. The private nature of beauty and its potential vulnerability are central themes introduced here.
← Stanza 4📚 OverviewStanza 6 →

← Stanza 5📚 OverviewStanza 7 →

Stanza 6 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece explores the possible motivations behind Tarquin's rape of Lucrece. Let's break it down line by line:

Line 1: "Perchance his boast of Lucrece' sovereignty": This introduces the possibility (hence "perchance") that Tarquin's pride stemmed from Lucrece's renowned virtue and status ("sovereignty" here implies supreme excellence, not just political power). This is a hypothetical statement, setting up the exploration of possible motives.

Line 2: "Suggested this proud issue of a king": This connects Lucrece's exceptional virtue to Tarquin's royal pride. The "proud issue" is the rape itself, presented as a consequence of Tarquin's inflated ego ("issue" has double meaning – outcome and offspring, hinting at the potential for illegitimate children).

Line 3: "For by our ears our hearts oft tainted be": This is a general statement about the corrupting influence of flattery and boasting. It acts as a transition, connecting Tarquin's hearing about Lucrece's excellence to the possibility of his corruption. The use of "tainted" suggests a subtle poisoning of his mind.

Line 4: "Perchance that envy of so rich a thing": This introduces another potential motive: envy. Lucrece's virtue ("so rich a thing") is so exceptional that it provokes envy in Tarquin.

Line 5: "Braving compare, disdainfully did sting": This line describes the nature of this envy. Lucrece's virtues are presented as "braving compare," meaning they challenge any comparison, highlighting her superiority. This defiance ("disdainfully") stings Tarquin's pride.

Line 6: "His high-pitch'd thoughts, that meaner men should vaunt": This explains the effect of the envy. Tarquin's "high-pitched thoughts" (his arrogant ambitions) are wounded by the idea that "meaner men" (those less noble than himself) might boast of possessing such happiness and virtue ("vaunt").

Line 7: "That golden hap which their superiors want": This concludes the argument. The "golden hap" refers to Lucrece's virtue and happiness, which Tarquin envies because he, a superior in social standing, lacks it. This creates a sense of injustice and resentment in him.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza explores the psychology of Tarquin's actions, suggesting that his rape of Lucrece wasn't merely lustful but deeply rooted in pride and envy. It proposes that hearing of Lucrece's exceptional virtue, rather than diminishing his pride, instead provoked a dangerous reaction: either a desire to possess what he perceived as rightfully his (as a king) or an envious rage at someone of lower status possessing something he lacked. This uses the concept of envy to justify his actions.

Literary Devices:

Hypothetical statements ("Perchance"): The repeated use of "perchance" creates ambiguity, allowing Shakespeare to explore multiple potential motives without definitively committing to one. Metaphor: "Tainted be" is a metaphor suggesting a moral corruption. "Golden hap" is a metaphor for Lucrece's virtue and happiness.

Perchance his boast of Lucrece' sovereignty
Suggested this proud issue of a king;
For by our ears our hearts oft tainted be:
Perchance that envy of so rich a thing,
Braving compare, disdainfully did sting
His high-pitch'd thoughts, that meaner men should vaunt That golden hap which their superiors want.

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Personification: Envy is personified as actively "stinging" Tarquin's thoughts.
Antithesis: The contrast between Tarquin's high status and his envy of Lucrece's virtue creates a powerful dramatic irony.

The stanza masterfully blends psychological insight with poetic language, prompting the reader to consider the complex nature of Tarquin's motivations and the devastating consequences of pride and envy.

← Stanza 5📚 OverviewStanza 7 →

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← Stanza 6📚 OverviewStanza 8 →

Stanza 7 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece focuses on Tarquin's sudden and reckless pursuit of Lucrece, exploring the internal conflict and consequences of his actions. Let's break it down line by line:

"But some untimely thought did instigate / His all-too-timeless speed, if none of those:" This opens with a contrast. "Some untimely thought" suggests a sudden, inappropriate impulse, a desire that overrides reason and proper conduct. "Instigate" implies a forceful, almost demonic prompting. "His all-too-timeless speed" is a paradoxical phrase; his haste is excessive and ill-timed, ignoring the usual considerations of time and decorum. The "if none of those" suggests that even if we dismiss more obvious explanations (like duty or business), something deeply inappropriate drove him. This line uses antithesis (contrast between "untimely" and "timeless") and paradox ("all-too-timeless speed").

"His honour, his affairs, his friends, his state, / Neglected all, with swift intent he goes": This line lists the things Tarquin is neglecting in his frantic rush – his reputation, his responsibilities, his relationships, and his social standing. This is a form of anaphora, with the repetition of "his" emphasizing the complete disregard for his life's essentials. The use of a series highlights the scope of his negligence.

"To quench the coal which in his liver glows.": This is a metaphor. In Elizabethan physiology, the liver was associated with lust and passion. "Coal" represents the burning intensity of Tarquin's desire, a fire that consumes him. This is metaphorical language used to show the consuming nature of his lust.

"O rash false heat, wrapp'd in repentant cold, / Thy hasty spring still blasts, and ne'er grows old!": This is an apostrophe, a direct address to Tarquin's lust. "Rash false heat" personifies his passion, describing it as both reckless and deceptive. "Wrapp'd in repentant cold" is another paradox: it suggests that even amidst the heat of his actions, the seeds of regret and future suffering already exist. "Thy hasty spring still blasts, and ne'er grows old!" uses imagery of a premature spring that is immediately destroyed by frost; it's a metaphor for the destructive and eternally self-defeating nature of Tarquin's impulsive, lustful behavior. The "ne'er grows old" emphasizes the enduring consequences of his rash actions. This line uses personification (giving human qualities to "heat") and imagery (of spring and frost).

Overall Meaning:

The stanza portrays Tarquin's impulsive act as driven by an internal force he cannot control, a "rash false heat." It highlights the destructive nature of uncontrolled lust and its immediate and long-lasting consequences. Shakespeare uses paradox, metaphor, and personification to emphasize the destructive nature of Tarquin's passion, foreshadowing the tragic events to come. His reckless disregard for his obligations foreshadows his moral collapse and the devastating consequences that follow his rape of Lucrece. The stanza's imagery foreshadows the destructive nature of Tarquin's lust and suggests that it is a force that will continue to torment him.

← Stanza 6📚 OverviewStanza 8 →

But some untimely thought did instigate
His all-too-timeless speed, if none of those:
His honour, his affairs, his friends, his state,
Neglected all, with swift intent he goes
To quench the coal which in his liver glows.
O rash false heat, wrapp'd in repentant cold,
Thy hasty spring still blasts, and ne'er grows old!

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← Stanza 7📚 OverviewStanza 9 →

Stanza 8 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece describes Tarquin's arrival at Collatium and Lucrece's inherent internal conflict between her beauty and her virtue. Let's break it down line by line:

"When at Collatium this false lord arrived," This sets the scene. "Collatium" is the location, establishing the context. "False lord" immediately characterizes Tarquin, foreshadowing his treachery. The word "false" is a key epithet, establishing his deceptive nature.

"Well was he welcomed by the Roman dame," This introduces Lucrece, referred to as a
"Roman dame," highlighting her social standing and emphasizing the irony of her impending violation. The phrase "well was he welcomed" creates a sense of deceptive normalcy before the tragedy unfolds. This is irony.

"Within whose face beauty and virtue strived / Which of them both should underprop her fame:" This is the central image of the stanza. Lucrece's beauty and virtue are personified and presented as being in conflict. They "strive" – compete – for dominance in shaping her reputation ("fame"). "Underprop" suggests a support or foundation for her reputation. This is personification.

"When virtue bragg'd, beauty would blush for shame; / When beauty boasted blushes, in despite / Virtue would stain that o'er with silver white." This describes the dynamic between beauty and virtue. "Bragg'd" and "boasted" are verbs that illustrate the competitive nature of these qualities. When virtue is prominent, beauty feels ashamed ("blush for shame"). Conversely, when beauty asserts itself through blushing, virtue subtly counters it ("stain that o'er with silver white"). "Silver white" likely refers to a chaste, pure white color, further enhancing the contrast. This section uses antithesis (contrasting ideas) and metaphor (the blushing and staining represent the
internal struggle).

Overall Meaning:

The stanza depicts Lucrece as a woman of exceptional beauty and virtue, qualities that are in a delicate and constant tension within her. Her internal conflict is not a battle between good and evil, but a conflict between two positive but potentially opposing aspects of her identity. Shakespeare highlights the vulnerability of her virtue in the face of Tarquin's impending attack. The apparent harmony of the welcome masks the inner struggle and foreshadows the destructive power of Tarquin's evil, which will shatter this balance and ultimately lead to Lucrece's tragedy. The stanza thus prepares the reader for the rape, emphasizing the internal strength Lucrece possesses which will be brutally violated. The imagery of blushing and staining symbolizes the inherent tension between outward beauty and inner purity, a tension that Tarquin will exploit.

← Stanza 7📚 OverviewStanza 9 →

When at Collatium this false lord arrived,
Well was he welcomed by the Roman dame,
Within whose face beauty and virtue strived
Which of them both should underprop her fame:
When virtue bragg'd, beauty would blush for shame; When beauty boasted blushes, in despite
Virtue would stain that o'er with silver white.

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← Stanza 8📚 OverviewStanza 10 →

Stanza 9 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece is a complex allegory about the conflict between beauty and virtue, using the imagery of a battlefield to illustrate their intertwined relationship. Let's break down each line:

"But beauty, in that white intituled," This line introduces the central conflict. "Beauty" is personified, and "in that white intituled" refers to Lucrece's fair skin, which is seen as a symbol of her purity and virtue. "Intituled" means "entitled" or "vested," suggesting that beauty has a claim to this whiteness.

"From Venus' doves doth challenge that fair field:" This line introduces a challenge. Venus, the goddess of love and beauty, whose doves symbolize beauty and desire, challenges for the "fair field," which represents Lucrece's beauty and virtue. This establishes a conflict between the inherent attractiveness of Lucrece and the potential for that beauty to be violated. This is an example of metaphor (fair field = Lucrece's virtue and beauty) and allusion (to Venus and her doves).

"Then virtue claims from beauty beauty's red," This line shifts the focus to virtue. "Beauty's red" likely refers to the blush of modesty or the redness of blood, representing the potential for shame or injury resulting from the violation of virtue. Virtue is claiming this "red," suggesting a protective or restorative role.

"Which virtue gave the golden age to gild / Their silver cheeks, and call'd it then their shield;" This line invokes the Golden Age, a mythical period of innocence and purity. Virtue, during this age, bestowed the blush ("gild their silver cheeks") as a protective shield against shame. This is an example of metaphor (Golden Age representing a time of pure virtue) and personification (virtue giving and calling the blush a shield).

"Teaching them thus to use it in the fight, / When shame assail'd, the red should fence the white." This line concludes the allegory. Virtue teaches the use of this "red" (blush/blood) as a defense against shame ("the fight") which threatens the "white" (Lucrece's purity). "Fence" signifies protection. This is a continuation of the metaphor of battle.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza explores the relationship between beauty and virtue, presenting them as forces that are both interconnected and potentially at odds. Lucrece's beauty ("the white") is vulnerable to violation, but virtue ("the red") offers protection against such attacks. The "red" is not simply a sign of shame, but a symbol of the resilience and potential for defense against the corrupting influences that threaten beauty's innocence. The stanza foreshadows the impending rape and the conflict between beauty and virtue that will unfold. The image of a battle prepares the reader for the devastating conflict to come. The beauty of Lucrece is challenged, and virtue is presented as a shield against that challenge, even if that shield involves the potential for suffering and bloody consequences.

← Stanza 8📚 OverviewStanza 10 →

But beauty, in that white intituled,
From Venus' doves doth challenge that fair field:
Then virtue claims from beauty beauty's red,
Which virtue gave the golden age to gild
Their silver cheeks, and call'd it then their shield; Teaching them thus to use it in the fight,
When shame assail'd, the red should fence the white.

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← Stanza 9📚 OverviewStanza 11 →

Stanza 10 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece uses the imagery of heraldry (the system of symbols used in coats of arms) to depict the conflict between beauty and virtue in Lucrece's appearance and character. Let's break it down line by line:

"This heraldry in Lucrece' face was seen," This opening line introduces the central metaphor. Lucrece's face is presented as a coat of arms, displaying the symbolic colours representing her beauty and virtue. "Heraldry" is a key metaphor.

"Argued by beauty's red and virtue's white" Here, Shakespeare assigns colours to abstract qualities: red for beauty (perhaps suggesting passion or warmth) and white for virtue (suggesting purity and innocence). This is synecdoche, using the colours to represent the larger concepts. The word "argued" implies a debate or conflict between these two aspects of Lucrece's character.

"Of either's colour was the other queen," This line reinforces the equality of beauty and virtue. Each colour (and thus each quality) holds equal power or "queenship" in Lucrece's appearance. The use of "queen" emphasizes their dominance.

"Proving from world's minority their right:" This refers to the idea that from the earliest times ("world's minority" – infancy of the world) beauty and virtue have co-existed and claimed their right to exist. It emphasizes their long-standing and undeniable presence.

"Yet their ambition makes them still to fight;" Despite their equal status, beauty and virtue are presented as being in conflict. "Ambition" suggests a desire for dominance, highlighting the inherent tension between the two. This is personification, giving human qualities (ambition and conflict) to abstract concepts.

"The sovereignty of either being so great," This line further underlines the equal power of beauty and virtue. Both claim "sovereignty," or supreme rule.

"That oft they interchange each other's seat." This concludes the image by suggesting that the dominance of beauty and virtue shifts. Neither consistently prevails; they continually alternate in their influence on Lucrece's character and presentation. This is a powerful image of inner conflict.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza depicts Lucrece as a woman possessing both exceptional beauty and unwavering virtue. However, Shakespeare presents these qualities not as harmonious but as locked in a constant, internal struggle for dominance. This internal conflict, foreshadowed visually through the metaphorical heraldry, is a crucial element of the poem's exploration of virtue under threat. The imagery suggests that even a woman of perfect virtue is not immune to the allure of beauty and the challenges it presents, making her vulnerability to Tarquin’s assault more believable. The struggle between beauty and virtue within Lucrece acts as a microcosm of the larger conflict between appearance and reality, seduction and morality that unfolds throughout the narrative.

← Stanza 9📚 OverviewStanza 11 →

This heraldry in Lucrece' face was seen,
Argued by beauty's red and virtue's white
Of either's colour was the other queen,
Proving from world's minority their right:
Yet their ambition makes them still to fight; The sovereignty of either being so great, That oft they interchange each other's seat.

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← Stanza 10📚 OverviewStanza 12 →

Stanza 11 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece describes the internal conflict Lucrece experiences as Tarquin observes her. Let's break it down line by line:

"Their silent war of lilies and of roses," This line uses the metaphor of a battle between lilies (typically representing purity and innocence) and roses (often symbolizing love and passion). These represent the conflicting emotions within Lucrece: her virtue (lilies) struggling against the burgeoning feelings stirred by Tarquin's presence (roses). This is an example of personification,
as the flowers are given human-like qualities of warfare.

"Which Tarquin view'd in her fair face's field," This line continues the military metaphor. Lucrece's face is described as a "field" – the battlefield where this internal conflict plays out. Tarquin is the observer, strategically watching this internal struggle. The use of "field" is a metaphor that visually encapsulates the internal war raging within Lucrece.

"In their pure ranks his traitor eye encloses;" Tarquin's gaze ("his traitor eye") is described as "enclosing" the warring emotions. This imagery suggests he is actively observing and perhaps even influencing the internal struggle. The word "traitor" foreshadows his impending actions and labels him as an antagonist before any direct act of violence.

"Where, lest between them both it should be kill'd," This line refers to the "it" – likely representing Lucrece's will or her sense of self. The concern is that if the conflict between purity and passion rages on unchecked, it will destroy her ("be kill'd"). This shows Lucrece’s internal struggle is a fight for her very being.

"The coward captive vanquished doth yield" Here, Lucrece's will ("the coward captive") is shown to be defeated. She surrenders ("doth yield") not through active choice, but because her internal struggle has been lost. The use of "coward" is significant. It doesn't describe Lucrece's actions but rather the fragility of her willpower against Tarquin's overwhelming presence. This speaks to the vulnerability of her situation.

"To those two armies that would let him go," The surrender is to the "two armies" (lilies and roses), not to Tarquin directly. This implies that Lucrece's virtue is not actively giving in to Tarquin's desire but is overwhelmed by the conflicting emotions he awakened. The suggestion that the opposing emotions would "let him go" (her will) implies the conflict was irresolvable for her, a point strengthened by the next line.

"Rather than triumph in so false a foe." This line clarifies that Lucrece's surrender isn't a
victory for Tarquin, but the avoidance of a worse outcome. "So false a foe" refers to the destructive nature of passion, especially considering Tarquin's deceitful character. The internal conflict is resolved with the loss of her own control. The "false foe" is both Tarquin and her own feelings.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza masterfully portrays Lucrece's internal struggle as Tarquin watches. Her virtue and potential passion are presented as warring forces, and Tarquin's presence acts as a catalyst to this conflict. Ultimately, her will is not actively overcome by Tarquin's strength, but rather crumbles under the weight of conflicting emotions, highlighting her vulnerability and foreshadowing the tragedy to

Their silent war of lilies and of roses,
Which Tarquin view'd in her fair face's field,
In their pure ranks his traitor eye encloses;
Where, lest between them both it should be kill'd,
The coward captive vanquished doth yield
To those two armies that would let him go,
Rather than triumph in so false a foe.

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come. The stanza uses vivid military metaphors and personification to convey the intensity of this psychological battle.
← Stanza 10📚 OverviewStanza 12 →

← Stanza 11📚 OverviewStanza 13 →

Stanza 12 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Tarquin's contemplation of Lucrece after seeing her beauty. Let's break it down line by line:

"Now thinks he that her husband's shallow tongue,--": This line introduces Tarquin's thoughts. He believes Lucrece's husband, Collatine, has inadequately described her beauty. "Shallow tongue" suggests Collatine's praise was insufficient, lacking depth and eloquence.

"The niggard prodigal that praised her so,--": This is a powerful oxymoron. "Niggard" means stingy or miserly, while "prodigal" means wasteful or extravagant. Shakespeare uses this to highlight the perceived contradiction in Collatine's praise: he was both insufficient (stingy with his words, not giving her beauty full justice) and excessive (in the sense that even his insufficient praise was still more than the situation warranted, hinting at an over-estimation of his abilities to describe her). It emphasizes the inadequacy of Collatine's words to capture Lucrece's magnificence.

"In that high task hath done her beauty wrong,": Tarquin judges that Collatine has failed in the "high task" of adequately describing Lucrece's beauty. He has "done her beauty wrong" by underselling it. This suggests Tarquin sees himself as superior in his appreciation of beauty.

"Which far exceeds his barren skill to show:": This line reinforces the previous one, emphasizing the vast difference between Lucrece's true beauty and Collatine's ability to portray it. "Barren skill" highlights Collatine's inadequacy further.

"Therefore that praise which Collatine doth owe": This line explains Tarquin's motivation. He believes that Collatine hasn't fully given Lucrece the praise she deserves ("owes"). The use of "owes" emphasizes a debt or obligation Collatine hasn't fulfilled.

"Enchanted Tarquin answers with surmise,": This is the turning point. "Enchanted" doesn't imply magic, but rather a captivated, spellbound state. Tarquin, mesmerized by Lucrece's beauty, "answers" Collatine's insufficient praise with "surmise"—conjecture or speculation, filled with his own intense, subjective appreciation of her beauty.

"In silent wonder of still-gazing eyes.": This line describes Tarquin's state. He is lost in silent awe ("silent wonder"), his gaze fixed ("still-gazing eyes") on Lucrece. The "stillness" emphasizes
the intensity of his fascination, foreboding the violence to come.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza shows Tarquin's initial response to Lucrece's beauty. He believes her husband's praise falls dramatically short, allowing him to justify his own possessive and ultimately predatory interest in her. It establishes Tarquin's arrogant self-assessment, positioning himself as a superior judge of beauty and subtly planting the seeds for his later actions. The silent wonder masks his lustful intentions, which the reader already understands to be deeply problematic. The literary devices, especially the oxymoron and carefully chosen verbs, contribute to a sense of mounting tension and foreshadow the tragedy.

← Stanza 11📚 OverviewStanza 13 →

Now thinks he that her husband's shallow tongue,--
The niggard prodigal that praised her so,--
In that high task hath done her beauty wrong,
Which far exceeds his barren skill to show: Therefore that praise which Collatine doth owe Enchanted Tarquin answers with surmise,
In silent wonder of still-gazing eyes.

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← Stanza 12📚 OverviewStanza 14 →

Stanza 13 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Lucrece's unsuspecting nature and Tarquin's deceptive appearance. Let's break it down line by line:

"This earthly saint, adored by this devil," This line establishes a stark contrast using antithesis. Lucrece is presented as an "earthly saint," implying purity and innocence, while Tarquin, her admirer, is a "devil," representing evil and deceit. The juxtaposition immediately sets the stage for the tragedy.

"Little suspecteth the false worshipper;" This reinforces Lucrece's innocence. She has little suspicion of Tarquin's true nature, highlighting her naiveté and the deceptive nature of his "worship." The word "worshipper" is ironic, as his adoration is a pretense.

"For unstain'd thoughts do seldom dream on evil;" This line explains Lucrece's lack of suspicion. Her pure mind, symbolized by "unstain'd thoughts," prevents her from imagining or suspecting evil intentions. This is a statement about the nature of innocence and its vulnerability to deception.

"Birds never limed no secret bushes fear:" This is a simile, comparing Lucrece's innocence to a bird unaware of a trap. Birds that haven't been caught in birdlime (a sticky substance used to trap birds) don't fear hidden bushes. This emphasizes her lack of experience with treachery and her resulting vulnerability. Note the double negative ("never limed no") for emphasis.

"So guiltless she securely gives good cheer" This line directly connects Lucrece's innocence ("guiltless") to her actions. She offers hospitality ("good cheer") without suspicion. The word "securely" underlines her misplaced confidence.

"And reverend welcome to her princely guest," This line describes her respectful reception of Tarquin, emphasizing her proper behavior and respect for his high social standing ("princely guest"). This further highlights the irony of the situation.

"Whose inward ill no outward harm express'd:" This final line reveals Tarquin's deception. His inner wickedness ("inward ill") is completely hidden ("no outward harm express'd"), making him appear harmless and trustworthy. This is dramatic irony; the reader knows his true nature, but Lucrece does not.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza portrays the crucial imbalance of power and knowledge between Lucrece and Tarquin. Lucrece's innocence and purity blind her to Tarquin's malicious intent. Shakespeare uses imagery and similes to highlight her vulnerability and Tarquin's cunning deception. The stanza foreshadows the tragic events to come, emphasizing the devastating consequences of innocence encountering deliberate malice. The use of antithesis, simile, and dramatic irony are central to creating this effect and setting the tone for the entire poem.

← Stanza 12📚 OverviewStanza 14 →

This earthly saint, adored by this devil,
Little suspecteth the false worshipper;
For unstain'd thoughts do seldom dream on evil;
Birds never limed no secret bushes fear:
So guiltless she securely gives good cheer
And reverend welcome to her princely guest, Whose inward ill no outward harm express'd:

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← Stanza 13📚 OverviewStanza 15 →

Stanza 14 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece focuses on Tarquin's deceptive nature and insatiable desires. Let's break down each line:

"For that he colour'd with his high estate," This opens by stating a reason for the later consequences. "Colour'd" means disguised or masked. Tarquin's high social standing ("high estate") allowed him to conceal his evil intentions. This is a metaphor – his position acts as a cosmetic cover for his true nature.

"Hiding base sin in plaits of majesty;" This continues the metaphor. "Base sin" refers to his inherent wickedness, specifically his lust and impending rape. "Plaits of majesty" suggests the elaborate and seemingly flawless folds of regal attire and bearing. The image is one of carefully constructed deception, where wickedness is hidden beneath the outward appearance of power and dignity. This is another metaphor.

"That nothing in him seem'd inordinate," This highlights the effectiveness of Tarquin's disguise. To onlookers, nothing about him appeared excessive or out of control. He presented a flawless image of composure and nobility. "Inordinate" means excessive or immoderate.

"Save something too much wonder of his eye," This is the crucial exception to his seemingly perfect façade. "Too much wonder" describes the intense, almost unsettling gaze in his eyes, which hints at his inner depravity. The "wonder" here is not admiration, but something awe-inspiring in a disturbing way. This line uses personification by giving his eyes an overwhelming quality.

"Which, having all, all could not satisfy;" This line explains the consequence of his inner turmoil. Despite possessing everything – power, wealth, status – Tarquin remains unsatisfied. This reveals his insatiable lust as a deep-seated problem, not a mere fleeting desire. This uses pleonasm (repetition for emphasis) "all...all".

"But, poorly rich, so wanteth in his store," This line presents a paradox. "Poorly rich" is an oxymoron, highlighting the irony of his situation. Despite material wealth ("store"), he's spiritually impoverished. He lacks inner peace and contentment.

"That, cloy'd with much, he pineth still for more." This concludes the stanza by summarizing Tarquin's condition. "Cloy'd" means surfeited or overwhelmed. Despite having more than enough to satisfy any reasonable person, he remains consumed by an unquenchable desire, "pineth still for more". This reveals his addiction to power and lust.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza portrays Tarquin as a master of deception, concealing his base desires beneath the veneer of his high social standing. His insatiable lust, however, betrays him, manifested in the unsettling intensity of his gaze. The stanza establishes a key theme of the poem: the destructive nature of unchecked ambition and desire, and how outward appearances can mask inner corruption. The use of metaphors, oxymorons, and personification create a vivid and psychologically insightful portrait of a deeply flawed character. The concluding lines establish his insatiable nature as the underlying cause of the tragedy to come.

For that he colour'd with his high estate,
Hiding base sin in plaits of majesty;
That nothing in him seem'd inordinate,
Save something too much wonder of his eye,
Which, having all, all could not satisfy;
But, poorly rich, so wanteth in his store,
That, cloy'd with much, he pineth still for more.

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← Stanza 13📚 OverviewStanza 15 →

← Stanza 14📚 OverviewStanza 16 →

Stanza 15 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece describes Lucrece's innocence and naiveté in the face of Tarquin's seductive advances. Let's break it down line by line:

"But she, that never coped with stranger eyes," This establishes Lucrece's inexperience. "Coped" here means "engaged," or "dealt with." She's never had to navigate the complexities of flirtation or seduction from unfamiliar men. The emphasis is on her lack of previous encounters with such suggestive gazes.

"Could pick no meaning from their parling looks," Tarquin's eyes are described as "parling," meaning speaking or conversing. Lucrece, however, is unable to decipher the meaning behind his suggestive glances. She lacks the experience to understand the nonverbal communication of flirtation.

"Nor read the subtle-shining secrecies / Writ in the glassy margents of such books:" This is a powerful metaphor. Tarquin's eyes are compared to "books" whose "subtle-shining secrecies" (hidden meanings) are written in the "glassy margents" (the margins or borders, reflecting like glass). The metaphor suggests that experienced women might read these unspoken messages like text on a page, but Lucrece cannot. The "glassy" quality emphasizes the alluring but potentially deceptive nature of Tarquin's gaze.

"She touch'd no unknown baits, nor fear'd no hooks;" This continues the fishing metaphor introduced subtly in the previous lines. Lucrece has never encountered the manipulative tactics of seduction; she's unfamiliar with the "baits" (lures) and "hooks" (traps) used to ensnare her. The imagery reinforces her innocence and inexperience.

"Nor could she moralize his wanton sight," "Moralize" here means to interpret or find a meaning in. Lucrece is unable to understand or interpret the lasciviousness ("wanton sight") in Tarquin's gaze. Her purity prevents her from recognizing his malicious intent.

"More than his eyes were open'd to the light." This final line is a concise and impactful comparison. Tarquin's eyes are "open'd to the light" - they clearly see their goal (Lucrece). However, Lucrece's innocence prevents her from seeing the dark intention behind his gaze; she perceives only the surface level. It highlights the stark contrast between their states of awareness.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: The extended metaphor comparing Tarquin's eyes to a book with hidden meanings and to a fisherman's bait and hook is central to the stanza.
Personification: Tarquin's eyes are personified; they "parle" (speak) and are "open'd to the light." Imagery: Vivid sensory details, such as "subtle-shining secrecies," "glassy margents," "unknown baits," and "hooks," create a strong visual and tactile impression.
Antithesis: The final line uses antithesis (contrasting ideas) to emphasize the difference between Tarquin's awareness and Lucrece's naivete.

Overall Meaning:

But she, that never coped with stranger eyes,
Could pick no meaning from their parling looks,
Nor read the subtle-shining secrecies
Writ in the glassy margents of such books:
She touch'd no unknown baits, nor fear'd no hooks; Nor could she moralize his wanton sight,
More than his eyes were open'd to the light.

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The stanza powerfully portrays Lucrece's complete vulnerability to Tarquin's manipulation. Her innocence and lack of experience leave her incapable of recognizing the danger inherent in his seductive advances. The stanza contrasts her purity and lack of understanding with Tarquin's calculated and predatory intentions. It sets the stage for the tragic events to follow by showing Lucrece's defenselessness against a seasoned seducer.

← Stanza 14📚 OverviewStanza 16 →

← Stanza 15📚 OverviewStanza 17 →

Stanza 16 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts the moment before the rape, establishing the idyllic happiness of Lucrece and highlighting the stark contrast that will follow. Let's break it down line by line:

"He stories to her ears her husband's fame," This line introduces Tarquin, who begins to woo Lucrece by recounting the glories of her husband, Collatine. "Stories" here means "tells tales" or "relates stories," subtly foreshadowing the deceptive nature of Tarquin's words.

"Won in the fields of fruitful Italy;" This line specifies the location of Collatine's military victories, emphasizing the abundance and prosperity of Italy, which stands in stark contrast to the devastation about to occur. "Fruitful Italy" is an example of epithet, a descriptive adjective that adds to the imagery.

"And decks with praises Collatine's high name," This continues the praise, using the metaphor of "decks" to imply lavish embellishment and admiration. This is further emphasized by the following line.

"Made glorious by his manly chivalry" This line directly praises Collatine's valor and knightly virtues, reinforcing the image of a perfect husband. "Manly chivalry" is a synecdoche, using a part (chivalry) to represent the whole (Collatine's heroic qualities).

"With bruised arms and wreaths of victory:" This line provides vivid imagery, depicting the physical signs of Collatine's military success. "Bruised arms" represent the hard work and struggle involved, while "wreaths of victory" signify his triumph. This is an example of juxtaposition, placing contrasting images (bruised arms and wreaths) to emphasize the struggle and reward.

"Her joy with heaved-up hand she doth express," This line shows Lucrece's reaction to Tarquin's words. The physical act of raising her hand is a visual representation of her happiness and gratitude for her husband’s achievements.

"And, wordless, so greets heaven for his success." This final line emphasizes Lucrece's silent prayer of thanks, highlighting her piety and devotion to her husband. The wordlessness underscores the depth of her emotion, which is all the more poignant given the events to come.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza depicts a scene of domestic bliss and marital fidelity. Tarquin, through his flattery and skillful manipulation, exploits Lucrece's love and admiration for her husband to gain her trust and lower her defenses before committing his heinous act. The vivid descriptions of Collatine's glories and Lucrece's joyful response create a strong contrast with the impending violence and rape, making the subsequent violation even more shocking and impactful. The use of various literary devices enhances the dramatic irony, allowing the reader to anticipate the tragedy while fully appreciating the serene moment described. The stanza functions as a crucial setup, establishing the idyllic world that Tarquin is about to shatter.

← Stanza 15📚 OverviewStanza 17 →

He stories to her ears her husband's fame,
Won in the fields of fruitful Italy;
And decks with praises Collatine's high name,
Made glorious by his manly chivalry
With bruised arms and wreaths of victory:
Her joy with heaved-up hand she doth express, And, wordless, so greets heaven for his success.

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← Stanza 16📚 OverviewStanza 18 →

Stanza 17 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece sets the scene and establishes the deceptive nature of Tarquin's presence. Let's break it down line by line:

"Far from the purpose of his coming hither," This opening line immediately establishes a sense of deception. Tarquin's stated reason for being at Lucrece's house is a pretense; his true intentions are hidden. "Hither" is an archaic word for "here."

"He makes excuses for his being there:" This reinforces the deception. Tarquin is actively constructing justifications for his presence, masking his sinister plan.

"No cloudy show of stormy blustering weather / Doth yet in his fair welkin once appear;" This uses vivid imagery and personification. "Welkin" refers to the sky, presented here as "fair," suggesting a calm and peaceful atmosphere, contrasting sharply with the storm brewing within Tarquin and the impending violence. The "cloudy show" and "stormy blustering weather" are metaphorical foreshadowing of the approaching rape.

"Till sable Night, mother of Dread and Fear, / Upon the world dim darkness doth display," This introduces night as a key player. Shakespeare uses personification again, portraying Night as a "mother" of dread and fear, highlighting its association with violence and hidden actions. "Sable" (black) emphasizes the darkness and the ominous nature of the approaching night. The line also uses strong verbs: "display" and "stows" to create a sense of power and inevitability.

"And in her vaulty prison stows the Day." This continues the personification of Night, depicting it as a jailer that imprisons the "Day." The "vaulty prison" imagery evokes a sense of confinement and secrecy, ideal conditions for Tarquin's nefarious plan to unfold. The "Day" represents virtue and light, which is being forcibly concealed by the approaching darkness of night.

Literary Devices:

Personification: Night is given human characteristics (motherhood, ability to display darkness, imprisoning the day). The weather is also personified, foreshadowing events.
Imagery: Vivid descriptions of weather ("cloudy show," "stormy blustering weather," "sable
Night"), darkness ("dim darkness"), and confinement ("vaulty prison") create a strong sensory experience for the reader.
Metaphor: The "fair welkin" contrasts with the impending storm, metaphorically foreshadowing the deceptive calm before the violent act.
Antithesis: The contrast between the outward appearance of calm ("fair welkin") and the inner turmoil and deception (Tarquin's hidden purpose) creates an antithesis.
Foreshadowing: The description of the approaching night and the calm weather subtly foreshadows the violence to come.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza masterfully sets the stage for the rape. It highlights the deceptive nature of appearances, contrasting the outwardly peaceful atmosphere with Tarquin's hidden, malicious intentions. The arrival of night, personified as a sinister force, provides the cover of darkness necessary for Tarquin's crime, emphasizing the vulnerability of Lucrece and the inevitability of the impending tragedy. The stanza is

Far from the purpose of his coming hither,
He makes excuses for his being there:
No cloudy show of stormy blustering weather
Doth yet in his fair welkin once appear;
Till sable Night, mother of Dread and Fear,
Upon the world dim darkness doth display, And in her vaulty prison stows the Day.

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a microcosm of the poem's central theme: the destructive power of hidden desires and the deception that allows violence to flourish.

← Stanza 16📚 OverviewStanza 18 →

← Stanza 17📚 OverviewStanza 19 →

Stanza 18 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Shakespeare's stanza from The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, identifying literary devices:

"For then is Tarquin brought unto his bed," This line introduces Tarquin, the antagonist, as he retires to his bed. It sets the scene and establishes a sense of impending action. The word "then" implies a chronological progression from previous events in the poem.

"Intending weariness with heavy spright;" This line describes Tarquin's state of mind. "Intending" here means "pretending" or "feigning." He's putting on a show of weariness, despite his true intentions. "Heavy spright" is a personification; "spright" (spirit) is given the human attribute of heaviness, suggesting a burdened or sluggish soul, which is deceptive.

"For, after supper, long he questioned / With modest Lucrece, and wore out the night:" This explains Tarquin's pretense. He spent a long time talking with Lucrece, ostensibly to wear out the night and appear tired. This establishes a contrast between his outward actions and his inner desires. The phrase "wore out the night" uses a metaphor – he's not just passing the time, he's wearing it down, suggesting a deliberate, manipulative strategy.

"Now leaden slumber with life's strength doth fight;" This line shifts focus to the overall atmosphere. "Leaden slumber" is a metaphor; sleep is heavy and slow, like lead. It's personified as fighting with "life's strength," indicating a struggle between rest and vitality, mirroring the internal conflict within Tarquin.

"And every one to rest themselves betake," This line describes the general descent into sleep, reinforcing the quiet before the storm. "Betake" means to apply or dedicate oneself.

"Save thieves, and cares, and troubled minds, that wake." This line contrasts the sleeping majority with those who remain awake, setting a tone of ominous anticipation. The list ("thieves,
and cares, and troubled minds") uses parallelism, highlighting the different types of unrest that prevent sleep. Tarquin's own troubled mind, of course, is implied within this group.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza sets the scene for the rape. It depicts Tarquin's deceptive behavior, feigning tiredness after a long conversation with Lucrece, while secretly harboring sinister intentions. The contrast between the general sleep and the wakefulness of those with troubled minds creates suspense and foreshadows the violence to come. The imagery of "leaden slumber" battling "life's strength" reflects the internal struggle and the impending disruption of the peaceful night. The stanza masterfully uses imagery, personification, metaphor, and parallelism to create a sense of dramatic irony and foreshadowing. We, the readers, are privy to Tarquin’s true intentions, while the other characters are unaware of the impending tragedy, creating a palpable tension.

← Stanza 17📚 OverviewStanza 19 →

For then is Tarquin brought unto his bed,
Intending weariness with heavy spright;
For, after supper, long he questioned
With modest Lucrece, and wore out the night:
Now leaden slumber with life's strength doth fight;
And every one to rest themselves betake,
Save thieves, and cares, and troubled minds, that wake.

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← Stanza 18📚 OverviewStanza 20 →

Stanza 19 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Tarquin's internal conflict as he weighs the risks and rewards of raping Lucrece. Let's break it down line by line:

"As one of which doth Tarquin lie revolving / The sundry dangers of his will's obtaining;" This opens with a simile ("As one of which"), comparing Tarquin to someone wrestling with a difficult decision. He is "revolving" (considering) the various ("sundry") dangers associated with fulfilling his lustful "will" (his desire to rape Lucrece). This sets up the internal struggle as the central theme.

"Yet ever to obtain his will resolving," Despite recognizing the dangers, Tarquin remains steadfast ("ever") in his resolve ("resolving") to achieve his goal. This highlights his stubbornness and determination, even in the face of potential consequences.

"Though weak-built hopes persuade him to abstaining:" Here, Shakespeare introduces the counterforce: "weak-built hopes" represent the rational part of Tarquin's mind suggesting he should refrain ("abstaining"). These hopes are described as "weak-built" to emphasize their fragility and inability to truly counter his powerful desire. The use of "persuade" suggests a struggle, not a complete victory of reason.

"Despair to gain doth traffic oft for gaining;" This line presents a paradox. "Despair to gain" – the despair of not achieving his goal – paradoxically becomes a motivator for achieving it ("doth traffic oft for gaining"). The desperation of failure fuels his determination. "Traffic" implies a calculated exchange, suggesting a cynical acceptance of risk for reward.

"And when great treasure is the meed proposed," This line introduces the "treasure" – the sexual conquest of Lucrece – as the prize ("meed") Tarquin desires. The phrasing elevates the act to something of immense value in his warped perspective.

"Though death be adjunct, there's no death supposed." This is the climax of the stanza. Even though death ("death be adjunct") is a potential consequence ("adjunct"), Tarquin dismisses it ("there's no death supposed"). He doesn't actively want to die, but the possibility of death is outweighed by the desired "treasure." The word "supposed" implies a willful ignorance or denial of the potential consequences.

Literary Devices:

Simile: "As one of which doth Tarquin lie revolving..."
Personification: "Despair to gain doth traffic oft for gaining" (Despair is given the human action of "trafficing").
Paradox: The central idea of despair motivating action is a paradox.
Antithesis: The contrasting ideas of "obtaining" and "abstaining" create antithesis.
Internal Conflict: The stanza vividly portrays Tarquin's internal struggle between desire and
reason.

Overall Meaning:

As one of which doth Tarquin lie revolving
The sundry dangers of his will's obtaining;
Yet ever to obtain his will resolving,
Though weak-built hopes persuade him to abstaining: Despair to gain doth traffic oft for gaining;
And when great treasure is the meed proposed, Though death be adjunct, there's no death supposed.

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The stanza portrays Tarquin's ruthless pursuit of his lustful desire. He is fully aware of the potential dangers, but his powerful craving and the perceived value of the prize overshadow any rational concerns. His decision-making process is driven by a desperate determination and a calculated willingness to accept even death as a potential consequence. The stanza masterfully showcases the corrupting influence of unchecked desire and the psychological mechanisms that justify morally reprehensible actions. Shakespeare uses the internal monologue to highlight the chilling logic of a rapist, where the potential reward blinds him to the profound wrong he is about to commit.

← Stanza 18📚 OverviewStanza 20 →

← Stanza 19📚 OverviewStanza 21 →

Stanza 20 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece explores the destructive nature of avarice and insatiable desire. Let's break it down line by line:

Line 1: "Those that much covet are with gain so fond," This line introduces the subject: those who excessively desire (covet) are foolishly attached ("fond") to the idea of gain. "Covet" implies a restless, unsatisfied longing.

Line 2: "For what they have not, that which they possess / They scatter and unloose it from their bond," This is a crucial line. It explains why the covetous are foolish. In their pursuit of what they lack, they neglect and squander ("scatter and unloose...from their bond") what they already have. The "bond" refers to the value or security of their possessions. This is a clear example of metaphor, representing possessions as being bound, easily lost through reckless pursuit of more.

Line 3: "And so, by hoping more, they have but less;" This line is the consequence of the previous one. By constantly chasing more, they end up with less, both materially and perhaps spiritually. This is a paradox, highlighting the irony of their situation.

Line 4: "Or, gaining more, the profit of excess / Is but to surfeit, and such griefs sustain," This line offers an alternative scenario: even if they achieve their excessive goals, the "profit of excess" only brings about "surfeit" (overindulgence leading to discomfort) and "griefs." This is another example of paradox, as more wealth leads to suffering.

Line 5: "That they prove bankrupt in this poor-rich gain." This line provides the conclusion. Despite appearing rich, their excessive pursuit of wealth ultimately renders them "bankrupt." This is a powerful oxymoron ("poor-rich gain") summarizing the whole stanza – they are financially wealthy but spiritually and emotionally impoverished.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza argues that insatiable greed is self-defeating. The relentless pursuit of more leads to the neglect and loss of what one already possesses, resulting in unhappiness even if material gains are achieved. The true wealth lies not in accumulating possessions but in appreciating and cherishing what one already has. Shakespeare uses the metaphor of binding and loosing to illustrate how greed weakens the value of one's existing assets. The stanza acts as a cautionary tale against avarice, foreshadowing the destructive consequences of uncontrolled desire, a theme relevant to Tarquin's lustful pursuit of Lucrece in the poem. The use of paradoxes and an oxymoron effectively emphasizes the irony and ultimately the tragic nature of unchecked ambition.

← Stanza 19📚 OverviewStanza 21 →

Those that much covet are with gain so fond,
For what they have not, that which they possess
They scatter and unloose it from their bond,
And so, by hoping more, they have but less;
Or, gaining more, the profit of excess
Is but to surfeit, and such griefs sustain,
That they prove bankrupt in this poor-rich gain.

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← Stanza 20📚 OverviewStanza 22 →

Stanza 21 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Shakespeare's stanza 21 from The Rape of Lucrece:

"The aim of all is but to nurse the life / With honour, wealth, and ease, in waning age;": This opening sets the stage. "The aim of all" refers to the universal human goal. "Nurse the life" signifies preserving and cherishing life, particularly in "waning age," meaning old age. The three things desired to achieve this are "honour, wealth, and ease," representing societal status, material comfort, and a peaceful existence. This is a straightforward statement of a common human aspiration.

"And in this aim there is such thwarting strife, / That one for all, or all for one we gage;": Here, Shakespeare introduces conflict. "Thwarting strife" highlights the inherent difficulties in pursuing this goal. The next line, "That one for all, or all for one we gage," introduces the central conflict. "Gage" means to pledge or risk. This suggests that people often must sacrifice one of these desired things (honour, wealth, ease) for the others. It's a choice between prioritizing one aspect ("one for all") or risking all for a single aspect ("all for one"). This is a powerful example of antithesis, contrasting the two options.

"As life for honour in fell battle's rage; / Honour for wealth; and oft that wealth doth cost / The death of all, and all together lost.": This section provides examples of the trade-offs described earlier. "Life for honour in fell battle's rage" illustrates how people risk their lives (life) to achieve honour (e.g., in war). "Honour for wealth" shows how someone might compromise their honour to gain wealth (e.g., through corruption). Finally, "oft that wealth doth cost / The death of all, and all together lost" presents the ultimate irony—the pursuit of wealth often leads to the loss
of everything (life, honour, and ease). The repeated use of "all" emphasizes the completeness of this potential loss. This section employs parallel structure for emphasis and rhythmic effect.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza explores the paradoxical nature of human ambition. While the fundamental aim is to secure a comfortable and honorable old age, the pursuit of this goal is fraught with internal conflict and potential loss. People are forced to make difficult choices, often sacrificing one aspect for another, and even the attainment of one desired element (like wealth) can lead to the loss of everything. It sets a tone of caution and underlines the inherent instability and potential for tragedy in the pursuit of worldly success. The stanza is a microcosm of the larger themes of the poem, which deals with the destructive nature of lust and the fragility of virtue. The use of literary devices enhances the poem's impact, creating a sense of both inevitability and tragedy in the human condition.

← Stanza 20📚 OverviewStanza 22 →

The aim of all is but to nurse the life
With honour, wealth, and ease, in waning age;
And in this aim there is such thwarting strife,
That one for all, or all for one we gage;
As life for honour in fell battle's rage;
Honour for wealth; and oft that wealth doth cost The death of all, and all together lost.

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← Stanza 21📚 OverviewStanza 23 →

Stanza 22 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Shakespeare's stanza 22 from The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identifying literary devices along the way:

"So that in venturing ill we leave to be / The things we are for that which we expect;"

"So that in venturing ill": This sets the context. "Venturing ill" refers to taking risky actions, pursuing ill-advised goals, often driven by ambition.
"we leave to be / The things we are": This is a powerful statement highlighting the self-destructive nature of such ventures. We abandon our present selves, our current state of being, often neglecting our existing possessions or happiness.
"for that which we expect": This points towards the allure of future possibilities and the hope of gaining something greater. This phrase highlights the seductive nature of ambition. This is an example of antithesis, contrasting "what we are" with "what we expect."

"And this ambitious foul infirmity,"

This line summarizes the preceding lines. "Ambitious foul infirmity" personifies ambition as a disease or weakness ("infirmity"). The word "foul" adds a moral judgment, implying that ambition in this context is corrupting.

"In having much, torments us with defect / Of that we have:"

"In having much, torments us with defect": This is a paradoxical statement. Despite possessing much, abundance ironically leads to a sense of lack or deficiency. This highlights the insatiable nature of ambition.
"Of that we have": We are tormented by a perceived deficiency in what we already possess, often because our desires are perpetually exceeding our attainment. This is another example of paradox.

"So then we do neglect / The thing we have; and, all for want of wit,"

"So then we do neglect / The thing we have": This is a direct consequence of the previous lines. Driven by our insatiable desire, we neglect and undervalue what we already have.
"and, all for want of wit": This assigns blame to a lack of wisdom or good judgment. This is a simple, direct statement emphasizing folly.

"Make something nothing by augmenting it."

This final line is a powerful oxymoron. By trying to make something more (augmenting it), we end up making it less (nothing). It perfectly sums up the self-defeating nature of unchecked ambition. It is a concise and impactful conclusion to the stanza.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza explores the destructive nature of unchecked ambition. Shakespeare argues that the pursuit of more often leads to a dissatisfaction with what one already possesses. This relentless pursuit, driven by a lack of wisdom ("want of wit"), ironically diminishes the value of existing things. The more we try to gain, the more we lose the appreciation of what we already have, ultimately rendering our gains meaningless. The stanza warns against the perils of insatiable desire and the

So that in venturing ill we leave to be
The things we are for that which we expect;
And this ambitious foul infirmity,
In having much, torments us with defect
Of that we have: so then we do neglect
The thing we have; and, all for want of wit, Make something nothing by augmenting it.

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importance of appreciating the present. The literary devices employed, particularly paradox and oxymoron, emphasize the ironic and self-destructive nature of this insatiable ambition.
← Stanza 21📚 OverviewStanza 23 →

← Stanza 22📚 OverviewStanza 24 →

Stanza 23 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece explores the moral decay and self-destruction of Tarquin, highlighting the consequences of his lustful pursuit of Lucrece. Let's break down each line:

Line 1: "Such hazard now must doting Tarquin make," This line introduces the central idea: Tarquin, described as "doting" (suggestive of senility or infatuation), is taking a significant risk. "Hazard" refers to the danger he puts himself in morally and potentially physically. The word "must" emphasizes the inevitability of his actions, driven by his overwhelming desire.

Line 2: "Pawning his honour to obtain his lust;" This line reveals the nature of the risk.
Tarquin is "pawning" his honor—his reputation and integrity—as collateral to achieve his "lust." This is a powerful metaphor, implying a transaction where he sacrifices something precious for something base.

Line 3: "And for himself himself be must forsake:" This line is the crux of the stanza. It uses striking repetition ("himself himself") to emphasize Tarquin's complete self-betrayal. He is abandoning his own best interests and moral compass in pursuit of his desires. The use of "forsake" suggests a deliberate rejection of his own self.

Line 4: "Then where is truth, if there be no self-trust?" This line poses a rhetorical question, highlighting the inherent connection between self-respect and truthfulness. If one cannot trust oneself, how can others trust them? This line introduces a broader philosophical reflection on the consequences of self-betrayal.

Line 5: "When shall he think to find a stranger just," This line continues the rhetorical questioning. If Tarquin cannot be just to himself, how can he expect justice or fairness from others ("a stranger")? It implies a lack of credibility and the impossibility of finding trust outside of oneself when one has lost internal integrity.

Line 6-7: "When he himself himself confounds, betrays / To slanderous tongues and wretched hateful days?" These lines conclude the stanza by highlighting the inevitable consequences of Tarquin's actions. He "confounds" (ruins) and "betrays" himself, leaving himself vulnerable to "slanderous tongues" (gossip and accusations) and "wretched hateful days" (a life filled with misery and regret). The repetition of "himself" reinforces the self-inflicted nature of his suffering.

Literary Devices:

Anaphora: The repetition of "himself himself" in lines 3 and 6 emphasizes the severity of Tarquin's self-betrayal.
Rhetorical Questions: The questions in lines 4 and 5 are not meant to be answered literally; they serve to emphasize the absurdity of Tarquin's actions and their consequences.
Metaphor: "Pawning his honour" is a strong metaphor illustrating the transactional nature of Tarquin's actions.
Personification: "Slanderous tongues" gives human-like qualities to gossip and accusations, emphasizing their power to harm.

Overall Meaning:

Such hazard now must doting Tarquin make,
Pawning his honour to obtain his lust;
And for himself himself be must forsake:
Then where is truth, if there be no self-trust? When shall he think to find a stranger just, When he himself himself confounds, betrays
To slanderous tongues and wretched hateful days?

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The stanza powerfully illustrates the self-destructive nature of unchecked lust and the erosion of moral integrity. Tarquin's pursuit of Lucrece leads him to betray himself, undermining his own sense of self-worth and making him vulnerable to external judgment and suffering. Shakespeare uses vivid language and rhetorical techniques to underscore the inextricable link between self-respect, truth, and the consequences of moral failure. The stanza acts as a warning about the dangers of prioritizing base desires over personal integrity.

← Stanza 22📚 OverviewStanza 24 →

← Stanza 23📚 OverviewStanza 25 →

Stanza 24 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Shakespeare's stanza from The Rape of Lucrece, line by line:

"Now stole upon the time the dead of night," This sets the scene. "Stole" personifies night, suggesting its quiet, stealthy arrival. "Dead of night" emphasizes the deepest, darkest part of the night, a time associated with vulnerability and danger.

"When heavy sleep had closed up mortal eyes:" This continues the setting, emphasizing the pervasive stillness and vulnerability of those asleep. "Heavy sleep" suggests a deep, unconscious slumber, making people defenseless.

"No comfortable star did lend his light," This builds suspense and foreshadows the impending violence. The absence of starlight creates darkness, both literally and metaphorically, symbolizing the lack of guidance and protection. The use of "comfortable" is interesting; stars are usually associated with comfort, but their absence amplifies the discomfort and danger.

"No noise but owls' and wolves' death-boding cries;" This uses onomatopoeia (the sounds mirroring the meaning— though not explicitly sounded out) and creates a terrifying atmosphere. Owls and wolves, traditionally associated with death and ill omen, further intensify the sense of foreboding. The "death-boding cries" are a clear sign of impending doom.

"Now serves the season that they may surprise" This line shifts the focus, indicating the opportune moment for the villains to act. "Season" here refers to the time and the circumstances, ideal for their nefarious plans.

"The silly lambs: pure thoughts are dead and still," This line introduces a metaphor. "Silly lambs" represent innocence and purity (Lucrece). "Pure thoughts are dead and still" suggests that virtue and innocence are passive and vulnerable in the face of evil. This is a powerful juxtaposition, highlighting the helplessness of the innocent against the forces of darkness.

"While lust and murder wake to stain and kill." This is the climax of the stanza. "Lust and murder" personified, are actively engaged and awake, ready to commit their vile acts. "Stain and kill" vividly depicts the physical and moral corruption that will follow. The use of parallelism with "stain and kill" emphasizes the dual nature of the impending crime— both physical violation and the corruption of innocence.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza establishes a dark and ominous atmosphere, perfectly setting the stage for the rape of Lucrece. It uses vivid imagery and personification to contrast the vulnerability of innocence (represented by the "silly lambs" and "pure thoughts") with the active malevolence of lust and murder, personified and empowered by the darkness of night. The absence of comforting light and the presence of death-boding cries heighten the sense of impending doom and foreshadow the devastating events to come. The stanza is a masterclass in creating suspense and highlighting the thematic conflict between innocence and evil that dominates the poem.

← Stanza 23📚 OverviewStanza 25 →

Now stole upon the time the dead of night,
When heavy sleep had closed up mortal eyes:
No comfortable star did lend his light,
No noise but owls' and wolves' death-boding cries;
Now serves the season that they may surprise
The silly lambs: pure thoughts are dead and still, While lust and murder wake to stain and kill.

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← Stanza 24📚 OverviewStanza 26 →

Stanza 25 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Tarquin's internal conflict as he wrestles with his lust for Lucrece. Let's break down each line:

"And now this lustful lord leap'd from his bed," This line sets the scene. "Lustful lord" immediately establishes Tarquin's character and the nature of his action. The verb "leaped" suggests impulsive, uncontrolled action, emphasizing his overwhelming desire.

"Throwing his mantle rudely o'er his arm;" This detail adds to the sense of urgency and disarray. The "rudely" suggests a lack of decorum, further highlighting his uncontrolled state. It's a physical manifestation of his inner turmoil.

"Is madly toss'd between desire and dread;" This is the core of the stanza. Tarquin is presented as being "madly toss'd," a metaphor depicting his internal conflict between his overwhelming lust ("desire") and the potential consequences ("dread"). This uses the literary device of personification, giving human qualities to abstract concepts of desire and dread.

"Th' one sweetly flatters, th' other feareth harm;" This line expands on the previous one, personifying desire and dread further. Desire "sweetly flatters," highlighting its seductive power, while dread "feareth harm," showing its rational, cautionary nature. The use of "sweetly" and "harm" creates a stark contrast.

"But honest fear, bewitch'd with lust's foul charm," Here, Shakespeare introduces a crucial element: "honest fear," representing Tarquin's conscience, is "bewitched" by lust. This is a powerful metaphor, showing how lust overcomes even rational apprehension. "Lust's foul charm" emphasizes the corrupting nature of desire.

"Doth too too oft betake him to retire," "Honest fear" initially tries to make Tarquin retreat ("retire"). The repetition of "too" ("too too oft") emphasizes the frequency of this internal struggle and the weakness of his resolve.

"Beaten away by brain-sick rude desire." Ultimately, lust ("brain-sick rude desire") triumphs. "Brain-sick" suggests a deranged mind, overwhelmed by passion. "Beaten away" uses violent imagery, signifying the complete domination of lust over reason and conscience.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza masterfully depicts the internal battle between Tarquin's lust and his conscience. While he experiences fear and momentary hesitation, his lust ultimately overpowers his better judgment. The imagery and personification highlight the seductive power of lust and its ability to corrupt even a seemingly rational individual. The stanza foreshadows the tragic consequences of Tarquin's actions, emphasizing the destructive nature of unchecked desire. It's a powerful psychological portrait demonstrating the internal conflict that leads to a morally reprehensible act.

← Stanza 24📚 OverviewStanza 26 →

And now this lustful lord leap'd from his bed,
Throwing his mantle rudely o'er his arm;
Is madly toss'd between desire and dread;
Th' one sweetly flatters, th' other feareth harm;
But honest fear, bewitch'd with lust's foul charm, Doth too too oft betake him to retire,
Beaten away by brain-sick rude desire.

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← Stanza 25📚 OverviewStanza 27 →

Stanza 26 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Tarquin's preparation for the rape, using the act of striking a flint to create a fire as a metaphor for his intended violation of Lucrece. Let's break down each line:

"His falchion on a flint he softly smiteth," This line sets the scene. "Falchion" is a type of sword. Tarquin strikes his sword, not directly to ignite anything, but to strike the flint. The word "softly" is intriguing; it suggests a calculated, controlled violence, foreshadowing the deceptive nature of his actions. This is a foreshadowing device.

"That from the cold stone sparks of fire do fly," This line describes the result of the strike – sparks emerging from the cold flint. This is a visually powerful image, showing the creation of something hot and vibrant from a cold, inert material. It is an example of imagery and sets up the metaphor.

"Whereat a waxen torch forthwith he lighteth," Tarquin uses the sparks to light a waxen torch. This highlights the deliberate nature of his actions; he's not just acting impulsively, but methodically preparing for his crime. The “forthwith” emphasizes the swiftness of his actions, although "softly" previously indicated deliberateness. This shows a conflict, highlighting the conflict within Tarquin himself. It is a significant contradiction.

"Which must be lode-star to his lustful eye;" The torch becomes a guiding light ("lode-star," meaning a guiding star or Polaris) for his lustful gaze. This is powerful metaphor, comparing the torch to his lust, which will guide his actions toward Lucrece. “Lustful eye” is personification, giving the eye a human quality.

"And to the flame thus speaks advisedly," Tarquin speaks to the flame. This is a sign of his deliberation and perhaps a hint of self-awareness of his wrongdoing. "Advisedly" suggests a conscious, planned decision. This indicates Tarquin is actively making the choice to rape.

"'As from this cold flint I enforced this fire,' This is the crux of the metaphor. Tarquin explicitly links the forcing of fire from the flint to his intention to force Lucrece. "Enforced" highlights the violence inherent in both actions. This is a key example of metaphor and simile (a comparison using "as").

'So Lucrece must I force to my desire.'" This line completes the metaphor, drawing a direct parallel between the violent extraction of fire and the violent act of rape he intends to commit upon Lucrece.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza uses the striking of flint to create fire as a powerful metaphor for Tarquin's planned rape of Lucrece. The careful preparation, the deliberate lighting of the torch, and the explicit comparison reveal Tarquin's calculated, cold, and violent intentions. The metaphor emphasizes the forceful, non-consensual nature of his act, highlighting the lack of respect and the inherently destructive nature of his desire. It also displays Tarquin's self-awareness of the violence he plans to perpetrate. The stanza foreshadows the rape and sets a dark and ominous tone for the events to come.

His falchion on a flint he softly smiteth,
That from the cold stone sparks of fire do fly;
Whereat a waxen torch forthwith he lighteth,
Which must be lode-star to his lustful eye;
And to the flame thus speaks advisedly,
'As from this cold flint I enforced this fire, So Lucrece must I force to my desire.'

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← Stanza 25📚 OverviewStanza 27 →

← Stanza 26📚 OverviewStanza 28 →

Stanza 27 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Tarquin's internal conflict before raping Lucrece. Let's break it down line by line:

"Here pale with fear he doth premeditate / The dangers of his loathsome enterprise,"
This sets the scene. "Pale with fear" uses vivid imagery to show Tarquin's apprehension, despite his intent. "Premeditate" emphasizes the conscious, planned nature of his actions, highlighting his guilt even before committing the act. "Loathsome enterprise" uses strong, negative diction to describe the rape, foreshadowing its repulsiveness.

"And in his inward mind he doth debate / What following sorrow may on this arise:" This reveals Tarquin's awareness of potential consequences. "Debate" suggests a struggle within his conscience. The phrase "following sorrow" foreshadows the devastating aftermath of his actions. This is a form of foreshadowing.

"Then looking scornfully, he doth despise / His naked armour of still-slaughter'd lust," This shows a shift in Tarquin's mindset. He attempts to dismiss his fear and guilt. "Looking scornfully" indicates a deliberate attempt to suppress his conscience. The powerful metaphor, "naked armour of still-slaughter'd lust," is crucial. "Naked armour" paradoxically portrays his lust as a feeble defense, not a strength. "Still-slaughter'd lust" is an oxymoron—lust is presented as already having caused death (symbolically, morally) even before the rape itself. This is a powerful metaphor and oxymoron.

"And justly thus controls his thoughts unjust:" This line marks the climax of the internal conflict. "Justly controls his thoughts unjust" is an ironic statement. Tarquin attempts to rationalize his evil intentions, claiming to exert control over his "unjust" thoughts, which further highlights the hypocrisy and self-deception at play. This is also an example of irony.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza portrays Tarquin's moment of internal conflict before the rape. While he is aware of the potential dangers and moral implications of his actions, his self-justification and arrogant dismissal of his conscience ultimately lead him to proceed with his heinous plan. Shakespeare uses vivid imagery, powerful metaphors, and ironic phrasing to expose the hypocrisy and self-deception at the heart of Tarquin's evil. The stanza prepares the reader for the brutality to follow, highlighting Tarquin’s conscious decision to commit the act despite his own internal warnings. The language emphasizes the premeditation and cold calculation involved, making the subsequent act even more reprehensible.

← Stanza 26📚 OverviewStanza 28 →

Here pale with fear he doth premeditate
The dangers of his loathsome enterprise,
And in his inward mind he doth debate
What following sorrow may on this arise:
Then looking scornfully, he doth despise
His naked armour of still-slaughter'd lust, And justly thus controls his thoughts unjust:

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← Stanza 27📚 OverviewStanza 29 →

Stanza 28 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece marks a turning point, shifting from the act of rape itself to a plea for purity and the condemnation of lust. Let's break it down line by line:

"Fair torch, burn out thy light, and lend it not / To darken her whose light excelleth thine:" This addresses the sun (the "fair torch"). The imagery suggests that the sun's light, representing beauty and virtue, should not illuminate Lucrece, whose inner light surpasses the sun's. This is a hyperbole (exaggeration), emphasizing Lucrece's exceptional purity. The implication is that the sun's light, if it shines on Lucrece after the rape, would somehow diminish her.

"And die, unhallow'd thoughts, before you blot / With your uncleanness that which is divine;" This is a direct command to lustful thoughts to cease. "Unhallowed thoughts" represent Tarquin's desires. The phrase "that which is divine" refers to Lucrece's virtue and purity, presented as something sacred and almost godly. The verb "blot" visually reinforces the idea of staining or corrupting something pure.

"Offer pure incense to so pure a shrine:" This line continues the religious imagery, comparing Lucrece to a sacred shrine. The "pure incense" represents the proper reverence and respect that should be shown to her. This is a metaphor, linking Lucrece's purity to religious devotion.

"Let fair humanity abhor the deed / That spots and stains love's modest snow-white weed." This is a general plea to humankind ("fair humanity") to condemn Tarquin's act. The phrase "love's modest snow-white weed" is another metaphor, describing Lucrece's chastity as a pure white flower (a "weed" here is used in the older sense meaning a plant, not a troublesome one).
The verbs "spots" and "stains" reiterate the defilement caused by the rape.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza serves as a powerful condemnation of Tarquin's actions and a celebration of Lucrece's virtue. Shakespeare uses vibrant imagery of light and darkness, purity and defilement, sacred and profane, to highlight the contrast between the rapist and the victim. The poem's speaker urges the extinguishing of lustful thoughts and a profound respect for Lucrece's moral purity, which is elevated to a near-divine status. The stanza acts as a moral interlude, emphasizing the gravity of the crime before delving into its consequences. It’s a call for justice and a lament for the violated innocence.

← Stanza 27📚 OverviewStanza 29 →

' Fair torch, burn out thy light, and lend it not
To darken her whose light excelleth thine:
And die, unhallow'd thoughts, before you blot
With your uncleanness that which is divine;
Offer pure incense to so pure a shrine:
Let fair humanity abhor the deed
That spots and stains love's modest snow-white weed.

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← Stanza 28📚 OverviewStanza 30 →

Stanza 29 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece is a powerful expression of Lucrece's self-reproach and shame following her rape by Tarquin. Let's break down each line:

"O shame to knighthood and to shining arms!" This line invokes the imagery of chivalry and military prowess, ideals associated with Tarquin's status as a nobleman and soldier. Lucrece is highlighting the hypocrisy of his actions, suggesting his supposed honour is a sham. The "shining arms" are a metonym for military glory and noble status. The "O" is an example of apostrophe, directly addressing abstract concepts (shame, knighthood).

"O foul dishonour to my household's grave!" This refers to the dishonour brought upon her family's lineage and reputation. "Household's grave" symbolizes the ancestral line and the lasting stain the rape will leave on her family's name.

"O impious act, including all foul harms!" This line emphasizes the wickedness and gravity of the act. "Impious" highlights the religious transgression, and "including all foul harms" emphasizes its encompassing nature—the damage done extends beyond the physical violation.

"A martial man to be soft fancy's slave!" This line is a stark contrast. "Martial man" again points to Tarquin's warrior image, while "soft fancy's slave" depicts him as controlled by lust ("soft fancy" is a euphemism for sexual desire). This is an example of oxymoron, juxtaposing opposing qualities. It underscores the unexpected weakness behind his outward strength.

"True valour still a true respect should have;" This line establishes a moral standard – true courage should be accompanied by respect for others. This is in direct contradiction to Tarquin's behavior.

"Then my digression is so vile, so base," This is Lucrece's self-condemnation. "Digression" refers to her yielding to Tarquin's advances, implying a deviation from virtue and proper conduct. The repetition of "so" emphasizes the profound nature of her shame.

"That it will live engraven in my face." This final line utilizes powerful imagery. Lucrece believes the shame of her rape will be permanently etched onto her face, a visual and lasting representation of her trauma. This foreshadows her suicide and the enduring nature of the dishonor.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza is a profound expression of Lucrece's despair and self-blame. It is not merely a lament, but a complex exploration of the societal expectations placed upon women, the hypocrisy of masculinity, and the lasting damage of sexual violence. She uses the language of chivalry and honor to highlight the violation of those very principles by Tarquin, internalizing the societal standards that judged her more harshly than her attacker. The stanza highlights the devastating psychological impact of rape, showing how a woman might internalize the shame and blame imposed upon her by a patriarchal society. The strong imagery and rhetorical devices emphasize the intensity of her emotional turmoil.

← Stanza 28📚 OverviewStanza 30 →

'O shame to knighthood and to shining arms!
O foul dishonour to my household's grave!
O impious act, including all foul harms!
A martial man to be soft fancy's slave!
True valour still a true respect should have; Then my digression is so vile, so base,
That it will live engraven in my face.

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← Stanza 29📚 OverviewStanza 31 →

Stanza 30 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece explores the lasting consequences of Lucrece's rape, specifically focusing on the shame and dishonor it will bring upon her and her lineage. Let's break it down line by line:

"Yea, though I die, the scandal will survive," This line establishes the central theme: even death won't erase the shame. The word "Yea" emphasizes the certainty and inevitability of this. The contrast between Lucrece's mortality and the scandal's immortality is stark.

"And be an eye-sore in my golden coat;" This is a powerful image. "Golden coat"
metaphorically represents Lucrece's high social standing and reputation, perhaps even her virtue and honor. The "eye-sore" – a blemish, a stain – signifies the scandal permanently marring her otherwise pristine image. This is a metaphor and also uses imagery to create a visual representation of shame.

"Some loathsome dash the herald will contrive," This refers to the family's coat of arms or lineage being defaced. The "herald" was the official responsible for recording and maintaining genealogical records and coats of arms. The "loathsome dash" represents the stain of the rape, a permanent alteration to her family's history. "Contrive" suggests a deliberate, malicious act of marking this family with shame.

"To cipher me how fondly I did dote;" This line uses the word "cipher" in the older sense of "to represent symbolically" or "to depict." Lucrece's actions, or inaction, in the face of the rape, will be interpreted as foolish "dote" (extreme fondness or infatuation, here implying naivete or weakness) and the heraldic symbol will communicate that interpretation. The rape is not only a scandal, but also evidence of a flaw in her character as interpreted by others.

"That my posterity, shamed with the note," This clarifies the consequence. Lucrece's descendants ("posterity") will bear the burden of this shame ("note," referring to the symbolic record of the scandal).

"Shall curse my bones, and hold it for no sin" This highlights the depth of the shame. Future generations will curse her for her perceived failings and even feel no guilt ("no sin") in doing so.

"To wish that I their father had not bin." This is the ultimate consequence: Lucrece's descendants will wish she had never existed. It reveals the profound and lasting impact of her rape, extending beyond her lifetime to affect her family for generations to come. This is a powerful statement about the destructive legacy of sexual violence.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza depicts the lasting and devastating effects of the rape on Lucrece's reputation and family legacy. It’s not just about the immediate trauma, but the indelible stain it leaves on her family name, passed down through generations. Shakespeare uses vivid imagery, metaphors, and powerful language to emphasize the permanence of this shame and the tragic consequences for Lucrece and her posterity. The stanza emphasizes the social repercussions of sexual assault, highlighting how victims often bear the brunt of societal judgment, even after their death.

'Yea, though I die, the scandal will survive,
And be an eye-sore in my golden coat;
Some loathsome dash the herald will contrive,
To cipher me how fondly I did dote;
That my posterity, shamed with the note
Shall curse my bones, and hold it for no sin To wish that I their father had not bin.

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← Stanza 29📚 OverviewStanza 31 →

← Stanza 30📚 OverviewStanza 32 →

Stanza 31 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece explores the fleeting nature of pleasure gained through immoral acts, specifically referencing Tarquin's lust for Lucrece. Let's break down each line:

"What win I, if I gain the thing I seek?" This opens with a rhetorical question, posing the central dilemma for Tarquin. "The thing I seek" refers to Lucrece's violation. This immediately establishes a questioning, self-reflective tone, atypical for a villain but highlighting the internal conflict, even if ultimately suppressed.

"A dream, a breath, a froth of fleeting joy." This line lists three metaphors depicting the ephemeral nature of the pleasure Tarquin anticipates. "Dream" suggests unreality, "breath" emphasizes its brevity, and "froth" its superficiality and lack of substance. The use of these short, evocative words creates a sense of fragility and impermanence.

"Who buys a minute's mirth to wail a week?" This is a rhetorical question that further emphasizes the disproportionate cost of the act. A "minute's mirth" represents the brief satisfaction of the rape, while "wail a week" suggests the prolonged suffering and consequences that will follow. This highlights the short-sightedness of pursuing immediate gratification.

"Or sells eternity to get a toy?" This continues the theme of disproportionate exchange, but on a grander scale. "Eternity" represents his soul, his moral standing, and his potential for future happiness, while "a toy" diminishes the act to something trivial and worthless. The hyperbole of "eternity" underscores the gravity of his choice.

"For one sweet grape who will the vine destroy?" This is a metaphor comparing the act to destroying the entire vine for just one grape. Lucrece's virtue is the "vine," a source of lasting value and beauty, while the "one sweet grape" represents the fleeting pleasure Tarquin seeks. This emphasizes the self-destructive nature of his desire.

"Or what fond beggar, but to touch the crown," This introduces another metaphor, comparing Tarquin’s lust to a beggar grasping at a crown. The "fond beggar" represents Tarquin's desperation and the inappropriateness of his desire.

"Would with the sceptre straight be strucken down?" This completes the metaphor. The "sceptre" symbolizes power and authority (associated with the crown) which is immediately lost ("struck down") upon the beggar's grasping. This emphasizes the fleeting nature of power gained through immoral means and the inevitable downfall that will follow.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza is a powerful meditation on the folly of pursuing immediate gratification at the cost of long-term happiness and moral integrity. Through a series of rhetorical questions and vivid metaphors, Shakespeare illustrates the ephemeral nature of sensual pleasure and the devastating consequences of sacrificing one's virtue for it. Tarquin, through this internal dialogue (even if unspoken aloud), reveals the conflict between his base desires and a faint awareness of the ruinous outcome. The stanza foreshadows the tragedy that will unfold. The literary devices of metaphor, rhetorical questions, and the use of short, impactful words contribute to the stanza's power and emotional resonance.

'What win I, if I gain the thing I seek?
A dream, a breath, a froth of fleeting joy.
Who buys a minute's mirth to wail a week?
Or sells eternity to get a toy?
For one sweet grape who will the vine destroy?
Or what fond beggar, but to touch the crown, Would with the sceptre straight be strucken down?

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← Stanza 30📚 OverviewStanza 32 →

← Stanza 31📚 OverviewStanza 33 →

Stanza 32 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Shakespeare's stanza from The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, identifying literary devices:

"If Collatinus dream of my intent," This line opens with a conditional clause, setting up a hypothetical situation. Tarquin, the speaker, considers the possibility that his husband, Collatinus, might somehow become aware of his plan to rape Lucrece. The word "dream" subtly suggests a premonition or subconscious awareness, adding to the tension.

"Will he not wake, and in a desperate rage" This continues the hypothetical, highlighting the expected reaction from Collatinus if he were to learn of Tarquin's plan. "Desperate rage" emphasizes the intensity of Collatinus's potential response.

"Post hither, this vile purpose to prevent?" This line shows Tarquin anticipating Collatinus's swift action ("post hither"—travel quickly here) to thwart his ("this vile purpose") plan. The rhetorical question serves to underscore Tarquin's own anxieties about being discovered.

"This siege that hath engirt his marriage," This line uses a powerful metaphor. "Siege" evokes the image of a military assault, comparing Tarquin's actions to a forceful attack on the sanctity of Collatinus's marriage. "Engirt" further emphasizes the encirclement and threat.

"This blur to youth, this sorrow to the sage," This is a parallel structure (using "this... this...") It expands on the consequences of the rape, suggesting it will cause a loss of innocence ("blur to youth") and deep sorrow ("sorrow to the sage") for both the young and the old, indicating the broad impact of the crime.

"This dying virtue, this surviving shame," This line continues the parallel structure and uses powerful personification. "Dying virtue" represents the destruction of Lucrece's innocence and goodness. "Surviving shame," in contrast, indicates the lasting, inescapable stain the rape will leave behind, even after the act itself is over.

"Whose crime will bear an ever-during blame?" This final line concludes the stanza with a rhetorical question, emphasizing the permanent and inescapable nature of the guilt and condemnation associated with the act. "Ever-during blame" signifies the eternal weight of the consequences.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza reveals Tarquin's internal conflict. While he is determined to rape Lucrece, he is also acutely aware of the potential consequences. He imagines Collatinus's furious reaction and the devastating impact his actions will have—not just on Lucrece and Collatinus, but on society as a whole. The stanza uses vivid imagery and rhetorical questions to intensify the drama and foreshadow the tragedy to come. The multiple uses of "this" create a sense of accumulating horror and inescapable consequences. The metaphors, particularly the "siege," emphasize the violent and destructive nature of the planned rape. The stanza powerfully foreshadows the lasting shame and devastating effects of the rape that are further developed in the poem.

← Stanza 31📚 OverviewStanza 33 →

' If Collatinus dream of my intent,
Will he not wake, and in a desperate rage
Post hither, this vile purpose to prevent?
This siege that hath engirt his marriage,
This blur to youth, this sorrow to the sage, This dying virtue, this surviving shame, Whose crime will bear an ever-during blame?

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← Stanza 32📚 OverviewStanza 34 →

Stanza 33 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Tarquin's internal struggle and overwhelming guilt after raping Lucrece. Let's break down each part:

"O, what excuse can my invention make," This line opens with an exclamation of despair. "Invention" here doesn't mean creativity, but rather, the ability to devise a plan or excuse. Tarquin is desperately searching for a way to justify his actions, acknowledging his need for a fabricated defense. The use of "O" is an apostrophe, a direct address to himself, reflecting his inner turmoil.

"When thou shalt charge me with so black a deed?" This line reveals the anticipated accusation. "Thou" refers to Lucrece herself, or possibly his own conscience acting as an accuser. "So black a deed" is a powerful metaphor highlighting the gravity of the rape, using the color black to symbolize evil and moral darkness.

"Will not my tongue be mute, my frail joints shake," This line anticipates his physical reaction to the accusation. He foresees his inability to speak ("mute"), his body betraying him through trembling ("frail joints shake"). This is pathetic fallacy, where the physical state reflects the inner emotional state.

"Mine eyes forego their light, my false heart bleed?" This continues the depiction of his physical response, his eyes losing their light suggesting shame and despair. "My false heart bleed" is a powerful image; hearts don't literally bleed, but this metaphor represents the inner pain and remorse, highlighting the hypocrisy ("false") of his actions. The use of "bleed" evokes a visceral reaction, enhancing the emotional impact.

"The guilt being great, the fear doth still exceed; " This line establishes a direct relationship between the magnitude of his guilt and the intensity of his fear. The guilt is the cause, the fear is the effect. Note the use of elevated language ("doth still exceed") reflecting the seriousness of the situation.

"And extreme fear can neither fight nor fly," This line presents a powerful paradox. Fear usually prompts either confrontation ("fight") or escape ("fly"). But Tarquin's fear is so overwhelming, it paralyzes him, rendering him completely helpless.

"But coward-like with trembling terror die." This final line concludes the stanza with a
powerful metaphor. Fear has become a form of death – a figurative death, representing his moral demise and the end of his self-respect. The simile "coward-like" underscores his moral weakness and lack of courage to face the consequences of his actions.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza portrays Tarquin's paralyzing fear and guilt following the rape. He anticipates Lucrece's accusation and his own inability to defend himself, not only because he has no legitimate defense, but because his overwhelming guilt has rendered him physically and mentally incapacitated. He isn't simply afraid of punishment; he is experiencing a profound moral breakdown, a spiritual death brought about by his own actions. The imagery of physical manifestations of guilt—shaking limbs, dimming sight, a bleeding heart—emphasizes the internal torment he suffers. The stanza highlights the devastating psychological consequences of his crime, foreshadowing his eventual downfall.

'O, what excuse can my invention make,
When thou shalt charge me with so black a deed?
Will not my tongue be mute, my frail joints shake,
Mine eyes forego their light, my false heart bleed?
The guilt being great, the fear doth still exceed;
And extreme fear can neither fight nor fly,
But coward-like with trembling terror die.

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← Stanza 32📚 OverviewStanza 34 →

← Stanza 33📚 OverviewStanza 35 →

Stanza 34 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece explores Lucrece's internal conflict and justification (or lack thereof) for Tarquin's actions. Let's break it down line by line:

"Had Collatinus kill'd my son or sire," This line establishes a hypothetical scenario. Lucrece imagines a situation where her husband, Collatinus, had committed grievous acts against her family. This sets up a potential justification for revenge or anger.

"Or lain in ambush to betray my life," This continues the hypothetical, escalating the severity. Collatinus is now portrayed as attempting to murder Lucrece herself. Again, this creates a context where strong negative emotions, even actions, might be understandable.

"Or were he not my dear friend, this desire / Might have excuse to work upon his wife," Here, the "desire" refers to Tarquin's lustful intentions. Lucrece suggests that if Collatinus were her enemy, Tarquin's actions might be seen as justifiable revenge, or at least understandable within the context of a feud. The phrase "work upon his wife" subtly implies that the act would be directed against Collatinus through his wife.

"As in revenge or quittal of such strife:" This reinforces the previous line, emphasizing the potential for revenge as a motive. "Quittal" means repayment or retribution.

"But as he is my kinsman, my dear friend," This is the pivotal turning point. Lucrece abruptly shifts from hypothetical justification to the reality of the situation. Collatinus is not her enemy, but rather her close relative and beloved husband.

"The shame and fault finds no excuse nor end." This concluding line is the crux of the stanza. There is no justification for Tarquin's actions; the shame and the "fault" (the rape itself) remain utterly inexcusable.

Literary Devices:

Hypothetical situation: Lucrece uses a series of "what if" clauses ("Had...Or...Or were...") to explore the potential justifications for Tarquin's actions if Collatinus were an enemy. This is a powerful way to highlight the stark contrast with the actual reality.

Antithesis: The stark opposition between the hypothetical scenarios and the actual relationship between Lucrece and Collatinus creates a strong antithesis, emphasizing the unforgivable nature of the rape.

Rhetorical questions (implied): While not explicitly posed, the stanza implies several rhetorical questions: "Could such actions be excused if...?" "But given the truth, what excuse remains?"

Parallelism: The repetition of "Or" in the second and third lines creates parallelism, building up the hypothetical scenarios and amplifying the reader's understanding of Lucrece's thought process.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza powerfully illustrates Lucrece's moral struggle. She attempts, almost desperately, to find any justification for Tarquin's horrific act, exploring the possibility of revenge or reprisal as a warped explanation. However, this exercise only serves to highlight the utter lack of justification for the rape,

' Had Collatinus kill'd my son or sire,
Or lain in ambush to betray my life,
Or were he not my dear friend, this desire
Might have excuse to work upon his wife,
As in revenge or quittal of such strife:
But as he is my kinsman, my dear friend,
The shame and fault finds no excuse nor end.

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given the reality of Collatinus's virtuous character and his loving relationship with Lucrece. The stanza underscores the depth of the tragedy and the profound injustice committed against her. It moves from a hypothetical exploration towards a tragic acceptance of the unjustifiable.

← Stanza 33📚 OverviewStanza 35 →

← Stanza 34📚 OverviewStanza 36 →

Stanza 35 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece explores Tarquin's internal conflict and justification for pursuing Lucrece. Let's break it down line by line:

"Shameful it is; ay, if the fact be known:" Tarquin acknowledges the shamefulness of his intended actions. The "fact" refers to his rape of Lucrece. The conditional clause ("if the fact be known") shows he's aware of the social repercussions but prioritizes his desire. The use of "ay" emphasizes his reluctant admission.

"Hateful it is; there is no hate in loving:" This is a paradoxical statement. He attempts to rationalize his lust by claiming that genuine love cannot be hateful. This is a weak argument, as his actions are inherently disrespectful and violent. The juxtaposition of "hateful" and "loving" highlights the internal conflict and the flawed logic he employs. This is an example of antithesis.

"I'll beg her love; but she is own:" He states his intention to "beg" Lucrece's love, a blatant underestimation of the situation. "She is own" implies she's already married and therefore unattainable – another obstacle he seemingly ignores. This shows his arrogance and disregard for her agency.

"The worst is but denial and reproving:" He downplays the potential consequences. He believes the worst outcome would be rejection ("denial") and criticism ("reproving"). This understates the gravity of his intended crime. This line exhibits understatement.

"My will is strong, past reason's weak removing:" This is a powerful statement showcasing Tarquin's hubris. He asserts his desire ("will") is stronger than reason, suggesting he's driven by passion rather than logic or morality. This is a clear example of hyperbole (exaggeration of his will's strength) and personification (giving reason human qualities of weakness and ability to be removed).

"Who fears a sentence or an old man's saw / Shall by a painted cloth be kept in awe."
This is a proverb-like statement. He dismisses the fear of punishment ("sentence") or conventional wisdom ("old man's saw"). He implies that anyone who hesitates due to such fears is easily intimidated ("kept in awe") by mere appearances ("painted cloth"). This uses metaphor (the "painted cloth" representing superficial threats) and synecdoche ("old man's saw" representing the wisdom of elders).

Overall Meaning:

This stanza reveals Tarquin's self-deceptive justifications for his planned rape. He superficially acknowledges the shamefulness and potential consequences, but his unwavering desire, coupled with his arrogant dismissal of societal norms and moral considerations, drives him forward. He rationalizes his actions through flawed logic, highlighting his lack of empathy and respect for Lucrece's autonomy. The stanza underscores the dangerous combination of powerful lust and a disregard for reason and morality. The literary devices used emphasize the dramatic irony of Tarquin's self-delusion and the inevitability of his actions' tragic consequences.

← Stanza 34📚 OverviewStanza 36 →

' Shameful it is; ay, if the fact be known:
Hateful it is; there is no hate in loving:
I'll beg her love; but she is own:
The worst is but denial and reproving:
My will is strong, past reason's weak removing. Who fears a sentence or an old man's saw
Shall by a painted cloth be kept in awe.'

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← Stanza 35📚 OverviewStanza 37 →

Stanza 36 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece describes Tarquin's internal conflict before raping Lucrece, focusing on the battle between his conscience and his desires. Let's break it down line by line:

"Thus, graceless, holds he disputation / 'Tween frozen conscience and hot-burning will," This sets the scene. "Thus" refers to the preceding events, showing the progression of Tarquin's descent. "Graceless" immediately establishes Tarquin's moral failing. He engages in a "disputation"
– a debate – between two opposing forces within himself: a "frozen conscience" (a cold, inactive, perhaps weak sense of morality) and a "hot-burning will" (a powerful, passionate desire, fueled by lust). The imagery of "frozen" versus "hot-burning" creates a stark contrast highlighting the intensity of his internal struggle.

"And with good thoughts make dispensation, / Urging the worser sense for vantage still;" Here, Tarquin actively manipulates his own moral compass. He grants himself "dispensation" (permission) from good thoughts, allowing them to be overridden. He "urges the worser sense" (his lustful desires) "for vantage still," meaning he consistently uses his base desires to gain an advantage, justifying his actions, even if only to himself. This reveals a cunning and manipulative aspect to his character.

"Which in a moment doth confound and kill / All pure effects, and doth so far proceed," The "which" refers to the prioritizing of his lust. The effect of this is swift and destructive: his base desires ("worser sense") "confound and kill" all pure effects – destroying any positive consequences or virtue he might have had. The action progresses rapidly and drastically.

"That what is vile shows like a virtuous deed." This is the culmination of the stanza's
argument. Tarquin's self-deception is so complete that his vile act (rape) appears, in his mind, to be a virtuous deed. This highlights the power of self-justification and the dangerous potential of unchecked desire.

Literary Devices:

Personification: "Frozen conscience" and "hot-burning will" are abstract concepts given human-like qualities.
Antithesis: The opposition between "frozen conscience" and "hot-burning will" creates a powerful contrast. Also, "good thoughts" versus "worser sense" establishes a clear dichotomy.
Imagery: The vivid imagery of "frozen" and "hot-burning" creates a visceral sense of the conflict within Tarquin.
Paradox: The final line presents a paradox: something inherently vile is made to seem virtuous. This reflects the twisted nature of Tarquin's justifications.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza vividly depicts Tarquin's moral collapse. He doesn't simply succumb to his lust; he actively rationalizes and justifies his actions, ultimately twisting his perception of right and wrong. The internal struggle is not a battle between good and evil, but rather a manipulation of his conscience to allow his base desires to prevail, demonstrating the insidious nature of self-deception and the ease with which

Thus, graceless, holds he disputation
'Tween frozen conscience and hot-burning will,
And with good thoughts make dispensation,
Urging the worser sense for vantage still;
Which in a moment doth confound and kill
All pure effects, and doth so far proceed, That what is vile shows like a virtuous deed.

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one can rationalize immoral behavior. It foreshadows the heinous act to come and highlights the psychological complexity of the villain.
← Stanza 35📚 OverviewStanza 37 →

← Stanza 36📚 OverviewStanza 38 →

Stanza 37 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Lucrece's initial interaction with Tarquin, before the rape itself. Let's break it down line by line:

"Quoth he, 'She took me kindly by the hand," This line introduces Tarquin's perspective (indicated by "Quoth he," an archaic form of "said he"). It sets a seemingly innocent and courteous tone, as Lucrece welcomes him with a friendly gesture. This is ironic foreshadowing, as we know Tarquin's true intentions are far from kind.

"And gazed for tidings in my eager eyes," Lucrece's gaze is described as searching for news ("tidings") in Tarquin's eyes. "Eager eyes" suggests anticipation and perhaps a degree of anxiety, reflecting her concern for her husband's safety.

"Fearing some hard news from the warlike band," This line reveals the source of Lucrece's anxiety: she's worried about her husband, Collatinus, who's away at war ("warlike band"). The phrase "hard news" implies bad or devastating news, setting a tone of apprehension.

"Where her beloved Collatinus lies." This line reinforces Lucrece's love and concern for her husband, emphasizing her vulnerability and dependence on him. The word "lies" is subtly ambiguous; it can mean both "rests" (as in sleeping) and "is situated/located," adding to the suspense.

"O, how her fear did make her colour rise!" This exclamation marks a shift in focus from dialogue to Lucrece's physical reaction. Her fear manifests as a change in her complexion, demonstrating the intensity of her emotional state.

"First red as roses that on lawn we lay," This line uses a simile to describe the initial flush of her fear. Her face turns red, compared to the vibrant red of roses resting on a green lawn. The image is visually striking and emphasizes the beauty of Lucrece even in her distress. The use of "we lay" is a subtle poetic license, personifying the roses.

"Then white as lawn, the roses took away." This line continues the simile, showing the rapid change in her complexion. As her fear intensifies, the redness fades, leaving her pale as the lawn itself, suggesting faintness or near-collapse. The phrase "the roses took away" is a powerful metaphor, implying the fear has drained the colour from her face, leaving her drained and vulnerable.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza masterfully establishes the deceptive calm before the storm. While presenting a seemingly innocent encounter, it subtly hints at the underlying tension and vulnerability of Lucrece's situation. Through imagery, simile, metaphor, and carefully chosen words, Shakespeare creates a sense of foreboding, preparing the reader for the horrific events to come. The description of Lucrece's fluctuating complexion, mirroring the fragility of her emotional state, highlights her innocence and her impending doom at the hands of Tarquin. The contrast between the initial courteous interaction and Lucrece's internal fear underscores the deceptive nature of Tarquin's charm and foreshadows the violence to follow.

Quoth he, 'She took me kindly by the hand,
And gazed for tidings in my eager eyes,
Fearing some hard news from the warlike band,
Where her beloved Collatinus lies.
O, how her fear did make her colour rise! First red as roses that on lawn we lay,
Then white as lawn, the roses took away.

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← Stanza 36📚 OverviewStanza 38 →

← Stanza 37📚 OverviewStanza 39 →

Stanza 38 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece focuses on Lucrece's reaction to the threat of rape, specifically highlighting her internal struggle and the power of her loyalty. Let's break it down line by line:

"And how her hand, in my hand being lock'd": This begins with an observation, seemingly from the perspective of Tarquin (though it's presented within Lucrece's internal monologue or a narrator's account of her experience). He notes the physical contact, the locking of hands, implying a moment of intimacy or attempted intimacy before the assault. The phrasing is deliberately understated.

"Forced it to tremble with her loyal fear!": This is crucial. Lucrece's hand trembles not from fear of Tarquin's physical power (at least not primarily), but from "loyal fear"—fear for her husband's honor and well-being. This establishes her steadfast virtue and prioritization of her marital vows over her own immediate safety. The use of "forced" suggests the involuntary nature of her trembling, a manifestation of her intense inner turmoil.

"Which struck her sad, and then it faster rock'd,": The trembling ("which") is the cause of her sadness, emphasizing the connection between her physical reaction and her emotional state. The "faster rock'd" uses a metaphor of a rocking or swaying movement, suggesting the increasing intensity of her fear and anxiety. The image is both physical and emotional.

"Until her husband's welfare she did hear;": This line provides the resolution, albeit temporary, to Lucrece's anxiety. The news of her husband's well-being provides a moment of relief, a temporary respite from the overwhelming fear.

"Whereat she smiled with so sweet a cheer,": This presents a stark contrast to the previous lines. The relief leads to a beautiful, genuine smile. "Cheer" implies both happiness and courage.

"That had Narcissus seen her as she stood,": This introduces a hypothetical scenario, a powerful hypothetical simile. Narcissus, the mythical figure who fell in love with his own reflection, is invoked here.

"Self-love had never drown'd him in the flood.": This line completes the simile. Lucrece's beauty is so captivating that even Narcissus, consumed by self-love, would have been distracted from his own reflection, implying her beauty surpasses even that which captivated the vain Narcissus. The "flood" refers to the pool in which Narcissus died.

Literary Devices:

Simile (extended): The comparison of Lucrece's beauty to its ability to surpass Narcissus' self-obsession is a sustained simile that runs through the final two lines.
Metaphor: "Faster rock'd" is a metaphor for the intensification of her fear.
Enjambment: The run-on lines create a sense of continuous flow, mirroring the continuous nature of Lucrece's emotional experience.
Personification: The hand's trembling is almost personified, acting independently. Understatement: The description of the physical encounter between Tarquin and Lucrece is very understated in the first line compared to the intense emotion described later.

'And how her hand, in my hand being lock'd
Forced it to tremble with her loyal fear!
Which struck her sad, and then it faster rock'd,
Until her husband's welfare she did hear;
Whereat she smiled with so sweet a cheer,
That had Narcissus seen her as she stood, Self-love had never drown'd him in the flood.

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Overall Meaning:

The stanza masterfully portrays Lucrece's strength and virtue through her reaction to fear. Her primary concern is not her own safety, but her husband's welfare. Her trembling hand, her sadness, and her subsequent smile all emphasize the depth of her loyalty and the profound impact of the looming threat. The final lines, using the Narcissus simile, highlight her extraordinary beauty and the power it holds, even in the face of immense distress. The stanza is not just about physical beauty, but also about inner strength and the unwavering dedication to her marital vows which eventually becomes a key factor in her later tragic choice.

← Stanza 37📚 OverviewStanza 39 →

← Stanza 38📚 OverviewStanza 40 →

Stanza 39 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece explores Tarquin's internal struggle as he contemplates raping Lucrece. Let's break down each line:

"Why hunt I then for colour or excuses?": This opens with a rhetorical question. Tarquin acknowledges his internal debate and the futility of searching for justifications ("colour" meaning pretext or plausible reason) for his actions. He's already decided, but a flicker of doubt or guilt is present.

"All orators are dumb when beauty pleadeth;": This is a hyperbole and personification. "Orators" represent reason and logic, rendered speechless ("dumb") by Lucrece's beauty. Beauty is personified as having such power that it silences rational argument. This suggests Tarquin's lust overrides his better judgment.

"Poor wretches have remorse in poor abuses;": This line is somewhat ambiguous. "Poor wretches" could refer to Tarquin himself, acknowledging his own potential for regret ("remorse") after committing a "poor abuse" (a wretched act). Alternatively, it could refer to others who have committed similar acts, implying that even those who act badly might feel remorse. The word "poor" is used ironically.

"Love thrives not in the heart that shadows dreadeth:": This is a paradoxical statement. Tarquin attempts to rationalize his actions by claiming true love ("Love") doesn't fear consequences ("shadows"). This is a clear self-deception; his "love" is clearly lust, not genuine affection.

"Affection is my captain, and he leadeth;": This is a powerful metaphor. "Affection," representing lust, is personified as a military commander ("captain") completely controlling Tarquin's actions. He's surrendering his free will.

"And when his gaudy banner is display'd,": The metaphor continues. "Affection's" "gaudy banner" represents the alluring and deceptive nature of lust, visually striking but ultimately leading to destruction. "Gaudy" hints at its superficial attractiveness.

"The coward fights and will not be dismay'd.": This is an oxymoron. Tarquin, despite calling himself a "coward" for yielding to his base desires, ironically claims he will not be deterred. He is a coward because he is not fighting his desires, but he also shows a false bravery in proceeding with his plan.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza reveals Tarquin's self-justification and rationalization before committing rape. He tries to silence his conscience, using the power of Lucrece's beauty and the intoxicating force of lust to excuse his impending actions. He uses military metaphors to portray himself as a soldier controlled by his desires, ultimately accepting his fate and rejecting moral reasoning. The stanza highlights the conflict between reason and passion, with passion winning decisively. The literary devices employed – hyperbole, personification, metaphor, paradox, and oxymoron – serve to amplify the internal turmoil and the self-deception fueling Tarquin's descent into violence.

← Stanza 38📚 OverviewStanza 40 →

'Why hunt I then for colour or excuses?
All orators are dumb when beauty pleadeth;
Poor wretches have remorse in poor abuses;
Love thrives not in the heart that shadows dreadeth: Affection is my captain, and he leadeth;
And when his gaudy banner is display'd,
The coward fights and will not be dismay'd.

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← Stanza 39📚 OverviewStanza 41 →

Stanza 40 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece marks a crucial turning point in Lucrece's internal conflict. Let's break it down line by line:

"Then, childish fear, avaunt! debating, die!": This is a forceful opening, rejecting both fear ("childish fear") and indecision ("debating"). "Avaunt!" is a commanding interjection meaning "get away!" This line employs apostrophe (direct address to abstract concepts) and personification (giving human qualities to fear and debating). Lucrece is actively silencing her anxieties and rational doubts.

"Respect and reason, wait on wrinkled age!": Here, Lucrece dismisses respect and reason as virtues belonging to older people. This is a form of antithesis, contrasting youth's passion with age's caution. She's rejecting the wisdom associated with age in favor of youthful impulsiveness.

"My heart shall never countermand mine eye:": This line establishes a crucial conflict – the heart (emotion) and the eye (desire, perception). Lucrece declares that her heart (representing reason and morality) will not oppose her desires as perceived by her eyes. This shows a subjugation of reason to passion.

"Sad pause and deep regard beseem the sage;": This line continues the antithesis, contrasting the contemplative actions of a wise person ("sad pause and deep regard") with her own impulsive behavior. "Beseem" means "is appropriate for." The use of "sage" emphasizes the rejection of wisdom she's choosing to ignore.

"My part is youth, and beats these from the stage:": This line uses a theatrical metaphor ("stage") to illustrate Lucrece's forceful rejection of reason and caution. "Beats these from the stage" signifies the forceful expulsion of those qualities, highlighting the dominance of her youthful passion.

"Desire my pilot is, beauty my prize;": This line clearly states her motivations. Desire is now her guide ("pilot"), and beauty is her ultimate goal ("prize"). This is a powerful declaration of her yielding to temptation.

"Then who fears sinking where such treasure lies?": This concluding line rhetorically asks who would fear danger ("sinking") when such a valuable reward ("treasure") is at stake. It's a rhetorical question designed to justify her actions and further dismiss her anxieties. The use of "treasure" elevates beauty to a highly desirable object, worth any risk.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza reveals Lucrece's decision to abandon her reason and morality in favor of her passionate desire for Tarquin. She actively rejects the wisdom and caution of older generations, embracing the impulsiveness of youth. This is a significant moment as she consciously chooses to prioritize her physical desire over her moral integrity, setting the stage for the tragic events to follow. Shakespeare uses various literary devices to powerfully convey Lucrece's internal struggle and her ultimate surrender to temptation. The stanza is characterized by strong self-justification and a deliberate dismissal of any counter-arguments.

'Then, childish fear, avaunt! debating, die!
Respect and reason, wait on wrinkled age!
My heart shall never countermand mine eye:
Sad pause and deep regard beseem the sage;
My part is youth, and beats these from the stage: Desire my pilot is, beauty my prize;
Then who fears sinking where such treasure lies?'

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← Stanza 39📚 OverviewStanza 41 →

← Stanza 40📚 OverviewStanza 42 →

Stanza 41 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Tarquin's internal conflict as he approaches Lucrece's chamber. Let's break it down line by line:

"As corn o'ergrown by weeds, so heedful fear / Is almost choked by unresisted lust." This is a simile comparing Tarquin's fear to corn choked by weeds. "Heedful fear" represents Tarquin's awareness of the wrong he's about to commit. "Unresisted lust" is his overpowering desire, which is presented as a stronger force, metaphorically overwhelming his conscience. The imagery emphasizes the struggle within Tarquin—his fear is present but severely weakened.

"Away he steals with open listening ear," This line describes Tarquin's stealthy approach. The "open listening ear" suggests both his attentiveness to potential danger and his eagerness to hear any sign of Lucrece's presence (or absence). This subtle detail adds to the suspense and builds the tension.

"Full of foul hope and full of fond mistrust;" This line highlights the paradoxical nature of Tarquin's state of mind. "Foul hope" refers to his wicked anticipation of success in his crime, while "fond mistrust" suggests a lingering doubt or fear of failure or discovery. The juxtaposition of "foul" and "fond" amplifies the internal conflict. The use of "full of" emphasizes the overwhelming nature of these conflicting emotions.

"Both which, as servitors to the unjust," This line personifies "foul hope" and "fond mistrust," portraying them as servants attending to Tarquin's unjust intentions. This personification allows Shakespeare to more easily portray the internal conflict as a battle of wills.

"So cross him with their opposite persuasion," This line indicates how these conflicting emotions continuously pull Tarquin in different directions, preventing him from acting decisively. "Opposite persuasion" emphasizes the contrasting nature of hope and mistrust, making his decision-making even more torturous.

"That now he vows a league, and now invasion." This line reveals the oscillating nature of Tarquin's intentions. "League" suggests a peaceful approach, possibly implying a desire to somehow reconcile his lust with his conscience, while "invasion" clearly refers to his violent plan. The repetition of "now" highlights the rapid back-and-forth of his thoughts.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza powerfully portrays Tarquin's inner turmoil in the face of his impending crime. His lust is a dominant force, but it's not without internal resistance. The conflict isn't a simple moral struggle; it's a chaotic interplay of conflicting emotions, each pulling him in different directions. The vivid imagery of the overgrown corn and the personified "servitors" paints a picture of a man consumed by his desire yet plagued by doubt and fear, highlighting the psychological complexity of the villain. Shakespeare masterfully uses literary devices to create suspense and illuminate the character's internal conflict. The stanza serves as a build-up to the horrific act to follow, making the ensuing rape even more impactful.

← Stanza 40📚 OverviewStanza 42 →

As corn o'ergrown by weeds, so heedful fear
Is almost choked by unresisted lust.
Away he steals with open listening ear,
Full of foul hope and full of fond mistrust; Both which, as servitors to the unjust,
So cross him with their opposite persuasion, That now he vows a league, and now invasion.

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← Stanza 41📚 OverviewStanza 43 →

Stanza 42 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece describes Tarquin's conflicted internal state after seeing Lucrece. Let's break it down line by line:

"Within his thought her heavenly image sits," This establishes the primary image: Lucrece's beauty is so striking that it occupies Tarquin's mind completely. "Heavenly image" uses metaphor to emphasize her surpassing loveliness and purity. The verb "sits" suggests a settled, persistent presence, not a fleeting impression.

"And in the self-same seat sits Collatine:" This is crucial. In Tarquin's mind, Lucrece's husband, Collatine, coexists with her image. This is not a peaceful coexistence, however. The "self-same seat" highlights the direct competition for Tarquin's attention and, by implication, Lucrece's affections. This is a powerful use of juxtaposition.

"That eye which looks on her confounds his wits;" This refers to one aspect of Tarquin's vision: his lustful gaze towards Lucrece, which overwhelms his reason ("confounds his wits"). This is personification – giving the "eye" the ability to act independently.

"That eye which him beholds, as more divine," This introduces a second gaze, a more virtuous one, which recognizes Lucrece's purity ("more divine"). This is a counterpoint to the lustful gaze – a conscience struggling against temptation.

"Unto a view so false will not incline;" This virtuous gaze rejects ("will not incline") the deceptive ("false") allure of lust. "False" refers to the falsity of Tarquin's desires in light of Lucrece's virtue.

"But with a pure appeal seeks to the heart," This "pure appeal" is a plea from reason to the heart, a metaphor for conscience trying to persuade the will. "Pure appeal" emphasizes the moral integrity of this part of Tarquin's consciousness.

"Which once corrupted takes the worser part;" This is the tragic crux. The heart, representing his will and emotions, is ultimately susceptible to corruption. Once lust ("corrupted") takes over, it chooses the destructive course of action ("worser part"). This highlights the vulnerability of moral strength to powerful temptation.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza masterfully portrays Tarquin's internal struggle between lust and conscience. His mind is a battlefield where the image of Lucrece and the competing impulses of desire and virtue clash. While a part of him recognizes her virtue and the wrongfulness of his intentions, ultimately, his lustful desires prevail, foreshadowing the rape to come. The use of metaphorical "eyes" and the personification of internal conflicts effectively captures the psychological complexity of the moment. The stanza serves as a powerful illustration of the internal conflict that often precedes morally reprehensible actions.

← Stanza 41📚 OverviewStanza 43 →

Within his thought her heavenly image sits,
And in the self-same seat sits Collatine:
That eye which looks on her confounds his wits;
That eye which him beholds, as more divine,
Unto a view so false will not incline;
But with a pure appeal seeks to the heart, Which once corrupted takes the worser part;

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← Stanza 42📚 OverviewStanza 44 →

Stanza 43 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Tarquin's descent into lust and his impending assault on Lucrece. Let's break it down line by line:

"And therein heartens up his servile powers," This line introduces Tarquin's "servile powers," which are his base instincts and desires, acting as his subservient forces. The verb "heartens" signifies that Tarquin encourages and emboldens these base desires within himself. This use of personification grants agency to his lustful impulses.

"Who, flatter'd by their leader's jocund show," This line explains how Tarquin's lustful desires are fueled. His own cheerful and playful ("jocund") demeanor ("leader's jocund show") flatters and encourages them. The use of "flatter'd" implies a deceptive self-deception; Tarquin's outward joy masks the darkness within.

"Stuff up his lust, as minutes fill up hours;" This line uses a simile ("as minutes fill up hours") to illustrate how Tarquin's lust grows uncontrollably. Just as minutes accumulate to form hours, so his base desires accumulate and intensify, filling him completely. "Stuff up" vividly portrays the overwhelming and suffocating nature of his lust.

"And as their captain, so their pride doth grow," This line continues the military metaphor. Tarquin's lustful desires are depicted as soldiers ("their"), and their growing "pride" mirrors his own increasing confidence, fueled by his unchecked passion. This emphasizes the escalating nature of his depravity.

"Paying more slavish tribute than they owe." Here, the metaphor shifts slightly. His desires, once his servants, are now demanding more than he initially intended, showing how lust consumes and enslaves. The phrase "slavish tribute" emphasizes the humiliating and excessive nature of this surrender to his passions.

"By reprobate desire thus madly led," This line summarizes Tarquin's state. "Reprobate desire" refers to his wicked and morally condemned lust. The adverb "madly" highlights the irrational and uncontrolled nature of his actions.

"The Roman lord marcheth to Lucrece' bed." This final line concludes the stanza with a stark and ominous statement. Tarquin, the "Roman lord," is now fully committed to his vile act, marching towards Lucrece's bed – signifying his impending rape. The word "marcheth" lends a sense of inevitability and grim determination.

Overall Meaning: The stanza depicts the internal struggle and ultimate triumph of Tarquin's base desires. Shakespeare uses powerful imagery and metaphors—particularly the military metaphor—to illustrate how Tarquin's lust grows exponentially, fuelled by self-deception and unchecked passion, leading him inexorably to commit the horrific act of rape. The stanza emphasizes the destructive power of unchecked desire and the self-deception that often accompanies moral failings. The dramatic irony lies in the fact that Tarquin, a Roman lord, is about to be consumed by his own depravity.

← Stanza 42📚 OverviewStanza 44 →

And therein heartens up his servile powers,
Who, flatter'd by their leader's jocund show,
Stuff up his lust, as minutes fill up hours;
And as their captain, so their pride doth grow,
Paying more slavish tribute than they owe.
By reprobate desire thus madly led,
The Roman lord marcheth to Lucrece' bed.

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← Stanza 43📚 OverviewStanza 45 →

Stanza 44 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Part-by-Part Breakdown:

"The locks between her chamber and his will,"
"The locks": Literal locks on the doors, but also a metaphor representing barriers of chastity and privacy.
"between her chamber and his will": Highlights the physical space and the forceful intentions
of Tarquin (his "will"). "Her chamber" represents Lucrece's sanctity and the area to be violated.

"Each one by him enforced, retires his ward;"
"Each one": Referring to each lock.
"by him enforced": Tarquin is forcing the locks open (violent act).
"retires his ward": "Ward" refers to the locking mechanism (the part of the lock that is guarded) "Retires" means the locks are yielding.

"But, as they open, they all rate his ill,"
"But, as they open": Transition as the locks are breached.
"they all rate his ill": The locks, personified, "rate" or condemn Tarquin's actions. The opening of the locks is a silent judgment.
Literary Device: Personification - Giving human qualities (judgment) to inanimate objects (locks).

"Which drives the creeping thief to some regard:"
"Which": Refers to the silent condemnation of the locks opening.
"creeping thief": Tarquin is described as a "creeping thief" emphasizing his stealthy and dishonorable actions.

"to some regard": Forces him to consider the enormity of his actions. Though a pause, it will not stop him.

"The threshold grates the door to have him heard;"
"The threshold grates": The threshold (the floor piece under the door) makes a grinding noise as Tarquin steps over it.
"the door to have him heard": The door's groaning sound seems to be warning or trying to alert someone.

Literary Device: Personification - The threshold is given a human quality.

"Night-wandering weasels shriek to see him there;"
"Night-wandering weasels": Weasels, often seen as sly creatures, are here a symbol of the darkness of the night. They seem to be witnesses or observers of Tarquin's action.
"shriek to see him there": The weasels cry in terror at his presence, highlighting the darkness and the wrongness of what he's doing.
Literary Device: Symbolism - The weasels.

"They fright him, yet he still pursues his fear."
"They fright him": The various omens and the judgmental surroundings are frightening him and are making him pause.

The locks between her chamber and his will,
Each one by him enforced, retires his ward;
But, as they open, they all rate his ill,
Which drives the creeping thief to some regard:
The threshold grates the door to have him heard; Night-wandering weasels shriek to see him there; They fright him, yet he still pursues his fear.

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"yet he still pursues his fear": Despite the fear and foreboding, Tarquin persists in his lust.
"His fear" could refer to either his apprehension about being discovered or to the fear that will lead to the act.
Literary Device: Paradox - He pursues his fear.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza portrays Tarquin's approach to Lucrece's chamber as a journey of transgression. The physical barriers (the locks) and the environment itself (threshold, weasels) are personified, turning into agents of condemnation and warning. The imagery paints a picture of stealth, violation, and a growing sense of the evil of Tarquin's intentions. Despite being aware of the sin he is committing, and the warning signals from the outside world, Tarquin pushes forward, compelled by his lust. The stanza emphasizes both the physical act of the break-in and the moral decay within Tarquin. The contrast of his internal desire to the external warnings makes this stanza very poignant.

← Stanza 43📚 OverviewStanza 45 →

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← Stanza 44📚 OverviewStanza 46 →

Stanza 45 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

As each unwilling portal yields him way,
Tarquin, the intruder, is forcing his way through doors ("unwilling portals") that do not open for him willingly, symbolizing the resistance of both the physical space and Lucrece herself.

Through little vents and crannies of the place
He moves stealthily, taking advantage of small openings and cracks in the building, emphasizing his secretive and illicit intentions.

The wind wars with his torch to make him stay,
As he moves, the wind blows against his torch, as if nature itself is trying to hinder his progress and prevent him from going further.

And blows the smoke of it into his face,
The wind not only threatens to extinguish the torch but also blows the smoke into Tarquin’s face, blinding and impeding him, symbolizing both literal and moral obstruction.

Extinguishing his conduct in this case;
The wind almost puts out his torch, which is his guide ("conduct") in the darkness, suggesting that his path is not only physically but morally obscured.

But his hot heart, which fond desire doth scorch,
Despite these obstacles, Tarquin’s burning passion ("hot heart") and uncontrollable desire drive him on, undeterred by the resistance of the world around him.

Puffs forth another wind that fires the torch:
His own breath, heated by his desire, rekindles the torch, symbolizing how his lust overcomes all opposition, both natural and moral.

Overall Meaning

This stanza vividly depicts Tarquin’s forced entry, with the physical environment and even the elements themselves seemingly conspiring to stop him. The wind tries to extinguish his torch, a metaphor for his conscience or guidance, but his overpowering desire reignites it. Shakespeare uses this imagery to show the struggle between Tarquin’s base impulses and the natural, moral resistance to his crime, highlighting the violence and unnaturalness of his actions.

Literary Devices

Personification: The wind is given agency, as if it actively tries to stop Tarquin.
Metaphor: The torch represents both literal light and Tarquin’s moral guidance.
Symbolism: The unwilling portals, vents, and wind all symbolize resistance to Tarquin’s crime; his own breath symbolizes the triumph of lust over conscience.

← Stanza 44📚 OverviewStanza 46 →

As each unwilling portal yields him way,
Through little vents and crannies of the place
The wind wars with his torch to make him stay,
And blows the smoke of it into his face,
Extinguishing his conduct in this case;
But his hot heart, which fond desire doth scorch, Puffs forth another wind that fires the torch:

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← Stanza 45📚 OverviewStanza 47 →

Stanza 46 - Explanation

Original Stanza

And being lighted, by the light he spies Lucretia's glove, wherein her needle sticks: He takes it from the rushes where it lies, And griping it, the needle his finger pricks; As who should say 'This glove to wanton tricks Is not inured; return again in haste; Thou see'st our mistress' ornaments are chaste.'

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

And being lighted, by the light he spies
With his torch now relit, Tarquin is able to see around him thanks to the light.

Lucretia's glove, wherein her needle sticks:
He notices Lucrece’s glove, which still has her sewing needle stuck in it, suggesting her recent presence and her domestic, innocent activities.

He takes it from the rushes where it lies,
Tarquin picks up the glove from the floor (rushes were commonly used as floor coverings), further invading Lucrece’s personal space.

And griping it, the needle his finger pricks;
As he grabs the glove, the needle pricks his finger, causing him pain—a symbolic warning or a sign of guilt.

As who should say 'This glove to wanton tricks
The prick of the needle seems to tell him that this glove has never been used for immoral acts (“wanton tricks”).

Is not inured; return again in haste;
The glove is not accustomed to such behavior and urges him to put it back quickly, as if the objects in Lucrece’s room are themselves chaste and virtuous.

Thou see'st our mistress' ornaments are chaste.'
The glove and needle seem to insist that their owner, Lucrece, is pure and virtuous, and that Tarquin’s intentions are dishonorable.

Overall Meaning
This stanza uses the imagery of Lucrece’s personal belongings to reinforce her innocence and virtue. The glove and needle, symbols of her domesticity and chastity, almost “speak” to Tarquin, warning him against his intended crime. The pain from the needle acts as a physical and moral warning, highlighting the unnaturalness and guilt of Tarquin’s actions.

Literary Devices
Symbolism: The glove and needle symbolize Lucrece’s innocence and purity.
Personification: The glove and needle are given voices and agency, as if they can warn or admonish Tarquin.
Foreshadowing: The prick of the needle hints at the pain and guilt that will follow Tarquin’s violation of Lucrece.

← Stanza 45📚 OverviewStanza 47 →

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← Stanza 46📚 OverviewStanza 48 →

Stanza 47

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

This stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece depicts Tarquin's relentless pursuit of Lucrece, despite obstacles. Let's break down each line:

"But all these poor forbiddings could not stay him;" This line establishes the central conflict. "Poor forbiddings" refers to the subtle resistances Lucrece offers – perhaps a hesitant demeanor, closed doors, or the wind delaying him. The word "poor" suggests the weakness of these attempts to deter him, highlighting Tarquin's overwhelming force.

"He in the worst sense construes their denial:" This is crucial. Tarquin doesn't interpret Lucrece's subtle refusals as genuine rejections. Instead, ("in the worst sense construes") he perversely interprets them as a game, a coy form of encouragement, or a test of his determination. This demonstrates his arrogant disregard for her agency.

"The doors, the wind, the glove, that did delay him," This line provides concrete examples of the minor obstacles Tarquin encounters. The "glove" could be a detail meant to suggest a dropped item that briefly hinders him, furthering the image of subtle resistance. These are presented as seemingly insignificant impediments.

"He takes for accidental things of trial;" Tarquin rationalizes the delays, viewing them not as deliberate rejections but as mere "accidental things of trial"—challenges to be overcome, rather than signs that he should desist. This is a form of metonymy, where the obstacles represent Lucrece's rejection.

"Or as those bars which stop the hourly dial," This line introduces a metaphor. The "bars" that stop the hourly dial represent the minor obstacles. The dial itself symbolizes the unstoppable progress of time, and the the "bars" delaying its progress suggest the temporary nature of Lucrece's resistance – it's delaying the inevitable.

"Who with a lingering slay his course doth let," The "dial" (personified as "who") is actively involved in delaying ("doth let") Tarquin's advance. "Lingering slay" is an oxymoron, suggesting a slow, methodical killing of time. This further emphasises Tarquin’s determination; even the obstacles only serve to make him more deliberate.

"Till every minute pays the hour his debt." This final line concludes the metaphor. Just as each minute eventually contributes to the completion of an hour, so too will each obstacle eventually lead to Tarquin's success in violating Lucrece. It suggests an inexorable, almost deterministic march toward rape.

Overall Meaning

The stanza depicts Tarquin's unwavering determination to achieve his goal. He refuses to acknowledge Lucrece's refusals, actively misinterpreting any obstacle as a mere test or delay on the inevitable path to his conquest. The imagery of the clock emphasizes the unstoppable nature of his pursuit, highlighting the vulnerability of Lucrece in the face of his unrelenting will. The use of metaphor and personification enhances the feeling of inevitability, foreshadowing the tragic rape to come. The poem uses these devices to critique male entitlement and predatory behavior.

But all these poor forbiddings could not stay him;
He in the worst sense construes their denial:
The doors, the wind, the glove, that did delay him,
He takes for accidental things of trial;
Or as those bars which stop the hourly dial,
Who with a lingering slay his course doth let,
Till every minute pays the hour his debt.

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Literary Devices

Personification: The wind is given agency, as if it actively tries to stop Tarquin.
Metaphor: The torch represents both literal light and Tarquin’s moral guidance.
Symbolism: The unwilling portals, vents, and wind all symbolize resistance to Tarquin’s crime; his own breath symbolizes the triumph of lust over conscience.
← Stanza 46📚 OverviewStanza 48 →

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← Stanza 47📚 OverviewStanza 49 →

Stanza 48 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"So, so,' quoth he, 'these lets attend the time,"

Meaning: Tarquin is speaking. "So, so" indicates a calculated acceptance or rationalization.
"Lets" means hindrances or obstacles. He's saying that these obstacles are normal for this time (i.e., for achieving his goal).
Literary Devices:
Direct Speech: Brings the reader into Tarquin's perspective.

"Like little frosts that sometime threat the spring,"

Meaning: He compares the obstacles to minor frosts that sometimes occur in springtime. These frosts are unpleasant but don't ultimately prevent the spring from arriving.
Literary Devices:
Simile: Uses "like" to compare the obstacles to frosts.
Imagery: Evokes the image of a fragile spring being threatened.

"To add a more rejoicing to the prime,"

Meaning: These small setbacks actually increase the joy and appreciation of the springtime when it finally arrives fully. "Prime" here refers to the peak of spring.
Literary Devices:
Paradox: The idea that a threat can add to joy seems contradictory.
Alliteration: 'prime' uses 'p' as previously used in 'pays'.

"And give the sneaped birds more cause to sing."

Meaning: "Sneaped" means checked, rebuked, or nipped. So, birds that have been silenced or subdued by the frost will sing with more enthusiasm when the weather improves.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Continues the spring imagery, focusing on the return of life and joy.
Personification: Giving birds the human emotion of "cause to sing."

"Pain pays the income of each precious thing;"

Meaning: This is the crux of the stanza's philosophy. You have to endure pain or hardship to earn or appreciate something valuable.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Life is a commercial transaction.
Aphorism: A concise statement of a principle or truth.

"Huge rocks, high winds, strong pirates, shelves and sands,"

Meaning: Lists various dangers a merchant faces at sea.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Invokes the dangers and uncertainty of sailing.
Polysyndeton: The use of many conjunctions ("and") to create a sense of overwhelming obstacles.

' So, so,' quoth he, 'these lets attend the time,
Like little frosts that sometime threat the spring,
To add a more rejoicing to the prime,
And give the sneaped birds more cause to sing.
Pain pays the income of each precious thing;
Huge rocks, high winds, strong pirates, shelves and sands, The merchant fears, ere rich at home he lands.'

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"The merchant fears, ere rich at home he lands."

Meaning: The merchant must confront all these fears and dangers before he can achieve the desired wealth and safe return home.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: Of 'rich' and 'rocks' or 'winds'

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is Tarquin's rationalization of the obstacles he faces in his pursuit of Lucrece. He uses the metaphor of spring and a merchant's journey to justify his actions. He argues that these challenges are actually beneficial, increasing the eventual pleasure he will derive from "possessing" Lucrece. He is using a distorted logic to convince himself that the potential consequences or moral implications of his actions are worth it, because the "prize" (Lucrece) will be all the more enjoyable after overcoming these "lets."

The stanza highlights the twisted and self-serving nature of Tarquin's thinking. He's attempting to elevate his lustful desires by framing them as a natural and even positive part of achieving something valuable. He's essentially saying that a bit of "pain" (for himself, and of course, far more for Lucrece) is a necessary investment for the ultimate "income" of pleasure. The reference to the merchant reinforces the idea that he views Lucrece as a commodity to be acquired, rather than a human being. It also shows how his ambition and lust are blinding him to the true moral implications of his planned actions.

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← Stanza 48📚 OverviewStanza 50 →

Stanza 49 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Now is he come unto the chamber-door,"

Meaning: This line establishes the immediate setting and action. Tarquin has arrived at Lucrece's bedroom door. It is a direct statement, setting the scene.
Literary Device: Enjambment carries the reader forward, increasing anticipation.

"That shuts him from the heaven of his thought,"

Meaning: This line uses metaphorical language. "The heaven of his thought" refers to the idealized, perhaps romanticized, vision Tarquin had of Lucrece or of achieving his desire. The door, a physical barrier, now separates him from this idealized vision. It suggests that the act of pursuing her physically is a corruption of his initial, perhaps more innocent, thoughts.
Literary Device: Metaphor: Comparing his desire to "heaven".

"Which with a yielding latch, and with no more,"

Meaning: The door is easily opened. The "yielding latch" suggests Lucrece's vulnerability and the ease with which Tarquin can overcome her physical defenses. "With no more" emphasizes how little resistance stands between him and his goal.
Literary Device: Understatement: "With no more" minimizes the physical barrier but heightens the moral one.

"Hath barr'd him from the blessed thing he sought."

Meaning: This line seems contradictory at first. He's physically at the door, about to seize Lucrece. But, it argues that the act itself has now removed him from actually obtaining what he truly desired. That 'blessed thing' is now tainted and no longer pure, and thus out of reach. A potential reading is that it is now tainted because of the sin he is about to commit.
Literary Device: Irony: While he's physically closer to his goal, he's emotionally and morally further away from the "blessed thing." This also continues the heaven/hell theme.

"So from himself impiety hath wrought,"

Meaning: This is a key line. "Impiety" (lack of reverence for the divine, wickedness) has originated from within Tarquin himself. His own immoral desires and actions have created this situation. He is the architect of his own downfall and moral corruption.
Literary Device: Personification: "Impiety hath wrought" implies that the wicked act is actively working against him.

"That for his prey to pray he doth begin,"

Meaning: This line is deeply disturbing and ironic. Tarquin, about to commit a heinous crime, paradoxically starts to pray. However, he's not praying for forgiveness or guidance. He is praying that the deed goes well. He's asking for divine assistance in his wicked pursuit of Lucrece as "prey".
Literary Device: Juxtaposition/Oxymoron: The act of praying is contrasted with the immoral act he is about to commit. Irony: He seeks divine help for a profoundly ungodly act.

Now is he come unto the chamber-door,
That shuts him from the heaven of his thought,
Which with a yielding latch, and with no more,
Hath barr'd him from the blessed thing be sought.
So from himself impiety hath wrought,
That for his prey to pray he doth begin,
As if the heavens should countenance his sin.

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"As if the heavens should countenance his sin."

Meaning: This line expresses the sheer audacity and delusion of Tarquin. He presumes, in his arrogance, that the heavens would condone or even support his sin. It highlights his complete lack of moral compass and his self-deception.
Literary Device: Irony: The heavens would never condone such an act. Hyperbole: The idea
that the heavens would "countenance his sin" exaggerates his delusion.

Overall Meaning:

Stanza 49 is a pivotal moment in the poem. It depicts Tarquin at the threshold, both physically and morally. The lines reveal the internal conflict and moral corruption that drive him. He has distanced himself from any idealized notion he had and embraced the reality of his sinful desire. His audacity is emphasized by the idea that he would pray for success in his crime, as if the heavens would endorse such wickedness. The stanza powerfully shows how he is the agent of his own downfall, the "impiety" originating from within. It sets the stage for the devastating consequences of his actions.

Key Literary Devices Highlighted:

Metaphor: Comparing his desire to "heaven."
Irony: The disparity between his supposed desire and his actions, and the idea of praying for success in a sin.
Juxtaposition/Oxymoron: The contrast between prayer and the act of rape. Personification: "Impiety hath wrought."
Understatement: "With no more" to emphasize the lack of true resistance.
Hyperbole: The idea that the heavens would "countenance his sin"
Enjambment: Contributes to the sense of forward momentum and rising tension.

This stanza is a masterclass in characterization and dramatic tension, revealing Tarquin's internal state and foreshadowing the tragedy to come.
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← Stanza 49📚 OverviewStanza 51 →

Stanza 50 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "But in the midst of his unfruitful prayer,"

"But": Establishes a contrast or turning point.
"In the midst of": Shows he's actively engaged in praying.
"His unfruitful prayer": This is the crucial part. The prayer isn't working, it's "unfruitful." He's not finding solace or divine sanction. The prayer isn't helping him in his task.

Line 2: "Having solicited th' eternal power"

"Having solicited": He has been actively pleading with, begging. "Solicited" implies earnest effort.
"Th' eternal power": Refers to God or the heavens, the divine realm.

Line 3: "That his foul thoughts might compass his fair fair,"

"That": Connects to the previous line, indicating the content of his prayer.
"His foul thoughts": His lustful, wicked desires.
"Might compass": "Compass" means to achieve, accomplish, or overtake. He wants his evil thoughts to succeed in their purpose.
"His fair fair": This is a key phrase. The repetition of "fair" emphasizes Lucrece's beauty and purity. Fair most likely is being used as a noun here and refers to his fair desire - Lucrece.

Line 4: "And they would stand auspicious to the hour,"

"And they": Refers back to the "eternal power" from line 2.
"Would stand auspicious": He is praying that the gods would be favorable or grant good omens for the coming act.
"To the hour": Refers to the specific moment when he plans to commit the rape.

Line 5: "Even there he starts: quoth he, 'I must deflower:"

"Even there": Emphasizes that this realization happens right in the middle of his prayer.
"He starts": He's startled or jolted by a thought.
"Quoth he": Archaic for "said he," indicating direct speech.
"'I must deflower:'": This is a brutal, declarative statement. "Deflower" is a euphemism for the violent act of taking a woman's virginity. The statement shows his determination, yet it is also tinged with internal conflict.

Line 6: "The powers to whom I pray abhor this fact,"

"The powers to whom I pray": Again, referring to the divine beings.
"Abhor this fact": They hate/detest/loathe this deed, that is, the rape.

Line 7: "How can they then assist me in the act?"

"How can they then assist me": He poses a logical question to himself. If the gods hate what he's about to do, how can he expect them to help him?

But in the midst of his unfruitful prayer,
Having solicited th' eternal power
That his foul thoughts might compass his fair fair,
And they would stand auspicious to the hour,
Even there he starts: quoth he, 'I must deflower:
The powers to whom I pray abhor this fact,
How can they then assist me in the act?

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"In the act": Refers to the rape itself.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza captures the psychological turmoil of Tarquin as he contemplates the rape of Lucrece. He attempts to justify his intentions by praying for divine assistance, but his prayer is "unfruitful" because he realizes the act he's about to commit is inherently evil and therefore cannot be sanctioned by the gods. This realization creates a conflict. He wants divine approval, but he knows it's impossible. The stanza highlights the contradiction between his desire and his understanding of morality, yet he continues on his path to rape her.

Literary Devices:

Internal Conflict: The entire stanza is driven by Tarquin's internal struggle. He's caught between his lustful desire and his (faint) sense of morality and the knowledge that his actions are
condemned by God.
Irony: It is ironic that Tarquin seeks divine assistance for an act that is inherently sinful and
against the will of the very powers he is praying to. This highlights his moral blindness and self-deception.
Repetition/Emphasis: The repetition of "fair" emphasizes Lucrece's innocence and the wickedness of Tarquin's intentions.
Apostrophe: Tarquin is speaking to the divine powers, which cannot literally speak back to him. Euphemism: "Deflower" is a gentler term for the violent act of rape.
Rhetorical Question: The final line is a rhetorical question, not meant to be answered but to emphasize the logical absurdity of his position.

In essence, Stanza 50 is a pivotal moment where Tarquin acknowledges the wickedness of his plan, yet he still chooses to proceed, sealing his fate and setting the tragic events of the poem in motion.

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← Stanza 50📚 OverviewStanza 52 →

Stanza 51 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Then Love and Fortune be my gods, my guide!"

Meaning: The speaker (Tarquin) is declaring that he will be guided and motivated by lust
("Love") and the belief in his own success ("Fortune"). He is essentially rejecting traditional
morality and embracing self-serving desires.
Literary Devices:
Invocation: He is invoking "Love" and "Fortune" as if they were deities, calling upon them for help and guidance. This highlights the perversion of his values. These concepts have replaced
any sense of morality or divinity for him.
Personification: "Love" and "Fortune" are personified, being treated as entities that can guide him.

"My will is back'd with resolution:"

Meaning: He is determined and resolute in his intentions. His desire is strong, and he has made up his mind.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: There's subtle alliteration in the 'w' sound of "will" making the line more
impactful.
Metaphor: He's saying that his "will" (desire) is "backed" or supported by determination, implying strength and solidity.

"Thoughts are but dreams till their effects be tried;"

Meaning: He is dismissing moral contemplation and hesitation as useless until action is taken. He believes that an idea is only validated when it's put into practice.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Comparing thoughts to "dreams" suggests that they are insubstantial and unreal until they become actions.
Pragmatism/Rationalization: This line represents Tarquin's rationalization of his immoral
act. He's convincing himself that the act itself will provide the clarity he needs, overriding any preemptive moral judgments.

"The blackest sin is clear'd with absolution;"

Meaning: He believes that he can be forgiven or absolved of even the worst sin (the rape he intends to commit). This is both an expression of his arrogance and perhaps a misguided belief in divine or earthly forgiveness. He might think that the fulfillment of his desire will justify the sin, or that his position will protect him from consequences.
Literary Devices:
Irony: This line drips with irony because the act he's about to commit is precisely the kind of
sin that cannot be easily cleared. His belief in absolution is a delusion.
Allusion: "Absolution" is a religious term implying forgiveness, highlighting his distortion of religious concepts to justify his actions.

'Then Love and Fortune be my gods, my guide!
My will is back'd with resolution:
Thoughts are but dreams till their effects be tried;
The blackest sin is clear'd with absolution;
Against love's fire fear's frost hath dissolution. The eye of heaven is out, and misty night
Covers the shame that follows sweet delight.'

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"Against love's fire fear's frost hath dissolution."

Meaning: The "fire" of his lust is so intense that it melts away any "frost" of fear or moral qualms. His desire overcomes his inhibitions.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Love's fire" and "fear's frost" are metaphors representing powerful emotions.
** противопоставление (Juxtaposition/Contrast):** The contrast between "fire" and "frost" is important. It highlights the battle between Tarquin's passion and his conscience, with passion winning.
Alliteration: The repetition of the "f" sound in "fear's frost" adds to the impact and
emphasizes the coldness that is being overcome.

"The eye of heaven is out, and misty night"

Meaning: It is night, and the sun (often seen as a symbol of justice and divine observation) is no longer watching. The darkness provides a cover for his actions.
Literary Devices:
Symbolism: "The eye of heaven" symbolizes divine judgement, morality, or even just public scrutiny. Its being "out" suggests the absence of these things.
Personification: "The eye of heaven" personifies the sun or perhaps God.
Pathetic Fallacy: The "misty night" reflects the moral obscurity and confusion that he is embracing.

"Covers the shame that follows sweet delight."

Meaning: The darkness will conceal the shame that will inevitably follow the pleasure (which he falsely believes will be "sweet") he seeks. This is a premonition of the guilt and consequences that await him.
Literary Devices:
Foreshadowing: This line hints at the eventual shame and regret that Tarquin will experience.
It foreshadows the tragic consequences of his actions.
Juxtaposition/Oxymoron (Implied): "Sweet delight" is contrasted with "shame," creating a sense of unease. The implication is that the delight will not be purely sweet, but will be tainted
by shame.
Symbolism: The "shame" represents the moral consequences and the feeling of guilt that will
haunt him.

Overall Meaning:

Stanza 51 is a crucial moment in the poem. It provides a disturbing insight into Tarquin's mindset just before the rape. He is completely consumed by his lust, rationalizing his actions by invoking "Love" and "Fortune" as his guiding principles, dismissing moral concerns as insubstantial until acted upon, and arrogantly believing he can be absolved of any sin. The imagery of darkness covering the act is both literal and symbolic, representing his attempt to escape accountability and the moral darkness he is embracing. The stanza is filled with dramatic irony, as the reader knows that Tarquin's "sweet delight" will ultimately lead to devastating shame, guilt, and destruction. The powerful literary devices emphasize the depth of his depravity and the tragic consequences that will follow. He is actively choosing to ignore conscience and morality, believing he can somehow escape the consequences of his actions. The stanza sets the stage for the horrific act and its repercussions.

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← Stanza 51📚 OverviewStanza 53 →

Stanza 52 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 52 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then put it all together.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"This said, his guilty hand pluck'd up the latch,"

"This said": This refers to the previous stanza where Tarquin presumably spoke to himself, justifying his actions. He has talked himself into it.
"his guilty hand pluck'd up the latch": The action itself. His "guilty hand" emphasizes his awareness of the wrongness of his actions. "Pluck'd" is a stronger, more forceful word than simply "lifted," suggesting urgency and a lack of gentleness.
Literary Devices: Alliteration of "hand" and "pluck'd" subtly emphasizes the physicality of the act.

"And with his knee the door he opens wide."

This continues the description of his forceful entry. Using his knee shows a lack of delicacy or stealth; he doesn't care about being quiet or gentle. "Opens wide" is a simple but effective phrase that implies the enormity of his intended violation.
Literary Devices: Caesura: The pause after 'knee' breaks up the flow, drawing attention to the brutal action.

"The dove sleeps fast that this night-owl will catch:"

Metaphor: This line introduces a powerful metaphor. Lucrece is the innocent "dove," sleeping peacefully, unaware of the danger. Tarquin is the predatory "night-owl," hunting under the cover of darkness.
"Sleeps fast" reinforces Lucrece's vulnerability and lack of awareness.
Literary Devices: Metaphor: As mentioned. Symbolism: Dove for innocence, owl for predator and darkness. Foreshadowing: Clearly indicates impending danger for Lucrece.

"Thus treason works ere traitors be espied."

This is a general observation. Treason (betrayal) operates best when it's unseen and unexpected. Tarquin's betrayal of Lucrece's hospitality and their friendship is likened to treason against a state.

"Ere traitors be espied" emphasizes the secrecy and deception involved.
Literary Devices: Generalization: Moves from the specific scene to a broader truth.

"Who sees the lurking serpent steps aside;"

A further generalization, building on the previous line. If you see a threat, you avoid it. The "lurking serpent" is another symbolic representation of danger, specifically hidden danger. Literary Devices: Metaphor: Serpent as hidden danger. Allusion: Serpent to the story of the Garden of Eden.

This said, his guilty hand pluck'd up the latch,
And with his knee the door he opens wide.
The dove sleeps fast that this night-owl will catch:
Thus treason works ere traitors be espied.
Who sees the lurking serpent steps aside;
But she, sound sleeping, fearing no such thing,
Lies at the mercy of his mortal sting.

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"But she, sound sleeping, fearing no such thing,"

This contrasts with the previous line. Lucrece, "sound sleeping" (repetition from line 3, emphasizing her unawareness), is not aware of any danger and therefore cannot protect herself. "Fearing no such thing" highlights her trust and innocence.

"Lies at the mercy of his mortal sting."

The culmination of the stanza. Lucrece is completely vulnerable, "at the mercy" of Tarquin.
"Mortal sting" refers to the rape and the potential consequences (loss of honor, societal ruin, possibly death). The "sting" is a violent, painful image.
Literary Devices: Metaphor: "Mortal sting" represents the rape and its consequences. Ironic Foreshadowing: Because while the rape is his "mortal sting", Lucrece's suicide will be a "mortal sting" to him.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza builds intense suspense and emphasizes Lucrece's utter vulnerability. Tarquin, fueled by lust and self-justification, moves from thought to action, breaking into her room with force. The metaphors of the dove and owl, the serpent, and the mortal sting all contribute to a sense of impending doom. The lines emphasize that betrayal thrives in darkness and that Lucrece, unsuspecting and defenseless, is now completely at the mercy of Tarquin's violent desires. The stanza underscores the injustice and horror of the situation. It's not just about a physical act but about the betrayal of trust and the violation of innocence.

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← Stanza 52📚 OverviewStanza 54 →

Stanza 53 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line 1: "Into the chamber wickedly he stalks,"

"Into the chamber": Sets the scene; Collatine is now inside Lucrece's private bedroom. "wickedly": Immediately characterizes Collatine's action and intent as evil and immoral.
"he stalks": The verb "stalks" is significant. It implies a predatory, hunting-like movement. It suggests Collatine is creeping and dangerous, and that Lucrece is the target of this pursuit. Literary Device: The alliteration of "wickedly" and "walks" emphasizes the sinister nature of his entrance.

Line 2: "And gazeth on her yet unstained bed."

"gazeth": Suggests a long, intense, and perhaps lustful look.
"her yet unstained bed": The word "unstained" is crucial. It highlights Lucrece's purity and innocence before Collatine's transgression. The bed symbolizes her chastity and marital fidelity, which are about to be violated. It also creates dramatic irony, because the reader knows that will not be the case for long.

Line 3: "The curtains being close, about he walks,"

"The curtains being close": The closed curtains create a sense of secrecy and confinement. They emphasize the private nature of the space that Collatine is invading.
"about he walks": He is pacing and circling as he is building the nerve to commit the assault.

Line 4: "Rolling his greedy eyeballs in his head:"

"Rolling his greedy eyeballs in his head": This is a vivid and grotesque image. "Rolling" suggests uncontrolled lust and agitation. "Greedy eyeballs" connects his eyes to his avarice and desire. It suggests he's consumed by his lust, and can't control his gaze.
Literary Device: The imagery here is striking and disturbing. It highlights the purely physical and predatory nature of his lust.

Line 5: "By their high treason is his heart misled;"

"By their high treason": "Treason" is a powerful word, suggesting a betrayal of something sacred. Here, it refers to his eyes and their treacherous role in leading him astray. This also introduces the concept that Collatine's actions are a betrayal of the social order.
"is his heart misled": He is trying to shift the blame, claiming his heart has been influenced.

Line 6: "Which gives the watch-word to his hand full soon"

"Which gives the watch-word": The word "watch-word" is interesting. This implies a command, as if his heart is ordering his hand to take action, as he is building the courage to commit the act.
"to his hand full soon": Implies that the action will not be delayed much longer.
Line 7: "To draw the cloud that hides the silver moon."

"To draw the cloud": The "cloud" is a metaphor for the curtain, or a covering.
"that hides the silver moon": "Silver moon" is a metaphor for Lucrece, representing her purity, beauty, and chastity. The moon, being associated with Diana, the goddess of chastity,

Into the chamber wickedly he stalks,
And gazeth on her yet unstained bed.
The curtains being close, about he walks,
Rolling his greedy eyeballs in his head:
By their high treason is his heart misled;
Which gives the watch-word to his hand full soon To draw the cloud that hides the silver moon.

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reinforces Lucrece's virtuous nature. Collatine pulling back the curtain is symbolic of him
preparing to violate her.
Literary Device: The metaphor of the "silver moon" for Lucrece is beautiful yet unsettling in this context. It contrasts her purity with the impending darkness of Collatine's actions.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

The stanza paints a picture of Collatine's escalating lust and intent as he enters Lucrece's chamber. Shakespeare emphasizes the predatory nature of his actions through vivid imagery and word choice. Collatine is not simply visiting; he is stalking. The "unstained bed" is a stark reminder of Lucrece's innocence, which is about to be shattered. The stanza highlights the internal conflict within Collatine, as he attempts to excuse his behavior by blaming his heart and eyes for misleading him. The final image of drawing back the "cloud" to reveal the "silver moon" foreshadows the impending violation of Lucrece's purity and the destruction of her chastity. The stanza is filled with dramatic tension, as the reader is aware of the impending tragedy and the inevitable loss of Lucrece's innocence.

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← Stanza 53📚 OverviewStanza 55 →

Stanza 54 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "Look, as the fair and fiery-pointed sun,"

"Look, as...": This is an imperative, a command to the reader to pay attention to the
comparison that will follow. It immediately draws the reader into the scene.
"fair and fiery-pointed sun": This describes the sun using vivid imagery. "Fair" suggests
beauty, brightness, perhaps even justice. "Fiery-pointed" emphasizes the sun's intense heat and the piercing nature of its rays. Alliteration is present in "fiery-pointed". The sun is a powerful and majestic force.

Line 2: "Rushing from forth a cloud, bereaves our sight;"

"Rushing from forth a cloud": The sun is presented as bursting out suddenly and powerfully. "Forth" is an archaic form of "from," adding a sense of formality.
"bereaves our sight": The sudden emergence of the sun overwhelms the viewer's eyes, causing a temporary loss of vision. "Bereaves" suggests a loss or deprivation, even if temporary. It highlights the sun's overwhelming power.

Line 3: "Even so, the curtain drawn, his eyes begun"

"Even so": Connects the image of the sun to the scene at hand, indicating a direct comparison. "the curtain drawn": This refers to the curtains around Lucrece's bed being pulled back, revealing her.
"his eyes begun": "His" refers to Tarquin. He is now seeing Lucrece for the first time (or perhaps more completely) as the curtains are drawn. The word "begun" subtly hints at the ongoing action and Tarquin's escalating desire.

Line 4: "To wink, being blinded with a greater light:"

"To wink": Tarquin's eyes are closing or squinting involuntarily.
"being blinded with a greater light": The cause of Tarquin's winking. This "greater light" is Lucrece's beauty and virtue, which is overpowering and disorienting to Tarquin. This line is a metaphor. Lucrece's beauty and purity are the 'light'.

Line 5: "Whether it is that she reflects so bright,"

"Whether it is that she reflects so bright": This line introduces a question about the source
of the light. "Reflects so bright" suggests that Lucrece is radiating beauty and virtue, like a mirror reflecting light.

Line 6: "That dazzleth them, or else some shame supposed;"

"That dazzleth them": Her beauty and virtue are overwhelming and blinding to Tarquin.
"or else some shame supposed": An alternative explanation. Perhaps Tarquin's reaction is caused by a subconscious sense of shame or guilt that he feels at the thought of violating her virtue. "Supposed" suggests that this shame might not be fully conscious.

Look, as the fair and fiery-pointed sun,
Rushing from forth a cloud, bereaves our sight;
Even so, the curtain drawn, his eyes begun
To wink, being blinded with a greater light:
Whether it is that she reflects so bright,
That dazzleth them, or else some shame supposed; But blind they are, and keep themselves enclosed.

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Line 7: "But blind they are, and keep themselves enclosed."

"But blind they are": Reinforces the idea that Tarquin's eyes are metaphorically blinded. He is either overwhelmed by Lucrece's beauty or by his own suppressed shame.
"and keep themselves enclosed": Implies that Tarquin's eyes remain closed, either literally or figuratively. They are "enclosed" because he's turning inward, shutting out the light, and succumbing to his lustful impulses.

Overall Meaning and Literary Devices:

This stanza compares the effect of Lucrece's beauty and virtue on Tarquin to the blinding effect of the sun emerging from behind a cloud. Shakespeare uses the powerful image of the sun to convey the overwhelming impact of Lucrece's presence.

The stanza explores the psychological impact of beauty and the conflict between lust and conscience. It suggests that Lucrece's virtue acts as a kind of moral "light" that blinds Tarquin, forcing him to turn away. The ambiguity of whether the "blindness" is caused by her beauty or his own shame highlights the internal struggle that Tarquin is experiencing.

Key Literary Devices:

Simile: The entire stanza revolves around a simile. Tarquin's reaction to Lucrece is like the effect of the sun on one's eyes. ("Look, as...")
Metaphor: Lucrece's beauty and virtue are presented as a "light" that can "blind."
Imagery: The stanza is rich in visual imagery, particularly the description of the sun and its fiery rays.
Alliteration: "Fair and fiery-pointed" emphasizes the intensity of the sun.
Ambiguity: Shakespeare intentionally leaves it unclear whether the "blindness" is due to Lucrece's beauty or Tarquin's shame, adding complexity to the characterization.
Personification: While not direct, the sun is treated with a certain agency, "rushing from forth a cloud" as if with purpose.
Foreshadowing: The "blindness" can be seen as foreshadowing the moral blindness that leads Tarquin to commit the rape.

In essence, this stanza is a crucial moment in the narrative, showing the power of Lucrece's virtue and the internal conflict that is consuming Tarquin as he prepares to violate it. The vivid imagery and careful use of literary devices create a powerful and unsettling effect on the reader.

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← Stanza 54📚 OverviewStanza 56 →

Stanza 55 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "O, had they in that darksome prison died!"
Meaning: Oh, if only Tarquin and his men had died in that dark, wretched place (Lucrece's bedroom).
Literary Devices:
Exclamatory O: Conveys intense emotion, grief, and longing.
"Darksome prison": Metaphor. It refers to Lucrece's bedroom, which has become a place of torment and potential violation. The "darkness" suggests evil, secrecy, and the moral darkness
of the act.

Alliteration: "Darksome died" emphasizes the negativity.

Line 2: "Then had they seen the period of their ill;"
Meaning: Then, if they had died, their suffering (their "ill") would have come to an end.
Literary Devices:
"Period": Here, "period" means ending or conclusion. It has the additional, subtle connotation
of a full stop on a sentence – absolute finality.
Irony: The line describes death as the "period of their ill," which is a common sentiment when discussing the end of suffering, but in this context, their death would have prevented the much greater ill of Lucrece's rape.

Line 3: "Then Collatine again, by Lucrece' side,"

Meaning: Then Collatine (Lucrece's husband) could have been with Lucrece again.
Literary Devices:
Idealized Image: Presents a picture of marital harmony, innocence, and peace.

Line 4: "In his clear bed might have reposed still:"

Meaning: In their virtuous (clear) bed, they could have remained at peace.
Literary Devices:
"Clear bed": Symbolism. "Clear" represents purity, innocence, and the unblemished state of their marriage before the rape. It contrasts sharply with the moral corruption represented by Tarquin's actions.
"Reposed still": Suggests serenity, tranquility, and the continuation of their idyllic life.

Line 5: "But they must ope, this blessed league to kill;"

Meaning: But they had to open the door (the attackers survived), which would destroy this blessed union (the marriage).
Literary Devices:
Dramatic Irony: The audience knows the consequences of opening the door. The opening of
the door is an action, a decision that will lead to the destruction of something sacred.
"Blessed league": Refers to the marriage; a sacred bond is about to be violated. Personification "they must ope, this blessed league to kill" The league (marriage) is being personified as something that can be killed.

O, had they in that darksome prison died!
Then had they seen the period of their ill;
Then Collatine again, by Lucrece' side,
In his clear bed might have reposed still:
But they must ope, this blessed league to kill; And holy-thoughted Lucrece to their sight
Must sell her joy, her life, her world's delight.

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Line 6: "And holy-thoughted Lucrece to their sight"

Meaning: And Lucrece, a woman of pure and virtuous thoughts, must be presented to their view. Literary Devices:
Epithet: "Holy-thoughted Lucrece" is a descriptive phrase that emphasizes her virtuous nature.
It serves to highlight the injustice of her fate.
Foreshadowing The word sight means she will be on display to the attackers, which is not
good.

Line 7: "Must sell her joy, her life, her world's delight."

Meaning: Must forfeit her happiness, her life, and everything that makes the world beautiful (or "her world's delight").
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Sell her joy, her life, her world's delight" - Lucrece won't literally sell these things,
but she will lose them due to the actions of Tarquin. "Sell" also suggests a sense of betrayal
and loss of control. She is a victim.
Climax: The line is the climax of the stanza, escalating the consequences. "Joy" is something personal, "life" is fundamental, and "world's delight" encompasses everything positive.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza expresses the speaker's deep lament over the unfolding tragedy. It highlights the lost potential for happiness, marital harmony, and innocence had the villains died earlier. The focus then shifts to the inevitability of the rape and its devastating consequences for Lucrece, who will lose not only her happiness but also her life and her entire world as a result of this violation. The stanza builds a sense of dread and foreshadows the tragic events to come. The idealized language used to describe the marriage intensifies the horror of its impending destruction.

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← Stanza 55📚 OverviewStanza 57 →

Stanza 56 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Her lily hand her rosy cheek lies under,"

Analysis: This line describes Lucrece's posture. "Lily hand" emphasizes the whiteness and
delicacy of her hand. "Rosy cheek" emphasizes the vibrant color of her face. The hand is
positioned beneath her cheek, indicating she is resting or asleep.
Literary Device: Metaphor (comparing her hand to a lily). Alliteration ("lily lies"). Inversion - normal word order would be "Her lily hand lies under her rosy cheek." The altered word order adds emphasis.

"Cozening the pillow of a lawful kiss;"

Analysis: "Cozening" means deceiving or cheating. The pillow is being tricked into receiving a kiss that is not "lawful," implying that the kiss would normally belong to her husband, Collatinus. Her hand is acting as a surrogate for that rightful kiss.
Literary Device: Personification (giving the pillow human qualities - the ability to be "cozened"). Euphemism - hints at the sexual tension and the impending violation without explicitly mentioning it.

"Who, therefore angry, seems to part in sunder,"

Analysis: "Who" refers back to the pillow (a continuation of the personification). Because it is being denied the lawful kiss, the pillow seems to be splitting apart ("part in sunder") in anger or frustration.

Literary Device: Personification (continued). Hyperbole (exaggerating the pillow's reaction).

"Swelling on either side to want his bliss;"

Analysis: The pillow's parting creates "swelling" sides. "Want his bliss" further emphasizes the pillow's desire for the kiss (or, perhaps, the embrace) it is being denied. "His" refers to the pillow. Literary Device: Personification (continued). Synecdoche - 'bliss' stands in for the greater pleasure of Lucrece.

"Between whose hills her head entombed is:"

Analysis: "Hills" refers to the raised sides of the pillow created by the parting. Her head is nestled between these hills, as if it is buried or confined. "Entombed" is a strong word choice, foreshadowing Lucrece's fate and emphasizing her vulnerability.
Literary Device: Metaphor (comparing the pillow's sides to hills). Imagery (evoking a sense of confinement and impending doom). Foreshadowing - Hints at the coming death.

"Where, like a virtuous monument, she lies,"

Analysis: Lucrece is compared to a "virtuous monument," a statue erected to commemorate someone of great moral character. She is presented as an image of purity and worthiness, even
in this vulnerable state.

Literary Device: Simile (using "like" to compare Lucrece to a monument). Irony (because her virtue is precisely what makes her a target).

Her lily hand her rosy cheek lies under,
Cozening the pillow of a lawful kiss;
Who, therefore angry, seems to part in sunder,
Swelling on either side to want his bliss;
Between whose hills her head entombed is: Where, like a virtuous monument, she lies,
To be admired of lewd unhallow'd eyes.

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"To be admired of lewd unhallow'd eyes."

Analysis: This line reveals the danger Lucrece is in. Her beauty and virtue, which should be celebrated, are instead attracting the "lewd unhallow'd eyes" of Tarquin. "Unhallowed" is a
religious reference, emphasizing Tarquin's lack of respect for sacred things (including Lucrece's virtue).
Literary Device: Contrast (between Lucrece's virtue and Tarquin's lust). Allusion (to religious concepts of sanctity).

Overall Meaning:

This stanza paints a vivid picture of Lucrece sleeping peacefully, unaware of the danger she is in. The imagery is richly suggestive, using personification and metaphor to create a sense of heightened tension. The pillow, denied the "lawful kiss" that should rightfully belong to Lucrece's husband, becomes a symbol of the violation that is about to occur. The comparison to a "virtuous monument" highlights Lucrece's purity, but also foreshadows her tragic fate, as her virtue makes her a target for Tarquin's lust. The closing line emphasizes the impending doom, as Lucrece's beauty is about to be profaned by "lewd unhallowed eyes." The stanza functions as a beautiful, yet ominous, setup for the unfolding tragedy, highlighting the contrast between innocence and corruption, virtue and lust.

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← Stanza 56📚 OverviewStanza 58 →

Stanza 57 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Without the bed her other fair hand was,"

Meaning: This line simply states that one of Lucrece's beautiful hands was outside the bed, resting on the bed covering. The use of "without" can also imply this hand is now lifeless or disconnected from her.

Literary Devices: Inversion (the normal word order would be "Her other fair hand was without the bed"). This stylistic choice emphasizes the location of her hand and draws immediate attention to her vulnerability. It is the placement of her hand that is important, not her hand itself.

"On the green coverlet; whose perfect white"

Meaning: Her hand rested on the green bed covering, which was pristine white. This sets up a visual contrast and highlights the purity that is about to be violated.
Literary Devices: Color Symbolism Green often symbolizes nature and life, while white represents purity and innocence. The use of both colors sets up a contrast that is symbolic of her innocence in a world dominated by sin.

"Show'd like an April daisy on the grass,"

Meaning: The white of her hand on the green coverlet resembled a daisy on green grass. This is a simile creating a vivid and delicate image.
Literary Devices: Simile (using "like" for comparison). Imagery evokes a sense of natural
beauty and fragility, as daisies are small and easily crushed. Pastoral Imagery This idyllic image is about to be marred, which emphasizes the tragedy of the event.

"With pearly sweat, resembling dew of night."

Meaning: The sweat on her hand shone like pearls, looking like the morning dew. This adds another layer of delicate imagery and suggests that she is either sleeping peacefully, or more likely, that the sweat is from the stress and trauma she has just experienced, but still has the
look of beauty.
Literary Devices: Simile (using "resembling" for comparison). Imagery The pearly sweat conjures an image of refinement and beauty, even in a state of distress. Metaphor "Pearly sweat" is a subtle metaphor, comparing the sweat to precious pearls.

"Her eyes, like marigolds, had sheathed their light,"

Meaning: Her eyes, which are compared to bright marigolds, were closed. This describes the closed eyes, suggesting sleep or unconsciousness.
Literary Devices: Simile (using "like" for comparison). Metaphor (eyes and light). Imagery Marigolds are associated with the sun, suggesting that her eyes are usually radiant and full of life.

"And canopied in darkness sweetly lay,"

Meaning: Her eyes were covered by her eyelids, lying peacefully in darkness. This further emphasizes the closed eyes and suggests a state of rest or unknowing.

Without the bed her other fair hand was,
On the green coverlet; whose perfect white
Show'd like an April daisy on the grass,
With pearly sweat, resembling dew of night.
Her eyes, like marigolds, had sheathed their light,
And canopied in darkness sweetly lay,
Till they might open to adorn the day.

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Literary Devices: Metaphor "Canopied in darkness" uses "canopied" as a verb, suggesting that her eyelids are like a canopy or covering, sheltering her eyes from the light. Alliteration (canopied, darkness). The soft "c" and "d" sounds contribute to the tranquil tone.

"Till they might open to adorn the day."

Meaning: This suggests that her eyes will eventually open and brighten the day, as if her eyes
are a source of light and beauty for the world. There's a hint of hope and potential, even in this tragic situation.
Literary Devices: Personification (eyes "adorn the day"). This endows her eyes with the power
to enhance the world. Foreshadowing There is a sense of impending doom. She will open her
eyes, but when she does it won't be to greet the day in a pleasant way.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza paints a picture of Lucrece in a state of post-assault stillness. She appears to be asleep, but the "pearly sweat" hints at the trauma she has endured. The imagery emphasizes her beauty, purity, and vulnerability, heightening the tragedy of her situation. The initial image is delicate and beautiful, using pastoral and natural imagery, but is marred by the realization that this beauty has been violated. There is a sense of false peace or respite before the inevitable awakening to the full horror of what has happened. The stanza emphasizes the contrast between her outward beauty and the internal pain she is experiencing.

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← Stanza 57📚 OverviewStanza 59 →

Stanza 58 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Her hair, like golden threads, play'd with her breath;"

Meaning: Lucrece's golden hair is described as being so fine and delicate that it moves gently
with her breathing. It paints a picture of peacefulness and beauty.
Literary Devices:
Simile: "like golden threads" - Compares her hair to golden threads, emphasizing its color and fineness.

Personification: "play'd with her breath" - Hair cannot play, but it moves like someone
playing. This adds to the gentle and delicate feel.

"O modest wantons! wanton modesty!"

Meaning: This is a paradoxical statement. It suggests a conflict between Lucrece's inherent virtue (modesty) and the vulnerability and allure she presents even in sleep, which could be seen as provocative (wanton). It's almost as if even in sleep, she possesses a captivating quality that could be misconstrued.

Literary Devices:
Oxymoron: "modest wantons" and "wanton modesty" - Juxtaposes contradictory terms to
create a complex and thought-provoking effect. It forces the reader to consider the ambiguity
of her beauty and innocence.

"Showing life's triumph in the map of death,"

Meaning: Even in sleep (which resembles a kind of miniature death), Lucrece's beauty shines through, showcasing the vibrancy of life. Her beauty is so potent that it transcends the death-like state of sleep.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "map of death" - Sleep is indirectly compared to death, emphasizing its stillness
and lack of consciousness.

Personification: "life's triumph" - Life is given the power to triumph or overcome.

"And death's dim look in life's mortality:"

Meaning: Conversely, the poem acknowledges that even in her living state, Lucrece is subject to mortality. There's a hint of death or decay (a "dim look") even in the beauty of her mortal life. The stanza subtly foreshadows her impending death.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "death's dim look" - Death is given a quality of looking.
Metaphor: "life's mortality" - Life and mortality are intertwined, suggesting the presence of
death even in living beings.

"Each in her sleep themselves so beautify,"

Meaning: In her sleep, Lucrece enhances her own beauty. It is almost as if sleep brings out her inherent beauty further.

Her hair, like golden threads, play'd with her breath;
O modest wantons! wanton modesty!
Showing life's triumph in the map of death,
And death's dim look in life's mortality:
Each in her sleep themselves so beautify,
As if between them twain there were no strife,
But that life lived in death, and death in life.

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Literary Devices:
Self-reflexive Language: The line refers to Lucrece beautifying themselves, meaning she is the subject and object of the sentence, emphasizing the inherent beauty.

"As if between them twain there were no strife,"

Meaning: Her sleeping state suggests that there is no conflict between life and death. She is at peace, appearing untouched by the struggles of the world.
Literary Devices:
Allusion: "them twain" is a archaic form to denote "between the two", referring to life and death.

"But that life lived in death, and death in life."

Meaning: This line reiterates the interconnectedness of life and death. Life and death are not seen as opposing forces, but rather as elements that exist within each other. This reinforces the paradoxical nature of beauty and vulnerability that characterizes Lucrece's portrayal.
Literary Devices:
Chiasmus: "life lived in death, and death in life" - A rhetorical device where the words or
phrases are repeated in reverse order. This emphasizes the reciprocal relationship between life
and death.
Paradox: Life living in death and death living in life creates an apparent contradiction that
reveals a deeper truth about the nature of existence.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a meditation on the complex relationship between beauty, innocence, life, and death. Shakespeare uses Lucrece's sleeping form as a canvas to explore these themes. He emphasizes the paradoxical nature of her beauty, highlighting how her "modest" appearance can also be perceived as "wanton" or provocative. More profoundly, he explores the idea that life and death are not mutually exclusive concepts but are intertwined, with each existing within the other. The stanza sets the stage for the tragedy to come by subtly foreshadowing Lucrece's vulnerability and the inevitability of mortality, even within the most beautiful and innocent existence. Her beauty, even in sleep, is both a source of her allure and a potential catalyst for the violence that will befall her. It highlights the precarious balance between beauty, virtue, and the ever-present threat of death. It creates a sense of foreboding, reminding the reader that even in the most serene moments, danger can lurk.

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← Stanza 58📚 OverviewStanza 60 →

Stanza 59 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Her breasts, like ivory globes circled with blue,"

Her breasts: Refers to Lucrece's breasts, the subject of the description.
like ivory globes: This is a simile. The whiteness and smooth, spherical shape of her breasts
are compared to polished ivory globes. This suggests purity, preciousness, and a sense of
idealized beauty.
circled with blue: This refers to the visible blue veins beneath the skin, a sign of delicate skin and innocence. The "blue" also connects to the idea of royalty, adding another layer of meaning.

"A pair of maiden worlds unconquered,"

A pair: Referring again to her breasts.
maiden worlds unconquered: This is a metaphor. Her breasts are likened to uncharted, pristine worlds. "Maiden" emphasizes her virginity and purity. "Unconquered" suggests they are untouched, inviolate, and represent a realm of innocence that has not been corrupted.
This line elevates the description from simple physical details to a symbolic representation of Lucrece's purity.

"Save of their lord no bearing yoke they knew,"

Save of their lord: Her husband, Collatinus.
no bearing yoke they knew: "Bearing yoke" is a metaphor for the sexual submission expected in marriage. They haven't yet experienced the "yoke" of conjugal duty.
This line emphasizes Lucrece's loyalty and fidelity to her husband. While she is married, her breasts (and, by extension, her sexuality) remain dedicated solely to him.

"And him by oath they truly honoured."

And him by oath: Again, referring to her husband, Collatinus.
they truly honoured: She is bound to him by a sacred vow (oath) of marriage, and she is faithful and devoted.
This line further underscores her commitment to her marital vows and her virtuous nature.

"These worlds in Tarquin new ambition bred;"

These worlds: Refers back to Lucrece's breasts as "maiden worlds unconquered."
in Tarquin new ambition bred: The sight of Lucrece's beauty and purity ignites a desire in Tarquin that transcends mere lust. It's an ambition to conquer, to defile, to possess something that is rightfully Collatinus's.
This line marks the turning point. The sight of Lucrece's purity doesn't inspire him; it incites his lust for power and domination.

"Who, like a foul usurper, went about"

Who: Refers to Tarquin.
like a foul usurper: This is a simile. Tarquin's impending actions are compared to a tyrant who illegally and unjustly seizes a throne. "Foul" emphasizes the depravity and injustice of his intent.

Her breasts, like ivory globes circled with blue,
A pair of maiden worlds unconquered,
Save of their lord no bearing yoke they knew,
And him by oath they truly honoured.
These worlds in Tarquin new ambition bred;
Who, like a foul ursurper, went about
From this fair throne to heave the owner out.

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This line explicitly links Tarquin's lust to a desire for power and control, turning his intentions into a political act of usurpation.

"From this fair throne to heave the owner out."

this fair throne: Lucrece, and by extension, her virtue and her body. This is a metaphor.
to heave the owner out: To violently displace Collatinus, the rightful possessor of Lucrece.
This line emphasizes the violent and unjust nature of Tarquin's planned assault. He's not simply seeking pleasure; he's attempting to dethrone the rightful owner of Lucrece's virtue and purity.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a pivotal point in the poem. It vividly describes Lucrece's beauty and, more importantly, her virtue and fidelity to her husband. Her breasts, depicted as ivory globes and "maiden worlds unconquered," symbolize her purity and untouched nature. However, this very purity becomes the catalyst for Tarquin's lust. The sight of her inspires in him a desire to conquer and defile, transforming him into a "foul usurper" seeking to overthrow the rightful owner (Collatinus) from his "fair throne" (Lucrece).

The stanza expertly uses vivid imagery, similes, and metaphors to elevate the depiction of Lucrece from mere physical beauty to a symbol of virtue and purity. It also foreshadows the tragic events to come, as Tarquin's "new ambition" sets the stage for his violent assault and Lucrece's eventual suicide. The language of usurpation and power highlights the political dimension of the rape, emphasizing the poem's broader themes of tyranny, injustice, and the abuse of power.

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← Stanza 59📚 OverviewStanza 61 →

Stanza 60 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"What could he see but mightily he noted?"

What could he see... - The opening asks what else could Tarquin see other than things to make note of?
...but mightily he noted? - He registered every detail with intense scrutiny and importance. The word "mightily" emphasizes the strength of his focus.
Literary Device: Rhetorical Question, emphasizing Tarquin's intense observation.

"What did he note but strongly he desired?"

What did he note... - Following on from the previous line, what did Tarquin observe?
...but strongly he desired? - Whatever he observed inspired intense desire. "Strongly" indicates the power of his lust.
Literary Device: Rhetorical Question, building on the previous line and emphasizing the direct link between Tarquin's observation and his desire.

"What he beheld, on that he firmly doted,"

What he beheld... - Whatever Tarquin looked upon...
... on that he firmly doted, - he fixed his attention and affection (in a twisted way) upon it.
"Doted" has an ironic usage here because it is usually connected to a positive relationship and Tarquin is using it in a negative sense.
Literary Device: Repetition of the "What..." structure. The alliteration of "firmly" and "doted" adds emphasis.

"And in his will his wilful eye he tired."

And in his will... - He forced himself (through his "will"). This highlights Tarquin's conscious choice to indulge in his lust.
...his wilful eye he tired. - He exhausted his eye, wearing it out. The repetition of the word "will" and "wilful" emphasizes Tarquin's determination and the intentional nature of his actions.
Literary Device: Alliteration ("will," "wilful"), Repetition, Paradox (the eye is "tired" by being active, but also symbolically "tired" in the sense of being jaded by lust).
"With more than admiration he admired"

With more than admiration... - Tarquin's gaze transcended mere appreciation.
...he admired - He was deeply and intensely fascinated by Lucrece's beauty.
Literary Device: Paradox/Oxymoron. It highlights the perversion of admiration into something darker and more dangerous. The repetition of "admired" emphasizes the intensity of his observation.

"Her azure veins, her alabaster skin,"

Her azure veins... - This begins the specific detailing of Lucrece's beauty. "Azure" (blue) veins suggest delicacy and purity.

What could he see but mightily he noted?
What did he note but strongly he desired?
What he beheld, on that he firmly doted,
And in his will his wilful eye he tired.
With more than admiration he admired
Her azure veins, her alabaster skin,
Her coral lips, her snow-white dimpled chin.

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...her alabaster skin, - "Alabaster" is a white, translucent stone, used to describe her pure, smooth, pale skin.
Literary Device: Metaphor (skin compared to alabaster), Imagery (visual).

"Her coral lips, her snow-white dimpled chin."

Her coral lips... - Her lips are described as "coral," suggesting their vibrant red color.
...her snow-white dimpled chin. - Her chin is "snow-white," continuing the imagery of purity, and "dimpled" adds to her innocent beauty.
Literary Device: Metaphor (lips compared to coral), Imagery (visual).

Overall Meaning:

Stanza 60 is a powerful depiction of Tarquin's escalating lust and his objectification of Lucrece. It traces the progression of his desire from simple observation to an overwhelming, almost obsessive fixation. The stanza highlights that his actions are not simply based on natural attraction but are fueled by a deliberate and forceful act of will. He is intentionally indulging in and feeding his lust. The meticulous detailing of Lucrece's physical attributes serves to dehumanize her, reducing her to a collection of beautiful, yet ultimately vulnerable, features. The contrasting imagery of purity and implied violation creates a sense of foreboding and sets the stage for the tragic events to follow. The stanza emphasizes the moral corruption and the active, conscious decision-making involved in Tarquin's villainy.

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← Stanza 60📚 OverviewStanza 62 →

Stanza 61 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"As the grim lion fawneth o'er his prey,"

Meaning: This line presents a simile. Just as a fierce lion, after a kill, might affectionately (or perhaps possessively) nuzzle its prey. The word "grim" emphasizes the lion's inherent ferocity. "Fawneth" suggests a deceptive tenderness.
Literary Devices: Simile (using "as"), imagery.

"Sharp hunger by the conquest satisfied,"

Meaning: The lion's intense hunger is now temporarily satisfied because it has successfully hunted and killed its prey. The "conquest" implies a struggle and victory.
Literary Devices: Alliteration ("Sharp, satisfied"), imagery.

"So o'er this sleeping soul doth Tarquin stay,"

Meaning: This completes the simile. Tarquin, like the lion, stands (or perhaps hovers) over Lucrece's sleeping body. The phrase "sleeping soul" is significant. It suggests Lucrece's innocence and vulnerability; her soul is at rest, unaware of the danger.
Literary Devices: Simile (continuation), metaphor (soul as a symbol of innocence), inversion ("doth Tarquin stay" instead of "Tarquin doth stay").

"His rage of lust by gazing qualified;"

Meaning: Tarquin's intense lust, his "rage," is somewhat lessened or calmed ("qualified") simply by looking at Lucrece. The act of gazing provides a temporary respite from his overwhelming desire. "Qualified" doesn't mean completely eliminated, just tempered.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (lust as a "rage"), alliteration ("rage by").

"Slack'd, not suppress'd; for standing by her side,"

Meaning: The lust is not gone, just lessened and lingering. This line emphasizes that the act of gazing has only weakened, not eliminated, his desire. He is still standing very close to her. Literary Devices: Antithesis ("slack'd, not suppressed"), repetition.

"His eye, which late this mutiny restrains,"

Meaning: Tarquin's eye, which only moments ago helped to control (restrain) his internal "mutiny" (the rebellion of his lustful desires against his reason). "Mutiny" is a powerful word, suggesting a violent uprising within him.
Literary Devices: Metaphor ("mutiny" for inner turmoil), personification (giving the eye the ability to restrain).

"Unto a greater uproar tempts his veins:"

Meaning: However, now the very same eye, through continued looking, is actually inciting a greater internal rebellion and stirring his blood (veins) to a higher degree of passion. The "greater uproar" indicates that his lust is building again, becoming even stronger than before.
Literary Devices: Metaphor ("uproar" for intensified lust), personification (veins being tempted).

As the grim lion fawneth o'er his prey,
Sharp hunger by the conquest satisfied,
So o'er this sleeping soul doth Tarquin stay,
His rage of lust by gazing qualified;
Slack'd, not suppress'd; for standing by her side,
His eye, which late this mutiny restrains,
Unto a greater uproar tempts his veins:

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Overall Meaning:

This stanza paints a vivid picture of Tarquin's internal struggle. He is depicted as a predator, like a lion, initially calmed by the mere proximity of his desired victim. However, the stanza makes it clear that this calm is only temporary and deceptive. The act of looking at Lucrece, which initially offered a brief respite from his lust, ultimately intensifies it, making his desire even more uncontrollable. The stanza highlights the dangerous power of temptation and the fragile nature of self-control in the face of overwhelming desire. It foreshadows Tarquin's inevitable descent into the act of rape.

Key Literary Devices Summary:

Simile: The primary device is the extended simile comparing Tarquin to a lion.
Metaphor: Lust is described as a "rage" and a "mutiny." The "sleeping soul" is a metaphorical representation of Lucrece's innocence.
Personification: Tarquin's eye is given the power to restrain and then tempt his veins.
Imagery: The stanza is rich in vivid imagery, evoking the predatory nature of Tarquin and the vulnerability of Lucrece.
Alliteration: Used sparingly but effectively ("Sharp satisfied," "rage by").
Antithesis: "Slack'd, not suppress'd" emphasizes the incomplete nature of Tarquin's control. Inversion: "doth Tarquin stay" to fit the meter.

The stanza is a masterclass in psychological portrayal, showing the internal conflict and the escalating desire that will lead to the tragic act. It establishes Tarquin as a figure driven by base desires, ultimately unable to control his impulses.
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← Stanza 61📚 OverviewStanza 63 →

Stanza 62 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"And they, like straggling slaves for pillage fighting,"

"And they": Refers to the rapists, specifically Tarquin's soldiers.
"like straggling slaves": This is a simile. They are compared to slaves who have broken ranks and are looting. "Straggling" emphasizes their lack of discipline and focused purpose beyond individual greed.
"for pillage fighting": Their motivation is base and self-serving: to steal and destroy. The word "pillage" emphasizes the violent and destructive nature of their actions.

"Obdurate vassals fell exploits effecting,"

"Obdurate vassals": "Obdurate" means stubborn, unyielding, and hardened in their evil. "Vassals" implies that they are under Tarquin's power. However, their obduracy suggests that their commitment to cruelty goes beyond simple obedience.
"fell exploits effecting": "Fell" means cruel, deadly, or destructive. "Exploits" here mean deeds or actions, but the word suggests a glorification that is ironic and disturbing. "Effecting" simply means carrying out or performing. The alliteration in "fell exploits" emphasizes the wickedness of their deeds.

"In bloody death and ravishment delighting,"

"In bloody death and ravishment": This line starkly describes the horror of their actions: murder and rape. "Ravishment" is a euphemism for rape but still communicates the brutal violation.

"delighting": This is the most chilling word in the line. It reveals that they find pleasure and enjoyment in inflicting pain and suffering.

"Nor children's tears nor mothers' groans respecting,"

"Nor children's tears nor mothers' groans": This highlights their complete lack of empathy and moral compass. They are unmoved by the suffering of the most vulnerable. This is an example of synecdoche, where "children's tears" and "mother's groans" represent the wider suffering of the innocent.
"respecting": They show no regard, consideration, or pity for the consequences of their actions.

"Swell in their pride, the onset still expecting:"

"Swell in their pride": Their confidence and arrogance grow as they anticipate more opportunities for violence and destruction. "Swell" suggests a repulsive inflation of ego.
"the onset still expecting": They are eager and waiting for the command to attack and continue their atrocities. "Onset" suggests the beginning of an even greater wave of violence.

"Anon his beating heart, alarum striking,"

"Anon his beating heart": "Anon" means soon or immediately. "His" refers to Tarquin. "Beating heart" is an expression of the building tension and sexual arousal.
"alarum striking": This is a metaphor. His heart is compared to an "alarum" or a signal for battle, urging him to proceed with his evil plan. The image is forceful and violent.

And they, like straggling slaves for pillage fighting,
Obdurate vassals fell exploits effecting,
In bloody death and ravishment delighting,
Nor children's tears nor mothers' groans respecting,
Swell in their pride, the onset still expecting:
Anon his beating heart, alarum striking,
Gives the hot charge and bids them do their liking.

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"Gives the hot charge and bids them do their liking."

"Gives the hot charge": He gives the order to attack with intense passion and eagerness. "Hot" suggests lust and uncontrolled desire. "Charge" here is a forceful command.
"and bids them do their liking": He essentially gives them permission to act on their darkest desires. This is a chillingly permissive statement, acknowledging and encouraging their brutality.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza depicts the savage and uncontrolled nature of Tarquin's soldiers. It emphasizes their lack of discipline, their enjoyment of violence and destruction, and their complete disregard for human suffering. They are driven by base instincts and a thirst for power and pleasure, fueled by Tarquin's desires. The imagery is violent and unsettling, conveying the horror and brutality of the impending rape. The stanza sets a stage of heightened intensity and anticipation for the tragic event.

Literary Devices:

Simile: "like straggling slaves for pillage fighting"
Alliteration: "fell exploits"
Metaphor: "alarum striking" (heart as a battle signal)
Synecdoche: "children's tears" and "mother's groans" representing broader suffering Euphemism: "Ravishment" for rape
Imagery: The stanza is filled with violent and disturbing imagery.

Shakespeare uses these devices to create a vivid and disturbing picture of the rapists' depravity and the impending tragedy. The stanza effectively conveys the brutal atmosphere and the psychological state of both the attackers and the victim.

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← Stanza 62📚 OverviewStanza 64 →

Stanza 63 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this chilling stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, piece by piece, and then discuss the overall meaning and devices used.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"His drumming heart cheers up his burning eye,"

Analysis: This line establishes the internal forces driving Tarquin. His "drumming heart" suggests fear, anxiety, and lustful excitement, all beating intensely. This 'cheers up', or emboldens, his "burning eye," which is focused intensely on Lucrece and consumed by desire.
Literary Devices:
Personification: The heart is given the ability to "cheer up" the eye.
Imagery: "Drumming heart" and "burning eye" are vivid, forceful images of internal turmoil and lust.

"His eye commends the leading to his hand;"

Analysis: The eye, representing Tarquin's gaze and desire, directs his hand to take action. "Commends the leading" suggests the eye is in command, giving an order. The eye dictates the action.

Literary Devices:
Personification: The eye "commends" or gives orders.

"His hand, as proud of such a dignity,"

Analysis: This line is deeply disturbing. The hand, an instrument of Tarquin's will, is described as "proud" of the power it has in this moment of violation. The word dignity suggests the hand sees its action as right or justified, which is a terrible perversion. The action is seen as some form of honor by the hand, further underscoring the evil of the character.

Literary Devices:
Personification: The hand is given the human quality of "pride." This is particularly unsettling. Irony: There is nothing dignified about the action the hand is about to perform. The hand's "dignity" is a grotesque distortion of true honor.

"Smoking with pride, march'd on to make his stand"

Analysis: This continues the personification of the hand, intensifying the sense of predatory force. "Smoking with pride" suggests intense, almost feverish confidence and arrogance. "March'd on" suggests a deliberate, unstoppable advance, like a soldier invading enemy territory. "Make his stand" furthers the militant metaphor, comparing the action to a conquest.

Literary Devices:
Personification: The hand "smoke(s) with pride" and "march(es)."
Metaphor: The action of the hand is presented as a military invasion.

"On her bare breast, the heart of all her land;"

His drumming heart cheers up his burning eye,
His eye commends the leading to his hand;
His hand, as proud of such a dignity,
Smoking with pride, march'd on to make his stand
On her bare breast, the heart of all her land; Whose ranks of blue veins, as his hand did scale, Left there round turrets destitute and pale.

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Analysis: This line marks the horrifying culmination of the preceding lines. The hand lands on Lucrece's "bare breast." The phrase "heart of all her land" is powerful. It suggests that Lucrece, with her virtue and honor, represents the very essence and integrity of Rome itself. By violating her, Tarquin is attacking the heart of the nation.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Lucrece's breast is equated with "the heart of all her land."
Symbolism: Lucrece embodies Rome's honor and purity. Her breast, a vulnerable and
nurturing part of her body, is thus a symbol of the nation's vulnerability.

"Whose ranks of blue veins, as his hand did scale,"

Analysis: The imagery shifts to a more detailed, physical description of Lucrece's body. "Ranks of blue veins" paints a picture of the veins visible beneath her skin, described in a military fashion. "As his hand did scale" continues the military metaphor, comparing the hand's movement across her breast to climbing a wall or scaling a fortress.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The veins are likened to "ranks." The hand is scaling a fortress.
Imagery: The detailed description of the veins creates a vivid and intimate image.

"Left there round turrets destitute and pale."

Analysis: This is the most disturbing and complex line of the stanza. "Round turrets" is a euphemism for Lucrece's nipples. "Destitute and pale" describes how they appear as a result of Tarquin's assault. "Destitute" suggests emptiness and loss, hinting at the violation of her innocence and the draining of her spirit. "Pale" suggests fear, shock, and the loss of vitality. The military metaphor reaches its culmination here, showing that the assault leaves the "turrets" or defensive towers of Lucrece's body abandoned and weak.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Nipples are described as "round turrets."
Euphemism: The term "round turrets" is used to avoid explicit description.
Imagery: The image of "destitute and pale" turrets conveys the devastating impact of the
assault.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza is a powerful and unsettling depiction of Tarquin's predatory assault on Lucrece. It shows the progression of his lust from internal desire to violent action. The personification of his heart, eye, and hand creates a sense of detached agency, as if Tarquin is being driven by forces beyond his control, although he is responsible for his actions. The extended military metaphor emphasizes the violent, invasive nature of his act, portraying it as a conquest and a violation not only of Lucrece's body but also of the very heart of Rome. The final lines are especially chilling, conveying the devastating impact of the assault on Lucrece, leaving her vulnerable and defiled. The language is deliberate and evocative, using vivid imagery and unsettling metaphors to capture the horror and brutality of the situation. The "dignity" of the hand is the perverse and twisted logic of the rapist. It is a stanza filled with tension, dread, and a profound sense of violation.

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Stanza 64 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"They, mustering to the quiet cabinet":

They: Refers to Lucrece's servants/attendants (we know from earlier stanzas that she woke them after the rape).
Mustering: Implies a gathering, a coming together with purpose. It suggests a sense of urgency and collective action, but also perhaps a lack of discipline (they are "mustering" not marching, connoting the chaos).
Quiet cabinet: A private room or chamber, a place of refuge or intimacy. The word "cabinet" is important, underscoring the enclosed and personal nature of the space, which is now being violated by the traumatic intrusion.
Overall: The servants are gathering quickly and in a disorganized manner at Lucrece's private chamber.

"Where their dear governess and lady lies":

Where: Connects this line directly to the previous one, explaining the location of the "quiet cabinet."
Dear governess and lady: Lucrece. The use of both terms ("governess" perhaps implying a more formal role than just "lady") reinforces her social status and the respect she commands. "Dear" shows their affection for her.
Lies: Resting, reposing. It's a loaded word. It could imply rest or sickness, but given the context, it foreshadows her upcoming death, where she will literally lie.
Overall: This line establishes that Lucrece is in her chamber, resting, and emphasizes her position of authority and the affection the servants hold for her.

"Do tell her she is dreadfully beset":

Do tell: Simple verb, conveying the direct and urgent nature of their communication.
Dreadfully beset: "Beset" means surrounded or attacked from all sides. "Dreadfully" intensifies the feeling of extreme peril. This is a euphemism; they are telling her she is in terrible danger, though they may not fully know the extent of the horror she has endured.
Overall: The servants inform Lucrece that she is in a terrible and dangerous situation.

"And fright her with confusion of their cries":

Fright her: They scare Lucrece. The simplicity of this verb emphasizes the immediate impact of their actions.
Confusion of their cries: The chaotic and overwhelming nature of their distressed voices. It highlights their panic and fear.
Overall: The servants further terrify Lucrece with their noisy and disorganized cries, adding to the overall sense of chaos.

"She, much amazed, breaks ope her lock'd-up eyes":
She: Refers to Lucrece.
Much amazed: Greatly surprised and bewildered.

They, mustering to the quiet cabinet
Where their dear governess and lady lies,
Do tell her she is dreadfully beset,
And fright her with confusion of their cries:
She, much amazed, breaks ope her lock'd-up eyes, Who, peeping forth this tumult to behold,
Are by his flaming torch dimm'd and controll'd.

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Breaks ope her lock'd-up eyes: A powerful metaphor. Her eyes were "locked up" either because she was resting or, more likely, because she was trying to block out the horrific memory of the rape. "Breaks ope" suggests a violent and forceful awakening. This "breaking" mirrors the violation she has endured.
Overall: Lucrece, startled and confused, forcibly opens her eyes, breaking free from her slumber or her attempt to shut out the reality of what happened.

"Who, peeping forth this tumult to behold":

Who: Refers back to her eyes (personification).
Peeping forth: Hesitant and fearful looking.
This tumult to behold: To see the chaos and confusion. "Tumult" emphasizes the disorderly and agitated state of the scene.
Overall: Her eyes cautiously peer out at the chaotic scene around her. This line continues the personification of her eyes, treating them as separate entities.

"Are by his flaming torch dimm'd and controll'd.":

Are by his flaming torch: Refers to Collatine's (Lucrece's husband) torch. This is the first mention of Collatine, who is the one holding the torch.
Dimm'd and controll'd: Her eyes are overwhelmed and dominated by the light of the torch. "Dimm'd" suggests that her vision is impaired, perhaps a metaphor for her understanding of the situation being obscured. "Controll'd" implies that the torch (and, by extension, Collatine and the male world) is now dictating her experience.
Overall: Her eyes, still fragile and vulnerable, are overwhelmed by the brightness of Collatine's torch, symbolizing the male dominance and the controlling force of the outside world intruding
upon her trauma.

Overall Meaning and Literary Devices:

This stanza depicts the immediate aftermath of the rape, focusing on Lucrece's disturbed awakening and the intrusion of the outside world into her private space and personal trauma. It highlights the chaos, fear, and vulnerability surrounding her.

Key Literary Devices:

Personification: Lucrece's eyes are given human qualities ("peeping forth").
Metaphor: "Breaks ope her lock'd-up eyes" is a powerful metaphor for her forceful awakening and the shattering of her inner peace. The "locked-up eyes" likely also allude to the idea that she is trying to block out the memory of the rape.
Euphemism: "Dreadfully beset" is a mild term for the severity of Lucrece's situation.
Imagery: The stanza is full of vivid imagery, such as the "quiet cabinet," "flaming torch," and "confusion of their cries," which create a strong sense of the scene.
Foreshadowing: "Lies" has multiple connotations and foreshadows Lucrece's death. Juxtaposition: The "quiet cabinet" juxtaposed with the "confusion of their cries" emphasizes the disruption of her peace.
Symbolism: The torch is a symbol of male power and the controlling force of the outside world intruding upon Lucrece's trauma.
Alliteration: The repetition of "D" in "dreadfully beset" helps emphasize the terror of the situation.

In essence, the stanza effectively portrays the moment when Lucrece is forced to confront the horror of her rape. The disruption of her private space, the chaotic cries of her servants, and the overwhelming presence of the torch all contribute to the sense of her loss of control and the beginning of her tragic downfall. The use of "dimmed and controlled" also alludes to her loss of agency and the beginning of a new period controlled by the patriarchal society.

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← Stanza 64📚 OverviewStanza 66 →

Stanza 65 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "Imagine her as one in dead of night"

Meaning: The speaker sets up a simile, urging the reader to picture Lucrece as someone experiencing a specific, terrifying situation in the middle of the night. The "dead of night" establishes a mood of deep darkness, vulnerability, and fear.
Literary Device: Simile (comparing Lucrece to someone else).

Line 2: "From forth dull sleep by dreadful fancy waking,"

Meaning: This person is roused from a heavy, dreamless sleep ("dull sleep") by a horrifying imagination or nightmare ("dreadful fancy"). The word "forth" is a bit archaic but emphasizes a sudden and forceful awakening.
Literary Device: Alliteration (the 'd' sound in "dull" and "dreadful") adds to the unsettling feeling.

Line 3: "That thinks she hath beheld some ghastly sprite,"

Meaning: The person believes they have seen a frightening ghost or apparition ("ghastly sprite"). It emphasizes the supernatural terror and extreme fear.
Literary Device: Imagery (evokes a vivid picture of a terrifying ghost).

Line 4: "Whose grim aspect sets every joint a-shaking;"

Meaning: The terrifying appearance of the ghost is so frightening that it causes the person to tremble uncontrollably ("sets every joint a-shaking").
Literary Device: Imagery (further describes the ghastly sprite).
Hyperbole - 'every joint a-shaking' is an exaggeration.
Personification - the ghost's aspect has the ability to set joints shaking.

Line 5: "What terror or 'tis! but she, in worser taking,"

Meaning: "What terror that is!" exclamation, recognizing the extreme fear of imagining a ghastly sprite and the physical reaction it causes. The comparison to Lucrece. "But she, in worser taking" acknowledges that Lucrece's reality is even worse than this imagined nightmare. "In worser taking" means in a worse state or predicament.
Literary Device: Exclamation - heightened emotion, disbelief.
Juxtaposition - the imagined horror, then the contrast to Lucrece's horrific reality.

Line 6: "From sleep disturbed, heedfully doth view"

Meaning: Lucrece, also awakened from sleep, carefully and attentively ("heedfully") looks upon...
Literary Device: The language creates a sense of suspense and anticipation.

Imagine her as one in dead of night
From forth dull sleep by dreadful fancy waking,
That thinks she hath beheld some ghastly sprite,
Whose grim aspect sets every joint a-shaking;
What terror or 'tis! but she, in worser taking,
From sleep disturbed, heedfully doth view
The sight which makes supposed terror true.

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Line 7: "The sight which makes supposed terror true."

Meaning: ...the scene before her, which is so horrific that it makes the imagined terror of the ghastly sprite seem real and pale in comparison. In other words, what she sees is a real horror, far surpassing any nightmare.
Literary Device: Irony - the "supposed terror" is now validated and surpassed by a greater, factual terror.
Alliteration - the repetition of the 's' sound in 'sight', 'supposed', which creates a sinister,
hissing sound.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza serves to build the reader's understanding of the magnitude of Lucrece's trauma. By first describing a common, relatable experience – waking from a nightmare and being terrified by an imagined ghost – Shakespeare provides a frame of reference for the emotion of fear. However, he immediately undercuts this comparison, emphasizing that Lucrece's actual experience is far more horrifying than any figment of the imagination. The speaker makes clear that the reader can't even imagine the terror that Lucrece is experiencing. The stanza foreshadows that Lucrece is about to confront something truly dreadful, something that will make her nightmare a reality. This heightens the tension and emphasizes the unspeakable nature of the rape. It underlines the poem's central theme of the devastating consequences of violence and the loss of innocence.

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Stanza 66 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Wrapp'd and confounded in a thousand fears,"

"Wrapp'd and confounded": This uses assonance (repetition of vowel sounds - 'a' in
'wrapp'd' and 'confounded' and the 'o' sound in both words as well) for emphasis. It emphasizes
the total state of being overwhelmed. "Wrapp'd" can be read literally (as being wrapped up or surrounded by her fears) but also figuratively.
"a thousand fears": This is hyperbole. It exaggerates the number of fears to convey the sheer magnitude of Lucrece's terror. It's not literally a thousand, but represents the overwhelming onslaught of anxieties.
Meaning: Lucrece is completely enveloped and disoriented by a multitude of anxieties and horrors. She's lost in a sea of fear.

"Like to a new-kill'd bird she trembling lies;"

"Like to a new-kill'd bird": This is a simile. It compares Lucrece to a freshly killed bird. The image is of something small, vulnerable, and recently traumatized.
"trembling lies": This emphasizes her physical state, highlighting her helplessness. The verb "lies" also speaks to how she is vulnerable and in a prone position.
Meaning: She is lying down, shaking uncontrollably, resembling a defenseless creature that has just been brutally harmed. The comparison underscores her fragility and victimhood.

"She dares not look; yet, winking, there appears"

"She dares not look": Shows her reluctance to confront what has just happened; she is trying to avoid the reality of her situation. The verb "dares" also suggests the trauma to her has fundamentally changed her ability to even bear witness to her surroundings.
"winking, there appears": Suggests involuntary reactions and a lack of control. Even though she is trying to shut out what is happening, her mind is betraying her.
Meaning: Though she avoids looking in order to escape the horror, she cannot control her mind which continues to force her to 'see'.

"Quick-shifting antics, ugly in her eyes:"

"Quick-shifting antics": Alliteration (repetition of the 'q' sound) highlights the rapid and erratic nature of the visions. "Antics" suggests distorted, grotesque, or mocking images.
"ugly in her eyes": Reinforces the repulsiveness and horror of what she is seeing (or imagining).
Meaning: Horrific, rapidly changing images fill her vision, emphasizing the mental torture she is enduring.

"Such shadows are the weak brain's forgeries;"

"shadows": Metaphor for the nightmarish visions and mental images tormenting her.
"weak brain's forgeries": This explains the origin of the visions. Her mind, weakened by trauma, is creating these illusions. The word "forgeries" implies that these are false, deceptive, and ultimately products of her traumatized state.

Wrapp'd and confounded in a thousand fears,
Like to a new-kill'd bird she trembling lies;
She dares not look; yet, winking, there appears
Quick-shifting antics, ugly in her eyes:
Such shadows are the weak brain's forgeries;
Who, angry that the eyes fly from their lights,
In darkness daunts them with more dreadful sights.

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Meaning: These horrifying images are not real but hallucinations created by her traumatized and vulnerable mind.

"Who, angry that the eyes fly from their lights,"

"Who": Refers back to the "brain" in the previous line. The brain is personified as having emotions (anger).
"eyes fly from their lights": This metaphorically describes her attempts to shut out the external world (avoiding the reality of what happened by refusing to look). "Lights" refers to the source of vision and understanding.
Meaning: Her brain, personified, is angry that she's trying to avoid reality by shutting her eyes.

"In darkness daunts them with more dreadful sights."

"In darkness daunts them": "Darkness" refers to the internal darkness of her mind. "Daunts" means to intimidate or discourage. The brain is intimidating her eyes (and, by extension, herself) with even more terrifying images.
"more dreadful sights": The content of the hallucinations is described as even worse than what she is trying to avoid.
Meaning: Because she is trying to escape reality by closing her eyes, her brain punishes her with even more terrifying mental images within the darkness of her own mind.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza describes Lucrece's mental and physical state immediately after the rape. It paints a picture of overwhelming terror, vulnerability, and mental torture. She is completely overwhelmed by fear, compared to a newly killed bird to emphasize her defenselessness. Though she attempts to avoid the reality of the assault by closing her eyes, her traumatized mind conjures even more horrifying images. The stanza personifies her brain as an angry entity that punishes her attempt to escape reality with vivid and dreadful hallucinations. In essence, the stanza depicts the psychological fallout of the rape, where her inner world becomes a landscape of horror reflecting the trauma she has experienced. The stanza vividly highlights the psychological impact of trauma, where the victim's own mind becomes a source of further suffering.

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← Stanza 66📚 OverviewStanza 68 →

Stanza 67 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"His hand, that yet remains upon her breast,–"

His hand: Refers to Tarquin's hand.
that yet remains upon her breast: Emphasizes the ongoing, violating act. The word "yet"
suggests a lingering, prolonged assault.
The dash (–) indicates a pause or a break in thought, creating suspense and drawing attention to the brutality of the action.

"Rude ram, to batter such an ivory wall!–"

Rude ram: A metaphor. Tarquin's hand is compared to a "ram" (a battering ram), an instrument of destruction used to break down walls. "Rude" implies its coarse and violent nature.
to batter such an ivory wall!: A metaphor. Lucrece's breast is compared to a delicate "ivory wall." Ivory suggests purity, beauty, and preciousness, contrasting sharply with the "rude ram." The exclamation point (!) amplifies the horror and injustice of the situation.

"May feel her heart–poor citizen!–distress'd,"

May feel her heart: Suggests that Tarquin, through his touch, could potentially perceive Lucrece's emotional and physical pain.
poor citizen!: A metaphor. Lucrece's heart is personified as a "citizen" within the "city" of her body. This citizen is "poor," implying its vulnerability and lack of power, and "distress'd,"
indicating its suffering. The dashes emphasize the heart's isolation and agony. This is also a form of apostrophe, as he is addressing the heart.

"Wounding itself to death, rise up and fall,"

Wounding itself to death: Continues the personification of the heart, suggesting that her emotional anguish is so severe that it's self-destructive.
rise up and fall: Describes the rapid, irregular heartbeat caused by fear and trauma. This imagery evokes the physical manifestation of extreme emotional distress.

"Beating her bulk, that his hand shakes withal."

Beating her bulk: "Bulk" here refers to Lucrece's body. Her heart is beating so violently that it's shaking her entire body.
that his hand shakes withal: The hand of Tarquin, the abuser, is also shaking. This could be from lust, adrenaline, or a hint of internal conflict, though the following lines suggest the former. "Withal" is an archaic way of saying "with it."

"This moves in him more rage and lesser pity,"

This: Refers to the described physical and emotional distress of Lucrece.
moves in him more rage and lesser pity: Paradoxically, instead of being moved to compassion, Tarquin is further inflamed. Her suffering fuels his lustful anger, diminishing any potential for empathy or remorse.

His hand, that yet remains upon her breast,--
Rude ram, to batter such an ivory wall!--
May feel her heart-poor citizen!--distress'd,
Wounding itself to death, rise up and fall,
Beating her bulk, that his hand shakes withal. This moves in him more rage and lesser pity, To make the breach and enter this sweet city.

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"To make the breach and enter this sweet city."

To make the breach: A metaphor. Refers to Tarquin's resolve to break down Lucrece's resistance and violate her.
and enter this sweet city: A metaphor. Lucrece's body is again described as a "sweet city" that Tarquin is determined to conquer. "Sweet" contrasts with the brutality of the act, highlighting the innocence he is destroying. The finality and definiteness of the line brings the reader to the
climax of the impending rape.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza depicts the moment just before Tarquin commits the rape. He is aware of Lucrece's distress and vulnerability. Her fear and her heart's frantic struggle are palpable. However, instead of deterring him, her suffering only increases his desire and determination to overpower her. The stanza uses vivid imagery and metaphors to emphasize the violent nature of his intentions and the tragic destruction of Lucrece's purity and innocence. The stanza is a powerful study of lust, cruelty, and the complete absence of empathy. The imagery of the city under siege underlines the idea of Lucrece's body being invaded and violated against her will.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: (Hand as "rude ram," Lucrece's breast/body as "ivory wall" and "sweet city," Heart as "poor citizen") This is the most prominent device. The metaphors create vivid imagery and highlight the violent invasion and the vulnerability of the victim.
Personification: (Heart "distress'd," "wounding itself to death") Giving human qualities to the heart emphasizes Lucrece's emotional turmoil.
Alliteration: Repetition of sounds "Beating her bulk" adds to the poetic effect.
Apostrophe: Addressing the heart (poor citizen!)
Exclamation: Used to emphasize the severity of the act.
Dashes: Create pauses and emphasize certain phrases.
Paradox: Her suffering causes rage, not pity, in Tarquin.
Contrast: Juxtaposition of "rude ram" and "ivory wall" emphasizes the violence against purity. The "sweet city" is about to be defiled.
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← Stanza 67📚 OverviewStanza 69 →

Stanza 68 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"First, like a trumpet, doth his tongue begin":

Meaning: Collatine (who is about to rape Lucrece) begins to speak. His voice is likened to a trumpet.
Literary Devices:
Simile: "like a trumpet" - a direct comparison using "like." This suggests his voice is loud, forceful, and perhaps somewhat jarring or aggressive. Trumpets were often used to signal
battle or important announcements.
Inversion (Anastrophe): The typical word order would be "His tongue doth begin, like a trumpet." The reversed order emphasizes "trumpet" and lends a more formal, poetic feel.

"To sound a parley to his heartless foe;":

Meaning: He is attempting to negotiate with Lucrece, whom he sees as his "heartless foe." The "parley" implies he's trying to reach an agreement or at least explain himself before proceeding. Collatine views her virtue as an obstacle.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Lucrece is referred to as a "heartless foe." This isn't literal; it signifies her
resistance to his advances, her moral opposition to his lust. It emphasizes his perceived battle against her virtue.
Personification: Giving Lucrece, who is the embodiment of virtue in Collatine's mind, the characteristic of being a "foe".
Allusion: "parley" suggests a formal discussion between enemies, reminiscent of battlefield negotiations.

"Who o'er the white sheet peers her whiter chin,":

Meaning: Lucrece, from beneath the bedsheets, looks up with her pale chin visible. The sheets emphasize her purity and vulnerability. The color white symbolizes innocence.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: The visual image of Lucrece peering over the sheets is vivid. The use of "white" is symbolic and reinforces her purity.
Alliteration: "white sheet" and "whiter chin". The repeated 'wh' sound emphasizes the purity theme.

Juxtaposition: Comparing the whiteness of the sheets to her chin. This highlights Lucrece's beauty and, again, emphasizes her innocence, making Collatine's actions even more reprehensible.

"The reason of this rash alarm to know,":

Meaning: Lucrece wants to know why Collatine is acting so abruptly and aggressively. She is alarmed and demands an explanation.

First, like a trumpet, doth his tongue begin
To sound a parley to his heartless foe;
Who o'er the white sheet peers her whiter chin,
The reason of this rash alarm to know,
Which he by dumb demeanor seeks to show;
But she with vehement prayers urgeth still Under what colour he commits this ill.

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Literary Devices:
None particularly strong, but consider the slight understatement: The word "alarm" is perhaps understated, given the gravity of the situation. It hints at her initial shock and confusion.

"Which he by dumb demeanor seeks to show;":

Meaning: He tries to show her, through his actions (his "dumb demeanor"), his intentions, but not verbally. He's not speaking directly about his desires.
Literary Devices:
Oxymoron (possibly): "dumb demeanor" can be interpreted as an oxymoron. "Dumb"
typically refers to a lack of speech, while "demeanor" implies behavior that communicates something. However, it can also simply mean that his behavior, rather than words, is trying to explain his intentions.

"But she with vehement prayers urgeth still":

Meaning: Lucrece continues to beg him earnestly, using "vehement prayers" (intense and passionate requests). She doesn't understand the non-verbal cues and wants a clear explanation. Literary Devices:
Imagery: "Vehement prayers" creates a strong image of Lucrece's desperation and intense pleading.
Alliteration: "prayers urgeth" emphasizes Lucrece's pleas through the repeated "pr" sound.

"Under what colour he commits this ill.":

Meaning: Lucrece demands to know his justification or pretense for his evil deed. "Colour" means pretext, excuse, or apparent reason. She wants to know what rationale, what twisted logic, he's using to justify his actions.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Colour" is used metaphorically to represent the apparent motive or excuse he's
using to hide the true nature of his evil.
Euphemism: "this ill" is a softer way of referring to the rape he is about to commit.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza captures the crucial moment of confrontation before the rape. Collatine attempts to initiate his assault, framing it as a negotiation ("parley") with Lucrece's virtue, which he personifies as a "heartless foe." Lucrece, awakened and alarmed, demands an explanation for his behavior. While Collatine attempts to communicate his intentions through his actions, Lucrece persists in seeking a verbal justification for what she perceives as a wrong. The stanza highlights the power imbalance, the conflicting perspectives, and the contrast between Collatine's aggressive desire and Lucrece's desperate pleas for reason and justice. The use of vivid imagery and literary devices emphasizes Lucrece's innocence, Collatine's twisted reasoning, and the imminent tragedy. Ultimately, it shows the breakdown of communication and the horrific inevitability of the act to come.

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← Stanza 68📚 OverviewStanza 70 →

Stanza 69 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Thus he replies: 'The colour in thy face,"
Meaning: This sets the scene, indicating that Tarquin is responding to Lucrece's initial protests or attempts to deter him. He is focusing on her physical appearance, particularly her complexion.

"That even for anger makes the lily pale,"
Meaning: Lucrece's anger, paradoxically, drains the color from her face, making her skin so white
it puts the lily (a symbol of purity and whiteness) to shame. The lily is metonymy for whiteness. Literary Device: Hyperbole (exaggeration) - it's unlikely that anger literally makes her face whiter than a lily. Metonymy.

"And the red rose blush at her own disgrace,"
Meaning: Conversely, the flush of red anger that should naturally appear is so intense that it would even make a red rose (a symbol of beauty and passion) feel ashamed by comparison. Literary Device: Hyperbole (again, exaggeration). Personification (the rose is blushing). Metonymy.

"Shall plead for me and tell my loving tale:"
Meaning: Tarquin is now twisting the situation. He claims that her beautiful, expressive face – the very evidence of her distress and anger – will actually argue on his behalf and convince her of his love. He is manipulating her reaction to his advances and portraying it as a sign of attraction. Literary Device: Irony (He's turning her resistance into a reason to justify his actions).

"Under that colour am I come to scale"
Meaning: He uses a military metaphor, comparing himself to a soldier who is scaling (climbing) a fort. The "colour" here refers to her complexion, which he sees as a sort of fortification. The "under" suggests he's using her beauty as a shield, or as a justification for his assault.
Literary Device: Metaphor (Tarquin is not literally scaling a fort, but comparing his pursuit of Lucrece to a military assault).

"Thy never-conquer'd fort: the fault is thine,"
Meaning: Lucrece is the fort that has never been conquered before. Tarquin is placing the blame on her, saying it's her fault that he's attacking her.
Literary Device: Metaphor (Extending the "fort" metaphor). Blaming the Victim (A manipulative tactic).

"For those thine eyes betray thee unto mine."
Meaning: Her eyes, her innermost being, have supposedly revealed her true desire to him. He suggests that she has been secretly inviting his advances with her gaze, despite her outward protests.
Literary Device: False Attribution (He's projecting his desires onto her).

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a critical moment in the poem where Tarquin attempts to justify his impending assault on Lucrece. He uses manipulative language, turning her distress into a twisted justification for his actions. He weaponizes her beauty, suggesting that her expressive face and eyes have essentially

Thus he replies: 'The colour in thy face,
That even for anger makes the lily pale,
And the red rose blush at her own disgrace,
Shall plead for me and tell my loving tale:
Under that colour am I come to scale
Thy never-conquer'd fort: the fault is thine, For those thine eyes betray thee unto mine.

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lured him into attacking her. He presents himself as a conqueror, and Lucrece as a previously unconquered fortress, further diminishing her agency. The stanza reveals his warped perspective, his lack of empathy, and his determination to absolve himself of guilt by blaming Lucrece for his own vile intentions. It is a masterclass in psychological manipulation and the abuse of power. The irony is heavy as he uses her natural reactions of anger and fear to fuel his predatory pursuit.

Key Literary Devices:

Hyperbole: Exaggeration to emphasize Lucrece's beauty and the intensity of her emotions. Metaphor: Comparing Lucrece to a "fort" and Tarquin's pursuit to "scaling" it.
Personification: Giving human qualities to the "red rose" (blushing).
Irony: Tarquin twisting Lucrece's resistance into a justification for his assault.
Blaming the Victim: He tries to shift the responsibility for his actions onto Lucrece.
Metonymy: Using 'lily' to mean whiteness, and 'rose' to mean beauty.
False Attribution: Projecting his desires onto Lucrece and claiming her eyes "betray" her.

In essence, this stanza is a disturbing example of power dynamics and how easily language can be used to twist reality and excuse horrific actions. It highlights the dangers of manipulation and the violation of consent that lies at the heart of the poem.
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← Stanza 69📚 OverviewStanza 71 →

Stanza 70 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Thus I forestall thee, if thou mean to chide:"

Forestall: To prevent or obstruct by taking action ahead of time.
Chide: To scold or rebuke.
Meaning: "So, I'm getting ahead of your reaction. If you intend to scold or blame me, let me explain why." He's preemptively justifying his actions to Lucrece.

"Thy beauty hath ensnared thee to this night,"

Ensnared: Trapped or caught, as in a snare.
Meaning: "Your beauty is the reason you are in this situation tonight; it is the reason I am here." He blames her appearance for his lust and the impending rape. This is a classic, and deeply troubling, example of victim-blaming.

"Where thou with patience must my will abide;"

Abide: To endure, accept, or comply with.
Meaning: "Therefore, you must patiently endure my will" implying she must let him do what he wants.

"My will that marks thee for my earth's delight,"

Will: His desire, his intention, specifically his lustful desire.
Earth's delight: A sensual, physical pleasure; a temporary, earthly gratification.
Meaning: "My desire chooses you to be my earthly pleasure, something that gives me physical satisfaction." He is objectifying Lucrece, reducing her to a source of his sexual gratification. "Which I to conquer sought with all my might;"

Conquer: To overcome, subdue, or take by force.
Meaning: "I tried with all my strength to suppress this desire, to master myself," he claims. Note the implication that he tried to resist, but that his efforts ultimately failed.

"But as reproof and reason beat it dead,"

Reproof: Rebuke or disapproval.
Reason: The ability to think, understand, and make judgments based on logic.
Beat it dead: Killed or extinguished it.
Meaning: "But just when my conscience (reproof) and logical thinking (reason) had managed to kill this desire..."

"By thy bright beauty was it newly bred."

Newly Bred: Born, created, or brought into existence again.
Meaning: "...Your bright beauty caused it to be reborn." Again, he directly places the blame for his lust on Lucrece's beauty.

Overall Meaning and Literary Devices:

'Thus I forestall thee, if thou mean to chide:
Thy beauty hath ensnared thee to this night,
Where thou with patience must my will abide;
My will that marks thee for my earth's delight, Which I to conquer sought with all my might; But as reproof and reason beat it dead,
By thy bright beauty was it newly bred.

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This stanza is a crucial moment in Collatine's justification for his actions. Collatine presents a twisted, self-serving argument.

The overall meaning of the stanza is that Collatine blames Lucrece for his lust and the impending rape. He attempts to absolve himself of responsibility by claiming that he tried to resist, but her beauty was too powerful to overcome. He objectifies her, reducing her to a source of physical pleasure, and insists that she must passively accept his will.

Literary Devices:

Victim-blaming: The most prominent device is the consistent blame placed on Lucrece for Collatine's own desires and actions.
Personification: "Reproof and reason beat it dead" gives human qualities (the ability to beat) to abstract concepts.
Euphemism: "Earth's delight" is a euphemism for sexual gratification, softening the harshness of his intention, at least to his own ears.
Dramatic Irony: The reader/audience knows the horror of the rape that is about to occur, making Collatine's justifications all the more repulsive and revealing.
Alliteration: "bright beauty" is an example of alliteration, which adds emphasis to the line.

In essence, this stanza is a chilling portrayal of how a perpetrator rationalizes his actions and attempts to shift the blame onto the victim. It highlights the themes of lust, power, and the abuse of innocence that are central to the poem. Collatine's words are a web of lies, excuses, and self-deception.

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← Stanza 70📚 OverviewStanza 72 →

Stanza 71 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"I see what crosses my attempt will bring;"

Meaning: "I understand the negative consequences that will result from thwarting my desires."
He is acknowledging that pursuing Lucrece will have terrible repercussions. He's not oblivious to
the potential damage. "Crosses" here means obstacles but also negative outcomes.
Literary Device: Foreshadowing (hints at the impending tragedy).

"I know what thorns the growing rose defends;"

Meaning: "I am aware of the dangers and difficulties that protect beauty and virtue." The rose is Lucrece, and the thorns represent her chastity, her husband, societal expectations, and the potential for resistance. He knows she's not an easy target.
Literary Device: Metaphor. The rose symbolizes beauty and virtue; the thorns symbolize the protective measures around it.

"I think the honey guarded with a sting;"

Meaning: "I believe that desirable things (like Lucrece's beauty and virtue) are often protected by painful consequences or resistance." Similar to the rose and thorns, this uses the image of honey to symbolize something sweet and desirable, guarded by the pain of a sting.
Literary Device: Metaphor. The honey represents desirability and the sting represents the danger or pain associated with obtaining it.

"All this beforehand counsel comprehends:"

Meaning: "My rational mind ("counsel") understands and acknowledges all of these potential dangers and consequences before I act." His intellect understands the risks; he is not acting out of ignorance.
Literary Device: Personification. "Counsel" is given the ability to "comprehend," representing Collatine's rational mind.

"But will is deaf and hears no heedful friends;"

Meaning: "However, my desire ("will") is stubborn and ignores the wise advice of reason and friends (internal or external)." He's admitting that his lust overrides his logical thought. "Will" here means desire, particularly lust.
Literary Device: Personification. "Will" is given the ability to be "deaf" and ignore "heedful friends," which emphasizes the power of uncontrolled desire. Metaphor - "heedful friends" are not literal people, but a metaphor for rational thought or external advice.

"Only he hath an eye to gaze on beauty,"

Meaning: "His desire only sees Lucrece's beauty." It is blinded by it.
Literary Device: Synecdoche - 'eye' is used to represent his desire and focus on the external beauty.

' I see what crosses my attempt will bring;
I know what thorns the growing rose defends;
I think the honey guarded with a sting;
All this beforehand counsel comprehends:
But will is deaf and hears no heedful friends; Only he hath an eye to gaze on beauty,
And dotes on what he looks, 'gainst law or duty.

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"And dotes on what he looks, 'gainst law or duty."

Meaning: "And is infatuated with what it sees, even though it goes against both legal and moral obligations." "Dotes" means to be excessively fond of. He is captivated by Lucrece to the point where he disregards morality and the law.
Literary Device: Antithesis. "Law or duty" emphasizes the violation of both social (law) and personal (duty) obligations.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza reveals the internal conflict within the speaker (Tarquin). He is fully aware of the potential consequences of his actions and the moral implications of his desire for Lucrece. His rational mind recognizes the thorns guarding the rose, the sting protecting the honey, and the potential destruction his pursuit could unleash. However, he is ultimately powerless to resist his "will," or lust, which blinds him to everything except the object of his desire. The stanza sets up the tragic events that follow, emphasizing the power of unchecked desire to override reason and morality. It highlights the human capacity for self-destructive behavior, even when fully aware of the risks.

Key Literary Devices Emphasized:

Metaphor: The rose and thorns, honey and sting are all metaphors for Lucrece's beauty and the dangers/resistance surrounding it.
Personification: "Counsel" comprehends and "will" is deaf, giving human qualities to abstract concepts to emphasize the internal conflict.
Foreshadowing: The first line hints at the tragic consequences that will follow.
Antithesis: "Law or duty" highlights the blatant violation of both.
Synecdoche: 'eye' for Tarquin's desire.

In essence, this stanza is a microcosm of the entire poem's theme: the destructive power of lust when it overpowers reason and morality. It demonstrates that knowledge of right and wrong is not enough to prevent wrongdoing if the "will" is allowed to run rampant.

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← Stanza 71📚 OverviewStanza 73 →

Stanza 72 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"I have debated, even in my soul,"

Meaning: The speaker (Tarquin) is acknowledging a deep inner conflict. "Debated" implies a conscious weighing of options. "Even in my soul" intensifies the seriousness of this internal struggle. He's not just casually thinking about it; he's wrestling with his conscience at the very core of his being.
Literary Devices: Internal Conflict: This line establishes the central conflict within Tarquin. Hyperbole: "Even in my soul" is a slight exaggeration to emphasize the depth of his internal struggle.

"What wrong, what shame, what sorrow I shall breed;"

Meaning: He's aware of the negative consequences his actions will cause. He anticipates the "wrong" (the act itself), the "shame" (the public disgrace and loss of honor), and the "sorrow" (the suffering he will inflict on Lucrece and others).
Literary Devices: Triad/List of three: The repetition of "what" followed by "wrong, shame, sorrow" creates a rhythmic emphasis on the negative consequences, highlighting their weight. Alliteration: The repetition of the 's' sound in "shame," "sorrow," and "shall" is alliterative.

"But nothing can affection's course control,"

Meaning: Here, "affection" is a euphemism for lust or overwhelming desire. He's claiming that his passion is so strong that it is uncontrollable. It is personified as if it has its own course and it cannot be changed.
Literary Devices: Euphemism: "Affection" softens the bluntness of lust. Personification: "Affection" is given a "course" implying it's an external force acting upon him.

"Or stop the headlong fury of his speed."

Meaning: This reinforces the previous line. The "headlong fury" describes the reckless, uncontrolled nature of his desire. "Speed" implies that this desire is rapidly accelerating. It builds on the personification that affection has its own force.
Literary Devices: Metaphor: Desire is compared to a "headlong fury" implying its destructive and impulsive nature. Alliteration: The repetition of the 'h' sound in "headlong" is alliterative. Personification: The fury is given the power of movement and speed.

"I know repentant tears ensue the deed,"

Meaning: He's fully aware that he will feel remorseful ("repentant tears") after he commits the act. He is not ignorant of the consequences, the knowledge doesn't deter him.
Literary Devices: Foreshadowing: This line hints at the inevitable guilt and regret Tarquin will experience. Irony: He acknowledges the future regret, yet continues on his path.

"Reproach, disdain, and deadly enmity;"

Meaning: He foresees the societal and personal consequences that will follow: "reproach" (censure from others), "disdain" (the scorn of Lucrece and others), and "deadly enmity" (the lasting hatred and potential for revenge).

' I have debated, even in my soul,
What wrong, what shame, what sorrow I shall breed;
But nothing can affection's course control,
Or stop the headlong fury of his speed.
I know repentant tears ensue the deed,
Reproach, disdain, and deadly enmity;
Yet strive I to embrace mine infamy.'

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Literary Devices: Triad/List of three: The repetition of the nouns "reproach, disdain, and deadly enmity" creates a dramatic impact. Assonance: The repetition of the 'e' sound in "reproach," "deadly," and "enmity" creates a harmonic effect.

"Yet strive I to embrace mine infamy."

Meaning: Despite knowing all the negative consequences (shame, sorrow, future regret, societal condemnation), he is actively choosing to pursue his desire. He is "striving" to commit this
infamous act. "Embrace" is shocking – it suggests a perverse willingness to accept the disgrace. Literary Devices: Paradox/Oxymoron: "Embrace mine infamy" is a paradox. "Embrace" typically denotes affection or acceptance, whereas "infamy" is something to be avoided. This juxtaposition highlights the irrationality of his desire. Foreshadowing: This line foreshadows his ultimate fall
from grace and reputation.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza reveals the internal turmoil of Tarquin as he contemplates the rape of Lucrece. He is not ignorant of the wrongness of his actions. He understands the profound consequences – the pain he will inflict, the shame he will bring upon himself, and the lasting hatred he will inspire. Despite this knowledge, he claims to be powerless against the overwhelming force of his lust. In the end, he chooses to surrender to his desire, even embracing the "infamy" that will inevitably follow. It demonstrates his descent from rational thought to uncontrolled passion.

Key Literary Devices Emphasized:
Internal Conflict: The central theme of the stanza.
Euphemism: "Affection" for lust.
Personification: Giving human qualities to "affection" and "fury."
Metaphor: Desire as a "headlong fury."
Triad/List of Three: Emphasizing the negative consequences. Foreshadowing: Hinting at Tarquin's future guilt and Lucrece's fate.
Irony: Knowing the regret yet continuing the deed.
Paradox/Oxymoron: "Embrace mine infamy" highlighting the irrationality. ← Stanza 71📚 OverviewStanza 73 →

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← Stanza 72📚 OverviewStanza 74 →

Stanza 73 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "This said, he shakes aloft his Roman blade,"

Literal Meaning: After saying this (presumably something threatening), Tarquin raises his
Roman sword high in the air. "Aloft" means upwards or on high.
Analysis: This is a simple, direct statement emphasizing the physical threat. The "Roman blade" reminds us of Tarquin's power, his status, and the potential for violence.
Literary Devices: None apparent in this line.

Line 2: "Which, like a falcon towering in the skies,"

Literal Meaning: The sword, as Tarquin holds it high, is compared to a falcon flying high up in the sky.
Analysis: This is the beginning of an extended simile, a comparison using "like" or "as". The falcon imagery is crucial, as it represents power, aggression, and predatory dominance. The "towering" suggests superiority and control.
Literary Devices: Simile.

Line 3: "Coucheth the fowl below with his wings' shade,"

Literal Meaning: The falcon's shadow cast by its wings, forces a bird (fowl) beneath him to crouch down. "Coucheth" means to crouch or lie down.
Analysis: This continues the falcon simile. The "fowl" is vulnerable, overwhelmed by the falcon's presence. The shadow is not physical, but it is enough to cause the bird to submit.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (the shadow stands for a larger threat of Tarquin's influence), Alliteration ("Wings' shade").
Line 4: "Whose crooked beak threatens if he mount he dies:"

Literal Meaning: The fowl's beak represents a futile defiance. If the bird tries to fly (mount), it will face deadly consequences.
Analysis: This line reinforces the imbalance of power. The fowl may still threaten, but it's an empty threat. Resistance is futile. The threat of death further underlines the peril.
Literary Devices: Personification (the beak threatens).

Line 5: "So under his insulting falchion lies,"

Literal Meaning: Just like the fowl under the falcon, Lucrece lies helpless beneath Tarquin's curved sword ("falchion"). "Insulting" suggests a cruel and humiliating display of power. Analysis: This line brings the simile back to Lucrece. She is the vulnerable fowl, and Tarquin is the falcon. The word "insulting" highlights the psychological and emotional violence alongside the physical threat.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (Lucrece is the fowl), Alliteration ("Falchion lies").

Line 6: "Harmless Lucretia, marking what he tells,"

Literal Meaning: Lucrece, who is innocent ("harmless"), is paying attention to what Tarquin is saying.

This said, he shakes aloft his Roman blade,
Which, like a falcon towering in the skies,
Coucheth the fowl below with his wings' shade,
Whose crooked beak threats if he mount he dies:
So under his insulting falchion lies
Harmless Lucretia, marking what he tells
With trembling fear, as fowl hear falcon's bells.

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Analysis: This line emphasizes Lucrece's innocence and passivity. She is simply listening to Tarquin’s threats, completely unarmed against his assault.
Literary Devices: None apparent in this line.

Line 7: "With trembling fear, as fowl hear falcon's bells."

Literal Meaning: Lucrece is trembling with fear, just as a bird would tremble upon hearing the bells attached to a falcon (used in falconry).
Analysis: This is another simile, driving home the fear and vulnerability of Lucrece. The falcon's bells were used to locate the bird during hunts. The noise would cause other birds great anxiety. Literary Devices: Simile, Assonance ("Fear, hear").

Overall Meaning:

This stanza uses an extended simile involving a falcon and its prey to depict the power dynamics between Tarquin and Lucrece. Tarquin, wielding his sword, is likened to a falcon, a symbol of dominance and aggression. Lucrece is represented as the helpless fowl, trapped and terrified by Tarquin's threat. The stanza highlights Lucrece's vulnerability, her fear, and the overwhelming power Tarquin holds over her. The "insulting falchion" underscores the humiliation and cruelty inflicted upon her, making her impending rape all the more tragic. The extended metaphor perfectly encapsulates the helplessness and fear experienced by Lucrece while trapped in this situation. The final line seals the comparison, solidifying the image of Lucrece's utter terror.

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← Stanza 73📚 OverviewStanza 75 →

Stanza 74 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Lucrece,' quoth he,'this night I must enjoy thee:"

Lucrece,: The direct address of Lucrece by Tarquin.
quoth he: An archaic way of saying "said he". It's a stylistic marker, giving the poem a sense of formality and distance.
this night I must enjoy thee: A direct and brutal declaration of Tarquin's intent. "Enjoy" is a euphemism, concealing the violent reality of rape. He is not asking, he is stating his intention. He asserts his perceived right to pleasure over Lucrece's body.

"If thou deny, then force must work my way,"

If thou deny: Presents Lucrece with a false choice.
then force must work my way: Explicit threat of violence. The phrase "work my way" is chillingly detached, as if he's dealing with an obstacle rather than a human being. It further reinforces the power dynamic, where he sees Lucrece as something to be overcome.

"For in thy bed I purpose to destroy thee:"

For in thy bed: Reinforces the violation he is planning and the intimate setting.
I purpose to destroy thee: The chilling statement of intent goes beyond simply "enjoying" her; it is about complete destruction, both physical and emotional. The word "purpose" implies premeditation and cold calculation.

"That done, some worthless slave of thine I'll slay,"

That done: A cold, almost business-like transition to the next phase of his plan.
some worthless slave of thine I'll slay: A threat to frame Lucrece and further defile her reputation. The phrase "worthless slave" highlights the social hierarchy and Tarquin's belief in his own superiority, granting him the power to dispose of others as he pleases.

"To kill thine honour with thy life's decay;"

To kill thine honour with thy life's decay: This connects the physical act of rape to the destruction of Lucrece's reputation ("honour"). "Life's decay" refers to both the physical ruin caused by the rape and the social ruin that will follow. It highlights the importance of chastity and reputation in the patriarchal society of the time.

"And in thy dead arms do I mean to place him,"

And in thy dead arms: This image is grotesque and further emphasizes the total lack of respect Tarquin has for Lucrece.
do I mean to place him: Reinforces the premeditation, and how deeply thought out his plan is.

"Swearing I slew him, seeing thee embrace him."

Swearing I slew him, seeing thee embrace him: This is the final, devastating stroke. Tarquin plans to lie, claiming he killed the slave in a fit of jealous rage after catching Lucrece with him. This would completely destroy her reputation and leave her with no recourse. It ensures she will be seen as an adulteress, not a victim of rape.

' Lucrece,' quoth he,'this night I must enjoy thee:
If thou deny, then force must work my way,
For in thy bed I purpose to destroy thee:
That done, some worthless slave of thine I'll slay,
To kill thine honour with thy life's decay;
And in thy dead arms do I mean to place him, Swearing I slew him, seeing thee embrace him.

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Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza is a chilling depiction of Tarquin's depravity and the extent of his evil plan. It reveals that his motivation is not just lust but also a desire to utterly destroy Lucrece's honor and reputation. He lays out his plan with cold, calculated precision, showcasing his ruthlessness and disregard for human life. The stanza highlights the vulnerability of women in a patriarchal society, where their worth is often tied to their chastity and reputation, and how easily these things can be taken from them. It emphasizes the importance of honor, reputation, and the devastating consequences of their loss.

Literary Devices:

Euphemism: "Enjoy" masks the violent nature of the intended rape.
Imagery: The image of Lucrece with the dead slave in her arms is powerful and disturbing. Irony: Tarquin speaks of honor while simultaneously planning to commit a dishonorable act. Repetition/Emphasis: "I must," "I purpose," "I mean" all underscore Tarquin's deliberate and resolute intentions.
Threat/Violence: The entire stanza is built on the threat of physical and social violence.
Diction: The formal and archaic language ("quoth," "thine") creates a sense of distance and elevates the scene to a level of tragic grandeur. The contrast between this formality and the brutal content is unsettling.
Alliteration: Possible example could be "life's decay", which emphasizes the corruption of Lucrece's honor.
Assonance: Possible example could be "slay" and "place", which links together Tarquin's actions
and how they will contribute to Lucrece's demise.
Dramatic Irony: The reader knows that Lucrece will not submit and that this will lead to her ultimate tragedy.

This stanza is a pivotal moment in the poem, setting the stage for the tragic events that follow. It underscores the power imbalance between Tarquin and Lucrece and the devastating consequences of his actions.

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← Stanza 74📚 OverviewStanza 76 →

Stanza 75 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"So thy surviving husband shall remain"

Breakdown: This line sets up the consequences Lucrece's actions (specifically, Tarquin's rape of her) will have on her husband, Collatinus, after her death. "So" indicates this is a direct consequence of the rape and her subsequent suicide.
Interpretation: Her husband's life will be forever altered and defined by this horrific event. He
will be permanently marked.

"The scornful mark of every open eye;"

Breakdown: This expands on the first line. Collatinus will not just be changed, he will be publicly shamed. "Open eye" suggests that everyone will be aware of his humiliation and be openly
critical of him.

Interpretation: He will be the object of public ridicule and contempt. He will be seen as weak or incapable of protecting his honor and his wife's. The phrase "scornful mark" is significant; it's a metaphor suggesting he's branded by this shame, visible to all.

"Thy kinsmen hang their heads at this disdain,"

Breakdown: This moves beyond the husband to Lucrece's extended family. "Kinsmen" refers to her male relatives, the ones who would be responsible for defending her honor. "Hang their heads" is a physical representation of shame and defeat. "Disdain" reinforces the idea of widespread contempt.
Interpretation: Her family will be humiliated and deeply ashamed by what has happened to her. They will feel they have failed in their duty to protect her and their family's reputation.

"Thy issue blurr'd with nameless bastardy:"

Breakdown: This line considers the impact on her children (or the children she would have had, if she weren't so traumatized by the rape). "Issue" means offspring. "Blurred with nameless bastardy" is a complex and harsh phrase. Since the rape has shattered her honor, the question of Lucrece's future children's paternity will be raised; they could be considered illegitimate, or "bastards". "Nameless" reinforces the idea that their true father is unknown, causing them to be dishonored.

Interpretation: Her future descendants will be tainted by this scandal. Their legitimacy and social standing will be forever questioned, and they will carry the stigma of her shame.

"And thou, the author of their obloquy,"

Breakdown: "Thou" is Lucrece. "Author" implies responsibility or origin. "Obloquy" means strong public criticism or condemnation; disgrace. This is a controversial line, placing (in a way) the blame for all of this on Lucrece.

Interpretation: This line argues that Lucrece, through her suicide (precipitated by the rape), will be seen as the cause of all the disgrace that befalls her family. It's a complex and arguably unfair accusation, but it reflects the patriarchal values of the time, where a woman's honor was seen as the foundation of the family's reputation. Note the irony: she is the victim of a crime, yet deemed the "author" of the shame.

' So thy surviving husband shall remain
The scornful mark of every open eye;
Thy kinsmen hang their heads at this disdain,
Thy issue blurr'd with nameless bastardy:
And thou, the author of their obloquy,
Shalt have thy trespass cited up in rhymes, And sung by children in succeeding times.

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"Shalt have thy trespass cited up in rhymes,"

Breakdown: "Trespass" can mean sin, transgression, or violation (referring to Tarquin's rape, but implying also the perceived sin of her suicide). "Cited up in rhymes" means that her story will be told in poems and songs.
Interpretation: Her tragic story, including the violation she suffered and her suicide, will be immortalized in verse.

"And sung by children in succeeding times."

Breakdown: This emphasizes the lasting impact of her story. "Succeeding times" means future generations.
Interpretation: The tale of Lucrece's rape and its consequences will be passed down through generations, becoming a cautionary tale and a permanent part of cultural memory.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza outlines the devastating and far-reaching consequences of Lucrece's rape. It depicts the shame and disgrace that will befall her husband, her family, and her potential descendants. It also highlights the paradox of her situation, where she, the victim, is also held responsible for the shame and obloquy that follows. Ultimately, the stanza suggests that Lucrece's tragedy will become a cautionary tale, forever etched in the collective memory of society.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: "The scornful mark" is a metaphor for the enduring shame and public humiliation that Collatinus will bear.
Irony: The attribution of authorship to Lucrece, when she is actually the victim of Tarquin's violence.
Imagery: The image of kinsmen "hanging their heads" is a vivid and symbolic representation of shame and defeat.
Allusion: The stanza contributes to the overall poem's engagement with classical themes of honor, virtue, and the consequences of transgression.
Foreshadowing: This stanza can be seen as foreshadowing the future political upheaval and rebellion that will eventually overthrow the Tarquin monarchy, as the rape of Lucrece is a key catalyst for those events.
Juxtaposition: The stanza juxtaposes the personal tragedy of Lucrece with the public and political ramifications of her rape.

The stanza is powerful because it explores the themes of honor, shame, responsibility, and the lasting impact of violence on individuals and society. It's a complex and nuanced portrayal of a tragic situation, highlighting the societal pressures and expectations that contribute to Lucrece's fate.

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← Stanza 75📚 OverviewStanza 77 →

Stanza 76 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"But if thou yield, I rest thy secret friend:"

Meaning: This is Tarquin speaking to Lucrece. He's saying, "If you give in to my desires (yield sexually), I will remain your hidden ally/friend."
Literary Devices: Directly addresses Lucrece, trying to persuade and soften the blow.

"The fault unknown is as a thought unacted;"

Meaning: "If no one finds out about this sin (the rape), it's as if it never even happened; it's like a thought that was never acted upon." He minimizes the impact of the act.
Literary Devices: Simile: "as a thought unacted." Compares the unseen transgression to an action never taken, diminishing its weight.

"A little harm done to a great good end"

Meaning: This is rationalization. He argues that this small "harm" (the rape) could lead to a greater good, though he doesn't specify what that "good" might be (perhaps political alliance, personal gain, etc.).
Literary Devices: Justification, twisted logic. It’s a manipulative tactic.

"For lawful policy remains enacted."

Meaning: This is a tricky line. It suggests that the "good end" somehow relates to the established laws and customs (policy). He implies that his actions serve some greater, legally sanctioned purpose, even if it's not immediately apparent. It’s a vague, self-serving justification.
Literary Devices: Ambiguity; it's not clear what lawful policy this serves, making it more of a rhetorical flourish than a genuine argument.

"The poisonous simple sometimes is compacted"

Meaning: "A poisonous substance (simple) is sometimes mixed (compacted) with other elements..."
Literary Devices: Analogy/Metaphor: The poisonous simple acts as a metaphor for the rape.

"In a pure compound; being so applied,"

Meaning: "...into a pure medicine/compound. When used in this way..."
Literary Devices: Continues the Analogy/Metaphor: the pure compound is what he claims to be the resultant effect.

"His venom in effect is purified."

Meaning: "...its poison is effectively neutralized or made harmless."
Literary Devices: Completes the Analogy/Metaphor: implies that the rape will be nullified and the result will be positive.
Further notes on Analogy/Metaphor: This is the most important literary device here. The analogy to medicine is deeply ironic because Tarquin is clearly not acting as a healer. Instead, he is attempting to justify his base actions by suggesting that they can be somehow transformed into

' But if thou yield, I rest thy secret friend:
The fault unknown is as a thought unacted;
A little harm done to a great good end
For lawful policy remains enacted.
The poisonous simple sometimes is compacted
In a pure compound; being so applied,
His venom in effect is purified.

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something beneficial. He wants to convince Lucrece that the act itself can be rendered harmless, even "pure," through some unspecified transformation.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Tarquin is using a series of manipulative and twisted arguments to persuade Lucrece to yield to his desires. He attempts to minimize the significance of the act, suggesting it can remain a secret, that it could serve a greater good, and that, like a poisonous substance used in medicine, the harm can be turned into something beneficial.

The stanza is a showcase of sophistry, where Tarquin employs clever-sounding but ultimately false or misleading reasoning to achieve his selfish goal. The medicinal analogy is particularly insidious, as it presents a violent and immoral act as potentially therapeutic or even purifying, highlighting the depths of Tarquin's depravity and his willingness to rationalize his actions. The stanza reveals his cunning and his complete lack of remorse or empathy for Lucrece. The "secret friend" line, in particular, is filled with false promises, as Tarquin has no intention of being a true friend to her. Instead, he seeks only to exploit and control her.

← Stanza 75📚 OverviewStanza 77 →

← Stanza 76📚 OverviewStanza 78 →

Stanza 77 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Breakdown of each line:

'Then, for thy husband and thy children's sake,' - This line sets up the persuasive appeal. Tarquin is imploring Lucrece to consider the well-being of her family: her husband, Collatinus, and her potential children. He's attempting to make her feel responsible for protecting their reputation and future. This is an appeal to duty and maternal instinct.

'Tender my suit: bequeath not to their lot' - Here, "Tender my suit" is a euphemism for "Grant my desire," which is to sleep with her. "Bequeath not to their lot" means "do not leave as an inheritance to them" or "do not cause them to suffer." This is a crucial part of his manipulation.

'The shame that from them no device can take,' - This line speaks about the lasting nature of the shame he threatens to bring upon them. "Device" here refers to any strategy, plan, or remedy. He argues that this shame is inescapable and permanent. This plays on Lucrece's fear of dishonor and social stigma.

'The blemish that will never be forgot;' - Reinforces the idea that the shame will be indelible. The word "blemish" suggests something impure, disfiguring, and unforgettable. It emphasizes the long-lasting consequences of her perceived transgression. Note the repetition of the concept of lasting shame from the previous line.

'Worse than a slavish wipe or birth-hour's blot:' - Provides an analogy to clarify the severity of the threatened shame. "Slavish wipe" could refer to a mark of servitude or a brand that identifies someone as a slave, while a "birth-hour's blot" is a birthmark. Tarquin is implying that the shame he threatens to bring is worse than these pre-existing, visible flaws that are beyond a person's control. This is an example of simile (using "worse than"). It's also worth noting the alliteration on "birth-hour's blot."

'For marks descried in men's nativity' - Introduces the rationale behind the analogy. "Marks descried in men's nativity" means birthmarks or inherent traits observable at birth.

'Are nature's faults, not their own infamy.' - This line concludes the comparison. Birthmarks are "nature's faults," not the individual's fault, therefore they don't bring infamy or dishonor. He's contrasting these innate marks (birthmarks, etc.) with the shame of adultery, which he is framing as a conscious choice Lucrece can prevent. The contrast serves to emphasize how much worse the shame he's threatening is, as it would be perceived as her own doing.

Literary Devices:

Euphemism: "Tender my suit"
Appeal to Ethos/Pathos: He tries to manipulate Lucrece by invoking her family's honor (ethos) and inciting fear and empathy (pathos).
Repetition: Of the concept of enduring shame.
Simile: "Worse than a slavish wipe or birth-hour's blot."
Alliteration: "Birth-hour's blot"
Contrast: Between birthmarks (nature's faults) and the shame he's threatening (perceived as Lucrece's choice).

'Then, for thy husband and thy children's sake,
Tender my suit: bequeath not to their lot
The shame that from them no device can take,
The blemish that will never be forgot;
Worse than a slavish wipe or birth-hour's blot: For marks descried in men's nativity
Are nature's faults, not their own infamy.'

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Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Tarquin uses carefully crafted arguments to pressure Lucrece into submitting to his desires. He appeals to her sense of responsibility towards her husband and children, arguing that the shame that would result from her refusal is far worse than any innate flaw or mark of fate. He attempts to minimize his own responsibility by suggesting that Lucrece has the power to prevent this dishonor, thus placing the burden of choice – and the blame – squarely on her shoulders. The stanza hinges on a false equivalence: birthmarks are not a source of shame because they are not a person's fault, whereas adultery would be perceived as Lucrece's choice, thus making it a much greater source of "infamy." In essence, Tarquin is trying to guilt and manipulate Lucrece into believing that she is responsible for her family's honor and that succumbing to his advances is the only way to preserve it.

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← Stanza 77📚 OverviewStanza 79 →

Stanza 78 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Here with a cockatrice' dead-killing eye"

Meaning: This describes Tarquin's gaze. The cockatrice is a mythical creature, a serpent or
dragon whose glance could kill. Therefore, Tarquin's stare is depicted as lethal, full of malicious intent, and foreboding. It also suggests that he is as devoid of any kind of mercy as a cockatrice. Literary Devices:
Allusion: To the mythological creature, the cockatrice.
Metaphor: Tarquin's eye is like a cockatrice's eye in its destructive power.

"He rouseth up himself and makes a pause;"

Meaning: Tarquin gathers himself, perhaps summoning his determination or steeling his resolve to commit the act he is about to perpetrate. The pause emphasizes the moment of decision, the point where he could still turn back but chooses not to.
Literary Devices:
Enjambment: The sentence continues from the first line, creating a sense of suspense. Implied Action: This line depicts Tarquin rousing and shows his planning and preparation.

"While she, the picture of pure piety,"

Meaning: This is a stark contrast to Tarquin. Lucrece is presented as the embodiment of virtue and religious devotion. She is innocent and blameless.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Lucrece is like a picture of piety; she perfectly embodies the concept.
Imagery: The word "picture" evokes a visual representation of purity.

"Like a white hind under the gripe's sharp claws,"

Meaning: This describes Lucrece's vulnerability. A "hind" is a female deer, often associated with innocence and gentleness. A "gripe" is a griffin (a mythical creature with an eagle's head and wings and a lion's body), signifying Tarquin as a predator. The claws emphasize his predatory nature and her defencelessness.
Literary Devices:
Simile: Lucrece is like a hind under the claws of a griffin.
Symbolism: The white hind symbolizes purity and innocence, while the griffin symbolizes predatory aggression and power.
Imagery: The image of the hind trapped in the griffin's claws is vivid and disturbing.

"Pleads, in a wilderness where are no laws,"

Meaning: Lucrece tries to reason with Tarquin, but her pleas are futile. She is in a "wilderness," a place devoid of justice, morality, or any restraining influence. This emphasizes Tarquin's lawless behaviour.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The "wilderness" represents the moral vacuum where Tarquin operates.
Symbolism: Wilderness: a place of danger, isolation, lack of civilization, and lack of rules.

Here with a cockatrice' dead-killing eye
He rouseth up himself and makes a pause;
While she, the picture of pure piety,
Like a white hind under the gripe's sharp claws,
Pleads, in a wilderness where are no laws,
To the rough beast that knows no gentle right, Nor aught obeys but his foul appetite.

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"To the rough beast that knows no gentle right,"

Meaning: Tarquin is described as a "rough beast," highlighting his animalistic nature, lack of civility, and disregard for moral principles or any concept of justice. He is governed by base instincts rather than reason or compassion.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Tarquin is like a "rough beast."
Imagery: "Rough" evokes a sense of coarseness, lack of refinement, and potential for
violence.

"Nor aught obeys but his foul appetite."

Meaning: Tarquin is solely driven by his lust and desire. He is uncontrollable and ignores all other considerations.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: Emphasises the destructive nature of Tarquin's desire.
Imagery: "Foul" evokes a sense of disgust and moral corruption.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza paints a harrowing picture of the imbalance of power and the tragedy about to unfold. Lucrece, the embodiment of innocence and piety, is utterly vulnerable and helpless against Tarquin, a man consumed by lust and devoid of morality. The stark contrasts between them highlight the horror of the impending rape. The stanza establishes a setting where justice and reason are absent, leaving Lucrece completely at the mercy of Tarquin's brutal desires. Shakespeare emphasizes the animalistic and predatory nature of Tarquin, stripping him of any pretense of humanity and portraying him as a force of pure, destructive appetite. The allusions and imagery create a sense of dread and foreshadow the tragic consequences that will follow. It is a powerful condemnation of unchecked power and the devastating impact of violence on the innocent.

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← Stanza 78📚 OverviewStanza 80 →

Stanza 79 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line Breakdown:

"But when a black-faced cloud the world doth threat,"

Meaning: This line introduces a dark and ominous image. A "black-faced cloud" is a metaphor for impending danger, trouble, or evil. The phrase "doth threat" emphasizes the menacing nature of
this situation. The world is at risk.

Literary Devices:
Personification: The cloud is given a "face" and the ability to "threaten," attributing human-
like qualities to it.
Metaphor: The cloud acts as a representation of a threat to the 'world'.

"In his dim mist the aspiring mountains hiding,"

Meaning: The "dim mist" refers to the dark cloud's obscurity. "Aspiring mountains" likely symbolize virtue, honor, or stability. The mist hides them, suggesting that the danger obscures or corrupts these positive qualities.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Creates a visual image of obscured and immense mountains due to mist.
Metaphor: Mountains are metaphorically representative of something of importance, likely of virtue and stability.

"From earth's dark womb some gentle gust doth get,"

Meaning: This line introduces a counterforce. A "gentle gust" (a light breeze) arises from "earth's dark womb." The "dark womb" suggests the origin of this gust is a hidden or unexpected source, perhaps even the potential for good within a flawed world.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Contrast with the prior imagery, suggesting something gentle is emerging from the 'dark womb' of the earth.

Metaphor: The "earth's dark womb" is metaphorically representative of the source of a new change.

"Which blows these pitchy vapours from their bidding,"

Meaning: The gentle gust is strong enough to push the "pitchy vapours" (the dark, heavy clouds) away from their intended purpose or direction ("their bidding"). The threat is being averted, at least temporarily.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Pitchy vapours" are a metaphor for the threat to the world introduced in the first line.

"Hindering their present fall by this dividing;"

Meaning: The gust prevents the immediate downfall that the dark clouds were threatening. It achieves this by separating and dispersing them.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: the vapours are being divided and halted from falling.

But when a black-faced cloud the world doth threat,
In his dim mist the aspiring mountains hiding,
From earth's dark womb some gentle gust doth get,
Which blows these pitchy vapours from their bidding,
Hindering their present fall by this dividing;
So his unhallow'd haste her words delays,
And moody Pluto winks while Orpheus plays.

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"So his unhallow'd haste her words delays,"

Meaning: This line applies the earlier imagery to the situation in the poem, the rape of Lucrece. "His unhallow'd haste" refers to Tarquin's lustful rush towards his goal (raping Lucrece). "Her words delays" refers to how her arguments are delaying his actions. The breeze delaying the clouds is a metaphor for her resistance delaying his attack.
Literary Devices:
Analogy: The previous lines are used as an analogy to Tarquin's actions.

"And moody Pluto winks while Orpheus plays."

Meaning: This line adds a layer of classical allusion. Pluto is the god of the underworld, often associated with darkness and evil. Orpheus, a legendary musician, was known for his ability to charm even the most formidable figures with his music. "Moody Pluto winks" suggests that even the forces of darkness are momentarily swayed or distracted by the power of art/persuasion,
albeit with a hint of disapproval.
Literary Devices:
Allusion: To Greek mythology (Pluto and Orpheus).
Juxtaposition: Pluto represents darkness and Orpheus represents light and beauty.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza uses an extended metaphor to describe the conflict between Tarquin's lust and Lucrece's resistance. The opening lines establish the threat of darkness and danger. A glimmer of hope then emerges through the "gentle gust," which represents Lucrece's attempts to reason with Tarquin and delay his attack. This effort is enough to temporarily hinder his progress. The final line emphasizes that even the forces of evil (Pluto) are momentarily affected by the power of beauty and persuasion (Orpheus), though ultimately darkness will prevail.

Key Themes and Ideas:

The Power of Resistance: Lucrece's words, like the gust of wind, offer a temporary reprieve from the impending doom.
The Conflict Between Light and Darkness: The stanza presents a struggle between good and evil, represented by the contrasting images of light and darkness, and by the allusions to Pluto and Orpheus.
The Nature of Persuasion: Orpheus's music suggests that even evil can be swayed, though perhaps not completely overcome, by the power of art and reason.
The Inevitability of Tragedy: While there's a moment of delay, the ominous opening and the mention of Pluto hint that the tragedy is ultimately inevitable.

In essence, this stanza offers a moment of hope and resistance within a narrative headed towards tragedy. It is a beautiful piece of writing filled with literary devices that convey meaning.

← Stanza 78📚 OverviewStanza 80 →

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← Stanza 79📚 OverviewStanza 81 →

Stanza 80 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: Yet, foul night-waking cat, he doth but dally,

"Yet, foul night-waking cat": This is a simile comparing Tarquin to a cat. "Foul" establishes
him as morally repugnant, "night-waking" emphasizes his nocturnal, predatory nature. Cats are naturally associated with hunting small prey in the night, further driving the violent and stealthy nature of Tarquin's actions. "Dally" means to play or trifle with something, here suggesting
Tarquin is toying with Lucrece before the "kill."
"he doth but dally": This means he's only playing around; he's not yet committing the full act of rape. He's enjoying the chase and Lucrece's fear.

Line 2: While in his hold-fast foot the weak mouse panteth:

"While in his hold-fast foot": A continuation of the animalistic metaphor. The "foot" of the cat is holding the mouse captive. "Hold-fast" implies a powerful, inescapable grip. It highlights Tarquin's control over Lucrece's fate.
"the weak mouse panteth": Lucrece is compared to a "weak mouse." This reinforces her vulnerability and powerlessness against Tarquin's strength. "Panteth" conveys her fear, anxiety, and struggle for breath, as she realizes what is happening.

Line 3: Her sad behavior feeds his vulture folly,

"Her sad behavior": Refers to Lucrece's distress, her pleading, and her evident fear.
"feeds his vulture folly": This is a powerful metaphor. Tarquin's "folly" (his foolish, wicked lust) is compared to a vulture that is being fed by Lucrece's sadness. Vultures are scavengers, feeding on the dead or dying. The more distressed Lucrece becomes, the more his lust grows stronger. It is also associated with the idea of death and decay, foreshadowing the destruction to come.

Line 4: A swallowing gulf that even in plenty wanteth:

"A swallowing gulf": Metaphor for Tarquin's lust. It's an insatiable abyss that consumes everything. "Swallowing" suggests the destructive and all-consuming nature of his desire.
"that even in plenty wanteth": Even when surrounded by abundance, it always lacks. This highlights the idea that lust is never satisfied. Even if Tarquin obtains Lucrece, his desire will not be fulfilled, and will search for another victim.

Line 5: His ear her prayers admits, but his heart granteth

"His ear her prayers admits": Suggests that Tarquin hears Lucrece's pleas for mercy, but only acknowledges them.
"but his heart granteth": He doesn't allow her prayers into his heart. He's acknowledging her words, but not changing his behavior.

Line 6: No penetrable entrance to her plaining:

"No penetrable entrance to her plaining": Tarquin's heart is impenetrable to her lamentation. "Plaining" is her complaint. It implies his heart is impenetrable and indifferent. There is no way
for her sadness to reach and affect him.

Yet, foul night-waking cat, he doth but dally,
While in his hold-fast foot the weak mouse panteth:
Her sad behavior feeds his vulture folly,
A swallowing gulf that even in plenty wanteth:
His ear her prayers admits, but his heart granteth No penetrable entrance to her plaining:
Tears harden lust, though marble wear with raining.

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Line 7: Tears harden lust, though marble wear with raining.

"Tears harden lust": This is the paradox. Lucrece's tears, which should inspire pity, only
intensify Tarquin's lust.
"though marble wear with raining": This is a simile. The tears would eventually wear down
even the toughest materials (marble). This emphasizes the power of tears in general. It contrasts sharply with the previous clause, making it clear that Tarquin's lust is so strong it is immune to
the softening effects of tears.

Overall Meaning:

Stanza 80 vividly portrays Tarquin's relentless pursuit of Lucrece and her utter powerlessness. It emphasizes his predatory nature and insatiable lust, which are fueled by her fear and distress. He acknowledges her pleas but remains unmoved, his heart hardened against any sense of compassion. The stanza underscores the tragic irony that her very suffering only intensifies his desire, highlighting the destructive and dehumanizing nature of uncontrolled lust. The final line provides a bleak commentary on the strength of lust, surpassing the effects of tears on a hardened stone.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: Tarquin's lust as a "swallowing gulf."
Simile: Tarquin as a "foul night-waking cat," Lucrece's tears wearing down marble.
Paradox: "Tears harden lust," highlighting the counterintuitive effect of her suffering.
Imagery: The animalistic imagery of the cat and mouse, the vulture feeding, and the swallowing gulf create a strong, visceral sense of the predatory nature of the situation.
Alliteration: "Hold-fast foot" and "Vulture folly."
Personification: "His ear her prayers admits, but his heart granteth." (Giving human qualities to abstract ideas.)
← Stanza 79📚 OverviewStanza 81 →

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← Stanza 80📚 OverviewStanza 82 →

Stanza 81 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Her pity-pleading eyes are sadly fix'd"

Meaning: Lucrece's eyes, filled with an expression begging for pity, are focused sadly and
intently on Tarquin.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "Pity-pleading eyes" gives the eyes a human action.
Alliteration: "Pity-pleading"

"In the remorseless wrinkles of his face;"

Meaning: She gazes at the wrinkles in Tarquin's face, which she interprets as signs of his hard, unfeeling, and unforgiving nature. The wrinkles represent his age and experience, but Shakespeare uses them to symbolize his lack of empathy.
Literary Devices:
Symbolism: Wrinkles symbolize a lack of remorse/empathy, instead of experience/wisdom. Contrast: Contrast between her pity and his remorselessness.

"Her modest eloquence with sighs is mix'd,"

Meaning: Lucrece's attempt at speaking eloquently is punctuated by sighs, showing her distress and emotional state. Her speech is not just words; it is also filled with physical manifestations of her suffering.
Literary Devices:
Juxtaposition: Placing eloquence (skillful speech) next to sighs (expressions of sadness)
creates a contrast and emphasizes her internal conflict.

"Which to her oratory adds more grace."

Meaning: The sighs, rather than detracting from her speech, paradoxically make it more moving and compelling. Her suffering enhances the power of her pleas.
Literary Devices:
Paradox: The statement seems contradictory at first glance. How can sighs, usually a sign of weakness, add grace? But in this context, they amplify the emotional impact.

"She puts the period often from his place;"

Meaning: "Period" here likely means 'end' or 'conclusion'. She interrupts his planned statements or logical flow of argument. She derails him, preventing him from reaching his intended conclusion (which is implied to be his seduction or rape).
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The "period" stands in for the conclusion of his argument/plan.
Euphemism: 'His place' can be interpreted as him completing his act.

"And midst the sentence so her accent breaks,"

Meaning: In the middle of a sentence, her voice cracks or fails due to emotion. "Accent" here refers to her tone and vocal delivery.

Her pity-pleading eyes are sadly fix'd
In the remorseless wrinkles of his face;
Her modest eloquence with sighs is mix'd,
Which to her oratory adds more grace.
She puts the period often from his place;
And midst the sentence so her accent breaks, That twice she doth begin ere once she speaks.

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Literary Devices:
Imagery: The phrase evokes a clear image of her breaking voice.

"That twice she doth begin ere once she speaks."

Meaning: She starts to speak twice before she can complete even one full utterance. This
highlights her overwhelming distress and difficulty in forming coherent sentences.
Literary Devices:
Repetition: The emphasis on "twice" underscores her difficulty.
Hyperbole: Potentially, but more likely emphasizes the emotional turmoil.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza vividly depicts Lucrece's desperate attempt to dissuade Tarquin from his wicked intentions through her words. It is a portrait of her struggle to maintain composure and use language effectively while battling overwhelming fear and grief. The stanza emphasizes the powerlessness and vulnerability of Lucrece. Her pleas are not just words, but a mix of eloquent arguments, desperate sighs, and broken utterances. She is trying to use language as a weapon, but her emotional state makes her efforts fragmented and ultimately ineffective. The contrast between her eloquence and her broken voice, her pity and his remorselessness, highlights the tragic nature of her situation. The stanza foreshadows her eventual powerlessness and rape, showing the futility of her resistance in the face of Tarquin's unwavering resolve.

← Stanza 80📚 OverviewStanza 82 →

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← Stanza 81📚 OverviewStanza 83 →

Stanza 82 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"She conjures him by high almighty Jove,"

conjures: Implores, begs, appeals to, invokes.
high almighty Jove: Zeus, the king of the gods in Roman mythology, representing supreme power and authority. Jove is used here instead of Jupiter, emphasizing a lofty and powerful image.
Literary Device: Allusion (to Roman mythology), invoking a sense of divine power and moral
order.
Meaning: Lucrece begins her desperate plea by invoking the most powerful god, hoping to
appeal to Tarquin's sense of piety or fear of divine retribution.

"By knighthood, gentry, and sweet friendship's oath,"

knighthood: The code of chivalry, representing honor, loyalty, and protecting the weak.
gentry: His noble birth and status, carrying obligations and expectations of honorable behavior. sweet friendship's oath: The bond of trust and loyalty between friends, which Tarquin is betraying as a guest in Lucrece's house.
Literary Device: Anaphora (implied - "By...") - building intensity with a list of ideals.
Meaning: Lucrece appeals to Tarquin's identity and social standing, reminding him of the values he should uphold. She appeals to their assumed friendship and the promises inherent in that bond.

"By her untimely tears, her husband's love,"

untimely tears: Her premature grief and distress, caused by Tarquin's presence and intentions. her husband's love: The affection and trust that Collatine has for her, which Tarquin is violating. Literary Device: Pathos (emotional appeal). The tears and love are designed to evoke sympathy and compassion.
Meaning: She appeals to his pity, emphasizing her own suffering and the damage he is inflicting on her marriage and her husband's happiness.

"By holy human law, and common troth,"

holy human law: The moral and legal codes that govern society, including marriage vows and the prohibition of adultery.
common troth: Basic human decency, fidelity, and trust. Troth means faith or pledged fidelity. Literary Device: Parallelism (holy human law/common troth), emphasizing the interconnectedness of divine and human expectations.
Meaning: She invokes the established social order and the fundamental principles of honesty
and faithfulness that bind people together.

"By heaven and earth, and all the power of both,"

heaven and earth: The entirety of creation, representing everything that exists.
all the power of both: A re-emphasis of Jove earlier in the stanza, alluding to the ultimate authority in the universe and the repercussions of evil actions.

She conjures him by high almighty Jove,
By knighthood, gentry, and sweet friendship's oath,
By her untimely tears, her husband's love,
By holy human law, and common troth,
By heaven and earth, and all the power of both,
That to his borrow'd bed he make retire,
And stoop to honour, not to foul desire.

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Literary Device: Hyperbole (exaggeration for effect), underlining the vastness and seriousness of the situation.
Meaning: She broadens her appeal to encompass all of existence, suggesting that Tarquin's actions are not only a violation of earthly rules but also a transgression against the very fabric of the universe.

"That to his borrow'd bed he make retire,"

borrow'd bed: Lucrece's bed. It's "borrowed" because Tarquin is a guest in her house.
retire: Withdraw, go away, depart.
Literary Device: Metonymy (using "borrow'd bed" to represent the entire act of sexual violation).
Meaning: She pleads with him to leave her bed and her chamber, acknowledging the specific act he intends to commit.

"And stoop to honour, not to foul desire."

stoop to honour: Lower himself to the level of acting honorably, implying it's below his current intention. (The verb "stoop" often has a negative connotation, suggesting condescension, but here, it's used ironically to highlight the contrast between his present actions and true honor).
foul desire: His lustful and corrupt inclinations.
Literary Device: Juxtaposition (placing "honour" and "foul desire" in direct contrast),
emphasizing the moral choice Tarquin faces.
Meaning: She urges him to choose honor over his base instincts, to control his passions and act
in a virtuous manner.

Overall Meaning of Stanza 82:

This stanza is a powerful and desperate plea from Lucrece to Tarquin, using a comprehensive range of appeals to try to dissuade him from raping her. She invokes divine authority, social conventions, moral obligations, personal relationships, and the fundamental principles of right and wrong. She hopes to trigger a sense of conscience and shame in Tarquin, urging him to reject his lustful desires and choose the path of honor instead. The sheer scope of her appeals highlights the magnitude of the crime Tarquin is about to commit and the moral crisis at the heart of the poem. It is a desperate attempt to stop the inevitable by appealing to every possible virtue or sense of obligation Tarquin might possess. It tragically underscores the futility of her efforts.

← Stanza 81📚 OverviewStanza 83 →

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← Stanza 82📚 OverviewStanza 84 →

Stanza 83 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Quoth she, 'Reward not hospitality": "Quoth she" is an archaic way of saying "she said." This line directly addresses Tarquin. She implores him not to repay the kindness he has been shown ("hospitality") with evil.

"With such black payment as thou hast pretended;": This line describes the betrayal. "Black payment" is a metaphor for a terrible deed, specifically rape. "Pretended" here means intended or planned, not necessarily faked. Tarquin is about to "pay" the hospitality he's received with the "black payment" he had planned - the rape of Lucrece.

"Mud not the fountain that gave drink to thee;": This is a powerful metaphor. The "fountain" represents Lucrece herself, but also, more broadly, her house, family, and reputation. She is the source of comfort and hospitality for Tarquin. "Mud not the fountain" means don't defile or corrupt the source of your sustenance and kindness. This also carries a subtle allusion to chastity, purity, and the corruption thereof.

"Mar not the thing that cannot be amended;": This is a crucial line emphasizing the irreversible nature of rape and loss of honor. "Mar not" means "do not ruin or damage." "The thing that cannot be amended" refers specifically to her chastity and honor. Once lost, they cannot be restored. This line speaks to the social value placed on a woman's virtue.

"End thy ill aim before thy shoot be ended;": This line uses the metaphor of archery to illustrate Tarquin's predatory intent. "Ill aim" represents his wicked plan, while "shoot" symbolizes the act of violence itself. Lucrece begs him to stop before his malicious intention becomes a completed act of violence.

"He is no woodman that doth bend his bow": A "woodman" is a hunter. Lucrece is saying that the act of hunting a "doe" is dishonorable. This is another metaphor, continuing the archery imagery.

"To strike a poor unseasonable doe.": The "doe" (female deer) represents Lucrece herself: vulnerable, innocent, and unprotected. "Unseasonable" suggests that it is not the proper time to hunt. Lucrece is an inappropriate target; she is defenseless and has offered him hospitality. It is a cowardly and dishonorable act to target her.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: The "fountain," "black payment," and archery imagery are all metaphors to illustrate abstract concepts like virtue, betrayal, and intent.
Imagery: The language evokes vivid images of defilement ("mudding the fountain") and violence ("bending the bow").
Allusion: The imagery of the "fountain" and of the hunt alludes to classical tropes of purity, chastity, and honor, and the potential for their violation.
Apostrophe: Lucrece directly addresses Tarquin, though he may not be present as she delivers this line.

Quoth she, 'Reward not hospitality
With such black payment as thou hast pretended;
Mud not the fountain that gave drink to thee;
Mar not the thing that cannot be amended;
End thy ill aim before thy shoot be ended;
He is no woodman that doth bend his bow
To strike a poor unseasonable doe.

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Repetition: The repeated use of negative commands ("Reward not," "Mud not," "Mar not," "End thy ill aim") emphasizes the urgency of her plea.
Pathetic Fallacy (subtle): The "unseasonable" doe might suggest that something is out of order in the world, reflecting the injustice being perpetrated against Lucrece.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza is Lucrece's desperate plea to Tarquin to reconsider his intended act of violence. She argues that raping her would be a profound betrayal of hospitality and would destroy something irreplaceable – her honor. She uses powerful metaphors of defiling a clean fountain and hunting an innocent doe to illustrate the gravity of his actions. She highlights the irreversible damage that rape would inflict on her, her family, and her reputation, and appeals to him to stop before it's too late. The stanza portrays Lucrece as intelligent, articulate, and deeply aware of the social and moral implications of Tarquin's threat. The underlying theme is the importance of honor, virtue, and the devastating consequences of betrayal and violence, particularly against the vulnerable.

← Stanza 82📚 OverviewStanza 84 →

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← Stanza 83📚 OverviewStanza 85 →

Stanza 84 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"My husband is thy friend; for his sake spare me:"
Meaning: Lucrece attempts to appeal to Tarquin's loyalty and sense of honor. She reminds him
that her husband, Collatinus, is Tarquin's friend. She asks that he show mercy and not violate her based on this friendship.
Emphasis: Highlights the bond of male friendship, a value often upheld in the society of the play. The assumption is that Tarquin would not betray a friend by harming his wife.

"Thyself art mighty; for thine own sake leave me:"
Meaning: Lucrece shifts her appeal to Tarquin's ego. She acknowledges his power ("mighty") and suggests that he has nothing to gain from forcing himself on her. It's beneath him, she implies. She argues that his own reputation and self-respect would be better served by leaving her alone. Emphasis: Appeals to the idea that a powerful man should not need to resort to such a base act. It plays on his pride and position.

"Myself a weakling; do not then ensnare me:"
Meaning: Lucrece emphasizes her vulnerability. She presents herself as a "weakling," incapable of resisting Tarquin's force. The verb "ensnare" suggests a deliberate trapping and exploitation of her weakness. She asks him not to abuse this power imbalance.
Emphasis: Reinforces the disparity in power between the aggressor and the victim. Calls on a sense of basic fairness.

"Thou look'st not like deceit; do not deceive me."
Meaning: Lucrece attempts to appeal to Tarquin's apparent honesty. She says he doesn't look like a deceiver, suggesting that his outward appearance is trustworthy. She begs him not to belie that appearance by betraying her trust.
Emphasis: This is a subtle and potentially ironic appeal. It highlights the discrepancy between appearance and reality, a recurring theme in the poem. She's hoping he is who he appears to be.

"My sighs, like whirlwinds, labour hence to heave thee:"
Meaning: Lucrece describes the intensity of her emotional distress. Her sighs are not mere breaths; they are powerful "whirlwinds" of sorrow and anguish. She hopes these sighs, these outward signs of her suffering, will "heave" (push, move) him away. She wishes her pain would be so palpable it would compel him to leave.
Emphasis: Uses powerful imagery ("whirlwinds") to convey the depth of her emotional turmoil. "Labour" suggests the physical strain of her distress.

"If ever man were moved with woman moans,"
Meaning: Lucrece invokes a general principle of human compassion. She suggests that if men have ever been moved by the suffering of women, then she hopes Tarquin will be moved now. Emphasis: Appeals to a sense of universal empathy and shared humanity. It is a plea based on the common experience of men being moved by female suffering.

'My husband is thy friend; for his sake spare me:
Thyself art mighty; for thine own sake leave me:
Myself a weakling; do not then ensnare me:
Thou look'st not like deceit; do not deceive me.
My sighs, like whirlwinds, labour hence to heave thee:
If ever man were moved with woman moans,
Be moved with my tears, my sighs, my groans:

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"Be moved with my tears, my sighs, my groans:"
Meaning: This is the culmination of her plea. She lists the outward manifestations of her
distress: tears, sighs, and groans. She implores Tarquin to be moved by these physical
expressions of her suffering.
Emphasis: Creates a crescendo of pain. The repetition and the increasing intensity of the words (tears -> sighs -> groans) amplifies her desperation.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza is a desperate, multi-faceted appeal by Lucrece to Tarquin's better nature (or what she hopes is his better nature). She tries to reason with him by appealing to:

His friendship with her husband
His sense of pride and honor
His compassion for the weak
His outward appearance of honesty

When those approaches fail, she resorts to pleading, emphasizing the depth and intensity of her suffering, hoping that he will be moved by her tears, sighs, and groans. She is using every argument she can think of, in the hope that something will work. This stanza showcases her intelligence and her intense desire to avoid the impending tragedy.

Literary Devices:

Repetition: "My" is repeated at the beginning of several lines, emphasizing her personal
connection to the arguments she presents. Repetition of certain words like 'thee' also strengthens the impact.
Imagery: The "whirlwinds" of her sighs are a powerful image.
Alliteration: Subtle alliteration can be found throughout (e.g., "sake spare", "moved with moans"). Apostrophe: While subtle, the stanza as a whole is a direct address to Tarquin. She's pleading with him directly.
Irony: The line, "Thou look'st not like deceit; do not deceive me," carries a heavy dose of dramatic irony. The audience knows Tarquin is about to deceive her, despite appearances.
Climax: The final line builds to a climax of pain, moving from "tears" to "sighs" to "groans," each word representing a deeper level of suffering.
Appeal to Logos, Ethos, and Pathos: The stanza is a masterful blend of appeals to logic (logos – her husband is your friend), ethics (ethos – you are a powerful man, don't abuse your position),
and emotion (pathos – be moved by my suffering). This is a classical rhetorical technique often used in Shakespearean drama.
← Stanza 83📚 OverviewStanza 85 →

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← Stanza 84📚 OverviewStanza 86 →

Stanza 85 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"All which together, like a troubled ocean,"

Meaning: This line introduces a metaphor comparing the combined effect of Tarquin's arguments, threats, and pleas to a stormy, chaotic ocean. "All which together" refers to the cumulative pressure Tarquin is putting on Lucrece.
Literary Device: Simile ("like a troubled ocean"). This immediately establishes the image of overwhelming force and agitation. The "troubled ocean" suggests a feeling of instability and threat.

"Beat at thy rocky and wreck-threatening heart,"

Meaning: The "troubled ocean" of Tarquin's words and actions are being metaphorically slammed against Lucrece's heart. The heart is described as "rocky and wreck-threatening," meaning it is hard, resistant, and capable of causing destruction (likely referring to the potential destruction of Tarquin's reputation if she reveals his intentions).
Literary Device: Metaphor: Lucrece's heart is not literally a rock, but the description conveys
its coldness and resistance. Imagery: The imagery of "beating" against a "rocky" heart creates a vivid picture of a relentless assault. Alliteration: The repetition of the 'w' sound in "wreck-threatening" adds to the intensity.

"To soften it with their continual motion;"

Meaning: This suggests that the purpose of the relentless "beating" is to break down Lucrece's resistance, to make her heart more yielding. "Continual motion" implies a persistent and ongoing effort.

Literary Device: None particularly stand out, but the line continues to build on the extended metaphor.

"For stones dissolved to water do convert."

Meaning: This provides a justification for Tarquin's belief that Lucrece can be softened. It is a proverbial statement, suggesting that even the hardest things can eventually be worn down by constant pressure. Stones dissolving into water is a well known analogy for how time and persistence can change even the most resistant things.
Literary Device: Proverb/Analogy: This is a saying that relies on a physical example that everyone understands, and therefore it seems more likely to be true.

"O, if no harder than a stone thou art,"

Meaning: This is a direct address to Lucrece (an apostrophe). Tarquin is using this line to say that she should not be more resistant than a stone. He believes that she is, in fact, softer than a stone because she has feelings and is a woman.
Literary Device: Apostrophe: Direct address to someone (or something) who is not literally there, or cannot respond. It adds a personal, dramatic quality.

'All which together, like a troubled ocean,
Beat at thy rocky and wreck-threatening heart,
To soften it with their continual motion;
For stones dissolved to water do convert.
O, if no harder than a stone thou art,
Melt at my tears, and be compassionate!
Soft pity enters at an iron gate.

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"Melt at my tears, and be compassionate!"

Meaning: Here, Tarquin directly asks Lucrece to show him pity and let his tears influence her. He's imploring her to succumb to his desires. This is emotional manipulation. He's trying to guilt or sway her.
Literary Device: Imperative verbs: "Melt" and "be" are commands, highlighting Tarquin's forceful and demanding tone, despite the show of tears. Imagery: The imagery of "melting" reinforces the earlier metaphor of softening resistance.

"Soft pity enters at an iron gate."

Meaning: This is perhaps the most layered line. It suggests that even a heart as fortified as Lucrece's ("iron gate") can be penetrated by "soft pity." This could be interpreted in two ways: 1) Tarquin is arguing that his pity (or feigned pity) should move her. 2) He is suggesting that her pity for him should move her to yield. The "iron gate" is a metaphor for her resolve and her
virtue.
Literary Device: Metaphor: As above, "iron gate" is a metaphor for her strong resolve. Paradox/Irony: The line itself is somewhat paradoxical. "Soft pity" and "iron gate" seem contradictory, highlighting the tension between Lucrece's virtue and the possibility of being
moved by emotion.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza is a crucial part of Tarquin's persuasive (or manipulative) rhetoric. He's attempting to break down Lucrece's resistance by comparing his pressure to the constant force of the ocean against a rock. He argues that even the hardest heart can be softened by persistent appeals and that Lucrece, if she's no harder than a stone, should be moved by his tears and show him compassion. The final line, with its image of "soft pity" entering an "iron gate," is a key statement of Tarquin's belief that he can overcome her defenses, either by inspiring pity in her for him or by offering his own feigned pity. The stanza reveals his understanding of psychological warfare and his willingness to exploit Lucrece's potential for empathy. It demonstrates the power of rhetoric in shaping action and setting the stage for the tragic events to come.

← Stanza 84📚 OverviewStanza 86 →

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← Stanza 85📚 OverviewStanza 87 →

Stanza 86 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece and then discuss its overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"In Tarquin's likeness I did entertain thee:"

Meaning: "I welcomed you into my home because you seemed to be a man like Tarquin
(Lucrece's husband's friend, Sextus Tarquinius, who is currently inside her house). I believed you were trustworthy and honorable, like him."
Literary Devices: This line sets the stage with dramatic irony. Lucrece believed she was
welcoming someone like her husband's friend, but the audience knows the true, treacherous nature of Tarquin, who is about to betray her trust.

"Hast thou put on his shape to do him shame?"

Meaning: "Have you disguised yourself as Tarquin, in order to bring dishonor to him? Are you pretending to be his friend only to betray him and ruin his reputation?"
Literary Devices:
Rhetorical Question: Lucrece is expressing her outrage and disbelief; she's not necessarily seeking an answer.
Irony: The irony is that Tarquin is using his position (and his resemblance to his namesake) to betray Tarquin, but in a far more heinous way than just shaming his reputation.

"To all the host of heaven I complain me,"

Meaning: "I appeal to all the heavenly beings (angels, gods) to witness this injustice."
Literary Devices:
Invocation/Appeal: A common device in classical and Renaissance literature, calling upon
higher powers to witness or aid. This elevates the scene and emphasizes the enormity of the wrong being committed.

"Thou wrong'st his honour, wound'st his princely name."

Meaning: "You are injuring Tarquin's honor and damaging his noble reputation."
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Honor and name are treated as things that can be wounded, emphasizing their importance in the social and political context of the time.
Synecdoche: "Princely name" refers to the entirety of Tarquin's noble standing and reputation.

"Thou art not what thou seem'st; and if the same,"

Meaning: "You are not what you appear to be; and even if you are the same person I thought,..." Literary Devices:
Antithesis: The line sets up a contradiction between appearance and reality.
Paradox: Suggests two conflicting states: that Tarquin is not who he seems and, even if he is
the person she thought he was, he now seems different from who she thought he was. This highlights the jarring dissonance in Lucrece's understanding of Tarquin.

' In Tarquin's likeness I did entertain thee:
Hast thou put on his shape to do him shame?
To all the host of heaven I complain me,
Thou wrong'st his honour, wound'st his princely name.
Thou art not what thou seem'st; and if the same,
Thou seem'st not what thou art, a god, a king;
For kings like gods should govern everything.

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"Thou seem'st not what thou art, a god, a king;"

Meaning: "...You do not act like what you truly are meant to be, namely a god or a king (or, at least, a noble prince)."
Literary Devices:
Antithesis: Continuing the theme of appearance versus reality.
Hyperbole: Exaggerating Tarquin's position to emphasize the gravity of his betrayal. In
essence, she is saying that his position should make him morally superior.

"For kings like gods should govern everything."

Meaning: "Because kings (and princes) like gods should rule justly and with wisdom in all matters."
Literary Devices:
Simile: Comparing kings to gods emphasizes the expected moral authority and responsibility of rulers.
Implied Social Commentary: This line reflects the contemporary belief in the divine right of
kings. It suggests that kings have a duty to uphold justice and virtue because they are seen as representatives of God on Earth.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

In this stanza, Lucrece, realizing the horrific intentions of Tarquin, confronts him. She expresses her shock and betrayal, emphasizing the vast difference between his outward appearance and his true, wicked nature. She appeals to divine justice and accuses him of dishonoring his name and position. She appeals to the standards expected of nobility and royalty, suggesting that rulers, like gods, should embody justice, honor, and moral governance. Her outrage is fueled by the belief that Tarquin, by his actions, is violating not only her personal honor but also the sacred trust placed in those in positions of power. The stanza highlights the theme of appearance versus reality and the importance of morality and justice in leadership.

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← Stanza 86📚 OverviewStanza 88 →

Stanza 87 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down stanza 87 of 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line, and then consider the overall meaning:

Line 1: 'How will thy shame be seeded in thine age,'

Analysis: This line asks how Tarquin's shame will fester and grow as he gets older. The metaphor
of "seeded" suggests that the shame is like a plant that will grow from a seed into something significant and potentially damaging.
Literary Device: Metaphor (shame as a seed). Personification (shame is able to be seeded).

Line 2: 'When thus thy vices bud before thy spring!'

Analysis: This line highlights that Tarquin's vices are emerging ("budding") even before he is
fully in power ("spring" represents his reign as king). It implies that his evil actions are premature and foreshadow an even greater corruption to come.
Literary Device: Metaphor ("spring" representing his reign). Allusion (to spring as a time of growth).

Line 3: 'If in thy hope thou darest do such outrage,'

Analysis: This line presents a conditional statement. "In thy hope" could refer to hope of the throne, or simply hope of getting away with his actions. It is saying, "If you dare to commit such
a terrible act while still only aspiring to the throne (or hoping for personal gain),..." It focuses on the audacity of his crime given his current position.
Literary Device: Rhetorical question.

Line 4: 'What darest thou not when once thou art a king?'

Analysis: This line is the conclusion of the conditional statement started in line 3. It completes the rhetorical question with "What won't you dare to do once you are king?" It suggests that once he has absolute power, there will be no limit to his depravity. His potential for evil is limitless. Literary Device: Rhetorical question. Foreshadowing (of further abuses of power).

Line 5: 'O, be remember'd, no outrageous thing

Analysis: This is a direct address - a warning that is spoken directly to Tarquin and to the audience. "Be remembered" is Shakespeare's use of archaic language, but it is simply a plea to remember something important.
Literary Device: Apostrophe (direct address).

Line 6: 'From vassal actors can be wiped away;'

Analysis: A "vassal actor" means someone in a subordinate role who carries out another's
orders. It suggests that no terrible deed done by those who are beneath Tarquin and following his orders can be excused by the claim that they were just following orders. No horrible act by a lower-class citizen can be erased.
Literary Device: Implies a political or social hierarchy.

' How will thy shame be seeded in thine age,
When thus thy vices bud before thy spring!
If in thy hope thou darest do such outrage,
What darest thou not when once thou art a king?
O, be remember'd, no outrageous thing
From vassal actors can be wiped away;
Then kings' misdeeds cannot be hid in clay.

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Line 7: 'Then kings' misdeeds cannot be hid in clay.'

Analysis: This final line implies that the mistakes and misdeeds of the kings cannot be covered up, ignored, or hidden once they are done. Even in death "clay" cannot hide or protect them from the consequences and repercussions of their wrongdoings. Clay is a metaphor for death, covering the body after burial, but the deeds will come back to haunt them. The line also contrasts kings
and vassal actors, suggesting their behavior is held to different standards.
Literary Device: Metaphor (clay representing death and attempted concealment). Juxtaposition
(of kings and "vassal actors").

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a powerful condemnation of Tarquin's actions and a dire warning about the potential for corruption when unchecked power is involved. It emphasizes the lasting consequences of his crime, predicting that his shame will only grow with time and that his potential for evil is limitless once he becomes king. The stanza suggests that the misdeeds of kings are never truly hidden and will inevitably lead to consequences. It highlights the importance of accountability, especially for those in positions of authority, and underscores the idea that power corrupts. The stanza is both a critique of Tarquin's character and a commentary on the nature of power and responsibility. It warns of the danger of unchecked ambition and the lasting impact of even a single act of "outrage."

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← Stanza 87📚 OverviewStanza 89 →

Stanza 88 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"This deed will make thee only loved for fear;"

Meaning: The speaker (Lucrece, or the narrator on her behalf) is addressing Tarquin (the rapist). This line means that Tarquin's action (the rape) will ensure he is only loved out of fear, not
genuine affection or respect. His power will be maintained only through intimidation.
Literary Devices: Possible foreshadowing of his demise to follow.

"But happy monarchs still are fear'd for love:"

Meaning: In contrast to Tarquin, truly successful and "happy" rulers are feared because they are loved. Their power stems from the respect and devotion of their subjects, not simply from the threat of violence. This is the ideal, a virtuous cycle of affection and authority.
Literary Devices: Juxtaposition/Contrast: Emphasizes the difference between Tarquin's corrupt rule and the ideal of good kingship. Implied value judgment in the word "happy," suggesting true happiness for a ruler comes from legitimate power.

"With foul offenders thou perforce must bear,"

Meaning: Because Tarquin is a "foul offender" himself (having committed such a heinous act), he will be forced to tolerate similar offenses in others. He will be unable to justly punish wrongdoing because he lacks moral authority. He will become a victim of his own standard.
Literary Devices: Foreshadowing, irony.

"When they in thee the like offences prove:"

Meaning: This line expands on the previous one, stating that others will commit similar offenses against him (or his rule), reflecting his own actions. "Prove" here means demonstrate or experience. They will mirror his corruption.
Literary Devices: Irony, connection to the principle of karma or reaping what you sow.

"If but for fear of this, thy will remove;"

Meaning: Lucrece, or the narrator, urges Tarquin to stop pursuing his desires ("thy will remove") even if only out of fear of the consequences outlined in the previous lines. She appeals to his self-preservation, suggesting that even if he lacks a moral compass, he should at least be concerned about the practical outcome of his actions.
Literary Devices: Alliteration ("will remove"), persuasive rhetoric.

"For princes are the glass, the school, the book,"

Meaning: This is a powerful metaphor explaining the role of rulers in society. Princes (or leaders) act as mirrors reflecting behavior, schools from which subjects learn, and books from which they read morals and principles. Their actions set the example for the entire kingdom.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (extended). Tricolon (three related things listed in parallel).

'This deed will make thee only loved for fear;
But happy monarchs still are fear'd for love:
With foul offenders thou perforce must bear,
When they in thee the like offences prove:
If but for fear of this, thy will remove;
For princes are the glass, the school, the book, Where subjects' eyes do learn, do read, do look.

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"Where subjects' eyes do learn, do read, do look."

Meaning: This reinforces the previous line. The subjects of a ruler closely observe their leader and base their own actions and values upon what they see. This emphasizes the responsibility a ruler has to act justly and morally.
Literary Devices: Repetition ("do"), implied personification of subjects' eyes learning and
reading. Tricolon. Reinforces and amplifies the metaphor of the prince/ruler being a source of education and example.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza argues that Tarquin's act of rape has damaged his ability to rule effectively and justly. By succumbing to his lust, he has forfeited the right to command respect and obedience based on anything other than fear. He will be unable to punish similar offenses in others because he himself is guilty. The stanza also articulates the idea that leaders are role models. Their actions are scrutinized by their subjects, who will emulate their behavior. If Tarquin continues on this path, he will corrupt the entire kingdom. The stanza urges him to reconsider his course, not out of morality, but out of self-preservation and a recognition of the social consequences of his actions. It serves as a warning and a profound statement about the responsibilities of leadership. The stanza highlights the interconnectedness of private actions and public consequences, emphasizing the moral duty of those in power.

← Stanza 87📚 OverviewStanza 89 →

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← Stanza 88📚 OverviewStanza 90 →

Stanza 89 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"And wilt thou be the school where Lust shall learn?"

Meaning: Are you going to become the place where lust can learn and be educated?
Analysis: This is a rhetorical question directed at Lucrece herself. It uses metaphor - Lucrece is being compared to a school, a place of instruction. The verb "wilt" suggests a questioning of Lucrece's will or choice, although she is a victim of forced sexual assault.

"Must he in thee read lectures of such shame?"

Meaning: Will lust be able to find lessons and examples of such deep shame within you? Analysis: Again, a rhetorical question. "He" refers to lust, personified as a student. The idea is that Lucrece's rape will provide justification or excuses for lust to commit further violations. Another metaphor with "lectures" connecting to the idea of school from the previous line.

"Wilt thou be glass wherein it shall discern"

Meaning: Will you become a mirror in which lust sees?
Analysis: "It" continues to refer to "Lust." Another rhetorical question. Here, Lucrece is cast as a mirror reflecting back an image of "authority for sin," suggesting that her situation might be twisted to give permission for further transgressions. The mirror metaphor implies a distorted reflection or perspective.

"Authority for sin, warrant for blame,"

Meaning: Will you provide permission for sinful acts and justification for others to be blamed? Analysis: This line clarifies what Lust might "discern" or see in Lucrece. The "authority" and "warrant" suggests that the act can be repeated, as Lucrece's experience legitimizes "blame" for another.

"To privilege dishonour in thy name?"

Meaning: Will you make dishonor esteemed or given special status through your own name/reputation?
Analysis: Another rhetorical question that builds on the previous lines. It's suggesting that Lucrece's good name will be tarnished and that dishonor will gain power through association with her.

"Thou black'st reproach against long-living laud,"

Meaning: You are staining (blackening) the memory of virtuous things that were once highly respected.
Analysis: "Long-living laud" refers to things that are traditionally praised. "Black'st" is a verb made from the adjective. The line suggests that this one act will damage all past acts of integrity, so to speak. This is an example of imagery of light and darkness.

'And wilt thou be the school where Lust shall learn?
Must he in thee read lectures of such shame?
Wilt thou be glass wherein it shall discern
Authority for sin, warrant for blame,
To privilege dishonour in thy name?
Thou black'st reproach against long-living laud,
And makest fair reputation but a bawd.

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"And makest fair reputation but a bawd."

Meaning: And you turn a good reputation into something that encourages depravity.
Analysis: This is a powerful and damning statement. A "bawd" is someone who manages or profits from prostitution. The line suggests that Lucrece's once-pristine reputation will now be used to facilitate or excuse further immoral behavior. It ends the stanza on a devastating note, highlighting the corrupting influence of the rape. Metaphor: reputation compared to a bawd.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a blistering condemnation of the potential consequences of the rape of Lucrece. It argues that her suffering could inadvertently embolden lust and sin, providing it with a justification and even a sense of authority. The stanza suggests that her violated purity will be twisted to excuse further acts of dishonor, ultimately corrupting not only her reputation but also the very concept of virtue itself. The speaker is essentially saying that Lucrece's tragedy could become a license for future transgressions, turning her into an unwilling "school" for lust and transforming her good name into a facilitator of vice. The speaker is making an impassioned plea (albeit indirectly) to Lucrece to consider the potential ramifications of her situation and to act in a way that preserves virtue, even in the face of unspeakable trauma.

Literary Devices:

Rhetorical Questions: The repeated use of "wilt thou" and "must he" emphasizes the gravity of the situation and forces the audience to confront the potential consequences of Lucrece's rape. Metaphor: Lucrece is compared to a "school," a "glass," and ultimately, her reputation is likened to a "bawd." These metaphors highlight the way her virtue could be corrupted and exploited. Personification: Lust is personified as "he," further emphasizing its active and destructive nature. Imagery: The phrase "black'st reproach" creates a strong visual image of defilement and corruption.
Alliteration: While not abundant, there is some subtle alliteration, such as "long-living laud," which enhances the musicality of the language.
Juxtaposition: The stark contrast between "fair reputation" and "bawd" underscores the devastating transformation that Lucrece's rape threatens to bring about.

The stanza is a masterclass in persuasive rhetoric, using a combination of vivid imagery, powerful metaphors, and carefully crafted questions to convey the profound ethical and social implications of Lucrece's tragedy.

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← Stanza 89📚 OverviewStanza 91 →

Stanza 90 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 90 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then analyze the overall meaning and literary devices.
Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Hast thou command? by him that gave it thee,"
Meaning: Do you hold a position of authority (command)? Remember the one who granted you that power. This line immediately establishes the speaker (Lucrece, likely) as confronting Tarquin about his abuse of power.
Literary Devices: Rhetorical question, emphasis on the source of power.
"From a pure heart command thy rebel will:"
Meaning: Use the good intentions you should have as the basis of your authority, to take control of your disobedient desires (rebel will). Your desires are in rebellion against good reason. Literary Devices: Juxtaposition (pure heart vs. rebel will), personification (will is "rebel"). "Draw not thy sword to guard iniquity,"
Meaning: Do not use your power (represented by the sword) to protect or enable wickedness. Your sword should not be used to defend evil actions.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (sword represents power and authority), personification (Iniquity needs guarding)
"For it was lent thee all that brood to kill."

Meaning: Because that power was given to you to destroy and eradicate evil, not to protect it. Your authority should be used to suppress wickedness. The use of "brood" suggests a multitude of sins, implying that unchecked evil will reproduce.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (brood=evil), alliteration with 'brood' and 'kill'
"Thy princely office how canst thou fulfil,"
Meaning: How can you possibly perform the duties and responsibilities of your royal position. Literary Devices: Rhetorical question.
"When, pattern'd by thy fault, foul sin may say,"
Meaning: When, because of your sin, evil can use you as an example and claim that it was inspired by you. Other people could be motivated to be evil because of what Tarquin has done. Literary Devices: Personification (sin can speak), imagery of "pattern" or model.
"He learn'd to sin, and thou didst teach the way?"
Meaning: Will it be said that others learned to sin from you, that you demonstrated the path of sin?
Literary Devices: Rhetorical question, direct address, cause-and-effect logic.
Overall Meaning:

' Hast thou command? by him that gave it thee,
From a pure heart command thy rebel will:
Draw not thy sword to guard iniquity,
For it was lent thee all that brood to kill.
Thy princely office how canst thou fulfil,
When, pattern'd by thy fault, foul sin may say, He learn'd to sin, and thou didst teach the way?

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This stanza is a powerful condemnation of Tarquin's abuse of power. Lucrece argues that he is betraying the very foundation of his authority by using it to perpetrate evil rather than suppress it. She highlights the corrupting influence of his actions, emphasizing that he is not just committing a personal sin but setting a dangerous example that could lead others astray. The core argument is: Power comes with responsibility, and to use power for evil is a profound violation of that trust. It also opens the door for more sin to spread.

Key Literary Devices Across the Stanza:

Rhetorical Questions: Dominate the stanza, challenging Tarquin and forcing him to confront the implications of his actions.
Metaphor: The "sword" as a symbol of authority, "brood" of evil.
Personification: Giving human qualities to abstract concepts like "will" and "sin."
Juxtaposition: Contrasting "pure heart" with "rebel will" to highlight the internal conflict.
Imagery: Vivid descriptions that appeal to the senses, contributing to the emotional intensity. Alliteration: Repetition of the 'b' sound and 'k' sound in line 4.

The stanza is a complex and carefully constructed argument, using rhetorical skill and powerful imagery to expose Tarquin's moral failing and the far-reaching consequences of his actions. It sets the stage for Lucrece's tragic response.
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← Stanza 90📚 OverviewStanza 92 →

Stanza 91 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, focusing on meaning and literary devices:
Line-by-Line Breakdown:
'Think but how vile a spectacle it were,'
Meaning: Imagine how disgusting it would be to witness your current wrongdoing in someone else.
Literary Devices: Direct address (speaking to Tarquin), sets the scene for moral reasoning.
'To view thy present trespass in another.'
Meaning: To see someone else committing the sin you are about to commit.
Literary Devices: Trespass is a formal, weighty word emphasizing the severity of the act. 'Men's faults do seldom to themselves appear;'
Meaning: People rarely recognize their own flaws.
Literary Devices: Generalization, setting up the human tendency to be blind to one's own shortcomings.
'Their own transgressions partially they smother:'
Meaning: They tend to suppress or downplay their own wrongdoings.
Literary Devices: Smother is a powerful verb suggesting the act of concealing and suffocating the truth. Alliteration (partially they).
'This guilt would seem death-worthy in thy brother.'
Meaning: The guilt of this act would seem worthy of death if your brother were to commit it. Literary Devices: Hypothetical scenario, emphasizing the hypocrisy of judging others more harshly than oneself.
'O, how are they wrapp'd in with infamies
Meaning: Oh, how people become entangled with disgrace and shame!
Literary Devices: Wrapp'd in is a metaphor for being consumed by disgrace, Interjection "O" indicates emotional intensity.
'That from their own misdeeds askance their eyes!'
Meaning: People tend to avert their eyes or look away from their own sins.
Literary Devices: Personification (misdeeds askance their eyes), Askance is a visual image of shame and avoidance, creating a strong sense of moral evasion.
Overall Meaning of the Stanza:
This stanza is a complex and insightful exploration of hypocrisy and self-deception. The speaker (presumably Lucrece, or perhaps the narrative voice) is trying to appeal to Tarquin's conscience by making him confront the ugliness of his intended act. The stanza argues that people are often blind to

'Think but how vile a spectacle it were,
To view thy present trespass in another.
Men's faults do seldom to themselves appear;
Their own transgressions partially they smother:
This guilt would seem death-worthy in thy brother.
O, how are they wrapp'd in with infamies
That from their own misdeeds askance their eyes!

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their own faults, minimizing or ignoring their transgressions while readily condemning the same actions in others. The vivid imagery of "smothering" transgressions and looking "askance" at misdeeds conveys the sense of shame and guilt that people try to avoid. Ultimately, the stanza condemns the self-serving blindness that allows people to commit atrocities while justifying them to themselves.

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← Stanza 91📚 OverviewStanza 93 →

Stanza 92 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 92 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, then look at the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"To thee, to thee, my heaved-up hands appeal,"

"To thee, to thee": This is an apostrophe, a direct address to someone or something that is
not physically present or, in this case, a specific aspect of the present person (Tarquin). It's a
plea, emphasizing her desperation. The repetition of "thee" heightens the emotional intensity.
"my heaved-up hands appeal": A classic gesture of supplication and prayer. "Heaved-up
hands" conveys the physical act of begging, reaching out for help. "Appeal" emphasizes she's not demanding but pleading.

"Not to seducing lust, thy rash relier:"

"Not to seducing lust": A direct contrast to whom/what she doesn't appeal to. She's differentiating between Tarquin's true self and his overwhelming lust. "Seducing" highlights the deceptive and manipulative nature of lust.
"thy rash relier": "Thy" refers back to Tarquin. "Rash relier" means something he relies on impulsively and recklessly. This line identifies lust as the reckless force guiding Tarquin's actions. This also personifies "lust".

"I sue for exiled majesty's repeal;"

"I sue": Again, a plea, but now more formal and legalistic. "Sue" suggests a formal request or petition.
"for exiled majesty's repeal": "Exiled majesty" refers to Tarquin's inherent nobility, his potential for greatness, which has been banished by his lust. "Repeal" suggests the lifting of a banishment, a restoration of his true self. Lucrece is asking that Tarquin's former nobility be restored.

"Let him return, and flattering thoughts retire:"

"Let him return": A direct request for Tarquin's true, noble self to come back.
"and flattering thoughts retire": "Flattering thoughts" are the seductive, deceptive ideas and rationalizations that fueled his lust. "Retire" suggests they should withdraw and disappear.

"His true respect will prison false desire,"

"His true respect": Referring to Tarquin's innate sense of honor, his potential for moral
behavior.

"will prison false desire": A metaphor. "Prison" suggests containment, control, and restraint. The idea is that Tarquin's inherent respect and nobility can overpower and subdue his lust ("false desire").

'To thee, to thee, my heaved-up hands appeal,
Not to seducing lust, thy rash relier:
I sue for exiled majesty's repeal;
Let him return, and flattering thoughts retire:
His true respect will prison false desire,
And wipe the dim mist from thy doting eyne, That thou shalt see thy state and pity mine.'

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"And wipe the dim mist from thy doting eyne,"

"wipe the dim mist from thy doting eyne": A metaphorical cleansing of perception. "Dim mist" represents the clouded judgment caused by lust. "Doting eyne" (archaic for eyes) suggests that lust has made Tarquin foolish and infatuated. Lucrece wishes he could see clearly again.

"That thou shalt see thy state and pity mine."

"That thou shalt see thy state": Lucrece hopes Tarquin will recognize the gravity of his actions and the damage he has done. "State" refers to his moral condition and his position in society
(which he has jeopardized).
"and pity mine": Lucrece desires his empathy and understanding of the immense suffering he
has inflicted upon her.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece isn't speaking directly to Tarquin in his current, lust-driven state. Instead, she's appealing to the potential for good that she believes still exists within him. She begs for his better nature to reassert itself, displacing the overwhelming lust that has consumed him. She pleads for his true nobility to return, so that he can see the error of his ways, understand the consequences of his actions, and, ultimately, feel remorse for the pain he has inflicted upon her. She hopes for him to be freed from his lustful desire. She also wants him to be able to see the gravity of the situation, the state he has put her in, and for him to then pity her. The stanza is a desperate attempt to reach the man she believes is buried beneath his current destructive behavior.

Literary Devices Highlighted:

Apostrophe: Direct address to Tarquin's "thee"
Personification: Giving human qualities to abstract concepts like "lust" and "respect."
Metaphor: Comparing "false desire" to a prisoner being held captive, and the "dim mist" of lust to a clouded perception.
Repetition: "To thee, to thee" emphasizes the desperation of her plea.
Imagery: Visual images such as "heaved-up hands," "dim mist," and "doting eyne" contribute to the stanza's emotional impact.
Archaism: The use of "eyne" (eyes) gives the language a formal, elevated tone.
Alliteration: A subtle alliteration like "flattering thoughts" adds a musicality to the lines.

The stanza is a complex and powerful expression of Lucrece's internal struggle, her hope for redemption, and her profound sense of injustice. It encapsulates the tragic core of the poem: the conflict between virtue and vice, and the devastating consequences of unchecked desire.

← Stanza 91📚 OverviewStanza 93 →

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← Stanza 92📚 OverviewStanza 94 →

Stanza 93 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 93 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line, identifying literary devices and then pulling it all together for an overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

'Have done,' quoth he: 'my uncontrolled tide'

"Have done": An imperative command; telling Lucrece to stop her resistance. It sets a tone of forceful authority.
"quoth he": An archaic way of saying "said he."
"my uncontrolled tide": A metaphor. Collatine's lust is likened to a powerful, relentless ocean tide. The "uncontrolled" aspect emphasizes his inability (or unwillingness) to restrain himself. Meaning: Collatine tells Lucrece to stop resisting, declaring that his lust is like an unstoppable tide.

'Turns not, but swells the higher by this let.'

"Turns not": The tide will not turn back; he won't stop his assault.
"swells the higher by this let": Another metaphor. "Let" here means hindrance or obstacle (her resistance). He claims that her resistance isn't stopping him; instead, it's fueling his desire, making it stronger. This is a perversion of a loving encounter, it is the pursuit of forced conquest. Meaning: Her resistance isn't stopping him; it is only inflaming his desire further.

'Small lights are soon blown out, huge fires abide,'

"Small lights are soon blown out": Metaphor and alliteration ("blown out"). Small lights represent those easily subdued, the innocent, or those lacking strength to resist.
"huge fires abide": Metaphor. Huge fires represent his powerful lust, which cannot be extinguished. "Abide" suggests permanence and resilience.
Meaning: Things that are weak can be easily stopped, but powerful forces (like his lust) persist.

'And with the wind in greater fury fret:'

"And with the wind in greater fury fret": The fire (his lust) is exacerbated by the "wind" (her resistance). "Fret" means to agitate or chafe. The alliteration on the "f" sound in "fury fret" emphasizes the escalating intensity.
Meaning: Her resistance is only making him angrier and more determined.

'The petty streams that pay a daily debt'

"petty streams that pay a daily debt": Metaphor. "Petty streams" symbolize smaller, individual acts or desires that contribute to a larger, dominant force. "Paying a daily debt" suggests these streams are obligated to contribute to the whole, illustrating that these acts or desires constantly feed into the "salt sovereign".
Meaning: Small, insignificant things feed into the power of the larger entity (his lust).

' Have done,' quoth he: 'my uncontrolled tide
Turns not, but swells the higher by this let.
Small lights are soon blown out, huge fires abide,
And with the wind in greater fury fret:
The petty streams that pay a daily debt
To their salt sovereign, with their fresh falls' haste Add to his flow, but alter not his taste.'

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'To their salt sovereign, with their fresh falls' haste'

"their salt sovereign": A metaphor referring to the ocean. "Salt" suggests something corrupt or defiled, an ironic association with the "fresh falls" that feed into it. "Sovereign" emphasizes the ocean's (and, by extension, Collatine's lust's) absolute power.
"fresh falls' haste": The eagerness with which these streams contribute to the ocean.
Meaning: The streams eagerly and constantly feed into the all-powerful sea.

'Add to his flow, but alter not his taste.'

"Add to his flow": They make the ocean (and his lust) larger and more powerful.
"alter not his taste": Even though the streams are "fresh," they don't change the overall salty, and perhaps corrupted, nature of the ocean or lust.
Meaning: The streams increase the sea's power but do not change its fundamental nature.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: Dominates the stanza. Collatine's lust is consistently compared to a powerful tide and a raging fire. Smaller desires or contributions are likened to petty streams.
Alliteration: Used for emphasis and musicality, e.g., "blown out," "fury fret."
Imperative mood: "Have done" creates a sense of command and authority.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a powerful and disturbing expression of Collatine's rationalization of his behavior. He argues that his lust is an unstoppable force, like a tide or a fire that cannot be extinguished. He even goes further, claiming that Lucrece's resistance is only fueling his desire, making it stronger. The metaphor of the ocean and the streams suggests that his lust is a fundamental part of him, a powerful force that is not easily changed or controlled. He absolves himself of responsibility by portraying himself as subject to a force beyond his control, and he twists Lucrece's resistance to justify his impending assault. The overall message is one of ruthless power and a disturbing disregard for Lucrece's agency. The final line underscores the idea that Lucrece's innocence ("fresh falls") will be overwhelmed and corrupted ("salt sovereign") by Collatine's relentless and unyielding lust. It highlights the tragic inevitability of the impending rape.
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← Stanza 93📚 OverviewStanza 95 →

Stanza 94 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 94 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices, and then discuss the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Thou art,' quoth she, 'a sea, a sovereign king;"

Meaning: Lucrece is speaking to Tarquin. She directly addresses him, using strong metaphors. She declares that he is both a "sea" and a "sovereign king," both indicating immense power, vastness, and authority.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Tarquin is the sea and a king. There is no "like" or "as" (simile).
Apostrophe: Direct address to someone (Tarquin) who is present.
Juxtaposition: Putting "sea" and "sovereign king" together emphasizes both his natural and political power.

"And, lo, there falls into thy boundless flood"

Meaning: Lucrece continues the sea metaphor. "Lo" is an archaic interjection meaning "look!" She says that something is falling into his "boundless flood," meaning his vast, powerful being (still referring to Tarquin).
Literary Devices:
Continuing Metaphor: Reinforces the "sea" imagery.
Archaism: "Lo" adds a formal, elevated tone.

"Black lust, dishonour, shame, misgoverning,"

Meaning: These are the things falling into his "boundless flood." They are negative forces: lust, dishonor, shame, and poor rule or leadership.
Literary Devices:
Personification: These abstract concepts are presented as if they can physically "fall" into something.
Enumeration (List): The listing of negative qualities intensifies the sense of corruption. Alliteration: The repetition of "shame" and "misgoverning" adds emphasis.

"Who seek to stain the ocean of thy blood."

Meaning: These negative forces (lust, dishonour, shame, misgoverning) aim to corrupt his lineage or essence. The phrase "ocean of thy blood" suggests not just his lifeblood but also his entire heritage, character, and noble nature.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Compares his heritage to an ocean of blood.
Personification: Giving the abstract forces agency ("seek to stain").

'Thou art,' quoth she, 'a sea, a sovereign king;
And, lo, there falls into thy boundless flood
Black lust, dishonour, shame, misgoverning,
Who seek to stain the ocean of thy blood.
If all these pretty ills shall change thy good,
Thy sea within a puddle's womb is hearsed,
And not the puddle in thy sea dispersed.

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"If all these pretty ills shall change thy good,"

Meaning: "Pretty ills" is an ironic and paradoxical phrase. Lucrece calls the negative things "pretty", which is obviously the opposite of what they are. She proposes a hypothetical situation: If these seemingly insignificant evils (his lust) were to corrupt his inherent goodness.
Literary Devices:
Irony: "Pretty ills" is ironic because they are far from pretty. It's a sarcastic understatement. Alliteration: The repetition of 'p' in "pretty" adds emphasis.

"Thy sea within a puddle's womb is hearsed,"

Meaning: Continuing the "sea" metaphor, if Tarquin's good nature is corrupted by these "pretty ills," then his great, powerful being (the sea) will be confined and buried ("hearsed") within the insignificant container of a "puddle's womb." The "puddle's womb" represents the smallness and insignificance of the "ills" that are corrupting him.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The sea (Tarquin's goodness) and the puddle's womb (the sin of lust).
Imagery: Vivid contrast between the vast sea and the tiny puddle.
Personification: The "puddle" has a womb (place of origin/holding).
Alliteration: Repetition of 'w' in "womb" further emphasizes.

"And not the puddle in thy sea dispersed."

Meaning: This line emphasizes the total corruption. The implication is that ordinarily, a small puddle would be lost within a vast sea. But here, it's the opposite. The 'puddle' of sin will not simply disappear within him; rather, his entire being will be overtaken and confined by the
'puddle' of sin.
Literary Devices:
Inversion: Reversal of the natural order (the puddle overwhelming the sea).
Continuing Metaphor: Reinforces the sea/puddle imagery.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

Lucrece is powerfully warning Tarquin about the destructive nature of his lust. She uses the extended metaphor of the sea to represent his power, nobility, and essential goodness. She argues that if he succumbs to his "pretty ills" (his lust and dishonorable desires), these small but potent evils will not simply disappear within him; instead, they will consume and corrupt his entire being, burying his greatness within the confines of something small and insignificant. She emphasizes that his potential for greatness (his "sea") will be lost, swallowed by the "puddle" of his sinful actions. The stanza is a plea for him to resist temptation and preserve his honor, warning of the catastrophic consequences of succumbing to his lust. It is a vivid and dramatic portrayal of the struggle between good and evil within a person. She argues that his reputation, nobility and worth would be diminished significantly if he gave in to this lust.

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← Stanza 94📚 OverviewStanza 96 →

Stanza 95 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 95 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"So shall these slaves be king, and thou their slave;"

Meaning: If Lucrece submits to Tarquin and lives with the shame of the rape, then the metaphorical "slaves" (Tarquin's lust, his base instincts, his corrupted court) will become "king," meaning they will rule over the situation and dictate Lucrece's life. Lucrece herself, though noble, will become enslaved by her own shame and by the power that Tarquin's actions hold over her. Literary Devices: Paradox (the slaves becoming king and the noble becoming the slave), Metaphor ("slaves" representing base desires).

"Thou nobly base, they basely dignified;"

Meaning: Lucrece, despite being inherently noble and virtuous, will be perceived as "base" or degraded because of the rape. Conversely, Tarquin and his actions, which are inherently "base," will be "dignified" – that is, given a veneer of power or status because he remains unpunished and in control. Her nobility has become a liability.
Literary Devices: Antithesis (Nobly base versus basely dignified), Oxymoron (nobly base), Paradox.

"Thou their fair life, and they thy fouler grave:"

Meaning: This is a very powerful line. Lucrece, by her virtue and purity, has been the "fair life" for those around her (her husband, her family, Rome). However, Tarquin's actions and their consequences (her shame, the potential for civil unrest) become her "fouler grave," both literally (as it leads to her suicide) and figuratively (as it destroys her reputation and her place in
society).
Literary Devices: Metaphor ("fair life" and "fouler grave"), Imagery (contrasting "fair" with "foul").

"Thou loathed in their shame, they in thy pride:"

Meaning: Lucrece, through no fault of her own, will be "loathed" by some due to the shame that has been forced upon her. They might look down on her for being defiled. Tarquin and his cohorts, on the other hand, will revel in their "pride" (meaning arrogance and power) stemming from their actions. He has achieved his goal, though ignoble.
Literary Devices: Antithesis (loathed in their shame versus in their pride).

"The lesser thing should not the greater hide;"

Meaning: This is a general statement of principle, but also a direct challenge to the situation. The "lesser thing" is Tarquin's base act of violence, his lust, and his wickedness. The "greater" is Lucrece's inherent nobility, her virtue, and her rightful position in society. The speaker argues
that the lesser (Tarquin's crime) should not overshadow and obscure the greater (Lucrece's virtue). This line has implications for justice and the proper ordering of society. It's an argument against allowing evil to triumph over good.

' So shall these slaves be king, and thou their slave;
Thou nobly base, they basely dignified;
Thou their fair life, and they thy fouler grave:
Thou loathed in their shame, they in thy pride:
The lesser thing should not the greater hide;
The cedar stoops not to the base shrub's foot,
But low shrubs wither at the cedar's root.

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Literary Devices: Metaphor (lesser and greater as concepts), General Statement/Maxim.

"The cedar stoops not to the base shrub's foot,"

Meaning: This is a simile using natural imagery to further illustrate the point of the previous line. A cedar tree (representing Lucrece, her virtue, and her high status) does not bow down or submit to a low-growing "shrub" (Tarquin and his base desires/actions).
Literary Devices: Simile (using "not" to compare), Imagery (cedar and shrub as visual
symbols of status).
"But low shrubs wither at the cedar's root."

Meaning: The opposite should be true: the "low shrubs" (Tarquin and his ilk) should wither and
die under the strength and virtue of the "cedar" (Lucrece and her nobility). The implication is that justice should prevail and that evil should be punished, not the other way around.
Literary Devices: Imagery (withered shrubs), Metaphor.

Overall Meaning:

Stanza 95 expresses the tragic injustice of Lucrece's situation and argues for a proper, just order. It laments the potential for evil to triumph over good and for the innocent to be punished while the guilty prosper. The stanza highlights the perversion of natural order that results from Tarquin's crime. The speaker contends that Lucrece's inherent nobility and virtue should not be eclipsed by the shame forced upon her. The powerful imagery of the cedar and the shrub reinforces the idea that the "greater" (Lucrece) should not be subjected to the "lesser" (Tarquin), but that the "lesser" should rightly be crushed beneath the "greater." It's a statement of outrage against the injustice Lucrece is enduring, a plea for a return to natural and moral order, and a foreshadowing of the tragic consequences if that order is not restored.

Key Literary Devices:

Paradox: The slaves becoming king, the noble becoming base.
Antithesis: Contrasting opposing concepts (nobly base/basely dignified, loathed in shame/in
pride).
Metaphor: "Slaves," "fair life," "fouler grave," cedar tree, low shrub.
Simile: The cedar stooping not to the shrub's foot.
Imagery: Vivid visual descriptions (withered shrubs, the contrast of fair and foul).
General Statement/Maxim: The lesser thing should not the greater hide.

This stanza is a microcosm of the larger themes of the poem: the conflict between virtue and vice, the abuse of power, and the tragic consequences of injustice. Shakespeare uses a variety of rhetorical devices to create a powerful and emotionally resonant statement about the moral disorder resulting from Tarquin's actions.

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← Stanza 95📚 OverviewStanza 97 →

Stanza 96 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 96 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then consider the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line 1: 'So let thy thoughts, low vassals to thy state'

"So let thy thoughts..." : This sets the context. Tarquin is interrupting Lucrece's plea (from the previous stanza). "So let thy thoughts" can be interpreted as "stop thinking like that" or "give up those thoughts." It's dismissive.
"...low vassals to thy state...": This is a crucial metaphor.

"low vassals": Vassals are subjects, servants, those who owe allegiance to a higher power (in
this case, Lucrece). They are described as "low," implying they are inferior and should be controlled. Tarquin is implying Lucrece should control her "thoughts" (i.e. her ideas about chastity and honor) as if they were just subordinates.
"thy state": This refers to Lucrece's inner "state" or self - her honor, her self-control, her principles, her body.

Overall meaning of line 1: Tarquin wants Lucrece to stop thinking about her honor or her principles as if they hold any power over her. He wants her to control those thoughts as easily as
a ruler controls servants.

Line 2: 'No more,' quoth he; 'by heaven, I will not hear thee:'

"No more,' quoth he...": This is a straightforward declaration. Tarquin is refusing to listen to Lucrece any further. "Quoth" is an archaic word for "said".
"...by heaven, I will not hear thee": He swears "by heaven" to emphasize the force of his resolve. He emphatically refuses to listen to Lucrece's protests.

Overall meaning of line 2: This line reinforces the end of any possibility of discussion. Tarquin makes a firm statement that he will not listen to Lucrece any further.

Line 3: 'Yield to my love; if not, enforced hate,'

"Yield to my love...": This is the central demand. Tarquin is demanding that Lucrece surrender to his lust.

"...if not, enforced hate...": This is the threat. He's saying that if she doesn't "yield to my love," he will replace his pretended love with "enforced hate" (i.e. hatred that is put into practice).

Overall meaning of line 3: Tarquin states the ultimatum clearly: consent to his desires, or face the consequences of his hatred.

Line 4: 'Instead of love's coy touch, shall rudely tear thee;'

"Instead of love's coy touch...": This creates a contrast between a gentle, playful (coy) love and the violence to come. "Coy touch" represents how Tarquin tries to portray his actions.

' So let thy thoughts, low vassals to thy state'--
No more,' quoth he; 'by heaven, I will not hear thee:
Yield to my love; if not, enforced hate,
Instead of love's coy touch, shall rudely tear thee;
That done, despitefully I mean to bear thee
Unto the base bed of some rascal groom,
To be thy partner in this shameful doom.'

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"...shall rudely tear thee": This is the graphic threat of physical violence. The verb "tear" is brutal and suggests a violation far beyond a simple seduction. It signifies the potential literal tearing of her virginity.

Overall meaning of line 4: Tarquin replaces his gentle and enticing behavior with the reality of physical assault. The words show the severity of his threat.

Line 5: 'That done, despitefully I mean to bear thee'
"That done...": After the act of violence.
"...despitefully I mean to bear thee": "Despitefully" means maliciously or with contempt. "Bear thee" means to carry or take her.

Overall meaning of line 5: Tarquin is planning further acts of malice, beyond the initial rape.
This sets the stage for the ultimate humiliation to come.

Line 6: 'Unto the base bed of some rascal groom,'

"Unto the base bed...": "Base" implies low social status and morally debased. "Bed" represents the act of sexual intercourse.
"...of some rascal groom": A "rascal groom" is a low-class servant or stable boy who is also a scoundrel.

Overall meaning of line 6: Tarquin is planning to force Lucrece to sleep with a low-status servant, compounding the shame of the rape.

Line 7: 'To be thy partner in this shameful doom.'

"To be thy partner...": To be a partner in the act of humiliation.
"...in this shameful doom": "Shameful doom" refers to her fate after the rape, including the loss of her honor and reputation. "Doom" suggests this outcome is inevitable.

Overall meaning of line 7: Tarquin wants to make Lucrece's shame complete by forcing her
into a sexual relationship with a base person. This will ensure the shame never leaves her.

Overall Meaning of Stanza 96:

This stanza represents the climax of Tarquin's threats and the stark choice he offers Lucrece. He dismisses her pleas, demands that she yield to his lust, and threatens her with rape and subsequent humiliation if she refuses. The stanza reveals the depth of Tarquin's depravity and his desire not only to possess Lucrece physically but also to utterly destroy her honor and reputation. It foreshadows the tragic consequences that will follow.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: The comparison of Lucrece's thoughts to "low vassals" is a key metaphor that reveals Tarquin's desire to control her internal state.
Imagery: The stanza is filled with vivid imagery, particularly the contrast between "love's coy touch" and the act of being "rudely tear[ed]". This creates a sense of both seduction and violent threat.
Contrast: The contrast between love and hate, tenderness and violence, purity and debasement is central to the stanza's power.
Foreshadowing: The mention of "shameful doom" foreshadows the tragic consequences of the rape and Lucrece's eventual suicide.
Hyperbole: The act of forcing her to sleep with a low-status servant is an exaggerated way to describe the "doom" that is set to occur after the rape.
Alliteration: The repetition of "b" in "base bed" creates an emphasis to the shame and degradation.

The stanza is a powerful example of Shakespeare's ability to use language to convey both the seductive lure of temptation and the horrific potential for violence and degradation. It highlights the complex themes of honor, lust, power, and shame that are central to the poem.
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← Stanza 96📚 OverviewStanza 98 →

Stanza 97 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this chilling stanza from The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning, highlighting the literary devices Shakespeare uses.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"This said, he sets his foot upon the light,"

Meaning: After speaking (likely making threats or pronouncements of his intention), Tarquin physically extinguishes the light in the room. This is a deliberate and symbolic act.
Literary Devices:
Symbolism: "Light" symbolizes purity, goodness, virtue, reason, and truth. Extinguishing it represents the deliberate suppression of these qualities in favor of darkness and evil.

"For light and lust are deadly enemies:"

Meaning: This line provides the justification for his action. Lust cannot flourish in the presence of light, which exposes and judges its base nature. They are diametrically opposed forces.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Lust is personified as an entity that has "enemies."
Antithesis: Light and lust are presented as direct opposites, creating a stark contrast.

"Shame folded up in blind concealing night,"

Meaning: Shame, the inevitable consequence of Tarquin's intended act, is now hidden and sheltered by the darkness of the night. The darkness allows him to act without being seen by others and prevents him from seeing the truth of his actions.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Shame is personified as something that can be "folded up."
Imagery: The image of "blind concealing night" creates a sense of secrecy, foreboding, and moral darkness.

"When most unseen, then most doth tyrannize."

Meaning: The hidden and concealed nature of his actions only empowers him. The act will cause greater pain and shame when hidden away.
Literary Devices:
Paradox: The idea that being "unseen" allows something to "tyrannize" more powerfully is a paradox. The lack of external restraint allows Tarquin's internal desires to run rampant. Alliteration: the "m" sound is repeated which highlights the line's meaning.

"The wolf hath seized his prey, the poor lamb cries;"

Meaning: A vivid metaphor of predator and prey. Tarquin (the wolf) has captured Lucrece (the lamb). Her cries for help are now heard.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Tarquin is compared to a wolf, representing his predatory and aggressive nature. Lucrece is compared to a lamb, symbolizing her innocence, vulnerability, and helplessness. Imagery: The imagery of the wolf seizing the lamb is visceral and evokes a sense of violence and helplessness.

This said, he sets his foot upon the light,
For light and lust are deadly enemies:
Shame folded up in blind concealing night,
When most unseen, then most doth tyrannize.
The wolf hath seized his prey, the poor lamb cries; Till with her own white fleece her voice controll'd Entombs her outcry in her lips' sweet fold:

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"Till with her own white fleece her voice controll'd"

Meaning: Lucrece's own white robe (fleece), symbolic of her purity, is used to smother and silence her screams. This is a terrifying detail, highlighting her powerlessness.
Literary Devices:
Symbolism: "White fleece" (her robe) continues to symbolize her purity, but now it ironically becomes an instrument of her silencing.
Imagery: The image of the fleece stifling her voice is suffocating and emphasizes her loss of control.

"Entombs her outcry in her lips' sweet fold:"

Meaning: Her cry of protest is trapped within her own mouth, a final image of her utter helplessness and the violation of her voice.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Entombs" suggests that her cry is buried alive, emphasizing the finality of her silencing.
Synecdoche: "lips' sweet fold" is a synecdoche (part representing the whole), referring to her mouth but also to her entire being. The adjective "sweet" is ironic, highlighting the corruption
of something pure.
Alliteration: The 's' sound is repeated.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza captures the precise moment when Tarquin's predatory intentions fully manifest and Lucrece's resistance is violently suppressed. The extinguishing of the light, the personification of shame hidden in the darkness, and the brutal metaphor of the wolf and the lamb create a sense of impending horror and the loss of innocence. The final lines, where Lucrece's own purity (symbolized by her white robe) becomes the instrument of her silencing, are particularly disturbing and underscore the tragedy of her situation. The stanza is a masterclass in creating tension, dread, and a sense of moral corruption through vivid imagery, symbolism, and personification. It prepares the reader for the inevitable and horrific act of rape that is to follow.

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← Stanza 97📚 OverviewStanza 99 →

Stanza 98 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 98 of "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line and then synthesize the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "For with the nightly linen that she wears"

Meaning: This line introduces a physical detail that underscores the violation. "Nightly linen"
refers to Lucrece's nightgown or bedclothes. The "with" implies that he uses the clothing as a means of oppression. He is using a symbol of her vulnerability and purity (being in bed, asleep)
as a tool against her.
Literary Devices: Synecdoche or Metonymy: The "nightly linen" represents Lucrece herself, or her vulnerability.

Line 2: "He pens her piteous clamours in her head;"

Meaning: This is a figurative line describing how Tarquin stifles Lucrece's cries and protests, not literally, but psychologically. "Pens" means to enclose or confine. Her cries of pain and distress are trapped in her mind, unable to escape and perhaps intensifying her internal torment. Literary Devices: Metaphor: "Pens" is a metaphor for the overwhelming force that prevents her from expressing her pain. Alliteration: the repetition of the P sound in "pens" and "piteous" emphasizes the line.

Line 3: "Cooling his hot face in the chastest tears"

Meaning: This is a stark image of Tarquin's cold and callous behavior. He is unmoved by Lucrece's suffering and is literally "cooling" his flushed, lustful face with her tears, which are described as "chastest," meaning pure and innocent. This emphasizes the contrast between Tarquin's hot, lustful actions and Lucrece's pure innocence.
Literary Devices: Juxtaposition/Contrast: The "hot face" of lust contrasted with "chastest tears" highlights the profound difference between Tarquin's motives and Lucrece's innocence.
Hyperbole: Exaggeration in the use of "chastest tears"

Line 4: "That ever modest eyes with sorrow shed."

Meaning: This line emphasizes the unparalleled purity and innocence of Lucrece. It reinforces
the idea that these are the purest tears of sorrow ever shed by a woman of such modesty and virtue. It's a compliment, but one born out of a horrible situation.
Literary Devices: Hyperbole: Similar to the previous line, exaggerating the purity of the tears.

Line 5: "O, that prone lust should stain so pure a bed!"

Meaning: This is an exclamation expressing grief and outrage at the act of rape. "Prone lust" refers to lust that is inclined (prone) towards evil and wickedness. "Pure a bed" refers both to the literal bed (a symbol of the marriage bed and domestic sanctity) and to Lucrece herself (her purity). The word "stain" evokes a sense of lasting damage. The line is a lament over the defilement of something so sacred.

For with the nightly linen that she wears
He pens her piteous clamours in her head;
Cooling his hot face in the chastest tears
That ever modest eyes with sorrow shed.
O, that prone lust should stain so pure a bed! The spots whereof could weeping purify,
Her tears should drop on them perpetually.

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Literary Devices: Exclamation: The "O" marks this as an expression of strong emotion. Metaphor: "Stain" is a metaphor for the corruption and dishonor that Tarquin has inflicted. Alliteration: repetition of the P sound in "prone" and "pure" to highlight this idea.

Line 6: "The spots whereof could weeping purify,"

Meaning: This introduces the idea that perhaps the shame and pollution of the act could be washed away by tears. "Spots" refers to both physical stains (perhaps from the act of violence) and the metaphorical stain of dishonor.
Literary Devices: Metaphor: The "spots" are symbolic of the stain of dishonor.

Line 7: "Her tears should drop on them perpetually."

Meaning: This line continues the idea that Lucrece's tears could (or should) endlessly fall on the "spots" to cleanse them. It suggests a desire for unending penance and atonement, even if it is ultimately futile. There is a sense of overwhelming guilt and the impossible desire to undo the wrong.
Literary Devices: Hyperbole: The idea of tears falling "perpetually" emphasizes the unending sorrow and guilt.

Overall Meaning:

Stanza 98 paints a vivid and disturbing picture of the rape of Lucrece. It focuses on the psychological torment she endures, the callousness of Tarquin, and the profound sense of defilement and loss of innocence. The stanza highlights the stark contrast between Tarquin's base lust and Lucrece's inherent purity, emphasizing the tragedy of the event. The use of powerful imagery and figurative language creates a sense of outrage and pity, foreshadowing Lucrece's ultimate despair and suicide. The stanza also begins to explore the idea of whether the stain of the rape can ever be cleansed, introducing a theme of guilt and the desire for expiation that will be central to the rest of the poem. The stanza showcases the immense violation that Lucrece has endured and sets a mournful and despondent tone for the rest of the narrative.

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← Stanza 98📚 OverviewStanza 100 →

Stanza 99 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 99 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"But she hath lost a dearer thing than life,"

Meaning: Lucrece has lost something more valuable than her physical existence. This refers to
her honor and chastity.
Literary Devices:
Hyperbole: Exaggeration, as honor/chastity cannot be literally dearer than life itself. It is used
to emphasize the importance of Lucrece's virtue in the societal context of the poem.

"And he hath won what he would lose again:"

Meaning: Tarquin has gained something (Lucrece's body and temporary satisfaction), but it will ultimately lead to his downfall and he'll lose it again through shame, guilt, and eventually death. Literary Devices:
Irony: Tarquin thinks he has won, but his "victory" will actually destroy him.
Foreshadowing: Hints at the negative consequences that will come to Tarquin.

"This forced league doth force a further strife;"

Meaning: The forced union (the rape) will inevitably lead to more conflict and trouble. The rape is presented as not just a violation of a person, but also of the social and political order.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: Repetition of the 'f' sound for emphasis ("forced" and "further").
Metaphor: The use of "league" represents the violent union, which is not a true bond, but a forced connection.

"This momentary joy breeds months of pain;"

Meaning: The fleeting pleasure Tarquin experiences from the rape will result in extended suffering and sorrow for both him and Lucrece (and potentially Rome).
Literary Devices:
Contrast: Juxtaposes the brief "joy" with the extended "months of pain," highlighting the imbalance of the situation and the disproportionate consequences.
"This hot desire converts to cold disdain:"

Meaning: Tarquin's passionate lust will transform into a feeling of disgust and contempt, both for himself and for Lucrece (perhaps, although more accurately, he will simply no longer desire her). Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Compares emotions to temperature, highlighting the intensity of Tarquin's feelings
and their subsequent shift.
Antithesis: Opposite ideas are put together (hot vs. cold, desire vs. disdain).

"Pure Chastity is rifled of her store,"

Meaning: Lucrece's virginity (her "store") has been stolen or violated.

But she hath lost a dearer thing than life,
And he hath won what he would lose again:
This forced league doth force a further strife;
This momentary joy breeds months of pain;
This hot desire converts to cold disdain:
Pure Chastity is rifled of her store,
And Lust, the thief, far poorer than before.

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Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Chastity is personified and treated as a valuable possession that can be robbed. Alliteration: Repetition of the 'r' sound (rifled/her).

"And Lust, the thief, far poorer than before."

Meaning: Even though Tarquin (lust) committed the act of theft, he is actually left worse off and impoverished by the experience. Lust is not fulfilling; it leaves one empty and degraded.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Lust is given human qualities as a "thief."
Paradox: Lust, which seeks to gain pleasure, ironically leaves the perpetrator "poorer."
Metaphor: Lust is a "thief" because it steals something of value (Lucrece's honor) but provides
no lasting fulfillment.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza functions as a pivotal reflection on the consequences of the rape. It asserts that the act has resulted in a profound loss for Lucrece that outweighs physical life itself, while Tarquin's perceived victory is ultimately self-destructive. The forced violation creates a cycle of further conflict and misery, with the fleeting pleasure of lust giving way to long-term suffering and disgust. The stanza underscores the tragic irony of the situation: Tarquin, in attempting to enrich himself through the act, is left spiritually impoverished, while Lucrece's purity is irrevocably stolen. The stanza emphasizes the destructive nature of lust and the immense value placed on chastity in the context of the poem. The stanza ultimately reinforces the futility of Tarquin's actions and foreshadows the devastating repercussions that will follow, both for him and for Rome. It highlights that the true cost of the rape extends far beyond the immediate physical act.

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← Stanza 99📚 OverviewStanza 101 →

Stanza 100 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 100 of The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then look at the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "Look, as the full-fed hound or gorged hawk,"

Look is an imperative, drawing the reader's attention to the following comparison.
Full-fed hound or gorged hawk introduces the analogy. A hound (dog) and a hawk, both predators, are described as having eaten too much. "Full-fed" and "gorged" are strong verbs implying overindulgence.
Literary Device: Simile (using "as") - comparing Tarquin to an overfed animal.

Line 2: "Unapt for tender smell or speedy flight,"

Unapt means unsuitable or incapable.
Tender smell refers to the hound's inability to pick up faint scents. Their sense of smell, usually sharp, is dulled by being overly full.
Speedy flight refers to the hawk's inability to fly quickly. Their agility in the air is impaired due to overeating.
Literary Device: Imagery - Creates a clear picture of animals incapacitated by gluttony.

Line 3: "Make slow pursuit, or altogether balk"

Slow pursuit reinforces the idea of diminished capability. The hound and hawk are not functioning at their usual predatory level.
Altogether balk means to completely avoid or refuse. Because of being full, they no longer feel the need or capability to pursue what they desire.
Literary Device: Contrast - highlights the difference between their natural state and their current state.

Line 4: "The prey wherein by nature they delight;"

The prey refers to the animals that the hound and hawk naturally hunt.
By nature they delight emphasizes that hunting is an innate and pleasurable drive for these animals. They should want to hunt.
Literary Device: Irony - their current state prevents them from fulfilling their natural desires.

Line 5: "So surfeit-taking Tarquin fares this night:"

So marks the transition from the animal analogy to Tarquin.
Surfeit-taking means indulging to excess, similar to "full-fed" and "gorged." This describes Tarquin's mental and physical state this night.
Fares means "behaves" or "proceeds."
Literary Device: Simile - the culmination of the comparison. Tarquin is like the overfed hound/hawk.

Look, as the full-fed hound or gorged hawk,
Unapt for tender smell or speedy flight,
Make slow pursuit, or altogether balk
The prey wherein by nature they delight;
So surfeit-taking Tarquin fares this night:
His taste delicious, in digestion souring, Devours his will, that lived by foul devouring.

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Line 6: "His taste delicious, in digestion souring,"

His taste delicious refers to Tarquin's initial pleasure in contemplating and committing the rape. He finds the idea of possessing Lucrece appealing.
In digestion souring foreshadows the guilt and regret that will follow the act. The "taste" is now turning bitter.
Literary Device: Metaphor - uses the concept of digestion to represent the experience of desire and its aftermath. Juxtaposition of "delicious" and "souring" to highlight the contrast.

Line 7: "Devours his will, that lived by foul devouring."

Devours his will means that the guilt and consequences of his actions are destroying his capacity to act.

That lived by foul devouring refers to how Tarquin’s will previously thrived off of impure and evil desires. His will, which fueled his lust, is now being consumed by the consequences of its own actions.
Literary Device: Personification - Tarquin's will is given the ability to "live" and "devour."
Repetition - "devouring" emphasizes the destructive nature of Tarquin's desires.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza vividly portrays Tarquin's state of mind and foreshadows the consequences of his lust. The simile of the overfed hound and hawk illustrates that his desire, initially appealing, will turn to disgust and self-destruction. Just as the overfed animals are incapable of their natural actions, Tarquin is becoming incapable of rational thought and action. The stanza suggests that his "delicious taste" (the pleasure he anticipates) will "sour in digestion" (become bitter and ruinous after the act). Ultimately, his lust, which once drove his actions, will ultimately destroy his very will. This destruction of the will foreshadows his inevitable despair and eventual demise. The stanza highlights the theme of the destructive nature of uncontrolled desire and the inevitable consequences of immoral actions.

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← Stanza 100📚 OverviewStanza 102 →

Stanza 101 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 101 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss its overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"O, deeper sin than bottomless conceit"

"O": An exclamation, emphasizing the depth of the sin.
"deeper sin": Sin is the subject being discussed, implying a moral transgression.
"bottomless conceit": "Conceit" here refers to an inflated sense of self-importance, pride, or vanity that knows no bounds. "Bottomless" means it is endless, unfathomable.
Meaning: The sin Tarquin commits is worse than even the most extreme form of self-worship
and pride imaginable.

"Can comprehend in still imagination!"

"Can comprehend": Ability to understand or grasp the sin.
"in still imagination": "Still" means quiet, calm, undisturbed. "Imagination" refers to the ability to form mental images or concepts.
Meaning: Even in the quietest, most profound and introspective imagination, the full extent of this sin cannot be grasped. It is beyond comprehension.

"Drunken Desire must vomit his receipt,"

"Drunken Desire": Personification. Desire is given human qualities (drunkenness). "Drunken" implies uncontrolled, irrational behavior fueled by lust.
"must vomit his receipt": "Receipt" refers to what Desire has taken in, specifically, the pleasure and satisfaction it anticipates from the sin. "Vomit" is a strong, visceral image suggesting disgust and expulsion.
Meaning: This line is a metaphor. Desire must purge itself of the intoxicating pleasure it anticipates before the perpetrator can recognize the true horror of his intended act.
"Ere he can see his own abomination."

"Ere": Archaic term for "before."
"he can see his own abomination": "Abomination" means something utterly detestable, repulsive, and morally reprehensible.
Meaning: Only after Desire is purged of its initial allure can the perpetrator truly understand how disgusting and monstrous his actions are.

"While Lust is in his pride, no exclamation"

"While Lust is in his pride": Personification. Lust is given human qualities. "Pride" indicates
that lust is at its most intense and arrogant.
"no exclamation": "Exclamation" refers to any form of protest, warning, or plea.
Meaning: As long as lust is at its peak and full of itself, no amount of warnings or pleas can have any effect.

O, deeper sin than bottomless conceit
Can comprehend in still imagination!
Drunken Desire must vomit his receipt,
Ere he can see his own abomination.
While Lust is in his pride, no exclamation Can curb his heat or rein his rash desire, Till like a jade Self-will himself doth tire.

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"Can curb his heat or rein his rash desire,"

"curb his heat": "Curb" means to restrain or control. "Heat" refers to the intense passion and excitement of lust.
"rein his rash desire": "Rein" suggests control, as in the reins of a horse. "Rash desire" is impulsive and reckless desire.
Meaning: Nothing can restrain the intensity of his lustful passion or control his impulsive desires.

"Till like a jade Self-will himself doth tire."

"Till": Up until the point.
"like a jade Self-will himself doth tire":
"jade": Refers to an old, worn-out, and stubborn horse that is no longer responsive to commands.
"Self-will": A personification of one's own stubbornness and unwillingness to be controlled. "himself doth tire": Eventually, even the most stubborn and unrestrained will becomes
exhausted from its own excess.

Meaning: It is only when Self-will, like a tired old horse, is exhausted from its own excesses that
its power to drive the action is diminished.

Overall Meaning and Literary Devices:

This stanza explores the overwhelming power of lust and the difficulty of recognizing the moral depravity of one's actions when driven by such intense desire.

Literary Devices:

Personification: "Drunken Desire," "Lust is in his pride," "Self-will." This brings abstract concepts to life and makes them more relatable.
Metaphor: "Drunken Desire must vomit his receipt." The entire idea of desire vomiting its pleasure is a metaphor for the eventual revulsion that follows unrestrained lust.
Imagery: The strong, visceral image of vomiting adds to the repugnance of the scene. The image of the "jade" or old tired horse also evokes a sense of exhaustion and depleted energy. Hyperbole: "Deeper sin than bottomless conceit" - exaggeration to emphasize the enormity of the sin.
Allusion: The "jade" likely has common use and understanding in Shakespeare's era.

Overall Meaning: The stanza conveys the idea that the power of lust blinds individuals to the consequences of their actions. Reason and moral conscience are suppressed by the overwhelming force of desire. It is only when that desire has run its course, when it has exhausted itself like a worn-out horse, that the perpetrator can begin to perceive the true horror of what he has done. The stanza suggests that reason and moral judgment are impotent against the immediate force of overwhelming desire. It is the dissipation of that desire that allows for moral recognition. The moral recognition comes after the act not during. This stanza foreshadows the mental torment Tarquin will go through because he did not understand the depth of his sin before he committed it.
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← Stanza 101📚 OverviewStanza 103 →

Stanza 102 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 102 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, and then discuss the overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"And then with lank and lean discolour'd cheek,"

Breakdown: "And then" connects this to the preceding narrative. "Lank and lean discolour'd cheek" describes the physical appearance of a person. "Lank" means thin and drooping, "lean" means thin and lacking flesh. "Discolour'd" implies paleness, sickness, or loss of natural color. Literary Devices:
Alliteration: "Lank and lean" emphasizes the physical deterioration.
Imagery: Creates a vivid image of someone looking ill or weakened.

"With heavy eye, knit brow, and strengthless pace,"

Breakdown: Continues describing physical signs of suffering. "Heavy eye" suggests sadness, fatigue, or guilt. "Knit brow" indicates worry, frustration, or anger. "Strengthless pace" means a weak or faltering walk.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Adds to the picture of physical and emotional distress.
Asyndeton: The lack of conjunctions speeds up the description, emphasizing the number of negative attributes.

"Feeble Desire, all recreant, poor, and meek,"

Breakdown: Here, Shakespeare personifies Desire. "Feeble Desire" suggests that the person's passions are weakened. "Recreant" means cowardly or disloyal (to what is right). "Poor" and "meek" further emphasize Desire's diminished state and humility.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Giving human qualities to "Desire."
Tricolon: The series of three adjectives ("recreant, poor, and meek") provides emphasis.

"Like to a bankrupt beggar wails his case:"

Breakdown: This is a simile comparing Desire to a "bankrupt beggar" who is lamenting their situation. "Bankrupt" means financially ruined. "Wails his case" means complaining loudly and sorrowfully about their situation. This amplifies the sense of loss and suffering.
Literary Devices:
Simile: Uses "like to" to draw a comparison.
Imagery: Creates a visual of a desperate beggar.

"The flesh being proud, Desire doth fight with Grace,"

Breakdown: Explains the internal conflict. "The flesh being proud" refers to the physical body and its sensual desires, implying arrogance and lust. "Desire doth fight with Grace" suggests a
struggle between base impulses and moral goodness or divine favor.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "Desire" and "Grace" are treated as combatants.

And then with lank and lean discolour'd cheek,
With heavy eye, knit brow, and strengthless pace,
Feeble Desire, all recreant, poor, and meek,
Like to a bankrupt beggar wails his case:
The flesh being proud, Desire doth fight with Grace,
For there it revels; and when that decays,
The guilty rebel for remission prays.

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Abstract Concepts as Characters: Desire and Grace symbolize the internal moral struggle.

"For there it revels; and when that decays,"

Breakdown: "For there it revels" refers to the "flesh" and suggests that the physical desires are initially dominant and enjoy themselves. "And when that decays" signifies that this physical dominance is not sustainable.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Revels" suggests a wild celebration, implying that the physical desires are unrestrained.

"The guilty rebel for remission prays."

Breakdown: "The guilty rebel" refers to the weakened Desire, now recognizing its wrongdoings. "For remission prays" means it begs for forgiveness. This highlights the repentance and remorse that follows the indulgence of sinful desires.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Desire as a "rebel" reinforces the idea of a violation of moral boundaries.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza describes the aftermath of giving in to lust or unchecked desire. It paints a picture of the physical and emotional consequences, using the personification of "Desire" to explore the internal conflict that arises. Initially, the "flesh" is proud and dominant, reveling in its desires. However, this state is unsustainable, and eventually, the individual (or "Desire") experiences remorse and seeks forgiveness ("remission"). The stanza highlights the cyclical nature of temptation, indulgence, and regret, emphasizing the struggle between physical desires and moral conscience. It also illustrates the debilitating effect of guilt and the desire for redemption. Essentially, it's a mini-allegory of sin, temptation, and repentance, showing the toll that immoral actions take on a person.

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← Stanza 102📚 OverviewStanza 104 →

Stanza 103 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 103 of "The Rape of Lucrece" and then put it all together:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"So fares it with this faultful lord of Rome,"

Meaning: "This is how it is going for this guilty/culpable lord of Rome." "Fares" is an archaic way
of saying "goes" or "turns out." "Faultful" signifies that he is to blame.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: "Faultful" and "fares"
Epithet: "Faultful lord" is a descriptive term used to describe Tarquin.

"Who this accomplishment so hotly chased;"

Meaning: "Who so passionately pursued this 'accomplishment' (referring to Lucrece and the act of her rape)." "Hotly" emphasizes the intensity of his desire.
Literary Devices:
Euphemism: "Accomplishment" is a euphemism. It's a softer word used to avoid the harsh reality of rape. It reveals Tarquin's (and perhaps society's) twisted perspective where violating
a woman is framed as a victory.
Metaphor: "Hotly chased" is metaphorical in that he metaphorically hunted Lucrece.

"For now against himself he sounds this doom,"

Meaning: "Because of his actions, he now pronounces his own judgment/condemnation." "Sounds" implies a formal, deliberate pronouncement.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Doom cannot actually be "sounded".

"That through the length of times he stands disgraced:"

Meaning: "That for all time (throughout history), he will be disgraced/dishonored." "Length of times" emphasizes the enduring nature of his shame.
Literary Devices:
Hyperbole: "Length of times" suggests a massive and vast sense of time, which highlights the permanence of his shame.

"Besides, his soul's fair temple is defaced;"

Meaning: "In addition, the beautiful/pure temple of his soul is now ruined/destroyed." This line uses a metaphor to describe the inner damage Tarquin has inflicted upon himself.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Soul's fair temple" is a powerful metaphor. The soul, originally a place of purity
and virtue (a temple), is now "defaced" like a desecrated building.
Alliteration: "Soul's" and "stands"

"To whose weak ruins muster troops of cares,"

Meaning: "To these weakened ruins of his soul, gather armies of worries/anxieties/troubles." "Muster" means to assemble or gather.

So fares it with this faultful lord of Rome,
Who this accomplishment so hotly chased;
For now against himself he sounds this doom,
That through the length of times he stands disgraced:
Besides, his soul's fair temple is defaced;
To whose weak ruins muster troops of cares,
To ask the spotted princess how she fares.

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Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Continuing the "temple" metaphor, the "ruins" of his soul are now besieged by "troops of cares."
Personification: "Cares" (worries) are personified as "troops" that can "muster."

"To ask the spotted princess how she fares."

Meaning: "These cares gather around to inquire about the well-being of the 'spotted princess' (Lucrece)." "Spotted" signifies stained, tainted, or dishonored, referring to Lucrece's defiled reputation.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Spotted princess" is a metaphor for Lucrece's tainted reputation.
Irony: The cares "ask" how she fares. This is ironic because his actions have directly caused
her suffering. The worries are a direct consequence of his sin.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza describes the consequences of Tarquin's actions, focusing on the internal turmoil and lasting disgrace he will endure. He will be forever remembered for his crime and his soul, once pure, is now ruined. The "troops of cares" symbolize the constant anxiety and guilt that will plague him, a direct consequence of his violence against Lucrece. This stanza also subtly highlights the impact of Tarquin's actions on Lucrece, portraying her as the "spotted princess" whose reputation and life are forever stained by the assault. The use of the "fair temple" metaphor emphasizes the loss of purity and innocence for both Tarquin and Lucrece, though their experiences of that loss are drastically different. The irony is bitter: his own internal anxieties are now concerned with the woman he so brutally wronged.

In essence, the stanza emphasizes the interconnectedness of their fates and the devastating consequences of lust and violence on both perpetrator and victim. It suggests that Tarquin will be haunted by his actions, his soul forever marred by his crime.

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← Stanza 103📚 OverviewStanza 105 →

Stanza 104 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 104 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line, then look at the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"She says, her subjects with foul insurrection":
"She says": This introduces Lucrece's anguished internal monologue or statement after the
rape.
"her subjects": This is a metaphorical reference to her own bodily functions and inner thoughts, specifically those related to her virtue and chastity. She sees them as under her command, things she should be able to control.

"with foul insurrection": The "subjects" have rebelled violently. "Foul insurrection" emphasizes the revolting and treacherous nature of this rebellion against her will.

"Have batter'd down her consecrated wall":
"Have batter'd down": A violent image suggesting forceful and destructive action.
"her consecrated wall": This is a metaphor for Lucrece's chastity, virtue, and physical integrity. "Consecrated" implies that her virtue was sacred, set apart, and inviolable. It also carries a religious connotation, adding to the sense of defilement.

"And by their mortal fault brought in subjection":
"by their mortal fault": "Their" refers back to the rebellious "subjects." "Mortal fault" highlights the gravity of their error - a fault so severe it leads to death (literal and metaphorical).
"brought in subjection": As a result of this 'mortal fault', Lucrece is now in a state of subjugation/enslavement.

"Her immortality, and made her thrall":
"Her immortality": This refers to her reputation, honor, and the lasting impact of her virtue. It's what would have ensured her place in history as a virtuous woman.
"and made her thrall": "Thrall" means a slave or someone completely under the control of another. Her reputation is now enslaved/destroyed.

"To living death and pain perpetual:":
"To living death": An oxymoron. Suggests a state where Lucrece is alive physically, but her spirit and essence are dead due to the shame and trauma.
"and pain perpetual": Describes the never-ending suffering that she believes will be her fate.

"Which in her prescience she controlled still":
"Which": Refers back to the "living death and pain".
"in her prescience she controlled still": This implies that she had the ability (prescience means foresight or foreknowledge) to control or prevent these inner turmoil before the rape. "still": means "up until this point".

"But her foresight could not forestall their will.":
"her foresight": Synonymous with "prescience" from the previous line.
"could not forestall their will": Despite her foresight, she couldn't prevent the rebellion of her "subjects" or Collatine's actions. "Forestall" means to prevent or obstruct. This line highlights the tragic irony: she was aware of the potential for danger but ultimately powerless to stop it.

She says, her subjects with foul insurrection
Have batter'd down her consecrated wall,
And by their mortal fault brought in subjection
Her immortality, and made her thrall
To living death and pain perpetual:
Which in her prescience she controlled still,
But her foresight could not forestall their will.

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Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece laments the destruction of her inner self (her virtue and integrity) through the act of rape. She uses a powerful metaphor of a besieged city to describe her internal state. Her "subjects" (her bodily functions and desires) have rebelled against her control, breaching the "consecrated wall" of her chastity. This has led to the enslavement of her reputation ("immortality") and condemned her to a life of perpetual suffering, a "living death." The tragic irony is that she possessed the prescience to understand the potential for this devastation, yet her foresight proved insufficient to prevent it. She blames herself for not being able to ultimately control these forces.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: The entire stanza is built upon an extended metaphor of a besieged city representing Lucrece's internal state.
Personification: Lucrece gives her "subjects" agency and will, portraying them as active participants in her downfall.
Oxymoron: "Living death" emphasizes the paradoxical nature of her suffering.
Allusion: "Consecrated wall" has religious undertones, alluding to the sacredness of virginity. Irony: She has foresight, but it's useless.
Imagery: The violent language of battering, insurrection, and thrall creates vivid and disturbing imagery.
Alliteration: "Fault" and "foresight"

In essence, this stanza captures the overwhelming sense of violation, loss of control, and impending despair that Lucrece experiences in the aftermath of the rape. The highly figurative language conveys the profound psychological and emotional impact of the assault.

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← Stanza 104📚 OverviewStanza 106 →

Stanza 105 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 105 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Even in this thought through the dark night he stealeth,"

Meaning: Collatine, driven by the thought of Lucrece, sneaks, driven by his lust, through the
dark night. The "thought" refers to the obsessive desire that consumes him. The imagery of "dark night" emphasizes the secrecy, evil, and moral darkness of his actions.
Literary Device: The darkness of the night is metaphorical and represents the moral darkness of Tarquin's intentions.

"A captive victor that hath lost in gain;"

Meaning: This is a paradox. Tarquin sees himself as the victor in this encounter, but in reality, he is a prisoner to his own lust. Even though he believes he has gained something (Lucrece's submission), he has actually lost something of far greater value (his honor, conscience, and potential for peace).
Literary Device: Paradox and Oxymoron are used here, showing contradictory terms side by side to display Tarquin's victory is also his downfall.

"Bearing away the wound that nothing healeth,"

Meaning: Tarquin takes away the damage to Lucrece, but he will never be able to get rid of the guilt from the act.
Literary Device: Metaphor - The "wound" symbolizes not only the physical violation of Lucrece but also the irreparable damage to her spirit and honor. Also, the lack of healing represents his permanent guilt.

"The scar that will, despite of cure, remain;"

Meaning: This line elaborates on the previous one. The consequences of his actions will be a permanent blemish on his soul, no matter what he tries to do to erase it. "Cure" here can refer to any attempt at repentance or justification.
Literary Device: Imagery - The scar is a strong visual representation of the lasting impact of the rape. It emphasizes the permanence of the damage done.

"Leaving his spoil perplex'd in greater pain."

Meaning: Tarquin abandons Lucrece after violating her, leaving her utterly confused and in far worse emotional and physical pain than she was before. "Spoil" refers to Lucrece.
Literary Device: Metaphor - Lucrece is referred to as "spoil," dehumanizing her and
highlighting Tarquin's selfish, predatory view of her.

"She bears the load of lust he left behind,"

Meaning: Lucrece is now burdened with the shame, dishonor, and trauma caused by Tarquin's
lust. She is the one who must live with the consequences of his action. "Load of lust" refers to the psychological and social consequences of the rape.

Even in this thought through the dark night he stealeth,
A captive victor that hath lost in gain;
Bearing away the wound that nothing healeth,
The scar that will, despite of cure, remain;
Leaving his spoil perplex'd in greater pain.
She bears the load of lust he left behind,
And he the burden of a guilty mind.

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Literary Device: Metaphor - The "load" signifies the heavy burden of shame and dishonor that Lucrece now carries.

"And he the burden of a guilty mind."

Meaning: Tarquin, though he might try to deny it, now carries the weight of his own guilt and conscience. He is burdened by the knowledge of what he has done.
Literary Device: Parallelism - This line directly mirrors the previous line, emphasizing the symmetrical but unequal distribution of the consequences. Lucrece bears the shame, while Tarquin bears the guilt.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza encapsulates the immediate aftermath of the rape of Lucrece and the psychological and emotional burdens carried by both victim and perpetrator. Tarquin, despite achieving his immediate lustful desires, is not a true victor. He is a captive to his own desires and now carries the weight of guilt that will haunt him. Lucrece, the victim, is left with an even greater burden of shame and dishonor. The stanza highlights the destructive nature of lust and the lasting consequences of violence and the inequality in power between the two characters. It emphasizes that both Tarquin and Lucrece are, in their own ways, prisoners of the event.

Key Literary Devices:

Metaphor: "Wound," "scar," "spoil," "load," "burden" are all used metaphorically to represent intangible emotional and psychological states.
Imagery: The descriptions of "dark night," "wound," and "scar" create vivid sensory experiences that evoke the darkness, pain, and lasting impact of the rape.
Paradox/Oxymoron: "Captive victor that hath lost in gain" is a powerful example of how Tarquin's apparent triumph is actually a self-destructive defeat.
Parallelism: The last two lines ("She bears the load..." and "And he the burden...") create a sense of balance and contrast, emphasizing the shared burden of the event but also the unequal distribution of suffering.
Alliteration: Occurs throughout the stanza, like the repetition of the 'l' in "load" and "lust" in line
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← Stanza 105📚 OverviewStanza 107 →

Stanza 106 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 106 of The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then look at the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "He like a thievish dog creeps sadly thence;"

"He": Refers to Tarquin, the rapist.
"like a thievish dog": A simile comparing Tarquin to a dog that has stolen something and feels shame or fear of being caught. The "thievish dog" emphasizes his guilt and the base, animalistic nature of his actions. He sees himself as pathetic.
"creeps sadly thence": Suggests he is moving slowly, dejectedly, and dishonorably away from Lucrece. "Thence" is an archaic term meaning "from there." His sadness is probably due to the guilt he is feeling.

Line 2: "She like a wearied lamb lies panting there;"

"She": Refers to Lucrece, the victim.
"like a wearied lamb": Another simile. This image paints Lucrece as innocent, vulnerable, and exhausted after the violent act. A lamb is a common symbol of purity and gentleness. The term "wearied" suggests she is extremely exhausted from the ordeal.
"lies panting there": Indicates her physical and emotional distress. The "panting" suggests rapid, shallow breathing due to shock, fear, or physical struggle. "There" is used to highlight the place in which she was wronged and is still suffering.

Line 3: "He scowls and hates himself for his offence;"

"He scowls": Suggests anger and displeasure, now directed inward at himself.
"hates himself for his offence": Reveals the beginning of his internal conflict and guilt. He now recognises the horror of what he has done.

Line 4: "She, desperate, with her nails her flesh doth tear;"

"She, desperate": Highlights her complete despair and loss of hope.
"with her nails her flesh doth tear": Illustrates her self-inflicted pain and anguish. It is a physical manifestation of her emotional torment. "Doth tear" is an archaic way of saying "tears", showing a more extreme version of the action.

Line 5: "He faintly flies, sneaking with guilty fear;"

"He faintly flies": Shows his reluctance to take action, he is hesitant.
"sneaking with guilty fear": This further reinforces the image of him as cowardly and ashamed. He is not facing the consequences, but running away.

Line 6: "She stays, exclaiming on the direful night;"

"She stays": Contrasts with Tarquin's flight. She is rooted to the spot, unable to escape the trauma.

"exclaiming on the direful night": She is lamenting and cursing the terrible night, the time of her rape. "Direful" emphasizes the horror and tragedy of the event.

He like a thievish dog creeps sadly thence;
She like a wearied lamb lies panting there;
He scowls and hates himself for his offence;
She, desperate, with her nails her flesh doth tear;
He faintly flies, sneaking with guilty fear;
She stays, exclaiming on the direful night;
He runs, and chides his vanish'd, loathed delight.

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Line 7: "He runs, and chides his vanish'd, loathed delight."

"He runs": Further emphasizes his escape and avoidance of responsibility.
"chides his vanish'd, loathed delight": He is scolding or rebuking his past pleasure, which is now gone and replaced with self-disgust. The "vanish'd, loathed delight" suggests he initially saw the act as pleasurable, but now recognizes it as vile and disgusting.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza powerfully contrasts the immediate aftermath of the rape for both Tarquin and Lucrece. Tarquin is consumed by guilt and flees the scene, his initial "delight" replaced by self-loathing. He wants to forget it happened and move on. Lucrece, on the other hand, is trapped in her trauma, overwhelmed by despair and self-inflicted pain. The stanza highlights the asymmetry of the experience: Tarquin can run from his crime, but Lucrece is bound to the place and memory of her violation. It shows the immediate physical and emotional responses of both the perpetrator and the victim.

Literary Devices:

Simile: The prominent use of similes ("like a thievish dog," "like a wearied lamb") creates vivid and contrasting images of the two characters. These similes emphasize their respective states of mind and moral standing.
Juxtaposition/Contrast: The stanza is built on a stark contrast between Tarquin's actions and Lucrece's reactions. His "creeping" and "flying" are set against her "staying." His "scowling and hating" are mirrored by her "desperation" and self-harm.
Alliteration: The use of alliteration in "direful delight" further enhances the description of the
scene.

Imagery: The stanza is full of powerful visual imagery: the "thievish dog," the "wearied lamb," the tearing of flesh, the guilty flight.
Internal Conflict: The stanza reveals Tarquin's internal conflict, showcasing his feelings of guilt and self-loathing. Lucrece also experiences internal conflict, which is shown through her self-harming actions.
Archaic language: The use of "thence" and "doth tear" adds to the formal, classical tone of the poem.

In conclusion, stanza 106 is a crucial moment in The Rape of Lucrece that emphasizes the immediate consequences of the crime and sets the stage for the tragic events that follow. It uses powerful imagery, contrasting characterizations, and literary devices to convey the profound impact of the rape on both the perpetrator and the victim.

← Stanza 105📚 OverviewStanza 107 →

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← Stanza 106📚 OverviewStanza 108 →

Stanza 107 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 107 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices, and then synthesize the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"He thence departs a heavy convertite;"

"He": Tarquin, the rapist.
"thence": From the scene of the crime, Lucrece's chamber.
"departs": Leaves.
"a heavy convertite": A penitent person, but one weighed down by guilt. "Heavy" suggests both the emotional weight of his guilt and potentially a literal heaviness because of the deed committed.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: "heavy" and "convertite"

"She there remains a hopeless castaway;"

"She": Lucrece, the victim.
"there": In her chamber, the scene of the rape.
"remains": Stays.
"a hopeless castaway": A person abandoned and without hope. "Castaway" suggests she feels discarded and worthless.
Literary Devices:
Contrast: This line directly contrasts with the first line, highlighting the different fates and feelings of the perpetrator and the victim.

"He in his speed looks for the morning light;"

"He": Tarquin.
"in his speed": Hurrying, trying to escape the scene and the consequences of his actions. "looks for the morning light": He anticipates the dawn, perhaps hoping that a new day will bring a fresh start or that he can escape under the cover of daylight. Here, "morning light" can also symbolize the exposure that the crime will inevitably bring, and that Tarquin is trying to outrun.

Literary Devices:
Symbolism: "Morning light" representing a new beginning, but also the dawning of truth and consequences.

"She prays she never may behold the day,"
"She": Lucrece.
"prays she never may behold the day": She wishes for death rather than to face the shame and dishonor of being raped. She would prefer to remain in darkness than face the implications of the light.
Literary Devices:
Contrast: Direct contrast with the previous line. Tarquin seeks the light, Lucrece dreads it.

He thence departs a heavy convertite;
She there remains a hopeless castaway;
He in his speed looks for the morning light;
She prays she never may behold the day,
' For day,' quoth she, 'nights scapes doth open lay,
And my true eyes have never practised how
To cloak offences with a cunning brow.

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Irony: Tarquin seeks light as a form of escape and new beginnings, whereas Lucrece seeks darkness as escape (of life) and ending.

"'For day,' quoth she, 'nights scapes doth open lay,"

"quoth she": an archaic way of saying "said she".
"'For day...' ": Lucrece explaining her wish for darkness.
"nights scapes doth open lay": The daylight reveals the crimes and secrets that were hidden in the darkness of the night. This is a metaphor. The night "escapes" refer to the evil acts that happened under the cover of night. The day "open lays" (reveals) the consequences and repercussions of these acts.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Comparing the revelation of crimes to opening a hidden secret.
Personification: Giving the "night" the ability to produce "escapes".

"And my true eyes have never practised how"

"And": Continuing Lucrece's lament.
"my true eyes": Emphasizing her honesty and innocence.
"have never practised how": She is not experienced in deceit or concealing the truth. Alliteration: "practised"

"To cloak offences with a cunning brow."

"To cloak offences": To hide or conceal wrongdoing.
"with a cunning brow": Through deceitful expressions and manipulation. The "brow" is a synecdoche, representing the entire face and one's ability to deceive through facial expressions. Literary Devices:
Synecdoche: "Brow" represents the whole face and the capacity for deception.
Imagery: Visualizing the act of concealing offenses with a deceptive facial expression.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza powerfully contrasts the immediate aftermath of the rape. Tarquin, burdened by guilt, flees the scene, seeking solace or escape in the coming dawn. He hopes for a new day that will absolve him of his sin. In stark contrast, Lucrece is left behind, feeling utterly abandoned and hopeless. She despairs of the light, seeing it as a revealer of her shame and the destruction of her honor. She emphasizes her inherent honesty and inability to feign innocence or hide the truth, highlighting the unbearable situation she now faces. She feels she cannot hide what has happened and is doomed to be exposed, and more importantly, disgraced, for something that was done to her. The stanza sets the stage for Lucrece's tragic decision to take her own life to preserve her honor.

Key Themes & Literary Devices:

Contrast: The most dominant device, highlighting the vastly different experiences and emotional states of Tarquin and Lucrece.
Light vs. Darkness: A symbolic motif. For Tarquin, light represents hope and escape; for Lucrece, it represents exposure and shame.
Guilt vs. Innocence: The stanza clearly establishes Tarquin's guilt and Lucrece's innocence, intensifying the tragedy.
Honour & Shame: Lucrece's focus on her inability to hide the crime speaks to the societal pressures surrounding female honour.
Synecdoche: "Brow" representing deception.
Metaphor: Day revealing hidden crimes.
Alliteration: Adding emphasis and flow to the language.

This stanza is crucial for understanding the psychological impact of the rape on both the perpetrator and the victim, and it foreshadows the devastating consequences that are to follow. It is a beautifully crafted and emotionally charged passage.
← Stanza 106📚 OverviewStanza 108 →

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← Stanza 107📚 OverviewStanza 109 →

Stanza 108 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 108 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, then look at the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"They think not but that every eye can see": This line is a bit convoluted. "Think not but that" is a double negative construction, meaning "They certainly think that". So, they (Lucrece is referring to Tarquin specifically, but also perhaps all perpetrators of similar crimes) believe that everyone is able to see...

"The same disgrace which they themselves behold;": ...the same shame/dishonor/degradation/outrage that they (the rapists) themselves now perceive (presumably because of the guilt and potential consequences of their actions). The disgrace is both the act and its consequences. The rapist projects his own feelings of disgrace onto the victim, and believes it is now readily apparent to everyone else.

"And therefore would they still in darkness be,": Because they believe everyone can see their disgrace, they would prefer to stay in darkness. "Darkness" here is both literal (they'd prefer the crime remained secret, hidden) and figurative (they want to stay hidden from scrutiny, to avoid the consequences of their actions). Their preference is for secrecy.

"To have their unseen sin remain untold;": This reinforces the previous line. Their motivation for wanting to remain in darkness is so that their unseen sin (the rape itself, which they hope remains hidden) remains untold (undiscovered, unconfessed, not spoken of). The rhyme 'be' and 'see' is continued.

"For they their guilt with weeping will unfold,": Here, the subject shifts. Lucrece turns her gaze to herself and her own response to the shame of the rape. This line means: because of them, she will be forced to "unfold" or reveal her own guilt (which is really shame and sorrow), through her own weeping and lamenting. The idea is that, because of their actions, she will inevitably have to reveal what happened, and she will do so with great sorrow.

"And grave, like water that doth eat in steel,": The act of unfolding guilt will grave this disgrace on her cheeks. She compares weeping to water that eats into steel. The image is powerful and striking - the tears (water) seem gentle and harmless, but over time, they will erode her
beauty, health, and reputation, just as water can corrode steel.

"Upon my cheeks what helpless shame I feel.": This is the culmination of the stanza. All the shame she feels will be visibly etched onto her face (cheeks) because of their actions. It's a physical manifestation of the emotional trauma she has experienced. She emphasizes her helplessness - she can't stop the shame from being visible, because it's a direct result of what they did.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

The stanza explores the complex and devastating consequences of rape. Lucrece starts by attributing a certain mindset to her attacker(s), suggesting they now fear the judgment and exposure of their actions. However, the stanza quickly pivots to focus on Lucrece's own experience. The core meaning is

'They think not but that every eye can see
The same disgrace which they themselves behold;
And therefore would they still in darkness be,
To have their unseen sin remain untold;
For they their guilt with weeping will unfold,
And grave, like water that doth eat in steel, Upon my cheeks what helpless shame I feel.'

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the lasting and visible impact of shame that the rape will have on Lucrece. It's not just about the physical act of the rape, but the deep, psychological wound that will forever alter her, leaving a permanent mark (etched on her face, figuratively, but also impacting her sense of self and place in society). Her shame is a direct result of their actions and she feels helpless to stop it.

Literary Devices:

Double Negative (Litotes): "Think not but that" - Used for emphasis.
Metaphor: "Darkness" as a metaphor for secrecy and avoidance of consequences.
Simile: "Grave, like water that doth eat in steel" - This is the most potent device, vividly illustrating the damaging effect of shame through the corrosive image of water on steel. It suggests something slow, relentless, and ultimately destructive.
Imagery: The stanza is full of visual imagery: eyes seeing disgrace, people hidden in darkness, tears etching shame on cheeks.
Personification: "water that doth eat in steel" - Water is given the human characteristic of eating. Alliteration: "Sin remain untold" - Used to add a subtle musicality to the line.
Shift in Subject: The change from 'they' to 'I' halfway through the stanza creates a powerful contrast between the perspective of the perpetrator and the victim. This highlights the differing burdens each carries.
Projection/Attribution: Lucrece begins by attributing feelings of shame and fear of exposure to the rapist, projecting what she thinks he must be feeling.

In Conclusion:

This stanza is a powerful expression of the aftermath of a violent act, focusing not just on the physical violation but on the enduring psychological and social consequences for the victim. Shakespeare masterfully uses imagery and metaphor to convey the depth of Lucrece's shame and her sense of helplessness in the face of it. The simile of water eroding steel is particularly evocative, capturing the slow but inevitable destruction of her innocence and reputation.

← Stanza 107📚 OverviewStanza 109 →

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← Stanza 108📚 OverviewStanza 110 →

Stanza 109 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 109 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line and then consider the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Here she exclaims against repose and rest,"

Meaning: Lucrece is vocally protesting and denouncing the idea of peace, quiet, and sleep. She rejects any comfort or solace.
Literary Devices:
Exclaims: The use of the verb "exclaims" emphasizes the vehemence and intensity of her emotions.
Repose and Rest: These words are synonyms and create pleonasm or a redundancy, further emphasizing her rejection of peace.

"And bids her eyes hereafter still be blind."

Meaning: She curses her eyes, wishing they would remain perpetually blind from this point forward. She wants to avoid ever seeing anything again after witnessing her own defilement. Literary Devices:
Imagery: The image of blindness is a powerful symbol of her desire to shut out the world and the memory of the rape.
Direct Address: Lucrece is speaking directly to her eyes ("bids her eyes"). This is an example
of apostrophe.

"She wakes her heart by beating on her breast,"

Meaning: She physically rouses her heart, beating on her chest to wake it up. She wants to revive a sense of hope or perhaps, a sense of outrage.
Literary Devices:
Physicality: This line brings a sense of the physical reality of her distress. It's not just mental anguish; it's a physical response.
Metaphor: The heart as a representation of emotion and life force.

"And bids it leap from thence, where it may find"

Meaning: She demands her heart to leave her body to find somewhere more suitable to reside. Literary Devices:
Apostrophe: Again, she's speaking directly to her heart, further demonstrating her despair.

"Some purer chest to close so pure a mind."

Meaning: She believes her body is now tainted and unworthy of harboring her pure mind and heart. She yearns for a more untainted vessel for her "pure" mind and heart.
Literary Devices:
Irony: The adjective "pure" is used with the word "mind" and "chest/heart" to heighten the
irony of the situation. She feels she has been defiled which has tarnished her "pure" mind and heart, a notion not typically associated with physical events like the rape.
Alliteration: "Purer...pure" highlights the purity theme.

Here she exclaims against repose and rest,
And bids her eyes hereafter still be blind.
She wakes her heart by beating on her breast,
And bids it leap from thence, where it may find
Some purer chest to close so pure a mind.
Frantic with grief thus breathes she forth her spite Against the unseen secrecy of night:

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"Frantic with grief thus breathes she forth her spite"

Meaning: Overwhelmed by grief and distraught, she gives vent to her anger and resentment. Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the "f" sound in "frantic" and "forth" adds to the emotional intensity.

"Against the unseen secrecy of night:"

Meaning: She directs her rage at the night itself, because under the cover of darkness, the crime happened unnoticed.
Literary Devices:
Personification: The night is given the quality of "secrecy" as if it is an entity capable of
hiding things.
Symbolism: The night acts as a symbol for the darkness that conceals evil and allows it to
flourish.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza encapsulates Lucrece's intense emotional and physical reaction to the rape. She is in a state of utter despair, rejecting any possibility of comfort or peace. Her grief is so profound that she wishes for blindness, the death of her heart, and directs her anger towards the night, which she sees as complicit in the crime. The stanza emphasizes her sense of defilement and her belief that her body and heart are no longer worthy of her pure mind. It also serves to foreshadow her eventual suicide, driven by the feeling that she can no longer live with the shame and dishonor. The heavy use of apostrophe underscores her isolation and the directness of her pain.

The stanza is a powerful expression of trauma and a testament to the devastating impact of the rape on Lucrece's psyche. It effectively conveys her feelings of worthlessness, defilement, and utter hopelessness.

← Stanza 108📚 OverviewStanza 110 →

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← Stanza 109📚 OverviewStanza 111 →

Stanza 110 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Shakespeare's chilling description of Night from The Rape of Lucrece, stanza 110:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"O comfort-killing Night, image of hell!"

"O comfort-killing Night": This line directly addresses Night with a sense of lamentation and dread. Night is personified as an active force that destroys comfort.
"image of hell": Night is being compared to hell. It's a metaphor and it suggests an atmosphere of torment, sin, and despair.
This entire line is an apostrophe because the narrator is directly addressing night, which is an inanimate concept.

"Dim register and notary of shame!"

"Dim register": Refers to a poorly lit or unclear record. It implies that Night keeps track of shameful deeds, but does so in a hidden or obscured manner.
"and notary of shame!": A notary is an official who witnesses and records important events. Night is like a notary, officially stamping shameful actions, validating them.
The line uses metaphor, comparing Night to legal officials.

"Black stage for tragedies and murders fell!"

"Black stage": Night is likened to a theater stage, but a black one. It suggests that dark and
evil acts play out during the night.
"tragedies and murders fell!": The kind of drama that is played out on this stage, these words imply tragedy and foul murders. The word "fell" reinforces the cruel and deadly nature of these acts.

Metaphor: Night is being compared to a stage for the unfolding of terrible events.

"Vast sin-concealing chaos! nurse of blame!"

"Vast sin-concealing chaos!": Night is described as a vast, chaotic place that hides sins. The word "chaos" suggests a lack of order and moral boundaries.
"nurse of blame!": Night is seen as nurturing and fostering blame. The implication is that sin and misdeeds can grow out of the cover of the night.
Metaphor: Night is the entity that hides sins and fosters blame.
"Blind muffled bawd! dark harbour for defame!"

"Blind muffled bawd!": This is a particularly striking and repulsive image. A "bawd" is a madam or procurer, someone who arranges immoral sexual encounters. Night is described as "blind" (lacking moral sight) and "muffled" (silencing conscience or preventing discovery), suggesting a deliberate hiding and encouragement of sin.
"dark harbour for defame!": Night is like a safe haven for slander and ruining of one's reputation. This suggests that the darkness protects and allows for the spread of malicious
rumours.

'O comfort-killing Night, image of hell!
Dim register and notary of shame!
Black stage for tragedies and murders fell!
Vast sin-concealing chaos! nurse of blame!
Blind muffled bawd! dark harbour for defame! Grim cave of death! whispering conspirator With close-tongued treason and the ravisher!

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Metaphor: Night is being compared to a pimp and a harbour.

"Grim cave of death! whispering conspirator"

"Grim cave of death!": Night is described as a fearsome, dark place of death. The word "grim" emphasizes the terror and coldness of death.
"whispering conspirator": Night is personified as a conspirator who whispers secrets and plans evil deeds.
Metaphor: Night is being compared to a death cave and a conspirator.

"With close-tongued treason and the ravisher!"

"With close-tongued treason": Night is working with treason.
"and the ravisher!": This is a direct link to the central event of the poem, the rape of Lucrece.
The ravisher (Tarquin) is aided and abetted by the darkness.
Personification: Treason has the quality of being "close-tongued," implying it is secretive and hidden.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza is a powerful condemnation of Night. It's not just a neutral time of day; it's an active force that enables and encourages evil. Shakespeare paints Night as a hellish, morally bankrupt entity that conspires with treachery and violence. It's a time when conscience is silenced, secrets are hidden, and the worst aspects of human nature are allowed to flourish. Night is not merely the backdrop for Lucrece's rape; it is an accomplice, an active participant in the tragic crime. The language is highly figurative, using metaphors and personification to create a vivid and disturbing portrait of Night as the incubator of sin and despair. The stanza creates a strong sense of foreboding and sets the stage for the violence to come.

← Stanza 109📚 OverviewStanza 111 →

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← Stanza 110📚 OverviewStanza 112 →

Stanza 111 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Shakespeare's Stanza 111 from The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, and then look at the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"O hateful, vaporous, and foggy Night!"

Analysis: This line is an apostrophe (direct address to an absent person or thing) addressed to Night. It's filled with strong negative emotions and sensory details. "Hateful" expresses her loathing. "Vaporous" and "foggy" evoke the thick, obscuring nature of the night, suggesting both physical and moral darkness. This dark, foggy atmosphere represents the moral corruption
Lucrece feels the night has enabled.
Literary Devices:
Apostrophe: Addressing "Night" directly.
Imagery: Vivid descriptions that appeal to the senses (sight, touch – the feeling of
dampness).
Alliteration: Possible faint alliteration with the 'f' in 'foggy' and 'hateful'.

"Since thou art guilty of my cureless crime,"

Analysis: This line states the reason for Lucrece's hatred. Lucrece blames Night for facilitating the rape, suggesting that the darkness and secrecy of the night allowed Tarquin to commit the "cureless crime." The "cureless crime" emphasizes the irreparable damage done to Lucrece's honor and soul. It also hints at her impending suicide, as she feels there is no healing from this violation.

Literary Devices:
Personification: Attributing guilt to "Night" as if it were a conscious being.

"Muster thy mists to meet the eastern light,"

Analysis: This is a call to arms of the darkness. Lucrece urges Night to gather its mists and fogs to fight against the rising sun (the "eastern light"). This is a direct confrontation between the darkness that enabled the crime and the light that will expose it. This also represents Lucrece's desire to delay the coming of day, which will bring the shame and exposure she dreads.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Giving Night the ability to "muster" mists like an army.
Metaphor: The "eastern light" can be seen as a metaphor for truth, justice, or simply the coming day that will expose the crime.
Imagery: A visual image of mists gathering.

"Make war against proportion'd course of time;"

Analysis: This line intensifies the call to arms. Lucrece is not just asking Night to fight the sun, but to disrupt the natural order of time itself. "Proportion'd course of time" refers to the regular, predictable movement of the sun and the days. Lucrece wants time to stop, or at least be disrupted, to prevent the inevitable exposure of the crime and the consequences she faces. Literary Devices:
Personification: Giving Night the agency to wage war.

'O hateful, vaporous, and foggy Night!
Since thou art guilty of my cureless crime,
Muster thy mists to meet the eastern light,
Make war against proportion'd course of time;
Or if thou wilt permit the sun to climb
His wonted height, yet ere he go to bed,
Knit poisonous clouds about his golden head.

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Abstract Noun Personification: Personifying time as 'proportion'd course of time.'

"Or if thou wilt permit the sun to climb"

Analysis: This line introduces an alternative scenario. Lucrece grudgingly acknowledges that Night might not be able to stop the sun's ascent. "Climb" gives the sun a sense of struggle, adding to the feeling of conflict.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Attributing action of 'climbing' to the sun.

"His wonted height, yet ere he go to bed,"

Analysis: This continues the alternative scenario, but adds a condition. Even if the sun reaches its usual height ("wonted height"), Lucrece still demands that Night exact revenge before the sun sets ("ere he go to bed"). She still seeks to disrupt the natural order.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Personifying the sun as having a 'bed' it goes to.
Implied Time Pressure: "Ere he go to bed" creates a sense of urgency.

"Knit poisonous clouds about his golden head."

Analysis: This is the final, violent image. Lucrece commands Night to create "poisonous clouds" to surround the sun's "golden head." This is an act of defiance and a desire for vengeance. The "poisonous clouds" suggest the destructive power of the crime and the potential for further corruption or darkness. The "golden head" is a powerful image of the sun's glory being suffocated and poisoned.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Giving Night the ability to "knit" clouds.
Metaphor: "Poisonous clouds" can be seen as a metaphor for the shame, guilt, and despair
that Lucrece feels.
Imagery: The image of the sun being surrounded by dark, poisonous clouds is striking and disturbing.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece passionately curses the night that allowed the rape to occur. She blames Night directly for her "cureless crime" and urges it to wage war against the sun and the natural order of time. She wants to delay the dawn and prevent the exposure of her shame. Even if the sun rises, she demands that Night ultimately destroy or corrupt its light before it sets. The stanza is a powerful expression of Lucrece's despair, anger, and desire for revenge against the forces that have destroyed her honor and peace of mind. It showcases the internal turmoil and violent impulses arising from her trauma. It sets the stage for the tragic choices she will make.

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← Stanza 111📚 OverviewStanza 113 →

Stanza 112 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 112 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices used, and then discuss the stanza's overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"With rotten damps ravish the morning air;"

Meaning: The speaker is calling upon some dark, personified force (likely Night or a destructive spirit) to contaminate or violate ("ravish") the fresh morning air with "rotten damps" (i.e., unhealthy, decaying moisture).
Literary Devices:
Personification: The "rotten damps" are given agency to "ravish," an act usually performed
by a person. This highlights the aggressive and corrupting nature of the darkness being
invoked.
Imagery: Evokes a strong image of decay and pollution spreading.
"Let their exhaled unwholesome breaths make sick"

Meaning: The "rotten damps" emit "unwholesome breaths" that sicken.
Literary Devices:
Personification: The "rotten damps" are given the ability to exhale breath.
Imagery: reinforces the idea of poison and disease

"The life of purity, the supreme fair,"

Meaning: This refers to Lucrece. She is the embodiment of purity and beauty. The goal of the dark forces is to attack and corrupt her.
Literary Devices:
Epithet: Lucrece is characterized by a defining attribute ("life of purity," "supreme fair"),
serving to emphasize her virtuous nature.
Metaphor: Lucrece is a representation of purity itself.

"Ere he arrive his weary noon-tide prick;"

Meaning: This refers to the sun reaching its zenith, or noon. The speaker wants the darkness to corrupt Lucrece before the sun, which represents light, truth, and justice, can arrive. The word "prick" is a now archaic term referring to a point in time.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The sun represents goodness, truth, and justice.
Alliteration: "weary noon-tide" emphasizes the point in time.

"And let thy misty vapours march so thick,"

Meaning: Continue to call upon the darkness and its "misty vapours" to move forward aggressively and in great abundance. The idea is to create a dense cover or fog.
Literary Devices:
Personification: The "misty vapours" are given the ability to "march," suggesting a deliberate and powerful advance.

'With rotten damps ravish the morning air;
Let their exhaled unwholesome breaths make sick
The life of purity, the supreme fair,
Ere he arrive his weary noon-tide prick;
And let thy misty vapours march so thick,
That in their smoky ranks his smother'd light May set at noon and make perpetual night.

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Imagery: Creates a feeling of being crowded, of lack of air.

"That in their smoky ranks his smother'd light"

Meaning: The dense formation of darkness completely extinguishes the sun.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Strong visual image of the sun's light being suffocated by smoke.
Metaphor: The "smoky ranks" are a metaphor for the forces of evil/darkness that are overwhelming the light.

"May set at noon and make perpetual night."

Meaning: That the sun, which should be at its highest point, will instead "set" (like it would at night), creating a permanent state of darkness. This represents the complete triumph of evil and the loss of virtue.
Literary Devices:
Paradox: The sun setting at noon is a contradiction, highlighting the unnatural and
catastrophic nature of the impending event.
Hyperbole: The idea of "perpetual night" is an exaggeration, emphasizing the total and devastating victory of darkness.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a powerful curse or invocation. The speaker, filled with foreboding, is calling upon the forces of darkness to corrupt Lucrece before the light of day (representing justice, truth, and virtue) can arrive. The darkness is meant to overwhelm and destroy her purity, plunging the world into a state of perpetual moral and spiritual darkness. The "rotten damps" and "misty vapours" represent the spread of evil and corruption, while the image of the sun being smothered at noon symbolizes the utter defeat of goodness. The stanza foreshadows the tragedy that is about to unfold, emphasizing the violence and destructive power of the forces that are about to violate Lucrece. It sets a tone of hopelessness and despair.

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← Stanza 112📚 OverviewStanza 114 →

Stanza 113 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 113 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then look at the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Were Tarquin Night, as he is but Night's child,"

Breakdown: This line uses a Metaphor and introduces the overarching imagery of darkness and evil associated with Tarquin.
"Were Tarquin Night": Hyperbole: It proposes a counterfactual. If Tarquin were the embodiment
of Night itself...
"as he is but Night's child": He is merely a product of Night. The "child" could suggest a
younger, less experienced or less powerful version of absolute darkness, but is still imbued with evil. This is a gentler version of calling him night and highlights the source of his immorality.

Meaning: Even though Tarquin is not literally Night, his actions are so evil that he is like Night's offspring, embodying the darkness, immorality, and treachery associated with it.

"The silver-shining queen he would distain;"

Breakdown: More Metaphor and Imagery.
"silver-shining queen": Refers to the moon. The moon symbolizes purity, beauty, and light – qualities that are the opposite of Tarquin's character and intentions. This could also be referring
to Lucrece who can be seen as the pure, and silver shining queen.
"he would distain": He would defile or stain (with dishonor) the moon.

Meaning: If Tarquin were the full embodiment of Night, his wickedness would even extend to defiling something as inherently pure and beautiful as the moon. Tarquin is evil enough to stain the purity of the moon.

"Her twinkling handmaids too, by him defiled,"

Breakdown: More Metaphor and Imagery.
"Her twinkling handmaids": The stars, accompanying the moon. Again, associated with purity and light, celestial beauty.
"by him defiled": He would corrupt or stain them as well.

Meaning: Tarquin's evil would not be limited to just the most prominent symbol of purity (the moon); it would taint even the smaller, less significant aspects of goodness and light (the stars).

"Through Night's black bosom should not peep again:"

Breakdown: Personification and Imagery.
"Night's black bosom": Night is personified as a being with a bosom (chest), emphasizing the darkness and concealment it provides.
"should not peep again": The stars would be completely extinguished, never to shine through
the darkness again.

Meaning: The defilement would be so complete that even the faintest glimmer of goodness (the stars) would be extinguished, swallowed up by the all-encompassing darkness. The stars can no longer find solace in the night for Tarquin's evil has ruined it.

'Were Tarquin Night, as he is but Night's child,
The silver-shining queen he would distain;
Her twinkling handmaids too, by him defiled,
Through Night's black bosom should not peep again:
So should I have co-partners in my pain;
And fellowship in woe doth woe assuage,
As palmers' chat makes short their pilgrimage.

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"So should I have co-partners in my pain;"

Breakdown: This line shifts the focus back to Lucrece's personal suffering.
"co-partners in my pain": Others would share her suffering. If Tarquin were to defile even the Moon and stars, Lucrece would not be alone in being stained by his evil.

Meaning: Lucrece expresses a wish that others would suffer alongside her, that her pain would not be unique.

"And fellowship in woe doth woe assuage,"

Breakdown: This is a more general observation about human nature.
"fellowship in woe": Sharing suffering with others.
"doth woe assuage": Lessens or relieves the pain.

Meaning: Lucrece believes that shared suffering can alleviate the intensity of individual pain. There is a comfort in knowing you are not alone.

"As palmers' chat makes short their pilgrimage."
Breakdown: Simile.
"palmers' chat": The conversation of pilgrims (palmers were pilgrims returning from the Holy Land, carrying palm fronds).
"makes short their pilgrimage": Makes the long journey seem shorter.

Meaning: Just as the conversation of pilgrims makes a long journey seem shorter and more bearable, so too does shared suffering lessen individual pain.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza explores the overwhelming nature of Tarquin's evil and Lucrece's desire for shared suffering. Lucrece first establishes the all-encompassing nature of Tarquin's evil and her desire for companionship in suffering. The stanza argues that shared pain can make suffering more bearable, just as companionship can make a long and arduous journey feel shorter.

Literary Devices Highlighted:

Metaphor: Tarquin being "Night's child" and the moon as a "silver-shining queen."
Imagery: Vivid descriptions of the moon, stars, and "Night's black bosom" create a strong sense of darkness and purity.
Personification: Night is personified as having a "black bosom."
Hyperbole: "Were Tarquin Night" exaggerates his evil.
Simile: Comparing shared suffering to the chatter of pilgrims shortening a journey.
Alliteration: Silver-shining queen.

This stanza is a powerful expression of Lucrece's feelings of isolation and despair, and her yearning for connection and shared understanding in the face of unimaginable trauma. The image of darkness and light further emphasizes the battle between good and evil that is at the heart of the poem.
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← Stanza 113📚 OverviewStanza 115 →

Stanza 114 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 114 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line and then consider its overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Where now I have no one to blush with me,"

Where: Meaning "now that" or "since." It sets up a contrast between a past situation and the present one.
I have no one to blush with me: Lucrece laments her complete isolation. She has no one to share in her shame. The act of blushing is a physical manifestation of embarrassment and guilt. Before, she would have had members of the family to share in shaming the attacker.

"To cross their arms and hang their heads with mine,"

To cross their arms and hang their heads with mine: This describes actions of grief, shame, and mourning. Crossing arms suggests defensiveness and withdrawal; hanging the head signifies dejection and submission to shame. This line evokes the image of a community united in their response to a tragedy.

"To mask their brows and hide their infamy;"

To mask their brows and hide their infamy: Further emphasizes the desire to conceal shame. "Mask their brows" means to cover or hide their expressions, especially of shame or pain. "Infamy" refers to the disgrace or public shame caused by a terrible deed. The idea here is to
hide the shame of the whole family that's come about as a result of the rape.

"But I alone alone must sit and pine,"

But I alone alone must sit and pine: The repetition of "alone" emphasizes Lucrece's utter solitude and isolation. "Pine" means to languish, suffer, and waste away with grief. This is a pivotal line, highlighting the shift from communal shame to individual suffering.

"Seasoning the earth with showers of silver brine,"

Seasoning the earth with showers of silver brine: A highly poetic and evocative line. "Silver brine" refers to her tears (brine because of the salt), described as "silver" to emphasize their purity and preciousness. "Seasoning the earth" implies that her tears are falling onto the ground, fertilizing it with her sorrow. This is metaphorical language. It's not literal seasoning, but suggests the depth of her sadness is affecting even the world around her.

"Mingling my talk with tears, my grief with groans,"

Mingling my talk with tears, my grief with groans: This line emphasizes the overwhelming and all-encompassing nature of her grief. She can barely speak without crying, and her sorrow is constantly accompanied by groans of pain. This highlights her desperate physical state.

"Poor wasting monuments of lasting moans."

Poor wasting monuments of lasting moans: This line concludes the stanza with a sense of tragic finality. Lucrece sees herself as a "monument" – a reminder of the tragic event. "Wasting" suggests she is deteriorating, both physically and emotionally, due to her grief. "Lasting moans"

'Where now I have no one to blush with me,
To cross their arms and hang their heads with mine,
To mask their brows and hide their infamy;
But I alone alone must sit and pine,
Seasoning the earth with showers of silver brine,
Mingling my talk with tears, my grief with groans, Poor wasting monuments of lasting moans.

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suggests this sorrow will continue indefinitely. There is a sense of hopelessness here. This is also metaphorical language. She is turning into a 'monument' of grief.

Literary Devices:

Repetition: "Alone alone" emphasizes Lucrece's isolation.
Metaphor: "Seasoning the earth with showers of silver brine" compares her tears to silver brine. "Poor wasting monuments of lasting moans" compares her state to a monument.
Imagery: The stanza is rich in visual imagery, evoking images of drooping heads, masked faces, and tears falling on the ground.
Alliteration: Note the repeated 'm' sounds in "Mingling my talk with tears, my grief with groans".

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a powerful depiction of Lucrece's overwhelming grief and isolation after the rape. She mourns not only the loss of her honor but also the loss of community and the shared support she would have expected. She feels utterly alone in her suffering, left to waste away, consumed by her sorrow, and forever marked by this horrific event. The stanza conveys the depth of her despair and foreshadows her eventual suicide. It emphasizes the social consequences of rape and the devastating impact it has on the victim's sense of self and belonging.

← Stanza 113📚 OverviewStanza 115 →

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← Stanza 114📚 OverviewStanza 116 →

Stanza 115 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then synthesize its overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"O Night, thou furnace of foul-reeking smoke,"

Breakdown: The speaker directly addresses Night (an apostrophe), comparing it to a furnace (metaphor) filled with disgusting, bad-smelling smoke ("foul-reeking smoke").
Literary Devices: Apostrophe (addressing Night), Metaphor (Night as a furnace), Imagery (the unpleasant image of smoky furnace)
Meaning: Night is not presented as a comforting darkness but as a source of something unpleasant and corrupting. The "foul-reeking smoke" represents the evil deeds that occur under the cover of darkness, specifically the rape of Lucrece. The furnace imagery suggests something burning and intensely destructive.

"Let not the jealous Day behold that face"

Breakdown: The speaker begs Night to prevent the Day from seeing Lucrece's face. Day is personified here with the attribute of jealousy.
Literary Devices: Personification (Day as jealous), Alliteration (jealous Day)
Meaning: The speaker hopes to keep the shame and horror of the rape hidden. The "jealous Day" represents the revealing light of truth and justice. The idea of Day being "jealous" perhaps hints at a desire to steal the darkness's secrets or to expose the wickedness hidden within it.

"Which underneath thy black all-hiding cloak"

Breakdown: Continues to describe Lucrece, saying her face is hidden under Night's (metaphorical) cloak. Night is described as having a "black all-hiding cloak."
Literary Devices: Metaphor (Night's cloak), Imagery (the visual of being concealed)
Meaning: Reinforces the idea of secrecy and concealment. The "black all-hiding cloak"
symbolizes the protection Night offers to those committing evil deeds, but also the potential for darkness to bury and conceal the truth.

"Immodestly lies martyr'd with disgrace!"

Breakdown: Lucrece is described as lying in a state of "disgrace." She is referred to as a "martyr'd," implying suffering.
Literary Devices: Oxymoron (Immodestly lies), Imagery (visual and emotional image of Lucrece suffering)
Meaning: Lucrece is not "immodest" in the traditional sense, but rather because her body has been violated (exposed) in an act of violence. She is "martyr'd" because she has suffered greatly and innocently. The phrase creates a sense of the violation and its tragic consequences. It also foreshadows her eventual suicide.

"Keep still possession of thy gloomy place,"

Breakdown: Again, the speaker pleads with Night to stay in control of its dark realm.
Literary Devices: None obvious

'O Night, thou furnace of foul-reeking smoke,
Let not the jealous Day behold that face
Which underneath thy black all-hiding cloak
Immodestly lies martyr'd with disgrace!
Keep still possession of thy gloomy place,
That all the faults which in thy reign are made May likewise be sepulchred in thy shade!

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Meaning: This emphasizes the desire for continued secrecy and concealment. The "gloomy place" is Night's domain, a space where evil can thrive.

"That all the faults which in thy reign are made"

Breakdown: The speaker hopes that all the wrongdoings ("faults") committed during Night's "reign" will be...
Literary Devices: Metaphor (Night's reign)
Meaning: Night is treated like a ruler, and anything that happens during its rule is its responsibility.

"May likewise be sepulchred in thy shade!"

Breakdown: ...that all the wrongdoings will be buried ("sepulchred") in Night's shadow
("shade").
Literary Devices: Imagery (burial, darkness), Metaphor (shade represents concealment)
Meaning: The speaker wants the rape and its consequences to be completely hidden and
forgotten, as if buried in a tomb within the darkness. This is a wish for the crime and its shame to
be eternally concealed.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a desperate plea to Night to maintain its darkness and secrecy, not to allow the Day to reveal the horrific event that has taken place – the rape of Lucrece. The speaker wishes that the crime and its associated shame would be buried forever in the darkness. The stanza creates a sense of profound anguish and a desire to suppress the truth, driven by the overwhelming feeling of disgrace and the desire to protect Lucrece's reputation (although tragically, she will eventually choose death to resolve the shame). The powerful imagery and metaphors emphasize the destructive power of evil and the desire for concealment in the face of such a profound violation. The stanza is not about celebrating the darkness but about lamenting the fact that evil can thrive within it. It serves as a powerful condemnation of the crime and the destructive impact it has on Lucrece and, by extension, Roman society.

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← Stanza 115📚 OverviewStanza 117 →

Stanza 116 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 116 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line: Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Make me not object to the tell-tale Day!"

Meaning: Lucrece is begging (presumably Tarquin, though the stanza itself doesn't specify) not to be revealed to the light of day. "Tell-tale Day" is a personification. She fears exposure, the revealing of her shame. "Object" here means 'subject' or 'exposed'.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Giving human qualities to "Day."
Apostrophe: Addressing something (the Day) that cannot respond.
Imperative Mood: The line is a direct command, highlighting her desperation.

"The light will show, character'd in my brow,"

Meaning: She believes that the daylight will reveal the truth of what has happened written upon her face. "Character'd" means 'inscribed' or 'written'.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Comparing her face to a written record. The "characters" (letters) of guilt will be visible.

"The story of sweet chastity's decay,"

Meaning: The light will betray the loss of her precious virginity and honor. "Decay" suggests corruption and ruin.
Literary Devices:
Euphemism: "Decay" is a softer way of saying 'destruction' or 'loss', but still powerful. Alliteration: of the "s" sound in "story of sweet."

"The impious breach of holy wedlock vow:"

Meaning: It will reveal the sacrilegious violation of her marriage vows. "Impious" means lacking reverence or respect. "Breach" emphasizes the breaking of the vow.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Evokes the sanctity and importance of marriage vows.
Alliteration: of the "h" sound in "holy wedlock"

"Yea the illiterate, that know not how"

Meaning: Even the uneducated, those who cannot read written words,
Literary Devices:
Hyperbole/Exaggeration: Highlighting the idea that even those who cannot read books will
be able to "read" her face.

"To cipher what is writ in learned books,"

Meaning: who cannot decipher the meaning of complex texts

'Make me not object to the tell-tale Day!
The light will show, character'd in my brow,
The story of sweet chastity's decay,
The impious breach of holy wedlock vow:
Yea the illiterate, that know not how
To cipher what is writ in learned books,
Will quote my loathsome trespass in my looks.

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Literary Devices:
Allusion: This line is a subtle allusion to the idea that Lucrece's face will tell a story more
potent and universal than any book.

"Will quote my loathsome trespass in my looks."

Meaning: will be able to clearly see and denounce her shameful sin. "Quote" here doesn't mean recite verbatim, but rather 'interpret' or 'understand'. "Trespass" emphasizes that she has
crossed a forbidden boundary.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Powerful image of her shame being visible and being judged by everyone.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

In this stanza, Lucrece is desperately pleading to remain hidden from public view. She believes her rape has indelibly marked her, so that the shame will be etched upon her face for all to see. Even those who are uneducated and cannot read will be able to perceive her ruined honor through her appearance. She fears the public humiliation and condemnation that will inevitably follow the revelation of the crime. This stanza effectively communicates the profound sense of guilt, shame, and defilement Lucrece feels after the rape, and her dread of exposure. It demonstrates that her honor, once pure and spotless, is now perceived as tarnished beyond repair. She sees herself as a walking testament to the destruction of her virtue.

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← Stanza 116📚 OverviewStanza 118 →

Stanza 117 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 117 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece," line by line, and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"The nurse, to still her child, will tell my story,"

Breakdown: The nurse, in an effort to quiet a crying baby, will recount Lucrece's tragic tale. Meaning: This suggests Lucrece's story will become a common, cautionary tale, even used by nurses for disciplinary purposes. It highlights the widespread and long-lasting impact of the event.

"And fright her crying babe with Tarquin's name;"

Breakdown: The nurse will scare the baby by invoking Tarquin's name.
Meaning: This reinforces the idea that Tarquin's name will become synonymous with evil and terror. It shows the extreme negativity associated with his actions. We can also see that this could serve as an early kind of 'boogeyman' tale.

"The orator, to deck his oratory,"

Breakdown: The public speaker, to embellish and improve his speech.
Meaning: Orators, when giving speeches, will use Lucrece's story as an example in order to give weight to their arguments.

"Will couple my reproach to Tarquin's shame;"

Breakdown: Will link Lucrece's dishonor with Tarquin's disgrace.
Meaning: The orator will use the story to emphasize the contrast between Lucrece's innocence and Tarquin's guilt, highlighting the injustice she suffered. This implies Lucrece's story will be used as an example of injustice and virtue.

"Feast-finding minstrels, tuning my defame,"

Breakdown: Minstrels (traveling singers/musicians) who seek out feasts and celebrations will create songs about Lucrece's dishonor. They are 'tuning' (arranging or creating) the story of her 'defame' (loss of reputation).
Meaning: This emphasizes how Lucrece's story will be popularized and spread through entertainment. However, there's a subtle nuance: "tuning my defame" suggests the minstrels are not necessarily glorifying her, but rather using her tragedy for entertainment value. While spreading the story, they are still dealing with the 'defame' aspect - the damage to her reputation.

"Will tie the hearers to attend each line,"

Breakdown: The minstrels' songs will captivate the audience and hold their attention on every word.

Meaning: This shows the powerful and engaging nature of the story. The audience will be drawn in and deeply affected by the tale of Lucrece. It also implies that the story has inherent dramatic appeal.

'The nurse, to still her child, will tell my story,
And fright her crying babe with Tarquin's name;
The orator, to deck his oratory,
Will couple my reproach to Tarquin's shame;
Feast-finding minstrels, tuning my defame,
Will tie the hearers to attend each line,
How Tarquin wronged me, I Collatine.

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"How Tarquin wronged me, I Collatine."

Breakdown: How Tarquin committed a wrong against me, Lucrece, wife of Collatine.
Meaning: This is a direct, simple statement that reinforces the personal aspect of the tragedy
and identifies the victim and the perpetrator. The mention of "Collatine" connects her tragedy to her husband, and implies the damage and shame Tarquin has brought upon him too.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza paints a picture of Lucrece's story becoming a widespread, legendary tale, used for moral instruction, political rhetoric, and entertainment. It emphasizes the enduring power of the story and the lasting impact of Tarquin's crime. Lucrece's name and story will become synonymous with innocence violated and injustice, while Tarquin's name will be associated with evil and shame. However, there's a subtle layer of complexity: the minstrels' "tuning my defame" suggests that, while the story is being spread, the focus may still be on her dishonor, even if indirectly. This acknowledges the complex and often unfair way women's stories, especially those involving sexual violence, are treated.

Literary Devices:

Foreshadowing: The entire stanza foreshadows the long-term consequences of Tarquin's actions and the enduring nature of Lucrece's story.
Imagery: The stanza evokes vivid images: a crying baby being hushed, an orator passionately declaiming, minstrels singing to a captivated audience.
Synecdoche: Perhaps "The nurse" could be seen as synecdoche, representing the wider female community who will perpetuate the story.
Contrast: The stanza emphasizes the contrast between Lucrece's innocence and Tarquin's guilt, and between her reputation and his shame.
Alliteration: "Feast-finding" uses alliteration to make that particular line more memorable.
Irony: There's a degree of irony in the minstrels "tuning my defame." Lucrece is already defamed, yet the act of telling her story, even with good intentions, still risks focusing on that aspect.

In essence, this stanza highlights how Lucrece's personal tragedy transforms into a public and enduring narrative, shaping the moral and political landscape of Rome, but it does so with a nuanced acknowledgement of the potential for that narrative to perpetuate the very injustice it seeks to condemn.

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← Stanza 117📚 OverviewStanza 119 →

Stanza 118 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 118 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line, highlighting literary devices, and then provide an overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Let my good name, that senseless reputation,"

Meaning: Lucrece is calling her "good name" or reputation something "senseless" because it is now ruined. She is dismissing it as something meaningless now that she has been raped. Literary Devices:
Apostrophe: Lucrece is directly addressing her "good name," which is an abstract concept. Epithet: "Senseless" is an epithet modifying "reputation."
Metaphor: The "good name" represents her social standing and honour, but it is also a "senseless reputation" as she now values truth above societal perception.

"For Collatine's dear love be kept unspotted:"

Meaning: She hopes that Collatine's love for her will remain pure and untainted, despite what
has happened to her. She wants him to continue to value her despite her tarnished reputation. Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the 'd' sound in "dear love" adds emphasis.
Irony: There's a deep irony here. She's concerned about his love being "unspotted" when she's the one who has been physically violated.

"If that be made a theme for disputation,"

Meaning: If her situation becomes a subject of debate or argument. She's anticipating that people will discuss and judge what has happened.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The 't' sound in "theme" connects the words and emphasises the importance of the concept.

"The branches of another root are rotted,"

Meaning: The "branches of another root" are a metaphor for Collatine's reputation, lineage, or family. If Lucrece's reputation is questioned, it will damage him and his family as well.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The "branches of another root" are not literally rotting; it is a symbolic representation of the damage to Collatine and his family's reputation.
Synecdoche: "Branches" can be seen as a synecdoche, where a part (branches) represents the whole (the tree/family).

"And undeserved reproach to him allotted"

Meaning: Collatine will be unfairly blamed or criticised. He'll suffer the consequences of something he didn't do.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the 'r' sound in "reproach" adds emphasis.

' Let my good name, that senseless reputation,
For Collatine's dear love be kept unspotted:
If that be made a theme for disputation,
The branches of another root are rotted,
And undeserved reproach to him allotted
That is as clear from this attaint of mine
As I, ere this, was pure to Collatine.

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"That is as clear from this attaint of mine"

Meaning: Collatine is as innocent of this crime (the rape) as she is. "Attaint" means stain or dishonour.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Attaint" is a metaphor for the stain of dishonour.

"As I, ere this, was pure to Collatine."

Meaning: Just as she was pure and faithful to Collatine before the rape, Collatine is completely innocent of the crime. This emphasises her innocence and Collatine's innocence.
Literary Devices:
Simile: Using "as" to compare her past purity to Collatine's innocence.
Irony: Now that she is raped, her idea of "purity" has forever been tainted and changed.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece is deeply concerned about the impact of her rape on Collatine's reputation and love for her. She believes that if her good name is questioned or debated, it will inevitably damage Collatine and his family's honour. She insists that he is as innocent of this crime as she once was pure in her love for him.

The stanza reveals Lucrece's noble character. Even in her own suffering, she is thinking about the consequences for her husband and his family. She wants to protect him from the scandal and shame that will result from her rape, recognising that his reputation will also be tainted by the event. The use of metaphors like "branches of another root" and "attaint" creates a powerful image of the potential for reputational damage and highlights the unfairness of the situation for Collatine.

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← Stanza 118📚 OverviewStanza 120 →

Stanza 119 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 119 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, and then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"O unseen shame! invisible disgrace!"

Analysis: This line sets the tone with a powerful exclamatory cry. The shame Lucrece feels after the rape is not something tangible or visible to the public. It is deeply internal and personal, therefore "unseen" and "invisible." "Disgrace" is a synonym, emphasizing the social damage the event has caused, even if no one knows about it yet.
Literary Devices: Apostrophe (addressing the abstract concepts of shame and disgrace), Exclamation, Parallelism (similar structure and meaning).

"O unfelt sore! crest-wounding, private scar!"

Analysis: Here, the feeling of shame is compared to a wound. However, this wound is "unfelt" in a physical sense; it is a deep emotional and psychological injury. "Crest-wounding" implies that it damages a person's reputation, honor, or pride (the "crest" symbolizing nobility and status). The "private scar" reinforces the idea that the wound is hidden and personal.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (comparing shame to a wound and scar), Alliteration ("crest-wounding").

"Reproach is stamp'd in Collatinus' face,"

Analysis: This line shifts the focus to Lucrece's husband, Collatinus. Even though he is unaware of the specific details of the rape at this point in the narrative, Lucrece feels that the shame and dishonor are somehow visible in his face, as if marked or "stamped" there. The word "reproach" refers to the shame and blame associated with a wrongdoing.
Literary Devices: Imagery (the image of "reproach" being stamped), Synecdoche (Collatinus' "face" represents his entire being and reputation).

"And Tarquin's eye may read the mot afar,"

Analysis: This refers to Tarquin, the rapist. Lucrece imagines that even from a distance ("afar"), Tarquin's sharp and knowing gaze ("eye") would be able to discern the message ("mot") of Collatinus's wounded honor. The "mot" is the unspoken truth of the violation.
Literary Devices: Metonymy (Tarquin's "eye" represents Tarquin's awareness and perception), Imagery.

"How he in peace is wounded, not in war."

Analysis: This explains the "mot" or message that Tarquin's eye can read. Collatinus has been injured and dishonored in a situation of peace and trust, not in honorable battle or war. This emphasizes the treachery and unexpected nature of Tarquin's act.
Literary Devices: Irony (war is typically associated with wounds, but here, peace is the setting for the injury), Juxtaposition (contrasting "peace" and "war").

'O unseen shame! invisible disgrace!
O unfelt sore! crest-wounding, private scar!
Reproach is stamp'd in Collatinus' face,
And Tarquin's eye may read the mot afar,
How he in peace is wounded, not in war.
Alas, how many bear such shameful blows,
Which not themselves, but he that gives them knows!

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"Alas, how many bear such shameful blows,"

Analysis: This line broadens the scope. It is a lament ("Alas") about the fact that many people endure similar "shameful blows" - secret wounds and violations that impact their lives and honor. This connects Lucrece's personal tragedy to a more universal suffering.
Literary Devices: Exclamation, Rhetorical question.

"Which not themselves, but he that gives them knows!"

Analysis: This final line highlights the secrecy and loneliness of the victim's experience. The
victims suffer silently, but only the perpetrator truly understands the full extent of the damage
they have caused. This underscores the power imbalance between victim and abuser.
Literary Devices: Irony (the perpetrator knows more about the victim's suffering than the victim might even realize), Understatement (downplaying the severity of the act by simply saying "he that gives them knows!" instead of describing the impact).

Overall Meaning:

Stanza 119 encapsulates the profound and hidden consequences of the rape. It explores the internal shame and disgrace Lucrece feels, the damage to Collatinus's honor, and the contrast between outward appearances and inner reality. The stanza also emphasizes the isolating nature of the experience, where the victim suffers in silence, while the perpetrator holds the knowledge of the deed. It shifts from Lucrece's personal pain to a broader meditation on the widespread occurrence of such secret traumas, making it a powerful and haunting reflection on the nature of honor, shame, and abuse. It also highlights the imbalance of power and the perpetrator's sole awareness of the full extent of the damage caused. The stanza establishes a sense of injustice and foreshadows the tragic events to come.

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Stanza 120 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down stanza 120 of The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"If, Collatine, thine honour lay in me,"
Breakdown: Lucrece addresses her husband, Collatine. She states that if his honor was
dependent on her chastity and purity.
Literary Device: This line sets up a conditional statement. It immediately highlights the societal belief that a husband's honor is tied to his wife's sexual purity.

"From me by strong assault it is bereft."
Breakdown: She declares that this honor, which was residing within her (i.e., her chastity), has been violently taken away from her by force (the "strong assault" of Tarquin). "Bereft" means deprived or robbed.
Literary Device: Euphemism (implied rather than explicit discussion of the rape). Understatement and Irony - uses words like 'bereft' instead of harsher terms to describe rape.

"My honour lost, and I, a drone-like bee,"
Breakdown: Because her chastity is gone, Lucrece compares herself to a "drone-like bee." A drone bee is male, sterile, and doesn't contribute to the work of the hive (making honey, protecting it).
Literary Devices: Simile (using "like"), Metaphor (Lucrece is the bee), Alliteration (drone-like)

"Have no perfection of my summer left,"
Breakdown: "Summer" symbolizes the prime of her life, her beauty, her purpose, and her happiness. She feels that all the best parts of her are now ruined and gone due to the rape. She lacks the "perfection" that her honor gave her.
Literary Device: Metaphor (Summer = her prime), Synecdoche (Summer stands in for the whole season)

"But robb'd and ransack'd by injurious theft:"
Breakdown: Emphasizes the violation and the extent of the damage. She has not just been robbed, but utterly "ransack'd." "Injurious theft" is a powerful way to describe the act, emphasizing that it caused her harm and was an unjust and illegal taking.
Literary Devices: Repetition (reinforces the action), tautology (Robbed and Ransacked), Alliteration (robb'd, ransack'd).

"In thy weak hive a wandering wasp hath crept,"
Breakdown: Here, Collatine's household and his own person are metaphorically the "weak hive." A "wandering wasp" (Tarquin) has infiltrated this vulnerable space. Wasps are predators of bees and their honey.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (hive=household, wasp=Tarquin)

"And suck'd the honey which thy chaste bee kept."
Breakdown: The "honey" is her chastity, which Lucrece, the "chaste bee," was protecting.
Tarquin has stolen this "honey." The verb "suck'd" emphasizes the predatory and parasitic nature of Tarquin's act.

' If, Collatine, thine honour lay in me,
From me by strong assault it is bereft.
My honour lost, and I, a drone-like bee,
Have no perfection of my summer left,
But robb'd and ransack'd by injurious theft:
In thy weak hive a wandering wasp hath crept, And suck'd the honey which thy chaste bee kept.

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Literary Devices: Metaphor ("honey" = chastity), Imagery (vivid, disturbing image of the wasp and honey).

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece expresses the devastating impact of the rape on her, her husband, and their marriage. She believes her rape has robbed Collatine of his honor, which society placed upon her. She describes herself as useless and incomplete, like a drone bee, having lost her "perfection" and the prime of her life. She uses the metaphor of the "hive" and "bee" to illustrate the intrusion of Tarquin (the wasp) and the theft of her chastity ("honey"). The stanza emphasizes the violence of the act and the lasting damage it has inflicted, not only on Lucrece but also on the foundation of her marriage. It reflects the patriarchal society's view of female chastity as a valuable commodity belonging to the husband.

Key Literary Devices Summed Up:

Metaphor: Used extensively throughout to compare Lucrece to a bee, Collatine's household to a hive, Tarquin to a wasp, and her chastity to honey.
Simile: "drone-like bee"
Euphemism: The use of "bereft" and other gentler terms to describe the violent act of rape. Imagery: Vivid images of the hive, bee, wasp, and honey create a strong impression on the reader. Alliteration: "drone-like," "robb'd and ransack'd"
Irony - The situation is the very opposite of how it should be, honour is now dishonour.
Repetition - Robbed
Synecdoche - Summer stands in for the whole season of her life.
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← Stanza 120📚 OverviewStanza 122 →

Stanza 121 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 121 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece: Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Yet am I guilty of thy honour's wrack;"

"Yet": Indicates a continuation of thought, even a contradiction or twist on what came before. "I": Lucrece is speaking (or, more accurately, her internal monologue is being presented). "guilty of thy honour's wrack": She feels responsible for the destruction ("wrack") of her husband's honor ("thy honour"). The word "wrack" suggests a violent shattering.
Literary Device: Alliteration: The 'wr' sound emphasizes the violence and destruction. "Yet for thy honour did I entertain him;"

"Yet": Again, a contrast.
"for thy honour": Intended to uphold or show respect for her husband's honor.
"did I entertain him": She offered Collatine's friend, Tarquin, hospitality as a guest. Literary Device: Irony: Her intention to protect her husband's honor is precisely what led to its destruction.

"Coming from thee, I could not put him back,"

"Coming from thee": Because Tarquin was a messenger or friend from her husband (Collatine). "I could not put him back": She felt obliged to welcome him because of his connection to Collatine. She felt it would be rude to turn away someone he had sent.
Literary Device: Reason/Justification: Lucrece explains why she allowed Tarquin to enter.
"For it had been dishonour to disdain him:"

"For it had been dishonour": It would have been considered impolite or a breach of hospitality to reject him.
"to disdain him": To reject or treat him with contempt.
Literary Device: Repetition/Parallelism: Reinforces the importance of honor and appearance in the social context.

"Besides, of weariness he did complain him,"

"Besides": In addition to the obligation of hospitality.
"of weariness he did complain him": Tarquin claimed to be tired from his journey. The archaic phrasing "complain him" suggests he was vocal about his exhaustion.
Literary Device: Characterization: Shows Tarquin's manipulative behavior, using fatigue as a way to gain sympathy and entry.

"And talk'd of virtue: O unlook'd-for evil,"

"And talk'd of virtue": Tarquin deceptively spoke of virtuous principles and values.
"O unlook'd-for evil": An exclamation expressing her shock and horror at the unexpected turn of events.

'Yet am I guilty of thy honour's wrack;
Yet for thy honour did I entertain him;
Coming from thee, I could not put him back,
For it had been dishonour to disdain him:
Besides, of weariness he did complain him, And talk'd of virtue: O unlook'd-for evil, When virtue is profaned in such a devil!

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Literary Device: Juxtaposition/Contrast: The contrast between Tarquin's words ("virtue") and
his actions ("evil") highlights the hypocrisy and treachery of his character.

"When virtue is profaned in such a devil!"

"When virtue is profaned": When goodness is corrupted or desecrated.
"in such a devil!": By a person so evil and wicked (Tarquin). Lucrece is condemning Tarquin as a demonic figure.
Literary Device: Metaphor: Tarquin is likened to a "devil," emphasizing his inherent wickedness. Exclamation: Emphasizes Lucrece's horror.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece is wrestling with her guilt and trying to understand how she became complicit in the events that led to her rape. She justifies her initial actions – entertaining Tarquin – by emphasizing the importance of honor, hospitality, and social obligations. She believed she was acting virtuously by showing kindness to a guest who claimed to be a friend of her husband. However, she now realizes that Tarquin's outward display of virtue was a deceptive mask for his evil intentions. The stanza expresses Lucrece's horror and despair at the realization that her well-intentioned actions have been manipulated and that virtue itself has been profaned by Tarquin's wickedness. She sees Tarquin as a devil, highlighting the depth of his depravity.

The stanza showcases the dangers of misplaced trust and the devastating consequences that can arise when appearances are deceiving. Lucrece is trapped in a situation where adherence to social norms and expectations ultimately led to the violation of her own honor.

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← Stanza 121📚 OverviewStanza 123 →

Stanza 122 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 122 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Why should the worm intrude the maiden bud?"

Meaning: This is a rhetorical question. Why should something vile (the worm) invade something pure and innocent (the maiden bud, representing Lucrece's virginity and potential)? The "bud"
has a symbolic connection to feminine purity.
Literary Device(s):
Metaphor: "Maiden bud" is a metaphor for Lucrece's innocence and untouched state. Symbolism: Worm is symbolic of decay, corruption, and evil.

"Or hateful cuckoos hatch in sparrows' nests?"

Meaning: Another rhetorical question. Cuckoos are known for laying their eggs in other birds' nests (like sparrows') forcing the sparows to raise their young. Why should treachery (cuckoo's parasitic behaviour) violate the natural order of things?
Literary Device(s):
Analogy: It's an analogy for Tarquin's betrayal and usurpation of Lucrece's honour and
Collatine's trust.
Symbolism: Cuckoos are symbolic of treachery and usurpation. Sparrows represent innocence and vulnerability.
"Or toads infect fair founts with venom mud?"

Meaning: Yet another rhetorical question. Why should something ugly and poisonous (toads and venom mud) contaminate something beautiful and life-giving (fair founts – springs or fountains, representing purity and life)?
Literary Device(s):
Metaphor: "Fair founts" can be a metaphor for Lucrece's virtuous nature.
Symbolism: Toads and venom mud symbolize corruption, ugliness, and poison.

"Or tyrant folly lurk in gentle breasts?"

Meaning: Why should foolishness or tyranny (Tarquin's lustful and destructive impulse) exist within those of noble character? "Gentle breasts" refers to both the emotional centre of a kind person, and also the more literal association with women and their traditional representation as innocent and virtuous.
Literary Device(s):
Metaphor: "Gentle breasts" is a metaphor for people of good character.
Personification: "Tyrant folly" is personified as something that can "lurk."

"Or kings be breakers of their own behests?"

Meaning: Why should rulers (kings), who are supposed to uphold justice and order, violate their own laws and oaths (bestests)? This refers specifically to Tarquin's violation of his social role and his oath as a guest to Collatine.

'Why should the worm intrude the maiden bud?
Or hateful cuckoos hatch in sparrows' nests?
Or toads infect fair founts with venom mud?
Or tyrant folly lurk in gentle breasts?
Or kings be breakers of their own behests? But no perfection is so absolute,
That some impurity doth not pollute.

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Literary Device(s):
Irony: Kings are supposed to be upholders of law and morality, not breakers of them.

"But no perfection is so absolute,"

Meaning: A statement that no state of perfection is entirely immune to corruption or imperfection.
Literary Device(s):
Generalization: A broad statement about the nature of perfection.

"That some impurity doth not pollute."

Meaning: Continues the idea that imperfection inevitably taints even the most perfect things. Literary Device(s):
Alliteration: The repetition of the 'p' sound in "purity" and "pollute" emphasizes the
relationship between the two concepts.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

The stanza explores the universal presence of evil and corruption in the world. It poses a series of rhetorical questions asking why innocence, virtue, and order are so easily violated by base impulses and moral failings. The stanza suggests that no matter how perfect something seems, it is always vulnerable to being corrupted. It sets the stage for understanding the tragedy that befalls Lucrece, showing that even she, a paragon of virtue, cannot escape the pervasive presence of evil.

Key Literary Devices Employed:

Rhetorical Questions: The primary device used to express the poet's lament and to engage the reader in contemplating the injustice of the events.
Metaphor: Used to represent abstract concepts like innocence, virtue, and corruption in concrete terms.

Symbolism: The worm, cuckoo, toads, and founts all act as powerful symbols representing decay, treachery, corruption, and purity.
Analogy: The examples drawn from nature (cuckoo in sparrow's nest) help the reader understand the violation that Lucrece is about to experience.
Irony: The idea of a king breaking his own laws highlights the betrayal of trust and the perversion of order.
Alliteration: Adds emphasis and musicality to the lines.

In essence, this stanza is a philosophical reflection on the nature of evil and its ability to undermine even the most seemingly perfect and virtuous aspects of life. It foreshadows the tragedy to come and invites the reader to ponder the inevitable presence of corruption in the world.
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← Stanza 122📚 OverviewStanza 124 →

Stanza 123 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 123 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line:

Line 1: 'The aged man that coffers-up his gold'

"The aged man": A stereotype of an old miser.
"that coffers-up his gold": "Coffers-up" means to hoard or store away in chests (coffers). This paints a picture of someone obsessively accumulating wealth.
Literary Device: Imagery, emphasizing the act of hoarding.

Line 2: 'Is plagued with cramps and gouts and painful fits;'

"Is plagued": Afflicted, burdened, suggesting the miser's wealth doesn't bring happiness, but suffering.
"with cramps and gouts and painful fits": Specific physical ailments associated with old age and, metaphorically, the stress and anxiety of guarding wealth. Gout was particularly associated with the rich due to rich foods, meaning more of a symbolic burden of his lifestyle.
Literary Device: Specific Detail, creates vividness, and establishes a contrast between the expected comfort of wealth and the reality of suffering. Also, Alliteration ("painful fits") adds emphasis.

Line 3: 'And scarce hath eyes his treasure to behold,'

"And scarce hath eyes": Almost blind, either literally due to age or figuratively because his focus is so consumed by his treasure that he can barely appreciate it.
"his treasure to behold": He can't even properly enjoy the sight of his wealth.
Literary Device: Irony. The man possesses wealth but is unable to enjoy it, highlighting the futility of hoarding.

Line 4: 'But like still-pining Tantalus he sits,'

"But like still-pining Tantalus he sits": A classical allusion to the Greek myth of Tantalus, who was punished in the underworld by being forever within reach of food and water but unable to partake of them. "Still-pining" means constantly longing.
Literary Device: Classical Allusion. This is a powerful comparison, elevating the miser's suffering to a legendary scale. Also, Simile ("like") creates a direct comparison to Tantalus.

Line 5: 'And useless barns the harvest of his wits;'

"And useless barns": The barns here are symbolic. Like the barns of a farmer are filled with harvest, so too this man's barns are filled with the harvest of his labor and intelligence.
"the harvest of his wits": A Metaphor. "Harvest of his wits" means the result of his intellectual efforts, all the things he has accomplished and achieved through his intelligence.
Literary Device: Metaphor. The barns filled with harvest suggest the man has wasted his intelligence on merely acquiring treasure.

Line 6: 'Having no other pleasure of his gain'

"Having no other pleasure of his gain": States directly that the man gets no genuine enjoyment from his wealth.

'The aged man that coffers-up his gold
Is plagued with cramps and gouts and painful fits;
And scarce hath eyes his treasure to behold,
But like still-pining Tantalus he sits,
And useless barns the harvest of his wits;
Having no other pleasure of his gain
But torment that it cannot cure his pain.

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Literary Device: None. Clear and concise statement of the predicament.

Line 7: 'But torment that it cannot cure his pain.'

"But torment that it cannot cure his pain": The final, damning indictment. The wealth, instead of relieving suffering, becomes a source of it. It cannot alleviate the physical and existential pain of his existence.
Literary Device: Irony and Paradox. The expected use of wealth (to alleviate pain) is reversed, creating a painful irony. The fact that the miser's wealth is a torment is a paradox.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza argues that the obsessive pursuit and hoarding of wealth is ultimately a futile and self-destructive endeavor. The miser, despite possessing riches, is miserable. He is physically ill, can't appreciate his wealth, and is perpetually tormented by the fear of losing it or the inability to truly enjoy it. The allusion to Tantalus reinforces the idea that the wealth is tantalizingly close but ultimately unattainable in terms of providing genuine happiness. The stanza emphasizes the idea that true fulfillment comes from something other than material possessions, suggesting that the man has wasted his life and intellect in pursuit of a goal that ultimately leaves him empty and in pain. The wealth, instead of being a source of comfort, becomes another source of suffering. The point is that the miser's obsessive pursuit of wealth has not brought him happiness or contentment, but rather misery and torment.

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← Stanza 123📚 OverviewStanza 125 →

Stanza 124 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Shakespeare's Stanza 124 from The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"So then he hath it when he cannot use it,"

Meaning: "He" (Tarquin, implied from the context of the poem) possesses power or fortune, but
is unable to properly enjoy or utilize it. The "it" could be interpreted as his kingship, his social standing, or even the ill-gotten satisfaction he seeks through the rape of Lucrece. He's consumed by guilt and shame, rendering the possession hollow.
Literary Devices: Pronoun ambiguity (he is not clearly defined as Tarquin directly).

"And leaves it to be master'd by his young;"

Meaning: Tarquin's power and the consequences of his actions will be inherited by his children. He will leave his legacy and fortune (and also a society ripe for revolt due to his actions) to his sons. "Master'd" implies both inheritance and potential control/domination.
Literary Devices: Implied Foreshadowing: Hints at the future consequences of Tarquin's actions on his family.

"Who in their pride do presently abuse it:"

Meaning: Tarquin's children, fueled by arrogance ("pride"), will quickly misuse or corrupt the power they inherit. They will not learn from their father's mistakes and will continue the cycle of abuse.

Literary Devices: Characterization: Highlights the negative qualities (pride, abuse) of the next generation. Alliteration: the repeated 'p' sound in 'pride do presently'

"Their father was too weak, and they too strong,"

Meaning: Tarquin was too weak (morally, spiritually) to control his desires and impulses. His sons, by contrast, will be too "strong" (in the sense of being tyrannical and ruthless) in their use of power. This highlights a generational failing of moderation and self-control.
Literary Devices: Antithesis: "weak" versus "strong" creates a direct contrast between father and sons.

"To hold their cursed-blessed fortune long."

Meaning: Neither the father (Tarquin) nor his sons will be able to maintain their "fortune" (kingdom, power) for an extended period of time because of their actions. The "cursed-blessed" paradox shows the duality of their position. Their fortune is a source of power and privilege (blessed) but is tainted by immorality and destined to bring downfall (cursed).
Literary Devices: Oxymoron: "cursed-blessed" is a contradiction that creates a complex meaning. Foreshadowing: Again, the stanza hints at the ultimate overthrow of Tarquin's dynasty, foreshadowing the Roman Republic.

"The sweets we wish for turn to loathed sours"

Meaning: The pleasures we desire ("sweets") eventually become distasteful and hateful
("loathed sours"). This is a universal observation about the ephemeral and often disappointing

' So then he hath it when he cannot use it,
And leaves it to be master'd by his young;
Who in their pride do presently abuse it:
Their father was too weak, and they too strong,
To hold their cursed-blessed fortune long.
The sweets we wish for turn to loathed sours Even in the moment that we call them ours.

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nature of worldly desires. Implies that ill gotten gains or immoral actions, which may at first seem pleasurable, will ultimately turn bitter.
Literary Devices: Metaphor: Compares desires to flavors, highlighting the changing nature of satisfaction.

"Even in the moment that we call them ours."

Meaning: This line emphasizes the fleeting and deceptive nature of pleasure. The moment we think we have fully possessed and enjoyed something, it can turn sour.
Literary Devices: Emphasis: Underscores the transience of happiness. Paradox: The paradox is that the moment we claim something "ours," its value can diminish or its negative consequences can begin to manifest.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza is a reflection on the nature of power, desire, and inheritance. It argues that ill-gotten gains and unchecked ambition are ultimately self-destructive. Tarquin's lust and abuse of power will have far-reaching consequences, affecting his sons, his dynasty, and, ultimately, the fate of Rome. The stanza serves as a warning about the dangers of unchecked power and the ultimate futility of pursuing pleasure at the expense of morality. It also explores the idea that happiness is fleeting and that the things we desire most can ultimately bring us the greatest disappointment. The cursed and blessed aspect of fortune also reinforces the idea that power can be a source of both great good and great evil, and that it is the responsibility of those who wield it to use it wisely.

Key Literary Devices Summary:

Pronoun ambiguity: Unclear pronoun reference forces reader engagement.
Foreshadowing: Hints at future events and consequences.
Characterization: Reveals the flaws and potential downfall of characters.
Antithesis: Contrasting ideas highlight opposing forces.
Oxymoron: Juxtaposes contradictory terms to create complex meaning.
Metaphor: Uses figurative language to represent abstract concepts.
Emphasis: Underlines important themes and ideas.
Paradox: Presents seemingly contradictory statements that reveal a deeper truth.
Alliteration Repeated 'p' sound to empahsize words.

This stanza encapsulates a central theme of The Rape of Lucrece: the destructive consequences of lust, the corruption of power, and the cyclical nature of violence and abuse. It highlights the importance of moral responsibility and the fleeting nature of worldly pleasures.
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← Stanza 124📚 OverviewStanza 126 →

Stanza 125 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 125 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then put it all together to understand its overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Unruly blasts wait on the tender spring;"

Breakdown: "Unruly blasts" refers to violent, destructive winds. "Tender spring" represents the delicate and vulnerable season of new growth and hope. "Wait on" means attend or are present,
but in a potentially threatening way.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The spring is a metaphor for something delicate, new, and easily harmed. Personification: The blasts "wait on" the spring, giving them a human-like intention. Juxtaposition: The "unruly blasts" and "tender spring" are sharply contrasted, highlighting the vulnerability of goodness to corruption.

"Unwholesome weeds take root with precious flowers;"

Breakdown: "Unwholesome weeds" symbolizes evil or negative influences. "Precious flowers" represent virtue, beauty, and goodness. The weeds thriving alongside the flowers shows that evil and good can coexist and even compete.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Weeds and flowers are metaphors for negativity and positivity respectively. Juxtaposition: Contrasting good and evil, similar to the previous line.
Alliteration: The repetition of "w" in "unwholesome weeds" emphasizes the negative aspect.

"The adder hisses where the sweet birds sing;"

Breakdown: "Adder" (a poisonous snake) represents danger, deceit, and malice. "Sweet birds" represent innocence, joy, and harmony. The hissing of the adder interrupting the birdsong represents the intrusion of evil into a place of peace.
Literary Devices:
Symbolism: The adder and the birds are symbolic of evil and good.
Auditory Imagery: "Hisses" and "sing" create contrasting sound images.

"What virtue breeds iniquity devours:"

Breakdown: "Virtue" is goodness, morality, and integrity. "Iniquity" is wickedness, injustice, and evil. This line states directly that evil consumes or destroys the things that virtue creates. Literary Devices:
Personification: Iniquity "devours", which gives it a destructive agency.
Aphorism: This line is a concise and insightful statement about the nature of good and evil.

"We have no good that we can say is ours,"

Breakdown: This is a statement of despair and vulnerability. It suggests that anything good we possess is not truly secure and can be taken away.

' Unruly blasts wait on the tender spring;
Unwholesome weeds take root with precious flowers;
The adder hisses where the sweet birds sing;
What virtue breeds iniquity devours:
We have no good that we can say is ours,
But ill-annexed Opportunity
Or kills his life or else his quality.

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Literary Devices:
Hyperbole: The statement may be an exaggeration of the extent to which we are vulnerable, however it still conveys a strong feeling of helplessness.

"But ill-annexed Opportunity"

Breakdown: "Ill-annexed Opportunity" refers to a chance or situation that is wrongly or unfortunately connected to something else. It suggests that the only opportunities we seem to have are those that are attached to something negative or dangerous.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Opportunity is given an attachment and therefore agency.
Euphemism: "Ill-annexed Opportunity" is a veiled way of expressing that opportunities are dangerous.

"Or kills his life or else his quality."

Breakdown: "Kills his life" is a straightforward reference to physical death. "Kills his quality" refers to the destruction of one's character, reputation, or essential goodness. The line states that even the opportunities that seem to be available can destroy us either physically or morally. Literary Devices:
Parallelism: The structure "kills his life or else his quality" creates a balanced and emphatic statement.

Irony: The idea of "opportunity" leading to death or degradation is deeply ironic.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza expresses a profound sense of pessimism and vulnerability in the face of evil. It argues that goodness is constantly threatened by destructive forces, that evil can corrupt and destroy even the most virtuous things, and that true security and possession of good are illusory. The stanza suggests that opportunity itself is dangerous, leading either to physical death or to the corruption of one's character. Ultimately, the stanza paints a bleak picture of a world where evil prevails and goodness is fragile and easily overcome. This ties into the central themes of The Rape of Lucrece, as Lucrece's virtue is destroyed through a violent act of evil.

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← Stanza 125📚 OverviewStanza 127 →

Stanza 126 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 126 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then consider the overall meaning, paying attention to the literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: 'O Opportunity, thy guilt is great!'

Analysis: This is a direct apostrophe, an address to an inanimate object or abstract concept as if
it were a person who could hear and respond. The speaker is directly accusing Opportunity of
being greatly guilty. It establishes a strong emotional tone of blame and condemnation.
Meaning: Opportunity is being personified and blamed for enabling the horrors that are to come
(i.e. the rape).

Line 2: 'Tis thou that executest the traitor's treason:'

Analysis: This line continues the personification and reinforces Opportunity's role as an active agent. Treason is usually committed by someone, yet here it is said that "Opportunity" executes it. The use of "traitor's treason" is an example of tautology or redundancy, emphasizing the evilness of the act.

Meaning: Opportunity is not just a passive factor; it actively carries out the plans of evil-doers. It makes the wrongdoer's vile intentions a reality.

Line 3: 'Thou set'st the wolf where he the lamb may get;'

Analysis: This line employs a metaphor. The "wolf" represents a predator (Tarquin) and the "lamb" represents vulnerability and innocence (Lucrece). It's a powerful, easily understood image of predator and prey.
Meaning: Opportunity provides the circumstances in which the strong and ruthless can take advantage of the weak and innocent. Opportunity facilitates the act of the villain preying on the virtuous.

Line 4: 'Whoever plots the sin, thou 'point'st the season;'

Analysis: This continues the personification of Opportunity and emphasizes its crucial role in the timing and execution of evil. The word "'point'st" (appointest) suggests a deliberate and active choosing of the right time for the sin to occur.
Meaning: It doesn't matter who plans the evil deed; Opportunity determines when and where it can be carried out successfully. It is the crucial element, making the execution of the plan possible.

Line 5: 'Tis thou that spurn'st at right, at law, at reason;'

Analysis: This uses polysyndeton, the repetition of the conjunction "at," to emphasize the
extent to which Opportunity disregards all forms of morality and order. "Right, law, and reason" represent the pillars of a just society.
Meaning: Opportunity is utterly indifferent to justice, the established order, and logical thought. It dismisses all moral boundaries in favor of achieving its goals.

'O Opportunity, thy guilt is great!
'Tis thou that executest the traitor's treason:
Thou set'st the wolf where he the lamb may get;
Whoever plots the sin, thou 'point'st the season;
'Tis thou that spurn'st at right, at law, at reason;
And in thy shady cell, where none may spy him,
Sits Sin, to seize the souls that wander by him.

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Line 6: 'And in thy shady cell, where none may spy him,'

Analysis: The "shady cell" is a metaphor for the secret, hidden places where evil thrives. The phrase "where none may spy him" suggests secrecy and concealment. The indefinite reference to "him" could refer back to the "traitor" or the "wolf" from earlier lines.
Meaning: Opportunity provides a secret and protected environment where evil can flourish without being seen or judged.

Line 7: 'Sits Sin, to seize the souls that wander by him.'

Analysis: This line concludes the stanza with another personification. Sin itself is personified as a figure sitting in wait, ready to capture unsuspecting "souls that wander by." There's a sense of predation and moral danger. The imagery echoes the wolf/lamb metaphor from earlier.
Meaning: Opportunity creates the environment where sin can easily trap and corrupt individuals who are not careful or who are simply vulnerable. It highlights the inherent danger lurking within opportune situations.

Overall Meaning:

Stanza 126 is a powerful condemnation of Opportunity as an active agent in the perpetration of evil. It argues that Opportunity is not just a passive circumstance but an active force that enables and facilitates sin. Opportunity is personified as a treacherous figure that dismisses morality, disregards justice, and creates the environment where evil can thrive and prey on the innocent. The stanza serves to highlight the importance of resisting temptation and being aware of the potential dangers of seemingly advantageous situations. It sets the stage for the tragedy that is about to unfold by emphasizing the active role of circumstances in the unfolding of Tarquin's evil plan.

Literary Devices Summary:

Apostrophe: Direct address to Opportunity.
Personification: Opportunity and Sin are given human qualities.
Metaphor: Wolf/Lamb representing predator/victim; shady cell representing the secret place of evil.
Tautology (or Redundancy): "Traitor's treason."
Polysyndeton: Repetition of "at" in "...spurn'st at right, at law, at reason."

This stanza serves as a powerful warning and a strong moral commentary on the dangers of uncontrolled desire and the insidious role of opportunity in facilitating evil acts.

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← Stanza 126📚 OverviewStanza 128 →

Stanza 127 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 127 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Thou makest the vestal violate her oath;"

Meaning: You (referring to Lust/Tarquin) cause a chaste (vestal) woman to break her sacred promise of virginity.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor/Implied Metaphor: Lust is personified as an active agent, causing the violation. Allusion: "Vestal" alludes to the Vestal Virgins of ancient Rome, who were sworn to chastity. This alludes to the gravity of Lucrece's oath.

"Thou blow'st the fire when temperance is thaw'd;"

Meaning: You fuel desire when self-control (temperance) weakens.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Fire represents sexual desire, and blowing on it intensifies it. "Temperance is
thaw'd" uses the image of melting ice to signify the loss of self-restraint.

"Thou smother'st honesty, thou murder'st troth;"

Meaning: You suppress (smother) honesty and kill (murder) faithfulness/loyalty (troth).
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Honesty and Troth are personified as qualities that can be suppressed or murdered. Parallelism: The similar structure of the two clauses ("Thou smother'st..." and "Thou murder'st...") emphasizes the destructive power of lust.
"Thou foul abettor! thou notorious bawd!"

Meaning: You are a disgusting instigator of evil (abettor) and a well-known panderer/procurer of immoral acts (bawd).
Literary Devices:
Direct Address: The stanza is directly addressing Lust/Tarquin.
Epithets: "Foul abettor" and "notorious bawd" are insulting labels.

"Thou plantest scandal and displacest laud:"

Meaning: You create (plant) scandalous stories and remove (displace) praise/good reputation (laud).
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Scandal is something planted and spread, while laud is something removed or taken away.
Parallelism: Similar structure highlights the opposing forces.

"Thou ravisher, thou traitor, thou false thief,"

Meaning: You are a rapist, a betrayer, and a dishonest robber.

'Thou makest the vestal violate her oath;
Thou blow'st the fire when temperance is thaw'd;
Thou smother'st honesty, thou murder'st troth;
Thou foul abettor! thou notorious bawd!
Thou plantest scandal and displacest laud:
Thou ravisher, thou traitor, thou false thief, Thy honey turns to gall, thy joy to grief!

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Literary Devices:
Direct Address: The stanza is directly addressing Lust/Tarquin.
Triadic Structure: The use of three nouns ("ravisher, traitor, false thief") emphasizes the
extent of the accusations.

"Thy honey turns to gall, thy joy to grief!"

Meaning: What seems sweet (honey) becomes bitter (gall), and what seems joyful (joy) turns to sorrow (grief).
Literary Devices:
Antithesis: The contrast between "honey" and "gall," and "joy" and "grief," highlights the
ultimate consequences of succumbing to lust.
Metaphor: "Honey" represents fleeting pleasure, while "gall" represents the long-lasting
bitterness of guilt and shame.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

Stanza 127 is a powerful condemnation of Lust (personified as Tarquin) and its destructive consequences. It argues that lust corrupts innocence, destroys virtue, and replaces honor with scandal and sorrow. The stanza uses strong imagery and metaphorical language to paint a vivid picture of the devastation caused by unrestrained desire, highlighting its tendency to undermine everything valuable and pure. It transforms the temporary pleasure that it can bring into lasting grief and despair. The stanza focuses on the moral ruin that lust brings, emphasizing the betrayal of oaths, the loss of reputation, and the ultimate turning of pleasure into pain. In other words, it's an attack on the consequences of uncontrolled desire, particularly regarding the violation of chastity and the destruction of honor.

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Stanza 128 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 128 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line, identify the literary devices used, and then synthesize an overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Thy secret pleasure turns to open shame,"

Thy: Archaic form of "your," directly addressing Opportunity (personified).
Secret pleasure: Refers to the hidden, illicit gratification that results from seizing an opportune moment for wrongdoing. Here, it alludes to Tarquin's upcoming rape of Lucrece.
Open shame: The public disgrace and humiliation that will inevitably follow the initial, concealed
act of pleasure.
Literary Devices: Antithesis (contrasting "secret pleasure" with "open shame") creates a stark opposition, highlighting the ultimate consequence of acting on a wicked opportunity.

"Thy private feasting to a public fast,"

Private feasting: Implies the individual or select group indulgence and celebration associated with the opportunity (the sense of revelry Tarquin feels as he plans his attack).
Public fast: The communal suffering, mourning, and self-denial that will result from the crime when it is revealed. Rome will be in mourning and will ultimately overthrow the Tarquins.
Literary Devices: Antithesis (contrasting "private feasting" with "public fast") reinforces the reversal of fortune and the widespread impact of the sin. Metaphor: "feasting" and "fast" are metaphors for happiness and suffering, respectively.

"Thy smoothing titles to a ragged name,"

Smoothing titles: Refers to flattering, deceptive names, positions, or the initial favorable impressions one might receive thanks to Opportunity. It represents how Opportunity may be initially attractive but is ultimately deceptive.
Ragged name: A dishonored reputation, tarnished by scandal and infamy.
Literary Devices: Antithesis (contrasting "smoothing titles" with "ragged name") again emphasizes the downfall and ruin that follow. Metaphor: "smoothing titles" and "ragged name" are metaphors for reputation.

"Thy sugar'd tongue to bitter wormwood taste:"

Sugar'd tongue: Refers to sweet, enticing words or promises of opportunity that lure someone in. The deceptive persuasion used to convince someone to seize an ill-advised moment.
Bitter wormwood taste: The repulsive and unpleasant aftermath or realization of the true cost of seizing the opportunity. Wormwood is a bitter herb often associated with grief and regret.
Literary Devices: Antithesis (contrasting "sugar'd tongue" with "bitter wormwood taste") emphasizes the change from allurement to revulsion. Metaphor: "sugar'd tongue" and "bitter wormwood taste" are metaphors for pleasant communication turning into unpleasant feelings/consequences.

'Thy secret pleasure turns to open shame,
Thy private feasting to a public fast,
Thy smoothing titles to a ragged name,
Thy sugar'd tongue to bitter wormwood taste:
Thy violent vanities can never last.
How comes it then, vile Opportunity,
Being so bad, such numbers seek for thee?

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"Thy violent vanities can never last."

Violent vanities: The destructive, empty, and fleeting pleasures gained through seizing Opportunity (linked to Tarquin's lust).
Can never last: These ephemeral delights are ultimately unsustainable and destined to crumble. Literary Devices: Alliteration: Repetition of the "v" sound (violent vanities). Emphasis: This line serves as a summary of the overarching consequence of relying on Opportunity.

"How comes it then, vile Opportunity,"

How comes it then: A rhetorical question expressing bewilderment.
Vile Opportunity: "Vile" signifies how repulsive the concept of Opportunity truly is.

"Being so bad, such numbers seek for thee?"

Being so bad: Referring to all the negative consequences described in the previous lines.
Such numbers seek for thee: Despite its harmful nature, so many people still pursue and
succumb to Opportunity.
Literary Devices: Rhetorical question: Invites the reader to consider the paradoxical allure of Opportunity. Personification: Opportunity is addressed directly, making it a character to be questioned and critiqued.

Overall Meaning and Interpretation:

This stanza functions as a powerful condemnation of "Opportunity" (personified), which is depicted as an enticing yet ultimately destructive force. The stanza argues that the fleeting pleasures and advantages gained through seizing immoral or ill-advised opportunities inevitably lead to lasting shame, suffering, dishonor, and regret. The core message revolves around the paradoxical human tendency to pursue things that are known to be harmful.

The repetitive use of antithesis throughout the first four lines underscores the dramatic reversal of fortune that awaits those who succumb to the allure of Opportunity. The rhetorical question in the final two lines serves to challenge the reader to contemplate this inherent human flaw. The stanza paints a picture of an individual chasing fleeting desires while facing ultimate misery.
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← Stanza 128📚 OverviewStanza 130 →

Stanza 129 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 129 of "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"When wilt thou be the humble suppliant's friend,"

Breakdown: "Thou" refers to Opportunity (addressed as if it is a person). A "humble suppliant"
is someone who is begging or pleading earnestly. The line asks when Opportunity will be a friend
to those who are pleading for help.
Meaning: When will Opportunity help those who humbly ask for it?

"And bring him where his suit may be obtain'd?"

Breakdown: "Suit" refers to the request or plea. "Obtain'd" means granted or received. The line asks when Opportunity will lead the suppliant to a place where their request can be fulfilled. Meaning: When will Opportunity guide the person pleading for help to a place where their request can be granted?

"When wilt thou sort an hour great strifes to end?"

Breakdown: "Sort an hour" means to find or arrange a time. "Great strifes" refers to significant conflicts or struggles.
Meaning: When will Opportunity find a time to end major conflicts or struggles? When will it make things right?
"Or free that soul which wretchedness hath chain'd?"

Breakdown: "Wretchedness" means misery, suffering, or despair. The line refers to souls burdened by sorrow.
Meaning: When will Opportunity liberate souls imprisoned by their misery and suffering?

"Give physic to the sick, ease to the pain'd?"

Breakdown: "Physic" is old term for medicine. "Pained" means those who are suffering physically or emotionally.
Meaning: When will Opportunity provide healing and relief to those who are sick and in pain?

"The poor, lame, blind, halt, creep, cry out for thee;"

Breakdown: This line paints a vivid picture of suffering humanity. "Lame," "blind," "halt" (limping), and "creep" all describe physical disabilities. "Cry out for thee" emphasizes the desperate pleas directed toward Opportunity.
Meaning: Those who are suffering – the poor, the disabled, those barely able to move – are all desperately calling out for Opportunity's help.

"But they ne'er meet with Opportunity."

Breakdown: "Ne'er" means never. This line expresses the sad truth that those who need Opportunity the most rarely find it.

'When wilt thou be the humble suppliant's friend,
And bring him where his suit may be obtain'd?
When wilt thou sort an hour great strifes to end?
Or free that soul which wretchedness hath chain'd?
Give physic to the sick, ease to the pain'd?
The poor, lame, blind, halt, creep, cry out for thee; But they ne'er meet with Opportunity.

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Meaning: Despite their desperate pleas, those who need Opportunity never seem to encounter
it.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

The stanza is a lament, a cry of despair about the elusiveness of Opportunity, particularly for those who need it most. It highlights the suffering of the world and criticizes the unfairness of a system where the vulnerable are constantly denied the chance to improve their situations. Opportunity is personified and questioned about its absence. The stanza underscores the idea that Opportunity is not equally available to everyone and that those who are already disadvantaged often remain trapped in their suffering.

Literary Devices:

Personification: Opportunity is treated as a human being and is addressed as "thou." This personification allows the speaker to directly question and criticize Opportunity's actions (or lack thereof).
Anaphora: The repetition of "When wilt thou..." at the beginning of several lines emphasizes the speaker's frustration and the seemingly endless wait for Opportunity to act.
Imagery: The line "The poor, lame, blind, halt, creep, cry out for thee" creates a powerful image of suffering and evokes pity in the reader.
Alliteration: There is some subtle alliteration, such as "sick" and "soul" and "sort" and "strifes." These devices help the sounds connect and make the stanza more appealing.
Irony: There is a certain irony that Opportunity seems to be available to those who least need it and not to those who are desperate.

In conclusion, this stanza powerfully expresses the injustice of a world where opportunity is unevenly distributed, leaving the most vulnerable individuals to suffer without hope of relief.

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← Stanza 129📚 OverviewStanza 131 →

Stanza 130 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 130 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: 'The patient dies while the physician sleeps;'

Literal Meaning: Someone who is sick and needs help (the patient) dies because the doctor (physician) is asleep and neglectful.
Figurative Meaning: Represents a situation where those who are meant to help or heal are failing to do so, leading to tragic consequences. The patient can also be representative of a kingdom, community, or society.
Literary Devices: Juxtaposition (contrasting the patient's need with the physician's inaction). Metaphor (the patient representing something larger).

Line 2: 'The orphan pines while the oppressor feeds;'

Literal Meaning: An orphaned child suffers from hunger and neglect (pines), while the person who is causing the suffering (the oppressor) enjoys plenty.
Figurative Meaning: Again, highlights injustice. The vulnerable (the orphan) suffer, while the powerful who are responsible continue to thrive.
Literary Devices: Juxtaposition. Metaphor (orphan and oppressor as symbols of wider power imbalances).

Line 3: 'Justice is feasting while the widow weeps;'

Literal Meaning: Instead of upholding fairness, justice is enjoying itself (feasting) while a grieving widow (a symbol of helplessness and loss) is suffering.
Figurative Meaning: Corruption and the absence of true justice. Those who should be dispensing fairness are instead complicit or actively benefiting from the suffering of others. Literary Devices: Personification (Justice is given human qualities). Juxtaposition. Metaphor.

Line 4: 'Advice is sporting while infection breeds:'

Literal Meaning: Helpful counsel or guidance (advice) is being wasted on frivolous activities (sporting) instead of being used to stop the spread of something harmful (infection).
Figurative Meaning: Represents a failure to address a growing problem, perhaps ignoring warnings or prioritizing unimportant matters while a serious issue festers. The "infection" here is representative of evil, immoral behavior.
Literary Devices: Personification (Advice is given human qualities). Metaphor.

Line 5: 'Thou grant'st no time for charitable deeds:'

Literal Meaning: "You" (addressed to Night/Time/Opportunity, the subject of many stanzas in the poem) allow no chance or space for acts of kindness or compassion.
Figurative Meaning: Implies that the circumstances, facilitated by the passage of time or a period of darkness, are such that goodness cannot flourish. There is a hostile environment for compassion and charity.

'The patient dies while the physician sleeps;
The orphan pines while the oppressor feeds;
Justice is feasting while the widow weeps;
Advice is sporting while infection breeds:
Thou grant'st no time for charitable deeds: Wrath, envy, treason, rape, and murder's rages, Thy heinous hours wait on them as their pages.

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Literary Devices: Direct Address (Apostrophe). Personification (Night/Time is being addressed).

Line 6: 'Wrath, envy, treason, rape, and murder's rages,'

Literal Meaning: Lists a series of violent and destructive sins and crimes. The "rages" emphasizes the intensity and destructive power of these forces.
Figurative Meaning: Represents the forces of evil that are unleashed during the "heinous hours" that the speaker is lamenting. This line is an example of Asyndeton, as it is a list without conjunctions, and gives a sense of an abundance of evil.
Literary Devices: Enumeration (listing). Asyndeton.

Line 7: 'Thy heinous hours wait on them as their pages.'

Literal Meaning: The "heinous hours" (the dark, evil times) serve these sins (Wrath, envy, treason, rape, murder) as attendants or servants ("pages").
Figurative Meaning: Reinforces the idea that the circumstances (the "heinous hours") are
actively enabling and supporting these destructive forces. Time, or the opportunity afforded by
the dark of night, acts as a facilitator for evil.
Literary Devices: Personification (hours acting as pages). Metaphor.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza is a powerful indictment of injustice and the triumph of evil. It paints a picture of a world where those who should be helping and protecting are failing in their duties, creating an environment where suffering flourishes. The stanza emphasizes the absence of compassion, the prevalence of corruption, and the unleashing of destructive forces. The speaker accuses "Time/Night" of creating the very conditions that allow these evils to thrive, suggesting that some circumstances enable and encourage the worst aspects of human behavior. The stanza ultimately serves as a lament for the state of the world and a condemnation of the forces that allow such atrocities to occur.

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Stanza 131 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, and then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: 'When Truth and Virtue have to do with thee,'

Meaning: This line addresses some abstract entity, which contextually is referring to the "opportunity" or "circumstance" for good/virtue. It's saying that when Truth and Virtue need to interact with you (this "opportunity"), it's difficult.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Truth and Virtue are given human-like qualities (having to "do" with someone).
Apostrophe: The stanza is addressed to an abstract concept.

Line 2: 'A thousand crosses keep them from thy aid:'

Meaning: A multitude of obstacles or difficulties ("crosses") prevent Truth and Virtue from getting help from, or utilizing, this "opportunity".
Literary Devices:
Hyperbole: "A thousand crosses" is likely an exaggeration to emphasize the overwhelming
nature of the obstacles.
Metaphor: "Crosses" stand in for obstacles and burdens.

Line 3: 'They buy thy help; but Sin ne'er gives a fee,'

Meaning: Truth and Virtue must essentially pay a price (struggle) to receive this opportunity, but Sin doesn't need to. It is a stark contrast.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Sin is personified as something that can "give a fee".
Contrast: This line sets up a strong contrast between the effort needed for good and the ease
of evil.

Line 4: 'He gratis comes; and thou art well appaid'

Meaning: Sin comes freely ("gratis"), without any cost or effort, and this "opportunity" is perfectly happy ("well appaid") to receive him.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The 'g' sound in "gratis comes" is repeated.
Understatement: "Well appaid" is an understatement. The opportunity is not just happy but welcomes sin eagerly, implying a complicity or even a preference for it.

Line 5: 'As well to hear as grant what he hath said.'

Meaning: This "opportunity" is just as willing to listen to and act on the words of Sin.
Literary Devices:
Parallelism: The structure of "as well to hear as grant" emphasizes the equal willingness to listen and obey Sin.

'When Truth and Virtue have to do with thee,
A thousand crosses keep them from thy aid:
They buy thy help; but Sin ne'er gives a fee,
He gratis comes; and thou art well appaid
As well to hear as grant what he hath said. My Collatine would else have come to me
When Tarquin did, but he was stay'd by thee.

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Line 6: 'My Collatine would else have come to me'

Meaning: If it wasn't for this 'opportunity' favouring Tarquin, Lucrece believes her husband Collatine would have been with her.
Context: Lucrece is speaking after being raped by Tarquin. She believes that under normal circumstances, her husband would have been able to come to her, perhaps if she had called for him.

Line 7: 'When Tarquin did, but he was stay'd by thee.'

Meaning: When Tarquin arrived, Collatine was prevented from coming to her by the very 'opportunity' that should have allowed it.
Irony: Collatine's absence is directly linked to this opportunity favouring the evil of Tarquin's intentions.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza is a lament and a condemnation of the circumstances that allowed Tarquin to rape Lucrece. Lucrece is personifying "Opportunity" and accusing it of favoring evil over good. She argues that it is inherently easier for sin to flourish than for truth and virtue to prevail. The stanza highlights the injustice of her situation: Collatine was prevented from protecting her because the very circumstances that should have aided her actually facilitated Tarquin's wicked deed. It emphasizes the overwhelming difficulty of goodness triumphing over the ease and allure of evil.

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Stanza 132 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this powerful and condemning stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, spoken by Lucrece to the absent Tarquin:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Guilty thou art of murder and of theft,"

Meaning: You are guilty of murder and theft. This establishes the core accusations against
Tarquin. While there's no literal murder yet (Lucrece will commit suicide), this foreshadows her death and places the blame squarely on Tarquin. Theft, here, refers to stealing her honor and
virtue.

Literary Devices: Anaphora (repetition of "Guilty") emphasizes the sheer volume of accusations. Assonance ("guilty" and "art") creates a sense of sonic unity, underscoring the certainty of her judgment.

"Guilty of perjury and subornation,"

Meaning: You are guilty of perjury (lying under oath or breaking a promise) and subornation (bribing or persuading someone to commit perjury or a crime). This suggests a wider conspiracy and that Tarquin has likely used lies and manipulation to achieve his aims.
Literary Devices: Anaphora (repetition of "Guilty" continues)

"Guilty of treason, forgery, and shift,"

Meaning: You are guilty of treason (betraying a trust, especially against a ruler or country), forgery (making false documents with intent to deceive), and shift (deception, trickery, or evasion). These lines intensify the gravity of his crimes, suggesting that his actions have broader implications beyond Lucrece herself. "Shift" also implies his cunning and deceitful nature. Literary Devices: Anaphora (repetition of "Guilty" continues)

"Guilty of incest, that abomination;"

Meaning: You are guilty of incest, that is, the act of sexual relations between people too closely related to marry. This line has perplexed scholars, as Tarquin and Lucrece are not related. However, Shakespeare might be using "incest" metaphorically to represent the violation of a sacred bond of hospitality and the corruption of his lineage. His crime is so heinous, it's akin to the worst sexual taboo.

Literary Devices: Anaphora (repetition of "Guilty" continues). The appositive "that abomination" emphasizes the utter detestability of the crime.

"An accessary by thine inclination"

Meaning: You are an accomplice (or inherently disposed) to all sins because of your corrupt nature/desire. This line shifts focus. It asserts that Tarquin is not just guilty of the specific crimes listed, but his very nature makes him prone to all kinds of evil. "Inclination" speaks to a fundamental flaw in his character.

Literary Devices: The shift from specific actions to "inclination" adds a layer of psychological condemnation.

Guilty thou art of murder and of theft,
Guilty of perjury and subornation,
Guilty of treason, forgery, and shift,
Guilty of incest, that abomination;
An accessary by thine inclination
To all sins past, and all that are to come, From the creation to the general doom.

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"To all sins past, and all that are to come,"

Meaning: To all sins that have happened and all sins that will happen. This expands the scope of Tarquin's guilt to encompass a universal timeframe. He is not just guilty of his specific crime against Lucrece, but he embodies the potential for all sin.
Literary Devices: Hyperbole (exaggeration) is used here to emphasize the enormity of Tarquin's guilt. Antithesis ("past" and "come") emphasizes the totality of time.

"From the creation to the general doom."

Meaning: From the beginning of the world to the end of time (Judgment Day). This is the
ultimate statement of Tarquin's universal guilt, linking him to the totality of human sin. It's an apocalyptic vision of his depravity.
Literary Devices: Hyperbole and Allusion to Christian eschatology (the "general doom" refers to the Last Judgement) elevate Tarquin's crime to a cosmic level.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a powerful and relentless condemnation of Tarquin. Lucrece uses a combination of specific accusations and broad, sweeping statements to portray him as a figure of absolute depravity. He is not simply guilty of raping her, but of breaking oaths, betraying trusts, corrupting his bloodline, and embodying the potential for all sin throughout history. The repetition, hyperbole, and allusions create a sense of overwhelming guilt and portray Tarquin as a figure of almost biblical villainy. The stanza functions to justify Lucrece's impending suicide by showing the world that Tarquin's crime is so heinous that it requires the ultimate sacrifice to restore justice and honor. She equates his transgression to something that defiles all time, past, present and future.

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Stanza 133 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 133 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then consider the overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

'Mis-shapen Time, copesmate of ugly Night,'

Mis-shapen Time: Time is personified and described as deformed or distorted, suggesting it is
not functioning as it should. The term "mis-shapen" also hints at the destructive and negative aspect of Time.
Copesmate of ugly Night: "Copesmate" means companion or partner. Time is linked to the
"ugly Night," further emphasizing its association with darkness, evil, and hidden deeds (like the rape that happened during the night). This creates a powerful image of a destructive partnership. Literary Devices:
Personification: Time is given human characteristics.
Metaphor: Time is being compared to something else.

'Swift subtle post, carrier of grisly care,'

Swift subtle post: Time is a messenger ("post") that is both quick and sly. It is swift because time passes quickly, but also subtle in its effects, often going unnoticed as it brings about decay and change.
Carrier of grisly care: Time brings "grisly care," which is terrible worry, sorrow, and suffering. It emphasizes the pain and negative experiences time delivers.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Time is compared to a messenger/post.
Alliteration: "Swift subtle".

Assonance: "grisly" and "care".

'Eater of youth, false slave to false delight,'

Eater of youth: A powerful image of time consuming and destroying beauty and vigor. It connects to the idea of aging, decay, and the loss of what is precious.
False slave to false delight: Time seems to serve "false delight" (deceptive pleasure or temporary joy), but is actually a "false slave," meaning it's not truly controlled by pleasure, but rather deceives and is destructive. In other words, Time allows for these fleeting pleasures, but ultimately those pleasures lead to greater pain and regret.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Time is a consumer and a slave.
Alliteration: "False slave" and "false delight".

'Base watch of woes, sin's pack-horse, virtue's snare;'

Base watch of woes: "Base" suggests something low, contemptible, or ignoble. Time is described as a lowly observer or guardian of suffering and sorrow. It allows the "woes" to accumulate and take their toll.

'Mis-shapen Time, copesmate of ugly Night,
Swift subtle post, carrier of grisly care,
Eater of youth, false slave to false delight,
Base watch of woes, sin's pack-horse, virtue's snare;
Thou nursest all and murder'st all that are:
O, hear me then, injurious, shifting Time!
Be guilty of my death, since of my crime.

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Sin's pack-horse: Time carries the burden of sin, enabling it to spread and endure. It emphasizes time's role in allowing evil to flourish.
Virtue's snare: Time can trap virtue, leading to its downfall. Suggests that even the virtuous are not immune to the corrosive effects of time and the temptations that arise within it. It reinforces the idea that even good qualities can be exploited or destroyed.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Time is a watch, a pack-horse and a snare.

'Thou nursest all and murder'st all that are:'

Thou nursest all and murder'st all that are: This line encapsulates the dual nature of time. It gives life and fosters growth ("nurst"), but ultimately destroys everything ("murder'st"). This highlights the tragic, inevitable cycle of creation and destruction that time governs.
Literary Device:
Paradox: Time nurtures and murders.

'O, hear me then, injurious, shifting Time!'

O, hear me then, injurious, shifting Time!: This is a direct address to time. "Injurious" means harmful or damaging. "Shifting" suggests time is fickle, unreliable, or always changing. Lucrece is pleading with time, acknowledging its power and its capacity for harm.
Literary Devices:
Apostrophe: Addressing an inanimate object.

'Be guilty of my death, since of my crime.

Be guilty of my death, since of my crime: Here, Lucrece declares that Time should be blamed for her death, because it is also responsible for her "crime" (not her sin, but the rape she
endured). She believes time is a force that enabled and perpetuated the evil that led to her downfall. It implies the events transpired because of the corrupting and destructive power of
time.
Literary Devices:
Paradox: Asking time to be guilty

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece delivers a powerful denunciation of Time. She sees it not as a neutral force but as a destructive entity that collaborates with darkness and evil. Time is portrayed as responsible for aging, suffering, the spread of sin, and ultimately, her own tragedy. She calls upon Time to be held accountable for her death, as it enabled and perpetuated the crime that led to her despair. The stanza reflects a deep sense of helplessness and a recognition of the overwhelming power of Time to corrupt and destroy even the most virtuous. It's a bleak and despairing perspective, highlighting the tragic implications of the events that have befallen Lucrece. She doesn't see Time as a healer, but as an accomplice in the evil that has ruined her life. She asks that if Time enabled the crime, it should take responsibility for the fallout which is her suicide.

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Stanza 134 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 134 of The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Why hath thy servant, Opportunity,":

Analysis: Lucrece is apostrophizing (addressing an absent person or thing) Opportunity. She personifies Opportunity as a servant of Time (implied). She is questioning why Opportunity, which should have served her well, has turned against her. "Hath" is archaic for "has."
Literary Devices: Apostrophe, Personification

"Betray'd the hours thou gavest me to repose,":

Analysis: She accuses Opportunity of betraying the "hours" that Time allotted her for rest and peace. This suggests the vulnerability and trust associated with sleep. Opportunity has taken advantage of her defenseless state.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (hours as something given)

"Cancell'd my fortunes, and enchained me":

Analysis: "Cancelled my fortunes" means her good luck, happiness, and reputation have been destroyed. "Enchained me" implies she is now bound (like a prisoner) to something terrible. Literary Devices: Metaphor (fortunes being cancelled like a debt), Metaphor (enchained)

"To endless date of never-ending woes?":

Analysis: This line elaborates on the "enchained" image. She is now bound to an infinite period of suffering and misery. The repetition of "endless" and "never-ending" emphasizes the permanence and hopelessness of her situation.
Literary Devices: Hyperbole (exaggeration), Repetition

"Time's office is to fine the hate of foes;":

Analysis: Now Lucrece considers the proper role of time. "Time's office" means Time's purpose or duty. "Fine the hate of foes" means that time is supposed to weaken or refine the animosity enemies feel towards each other, lessening the impact of their hate over time.
Literary Devices: None explicit

"To eat up errors by opinion bred,":

Analysis: Time should also "eat up" (diminish or erase) mistakes caused by misunderstandings or incorrect beliefs ("errors by opinion bred"). Time should heal and correct misjudgments. Literary Devices: Metaphor (time eating errors)

"Not spend the dowry of a lawful bed.":

Analysis: This line provides a direct contrast to the previous two. Time should not destroy the benefits and blessings ("dowry") of a legitimate and honorable marriage ("lawful bed"). Lucrece's rape has effectively robbed her of the sanctity and security of her marriage to Collatine.
Literary Devices: Juxtaposition, Metaphor (dowry of a lawful bed)

'Why hath thy servant, Opportunity,
Betray'd the hours thou gavest me to repose,
Cancell'd my fortunes, and enchained me
To endless date of never-ending woes?
Time's office is to fine the hate of foes;
To eat up errors by opinion bred,
Not spend the dowry of a lawful bed.

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Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece is lamenting the injustice of her situation. She accuses Opportunity (acting as Time's servant) of betraying her and turning against her. She feels her life, happiness, and honor have been irrevocably destroyed, and she is condemned to endless suffering. She highlights the irony that Time, which should heal wounds, diminish hatred, and correct mistakes, has instead ruined the sanctity of her marriage. The stanza is a powerful expression of grief, anger, and despair. It highlights the unfairness of the violation she has suffered and the destruction it has wrought upon her life.

Key Literary Devices:

Apostrophe: Addressing Opportunity as if it were a person.
Personification: Giving human qualities to Opportunity and Time.
Metaphor: Used extensively to describe abstract concepts like time, fortune, and her situation (e.g., "cancelled my fortunes," "enchained me," "dowry of a lawful bed," "eat up errors"). Hyperbole: Exaggerating the extent of her suffering ("endless date of never-ending woes"). Repetition: The repetition of "endless" and "never-ending" emphasizes the unending nature of her despair.
Juxtaposition: Contrasting what Time should do with what Time has done to her marriage.
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Stanza 135 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 135 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, analyzing each line and then offering an overall interpretation:

Line-by-Line Analysis:

'Time's glory is to calm contending kings,'

Analysis: This line establishes the primary subject: Time. It declares that one of Time's most magnificent achievements (its "glory") is to pacify warring rulers. "Contending" kings are kings in conflict, battling for power or territory.
Literary Devices: Personification (Time is given the ability to exert power)

'To unmask falsehood and bring truth to light,'

Analysis: Time is depicted as a revealer of truth. Falsehoods, lies, and deceit are exposed by Time, while truth is brought into the open, becoming visible.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (Falsehoods are masked), Personification (Time revealing truth)

'To stamp the seal of time in aged things,'

Analysis: This line means that Time leaves its mark on everything as it ages. The "seal of time" could be wrinkles, decay, historical significance, or simply the inevitable changes that occur with age. "Aged things" refers to things that grow old, such as people or objects.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (Seal of Time)

'To wake the morn and sentinel the night,'

Analysis: Time governs the cycle of day and night. It "wakes the morn," meaning it brings about the morning, and it acts as a "sentinel" (guard) over the night, controlling its duration and perhaps ensuring its safety.
Literary Devices: Personification (Time wakes), Metaphor (Sentinel)

'To wrong the wronger till he render right,'

Analysis: This line speaks to Time's role in justice. Time, in its due course, will inflict suffering on those who commit wrongdoings ("wrong the wronger") until they make amends ("render right"). Justice, if not immediate, is eventually delivered.
Literary Devices: Alliteration ("wrong the wronger"); Juxtaposition (wrong/right)

'To ruinate proud buildings with thy hours,'

Analysis: Time is a force of destruction. Even the most impressive and magnificent structures ("proud buildings") are subject to Time's destructive power. Time, measured in hours, leads to the decay and downfall of even the most seemingly indestructible things.
Literary Devices: Personification (Time possesses hours)

'And smear with dust their glittering golden towers;'

Analysis: The final line continues the theme of Time's destructive power. The beautiful, "glittering golden towers" of these proud buildings are ultimately reduced to dust by time. The image emphasizes the transience of even the most opulent and impressive creations.

'Time's glory is to calm contending kings,
To unmask falsehood and bring truth to light,
To stamp the seal of time in aged things,
To wake the morn and sentinel the night,
To wrong the wronger till he render right,
To ruinate proud buildings with thy hours,
And smear with dust their glittering golden towers;

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Literary Devices: Imagery (visual, descriptive), Alliteration ("glittering golden")

Overall Meaning:

This stanza presents Time as a complex and powerful force. It is not simply a neutral measurement of passing moments but an active agent that shapes the world. Time is a source of both good and bad. It brings peace, reveals truth, and ultimately delivers justice, but it also causes decay, destruction, and the inevitable downfall of even the most impressive achievements. The stanza emphasizes the transience of worldly power and beauty, reminding us that all things are subject to the relentless march of Time. The tone is somber and contemplative, reflecting the overall tragic nature of the poem.

In the context of The Rape of Lucrece, this stanza can be seen as a foreshadowing of the events to come. Tarquin's pride and lust will lead to Lucrece's rape and suicide, but ultimately, Time will bring about his downfall and the establishment of the Roman Republic. Time, in this context, is the ultimate judge and avenger.

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Stanza 136 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 136 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then look at the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"To fill with worm-holes stately monuments,"

Breakdown: This line describes the destructive power of time. "Worm-holes" symbolize decay
and corruption. "Stately monuments" represent things meant to be permanent and impressive.
The idea is that even the grandest structures are eventually eaten away by time and neglect. Literary Device: Alliteration with "worm-holes" and "stately" gives emphasis.

"To feed oblivion with decay of things,"

Breakdown: "Oblivion" is personified as a hungry force, always consuming. "Decay of things" means the inevitable breakdown and destruction of all material objects and even concepts. Time gives the decay of things to oblivion to consume.
Literary Device: Personification (oblivion feeding), Metaphor (oblivion as a force), and Alliteration with "feed" and "oblivion".

"To blot old books and alter their contents,"

Breakdown: This line goes beyond physical destruction and speaks to the distortion of history and knowledge. Time can corrupt written records, changing their meanings or erasing them altogether.
Literary Device: Imagery (blot old books) evokes a sense of destruction.

"To pluck the quills from ancient ravens' wings,"

Breakdown: Ravens were often associated with wisdom, prophecy, and longevity. Plucking their quills (used for writing) implies silencing the voices of the past, or disabling the means of recording or transmitting knowledge.
Literary Device: Symbolism (ravens represent wisdom/past), Imagery (violent action).

"To dry the old oak's sap and cherish springs,"

Breakdown: This line presents a paradox. An "old oak" symbolizes strength and endurance, whose sap drying would mean eventual destruction. "Springs" represent youth, growth, and renewal, which are being cherished/watered in comparison. Time favors the new and allows the old to decay.
Literary Device: Contrast (old oak vs. springs), Symbolism (oak representing enduring strength, springs representing new beginnings).

"To spoil antiquities of hammer'd steel,"

Breakdown: Even strong objects made of "hammer'd steel" which would be considered durable, are not immune to time's destruction. "Antiquities" represent the achievements and artifacts of the past.
Literary Device: Imagery (spoiled steel) is a very striking image, Alliteration with "spoil" and "steel".

'To fill with worm-holes stately monuments,
To feed oblivion with decay of things,
To blot old books and alter their contents,
To pluck the quills from ancient ravens' wings,
To dry the old oak's sap and cherish springs, To spoil antiquities of hammer'd steel,
And turn the giddy round of Fortune's wheel;

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"And turn the giddy round of Fortune's wheel;"

Breakdown: This line connects the destructive nature of time to the unpredictable nature of
fate. "Fortune's wheel" is a common symbol of the rise and fall of individuals and empires. Time,
or fate, controls who rises and falls on this wheel. "Giddy" suggests the dizzying, disorienting
effect of these changes.
Literary Device: Metaphor (Fortune's wheel), Alliteration with "giddy round".

Overall Meaning:

Stanza 136 is a powerful meditation on the destructive and transformative power of time. It paints a bleak picture of how time erodes not only physical objects but also history, knowledge, and even the very fabric of fate. Everything is subject to decay, corruption, and eventual oblivion. Time favors the new and diminishes the old. The stanza emphasizes the fleeting nature of human achievement and the ultimate triumph of time and change. These are the actions of time itself.

In the context of the poem: This stanza helps to explain why Lucrece is so upset and takes the actions she does. The violation of her honor is not just a personal tragedy but also an act of destruction that mirrors the destructive forces of time itself. This stanza, among others, emphasizes that her rape represents an act of destruction that goes beyond her person.

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Stanza 137 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices, and then summarize the overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"To show the beldam daughters of her daughter,"

Beldam means an old, ugly, or evil woman (akin to a hag). This line suggests showing future generations of women (descendants of Lucrece's daughter) the truth or consequences of what
has happened. It implies a warning or lesson to be learned from Lucrece's tragedy.
Alliteration: "Daughters of her daughter" uses similar sounds for emphasis.

"To make the child a man, the man a child,"

This is a statement about the power of the event to alter perceptions and roles. It suggests that the innocence of childhood ("child") can be lost prematurely, forcing someone to grow up quickly ("man"). Conversely, powerful or mature figures ("man") might be humbled or reduced to a state of helplessness ("child") by the consequences of the crime.
Antithesis: This line presents direct opposites (child/man) for contrast and dramatic effect.

"To slay the tiger that doth live by slaughter,"

The "tiger" symbolizes brutality, savagery, and predatory violence. "Slaughter" reinforces the violent nature. This line calls for the destruction of the force that perpetuates harm. In the context of the poem, it refers to Tarquin and the lust that motivated his actions.
Metaphor: The tiger is a metaphor for Tarquin's rapacious desire.
Personification: The tiger "lives by slaughter," giving it a human-like attribute.

"To tame the unicorn and lion wild,"

The "unicorn and lion" are creatures known for their untamable natures, representing chaos or destructive potential. "Unicorn" is also associated with purity. The call to "tame" them suggests bringing order and justice to what is currently uncontrollable.
Metaphor: Like the tiger, the unicorn and lion represent the wild, uncontrolled forces within human nature and society.
Alliteration: Lion wild" uses similar sounds for emphasis.

"To mock the subtle in themselves beguiled,"

"Subtle" refers to those who are clever, cunning, or deceitful. "Beguiled" means deceived. This line suggests that even those who pride themselves on their intelligence or cunning can be tricked or misled. The tragedy will expose and humiliate them.
Irony: There's an irony in mocking the "subtle" who are "beguiled," as it implies that their cleverness ultimately failed them.

"To cheer the ploughman with increaseful crops,"

The "ploughman" symbolizes the common, hard-working person or the land itself. "Increaseful crops" represents prosperity and abundance. This line suggests that the resolution of the tragedy

'To show the beldam daughters of her daughter,
To make the child a man, the man a child,
To slay the tiger that doth live by slaughter,
To tame the unicorn and lion wild,
To mock the subtle in themselves beguiled,
To cheer the ploughman with increaseful crops, And waste huge stones with little water drops.

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will bring about a renewed sense of hope and productivity to the land and its people. Justice will lead to renewed fertility and prosperity.
Symbolism: The ploughman represents the common people or the land.

"And waste huge stones with little water drops."

This line is a proverb about the power of persistence. "Huge stones" represent formidable obstacles or deeply ingrained problems. "Little water drops" represent small, consistent efforts. It conveys the idea that even seemingly insignificant actions, when repeated over time, can
overcome great challenges.
Metaphor: The "huge stones" are a metaphor for the deep wrongs and ingrained injustices of the world.
Proverbial expression: This line functions as a well-known proverb, lending it weight and
authority.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a complex summary of the potential consequences and outcomes of Lucrece's tragedy. It speaks to the power of the event to:

Instruct future generations about the dangers of lust and tyranny.
Transform individuals and societal structures.
Bring about justice by overcoming destructive forces.
Expose the limitations of cunning and deceit.
Restore prosperity and hope to the land and its people.
Highlight the power of persistent effort in achieving justice and change.

In essence, the stanza is not just about the immediate aftermath of the rape of Lucrece but about the potential for this tragedy to spark a wider societal transformation and create a better future. The repeated "To..." creates a sense of purpose and a call to action, implying that Lucrece's sacrifice should lead to positive change. It suggests that Lucrece's death will be a catalyst for significant change, leading to a world where virtue is valued, justice prevails, and societal ills are addressed.
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← Stanza 137📚 OverviewStanza 139 →

Stanza 138 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Why work'st thou mischief in thy pilgrimage,"

"Why work'st thou mischief": Why are you, Night (implied, being addressed), creating trouble/evil/harm? The archaic "work'st" indicates a direct address in the second person.
"in thy pilgrimage": While on your journey, while performing your duty. Night has a set course that it follows each day to return again. It's presented here as if Night is actively choosing to
inflict pain.
Analysis: This line sets the tone of frustration and accusatory tone. The Night is personified as an agent actively causing harm.
"Unless thou couldst return to make amends?"

"Unless thou couldst return": Unless you could come back after the mischief.
"to make amends": To repair the damage, to compensate for the harm done.
Analysis: This line builds on the first, suggesting that there might be some justification for the Night's evil if it were followed by a way to fix it. However, the speaker implies that no such "amends" are possible in this situation. The line also hints at a cyclical nature of time and suggests that Night may come back without undoing this wrong.

"One poor retiring minute in an age"

"One poor retiring minute": A single, insignificant minute (of darkness) retreating early.
"in an age": In an entire era, in the longest possible stretch of time.
Analysis: Lucrece is desperate for the night to end early. She is saying that even the slightest shortening of the night would be a great benefit. This line conveys the immense scale of Lucrece's suffering; she views even one minute of relief as precious in the vast expanse of time.

"Would purchase thee a thousand thousand friends,"

"Would purchase thee": Would earn you, would gain for you.
"a thousand thousand friends": An enormous number of friends, a multitude of gratitude. Analysis: This line shows the potential positive impact even a small act of kindness (shortening the night) could have. "A thousand thousand" is hyperbole, emphasizing the immense gratitude that would result. Lucrece implies that if the night would just end sooner it would have great benefits.

"Lending him wit that to bad debtors lends:"

"Lending him wit": Giving wisdom or intelligence to him (referring to time, or perhaps mankind in general).
"that to bad debtors lends": Which lends (wisdom/time/opportunity) to those who are not worthy, those who abuse it.

'Why work'st thou mischief in thy pilgrimage,
Unless thou couldst return to make amends?
One poor retiring minute in an age
Would purchase thee a thousand thousand friends,
Lending him wit that to bad debtors lends:
O, this dread night, wouldst thou one hour come back, I could prevent this storm and shun thy wrack!

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Analysis: This is a more complex line. It implies that even though Night is sometimes "generous" (lending time or opportunity) to those who waste it, in this case, it is being needlessly cruel. In some instances, Night lends something that is not appreciated, wasted on those who do not deserve it.

"O, this dread night, wouldst thou one hour come back,"

"O, this dread night": An exclamation, emphasizing the terror of the night.
"wouldst thou one hour come back": If only you, Night, would go back just one hour. Analysis: Lucrece expresses a desperate wish to rewind time, even a short amount of time, to alter what has happened.

"I could prevent this storm and shun thy wrack!"

"I could prevent this storm": I could stop the impending disaster, the awful event (the rape). "and shun thy wrack!": and avoid your destruction/ ruin. "Wrack" is an older spelling of
"wreck" but also means destruction and violence. In this case it means the violent destructive effects of the Night.
Analysis: This line reveals the core of Lucrece's anguish. She believes that even a small amount
of time reversed could prevent the tragedy that is about to unfold. She is aware of the
destruction that night has brought.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza is a desperate plea to the Night, personified as a cruel and indifferent force. Lucrece is begging the Night to shorten itself, even by the smallest amount of time. She believes that if she could just have a little time back, she could prevent the rape that is about to occur, saving herself from ruin and avoiding the tragedy that is about to unfold. Lucrece argues that if only the night would end soon, the suffering caused would be undone.

Literary Devices:

Personification: The Night is treated as a living being, capable of agency and making choices ("Why work'st thou mischief...").
Apostrophe: Direct address to an absent entity (the Night). The "O" in "O, this dread night" is a classic marker of apostrophe.
Rhetorical Question: The opening lines ("Why work'st thou mischief...? Unless thou couldst return...") are not seeking answers but are used to express Lucrece's frustration and outrage. Hyperbole: "A thousand thousand friends" is an exaggeration to emphasize the potential for gratitude.
Imagery: The "storm" and "wrack" (shipwreck/destruction) create vivid images of the destructive power of the Night and the impending tragedy. These are metaphors for the rape and its consequences.
Alliteration: "Wouldst thou one hour come back" for emphasis
Metaphor: Night represents the event to come and the darkness in Lucrece's soul.

This stanza is highly charged with emotion, revealing Lucrece's despair, her helplessness, and her desperate hope (however faint) that she can somehow avert the impending disaster. The use of personification and other literary devices intensifies the sense of the Night as an active, malevolent force working against her.

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Stanza 139 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Shakespeare's stanza 139 from 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line and then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Thou ceaseless lackey to eternity,"

Meaning: This line is an address to time itself. The phrase "ceaseless lackey" suggests that time
is a constant servant or attendant to eternity. It relentlessly marches on, ever subservient to the grand, unchanging concept of eternity.
Literary Devices:
Apostrophe: Addressing time directly, as if it can hear and act.
Metaphor: Time is being compared to a "lackey" implying that it serves the overarching and enduring concept of eternity.
Personification: Giving time the human-like quality of being a "lackey".

"With some mischance cross Tarquin in his flight:"

Meaning: The speaker implores time to intervene and cause some kind of bad luck or misfortune to Tarquin as he flees after raping Lucrece. "Cross" here means to hinder or frustrate his escape. Literary Devices:
Imperative Mood: The use of "cross" as a command to time.

"Devise extremes beyond extremity,"

Meaning: This line is a plea for time to create punishments for Tarquin that are worse than the worst imaginable. The speaker wants time to go beyond the boundaries of what's considered extremely bad.
Literary Devices:
Hyperbole: Exaggeration for effect; suggesting punishments that surpass all known limits. Repetition (of the root word): Repetition of the words "extremes" and "extremity". This reinforces the idea of the absolute worst.

"To make him curse this cursed crimeful night:"

Meaning: The goal of all this punishment is to make Tarquin regret the night of his crime so deeply that he curses it.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the 'c' sound in "curse," "cursed," and "crimeful" emphasize the gravity and evilness of the night.
Assonance: The repetition of the short "i" sound in "him," "this," and "crimeful" adds a sense
of unease.

"Let ghastly shadows his lewd eyes affright;"

Meaning: May frightening shadows scare Tarquin's lustful eyes. It's a call for his guilt and wickedness to manifest as terrifying visions. "Lewd eyes" emphasizes the objectification inherent in his crime.

'Thou ceaseless lackey to eternity,
With some mischance cross Tarquin in his flight:
Devise extremes beyond extremity,
To make him curse this cursed crimeful night:
Let ghastly shadows his lewd eyes affright;
And the dire thought of his committed evil Shape every bush a hideous shapeless devil.

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Literary Devices:
Imagery: Vivid description creating a sense of fear and horror.
Synecdoche: The use of "lewd eyes" to represent the entire man, suggesting that his entire being is defined by lust.

"And the dire thought of his committed evil"

Meaning: May the horrific thought of the evil deed he committed.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the "th" sound in "thought" and "the" creates an ominous tone.

"Shape every bush a hideous shapeless devil."

Meaning: May his guilt and fear transform every ordinary bush into a terrifying, deformed devil.
This shows how his conscience will torture him, making the world seem menacing.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: The vivid description of "hideous shapeless devil" creates a strong image of terror. Metaphor: The bush becoming a devil symbolizes how Tarquin's guilt distorts his perception of reality.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a powerful curse invoked against Tarquin. The speaker implores time to punish him relentlessly, going beyond any conceivable measure of suffering. The stanza highlights the speaker's desire for Tarquin to experience psychological torment. The visions, the fear, the distortion of reality are all meant to drive him to despair and to make him forever regret his crime. The imagery is deliberately designed to create a sense of intense dread and psychological torment, suggesting the profound impact of Tarquin's actions and the depth of Lucrece's suffering, even in her call for revenge. It focuses on the internal consequences of Tarquin's actions. It's a very active and vivid expression of revenge.

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Stanza 140 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 140 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Disturb his hours of rest with restless trances,"

Meaning: She hopes that Tarquin's sleep will be plagued by disturbing, unsettled visions or nightmares. He won't find peace even in his sleep.
Literary Devices: Alliteration (repetition of the 'r' sound in "rest" and "restless") emphasizes the disruption.

"Afflict him in his bed with bedrid groans;"

Meaning: Even in the supposed comfort of his bed, she wishes him to suffer as if he were bedridden with illness, writhing in pain and groaning. The bed, usually associated with rest and intimacy, becomes a site of torment.
Literary Devices: Metaphor - Comparing Tarquin to being bedridden to emphasize the physical suffering he should endure.

"Let there bechance him pitiful mischances,"

Meaning: She desires that unfortunate and regrettable events should occur to him. "Mischances" here means accidents, calamities, or misfortunes. The word "pitiful" is ironic as she will later
show no pity.
Literary Devices: None.

"To make him moan; but pity not his moans:"

Meaning: She wants him to suffer so much that he cries out in pain and regret, but she insists that no one should have any sympathy for him.
Literary Devices: Juxtaposition, the contrast between making him "moan" and "pity not his moans" highlights the severity of her anger and determination for revenge.

"Stone him with harden'd hearts harder than stones;"

Meaning: She wants people to be so cold and unforgiving towards him that their hearts are harder even than literal stones. This evokes the image of a public stoning, a brutal form of punishment.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (comparing hearts to stones), Hyperbole (hearts harder than stones), Allusion (to stoning as punishment)

"And let mild women to him lose their mildness,"

Meaning: She calls for even the most gentle and compassionate women to abandon their usual kindness towards Tarquin.
Literary Devices: Irony (contrast between "mild women" and their expected behavior)

' Disturb his hours of rest with restless trances,
Afflict him in his bed with bedrid groans;
Let there bechance him pitiful mischances,
To make him moan; but pity not his moans:
Stone him with harden'd hearts harder than stones;
And let mild women to him lose their mildness, Wilder to him than tigers in their wildness.

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"Wilder to him than tigers in their wildness."

Meaning: She wants these women to become more fierce and savage towards him than even
wild tigers in their natural habitat.
Literary Devices: Simile (comparing women to tigers), Hyperbole (the extreme degree of wildness), Alliteration (repetition of the 'w' sound in "wilder" and "wildness")

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza is a powerful expression of Lucrece's intense anger and desire for revenge. She is not merely seeking justice; she wants Tarquin to suffer immensely, both physically and emotionally. She calls for universal condemnation and a complete reversal of expected behaviors. Even the most compassionate people should turn against him with a ferocity that is almost inhuman. The stanza emphasizes the depth of her pain and the shattering of her innocence and trust. It highlights the transformative power of trauma, as she imagines even the mildest of women becoming vengeful figures. The repetition and use of extreme language (hyperbole) contribute to the stanza's forceful and emotionally charged atmosphere. It's a visceral representation of the destructive power of rape and the consuming desire for retribution. It shows the depths of despair and anger Lucrece feels, not only for herself but for all womankind.

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Stanza 141 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 141 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.
Line-by-Line Breakdown:
"Let him have time to tear his curled hair,"
Meaning: Allow Tarquin (the "him" being referred to here) the opportunity to express his anguish through physical violence against himself. Tearing his hair is a sign of extreme grief, regret, and self-hatred. The 'curled hair' adds to the imagery of his vanity which he now turns upon himself in self-harm.
Literary Devices: Imagery, evoking a vivid picture of a man in torment.
"Let him have time against himself to rave,"
Meaning: Let Tarquin have the chance to curse and denounce himself in a state of frenzied madness. "Rave" suggests uncontrolled, irrational speech driven by intense emotion. He has time to turn his wrath on himself.
Literary Devices: Imagery, reinforcing the chaotic and destructive nature of his guilt.
"Let him have time of Time's help to despair,"
Meaning: Let Tarquin experience a slow and agonizing realization that even the passage of time will not alleviate his despair. This is a very bleak and potent line, implying that his guilt will be a constant companion throughout his life. There is no hope that time will make his pain more bearable.
Literary Devices: Personification (Time is given the ability to help), Paradox (Time is typically seen as a healer, but here it only deepens despair), Alliteration ('time' repeated).
"Let him have time to live a loathed slave,"
Meaning: Let him endure a life of servitude and hatred, both from himself and others. He will be a slave to his guilt, and despised by society.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (Tarquin is not literally a slave, but his guilt makes him one)
"Let him have time a beggar's orts to crave,"
Meaning: Allow him the time to be reduced to begging for scraps (orts) like a common pauper. This depicts his complete downfall from nobility and power to utter destitution.
Literary Devices: Imagery, painting a picture of abject poverty.
"And time to see one that by alms doth live,"
Meaning: And give him the time to see someone who lives solely on charity. This is setting up a stark contrast.
Literary Devices: N/A
"Disdain to him disdained scraps to give."
Meaning: Let him have the time to be refused even the scraps that a beggar living off of alms would scorn to give. This is the ultimate humiliation. He is lower than the lowest.

' Let him have time to tear his curled hair,
Let him have time against himself to rave,
Let him have time of Time's help to despair,
Let him have time to live a loathed slave,
Let him have time a beggar's orts to crave,
And time to see one that by alms doth live Disdain to him disdained scraps to give.

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Literary Devices: Irony, the one-time ruler reduced to a state where even a beggar looks down upon him; Repetition ("disdain" and "disdained") emphasizes the utter contempt he will face.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza is a powerful and vengeful curse placed upon Tarquin, presumably by the speaker (Lucrece herself or someone acting on her behalf, like Collatine or Brutus). It outlines a prolonged, torturous, and utterly humiliating fate for him as punishment for his crime. The key element is the repetition of "Let him have time..." which creates a relentless rhythm and underscores the idea that Tarquin's suffering will be extended over a long period. The stanza emphasizes that Tarquin will not only experience physical and emotional pain, but also social degradation and complete loss of status. He will be utterly alone and despised, even by those who are themselves at the bottom of society. It represents a desire for absolute and complete retribution, ensuring that Tarquin suffers a fate far worse than death.

Key Literary Devices Summary:

Imagery: Vivid descriptions that create a strong emotional impact (tearing hair, raving, begging for scraps).
Personification: "Time's help" gives time human-like qualities.
Paradox: Time, usually a healer, here intensifies despair.
Alliteration: "Time" repeated.
Metaphor: Tarquin as a "loathed slave" (not literally, but in terms of his guilt).
Irony: A former nobleman being scorned by a beggar.
Repetition: "Let him have time..." emphasizes the relentless nature of the curse.
Anaphora: The repetition of the phrase "Let him have time" at the beginning of each line.

This stanza is a masterful example of Shakespeare's ability to create a vivid and emotionally charged portrayal of revenge and despair, using language rich in imagery and rhetorical devices.
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Stanza 142 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices, and then discuss its overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Let him have time to see his friends his foes,"

Breakdown: This line implores that Tarquin should be given ample time to distinguish between
true friends and enemies.
Literary Devices: Alliteration (repetition of the "f" sound in "friends" and "foes") emphasizes the contrast between the two groups.

"And merry fools to mock at him resort;"

Breakdown: This line suggests that Tarquin should be subject to ridicule and derision from foolish, light-hearted people. "Resort" means they should come to him for this purpose.
Literary Devices: Irony (these 'fools' are wise enough to mock him)

"Let him have time to mark how slow time goes"

Breakdown: This introduces a key concept: Tarquin should experience the agonizing slowness of time when in sorrow.
Literary Devices: None in particular. The line relies on the inherent understanding of how time feels when you are unhappy.

"In time of sorrow, and how swift and short"

Breakdown: This line directly contrasts the slow passage of time in sorrow with the rapid passage of time when indulging in pleasure or foolishness.
Literary Devices: Juxtaposition/Contrast (between "slow time" in sorrow and "swift and short" time in folly).

"His time of folly and his time of sport;"

Breakdown: This amplifies that idea: Tarquin should have the chance to see how quickly his pleasurable moments vanished.
Literary Devices: Parallelism (using the same grammatical structure "His time of...") for emphasis. Repetition of "time"

"And ever let his unrecalling crime"

Breakdown: This means Tarquin's crime, which he cannot undo or take back, must always weigh on him. "Unrecalling" means irreversible.
Literary Devices: None in particular

"Have time to wail th' abusing of his time."

Breakdown: Finally, Tarquin should have all the time in the world to lament (wail) the way he misused his time and life through his actions.
Literary Devices: Irony (Time is a thing he has abused and yet now it is the cause of his punishment). Alliteration (the "t" sound in "time to" and "th") connects time to his punishment.

' Let him have time to see his friends his foes,
And merry fools to mock at him resort;
Let him have time to mark how slow time goes
In time of sorrow, and how swift and short
His time of folly and his time of sport;
And ever let his unrecalling crime
Have time to wail th' abusing of his time.

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Overall Meaning and Interpretation:

The stanza is a powerful curse, or a desire for just retribution, levied against Tarquin (implied to be coming from a figure such as Lucrece's husband or father). It's not simply a wish for his death, but a much more elaborate and psychologically torturous fate. The idea is that Tarquin should live with the consequences of his actions, and those consequences should be drawn out and excruciating.

The stanza focuses heavily on the concept of time. The repetition of the word "time" emphasizes its importance. The desire is that he be forced to feel the weight of his crime.

He should realize the true nature of the people around him (friends vs. enemies).
He should be humiliated and mocked.
He should experience the slow agony of sorrow and regret, contrasting sharply with the fleeting pleasure he sought in his crime.
He should be forever haunted by the irreversible nature of his actions.
He should spend an eternity regretting his misuse of time and his life.

In essence, the stanza desires that Tarquin's life be a living hell, a constant reminder of his transgression. The emphasis on "time" suggests a prolonged period of suffering, a punishment far worse than a swift death. The stanza is a complex blend of justice, revenge, and moral condemnation. It is a wish that Tarquin live long enough to fully comprehend the gravity of his crime and to suffer the full consequences.

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← Stanza 142📚 OverviewStanza 144 →

Stanza 143 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 143 of 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line:

Line 1: 'O Time, thou tutor both to good and bad,'

O Time: This is an apostrophe, a direct address to an inanimate object or abstract concept, in this case, Time.
thou tutor both to good and bad: Time is personified as a teacher. The line suggests that Time is impartial, teaching both positive and negative lessons. Time allows for the development of virtue and vice.
Meaning: This line establishes Time as a powerful, neutral force that shapes human behavior for both good and evil.

Line 2: 'Teach me to curse him that thou taught'st this ill!'

Teach me to curse him: Lucrece is asking Time to teach her how to effectively curse Tarquin, the one who committed the "ill" (the rape). She wants to learn the most potent form of malediction. that thou taught'st this ill: This refers back to the idea of Time being a tutor. The implication is that Tarquin's capacity for evil, his ability to commit such a vile act, was somehow fostered by Time's influence or allowance.
Meaning: Lucrece desperately seeks a way to punish Tarquin, believing that Time, as the educator of evil, should also guide her in enacting retribution.

Line 3: 'At his own shadow let the thief run mad,'

At his own shadow let the thief run mad: This is a curse in the form of a wish or a command. Lucrece hopes that Tarquin's guilt and paranoia will drive him insane. The "thief" refers to Tarquin, who has stolen her honor and chastity. His own shadow becomes a symbol of his guilt, perpetually haunting him.
Imagery: The line conjures a vivid image of a man driven to madness by his own inner demons, represented by his shadow.
Meaning: Lucrece desires psychological torment for Tarquin, envisioning him consumed by his own guilt and fear.

Line 4: 'Himself himself seek every hour to kill!'

Himself himself: This repetition emphasizes the intensity of her wish for self-destruction. The doubled "himself" suggests a deep level of internal conflict and self-loathing.
seek every hour to kill: She wishes that he would be constantly tormented by the desire to end his own life.
Meaning: This line continues the curse, intensifying the desire for Tarquin's complete self-destruction. She wants him to be in a perpetual state of suicidal despair.

Line 5: 'Such wretched hands such wretched blood should spill;'

Such wretched hands such wretched blood should spill: The repetition of "wretched" reinforces the idea of Tarquin's depravity. The blood spilling is his own, reinforcing the desire for suicide.
Alliteration: The 's' sound is repeated "Such... should...spill" to emphasize this line.

'O Time, thou tutor both to good and bad,
Teach me to curse him that thou taught'st this ill!
At his own shadow let the thief run mad,
Himself himself seek every hour to kill!
Such wretched hands such wretched blood should spill;
For who so base would such an office have
As slanderous death's-man to so base a slave?

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Meaning: This line reinforces the idea of justice, suggesting that Tarquin's wicked actions necessitate a violent and self-inflicted end. It further emphasizes her desire for him to take his own life.

Line 6: 'For who so base would such an office have'

For who so base would such an office have: This is a rhetorical question. Lucrece asks who could be so low as to perform the job she's about to describe.
Meaning: Lucrece is highlighting the depravity of Tarquin's actions. By asking this question, she's emphasizing how base and unworthy he is.

Line 7: 'As slanderous death's-man to so base a slave?'

slanderous death's-man: This is a metaphor for Tarquin. He is like an executioner who murders (metaphorically, in this case, her honor) through slander and defamation. "Death's-man" refers to the executioner.
so base a slave: This refers to Lucrece herself. She sees herself as a "slave" to Tarquin's lust and the shame he has brought upon her. She believes her life has been rendered worthless by his actions.
Meaning: This line completes the rhetorical question. Lucrece implies that even a hired
executioner, a "death's-man," would be morally superior to Tarquin because he is a "base slave". She sees herself as having been reduced to a state of utter degradation.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza is a powerful expression of Lucrece's rage and despair after her rape. She curses Tarquin with a fervent desire for his psychological torment and self-destruction. She personifies Time, blaming it for fostering the evil within Tarquin. Lucrece sees Tarquin as so depraved that he is lower than even a hired executioner. Her use of vivid imagery, repetition, and rhetorical questions creates a sense of intense emotion and underscores her deep feelings of violation and shame. The stanza functions as a desperate attempt to find justice and reclaim some sense of control in the face of unimaginable trauma. It also sets the stage for Lucrece's own impending suicide, as she views herself as irreparably tainted by Tarquin's actions.

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← Stanza 143📚 OverviewStanza 145 →

Stanza 144 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 144 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"The baser is he, coming from a king,"

Meaning: Someone born into royalty (a king or someone descended from a king) is all the more despicable when he acts in a base (low, morally reprehensible) manner. The expectation is higher. Literary Devices: Inversion (the normal word order would be "He is the baser..."). This
emphasizes the 'baser' quality.

"To shame his hope with deeds degenerate:"

Meaning: To betray the promise and expectations placed upon him by committing degenerate (morally corrupt, base, fallen) acts. He is ruining the reputation and potential of his royal lineage. Literary Devices: Alliteration ("deeds degenerate") emphasizes the fall.

"The mightier man, the mightier is the thing"

Meaning: The more powerful a man is, the more powerful is the force (thing) that...
Literary Devices: Anaphora (repetition of "the mightier") emphasizes the contrast between great status and its potential outcomes.

"That makes him honour'd, or begets him hate;"

Meaning:... either makes him honored (for using his power for good) or causes people to hate him (for abusing his power). This is the "thing" referred to in the previous line: power, opportunity, expectations. It's a double-edged sword.
Literary Devices: Antithesis (honoured/hate) highlights the contrasting possibilities that come with great power.

"For greatest scandal waits on greatest state."

Meaning: The higher one's position or status ("greatest state"), the greater the potential for scandal (outrage, disgrace) when one falls from grace. The higher you are, the harder you fall. Literary Devices: This is a succinct and memorable statement of the stanza's central theme.

"The moon being clouded presently is miss'd,"

Meaning: If the moon, a large and bright presence in the sky, is obscured by clouds, its absence is immediately noticed.
Literary Devices: Analogy. This line starts the analogy that continues in the next line.

"But little stars may hide them when they list."

Meaning: But if small stars disappear, nobody notices, and so they may disappear whenever they please. "List" means "please."
Literary Devices: Analogy. This line completes the analogy. The moon represents a high-ranking person, and the stars represent ordinary people.

Overall Meaning:

'The baser is he, coming from a king,
To shame his hope with deeds degenerate:
The mightier man, the mightier is the thing
That makes him honour'd, or begets him hate;
For greatest scandal waits on greatest state. The moon being clouded presently is miss'd, But little stars may hide them when they list.

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This stanza argues that those in positions of power, particularly those born into royalty, are held to a higher standard. Their actions, especially morally reprehensible ones, are far more damaging and scandalous than the same actions committed by someone of lower status. The higher the position, the greater the expectations, and therefore the greater the potential for disgrace. The final two lines drive this point home with the analogy of the moon and stars: the higher the status, the more one's mistakes are noticed. The ordinary person's mistakes are negligible and easily forgotten. Collatine's status as Lucrece's husband only magnified the shame of Lucrece's rape. Similarly, Tarquin's crime is made worse by his royal standing.

Key Literary Devices Summary:

Inversion: Emphasizes key words by altering normal word order.
Alliteration: Enhances the sound and emphasizes particular phrases.
Anaphora: Repetition emphasizes a contrast.
Antithesis: Highlights the opposing possibilities associated with power.
Analogy: The moon and stars illustrate the theme of higher expectations for those in higher positions.

The stanza is a powerful commentary on the responsibilities of leadership and the consequences of abusing power. It establishes a moral framework by which to judge Tarquin's actions, arguing that his royal status makes his crime all the more abhorrent.

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← Stanza 144📚 OverviewStanza 146 →

Stanza 145 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 145 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then synthesize the overall meaning and highlight the literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"The crow may bathe his coal-black wings in mire,"

Literal Meaning: A crow can dip its black wings in mud (mire).
Figurative Meaning: A person of low status (implied moral "blackness") can engage in shameful actions (the mire) without much notice or consequence.
Literary Devices:
Symbolism: The crow symbolizes someone of low status or with a bad reputation. The mire symbolizes immoral or shameful actions.
Alliteration: "Coal-black" emphasizes the blackness of the crow.

"And unperceived fly with the filth away;"

Literal Meaning: The crow can fly away with the mud unnoticed.
Figurative Meaning: The actions of a person of low status, even if dirty, are easily overlooked
or forgiven. They escape scrutiny.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Creates a visual of the crow escaping unnoticed.

"But if the like the snow-white swan desire,"

Literal Meaning: But if the snow-white swan wants to do the same (bathe in mire).
Figurative Meaning: But if a person of high status (implied moral purity, like the swan) commits a shameful act.
Literary Devices:
Symbolism: The swan symbolizes someone of high status, purity, and reputation.
Contrast: Creates a direct contrast with the crow.
Alliteration: "Snow-white" emphasizes the purity of the swan.

"The stain upon his silver down will stay."

Literal Meaning: The dirt/stain will remain on the swan's white feathers.
Figurative Meaning: The reputation of a person of high status will be permanently damaged by a shameful act. They cannot escape the consequences.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Evokes a vivid image of the swan's soiled feathers.
Metaphor: "Silver down" metaphorically represents the swan's pure reputation.
Alliteration: "Stain" and "stay."

"Poor grooms are sightless night, kings glorious day:"

Literal Meaning: Poor grooms are like a night unseen, Kings like the glorious day.
Figurative Meaning: The lives and actions of the poor and powerless are hidden and unnoticed, while the lives and actions of the powerful (kings) are visible to all.

'The crow may bathe his coal-black wings in mire,
And unperceived fly with the filth away;
But if the like the snow-white swan desire,
The stain upon his silver down will stay.
Poor grooms are sightless night, kings glorious day:
Gnats are unnoted wheresoe'er they fly,
But eagles gazed upon with every eye.

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Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Compares grooms and kings to night and day respectively, highlighting their differing visibility and importance.
Parallelism: Creates balance and reinforces the contrast.
Alliteration: "kings" and "glorious"

"Gnats are unnoted wheresoe'er they fly,"

Literal Meaning: Gnats (small, insignificant insects) go unnoticed wherever they fly.
Figurative Meaning: The actions of unimportant people are disregarded.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Gnats represent insignificant people.

"But eagles gazed upon with every eye."

Literal Meaning: Eagles (large, impressive birds) are watched by everyone.
Figurative Meaning: The actions of powerful or important people are constantly scrutinized and judged.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Eagles represent powerful/important people.
Hyperbole: "Every eye" exaggerates the level of scrutiny.
Contrast: Again, reinforces the difference between the treatment of those of high and low
status.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza conveys the idea that social status significantly affects how actions are perceived and judged. People of low status can commit shameful acts without much notice, but people of high status are held to a much higher standard. Their actions, good or bad, are magnified, and any transgression leaves a lasting stain on their reputation. The stanza highlights the unfairness of the situation. It emphasizes that those in power are subject to greater scrutiny, and thus, greater consequences for their misdeeds. This applies directly to Lucrece's situation; because of her high social standing and virtuous reputation, her rape and subsequent suicide have a much greater impact than if she were a commoner. It foreshadows the political upheaval that will result from Tarquin's crime.

Key Literary Devices Recap:

Symbolism: Crow, Swan, Mire, Night, Day, Gnats, Eagles all symbolize social status, moral character, and visibility.
Metaphor: Using images of birds, insects, and natural phenomena to represent human characters and their actions.
Contrast: The stanza relies heavily on contrasting imagery (crow/swan, night/day, gnats/eagles) to emphasize the different treatment of people based on their social status.
Alliteration: "Coal-black," "snow-white," "stain/stay" creates emphasis and musicality.
Hyperbole: "Every eye" exaggerates the scrutiny given to those of high status.
Imagery: Vivid descriptions that appeal to the senses (especially sight) to create a lasting impression.

This stanza is a powerful commentary on social dynamics, reputation, and the burdens and responsibilities that come with high status. It is also a direct reflection on Lucrece’s plight as a high-born woman who is forever shamed by Tarquin's actions.
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← Stanza 145📚 OverviewStanza 147 →

Stanza 146 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down stanza 146 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices, and then summarize the overall meaning:

Line 1: 'Out, idle words, servants to shallow fools!'

Breakdown: Lucrece is commanding "idle words" to leave. She characterizes them as being "servants" to "shallow fools," suggesting that empty rhetoric is only useful to unintelligent people. "Out" is an imperative command.
Literary Devices:
Apostrophe: She is addressing an inanimate object as if it were a person (idle words).
Metaphor: "Servants to shallow fools" is a metaphorical description of idle words, linking them to
a specific type of person.
Exclamation: The tone is forceful and emotional.

Line 2: 'Unprofitable sounds, weak arbitrators!'

Breakdown: She reinforces the uselessness of words by calling them "unprofitable sounds" and "weak arbitrators." Arbitrators are mediators or judges; she's stating that words cannot resolve her situation effectively.
Literary Devices:
Apostrophe: Continuing from the previous line, she addresses the words directly.
Metaphor: "Weak arbitrators" is a metaphorical description of words, emphasizing their inability
to settle her problem.

Line 3: 'Busy yourselves in skill-contending schools;'

Breakdown: Lucrece suggests that words should be used in "skill-contending schools" (academic debates) instead of trying to assist her. She suggests this is a more appropriate place for them. Literary Devices:
Irony: There is an element of irony here, as she dismisses the value of words in a situation
where one might expect them to be crucial (a legal argument).

Line 4: 'Debate where leisure serves with dull debaters;'

Breakdown: She continues to dismiss the value of words. Where there is time for debate or discussion, the words can be used to argue with "dull debaters".
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: Repetition of the 'd' sound in "dull debaters"
Assonance: Repetition of the vowel sound 'e' in 'debate', 'leisure', 'debaters'

Line 5: 'To trembling clients be you mediators:'

Breakdown: She advises words to be mediators or advocates for nervous clients; implying that words are only useful in these standard scenarios.
Literary Devices:
Apostrophe: Continuation of addressing the words directly.

'Out, idle words, servants to shallow fools!
Unprofitable sounds, weak arbitrators!
Busy yourselves in skill-contending schools;
Debate where leisure serves with dull debaters;
To trembling clients be you mediators:
For me, I force not argument a straw,
Since that my case is past the help of law.

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Line 6: 'For me, I force not argument a straw,'

Breakdown: Lucrece declares that, as for herself, she doesn't care for argument "a straw," meaning she places no value in argument.
Literary Devices:
Understatement: "A straw" emphasizes how little importance she places on argument.

Line 7: 'Since that my case is past the help of law.'

Breakdown: She explains why she doesn't value argument: her situation is beyond legal remedy. Law cannot help her; the "rape" has already happened and the damage is irreparable.
Literary Devices:
Reasoning: This line provides the reason for the preceding dismissal of words.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece expresses her profound disillusionment with language and its power. She believes that words are essentially useless in her situation. She has been raped, and the law, argument, and debate are all incapable of undoing the violation she has suffered. She directs words to be used in trivial contexts like academic debates or mediating minor legal disputes, implying that they are incapable of dealing with the severity of her trauma. Her case is beyond legal recourse, thus rendering words and arguments irrelevant to her. This stanza highlights the devastating impact of the rape on Lucrece, emphasizing her sense of powerlessness and the futility of seeking justice through conventional means. The language serves to underscore the inadequacy of words to address the deep wound she has suffered.

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← Stanza 146📚 OverviewStanza 148 →

Stanza 147 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 147 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece and then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"In vain I rail at Opportunity":

In vain: This phrase is repeated throughout the stanza, emphasizing the futility of Lucrece's efforts. It sets a tone of despair and powerlessness.
Rail at Opportunity: To "rail" means to protest bitterly or vehemently. Lucrece is angrily blaming Opportunity for presenting the situation that allowed Tarquin to rape her. Opportunity represents the circumstances that allowed the crime to occur.

"At Time, at Tarquin, and uncheerful Night;":

This line continues the list of things Lucrece is railing against.
Time: Lucrece blames time itself, perhaps for allowing the events to unfold or for not preventing them.
Tarquin: The clear and direct blaming of Tarquin is a crucial point. He is the agent of the crime. Uncheerful Night: Night, being dark and secretive, is seen as complicit in the crime. It provided the cover for Tarquin's actions. Personification of night as 'uncheerful'.

"In vain I cavil with mine infamy,":

Cavil: To raise petty or trivial objections. Here, it means Lucrece is arguing or quibbling with the shame or dishonor she feels she has incurred.
Infamy: The shame and disgrace that has now befallen her because of the rape. She is trying to reason her way out of the shame, but it is no use.

"In vain I spurn at my confirm'd despite:":

Spurn: To reject or kick away, figuratively pushing back against something.
Confirm'd despite: "Despite" means malice, contempt, or defiance. "Confirm'd" suggests that this spite/contempt/hatred (likely directed at herself or the situation) is now a fixed and
unchangeable part of her reality.

"This helpless smoke of words doth me no right.":

Helpless smoke of words: This is a powerful metaphor. Lucrece's words, her complaints, her railing, are insubstantial and ineffective, like smoke dissipating into the air. They offer no real justice or relief. Alliteration - 'helpless' and 'smoke' adds emphasis to the image.
Doth me no right: They do not bring her justice, repair her honor, or ease her pain.

"The remedy indeed to do me good":

The remedy indeed: This signals a shift in thought. She is now proposing a solution.
To do me good: This phrase clarifies that the remedy is not just about justice, but about restoring something within herself.

' In vain I rail at Opportunity,
At Time, at Tarquin, and uncheerful Night;
In vain I cavil with mine infamy,
In vain I spurn at my confirm'd despite:
This helpless smoke of words doth me no right. The remedy indeed to do me good
Is to let forth my foul-defiled blood.

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"Is to let forth my foul-defiled blood.":

Let forth my foul-defiled blood: This is the climax and the tragic conclusion. Lucrece believes the only way to cleanse herself of the stain of the rape is through suicide, through the shedding of
her "foul-defiled blood." This is a stark and disturbing image, suggesting that she sees herself as permanently tainted. Alliteration - 'foul' and 'defiled' emphasizes the intensity of the defilement in Lucrece's eyes.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza expresses Lucrece's profound despair and her belief that she is irreparably damaged by the rape. She recognizes the futility of words to restore her honor or ease her pain. She has railed against the events and circumstances that led to the rape but ultimately sees death as the only "remedy" for her defilement. She has internalised the shame of the crime and views herself as unclean, unworthy of life.

Literary Devices:

Repetition (Anaphora): The repeated phrase "In vain" emphasizes the futility of Lucrece's actions and thoughts.
Metaphor: "Helpless smoke of words" is a powerful metaphor that illustrates the ineffectiveness of her lamentations.
Alliteration: "Helpless smoke", "foul-defiled blood".
Personification: "Uncheerful Night" gives human-like qualities to the night, making it complicit in the crime.
Imagery: The image of letting forth her "foul-defiled blood" is a strong and visceral image. Contrast: The contrast between the futile "smoke of words" and the decisive action of letting blood highlights the shift in Lucrece's thinking.

In summary, this stanza encapsulates Lucrece's tragic realization that words are meaningless in the face of her defilement, leading her to the desperate conclusion that only death can restore her honor. It is a powerful and poignant expression of shame, despair, and the destructive power of patriarchal values.

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← Stanza 147📚 OverviewStanza 149 →

Stanza 148 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 148 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identifying literary devices and then piecing together the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Poor hand, why quiver'st thou at this decree?"

Breakdown: Lucrece is addressing her own hand, which is presumably holding the dagger she intends to use to kill herself. She's asking why her hand is trembling at the "decree" – the decision, the command – to kill herself.
Literary Devices:
Apostrophe: Direct address to an inanimate object (her hand).
Personification: Giving the hand the human quality of quivering and having fear.
Rhetorical Question: She's not really expecting an answer; it's a way to express her inner turmoil.

"Honour thyself to rid me of this shame:"

Breakdown: She urges her hand to act honorably by freeing her from the overwhelming shame she feels after being raped by Tarquin. The act of suicide is framed as a way to reclaim honor. Literary Devices:
Personification: Again, the hand is being given the ability to possess "honour" and to act
upon it.
Alliteration: The repetition of the "h" sound in "honour" and "thyself" creates emphasis.

"For if I die, my honour lives in thee;"

Breakdown: She argues that if she dies by her own hand, her honor will be preserved in the act of suicide itself. The implication is that her honor will reside in her hand, which performed the act. Literary Devices:
Paradox: The idea that death can lead to life (of honor) is paradoxical.
Metaphor: Honor is being represented as something tangible that can live or die.

"But if I live, thou livest in my defame:"

Breakdown: Conversely, if she chooses to live after being raped, her hand (and, by extension, she herself) will be perpetually stained by the shame and dishonor of the act. "Defame" means disgrace.
Literary Devices:
Antithesis: Direct contrast to the previous line. Death = honor; Life = dishonor.
Metaphor: Defame is portrayed as a state of being that one "lives in".

"Since thou couldst not defend thy loyal dame,"

Breakdown: This is a stinging indictment of her own weakness. She blames her hand (again, representing herself) for failing to protect her from Tarquin's attack. "Dame" means lady or mistress.

' Poor hand, why quiver'st thou at this decree?
Honour thyself to rid me of this shame:
For if I die, my honour lives in thee;
But if I live, thou livest in my defame:
Since thou couldst not defend thy loyal dame, And wast afeard to scratch her wicked foe, Kill both thyself and her for yielding so.'

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Literary Devices:
Personification: The hand should have defended her.
Metonymy: The hand represents Lucrece herself, as it should have been the instrument of her defense.

"And wast afeard to scratch her wicked foe,"

Breakdown: She accuses her hand of being too afraid to even scratch or harm Tarquin. This emphasizes her sense of helplessness and her self-reproach for not resisting more forcefully. Literary Devices:
Alliteration: "wast", "wicked"

"Kill both thyself and her for yielding so."

Breakdown: The final, harsh command. She demands that her hand kill both itself and her (Lucrece) as punishment for succumbing to Tarquin's assault and failing to defend her honor. She views her yielding, whether forced or partially compliant in her own mind, as a fatal flaw.
Literary Devices:
Hyperbole: The harshness of the command emphasizes the extremity of her feelings.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza is a powerful exploration of Lucrece's internal conflict and her obsession with honor after being raped. She is consumed by shame and believes that her only path to redemption is through suicide. She personifies her hand, blaming it for her perceived failure to resist the assault, and argues that only by ending her life can she preserve her honor. The stanza highlights the patriarchal societal pressures of the time, where a woman's worth was intimately tied to her chastity and where rape was seen as a stain that could only be cleansed by death. It showcases her extreme emotional state, bordering on self-loathing and a desperate need to control her narrative, even through death. She views her body as tainted, and she sees her hand as a symbol of her powerlessness.

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Stanza 149 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then look at the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"This said, from her be-tumbled couch she starteth,"

"This said": Refers to her internal decision, likely her resolve to take action after the rape (likely referring to a resolve to take her own life).
"from her be-tumbled couch": The bed is described as "be-tumbled," emphasizing the
violence and disruption of the rape. It's a visual image of the struggle and disarray. "Be-" is an archaic prefix.
"she starteth": She jumps up suddenly from the bed. The verb "starteth" suggests a frantic, impulsive action.

"To find some desperate instrument of death:"

"To find": Her purpose is clear - she is searching, urgently.
"some desperate instrument of death": She seeks any object that can kill her. The adjective "desperate" underscores her mental state and the severity of her situation. "Instrument of death" is a euphemism, softening the harsh reality.

"But this no slaughterhouse no tool imparteth"

"But this no slaughterhouse": The immediate environment, the room where she finds herself, is contrasted with a slaughterhouse. She cannot easily find what she seeks.
"no tool imparteth": Emphasizes the lack of tools available for her suicide. "Imparteth" means to give or provide. The room does not offer her a quick way out.

"To make more vent for passage of her breath;"

"To make more vent for passage of her breath": This describes what she intends to do to
her body. "Vent for passage" is a roundabout way of saying a wound or opening to release her
life. This hints at a violent act of self-harm.

"Which, thronging through her lips, so vanisheth"

"Which, thronging through her lips": This describes the act of exhaling. "Thronging" suggests her breath is rushed, panicked, or filled with her pent-up emotion.
"so vanisheth": Her breath fades away quickly.

"As smoke from AEtna, that in air consumes,"

"As smoke from AEtna": This is a simile. Mount Etna, a Sicilian volcano, is used as a
comparison. The imagery is of smoke rising from a powerful, destructive source.
"that in air consumes": The smoke dissipates into the air. This mirrors the way Lucrece's breath (and potentially her life) will disappear.

This said, from her be-tumbled couch she starteth,
To find some desperate instrument of death:
But this no slaughterhouse no tool imparteth
To make more vent for passage of her breath;
Which, thronging through her lips, so vanisheth As smoke from AEtna, that in air consumes,
Or that which from discharged cannon fumes.

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"Or that which from discharged cannon fumes."

"Or that which from discharged cannon fumes": Another simile. This is a comparison to
smoke from a fired cannon. This image reinforces violence and sudden release of energy.
"Fumes" suggests a short, quick puff of smoke.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza depicts Lucrece's immediate reaction to her rape. She is filled with despair and a desire for death. She desperately looks for a weapon, but cannot find one. The stanza focuses on her breath, using vivid similes of smoke from Mount Etna and a cannon to illustrate how quickly and completely she feels her life and spirit are fading away. The imagery emphasizes the violence and destruction that has been inflicted upon her. The stanza sets the stage for her eventual suicide and highlights the profound sense of loss and hopelessness she experiences.

Literary Devices:

Simile: The stanza relies heavily on simile to convey Lucrece's state of mind. The comparisons to smoke from Mount Etna and cannon fumes powerfully illustrate the fleeting nature of her breath
and the destructive force of the rape.
Euphemism: "Instrument of death" is a more delicate way of referring to a weapon for suicide. Imagery: The stanza is rich in vivid imagery, especially the descriptions of the "be-tumbled couch," the smoke from Etna, and the cannon fumes. These images create a strong sense of the scene and Lucrece's emotional state.
Alliteration: AEtna and air. The /a/ sound here reinforces the fading nature of Lucrece's breath. Personification: "No tool imparteth." Giving the room or tools the ability to "impart" or give something.

In essence, this stanza is a powerful snapshot of Lucrece's devastation and her suicidal ideation, conveyed through striking imagery and carefully chosen language.

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← Stanza 149📚 OverviewStanza 151 →

Stanza 150 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 150 of The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identifying literary devices and then arriving at an overall understanding.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"In vain,' quoth she, 'I live, and seek in vain"

'In vain' (Anaphora): The repetition of "In vain" emphasizes Lucrece's despair and feelings of futility. She believes her existence is now pointless and all her efforts to find a solution are
fruitless.
"quoth she": An archaic way of saying "said she," adding to the poem's elevated and dramatic tone.

Meaning: Lucrece declares that she sees no purpose in her continued existence, and her search for a way out of her suffering seems hopeless.

"Some happy mean to end a hapless life."

"Happy mean": This refers to a balanced or ideal way to end her life. She's not just looking for death, but a death that preserves some semblance of honor or dignity. This is highly Ironic. "Hapless life": This emphasizes the unfortunate and miserable state her life has become because of Tarquin's actions.
Alliteration: of 'h' in "happy" and "hapless" emphasizes her situation.
Meaning: She is seeking a dignified way to end her life, one that won't further stain her reputation, which is now ruined.

"I fear'd by Tarquin's falchion to be slain,"

"Falchion": A type of sword; its use is to provide an elevated way to reference Tarquin's attack. Meaning: Ironically, she had feared being killed by Tarquin during his assault, but now she desires death as a means of escaping the shame.

"Yet for the self-same purpose seek a knife:"

"Self-same purpose": Referring back to the previous line, the purpose is death.
Meaning: While she feared Tarquin's sword, she is now actively seeking a knife as a tool for her own death, driven by the shame and dishonor inflicted upon her.

"But when I fear'd I was a loyal wife:"

Meaning: She refers to the past when she was afraid of losing her life to Tarquin, she was comforted by her belief that she was a faithful and virtuous wife. This was her shield against her fear.

"So am I now: O no, that cannot be;"

Internal Conflict: This line shows her internal struggle. She desperately wants to believe she is still a loyal wife, untainted by Tarquin's act, but immediately recognizes the impossibility of it. Meaning: She initially asserts that she is still a loyal wife, but then immediately contradicts herself, recognizing that the rape has changed everything.

' In vain,' quoth she, 'I live, and seek in vain
Some happy mean to end a hapless life.
I fear'd by Tarquin's falchion to be slain,
Yet for the self-same purpose seek a knife:
But when I fear'd I was a loyal wife:
So am I now: O no, that cannot be;
Of that true type hath Tarquin rifled me.

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"Of that true type hath Tarquin rifled me."

"True type": Refers to the ideal of a virtuous, loyal wife.
"Rifled": Means robbed, plundered, or violated. It's a strong and evocative word that
emphasizes the violence and completeness of Tarquin's assault, as well as the permanence of her loss.
Meaning: Tarquin's rape has stripped her of her identity as a virtuous wife, leaving her feeling empty and irrevocably changed. He has stolen her status as the "true type" of a loyal wife.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza captures Lucrece's profound despair and internal conflict following the rape. She is contemplating suicide as a means of escaping the unbearable shame and dishonor that Tarquin has inflicted upon her. She initially sought a way to end her life with honour. She wrestles with her identity as a loyal wife, desperately wanting to cling to that ideal but recognizing that Tarquin's violence has irrevocably changed her and stripped her of that virtue. The stanza highlights her sense of hopelessness, her desire for death, and the complete devastation she feels as a result of the rape. The repetition, stark imagery, and internal conflict effectively convey Lucrece's agonizing emotional state. The stanza foreshadows her impending suicide.

Literary Devices Highlighted:

Anaphora: Repetition of "In vain" to emphasize futility.
Alliteration: Repetition of 'h' in "happy" and "hapless"
Irony: Ironic as she sought a 'happy mean' to her end.
Internal Conflict: The "So am I now: O no, that cannot be;" line demonstrates her struggle. Metaphor: "Rifled" compares Tarquin's action to a complete and violent robbery of her virtue. Imagery: The "falchion" and "knife" create vivid images of violence and death.
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← Stanza 150📚 OverviewStanza 152 →

Stanza 151 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 151 of 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line, highlighting the literary devices used, and then providing an overall interpretation.

Line 1: 'O, that is gone for which I sought to live,'

Analysis: This line expresses Lucrece's profound despair. "That" refers to her chastity and honor, which she considers the sole reason for her existence. Now that it's lost, she sees no purpose in living.
Literary Device:
Metonymy: "That" stands in for her chastity and honor, using a related concept to represent the abstract idea.

Line 2: 'And therefore now I need not fear to die.'

Analysis: Logically follows from the previous line. Since the reason for her living is gone, the fear of death is also gone. Death is no longer a threat but a release.
Literary Device:
Logical Consequence: The sentence is a direct result of the preceding statement.

Line 3: 'To clear this spot by death, at least I give'

Analysis: Lucrece believes her death will, in some way, cleanse the stain of her rape. "This spot" refers to her body, her reputation, and the shame brought upon her family. She views her death as a form of atonement.

Literary Device:
Metaphor: "Spot" represents the stain of dishonor.

Line 4: 'A badge of fame to slander's livery;'

Analysis: "Livery" is the uniform worn by servants, in this case the "servants" of Slander. By killing herself, she is turning her death into a symbol of Slander's victory, but also giving it a badge of fame. The phrase is complex. Her death provides concrete proof of the devastation slander (i.e., the damage to her reputation) has wrought, making the slander itself more "famous" or powerful. But there's also an ironic suggestion that her death, though born of slander, will ultimately bring her fame for virtue and sacrifice.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Slander is personified as an entity with servants. "Livery" is a visual metaphor. Paradox/Ironic Twist: Her death is meant to clear her name, but it simultaneously gives
slander a "badge of fame".

Line 5: 'A dying life to living infamy:'

Analysis: This line further emphasizes the paradoxical nature of Lucrece's decision. Her "dying life" (her death) will ensure that Tarquin's "living infamy" (his lasting disgrace) will persist. Her death becomes a testament to his crime.

Literary Devices:
Antithesis: "Dying life" versus "living infamy." The contrasting words highlight the opposing
forces at play.
Juxtaposition: Putting these two concepts close together emphasizes their contrast.

'O, that is gone for which I sought to live,
And therefore now I need not fear to die.
To clear this spot by death, at least I give
A badge of fame to slander's livery;
A dying life to living infamy:
Poor helpless help, the treasure stol'n away, To burn the guiltless casket where it lay!

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Line 6: 'Poor helpless help, the treasure stol'n away,'

Analysis: This is a poignant description of Lucrece herself. She is "poor helpless help" because she cannot truly help herself. Even her suicide is a form of "help," an attempt to restore honor, but it's tragically insufficient. "The treasure stol'n away" refers to her lost chastity.
Literary Devices:
Oxymoron: "Helpless help" highlights the inadequacy of her actions.
Metaphor: She is "the treasure stol'n away," equating her chastity to a valuable possession.

Line 7: 'To burn the guiltless casket where it lay!'

Analysis: The "guiltless casket" is Lucrece's body, which is innocent of the crime of rape. The "it" in "where it lay" refers back to the treasure, her chastity. Burning the casket signifies destroying her body, an act driven by the theft of her chastity. She is punishing the vessel that held the treasure that was taken.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Her body is compared to a "casket."
Imagery: The image of burning is vivid and reinforces the sense of destruction and sacrifice.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza reveals Lucrece's desperate and tormented state of mind. She believes that her honor is irreparably damaged, and she can only restore it through death. Her death is not seen as a mere act of despair, but as a complex and paradoxical attempt to cleanse the "spot" of dishonor, provide a lasting indictment of Tarquin's crime, and prevent further infamy. The stanza is filled with contrasting ideas, such as dying life versus living infamy, and helpless help. These contrasts underscore the tragic irony of Lucrece's situation and her attempt to regain control of her reputation through self-destruction. Ultimately, she sees her body as a tainted vessel, a "guiltless casket," that must be destroyed to atone for the stolen "treasure" of her chastity. The stanza is a powerful exploration of honor, shame, and the destructive consequences of sexual violence.

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← Stanza 151📚 OverviewStanza 153 →

Stanza 152 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices used, and then arrive at an overall interpretation.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Well, well, dear Collatine, thou shalt not know"

Explanation: This is Lucrece addressing her absent husband, Collatine (in her mind). The
repetition of "Well, well" expresses a pained resignation or acceptance of a difficult situation. She
is preparing him, though he is not present to hear. She begins by assuring him he will not know
the truth.
Literary Devices: Apostrophe (addressing an absent person)

"The stained taste of violated troth;"

Explanation: This uses sensory imagery to describe the situation. "Stained taste" refers to the bitterness and defilement of a broken marriage vow (troth). The word "violated" shows the severity of the act.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (marriage vow is described as something tasted), Imagery (sensory description of a broken marriage vow). Alliteration of "stained" and "taste".

"I will not wrong thy true affection so,"

Explanation: Lucrece says she will not inflict further pain on Collatine by telling him the truth and letting him know he's now a cuckold. She sees his love as something pure and good that she wants to protect.
Literary Devices: Irony (She believes she is protecting him, but her silence perpetuates the injustice).

"To flatter thee with an infringed oath;"

Explanation: "Infringed oath" is another term for a broken promise or vow, like their marriage vows. She doesn't want to deceive him by pretending their marriage is still whole when it has been irrevocably broken. "Flatter" here means to deceive with false hope or a pleasing lie.
Literary Devices: Euphemism ("infringed oath" softens the harsh reality).

"This bastard graff shall never come to growth:"

Explanation: This is a crucial line. "Graff" refers to a cutting or shoot from one plant inserted into another in grafting. The "bastard graff" represents the child that might result from Tarquin's rape, and she vows that this child will never be born. This is a clear indication that she has decided to kill herself to prevent this.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (comparing a potential child of rape to a "bastard graff"). Foreshadowing (her suicide is implied).

"He shall not boast who did thy stock pollute"

Explanation: Here, Lucrece continues her thoughts from the previous line, and now begins to discuss Tarquin more directly. "He who did thy stock pollute" refers to Tarquin who has

'Well, well, dear Collatine, thou shalt not know
The stained taste of violated troth;
I will not wrong thy true affection so,
To flatter thee with an infringed oath;
This bastard graff shall never come to growth:
He shall not boast who did thy stock pollute That thou art doting father of his fruit.

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dishonored Collatine by defiling Lucrece. She won't let Tarquin triumph by fathering a child that will carry his (Tarquin's) blood into Collatine's family line.
Literary Devices: Metaphor ("stock pollute" refers to the family line being tainted).

"That thou art doting father of his fruit."

Explanation: This is the final nail in the coffin. The line ends with the idea that Collatine should never be forced to believe that he is the "doting father" to a child that Tarquin created through
rape. The word 'doting' suggests an overfondness for the child, which is a bitter and horrific
thought for Lucrece. "His fruit" continues the metaphor.
Literary Devices: Metaphor ("his fruit" referring to the child). Dramatic Irony (The reader knows
she will take her own life, which she knows will prevent this future).

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece is engaged in a painful internal monologue. She is resigned to the fact that her purity has been violated. She declares that she will not burden Collatine with the knowledge of her rape, believing it will spare him further suffering. More significantly, she resolves that she will prevent the birth of a child from the rape, whom she refers to as a "bastard graff." She is determined that Tarquin will not gain the satisfaction of polluting Collatine's lineage. This stanza strongly foreshadows Lucrece's suicide, as it is her death that will ensure the rape has no lasting consequences in terms of lineage. She is taking control of the situation by sacrificing herself. The language is full of bitterness, imagery of corruption and impurity, and a determination to preserve Collatine's honor, even at the cost of her own life. The stanza is full of tragic irony.

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Stanza 153 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 153 from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line and then discuss the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Nor shall he smile at thee in secret thought,"

Meaning: Tarquin will not secretly gloat or feel amusement about what he did to Lucrece. She ensures that this secret humiliation won't happen.
Literary Devices:
Negative Construction: The "Nor" emphasizes the absence of Tarquin's satisfaction.

"Nor laugh with his companions at thy state:"

Meaning: Tarquin will not boast or joke with his friends about having violated her. He won't publicly or privately revel in her degradation.
Literary Devices:
Parallelism: The structure mirrors the previous line, reinforcing the denial of Tarquin's potential joy.
Negative Construction: Similar to the first line, the "Nor" continues the emphasis on what won't happen.

"But thou shalt know thy interest was not bought"

Meaning: Lucrece wants it to be known, that she did not give in to Tarquin for financial gain or some other base reason. Her virtue was not something that could be purchased.
Literary Devices:
Direct Address: "thou shalt know" directly speaks to the listener/reader, emphasizing the importance of this understanding.

"Basely with gold, but stol'n from forth thy gate."

Meaning: Her virtue/honor was not bought with gold, but forcibly taken from her, "stol'n from forth thy gate", meaning her home and being. It stresses the element of theft and violation. Literary Devices:
Contrast/Antithesis: "Basely with gold" is contrasted with "stol'n from forth thy gate," highlighting the difference between a willing transaction (buying) and violent seizure (theft). Metaphor: Her virtue/honor is treated as something physical that could be stolen.
Alliteration: The repetition of "f" sounds in "stol'n from forth" creates a harsh, forceful effect.

"For me, I am the mistress of my fate,"

Meaning: Lucrece asserts her control over her own destiny, even in the face of such a horrific violation. She will decide what happens next.
Literary Devices:
Assertion: This is a powerful declaration of agency. It shows her defiance against being
defined solely by Tarquin's actions.
Metaphor: She is the "mistress of my fate," signifying her determination to control the narrative.

' Nor shall he smile at thee in secret thought,
Nor laugh with his companions at thy state:
But thou shalt know thy interest was not bought
Basely with gold, but stol'n from forth thy gate.
For me, I am the mistress of my fate,
And with my trespass never will dispense,
Till life to death acquit my forced offence.

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"And with my trespass never will dispense,"

Meaning: She will never forgive herself for this 'trespass' (here referring to the rape and its aftermath on her honor). She will not allow the violation to go unpunished, even if the 'punishment' is self-inflicted.
Literary Devices:
Euphemism: "My trespass" is a delicate way of referring to the rape, perhaps reflecting Lucrece's internal struggle to name the event directly.
Hyperbole: She is overemphasizing that she will never forgive herself.

"Till life to death acquit my forced offence."

Meaning: Only death will atone for the 'offence' that was forced upon her. Only through death can she reclaim her honor.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "Life" is personified as being able to "acquit" her offense, implying that living
with the shame is itself a kind of sentence.
Irony: The ultimate acquittal comes through death, a grim twist on the idea of justice. Alliteration: "forced offence" creates emphasis on the violation.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is crucial in understanding Lucrece's mindset and her impending suicide. She is determined to take control of the narrative surrounding her rape. She ensures that Tarquin won't find joy in his victory and asserts that her virtue was not something easily compromised. She reclaims her agency, stating she is the "mistress of my fate," and that the only resolution for this horrible, forced violation is through death. The stanza shows Lucrece grappling with shame and honor, ultimately deciding that suicide is the only way to cleanse her stained reputation and prevent further exploitation. The stanza highlights themes of honor, reputation, control, and the devastating consequences of sexual violence. It foreshadows her suicide as the only way she can see to regain her lost virtue and control over her destiny. The language is powerful, and the use of literary devices underscores the gravity of her decision and her profound sense of violation.

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← Stanza 153📚 OverviewStanza 155 →

Stanza 154 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 154 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece. This stanza is crucial as it marks Lucrece's resolve to reveal the truth of what happened to her.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"I will not poison thee with my attaint,"

"I will not poison thee": Lucrece is addressing someone (probably her husband, Collatine, or perhaps more broadly, the world/society). She won't metaphorically "poison" them, or taint them, with her shame.
"with my attaint": "Attaint" refers to disgrace, dishonor, corruption, or stain of guilt. Lucrece
feels utterly corrupted by the rape. She fears she will corrupt others by association.
Literary Device: Metaphor. The "poisoning" is not literal, but a metaphorical contamination of her honor and potential corruption of those connected to her.

"Nor fold my fault in cleanly-coin'd excuses;"

"fold my fault": She won't hide or conceal her "fault" (the rape, even though it was committed against her will). She refuses to try and bury what happened.
"in cleanly-coin'd excuses": "Cleanly-coin'd" means newly made, polished, or cleverly fabricated. She won't create elaborate, artful, or superficially acceptable excuses to diminish the truth. She will not try to package the horror into something palatable.
Literary Device: Metaphor. The excuses are likened to newly minted coins, suggesting they are manufactured and ultimately worthless in representing the true horror.

"My sable ground of sin I will not paint,"

"My sable ground of sin": "Sable" means black or dark, indicating the base, foundation, or canvas of her sin. The event itself is the origin of the sin. This suggests Lucrece blames herself to some degree, or that the act has become ingrained in her sense of self.
"I will not paint": She won't try to beautify, disguise, or cover up the dark reality.
Literary Device: Metaphor. The rape is conceived as a "sable ground" or dark canvas, something she might try to cover with paint. "Paint" here symbolizes deception and aesthetic alteration for the sake of appearance.

"To hide the truth of this false night's abuses:"

"hide the truth": Emphasizes her intention to be honest, despite the shame.
"this false night's abuses": "False" might imply a night of deception or violation of justice and natural order. "Abuses" refers to the violent and wrongful acts committed against her.
Literary Device: Alliteration (repetition of the "f" sound in "false" and "abuses") adds emphasis.

"My tongue shall utter all; mine eyes, like sluices,"

"My tongue shall utter all": She promises to speak everything, to fully articulate the horror
she endured.
"mine eyes, like sluices": Her eyes, in anticipation of speaking the truth, will act as "sluices,"
or floodgates. This means her tears will flow freely.

' I will not poison thee with my attaint,
Nor fold my fault in cleanly-coin'd excuses;
My sable ground of sin I will not paint,
To hide the truth of this false night's abuses:
My tongue shall utter all; mine eyes, like sluices, As from a mountain-spring that feeds a dale,
Shall gush pure streams to purge my impure tale.'

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Literary Device: Simile. Her eyes are directly compared to sluices, emphasizing the forceful and abundant outpouring of tears.

"As from a mountain-spring that feeds a dale,"

"As from a mountain-spring that feeds a dale": The tears are compared to a pure spring originating in the mountains, flowing down to nourish a valley ("dale"). This reinforces the image of abundance and purity.
Literary Device: Simile (extending the simile from the previous line) and imagery. The imagery is very evocative, suggesting a natural, cleansing force.

"Shall gush pure streams to purge my impure tale."

"Shall gush pure streams": The tears, again, are described as pure and flowing freely. "Gush" further emphasizes the intensity.
"to purge my impure tale": She believes that by telling her story, accompanied by tears, she
can somehow cleanse or purify the shame associated with the "impure tale" of the rape. She sees her catharsis tied to the act of speaking truth.
Literary Device: Juxtaposition or paradox. The "pure streams" (tears) are meant to cleanse the "impure tale" (the rape). This highlights the conflict between her purity and the defilement she suffered.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece makes a powerful declaration. She resolves to tell the truth about the rape, refusing to hide it behind deceptive excuses or attempts to beautify the horror. She embraces the painful reality and commits to exposing the truth. She envisions her tears as a cleansing force, a way to purge the shame and dishonor she feels as a result of the crime committed against her. The act of speaking the truth, even the horrible truth, is presented as a form of purification. It is through the truth that Lucrece finds a way to reclaim some agency and control in the face of her utter violation. This stanza is a pivotal moment in the poem, setting the stage for Lucrece's narrative and ultimate act. She will not be silenced by shame. She will use her voice, and her tears, to bear witness.

Key Literary Devices Summary:

Metaphor: "Poison thee with my attaint," "fold my fault in cleanly-coin'd excuses," "My sable ground of sin I will not paint."
Simile: "Mine eyes, like sluices, as from a mountain-spring that feeds a dale."
Imagery: The vivid descriptions of tears as pure streams from a mountain spring. Alliteration: "False night's abuses"
Juxtaposition/Paradox: "Pure streams" to purge an "impure tale."

I hope this detailed breakdown is helpful! Let me know if you have any other questions.

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← Stanza 154📚 OverviewStanza 156 →

Stanza 155 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 155 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identifying the key elements and then putting it all together to understand the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"By this, lamenting Philomel had ended":

Meaning: "By this time," (meaning around now) the mythic nightingale, Philomel (who was raped and had her tongue cut out, hence her "lamenting"), had finished singing.
Literary Devices:
Allusion: To the myth of Philomela. This immediately establishes a connection between
Lucrece and another woman who suffered a brutal sexual assault. This comparison sets the
tone for Lucrece's reaction.

"The well-tuned warble of her nightly sorrow,":

Meaning: The nightingale's beautiful, melodious song, expressing her deep grief, had stopped for the night.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: The words "well-tuned warble" create a vivid auditory image of the bird's song. Personification: Sorrow is personified as something that can be expressed through a song. Alliteration: The repetition of the 'w' sound in "well-tuned warble" adds to the musicality of
the line.

"And solemn night with slow sad gait descended":

Meaning: Night, personified as a somber figure, slowly moved toward hell.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Night is given human qualities ("solemn," "sad," "gait").
Imagery: The "slow sad gait" creates a visual image of the night dragging itself away, emphasizing the darkness and depression of the scene.
Metaphor: Suggests that night is essentially a journey to hell, reinforcing the idea that the night of the rape was a descent into a dark, horrible experience.

"To ugly hell; when, lo, the blushing morrow":

Meaning: Night left for hell, and then, surprisingly, the "blushing morrow" (morning) arrives. Literary Devices:
Personification: "Blushing morrow" personifies morning, giving it the human action of blushing.
Contrast: The arrival of the "blushing morrow" creates a stark contrast with the "solemn
night" and "ugly hell." The innocence of morning is juxtaposed with the horror of the previous night.
Interjection: "Lo" is an archaic interjection, emphasizing the surprise and suddenness of the morning's arrival.

By this, lamenting Philomel had ended
The well-tuned warble of her nightly sorrow,
And solemn night with slow sad gait descended
To ugly hell; when, lo, the blushing morrow
Lends light to all fair eyes that light will borrow: But cloudy Lucrece shames herself to see,
And therefore still in night would cloister'd be.

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"Lends light to all fair eyes that light will borrow:":

Meaning: Morning gives its light to all eyes that are willing to receive it.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Light is personified as something that can be lent.
Metaphor: "Borrow" suggests that eyes are dependent on morning for light.

"But cloudy Lucrece shames herself to see,":

Meaning: But Lucrece, whose mind is "cloudy" with sorrow and shame, feels too ashamed to look at the light of day.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Lucrece's mind is "cloudy," suggesting confusion, sorrow, and a lack of clarity. Contrast: This line contrasts Lucrece with the "fair eyes" in the previous line. She is no longer "fair" because of what has happened to her.
Allusion: Echoing the theme of shame and dishonour.

"And therefore still in night would cloister'd be.":

Meaning: And therefore, she wants to remain hidden in darkness.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: "Cloister'd be" creates an image of Lucrece enclosed and isolated, like a nun in a convent, seeking refuge from the world.
Symbolism: Night symbolizes the darkness of her trauma, her shame, and her desire to hide
from the world.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza sets the stage for Lucrece's struggle with the aftermath of her rape. The contrast between the emerging morning and Lucrece's desire to remain in darkness highlights the psychological impact of the assault. While the world moves on, bathed in the light of a new day, Lucrece is trapped in the darkness of her trauma and shame. The allusions to Philomela, the use of personification, and the vivid imagery all contribute to a powerful portrayal of Lucrece's internal state. She is fundamentally altered by the violation and can no longer face the world. The stanza emphasizes Lucrece's alienation and her desire to withdraw from the world, foreshadowing her tragic fate. She feels tainted and unable to participate in the restorative power of the new day. This highlights the social and psychological consequences of sexual violence.

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← Stanza 155📚 OverviewStanza 157 →

Stanza 156 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 156 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, before analyzing the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "Revealing day through every cranny spies,"

Revealing day: The coming of daylight, associated with truth and exposure.
through every cranny spies: Personification; the day is given the human action of "spying," suggesting an intrusive and unwanted observation. "Every cranny" suggests the thoroughness of the daylight's intrusion; it's inescapable.

Line 2: "And seems to point her out where she sits weeping;"

And seems to point her out: More personification; the daylight is actively drawing attention to Lucrece. It's not just present; it's accusatory.
where she sits weeping: Lucrece is in a state of intense grief and sorrow.

Line 3: "To whom she sobbing speaks: 'O eye of eyes,"

To whom she sobbing speaks: Lucrece is addressing the day (personified), highlighting her desperation and vulnerability.
O eye of eyes: A complex metaphor referring to the sun as the ultimate eye, all-seeing and all-knowing. It's a plea for mercy and understanding, but also highlights the overwhelming scrutiny Lucrece feels. It is also an apostrophe, addressing something inanimate as if it were alive.

Line 4: "Why pry'st thou through my window? leave thy peeping:"

Why pry'st thou through my window? leave thy peeping: Further personification and intensified diction. "Pry'st" and "peeping" convey a sense of unwanted voyeurism and violation of privacy. This reinforces the idea that the day is intruding upon her most private and painful moment.

Line 5: "Mock with thy tickling beams eyes that are sleeping:"

Mock with thy tickling beams: Personification again, but with a contrasting image. Day's light, represented by "tickling beams," mocks those who are sleeping, who can enjoy it in ignorance. This suggests that it is not a welcome sight for her, as she wishes to remain hidden and ignorant. eyes that are sleeping: Symbolically, this can represent innocence, ignorance, or those who are unaware of the tragedy that has occurred. The eyes sleeping also refer to those that are dead, whose eyes remain eternally closed.

Line 6: "Brand not my forehead with thy piercing light,"

Brand not my forehead with thy piercing light: The strongest imagery in the stanza. The
light is likened to a branding iron, searing her forehead with shame and marking her as guilty. "Piercing" emphasizes the pain and intensity of the light. A metaphor is present, light to branding iron.
Forehead: Symbolically represents reputation and honor.

Revealing day through every cranny spies,
And seems to point her out where she sits weeping;
To whom she sobbing speaks: 'O eye of eyes,
Why pry'st thou through my window? leave thy peeping: Mock with thy tickling beams eyes that are sleeping: Brand not my forehead with thy piercing light,
For day hath nought to do what's done by night.'

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Line 7: "For day hath nought to do what's done by night."

For day hath nought to do what's done by night: A concise statement of the central conflict. The day (representing justice, truth, and the public sphere) should have no involvement in the deeds committed in the secrecy and darkness of the night (representing evil, sin, and private violation). This is a powerful statement of the disconnect between public and private shame.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza captures Lucrece's agonizing transition from the horror of the night to the stark reality of the morning. She feels exposed and violated by the encroaching daylight, which she perceives as a judgmental observer. She is consumed by shame and fears that the light will reveal her disgrace to the world, branding her with the mark of her dishonor. Lucrece wants to hold onto her secret shame, as she believes that there should be no involvement of the day in what has been done in the night. The stanza expresses Lucrece's internal conflict between her desire for justice and her fear of public humiliation. She wishes the day would simply ignore her and focus on those who can innocently enjoy its light.

Literary Devices:

Personification: Giving human qualities to the day and sun.
Metaphor: Comparing the light to a branding iron. The "eye of eyes" is also a metaphor for the sun's all-seeing power.
Apostrophe: Addressing the day as if it were a person who could understand and respond. Imagery: Vivid descriptions that create a strong sensory experience for the reader (e.g., "tickling beams," "piercing light").
Alliteration: Repetition of consonant sounds for emphasis, can be seen in: "Why pry'st thou through my window? leave thy peeping:"

The stanza is a powerful and evocative depiction of Lucrece's psychological state, using figurative language to convey her profound shame, fear, and sense of violation.

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← Stanza 156📚 OverviewStanza 158 →

Stanza 157 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 157 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identifying literary devices, and then discuss the overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Thus cavils she with every thing she sees:"

Cavils: To raise trivial and frivolous objections. Lucrece finds fault with everything around her.
She: Refers to Lucrece.
Meaning: Lucrece, overwhelmed by her grief and trauma, is finding fault with everything she
looks at. She's picking at the smallest things, unable to find solace anywhere. This demonstrates how her internal state is projecting outwards, contaminating her perception of the external world.

"True grief is fond and testy as a child,"

Fond: Foolish, or overly trusting, sometimes endearing.
Testy: Irritable, easily annoyed.
As a child: Begins an extended simile.
Meaning: True grief is presented as being childish in its behavior. It's foolish and overly trusting in that it leaves one vulnerable to the pain, and also irritable and easily upset. This connects Lucrece's current state to a state of helplessness and emotional instability.

"Who wayward once, his mood with nought agrees:"

Wayward: Difficult to control or predict because of unusual or perverse behavior.
Nought agrees: Nothing pleases, nothing can satisfy.
Meaning: Continuing the child simile, a grieving person, once they are in a bad mood, cannot be appeased or satisfied by anything. Nothing seems right or good enough. This emphasizes the irrationality and consuming nature of grief.

"Old woes, not infant sorrows, bear them mild;"

Old woes: Long-standing sorrows, grief that has endured.
Infant sorrows: Newly experienced grief.
Bear them mild: Endure them calmly, accept them with patience.
Meaning: Grief that has been around for a long time is handled with more composure than the first sting of a new grief. Familiarity with sorrow can breed a sort of resigned acceptance. The key contrast lies with 'old' and 'infant' sorrows, which are juxtaposed to emphasize how time impacts grief.

"Continuance tames the one; the other wild,"

Continuance: The passage of time.
Tames the one: The older grief becomes subdued.
The other wild: The new grief remains untamed and uncontrollable.
Meaning: Continuing the contrast between new and old grief, the passage of time eventually helps to tame or soften old grief, whereas new grief is untamed and feels wild. This is a concise restatement of the previous line, further emphasizing the effect of time on grief.

Thus cavils she with every thing she sees:
True grief is fond and testy as a child,
Who wayward once, his mood with nought agrees:
Old woes, not infant sorrows, bear them mild;
Continuance tames the one; the other wild,
Like an unpractised swimmer plunging still, With too much labour drowns for want of skill.

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"Like an unpractised swimmer plunging still,"

Unpractised swimmer: A person who doesn't know how to swim well.
Plunging still: Constantly struggling and sinking.
Meaning: Another simile is introduced comparing new grief to an unpracticed swimmer. The person is still plunging/drowning, trying to survive, but lacking the skill to navigate the pain properly.
"With too much labour drowns for want of skill."

Too much labour: Exerting too much effort.
Drowns: Overwhelmed.
Want of skill: Lacking the ability or experience.
Meaning: The person in new grief, expends all their energy struggling against the pain, but because they lack the experience or ability to cope, they become overwhelmed and drowned in their grief. It's the lack of coping mechanisms that leads to devastation.

Literary Devices:

Simile: Several extended similes are present throughout the stanza.
"True grief is...as a child" compares grief to a child.
"Like an unpractised swimmer" compares new grief to someone struggling in the water.

Contrast/Juxtaposition: The stanza sets up a clear contrast between old grief and new grief ("Old woes, not infant sorrows"). This comparison is central to the stanza's meaning. Personification: Grief is personified as a "child" with moods and behaviors.
Metaphor: Grief is implicitly a metaphor for a turbulent sea in the swimmer simile.
Imagery: The "unpractised swimmer" creates vivid imagery of struggle and drowning. Alliteration: "Want of skill" uses alliteration to emphasize the lack of coping mechanisms. Aphorism: The line "Continuance tames the one; the other wild" can be taken as a general truth about the impact of time on sorrow.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza explores the nature of grief, particularly the difference between new and old sorrow. It argues that new grief is like a child: irrational, easily agitated, and insatiable. It also compares new grief to an inexperienced swimmer who exhausts themself in the struggle to stay afloat, ultimately drowning. In contrast, old grief is tamed by time and experience, allowing one to bear it more calmly. Ultimately, the stanza emphasizes the overwhelming and disorienting nature of fresh grief, contrasting it with the more manageable and tempered state of grief that has had time to heal. It suggests that coping with new trauma requires skill and experience, and that a lack of these can lead to being completely overwhelmed. In the context of The Rape of Lucrece, this stanza prefigures Lucrece's inability to cope with the fresh trauma she has suffered, leading to her tragic suicide. She is drowning in a sea of grief, and she lacks the skills to swim.
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← Stanza 157📚 OverviewStanza 159 →

Stanza 158 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then put it all together:

Line 1: "So she, deep-drenched in a sea of care,"

Breakdown: This line paints a vivid picture of Lucrece's mental state. "Deep-drenched" implies
she is completely consumed and overwhelmed. "A sea of care" is a powerful metaphor, comparing her worries and anxieties to an immense and dangerous body of water.
Literary Device:
Metaphor: The comparison of "care" to a "sea" is a clear metaphor, suggesting the vastness
and all-encompassing nature of her distress.
Imagery: The phrase "deep-drenched in a sea" creates strong visual and tactile imagery,
allowing the reader to feel Lucrece's overwhelming despair.

Line 2: "Holds disputation with each thing she views,"

Breakdown: "Disputation" means argument or debate. Lucrece is mentally arguing with everything she sees around her. She's not simply observing; she's engaging in a tortured internal dialogue, probably questioning everything and seeking answers or justifications (likely futile). Literary Device:
Personification (Implied): Suggests that the "things" she views are capable of engaging in
an argument.

Line 3: "And to herself all sorrow doth compare;"

Breakdown: She is measuring all forms of sorrow to her own. She sees her grief as the ultimate standard of suffering. She is constantly assessing how her suffering compares to the suffering of others.

Literary Device:
Imagery: Evokes a sense of scale and comparison.

Line 4: "No object but her passion's strength renews;"

Breakdown: "Passion" here refers to the intense suffering and pain she is experiencing. "No object" means that everything she sees, no matter how small, reminds her of her trauma and intensifies her feelings. Instead of distracting her, her surroundings only reinforce her pain. Literary Device:
Hyperbole (Possible): Implies that literally everything she sees reminds her of her trauma.
This is likely an exaggeration for emphasis.
Irony: Irony is present because one would expect outside influences to provide a distraction or relief to her suffering, not add to it.

Line 5: "And as one shifts, another straight ensues:"

Breakdown: As one object or thought fades from her attention, another quickly takes its place, continuing the cycle of torment. There's no respite or pause in her suffering.
Literary Device:
Imagery: Creates a sense of relentless succession of tormenting thoughts.

So she, deep-drenched in a sea of care,
Holds disputation with each thing she views,
And to herself all sorrow doth compare;
No object but her passion's strength renews;
And as one shifts, another straight ensues:
Sometime her grief is dumb and hath no words; Sometime 'tis mad and too much talk affords.

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Line 6: "Sometime her grief is dumb and hath no words;"

Breakdown: Sometimes, her grief is so profound that she is speechless. She is incapable of articulating the depth of her pain. She's beyond words.
Literary Device:
Contrast: Sets up a contrast with the next line.

Line 7: "Sometime 'tis mad and too much talk affords."

Breakdown: At other times, her grief manifests as madness and uncontrolled talking. She becomes almost manic in her outpouring of pain and despair. She is unable to contain herself. Literary Device:
Contrast: Directly contrasts with the previous line, showing the volatile and unpredictable
nature of her grief. This is antithesis.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza depicts the intense and overwhelming emotional turmoil that Lucrece experiences after the rape. She is utterly consumed by her grief, which is constantly renewed by her surroundings. Her mental state is volatile and unpredictable, fluctuating between speechless despair and frantic, uncontrolled outpouring of pain. The stanza emphasizes the relentless and inescapable nature of her suffering. It highlights the psychological impact of the rape, demonstrating how it has shattered her inner peace and plunged her into a sea of anguish. She is stuck in a vicious cycle of trauma and mental anguish that she can't escape from.

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← Stanza 158📚 OverviewStanza 160 →

Stanza 159 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 159 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then look at the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"The little birds that tune their morning's joy"

Meaning: This paints a picture of birds singing cheerfully at dawn. They are creating a pleasant, joyful atmosphere.
Literary Devices: Personification: "Tune their morning's joy" gives the birds the human
capability of tuning a musical instrument to express happiness. Imagery: This line creates a vivid auditory image of birdsong.

"Make her moans mad with their sweet melody:"

Meaning: The sweet and happy birdsong actually intensifies Lucrece's sorrow and drives her almost to madness. It's a stark contrast between the joy of nature and her overwhelming grief. Literary Devices: Juxtaposition/Contrast: The "sweet melody" is set against "her moans," highlighting the disparity between outward beauty and inner suffering. Alliteration: "Make...moans...mad" creates a strong, harsh sound, emphasizing Lucrece's anguish.

"For mirth doth search the bottom of annoy;"

Meaning: This is a generalization or maxim. Joy (mirth) doesn't alleviate sorrow, but instead delves deep into the depths of sadness (annoy). It stirs up and exacerbates the pain.
Literary Devices: Personification: "Mirth doth search" gives mirth the active role of seeking out and probing sadness. Metaphor: "Bottom of annoy" implies that sorrow is a deep, hidden place.

"Sad souls are slain in merry company;"

Meaning: This continues the idea that sadness is amplified by happiness. A person who is deeply sad feels even worse when surrounded by cheerful people. Their sadness is metaphorically "slain"
- suffocated and emphasized by the surrounding joy.
Literary Devices: Metaphor: "Slain" is a metaphorical death, representing the crushing effect of joy on grief. Antithesis: Contrasts the "sad souls" and "merry company" to emphasize their incompatibility.

"Grief best is pleased with grief's society:"

Meaning: This line provides the opposite perspective. Those who are grieving find the most comfort and solace in the company of others who are also grieving. Shared sorrow provides a
kind of understanding and validation.
Literary Devices: Paradox: The word "pleased" is unexpected in relation to grief, highlighting the unusual comfort found in shared suffering. Personification: "Grief best is pleased" attributes emotions to an abstract concept.

The little birds that tune their morning's joy
Make her moans mad with their sweet melody:
For mirth doth search the bottom of annoy;
Sad souls are slain in merry company;
Grief best is pleased with grief's society: True sorrow then is feelingly sufficed
When with like semblance it is sympathized.

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"True sorrow then is feelingly sufficed"

Meaning: Genuine, deep sorrow is best "satisfied" or comforted when it can fully express itself and be acknowledged. "Feelingly sufficed" indicates a profound and emotional fulfillment of that need for shared expression.
Literary Devices: Alliteration: "Sorrow...sufficed" emphasizes the connection between the
feeling and the satisfaction of expressing it.

"When with like semblance it is sympathized."

Meaning: Sorrow finds true comfort when it is met with empathy and understanding from
someone who has experienced something similar. "Like semblance" refers to the shared grief, and "sympathized" describes the feeling of mutual understanding and compassion.
Literary Devices: Repetition: Links back to the theme of 'shared grief'.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza explores the paradoxical nature of grief and happiness. It suggests that joy can amplify sorrow, making it even more unbearable. Conversely, it asserts that the best solace for grief is to be found in the company of others who understand and share that sorrow. It highlights the human need for empathy and the importance of acknowledging and validating genuine suffering. Lucrece's situation is intensified because she is alone with her grief in a world that continues with its usual joys and routines. The birdsong, normally a symbol of beauty and happiness, becomes a painful reminder of what she has lost and the injustice she has suffered. The stanza also highlights that people can seek validation from shared grief, in that they feel their true sorrow is realised and felt when someone else can connect with it.

Key Literary Devices:

Juxtaposition/Contrast: Happiness vs. Sorrow
Personification: Attributing human qualities to abstract concepts (Mirth, Grief) or natural
elements (birds).
Metaphor: Using comparisons to describe states of emotion (Sad souls are slain)
Paradox: The unexpected pleasure found in shared grief.
Alliteration: Emphasizes sounds to highlight certain ideas and create emphasis.
Imagery: Evokes sensory experiences (birds singing) to draw the reader into the scene.

This stanza is a powerful commentary on the complexities of human emotion and the importance of empathy and understanding in the face of suffering. It emphasizes how one's emotional state can be affected by outward circumstances and highlights the value of finding solace in shared experiences.

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← Stanza 159📚 OverviewStanza 161 →

Stanza 160 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 160 from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line, identifying literary devices and then piecing together the overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"’Tis double death to drown in ken of shore;"

Meaning: It's a double, or far worse, death to drown when land (safety, help) is visible and
nearby. The tragedy is compounded because rescue seems possible but is unattainable.
Literary Devices:
Hyperbole: Exaggeration ("double death") to emphasize the agonizing nature of the situation. Paradox: There is an inherent contradiction. Drowning near land should be easier to prevent.

"He ten times pines that pines beholding food;"

Meaning: A person starving suffers much more when they can see food but are unable to reach or consume it. The presence of the solution intensifies the suffering.
Literary Devices:
Hyperbole: "Ten times pines" exaggerates the increased suffering.
Analogy/Parallelism: Mirrors the previous line; the starving person is to the person drowning near land.

"To see the salve doth make the wound ache more;"

Meaning: Seeing the ointment or medicine that could heal a wound actually makes the pain of the wound feel even sharper. Again, the nearness of relief accentuates the pain of the affliction. Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Salve" stands in for any form of relief or cure.
Analogy/Parallelism: Continuing the pattern; seeing relief intensifies suffering.

"Great grief grieves most at that would do it good;"

Meaning: Intense sorrow/suffering feels most intensely when it is in proximity of the thing that would alleviate that grief.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "Grief grieves" gives the abstract concept of grief the ability to act. Repetition: "Grief grieves" reinforces the idea of suffering as the subject.

"Deep woes roll forward like a gentle flood,"

Meaning: Profound sorrow progresses forward steadily, like a slowly moving, powerful river. There is a sense of inevitability and relentless progression.
Literary Devices:
Simile: "Like a gentle flood" uses comparison to create a vivid image of grief's unstoppable movement.

Alliteration: "Deep woes" creates a subtle sonic link.

'Tis double death to drown in ken of shore;
He ten times pines that pines beholding food;
To see the salve doth make the wound ache more;
Great grief grieves most at that would do it good;
Deep woes roll forward like a gentle flood,
Who being stopp'd, the bounding banks o'erflows; Grief dallied with nor law nor limit knows.

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"Who being stopp'd, the bounding banks o'erflows;"

Meaning: If this flood of sorrow is dammed or stopped up, it will inevitably break through its confines (like a river overflowing its banks) and become even more destructive. Suppressed grief will ultimately erupt.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Expanding on the flood metaphor; the "banks" are the restraints, boundaries, or attempts to control grief.

"Grief dallied with nor law nor limit knows."

Meaning: Grief does not adhere to rules, boundaries, or restrictions. It is unrestrained and uncontrollable. "Dallied with" suggests that grief is not something to be trifled with.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Grief is given the capacity to disobey ("nor law nor limit knows").
Tricolon: The phrase "nor law nor limit" consists of three words, adding emphasis to the meaning.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza explores the torturous nature of grief, particularly when relief is tantalizingly close but unattainable, and the destructive potential of suppressed grief. The nearness of help or a cure only serves to magnify the suffering. The stanza asserts that grief is a powerful and overwhelming force that cannot be easily controlled or restrained. If one tries to suppress it, it will inevitably break free and become even more destructive. The images of drowning near shore, starving with food in sight, and wounds aching at the sight of salve all emphasize the profound agony of having hope dangled before you, only to be denied. It is a commentary on the destructive nature of both grief itself and the attempt to control it, implying that the best course of action is to acknowledge grief and let it flow rather than try to dam it up, which leads to more destructive consequences.

In the context of the poem, the stanza reflects Lucrece's mental state as she grapples with the overwhelming grief and shame caused by her rape. She is surrounded by the potential for healing and justice (her husband, her family, the legal system), but those possibilities are ultimately insufficient to overcome the trauma. Her grief, therefore, festers and contributes to her decision to commit suicide.

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Stanza 161 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from The Rape of Lucrece.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"You mocking-birds," quoth she, "your tunes entomb":

"You mocking-birds,": Lucrece is directly addressing the birds she hears singing, calling them "mocking-birds." This is apostrophe (addressing someone or something that is not present or cannot respond). The term mockingbirds is symbolic of their carefree joyful life which contrast to her life of despair.
"quoth she,": This is an archaic way of saying "said she." It is a typical Shakespearean way of introducing a speaker.
"your tunes entomb": This means she wants them to bury or hide their songs. The verb "entomb" is a strong word, suggesting death and burial, emphasizing the seriousness of her request. This is also metaphorical: she doesn't literally want them to bury their songs, but to stop singing.

"Within your hollow-swelling feather'd breasts,":

"Within your hollow-swelling feather'd breasts,": This is a description of the birds. "Hollow-swelling" might refer to the resonating chambers within their bodies that allow them to sing loudly. "Feather'd breasts" is simply a descriptive phrase. Note the alliteration in "hollow-swelling." This line describes the physical form of the birds with a hint of negativity that she is projecting on them.

"And in my hearing be you mute and dumb:":

"And in my hearing be you mute and dumb:": This is a direct command: she orders the birds to be silent. "Mute and dumb" is tautology (saying the same thing twice in different words) and
it emphasizes her desire for complete silence. It's also an example of repetition, further highlighting her desperation.

"My restless discord loves no stops nor rests;":

"My restless discord": This refers to Lucrece's inner turmoil and emotional pain. "Discord" suggests a lack of harmony or agreement, reflecting her internal conflict. This is a metaphor:
her emotional state is being compared to discord.
"loves no stops nor rests": She is saying that her pain is constant and unrelenting. It has no pauses ("stops") or moments of peace ("rests"). This line highlights the unending nature of her suffering. "Stops nor rests" are also musical terms, further connecting to the idea of harmony and discord.

"A woeful hostess brooks not merry guests:":

"A woeful hostess": Lucrece casts herself as a hostess (someone who receives and entertains guests). "Woeful" emphasizes her sorrowful state.
"brooks not merry guests": "Brooks" means tolerates or allows. "Merry guests" represent happiness and joy. Therefore, a "woeful hostess" cannot tolerate "merry guests." This is an analogy: the relationship between a hostess and guests is being used to represent Lucrece's internal state. She, in her misery, cannot bear to be around anything happy.

'You mocking-birds,' quoth she, 'your tunes entomb
Within your hollow-swelling feather'd breasts,
And in my hearing be you mute and dumb:
My restless discord loves no stops nor rests;
A woeful hostess brooks not merry guests:
Relish your nimble notes to pleasing ears; Distress likes dumps when time is kept with tears.

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"Relish your nimble notes to pleasing ears;":

"Relish your nimble notes": "Relish" means to enjoy or appreciate. "Nimble notes" refers to the birds' quick and lively songs.
"to pleasing ears": She suggests that their music should be enjoyed by those who are
receptive to it. It is a contrast to her own emotional state.

"Distress likes dumps when time is kept with tears.":

"Distress likes dumps": "Distress" refers to her suffering. "Dumps" are sad, mournful songs or laments. This means that her sorrow finds comfort in sorrowful music.
"when time is kept with tears": This implies that the appropriate accompaniment to her sorrowful songs is weeping. "Time is kept" again uses musical terminology, suggesting a rhythm and consistency to her grief.

Overall Meaning and Literary Devices:

This stanza is a powerful expression of Lucrece's grief and isolation. The main idea is that Lucrece, consumed by her suffering after the rape, cannot bear to be around anything that reminds her of joy or peace.

She silences the birds because their songs represent a joy she can no longer experience.
She acknowledges that her internal "discord" is constant and unrelenting.
She states that she, in her "woeful" state, cannot tolerate the presence of "merry guests," symbolizing happiness.
Finally, she reveals that she finds solace only in sorrow, symbolized by "dumps" (mournful songs) and the constant flow of "tears."

Key Literary Devices:

Apostrophe: Directly addressing the birds.
Metaphor: Her emotional state is compared to "discord."
Analogy: Comparing her situation to that of a "woeful hostess" who can't tolerate "merry guests." Alliteration: "hollow-swelling"
Repetition/Tautology: "mute and dumb"
Imagery: "hollow-swelling feather'd breasts," "nimble notes," "time is kept with tears."
Musical Imagery: "tunes," "notes," "discord," "stops," "rests," "time is kept." This highlights the contrast between the harmony she used to know and the discord she now feels.

The stanza is a masterful depiction of despair, using vivid imagery and carefully chosen words to convey the depth of Lucrece's suffering and her complete rejection of anything that offers a glimmer of hope or happiness. The musical imagery is particularly effective in highlighting the contrast between her former life and her current state of profound sorrow.
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← Stanza 161📚 OverviewStanza 163 →

Stanza 162 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then analyze the overall meaning and literary devices:

"Come, Philomel, that sing'st of ravishment":

Philomel: This is a reference to the mythological figure Philomela, who was raped by her brother-in-law Tereus. After the rape, Tereus cut out her tongue to prevent her from telling
anyone. She wove a tapestry to tell her sister, Procne, what had happened. Procne then killed her own son, Itys, and served him to Tereus for dinner. The gods then transformed Philomela into a nightingale.
"that sing'st of ravishment": The nightingale's song is traditionally interpreted as a lament, a mournful cry about her horrific experience. This is personification, as the nightingale, a bird, is given the human quality of singing about a specific traumatic event.

"Make thy sad grove in my dishevell'd hair":

"sad grove": This evokes the image of the woods or a secluded, mournful place associated with Philomel.

"my dishevell'd hair": Lucrece's loosened, tangled hair is a symbol of her emotional distress and loss of order. Her hair is wild and uncontrolled, mirroring her inner turmoil after the rape. The line is a plea to Philomel to dwell in her hair, meaning Lucrece wants to embody Philomel's sorrow and make it visible.

"As the dank earth weeps at thy languishment":

"dank earth": The wet, heavy earth is associated with sadness and mourning. "Dank" suggests a depressing, cold, and unpleasant environment.
"weeps at thy languishment": This uses pathetic fallacy, attributing human emotions (weeping) to nature (the earth). The earth's moisture (dew, rain) is presented as tears shed in sympathy with Philomel's suffering. Languishment means a state of weakening and suffering.

"So I at each sad strain will strain a tear":

This line draws a direct parallel between the earth's response to Philomel and Lucrece's own. Each time Philomel sings a sorrowful note ("sad strain"), Lucrece will force herself to cry ("strain a tear").
It emphasizes the depth of Lucrece's grief, aligning it with the natural world's mourning.

"And with deep groans the diapason bear":

"diapason": In music, a diapason is a fundamental, foundational tone or chord.
"bear": Here, bear means to carry or support.
Lucrece says that she will accompany Philomel’s song with her own "deep groans" to match the depth and breadth of the music. Lucrece is saying that her lament will provide the fundamental base note for the music of grief.

'Come, Philomel, that sing'st of ravishment,
Make thy sad grove in my dishevell'd hair:
As the dank earth weeps at thy languishment,
So I at each sad strain will strain a tear,
And with deep groans the diapason bear;
For burden-wise I'll hum on Tarquin still, While thou on Tereus descant'st better skill.

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"For burden-wise I'll hum on Tarquin still":

"burden-wise": In music, the "burden" is a refrain, a repeated line or phrase, often carrying the main theme of the song.
"hum on Tarquin still": Lucrece will continuously repeat the name of Tarquin in her lament, making him the constant subject of her grief. This implies that her grief is directly linked to and caused by Tarquin.
"While thou on Tereus descant'st better skill":

"descant'st": In music, a descant is a melody sung or played above the main melody. It's an embellishment or variation.
"Tereus": Philomel (as the nightingale) is better equipped to sing about Tereus (her rapist) because she is the original victim. Lucrece implies that Philomel can express the horror of rape more fully and accurately.
"better skill": She acknowledges Philomel's greater ability to articulate the pain of rape. This isn't to diminish her own suffering but to recognize the unique weight of the original trauma.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece expresses the profound depth of her grief and shame following the rape by comparing herself to the mythological figure of Philomel. She invites Philomel to inhabit her hair and lead the lament, indicating Lucrece’s overwhelming despair. She establishes an equivalence between Philomel's experience and her own and joins her voice in the mournful chorus. She will provide the foundation for a dirge centered on Tarquin, whose name will be perpetually repeated in her grief, while acknowledging Philomel’s unique capacity to articulate the unspeakable horror inflicted by Tereus. The stanza emphasizes the shared experience of violation and the power of lamentation as a form of expression.

Literary Devices:

Allusion: The stanza is heavily reliant on allusion to the myth of Philomela and Tereus. Personification: Giving human qualities to inanimate objects or animals (e.g., the earth weeps, Philomel sings).
Pathetic Fallacy: Attributing human emotions to nature (e.g., the dank earth weeps).
Metaphor: Comparing Lucrece's hair to a "sad grove."
Musical Imagery: Using musical terms like "diapason," "burden," and "descant" to describe the lament and structure her grief.
Repetition: The implied repetition of Tarquin's name reinforces his role as the source of her suffering.
Imagery: Vivid descriptions create a sense of sorrow and suffering (e.g., "dank earth," "dishevell'd hair").
Apostrophe: Addressing Philomel directly ("Come, Philomel").
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Stanza 163 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 163 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then analyze the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"And whiles against a thorn thou bear'st thy part,"
And whiles means "and while" or "meanwhile".
Against a thorn thou bear'st thy part refers to Lucrece, figuratively depicted here as suffering in sorrow as a thorn presses against her flesh. Bear'st thy part means to endure or take your share
of the suffering.
It sets up a contrast between Lucrece's silent, internal suffering and the speaker's (Collatine's) external and dramatic response.

"To keep thy sharp woes waking, wretched I,"

To keep thy sharp woes waking indicates that he doesn't want her pain to be forgotten, it needs to remain current and understood.
Wretched I emphasizes the speaker's (Collatine's) self-pity and misery. He sees himself as equally (or perhaps even more) affected by Lucrece's suffering.

"To imitate thee well, against my heart"

To imitate thee well implies a performative aspect to his grief. He feels the need to outwardly express his suffering in a way that mirrors hers. He wants to match her pain.
Against my heart introduces a violent image.

"Will fix a sharp knife to affright mine eye;"

Will fix a sharp knife to affright mine eye This is the most striking and disturbing line. He plans to hold a knife pointed at his own heart to scare his eye, and thus, himself. It's a theatrical, almost melodramatic, gesture of self-punishment and grief.

"Who, if it wink, shall thereon fall and die."

Who, if it wink, shall thereon fall and die The "who" refers to his eye. He threatens himself with death if he closes his eye (winces) from the pain or fright of the knife. He's trying to force himself to endure and witness his own suffering.

"These means, as frets upon an instrument,"

These means refers to the drastic actions he plans to take with the knife.
As frets upon an instrument introduces a metaphor. Frets are the raised ridges on the neck of a stringed instrument (like a lute or guitar) that help determine the pitch of the notes. The pains of Lucrece and Collentine are tuning the music of their sorrow.

"Shall tune our heart-strings to true languishment."

Shall tune our heart-strings to true languishment Continues the musical metaphor. The suffering (the "frets") will "tune" their "heart-strings" (emotions) to a state of perfect, pure, and resonant sadness (true languishment).

'And whiles against a thorn thou bear'st thy part,
To keep thy sharp woes waking, wretched I,
To imitate thee well, against my heart
Will fix a sharp knife to affright mine eye;
Who, if it wink, shall thereon fall and die.
These means, as frets upon an instrument,
Shall tune our heart-strings to true languishment.

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Overall Meaning:

This stanza reveals the speaker's (Collatine's) overwhelming grief and guilt in the wake of Lucrece's rape. He is engaging in a form of dramatic self-pity and self-punishment, trying to mirror the suffering he perceives in Lucrece. He almost seems to be competing with her pain, needing to prove the depth of his sorrow and commitment. The threat of the knife is not necessarily a genuine suicide attempt (although the possibility is there), but rather a performative act intended to shock and express the extremity of his emotions. He imagines these extreme measures as being necessary to "tune" their emotional state to a pitch of profound sadness, as if they are instruments playing a duet of grief.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: The entire stanza is framed by the central metaphor of tuning heart-strings to languishment, comparing emotional suffering to adjusting the pitch of a musical instrument. This extends to the thorn, which stands in for the emotional pain Lucrece feels.
Imagery: The stanza is filled with vivid and violent imagery: the thorn, the sharp knife pointed at the heart, the eye winking, death. This creates a powerful and unsettling atmosphere.
Allusion: While not explicit, the "thorn" could be seen as an allusion to the crown of thorns that Jesus wore, evoking themes of suffering and sacrifice.
Hyperbole: The threatened self-mutilation and death are arguably hyperbolic, exaggerating his grief to an extreme level. This is especially true if the speaker isn't necessarily intending to go through with the threat.
Irony: There is a subtle undercurrent of irony. The speaker's focus on his own pain and his performative grief can be seen as overshadowing and potentially minimizing Lucrece's actual trauma. He focuses on mimicking grief, rather than actually comforting Lucrece. Juxtaposition/Contrast: The contrast between Lucrece's internalized suffering and the speaker's external, theatrical grief is a key element of the stanza.

In essence, the stanza is a theatrical expression of grief, guilt, and a desperate need to participate in the suffering caused by the rape. It uses powerful imagery and a central metaphor to convey the overwhelming emotional turmoil of the speaker. However, it also reveals a potential self-centeredness and a focus on the performance of grief, rather than genuine empathy and support.

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← Stanza 163📚 OverviewStanza 165 →

Stanza 164 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 164 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then synthesize its overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"And for, poor bird, thou sing'st not in the day,"
Meaning: "And because, poor bird, you don't sing during the day..."
Analysis: "And for" means "because". The speaker (Lucrece) is addressing herself, metaphorically represented by a "poor bird," who is now afraid to express joy or happiness publicly.

"As shaming any eye should thee behold,"
Meaning: "...as if it were shameful for anyone to see you."
Analysis: The reason the bird doesn't sing during the day is because it feels ashamed, implying a fear of judgment or exposure. Lucrece, after the rape, feels similarly exposed and disgraced.

"Some dark deep desert, seated from the way,"
Meaning: "We will find some dark, remote desert, far from any path..."
Analysis: This is a shift in focus to a place of isolation and concealment. The desert is described as "dark" and "deep," emphasizing its remoteness and despair. "Seated from the way" underlines its isolation from society and normal life.

"That knows not parching heat nor freezing cold,"
Meaning: "...that experiences neither extreme heat nor extreme cold."
Analysis: This detail about the desert is significant. It suggests a place of emotional numbness or deadness. It's not just isolated, but also devoid of passion or strong feeling. Lucrece is envisioning a place that mirrors her own emotional state.

"Will we find out; and there we will unfold"
Meaning: "We will find such a place; and there we will reveal..."
Analysis: The speaker reiterates the intention to find this place of isolation. "Unfold" suggests the revealing of emotions or experiences that have been kept hidden.

"To creatures stern sad tunes, to change their kinds:"
Meaning: "...sad songs to the fierce creatures there, in order to change their natures."
Analysis: This is a crucial line. The idea is that even the most savage creatures can be softened or changed by sorrowful music. The "stern" creatures are metaphors for the inhumanity Lucrece has witnessed and, perhaps, a desperate hope for a return to decency. "Change their kinds" implies altering their very essence, making them gentler.

"Since men prove beasts, let beasts bear gentle minds."
Meaning: "Since men have proven themselves to be like beasts, let actual beasts become gentle and kind."

Analysis: This is a bitter irony. Men, who should be rational and moral, have acted like brutes (Tarquin's rape of Lucrece), while Lucrece hopes that actual animals can be made more humane through the power of her sorrow.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: Lucrece using the "poor bird" as a representation of herself.

'And for, poor bird, thou sing'st not in the day,
As shaming any eye should thee behold,
Some dark deep desert, seated from the way,
That knows not parching heat nor freezing cold,
Will we find out; and there we will unfold
To creatures stern sad tunes, to change their kinds: Since men prove beasts, let beasts bear gentle minds.'

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Imagery: The vivid descriptions of the "dark deep desert" and "parching heat nor freezing cold" create a strong sense of place and emotional atmosphere.
Irony: The final line is deeply ironic, highlighting the perversion of natural order where men are behaving like beasts and Lucrece hopes to change beasts to be more gentle.
Alliteration: "Stern Sad" - emphasizes the sad nature of the creatures and tunes.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza reveals Lucrece's profound despair and disillusionment after the rape. She feels ashamed and exposed, like a bird that can no longer sing in the daylight. She seeks a place of utter isolation and emotional numbness, represented by the desolate desert. However, within this despair, there's a flicker of hope – the belief that sorrowful music can change even the most savage creatures. The final line, dripping with irony, encapsulates Lucrece's sense of the world turned upside down: men have become beasts, so perhaps beasts can learn to be gentle. It's a plea for a restoration of moral order in a world where humanity has failed. It also underscores the power of grief and trauma to transform one's perception of the world and their place within it. Lucrece, in this stanza, is grappling with the loss of innocence and the corruption of human nature.

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Stanza 165 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 165 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line and then discuss its overall meaning, paying attention to literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "As the poor frighted deer, that stands at gaze,"

Meaning: Lucrece is being compared to a frightened deer. "At gaze" means the deer is staring, frozen, caught in the open and vulnerable. It's trapped in a moment of fear.
Literary Devices:
Simile: The "As" establishes a direct comparison between Lucrece's state and the deer.
Imagery: Vividly creates the image of a helpless, scared animal.

Line 2: "Wildly determining which way to fly,"

Meaning: The deer is desperately trying to decide which direction to escape, but its fear is clouding its judgment. "Wildly determining" suggests a frantic, chaotic decision-making process.

Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the 'w' sound in "Wildly" and "Which".
Personification: "Determining" gives the deer a human-like capacity for rational thought, albeit a chaotic one.

Line 3: "Or one encompass'd with a winding maze,"

Meaning: This shifts to a second, similar image: someone trapped in a maze. "Encompass'd" means surrounded or enclosed. The "winding maze" implies a confusing and disorienting situation with no clear path forward.

Literary Devices:
Simile (Implied): The "Or" suggests another comparison, similar to the deer. The reader fills in the implied "as."
Imagery: Evokes the feeling of being lost and confused.

Line 4: "That cannot tread the way out readily;"

Meaning: The person in the maze is unable to easily find the exit. "Tread the way out readily" implies difficulty, the paths are not obvious.

Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the 't' sound in "tread" and "that".

Line 5: "So with herself is she in mutiny,"

Meaning: This line finally brings the focus back to Lucrece. "In mutiny" means she's in internal conflict, a rebellion against herself. Her mind and emotions are at war. The previous lines were analogies that now directly apply to her.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The internal conflict is described as a "mutiny," a forceful and chaotic rebellion.

As the poor frighted deer, that stands at gaze,
Wildly determining which way to fly,
Or one encompass'd with a winding maze,
That cannot tread the way out readily;
So with herself is she in mutiny,
To live or die which of the twain were better, When life is shamed, and death reproach's debtor.

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Anaphora: The first four lines all begin with words indicating comparison, "As", "Or", "That" and thus line 5 ends with "So" to conclude the drawn out simile.

Line 6: "To live or die which of the twain were better,"

Meaning: Lucrece is agonizing over whether it would be better to live with the shame of the rape or to take her own life. "The twain" refers to the two options: life and death.

Literary Devices:
Dilemma: Highlights the agonizing choice she faces.

Line 7: "When life is shamed, and death reproach's debtor."

Meaning: This line explains why she's struggling with the decision. Living means enduring shame ("life is shamed"), but death is also undesirable because it implies she's running from the shame,
as if she owes something to reproach ("death reproach's debtor").

Literary Devices:
Personification: Death is portrayed as a "creditor," someone to whom a debt is owed.
Paradox: The situation is paradoxical because both options (life and death) present significant problems. She is trapped between two undesirable outcomes.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza is a powerful depiction of Lucrece's internal turmoil following the rape. She is paralyzed by fear and indecision, much like a deer caught in the open or someone lost in a maze. The imagery emphasizes her feeling of being trapped, both physically and emotionally. The core of the stanza is the agonizing choice she faces: whether to live with the unbearable shame or to die, which might be seen as an admission of guilt. The stanza sets up the internal conflict that drives the rest of the poem, highlighting the complexity of Lucrece's situation and her struggle to find a way to reclaim her honor and agency. It's a moment of intense psychological pressure, where she's caught between two equally undesirable fates.

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Stanza 166 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 166 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: 'To kill myself,' quoth she, 'alack, what were it,'

'To kill myself,' quoth she: This establishes that Lucrece is contemplating suicide. "Quoth she" is an archaic way of saying "said she."
'alack, what were it,': "Alack" is an exclamation of sorrow or regret. This phrase means: "What would suicide accomplish?" Lucrece is questioning the purpose or effect of taking her own life. Device: Apostrophe: Addressing the abstract concept of suicide.

Line 2: But with my body my poor soul's pollution?

But with my body: Suggests that suicide is an act affecting only the physical body.
my poor soul's pollution?: This is the core of the argument. Lucrece believes that suicide would further taint her already "polluted" soul, which she feels has been stained by the rape, despite her innocence.
Device: Metaphor: "Pollution" is used metaphorically to describe the stain of shame and the perceived sin associated with her experience.

Line 3: They that lose half with greater patience bear it

They that lose half: This introduces an analogy. "Half" refers to a partial loss or misfortune. with greater patience bear it: People who experience partial losses are able to endure their situation with more fortitude.

Line 4: Than they whose whole is swallow'd in confusion.

Than they whose whole: This contrasts with the previous line. This refers to those who have lost everything.
is swallow'd in confusion: Their entire being or situation is consumed by chaos and disorientation.
Device: Contrast: The comparison between losing "half" and losing "whole" highlights the difference in the ability to cope.
Line 5: That mother tries a merciless conclusion

That mother tries a merciless conclusion: This introduces a more specific and shocking analogy.
merciless conclusion: This refers to the "solution" or action of a mother who kills her remaining child.

Line 6: Who, having two sweet babes, when death takes one,

Who, having two sweet babes: Sets the scene with a mother who has two children.
when death takes one: One of her children dies.

'To kill myself,' quoth she, 'alack, what were it,
But with my body my poor soul's pollution?
They that lose half with greater patience bear it
Than they whose whole is swallow'd in confusion.
That mother tries a merciless conclusion
Who, having two sweet babes, when death takes one, Will slay the other and be nurse to none.

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Line 7: Will slay the other and be nurse to none.

Will slay the other: She kills her remaining child.
and be nurse to none: As a result of her actions, she is no longer a caregiver to any children. Device: Analogy/Extended Metaphor: The entire analogy of the mother and her children
serves as a extended metaphor. Lucrece equates suicide to killing the remaining child.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece grapples with the idea of suicide. She questions its value, suggesting that it would not cleanse her soul but instead further pollute it. She then argues that it's better to endure partial loss than to be completely overwhelmed and lose everything. She supports this with a disturbing analogy of a mother who, after losing one child, kills the other. The overall meaning is that suicide, while tempting, is ultimately a destructive act that offers no true resolution and only compounds the initial tragedy. She fears that it will leave her soul even more stained and without hope, similar to a mother who has needlessly destroyed her entire family line. Lucrece is arguing that life, even with its burdens, is worth preserving.

Literary Devices:

Apostrophe: Direct address to an abstract concept.
Metaphor: "Pollution" is a metaphorical representation of her dishonor and internal conflict. Analogy/Extended Metaphor: The analogy of the mother and her children is a powerful and sustained metaphor that represents Lucrece's own situation. She sees suicide as destroying the potential for any future good or redemption.
Contrast: The contrast between losing "half" and losing "whole" emphasizes the difference in the ability to cope and underscores the importance of preserving what remains.
Imagery: The imagery is both abstract (soul's pollution, swallowed in confusion) and concrete (two sweet babes, death takes one), creating a vivid and emotionally resonant effect.

This stanza is a crucial point in the poem because it showcases Lucrece's internal struggle and her rationale for the difficult path she eventually chooses.

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Stanza 167 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece," line by line, and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices employed.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

'My body or my soul, which was the dearer,'

Meaning: Lucrece is immediately questioning what was more valuable to her: her physical body
or her spiritual soul. This is a central dilemma after the rape; has she been harmed more
physically or spiritually.
Literary Devices: Rhetorical Question. This sets up the central conflict and the agonizing choices Lucrece now faces.

'When the one pure, the other made divine?'

Meaning: This line further elaborates on the ideal state Lucrece was in before the rape. She suggests that her pure body and chaste soul were intertwined. Her body's purity elevated her
soul to a state of near-divinity or spiritual perfection. In other words, her chastity made her sacred.

Literary Devices: Hyperbole (the "divine" soul) emphasizes the great value placed on her chastity. Juxtaposition - the purity of the body is contrasted to the divinity of the soul.

'Whose love of either to myself was nearer,'

Meaning: Lucrece continues her introspection. She asks: Which was more important to her, love of her body or love of her soul? Whose preservation was more important to her - in other words, what should she value more?

Literary Devices: Rhetorical Question. Builds on the initial question and deepens the internal conflict.

'When both were kept for heaven and Collatine?'

Meaning: This explains why both her body and soul were so precious. They were both dedicated to God ("heaven") and her husband, Collatine. Her chastity and fidelity were gifts she was preserving for these two entities.
Literary Devices: Allusion. "Heaven" is a direct reference to her religious devotion. This line reinforces the societal pressures and expectations surrounding female chastity in the era.

'Ay me! the bark peel'd from the lofty pine,'

Meaning: This line signals a shift into a metaphorical expression of her situation. "Ay me!" is an exclamation of grief. The image is of a majestic pine tree (representing Lucrece) that has had its bark stripped away.
Literary Devices: Metaphor, Exclamatory Phrase ("Ay me!"). The pine tree becomes a symbol
for Lucrece herself. Introduces a sense of lament and pathos.

'My body or my soul, which was the dearer,
When the one pure, the other made divine?
Whose love of either to myself was nearer,
When both were kept for heaven and Collatine?
Ay me! the bark peel'd from the lofty pine,
His leaves will wither and his sap decay;
So must my soul, her bark being peel'd away.

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'His leaves will wither and his sap decay;'

Meaning: The consequences of stripping the bark from the pine tree: its leaves will die, and its life-giving sap will rot. This represents the inevitable decline and ruin that Lucrece feels she will experience as a result of the rape.
Literary Devices: Imagery. Evokes a strong sense of decay and loss. Metaphor - the withered leaves and decayed sap represent the loss of Lucrece's vitality and her sense of self.

'So must my soul, her bark being peel'd away.'

Meaning: This line makes the metaphor explicit. Just as the tree dies when its bark is removed,
so too will Lucrece's soul die because her "bark" (her physical integrity, her chastity) has been violated. She equates the rape with a spiritual death.
Literary Devices: Direct Metaphor, Parallelism. The structure parallels the previous lines, emphasizing the connection between the tree's fate and Lucrece's. It reinforces the theme of destruction and despair.

Overall Meaning and Themes:

This stanza captures the core of Lucrece's anguish after the rape. She is grappling with the question of whether her body or soul has been more deeply damaged. Before the rape, they were inseparable, both dedicated to God and her husband. The rape, symbolized by the peeling away of the bark, has fundamentally violated her and, in her mind, destroyed her. She believes she can no longer fulfill her purpose, and her spiritual essence is now destined to wither and decay, leading to her eventual suicide.

Key Literary Devices:

Metaphor: The central image of the pine tree being stripped of its bark is the most significant metaphor. It represents Lucrece's violation and the subsequent decay of her spirit.
Rhetorical Questions: Lucrece's initial questions reveal her internal struggle and the impossible choices she faces.
Imagery: The vivid imagery of the decaying tree emphasizes the theme of destruction and loss. Allusion: The reference to "heaven" underscores the religious dimension of Lucrece's values. Hyperbole: Elevating the soul to the "divine" heightens the loss Lucrece feels.
Exclamatory Phrase: "Ay me!" contributes to the stanza's emotional intensity.
Parallelism: The similar structure of lines 6 and 7 reinforces the connection between the tree and Lucrece's fate.

In short, this stanza is a powerful and poignant expression of Lucrece's internal turmoil, using vivid metaphors and rhetorical questions to convey the devastating impact of the rape on her sense of self and her spiritual well-being. It speaks to the societal pressures placed on women's chastity and the profound consequences of its violation in her time.

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← Stanza 167📚 OverviewStanza 169 →

Stanza 168 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 168 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line and then analyze its overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Her house is sack'd, her quiet interrupted,"

"Her house is sack'd": This is a metaphor. 'House' represents Lucrece's virtue, her body, and
her honor. 'Sack'd' means looted, pillaged, or destroyed. This refers to the violation she has just endured.
"her quiet interrupted": This is a literal consequence of the rape. It also represents the loss of her inner peace and serenity.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "House" is a metaphor for Lucrece's body and virtue.
Alliteration: "House" and "Her" alliterate, emphasizing Lucrece.

"Her mansion batter'd by the enemy;"

"Her mansion batter'd": 'Mansion' is another metaphor for her body, emphasizing its physical vulnerability. 'Batter'd' suggests a forceful and violent attack.
"by the enemy": 'Enemy' is Collatine, the rapist, and also can be viewed as the embodiment of lust and dishonor.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Mansion" is a metaphor for Lucrece's body.

"Her sacred temple spotted, spoil'd, corrupted,"

"Her sacred temple": 'Temple' is yet another metaphor for her body, emphasizing its sanctity and purity, now violated.
"spotted, spoil'd, corrupted": These three verbs describe the consequences of the rape. 'Spotted' suggests a stain on her purity, 'spoil'd' emphasizes the loss of her value and integrity, and 'corrupted' denotes a fundamental alteration to her being.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Temple" is a metaphor for Lucrece's body and purity.
Triadic Structure/List of Three: The use of three verbs ("spotted, spoil'd, corrupted") intensifies the image of damage.

"Grossly engirt with daring infamy:"

"Grossly engirt": 'Grossly' means blatantly or obviously. 'Engirt' means surrounded or encircled. This suggests that her reputation and being are now completely enveloped by the dishonor of the rape.
"with daring infamy": 'Daring' underscores the audacity and boldness of Collatine's actions. 'Infamy' refers to the state of being known for something evil or dishonorable.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: "Grossly" and "Engirt"

' Her house is sack'd, her quiet interrupted,
Her mansion batter'd by the enemy;
Her sacred temple spotted, spoil'd, corrupted,
Grossly engirt with daring infamy:
Then let it not be call'd impiety,
If in this blemish'd fort I make some hole Through which I may convey this troubled soul.

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"Then let it not be call'd impiety,"

"Then let it not be call'd impiety": This is the key turning point. She sets up a rhetorical argument. She's arguing that her next action (suicide) should not be considered a sin against the gods (impiety).
Literary Devices:
Rhetorical Question/Statement: This is a persuasive statement disguised as a question.
"If in this blemish'd fort I make some hole"

"If in this blemish'd fort": 'Blemish'd fort' continues the metaphor of her body as a fortified structure, now defiled and weakened by the rape. 'Blemish'd' further emphasizes that it is no longer perfect.
"I make some hole": 'Hole' is a euphemism for the wound she will inflict upon herself to end her life.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Fort" is a metaphor for Lucrece's body.
Euphemism: "Hole" is a polite way to refer to a fatal wound.

"Through which I may convey this troubled soul."

"Through which I may convey": She sees suicide as a way to release her soul from the pain and dishonor she has experienced.
"this troubled soul": This emphasizes the internal anguish and suffering she is enduring.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Giving the soul the ability to be "troubled".

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a pivotal moment in the poem. Lucrece is contemplating suicide. She uses a series of vivid metaphors comparing her body to a house, mansion, temple, and fort, all of which have been violated and destroyed by Collatine's rape. Because of this violation, she argues that ending her life is not an act of impiety (disrespect to the gods) but rather a necessary means of freeing her tormented soul from a corrupted vessel. She views her body as irrevocably tainted, and death is the only way to preserve her honor and escape her suffering. The stanza serves as a justification for her impending suicide, framing it as a rational and even necessary act.

Key Literary Devices in the Stanza:

Extended Metaphor: The consistent comparison of Lucrece's body to various structures (house, mansion, temple, fort) is the dominant device. This emphasizes the physical and emotional damage she has sustained.
Euphemism: The use of "hole" to describe a fatal wound softens the harsh reality of suicide. Alliteration: Several instances ("Her House," "Grossly Engirt") add emphasis and musicality. Triadic Structure/List of Three: "Spotted, spoil'd, corrupted" enhances the image of devastation. Rhetorical Question/Statement: "Then let it not be call'd impiety..." sets up her defense of suicide.
Personification: Giving the soul the ability to be "troubled."

In essence, this stanza is a carefully constructed argument for suicide, driven by the overwhelming sense of dishonor and defilement Lucrece feels after the rape. It demonstrates Shakespeare's masterful use of language and imagery to explore complex moral and psychological themes.
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← Stanza 168📚 OverviewStanza 170 →

Stanza 169 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 169 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line, identify the literary devices, and then provide an overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Yet die I will not till my Collatine"

Literal Meaning: Despite everything, I will not die until my husband, Collatine,
Analysis: This line reveals Lucrece's resolve. Even in the face of death, she has a purpose to fulfill. "Collatine" is used in place of "My husband".

"Have heard the cause of my untimely death;"

Literal Meaning: Has heard the reason for my death, which has happened before its proper time.

Analysis: "Untimely death" emphasizes the injustice and tragedy of her situation. Lucrece is robbed of the natural course of her life.

"That he may vow, in that sad hour of mine,"

Literal Meaning: So that he may make a solemn promise (vow) during my last, sorrowful moments,
Analysis: Lucrece's primary concern is not simply her own demise, but what comes after. She wants Collatine to make a vow. "Sad hour of mine" refers to the time of her death.

"Revenge on him that made me stop my breath."

Literal Meaning: To take revenge on the man who caused my death.
Analysis: The "him that made me stop my breath" is, of course, Tarquin. This clarifies the nature of the vow she wants Collatine to make: revenge.

"My stained blood to Tarquin I'll bequeath,"

Literal Meaning: I will leave (bequeath) my defiled/shamed blood to Tarquin.
Analysis: This is a powerful and somewhat metaphorical line. Lucrece sees her blood as now belonging to Tarquin because he has tainted it through his crime. "Stained blood" refers to the blood she associates with her rape and ruined reputation. "Bequeath" implies she is giving it to him, but with a sinister intention.

"Which by him tainted shall for him be spent,"

Literal Meaning: The blood which he defiled will ultimately be used up (spent) on him. Analysis: This line suggests that Tarquin will be punished for what he has done, and the consequences of his actions will consume him. Her blood, tainted by him, will be the instrument of his downfall.

"And as his due writ in my testament."

Literal Meaning: And this (his punishment) will be written in my final will (testament) as something he deserves.

'Yet die I will not till my Collatine
Have heard the cause of my untimely death;
That he may vow, in that sad hour of mine,
Revenge on him that made me stop my breath.
My stained blood to Tarquin I'll bequeath, Which by him tainted shall for him be spent, And as his due writ in my testament.

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Analysis: Lucrece frames her death and the quest for revenge as a formal legal matter. She is making it her final wish. "His due" emphasizes the idea of justice and retribution. The
"testament" creates a sense of formality and finality.

Literary Devices:

Irony: Lucrece "bequeathing" her stained blood to Tarquin is deeply ironic. She's not giving him a gift; she's passing on a curse, a burden, and a demand for vengeance.
Metaphor: The "stained blood" is a metaphor for Lucrece's dishonored reputation and the injustice she has suffered.
Foreshadowing: The lines hint at the eventual downfall of Tarquin, suggesting that his actions will have dire consequences.
Alliteration: "made me"
Assonance: "death/breath"

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece is determined to ensure that her death has meaning and purpose. She will not die in silence or without seeking justice. She delays her death specifically to compel her husband, Collatine, to vow revenge against Tarquin. She frames her death and the act of revenge as her final will, ensuring that Tarquin's punishment is seen as a deserved and legally mandated consequence of his crime. The "stained blood" is a powerful symbol of Tarquin's corruption and the curse that Lucrece places upon him, suggesting that his actions will ultimately lead to his destruction. She is taking control of her narrative and ensuring that her voice is heard, even in death. Her goal is to spark action that will avenge her honor and punish Tarquin. The stanza highlights the themes of revenge, justice, honor, and the power of words and vows in the face of extreme injustice.

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← Stanza 169📚 OverviewStanza 171 →

Stanza 170 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 170 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then consider the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"My honour I'll bequeath unto the knife"

Meaning: Lucrece is saying that she will give her honour to the knife that will kill her. She is personifying the knife, giving it the agency to carry her honour forward.
Literary Device: Personification (giving the knife the ability to receive an inheritance).

"That wounds my body so dishonoured."

Meaning: The knife will wound her body, which has been defiled (dishonored) by the rape. This reinforces the belief that her physical body is now irrevocably tainted.
Literary Device: Emphasizing the physical impact of the rape.

"'Tis honour to deprive dishonour'd life;"

Meaning: It is an act of honour (right, noble) to take away a life that has been dishonored. Suicide, in this instance, is seen as a restoration, not a degradation.
Literary Device: Justification of suicide as a means of regaining honor, contrasting with modern viewpoints.

"The one will live, the other being dead:"

Meaning: Honour (or reputation) will continue to exist/live, even though her physical life (the "dishonoured life") will be gone. This is the core of her argument: her death isn't an end, but a transformation.
Literary Device: Antithesis (opposite ideas placed together - life and death)

"So of shame's ashes shall my fame be bred;"

Meaning: Out of the destruction of her shame (symbolized by ashes, a common metaphor for destruction), her good reputation (fame) will be born. Just like a phoenix rising from the ashes, her reputation for virtue will emerge from the ashes of the shameful act committed against her. Literary Device: Metaphor (shame as ashes, fame being bred), Allusion (to the Phoenix myth)

"For in my death I murder shameful scorn:"

Meaning: By killing herself, Lucrece believes she is killing the shameful disgrace that has been inflicted upon her. She is actively fighting back against the dishonor. This also implies that the act of suicide will destroy the power of future scorn as well.
Literary Device: Personification (giving 'scorn' the ability to be murdered).

"My shame so dead, mine honour is new-born."

Meaning: With her shame dead, her honour is reborn or renewed. The act of suicide is a cleansing, a way to reclaim what was taken from her. It echoes the earlier line about fame being bred from shame's ashes.
Literary Device: Metaphor (honour being reborn, shame being dead).

'My honour I'll bequeath unto the knife
That wounds my body so dishonoured.
'Tis honour to deprive dishonour'd life;
The one will live, the other being dead:
So of shame's ashes shall my fame be bred;
For in my death I murder shameful scorn: My shame so dead, mine honour is new-born.

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Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a powerful declaration of Lucrece's intent to commit suicide as a means of restoring her honor. She believes that her honor cannot coexist with the shame of the rape. She views suicide not as a defeat, but as an act of agency and a way to triumph over the dishonor that has been forced upon her. By choosing death, she believes she can transform her shame into lasting fame and restore her good name. She portrays the act of suicide as a purification, a cleansing fire that will eradicate the stain of the rape and allow her honour to be reborn. The stanza is filled with a sense of grim determination and a complex understanding of honor, shame, and reputation within the societal context of the time. It also demonstrates her belief that her death will have a powerful message for others. The act becomes a means of reclaiming her narrative and controlling her destiny.

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Stanza 171 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices at play.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Dear lord of that dear jewel I have lost,"

Dear lord: This refers to Lucrece's husband, Collatine. "Lord" emphasizes his position and authority.
of that dear jewel: The "dear jewel" is Lucrece's chastity and honor, which she considers her
most precious possession. The use of the word "jewel" is a metaphor, comparing her chastity to something valuable and beautiful.
I have lost: A direct statement of the core tragedy - she has lost her honor due to Tarquin's rape.
Meaning: Lucrece is addressing her husband, Collatine, acknowledging that she has been robbed of her most precious possession, her honor.

"What legacy shall I bequeath to thee?"

Legacy: Lucrece is contemplating what she can leave Collatine since she believes she is now tainted and unworthy of him. A legacy is usually something of value left to someone after death. Bequeath: The verb "bequeath" emphasizes the act of leaving something in a will, suggesting finality and death.
Meaning: Lucrece is asking what she can possibly leave her husband, given that she feels she has nothing of value left to give.

"My resolution, love, shall be thy boast,"

Resolution: This refers to her firm decision to take her own life. It's her unwavering determination to restore honor.
Love: This is her way of addressing Collatine.
Shall be thy boast: She believes her act of suicide, driven by honor, will be something Collatine can be proud of. It will be a source of strength and a call to action.
Meaning: She offers her firm resolve to die for her honor as the legacy she will leave to her husband. It will be an inspiring example for him.

"By whose example thou revenged mayest be."

By whose example: Her act of suicide will serve as an example for Collatine.
Thou revenged mayest be: Her death is meant to inspire and justify his revenge against Tarquin.
Meaning: Lucrece explicitly states that her suicide is meant to be an example that will motivate Collatine to seek revenge on Tarquin.

' Dear lord of that dear jewel I have lost,
What legacy shall I bequeath to thee?
My resolution, love, shall be thy boast,
By whose example thou revenged mayest be.
How Tarquin must be used, read it in me: Myself, thy friend, will kill myself, thy foe, And for my sake serve thou false Tarquin so.

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"How Tarquin must be used, read it in me:"

How Tarquin must be used: This is a powerful and somewhat ambiguous phrase. "Used"
implies Tarquin should be treated or dealt with in a certain way. In this context, it means that Tarquin should be punished.
Read it in me: She wants Collatine to understand the depth of Tarquin's crime and the need for retribution by witnessing her death. Her body becomes a text, a visual representation of Tarquin's wickedness.
Meaning: The sight of my body, the visual of my death will speak volumes and inspire you to understand the depth of Tarquin's crime and the need to punish him.

"Myself, thy friend, will kill myself, thy foe,"

Myself, thy friend: She emphasizes her love and loyalty to Collatine. The "myself" highlights that she is sacrificing her own life.
Will kill myself, thy foe: She sees her "self" (the dishonored Lucrece) as an enemy to Collatine's honor and happiness. She is killing the part of herself that has been defiled by Tarquin. This is a complex idea, showing the internal conflict she feels.
Meaning: She is taking responsibility for her own dishonor, believing that her death will eliminate the tainted part of herself that she sees as an enemy to Collatine.

"And for my sake serve thou false Tarquin so."

For my sake: She reiterates that her actions are for Collatine and for the sake of their shared honor.
Serve thou false Tarquin so: This is a direct instruction to Collatine to treat Tarquin in a similar way - to inflict pain and suffering as revenge for the rape. "Serve" here means "deal with" or
"treat."
Meaning: She commands Collatine to avenge her by inflicting similar harm on the treacherous Tarquin.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

In this stanza, Lucrece, devastated by the rape, addresses her husband, Collatine. She sees herself as having lost her most precious possession, her honor and chastity. She considers her own death as the only way to restore honor to herself and her family. She offers her resolution to die as a legacy for Collatine, hoping it will inspire him to seek revenge against Tarquin. Her suicide is not an act of despair, but a deliberate and calculated act of defiance and a call to action. She presents her body as a testament to Tarquin's crime and a rallying point for revenge. The stanza is filled with a sense of tragic nobility and a powerful demand for justice.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: "Dear jewel" comparing Lucrece's chastity to a valuable object.
Irony: Lucrece killing herself, "thy foe," to ultimately help Collatine, "thy friend." Her death, normally a symbol of loss, is presented as a form of empowerment.
Apostrophe: Addressing Collatine directly, even though he is not physically present at the time of her suicide.
Imagery: The stanza evokes vivid imagery of sacrifice, death, and revenge. The idea of "reading" Tarquin's punishment in her body is particularly striking.
Anaphora: There is an element of anaphora or repetition in the use of "thy" and "my" emphasizing ownership and responsibility.
Imperative: the use of the imperative "serve thou false Tarquin so." indicates the command and urgency in her final words.
Alliteration: There is alliteration in the words "dear Lord" and "false Tarquin" which emphasizes those phrases.

This stanza is a crucial turning point in the poem, marking Lucrece's decision and laying the groundwork for the political upheaval and revolution that follows. Her death becomes a catalyst for change, and her words in this stanza resonate with a powerful sense of purpose and tragic determination.

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← Stanza 171📚 OverviewStanza 173 →

Stanza 172 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, and then consider its overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"This brief abridgement of my will I make:"

Abridgement: A shortened version or summary.
Will: In this context, Lucrece's last will and testament, her final declaration of what she wants to happen after her death.
I make: She is actively declaring and creating this concise summary.
Literary Device: Formal diction - creates a sense of solemnity and a legalistic feel appropriate for a final testament.

Meaning: Lucrece is stating that she is about to give a summarized version of her final wishes, a concise declaration before she dies. This adds to the seriousness of the moment.

"My soul and body to the skies and ground;"

Soul to the skies: A typical Christian expectation that her soul will ascend to Heaven.
Body to the ground: Her physical remains will be buried in the earth.
Literary Device: Parallelism/ Antithesis- The juxtaposition of "skies" and "ground" creates a contrasting image that emphasizes the totality of her being; everything belongs to either Heaven or Earth after her death.
Literary Device: Metonymy - Using "skies" to represent heaven.
Meaning: She is relinquishing her soul to God and her physical body to the earth, acknowledging the end of her earthly existence. This is a common element in a will.

"My resolution, husband, do thou take;"

Resolution: Here, this refers to the action Lucrece is about to take (suicide) and her strength/determination to do so. It also implies her demand for vengeance.
Husband, do thou take: She is entrusting her husband, Collatinus, with the responsibility to avenge her.
Literary Device: Direct Address: She's speaking directly to her husband, emphasizing the personal plea and burden she places on him.
Meaning: She is asking her husband to accept her drastic act and to take up the mantle of avenging her dishonor. She implies the strength to complete her task.

"Mine honour be the knife's that makes my wound;"

Honour be the knife's: Her honor will be restored through the act of the knife and her suicide. The knife becomes the instrument of her cleansing.
That makes my wound: The knife that will create her fatal wound.
Literary Device: Personification: Attributing agency to the knife as the tool of her honor's restoration.

'This brief abridgement of my will I make:
My soul and body to the skies and ground;
My resolution, husband, do thou take;
Mine honour be the knife's that makes my wound;
My shame be his that did my fame confound;
And all my fame that lives disbursed be
To those that live, and think no shame of me.

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Literary Device: Metaphor: The knife represents the instrument of her honor's restoration. It is not literally her honor.
Meaning: She is stating that her suicide is not an act of cowardice, but rather a necessary act to reclaim her lost honor. The act of suicide itself becomes a way to regain it.

"My shame be his that did my fame confound;"

Shame be his: She wishes that the shame of the rape should fall entirely on Tarquin, the perpetrator.
That did my fame confound: "Confound" means to destroy, ruin, or confuse. Tarquin's actions have destroyed her reputation.
Literary Device: Juxtaposition/Contrast: Placing "shame" (to Tarquin) and "fame" (her own, now ruined) side by side emphasizes the injustice of the situation.
Meaning: Lucrece desires that Tarquin, who shattered her reputation, should bear the full weight of shame for his actions.

"And all my fame that lives disbursed be"

Fame that lives: The remaining reputation or legacy she might have after this scandal. Disbursed be: Distributed or spread out.
Literary Device: Alliteration: The repetition of the "d" sound in "disbursed be" emphasizes the spread of her story.
Meaning: She wishes that whatever good reputation remains of her after this tragedy should be spread and disseminated widely. She wants her story to be known.

"To those that live, and think no shame of me."

To those that live: Future generations, or those who survive her.
Think no shame of me: She hopes they will not think badly of her because of the rape. She wants them to see her as a victim, not as someone who is deserving of dishonor.
Meaning: She hopes that future generations will remember her without shame and understand
the injustice she suffered. This is a plea for her memory to be preserved with understanding and sympathy.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza encapsulates Lucrece's final act of defiance against the injustice she suffered. It is a powerful statement of her desire to restore her honor, assign blame, and ensure that her story is remembered and understood by future generations. She is not simply a victim, but a figure who actively shapes her legacy through her final act. Her "will" is a desperate attempt to control the narrative of her life and death in the face of unspeakable violation. She is sacrificing herself in the hopes of inciting justice and preventing future women from suffering the same fate. The stanza is filled with a profound sense of agency, even in the face of death, as Lucrece takes control of what remains of her reputation and demands retribution for the wrongs committed against her.

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← Stanza 172📚 OverviewStanza 174 →

Stanza 173 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 173 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line:

Line 1: 'Thou, Collatine, shalt oversee this will;'

Breakdown:
"Thou, Collatine": Direct address to her husband, Collatine.
"shalt oversee this will": You will be the executor of this, referring to her dying wishes, or perhaps
a more metaphorical "will" - her desire for justice.

Meaning: Lucrece is telling Collatine that he is responsible for carrying out the consequences of her death, ensuring her actions are understood.

Line 2: 'How was I overseen that thou shalt see it!'

Breakdown:
"How was I overseen": A double meaning; how could she have been so negligent to allow the
rape to happen, and also, how was she misunderstood or underestimated to have been targeted
in this way? "Overseen" could also hint at a sense of divine watchfulness, implying a question of why she was not protected.
"that thou shalt see it!": That you will now understand the consequences of what has happened (because of her death and explanation)

Meaning: She laments her vulnerability and the fact that Collatine will only truly understand the gravity of the situation after her death and her explanation. It's a cry of pain and a subtle accusation that he should have protected her better.

Line 3: 'My blood shall wash the slander of mine ill;'

Breakdown:
"My blood shall wash": Alliteration and metaphor. The alliteration of "blood" and "wash"
emphasizes the cleansing action. The "blood" symbolizes her sacrifice and the "slander of mine
ill" is the shame or guilt associated with being raped.
"the slander of mine ill": The false accusations or rumors surrounding her "ill" (the rape), which is seen as a stain on her honor.

Meaning: Her suicide, the shedding of her blood, will cleanse her reputation from the shame and false accusations brought about by Tarquin's act. She believes suicide is the only way to restore her honor.

Line 4: 'My life's foul deed, my life's fair end shall free it.'

Breakdown:
"My life's foul deed": Ambiguous. Could refer to the rape itself, which she internalizes as a
"deed," or to her act of suicide. In either case, it suggests a deeply personal sense of
responsibility or shame.
"my life's fair end shall free it": Her honorable (or at least perceived-as-honorable) death will liberate or exonerate her from the foul deed/shame. Juxtaposition between "foul deed" and "fair end".

'Thou, Collatine, shalt oversee this will;
How was I overseen that thou shalt see it!
My blood shall wash the slander of mine ill;
My life's foul deed, my life's fair end shall free it.
Faint not, faint heart, but stoutly say 'So be it:' Yield to my hand; my hand shall conquer thee:
Thou dead, both die, and both shall victors be.'

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Meaning: Her honorable death, in her view, will liberate her from the shame of the rape and/or the "foul deed" of taking her own life. Again, she sees death as the only path to freedom and redemption.

Line 5: 'Faint not, faint heart, but stoutly say 'So be it:'

Breakdown:
"Faint not, faint heart": Apostrophe (addressing an inanimate object - her heart). Repetition of "faint" emphasizes her internal struggle and fear.
"but stoutly say 'So be it:'": urging herself to be strong and accept her fate, to affirm her decision
to die.

Meaning: She is encouraging herself to be brave and accept her fate, to follow through with her plan, even though she is afraid.

Line 6: 'Yield to my hand; my hand shall conquer thee:'

Breakdown:
"Yield to my hand": This is complex. "My hand" literally refers to the hand that will take her own
life. "Yield" suggests a surrender to death.
"My hand shall conquer thee": Paradoxical. Her hand, acting as the instrument of her death, will paradoxically conquer "thee" - which could refer to the shame, the dishonor, or even to Tarquin's act itself.

Meaning: She commands herself to surrender to the act of suicide, believing that by killing herself, she will conquer the shame and dishonor brought upon her.

Line 7: 'Thou dead, both die, and both shall victors be.'

Breakdown:
"Thou dead": Refers to herself after death.
"both die": Complex and open to interpretation. "Both" could refer to:
Her body and her shame: Her physical self will die, and so will the shame she feels.
Herself and Tarquin (metaphorically): Her death will bring about the "death" of Tarquin's power, reputation, and potentially his life. This could be seen as a call for justice.

"both shall victors be": The ultimate paradox. Victory is achieved through death.

Meaning: Through her death, she hopes to eradicate both herself and the dishonor she feels, and perhaps symbolically defeat Tarquin. It's a twisted victory, achieved through sacrifice. She believes that her suicide will ultimately lead to a form of justice or redemption.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

Stanza 173 is a powerful and emotionally charged soliloquy where Lucrece contemplates her impending suicide. She sees it as the only way to cleanse her honor, restore her reputation, and ultimately achieve a twisted form of victory over Tarquin and the shame he has inflicted. She acknowledges the pain and fear, but steels herself to follow through with her plan, believing it is her duty to restore the moral order. The stanza is full of paradoxes, ambiguities, and internal conflict, highlighting the complex and tragic nature of her situation. It showcases her deep sense of shame, her determination to reclaim her honor, and her belief that death is the only way to achieve these goals. The stanza acts as a pivotal moment in the poem, illustrating Lucrece's tragic decision and her complex justification for taking her own life.

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← Stanza 173📚 OverviewStanza 175 →

Stanza 174 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 174 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identifying literary devices, and then provide an overall interpretation.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "This Plot of death when sadly she had laid,"

Meaning: Lucrece, after considering and deciding upon her course of action (suicide), which she refers to as her "Plot of death," is saddened by her decision. She has come to terms with her decision and now has to set the wheels in motion.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Plot of death" is a metaphor. Suicide, or at least her planned act of suicide, is equated to a theatrical plot or a carefully considered strategy. This emphasizes the deliberate
and considered nature of her decision.

Alliteration: The repetition of the "d" sound in "death" and "sadly" create a soft, mournful
tone.

Euphemism: "Plot of death" functions as a euphemism for suicide, making it less harsh for the audience.

Line 2: "And wiped the brinish pearl from her bright eyes,"

Meaning: She wipes away the salty (brinish) tears from her eyes. "Pearl" is a metaphor for the tears themselves.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Brinish pearl" is a metaphor for tears. The pearl is symbolic of her purity and what she has lost due to the rape.
Alliteration: the repetition of "b" in "brinish" and "bright" to emphasize the vivid, melancholic
scene.

Line 3: "With untuned tongue she hoarsely calls her maid,"

Meaning: Her voice is out of tune and rough because of her emotional distress as she calls for her servant.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Untuned tongue" is a metaphor indicating that her voice lacks its normal musicality or harmony. It's symbolic of her emotional disruption.

Line 4: "Whose swift obedience to her mistress hies;"

Meaning: The maidservant quickly hurries (hies) to her mistress out of obedience.
Literary Devices:
Archaism: "Hies" is an archaic word, meaning "hurries," giving the language a formal and slightly elevated tone.

Line 5: "For fleet-wing'd duty with thought's feathers flies."

Meaning: Her servant is quick and responsive out of duty. "Thought's feathers" suggest how quickly she comes, as if she's heard Lucrece's call in her mind and immediately acted.

This Plot of death when sadly she had laid,
And wiped the brinish pearl from her bright eyes,
With untuned tongue she hoarsely calls her maid,
Whose swift obedience to her mistress hies;
For fleet-wing'd duty with thought's feathers flies.
Poor Lucrece' cheeks unto her maid seem so
As winter meads when sun doth melt their snow.

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Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Fleet-wing'd duty" compares duty to something swift, like a bird in flight. Metaphor: "Thought's feathers" uses the feathers as a synecdoche for wings, which are used
to describe the speed of her reaction.

Line 6: "Poor Lucrece' cheeks unto her maid seem so"

Meaning: Lucrece's face looks to her maid as if it is a wintry landscape.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "Poor Lucrece' cheeks" - assigning a human quality, "poor," to an inanimate object to evoke sympathy.

Line 7: "As winter meads when sun doth melt their snow."

Meaning: Her cheeks are as pale as a winter meadow with melting snow, but now as the guilt washes over her, they are also becoming red.
Literary Devices:
Simile: The use of "as" makes this a simile. The comparison emphasizes her paleness, vulnerability, and the draining of her vitality.

Overall Meaning and Interpretation:

This stanza depicts the immediate aftermath of Lucrece's fateful decision to take her own life. The focus is on her summoning her maid and the contrast between Lucrece's emotional state and the maid's swift, unquestioning obedience.

The stanza highlights:

Lucrece's inner turmoil: The "plot of death," "brinish pearl," and "untuned tongue" all emphasize her profound grief and distress.
The maid's loyalty and speed: Her servant's prompt response underscores Lucrece's noble status and the societal expectations of service.
Lucrece's physical deterioration: The comparison of her cheeks to "winter meads when sun doth melt their snow" paints a picture of her as pale, weakened, and drained of life. This adds to the tragic and pitiful tone of the poem.

The overall effect of the stanza is to create a poignant image of Lucrece at a critical moment: resolute in her decision to commit suicide, but profoundly saddened by it, and physically weakened. The stanza underscores the tragic consequences of the rape and the devastating impact it has had on Lucrece. The literary devices create a vivid and emotional picture of Lucrece's suffering, leaving the reader in suspense as to what will happen next.

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← Stanza 174📚 OverviewStanza 176 →

Stanza 175 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 175 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Her mistress she doth give demure good-morrow,"

Her mistress: Refers to Lucrece, the lady of the house.
she doth give: The servant woman performs an action
demure good-morrow: "Demure" means modest, reserved, and respectful. "Good-morrow" is simply "good morning."
Meaning: The servant politely and respectfully greets Lucrece.

"With soft-slow tongue, true mark of modesty,"

soft-slow tongue: Suggests a gentle, quiet way of speaking. The servant is speaking slowly and quietly, as a sign of deference and respect.
true mark of modesty: This highlights the servant's humility and proper demeanor. Her speech is described as a true sign, or indication, of modesty.
Meaning: The servant speaks in a quiet and respectful manner, demonstrating her modest nature.

"And sorts a sad look to her lady's sorrow,"

sorts: Here, it means to arrange, adapt, or match.
sad look: A sorrowful, mournful expression.
to her lady's sorrow: In accordance with, or reflecting, Lucrece's obvious sadness.
Meaning: The servant arranges her facial expression to reflect the sorrow she sees in Lucrece's face, mirroring her mistress's mood.

"For why her face wore sorrow's livery;"

For why: An archaic way of saying "because" or "since."
her face wore sorrow's livery: "Livery" refers to a uniform or distinctive clothing, often worn by servants or members of a particular group. Here, it's used metaphorically. Lucrece's face is wearing sorrow like a garment.
Meaning: Because Lucrece's face was clearly displaying sorrow, like one who wears the colors or garments of their master.

"But durst not ask of her audaciously"
durst not ask: The servant dared not ask.
of her audaciously: Boldly, impudently, or disrespectfully of Lucrece.
Meaning: The servant didn't dare to ask Lucrece any bold or intrusive questions.

"Why her two suns were cloud-eclipsed so,"

her two suns: A metaphor referring to Lucrece's eyes, radiant and bright like the sun. cloud-eclipsed: Hidden or darkened by clouds (in this case, sadness).

Her mistress she doth give demure good-morrow,
With soft-slow tongue, true mark of modesty,
And sorts a sad look to her lady's sorrow,
For why her face wore sorrow's livery;
But durst not ask of her audaciously
Why her two suns were cloud-eclipsed so,
Nor why her fair cheeks over-wash'd with woe.

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Meaning: The servant wouldn't dare ask why Lucrece's eyes (her "suns") were so dimmed by sadness.

"Nor why her fair cheeks over-wash'd with woe."

fair cheeks: Lucrece's beautiful cheeks.
over-wash'd with woe: Soaked or covered with sorrow, suggesting tears.
Meaning: Nor would she ask why her fair cheeks were so drenched with tears and sadness.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza paints a picture of a servant observing Lucrece in deep distress. The servant is polite, respectful, and aware of Lucrece's sorrow. She expresses her empathy by mirroring Lucrece's sadness, but she remains mindful of her place and refrains from intruding with direct or probing questions. The stanza emphasizes the rigid social hierarchy of the time and the expected behavior of servants towards their superiors. It also highlights the profound sadness that Lucrece is experiencing, a sadness so overwhelming that it is immediately apparent to those around her. The servant is a passive observer, respectful and concerned, but ultimately powerless to help.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: The most prominent device is the metaphor of Lucrece's eyes as "two suns." This emphasizes her beauty and the brilliance that has now been dimmed by sorrow. "sorrow's livery" is also a metaphor.
Imagery: The stanza is rich in visual imagery. We can picture the servant's demure greeting, Lucrece's sorrowful face, and her tear-stained cheeks. The image of the "cloud-eclipsed" suns is particularly vivid.
Alliteration: The phrase "soft-slow tongue" uses alliteration to emphasize the gentleness of the servant's speech.
Archaic Language: The use of phrases like "doth give," "good-morrow," and "for why" contributes to the formal and somewhat distant tone of the poem.
Personification could be seen in "sorrow's livery" giving sorrow the human trait of being able to wear clothes.

In summary, this stanza is a carefully crafted portrait of a mistress's sorrow and a servant's cautious observation, rich in imagery and figures of speech that contribute to the overall tragic atmosphere of The Rape of Lucrece.

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← Stanza 175📚 OverviewStanza 177 →

Stanza 176 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 176 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then provide an overall interpretation, paying attention to literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"But as the earth doth weep, the sun being set,"

Literal Meaning: Just as the earth seems to weep with dew when the sun goes down.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "Earth doth weep" gives the earth human qualities.
Simile: The entire line initiates a comparison ("as...")
Imagery: Creates a visual image of a dewy landscape at sunset.

"Each flower moisten'd like a melting eye;"

Literal Meaning: Each flower is moistened with dew, resembling a weeping eye.
Literary Devices:
Simile: ("like") directly compares the dew-covered flower to a "melting eye."
Imagery: Extends the visual image, now focusing on individual flowers and their dewy appearance. The "melting eye" suggests sorrow and pain.

"Even so the maid with swelling drops gan wet"

Literal Meaning: In the same way, the maid (Lucrece's servant) began to wet her own eyes with swelling tears. "Gan" is an archaic form of "began."
Literary Devices:
Transition: "Even so" connects the previous imagery to the maid's reaction.
Alliteration: "Swelling" and "swelling" could be considered an example as it creates a gentle consonance within the line, drawing attention to the abundance of tears.

"Her circled eyne, enforced by sympathy"

Literal Meaning: Her round eyes, filled with tears, were caused by the sympathy she felt. "Eyne" is an archaic word for eyes.
Literary Devices:
Archaism: The use of "eyne" adds a formal and somewhat distanced tone.
Word Choice: "Enforced" emphasizes the involuntary nature of her tears; she cannot help but weep.

"Of those fair suns set in her mistress' sky,"

Literal Meaning: This sympathy stemmed from the beautiful eyes (suns) of her mistress (Lucrece) having been dimmed by tragedy (the "sunset"). The "sky" is Lucrece's face.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Lucrece's eyes are compared to "fair suns," representing their beauty and radiance. Metaphor: Lucrece's face is compared to "sky", emphasising the vastness of her character. Euphemism: "Set" is a gentle way of referring to the loss of Lucrece's light and joy due to the rape.

But as the earth doth weep, the sun being set,
Each flower moisten'd like a melting eye;
Even so the maid with swelling drops gan wet
Her circled eyne, enforced by sympathy
Of those fair suns set in her mistress' sky, Who in a salt-waved ocean quench their light, Which makes the maid weep like the dewy night.

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Conceit: An extended metaphor that continues from line to line.

"Who in a salt-waved ocean quench their light,"

Literal Meaning: These eyes, like suns, are now drowning in a "salt-waved ocean" of tears. Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The tears are a "salt-waved ocean," emphasizing their vastness and bitterness. Imagery: Continues the vivid visual of drowning or being extinguished.

"Which makes the maid weep like the dewy night."

Literal Meaning: This situation (Lucrece's sorrow) causes the maid to weep, just as the night weeps with dew.
Literary Devices:
Simile: The maid's weeping is compared to the "dewy night," completing the circle of
comparison started in the first line.
Personification: Continues to present nature as capable of feeling.

Overall Meaning and Interpretation:

This stanza describes the maid's reaction to Lucrece's despair, but it does so indirectly, through a series of extended comparisons to nature. The dominant image is that of a weeping world. The setting sun, dewy flowers, and dewy night all mirror the maid's sorrow.

The stanza uses the imagery of "suns" (Lucrece's eyes) being extinguished or drowned in a "salt-waved ocean" of tears to convey the intensity of Lucrece's suffering. The maid's tears are a direct result of her empathy for her mistress, demonstrating the powerful connection between them.

The use of metaphors and similes creates a sense of universal grief. Lucrece's tragedy is not just a personal one; it is reflected in the very fabric of the natural world. The maid's weeping is a natural response to the violation and the consequent dimming of Lucrece's light.

The archaic language adds a layer of formality and distance, which, paradoxically, can also heighten the sense of tragedy by giving it a timeless quality. This is a scene of profound sorrow and empathy, beautifully rendered through elaborate figurative language.
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← Stanza 176📚 OverviewStanza 178 →

Stanza 177 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 177 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, then provide an overall interpretation, and highlight the literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"A pretty while these pretty creatures stand,"

Pretty: Here, "pretty" means "for a good length of time". Shakespeare is using it in an archaic sense of duration, not just appearance.
Pretty creatures: Refers to Lucrece and her waiting women/attendants who are witnessing her distress. The repetition of "pretty" might suggest a certain aesthetic appreciation of their beauty, even amidst the tragic scene, or perhaps an ironic observation, implying their prettiness is now irrelevant in the face of suffering.
Stand: Implies a static, almost frozen posture, suggesting their shock and inability to act or intervene effectively.

"Like ivory conduits coral cisterns filling:"

Simile: This line is a simile, using "like" to compare the women and their tears to elaborate water features.
Ivory conduits: The women's pale, smooth faces (especially cheeks) are likened to ivory channels, through which tears flow.
Coral cisterns: Their eyes are likened to coral-colored (reddened from crying) cisterns, being filled with tears.
Elaborate Imagery: The imagery is highly ornamental and stylized. It's not just about sadness, but about the presentation of sadness in a visually beautiful, yet somewhat artificial, way.

"One justly weeps; the other takes in hand"

One justly weeps: This refers to Lucrece, who has legitimate and profound cause to weep due to the rape. Her weeping is justified.
The other takes in hand: Refers to one of the waiting women.

"No cause, but company, of her drops spilling:"

No cause, but company: This waiting woman has no personal reason to weep, but weeps simply out of empathy, solidarity, or the desire to share in Lucrece's grief.
Drops spilling: Suggests that the woman's tears are not heartfelt or personal, but only spilled because she sees Lucrece crying.

"Their gentle sex to weep are often willing;"

Their gentle sex: A general statement about women, portraying them as inherently prone to weeping. It's a stereotype of the time.
Often willing: They are predisposed to tears and emotional displays, suggesting a certain susceptibility or vulnerability.

A pretty while these pretty creatures stand,
Like ivory conduits coral cisterns filling:
One justly weeps; the other takes in hand
No cause, but company, of her drops spilling:
Their gentle sex to weep are often willing;
Grieving themselves to guess at others' smarts,
And then they drown their eyes or break their hearts.

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"Grieving themselves to guess at others' smarts,"

Grieving themselves: Experiencing grief, even though the original pain doesn't directly belong to them.
Guess at others' smarts: Their empathy involves a guess, an approximation, of another's pain. They can't fully understand the depth of Lucrece's suffering, but they try to imagine it.

"And then they drown their eyes or break their hearts."

Exaggeration/Hyperbole: This line uses hyperbole to emphasize the intensity of their
emotional response.
Drown their eyes: Indicates excessive weeping, to the point of obscuring their vision.
Break their hearts: Implies overwhelming sorrow and emotional anguish. The line is not meant
to be taken literally, but to convey the intensity of their emotional pain.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza paints a picture of Lucrece's profound sorrow and the empathetic (or perhaps performative) weeping of her attendants. It highlights the contrast between Lucrece's justified grief and the attendants' sympathetic, secondary sorrow. It also offers a somewhat stereotypical view of women as being emotionally sensitive and prone to weeping, even when the cause of sorrow isn't their own. The rich imagery and hyperbolic language emphasize the overwhelming nature of the scene and the powerful effect of grief. The stanza hints at the performative aspects of grief and the social expectations placed upon women to express emotions outwardly. The stanza also subtly questions the true depth of the attendants' empathy, as they can only "guess" at Lucrece's pain.

Literary Devices:

Simile: "Like ivory conduits coral cisterns filling"
Imagery: Vivid descriptions of the women, tears, and their visual appearance, creating a visually rich scene.
Hyperbole: "And then they drown their eyes or break their hearts"
Repetition: "Pretty while these pretty creatures stand"
Stereotype: The generalization about women's inherent willingness to weep reflects a common stereotype of the time.
Alliteration: There is some subtle alliteration, which contributes to the overall musicality of the stanza.

In essence, Shakespeare uses this stanza to create a tableau of grief, exploring the nuances of empathy and the societal expectations surrounding women's emotional expression within the context of Lucrece's tragic experience.

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← Stanza 177📚 OverviewStanza 179 →

Stanza 178 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 178 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices, and then synthesize it into an overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"For men have marble, women waxen, minds,"

Meaning: This line establishes a stark contrast between the presumed nature of men and women. Men are compared to marble, which is hard, durable, and resistant to change. Women are
compared to wax, which is soft, pliable, and easily molded. The focus is on the minds, or inner natures.

Literary Devices: Metaphor (marble and wax representing the minds), Juxtaposition/Contrast (between men and women), Stereotype (of gender roles)

"And therefore are they form'd as marble will;"

Meaning: Because men are perceived to have strong, unchanging minds (like marble), they are given the power to mold and shape things as they see fit (as "marble will"). This speaks to the societal structures that allow men to be dominant and impose their will. "Form'd" can mean both literally "shaped" and figuratively "governed".
Literary Devices: Implied Power Dynamic, Allusion (to the hardness and strength of marble)

"The weak oppress'd, the impression of strange kinds"

Meaning: This line extends the previous one, describing the outcome of the power dynamic. The "weak" (women implied) are "oppressed." The "impression of strange kinds" refers to the experiences and influences forced upon them. It is specifically used to refer to the act of rape. Literary Devices: Metaphor, Alliteration ("kinds" and "impression")

"Is form'd in them by force, by fraud, or skill:"

Meaning: This explains how the "impression" is made on women. The line offers three methods: force (physical violence), fraud (deception), or skill (manipulation). This captures the multifaceted nature of male dominance and abuse. It also alludes to the ways that men can impose themselves on women, whether through overt actions or subtle and calculated approaches.
Literary Devices: Triad/Tricolon (listing force, fraud, skill for emphasis), Synonymy (overlapping meanings reinforce the idea of male imposition)

"Then call them not the authors of their ill,"

Meaning: This is the central argument. Given the previous lines, women should not be blamed for the "ill" (harm or wrongdoing) that befalls them. This is a direct plea for understanding and exoneration for Lucrece (and, by extension, all women in similar situations).
Literary Devices: Direct Address (speaking to the audience/society), Moral Argument/Exoneration

For men have marble, women waxen, minds,
And therefore are they form'd as marble will;
The weak oppress'd, the impression of strange kinds
Is form'd in them by force, by fraud, or skill:
Then call them not the authors of their ill,
No more than wax shall be accounted evil
Wherein is stamp'd the semblance of a devil.

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"No more than wax shall be accounted evil"

Meaning: This reinforces the argument using the wax metaphor. Wax is not inherently evil, even though it can be molded into something evil. This highlights the idea that women are not inherently responsible for the evil that is imprinted upon them.
Literary Devices: Analogy (wax mirroring the situation of women), Metaphor (wax standing in for women)

"Wherein is stamp'd the semblance of a devil."

Meaning: This is the final punch of the stanza. Even if wax is used to create an image of the
devil, the wax itself is not to blame. Similarly, even if women are corrupted or "imprinted" with
evil (through rape or other forms of oppression), they are not intrinsically evil. The "semblance of
a devil" hints at the horrific impact of the act of rape on Lucrece's soul and reputation.
Literary Devices: Imagery (vivid image of the devil imprinted on wax), Metaphor (devil representing the evil inflicted upon women), Symbolism (the "devil" is a symbol of the harm and disgrace caused by the rape).

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a powerful indictment of the societal structures that enable the oppression of women. Shakespeare argues that men, perceived as strong and unyielding, wield power and impose their will on women, whom they see as pliable and easily influenced. He uses the metaphors of marble and wax to illustrate this power dynamic. Crucially, he argues that because women are shaped by external forces, they cannot be held responsible for the "ill" that befalls them. He defends Lucrece against the potential accusations of complicity or fault, suggesting that she is a victim of circumstances and not the author of her own misfortune. The stanza serves as a strong moral argument for empathy and exoneration of women who have been harmed. Shakespeare is not simply excusing Lucrece; he is challenging the audience to examine the systemic issues that contribute to such tragedies.

← Stanza 177📚 OverviewStanza 179 →

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← Stanza 178📚 OverviewStanza 180 →

Stanza 179 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 179 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify literary devices, and then discuss the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Their smoothness, like a goodly champaign plain,"

"Their smoothness": Refers to the surface appearance of women (specifically here, the poem suggests it is physical appearance and the apparent "gentle" outward behaviour expected of
them, particularly in contrast to men who are seen to have more "rough" outward behaviour) "like a goodly champaign plain": Simile comparing this surface smoothness to a beautiful, open, level field ("champaign"). A champaign plain is generally perceived as fair and open, without hiding places.

Meaning: This line establishes a superficial picture of women, suggesting they appear uncomplicated and without hidden depths (just as a plain is seen to be open and lacking hiding places). This is, however, immediately contradicted in the following lines.

"Lays open all the little worms that creep;"

"little worms that creep": Metaphor for weaknesses, vulnerabilities, flaws, and perhaps even moral failings. These 'worms' are exposed and visible on the 'plain'.

Meaning: This line argues that women's apparent "smoothness" makes their small flaws and faults highly visible and easily observed. Their faults and weaknesses are on display for all to see, just as worms are visible on the surface of a plain. The fact that they are "little" suggests that these flaws may be minor or insignificant, but because they are visible they are blown out of proportion, or open to exploitation.

"In men, as in a rough-grown grove, remain"

"In men": Shifts the focus to the opposite sex
"as in a rough-grown grove": Simile comparing men to a dense, overgrown forest or thicket.

Meaning: In contrast to women, men are presented as being like a tangled forest. Their true nature is hidden within a dense, impenetrable exterior.

"Cave-keeping evils that obscurely sleep:"

"Cave-keeping evils": Metaphor for the vices, sins, and wicked thoughts that men harbor. The "cave" is a metaphor for the hidden depths of men's nature.
"obscurely sleep": Suggests that these evils are dormant, lurking, but not always apparent.

Meaning: Men's inner evils are kept hidden, like dangerous creatures sleeping in caves. Their rough exterior conceals these flaws, allowing them to remain unseen and undisturbed.

"Through crystal walls each little mote will peep:"

"Through crystal walls": Metaphor for the clarity and transparency of women's outward appearance (the "smoothness" mentioned earlier).

Their smoothness, like a goodly champaign plain,
Lays open all the little worms that creep;
In men, as in a rough-grown grove, remain
Cave-keeping evils that obscurely sleep:
Through crystal walls each little mote will peep: Though men can cover crimes with bold stern looks, Poor women's faces are their own fault's books.

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"each little mote": Metaphor for the smallest flaw or blemish. A "mote" is a tiny speck of dust. "will peep": Suggests that even the smallest flaw is visible.

Meaning: This line reinforces the idea that women's flaws, even the tiniest ones, are easily seen because their outward appearance is clear and transparent, like looking through crystal. This links back to the champaign plain.

"Though men can cover crimes with bold stern looks,"

"cover crimes": Direct reference to the wrongs men are capable of, but can hide.
"bold stern looks": Highlights the power and ability of men to hide their true nature through outward shows of dominance and strength.

Meaning: Men can mask their wicked deeds and hide their true nature with their forceful and commanding demeanor. They are able to escape scrutiny.

"Poor women's faces are their own fault's books."

"Poor women's faces": Highlights the vulnerability and lack of power women possess in this society.
"their own fault's books": Metaphor comparing women's faces to open books that reveal their weaknesses and flaws.

Meaning: In contrast to men, women's faces betray their flaws and make them vulnerable. Their faces serve as "books" that expose their faults, making them easy targets.

Literary Devices:

Simile: Used to compare women's smoothness to a champaign plain and men to a rough-grown grove.
Metaphor: "Little worms" for flaws, "cave-keeping evils" for hidden vices, "crystal walls" for transparency, "their own fault's books" for revealing faces.
Imagery: Strong visual imagery of plains, groves, caves, and crystal walls.
Juxtaposition: The entire stanza relies on juxtaposing the perceived nature of women with the perceived nature of men, highlighting the differences in how they are viewed and judged.
Irony: There is underlying irony throughout the stanza, as the supposed "smoothness" of women is ultimately presented as a weakness, while the "roughness" of men allows them to conceal their flaws.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza presents a critical commentary on the societal double standard applied to men and women. It argues that women's perceived "smoothness" and transparency make them vulnerable, as their flaws and weaknesses are easily seen and judged. In contrast, men's "roughness" and hidden nature allow them to conceal their vices and escape scrutiny. The stanza highlights the power dynamics that allow men to hide their crimes while women's faces betray their perceived faults, making them easy targets. The core idea is that outward appearances don't always reflect true character, and that societal expectations and power structures contribute to this discrepancy. The poem ultimately suggests that these unequal standards contribute to women's vulnerability and their susceptibility to exploitation, as is evidenced by the rape of Lucrece.

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← Stanza 179📚 OverviewStanza 181 →

Stanza 180 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 180 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify literary devices, and then synthesize the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "No man inveigh against the wither'd flower,"

Meaning: "Let no one rail or bitterly criticize (inveigh) the flower that has withered or died." Figurative Language: Metaphor: Lucrece, and by extension, all victimized women, are represented as a "withered flower" – something delicate, beautiful, and now ruined.

Line 2: "But chide rough winter that the flower hath kill'd:"

Meaning: "Instead, scold the harsh winter that caused the flower to die."
Figurative Language: Metaphor: "Rough winter" symbolizes the aggressor, the force that destroys innocence and beauty (specifically, Tarquin and by extension, the patriarchal system). Personification: Giving "winter" the agency to "kill" the flower.

Line 3: "Not that devour'd, but that which doth devour,"

Meaning: "It's not the one that was devoured that should be blamed, but the one who does the devouring."
Literary Device: Parallelism/Antithesis: The structure emphasizes the contrast between the victim and the perpetrator. The repeated "that" creates a deliberate and forceful rhythm.

Line 4: "Is worthy blame. O, let it not be hild"

Meaning: "The one who does the devouring is deserving of blame. Oh, do not let it be held (hild) (thought or considered)."
Literary Device: Apostrophe: Addressing an abstract idea ("blame") directly.

Line 5: "Poor women's faults, that they are so fulfill'd"

Meaning: "Poor women's fault, that they are so filled/burdened."
Literary Device: Irony: "Fulfilled" is usually a positive word, suggesting completion or satisfaction. Here, it's used sarcastically to describe how women are filled with shame, trauma, and the consequences of men's actions.

Line 6: "With men's abuses: those proud lords, to blame,"

Meaning: "With the abuses perpetrated by men: those arrogant and powerful men are the ones who should be blamed."
Literary Device: Alliteration: "proud lords" (repetition of 'l' sound) emphasizes the power dynamic. Synecdoche: "proud lords" represents all abusive men.
Line 7: "Make weak-made women tenants to their shame."

Meaning: "Make women, who are weak by design (weak-made), into tenants (bearers) of their (the men's) shame."
Literary Device: Metaphor: Women as "tenants" (renters) of shame, not owners of their own fate. They are forced to carry the burden of shame created by the men's actions. The term

No man inveigh against the wither'd flower,
But chide rough winter that the flower hath kill'd:
Not that devour'd, but that which doth devour,
Is worthy blame. O, let it not be hild
Poor women's faults, that they are so fulfill'd
With men's abuses: those proud lords, to blame, Make weak-made women tenants to their shame.

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"weak-made" implies societal construction, suggesting that women are not inherently weak but
are made to be so by the prevailing patriarchal system.

Overall Meaning and Significance:

The stanza is a powerful condemnation of blaming victims of sexual assault and other forms of abuse. It argues that responsibility lies squarely with the perpetrators, not with the women who suffer. Shakespeare uses vivid metaphors of a "withered flower" and "rough winter" to represent the victim and abuser, respectively.

The stanza highlights the power imbalance between men and women, suggesting that men, through their actions and the societal structures they uphold, create a situation where women are vulnerable and then unfairly burdened with the shame of the abuse. The use of "fulfilled" is particularly cutting, emphasizing the tragic irony of a woman being "filled" not with joy or satisfaction, but with the weight of someone else's transgression.

In essence, Shakespeare is making a plea for justice and a call for a fundamental shift in societal attitudes towards women and sexual violence. The stanza argues for empathy, understanding, and a clear assignment of blame to those who perpetrate abuse, not to those who suffer from it.

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← Stanza 180📚 OverviewStanza 182 →

Stanza 181 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then look at its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"The precedent whereof in Lucrece view,"

Precedent: An earlier event or action that serves as an example or justification for subsequent events.

Whereof: Of which (referring to a situation of extreme moral conflict or danger).
In Lucrece view: To be seen, or considered in Lucrece's case.
Meaning: Consider Lucrece's situation as an example of this [moral dilemma/predicament]. "Assail'd by night with circumstances strong"
Assail'd: Attacked.
By night: Emphasizes the sneakiness, darkness, and treachery of the attack.
Circumstances strong: Overwhelming or powerful conditions/factors influencing the situation. Meaning: She was attacked in the night by powerful influencing factors.

"Of present death, and shame that might ensue"

Present death: Imminent death, the threat of dying at that very moment.
Shame that might ensue: The disgrace that could follow (if she resisted or was discovered, or even just as a consequence of the rape itself). Ensuing indicates consequence and future effect. Meaning: Those factors/circumstances being the threat of immediate death and the potential shame that would follow.

"By that her death, to do her husband wrong:"

By that her death: Through or because of her death
To do her husband wrong: To dishonor her husband
Meaning: Even her death would wrong her husband in some way - by association, or the shame it would bring to his house.

"Such danger to resistance did belong,"

Such danger to resistance did belong: Resistance would entail such grave consequences, such terrible risks. The word belong implies that great danger is a natural consequence of defiance. Meaning: Resisting the attack would be very dangerous.

"That dying fear through all her body spread;"

Dying fear: A fear so intense it feels like death itself.
Through all her body spread: This emphasizes the physical manifestation of her fear, making it tangible and visceral.
Meaning: An overwhelming fear, almost like death, consumed her entire body.

The precedent whereof in Lucrece view,
Assail'd by night with circumstances strong
Of present death, and shame that might ensue
By that her death, to do her husband wrong:
Such danger to resistance did belong,
That dying fear through all her body spread; And who cannot abuse a body dead?

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"And who cannot abuse a body dead?"

This is a rhetorical question, and it's a chilling one.
Who cannot abuse a body dead?: The implication is that anyone can, and that a dead body is completely vulnerable and without any recourse. Even if she died resisting, Tarquin could still further desecrate her corpse.
Meaning: Even if she were to die resisting, her body would still be vulnerable to further abuse and dishonor.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza presents the immense pressure and psychological torment Lucrece faced when she was attacked by Tarquin. It highlights the following points:

The No-Win Situation: Lucrece found herself in a situation where every choice was fraught with danger and potential dishonor. Whether she resisted, submitted, or died, shame and wrong would be done.
The Power of Fear: The stanza emphasizes the debilitating effect of fear. It was so intense that it permeated her entire being, hindering her ability to resist or think clearly.
Vulnerability and Powerlessness: The rhetorical question at the end is a stark reminder of Lucrece's utter vulnerability. Even in death, she would not be safe from further desecration. The stanza underscores the complete power imbalance between Lucrece and Tarquin.
The Context of Honor: The stanza is deeply concerned with honor—Lucrece's honor, her husband's honor, and the reputation of her family. The fear of shame is a powerful motivator in the poem.

Literary Devices:

Rhetorical Question: The final line, "And who cannot abuse a body dead?" is a rhetorical question. It is not meant to be answered but rather to emphasize the utter vulnerability of a dead body and to provoke a sense of outrage in the reader.
Imagery: The line "That dying fear through all her body spread" uses vivid imagery to convey the intensity of Lucrece's fear. The phrase "dying fear" is also an example of hyperbole, exaggeration for effect.
Alliteration: While not prominent, the phrase "present death" uses alliteration for emphasis. Juxtaposition: The stanza juxtaposes the idea of "present death" with the potential for future "shame," highlighting the dual threats Lucrece faced.
Historical Allusion: The stanza contributes to the overall narrative that's a part of Roman history/legend, setting up the backdrop against which Lucrece's tragedy unfolds.
Personification: "Such danger to resistance did belong" could be seen as a mild form of personification, as danger is given the ability to "belong" to something.

In essence, this stanza is a crucial moment in the poem because it reveals the terrifying circumstances Lucrece faces, making her subsequent rape and suicide more understandable and tragic. It sets the stage for the moral and political consequences that will follow.

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← Stanza 181📚 OverviewStanza 183 →

Stanza 182 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 182 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"By this, mild patience bid fair Lucrece speak"

"By this": This is a temporal marker, meaning "at this point in time" or "now." It indicates a shift
in the narrative.

"mild patience": Personification. Patience, an abstract quality, is given the agency to bid or command. "Mild" suggests Lucrece is exercising restraint despite her trauma.
"fair Lucrece speak": "Fair" is a common epithet for beautiful women in Shakespeare. "Speak" signals a turn in the poem. Lucrece, who has been silently suffering, finally decides to talk. Overall: After a period of silence and inner turmoil, Lucrece, fueled by a degree of controlled "patience", begins to speak. The poem's movement is towards speech, towards Lucrece's articulation of her trauma.

"To the poor counterfeit of her complaining:"

"To": This establishes the direction of Lucrece's speech. She is speaking to someone.
"poor counterfeit of her complaining": This is a tricky, but essential line. "Counterfeit" can mean "imitation" or "image." The "counterfeit of her complaining" is most likely the painting of the fall of Troy. It is a representation of suffering, a visual complaint that mirrors, but also falls short of, Lucrece's own agony. The painting is an image, a copy, not the real thing. "Poor" implies inadequacy, suggesting that the painting's depiction of woe can't compare to Lucrece's real experience.
Overall: Lucrece is addressing the painting (or more specifically, what the painting represents), recognizing it as a representation of suffering, but simultaneously belittling its ability to capture the full extent of human pain.

"'My girl,' quoth she, 'on what occasion break"

"'My girl,' quoth she": A direct quotation begins. "Quoth she" is an archaic way of saying "said she." "My girl" is an address, a term of endearment that may be slightly patronising.
"'on what occasion break": This begins the actual question Lucrece is asking. "Occasion" refers to the reason or cause.

Overall: Lucrece begins to question the painting, in a way addressing it as if it were a person.

"Those tears from thee, that down thy cheeks are raining?"

"Those tears from thee": She refers to the "tears" of the painting, or metaphorically, the sorrow it represents. "Thee" is the archaic second-person singular pronoun ("you").
"that down thy cheeks are raining": A vivid image! Hyperbole. The tears are not literally raining down the painting's cheeks (as a painting does not have actual cheeks), but the image creates a sense of overflowing grief. The word "raining" is a powerful verb emphasizing the abundance and relentlessness of sorrow.

Overall: Lucrece asks the painting (or the person depicted in it) why it is crying so profusely, intensifying the image of sorrow.

By this, mild patience bid fair Lucrece speak
To the poor counterfeit of her complaining:
'My girl,' quoth she, 'on what occasion break
Those tears from thee, that down thy cheeks are
raining?
If thou dost weep for grief of my sustaining, Know, gentle wench, it small avails my mood:
If tears could help, mine own would do me good.

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"If thou dost weep for grief of my sustaining,"

"If thou dost weep": A conditional clause. Lucrece proposes a hypothetical reason for the painting's (or subject's) tears.
"for grief of my sustaining": "Sustaining" means "suffering" or "enduring." Lucrece is saying, "If you are weeping because of the pain I am going through..."
Overall: Lucrece is suggesting that the painting's tears are sympathetic, that it weeps in response to her ordeal.

"Know, gentle wench, it small avails my mood:"

"Know, gentle wench": "Know" is an imperative verb (a command). "Gentle wench" is another address. "Wench" can sometimes have negative connotations, but here it seems to be a mild, perhaps slightly condescending, term of affection.
"it small avails my mood": This is the key statement. "Avails" means "helps" or "benefits." "My mood" refers to Lucrece's emotional state. The line essentially means "It doesn't really help me." Overall: Lucrece diminishes the value of the painting's (or the figure's) sympathy. She suggests that its sorrow is not effective in alleviating her own pain.

"If tears could help, mine own would do me good."

"If tears could help": Another conditional clause, building on the previous one.
"mine own would do me good": "Mine own" refers to Lucrece's own tears. She is implying that
if tears had any power, her own tears, which she has suppressed, would have already solved her problem.
Overall: Lucrece emphasizes the futility of tears. Her own suffering is so profound that even if
tears were capable of healing, hers would have already done the trick. Since she is still suffering, tears are clearly useless. This line reinforces her Stoic resignation.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

In this stanza, Lucrece, with great restraint, begins to address the painting of the fall of Troy. She questions the source of its lament, acknowledging that it may be weeping in sympathy for her plight. However, she asserts that the painting's sorrow, or the representation of grief in the painting, is ultimately useless to her. Lucrece argues that if tears held any curative power, her own immense suffering would have already been alleviated. This shows a degree of emotional detachment, a Stoic acceptance of her fate, and a recognition that her inner turmoil is too great to be resolved by mere expressions of sympathy or grief. The stanza underscores Lucrece's isolation in her suffering.

Literary Devices:

Personification: Giving patience the ability to bid Lucrece speak.
Hyperbole: Exaggerating the tears "raining" down the cheeks, emphasizing the magnitude of the grief.
Apostrophe: Addressing the painting (or its subject) as if it were a person.
Allusion: The painting is an allusion to the fall of Troy, a story rife with suffering, betrayal, and violence, mirroring Lucrece's own situation.
Irony: There's a layer of dramatic irony here, as the reader knows the true depth of Lucrece's suffering and the reason for it, whereas the painting remains a distant, inadequate reflection. Rhetorical Questions: Lucrece is more concerned with her own problem than the reason for the tears of the counterfeit.
Stoicism: This stanza is steeped in stoicism. Lucrece refuses to be comforted by the painting. Metaphor: Implied comparison between the tears of the counterfeit and the tears Lucrece could be crying.

This stanza is a powerful example of Shakespeare's ability to convey complex emotions through rich language and imagery. It reveals Lucrece's stoic nature, her profound isolation, and the inadequacy of mere representation in the face of true, devastating trauma.

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← Stanza 182📚 OverviewStanza 184 →

Stanza 183 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 183 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"But tell me, girl, when went”—and there she stayed"

Meaning: Lucrece is questioning her maid about when Tarquin left the house. The phrase "and there she stayed" indicates that Lucrece hesitates, pauses, or is interrupted in her question, likely overwhelmed by grief and shame, making it difficult for her to speak. It also creates suspense. Literary Devices: Ellipsis (represented by the dash) demonstrates a break in thought, conveying Lucrece's emotional state.

"Till after a deep groan—“Tarquin from hence?”

Meaning: Lucrece continues her question after a groan, indicating her pain and reluctance to even speak Tarquin's name or acknowledge his presence. "From hence" means "from here," referring to her house. The question itself is now more blunt.
Literary Devices: Interruption (Lucrece's groan); Euphemism ("from hence" avoids the direct mention of the scene of the crime)

"Madam, ere I was up,” replied the maid,"

Meaning: The maid responds, saying that Tarquin left before she was awake. This shows the maid was completely unaware of what occurred during the night.
Literary Devices: None particularly stand out in this line.

"The more to blame my sluggard negligence."

Meaning: The maid blames herself for not being awake earlier, considering it a sign of laziness and neglect of her duties. She feels guilty for not being alert.
Literary Devices: Alliteration ("sluggard negligence") to emphasize the maid's self-reproach.

"Yet with the fault I thus far can dispense:"

Meaning: The maid qualifies her self-reproach, meaning she thinks she can excuse herself to a certain extent.

Literary Devices: Formal diction ("dispense") creates a contrast with the emotional content of the poem.

"Myself was stirring ere the break of day,"

Meaning: The maid explains that she was actually awake and active (stirring) before sunrise. This is an attempt to mitigate her perceived fault.
Literary Devices: Imagery: "Stirring ere the break of day" creates a vivid picture of the maid's early activity.

"And, ere I rose, was Tarquin gone away."

Meaning: The maid confirms that Tarquin had already left before she even got out of bed. She implies she couldn't have prevented anything even if she had been up and about.

“But tell me, girl, when went”—and there she stayed
Till after a deep groan—“Tarquin from hence?”
“Madam, ere I was up,” replied the maid,
“The more to blame my sluggard negligence.
Yet with the fault I thus far can dispense:
Myself was stirring ere the break of day,
And, ere I rose, was Tarquin gone away.

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Literary Devices: Repetition: The phrases "ere I was up," "ere the break of day," and "ere I
rose" emphasizes the short time frame and reinforces the maid's point that she could not have been vigilant enough to catch Tarquin.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza depicts the aftermath of the rape. Lucrece, wracked with shame and grief, haltingly questions her maid about Tarquin's departure. The maid, completely ignorant of the crime, expresses guilt for not being awake earlier, but then defends herself by stating she was indeed up before sunrise, and Tarquin had already left. The stanza highlights the chasm between Lucrece's agonizing knowledge and the maid's innocent unawareness. It emphasizes Lucrece's isolation in her suffering and sets the stage for her subsequent actions. The maid's mundane concerns and focus on her own perceived negligence provide a stark contrast to the magnitude of the violation Lucrece has suffered, further emphasizing the tragedy. The stanza reinforces the idea that Tarquin was careful to conceal his actions, leaving no immediate indication of his crime to the outside world.

Key Literary Devices Highlighted:

Ellipsis: To show Lucrece's interrupted speech and emotional distress.
Interruption: Lucrece's groan further emphasizes her emotional struggle.
Euphemism: "From hence" to avoid direct mention of the scene of the crime.
Alliteration: "Sluggard negligence" for emphasis.
Formal diction ("dispense") creates a contrast with the emotional content.
Imagery: "Stirring ere the break of day" to create a vivid picture.
Repetition: "Ere" phrases to emphasize the short timeframe and maid's defense.
Dramatic Irony: The audience knows what happened, while the maid remains ignorant, adding to the tension and Lucrece's isolation.

In short, this stanza is a masterclass in Shakespearean character development and building tension through language, revealing the devastating consequences of Tarquin's actions and the profound isolation of Lucrece in her suffering.

← Stanza 182📚 OverviewStanza 184 →

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← Stanza 183📚 OverviewStanza 185 →

Stanza 184 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 184 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"But, lady, if your maid may be so bold,"

Analysis: The maid is speaking to Lucrece with deference, acknowledging the difference in social status. She begins with a polite, indirect request, asking for permission to be "bold" (which essentially means asking a personal question).
Literary Devices: Politeness, deference. Beginning with "But" signals a contrast or transition in
the scene.

"She would request to know your heaviness."

Analysis: "Heaviness" is a euphemism (indirect expression) for Lucrece's sadness, grief, or burden. The maid is tactfully trying to inquire about the reason for Lucrece's distress. The use of "would request" maintains the respectful tone.
Literary Devices: Euphemism (for sadness or sorrow), polite phrasing.

"O peace!" quoth Lucrece. "If it should be told,"

Analysis: Lucrece interrupts her maid. "O peace!" is an exclamation indicating that Lucrece wants silence or an end to the conversation topic. The beginning of the next phrase implies that Lucrece is hesitant or fearful of speaking about her experience.
Literary Devices: Interjection ("O peace!"), dramatic pause implied by the incomplete thought.

"The repetition cannot make it less;"

Analysis: This is the core of Lucrece's despair. She's saying that even if she were to recount the story of her rape, the act of telling it would not diminish the pain or the weight of the experience. The trauma remains unchanged, regardless of retelling.
Literary Devices: Paradox (repetition usually helps cope with trauma, but here, Lucrece states it has no effect), understatement (the act of telling cannot make the experience less, but it is clear the pain is immensely more).

"For more it is than I can well express,"

Analysis: This builds on the previous line. Lucrece emphasizes that the magnitude of her suffering is beyond her ability to put into words. The experience is so profound that language fails to capture its true extent.
Literary Devices: Hyperbole (to convey the overwhelming nature of the trauma), inadequacy of language.

"And that deep torture may be called a hell,"

Analysis: Lucrece escalates the description of her suffering, using the powerful metaphor of
"hell" to represent the internal torment she is enduring. This is not just sadness; it is a profound, excruciating agony.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (torture = hell), elevated language, powerful imagery.

“But, lady, if your maid may be so bold,
She would request to know your heaviness.”
“O peace!” quoth Lucrece. “If it should be told,
The repetition cannot make it less;
For more it is than I can well express,
And that deep torture may be called a hell, When more is felt than one hath power to tell.

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"When more is felt than one hath power to tell."

Analysis: This is a concluding statement summarizing Lucrece's predicament. It emphasizes the chasm between her internal experience and her capacity to articulate it. The pain is so immense that it exceeds the boundaries of language. This echoes the earlier point about repetition not diminishing the pain.
Literary Devices: Repetition of the inability to express the experience, emphasis on the overwhelming nature of trauma.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza captures the devastating impact of the rape on Lucrece's psyche. She is overwhelmed by the experience and feels utterly trapped. The maid's gentle inquiry only highlights the vast gulf between Lucrece's outward appearance and the internal turmoil she's battling. Lucrece emphasizes the unspeakable nature of her trauma, suggesting that language is inadequate to convey the depth of her suffering. She feels the weight of her experience so intensely that it is likened to a personal hell, one where the pain is so profound that it cannot be expressed. This feeling of being trapped, both by the event itself and by the inability to adequately express it, contributes to her ultimate decision to take her own life. The stanza builds a powerful sense of Lucrece's inner anguish and foreshadows her tragic fate.

Key Literary Devices Summary:

Euphemism: "Heaviness" for sadness/grief.
Interjection: "O peace!" for dramatic effect.
Paradox: The repetition cannot make the experience less.
Hyperbole: To emphasize the overwhelming nature of the trauma.
Metaphor: "Deep torture may be called a hell."
Understatement: Repetition cannot make it less.
Inadequacy of Language: The repeated emphasis on the inability to express the trauma. Politeness/Deference: Shown through the maid's careful wording.
Powerful Imagery: "Deep torture," "hell."
Repetition: The inability to express the experience.
Dramatic Irony: The audience knows what happened, while the maid does not. This heightens the tension and Lucrece's isolation.

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← Stanza 184📚 OverviewStanza 186 →

Stanza 185 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 185 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Go, get me hither paper, ink, and pen."

Meaning: Lucrece, in her distress after being raped by Tarquin, initially commands a servant to fetch writing materials. "Hither" is an archaic word meaning "here."
Literary Devices: Imperative mood (a command) emphasizes her agitation and decisiveness.

"Yet save that labour, for I have them here."

Meaning: She immediately countermands the order, realizing that the writing materials are already at hand.
Literary Devices: Apostrophe: she is speaking to the unmentioned servant Irony: It highlights the immediacy of her situation. She's so distraught that she momentarily forgets the basic necessities already around her.

"What should I say?—One of my husband’s men"

Meaning: She pauses, lost in thought and struggling to formulate the message she wants to convey. She is considering sending one of her husband's servants
Literary Devices: Rhetorical Question: "What should I say?" shows her internal turmoil and the difficulty of choosing the right words to describe the unspeakable.

"Bid thou be ready by and by to bear"

Meaning: She instructs the servant to tell one of her husband's men to be ready very soon (by and by) to carry something.
Literary Devices: archaic diction ("Bid thou")

"A letter to my lord, my love, my dear."

Meaning: The 'something' that is to be carried is revealed to be a letter to her husband, Collatine. Note the progression of endearments: "lord" (respect), "love" (affection), "dear" (deep emotional connection).
Literary Devices: Epiphet: "my lord, my love, my dear." It reflects the depth of her affection for him, which contrasts starkly with Tarquin's violation.

"Bid him with speed prepare to carry it;"

Meaning: She repeats the instruction that the servant must be ready to depart quickly.
Literary Devices: Repetition: "Bid him" further emphasizes the need for urgency.

"The cause craves haste, and it will soon be writ."

Meaning: The gravity of the situation demands immediate action, and the letter will be composed quickly.
Literary Devices: Understatement: The "cause" is not just some minor matter, but her rape. The need for "haste" underscores the urgency of seeking retribution.

“Go, get me hither paper, ink, and pen.
Yet save that labour, for I have them here.
What should I say?—One of my husband’s men
Bid thou be ready by and by to bear
A letter to my lord, my love, my dear.
Bid him with speed prepare to carry it;
The cause craves haste, and it will soon be writ.”

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Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza portrays Lucrece's immediate response to the trauma of her rape. She is determined to inform her husband and seek justice. The stanza reveals:

Her decisive action: She wastes no time in formulating a plan. She immediately thinks of contacting her husband.
Her internal turmoil: Despite her decisiveness, the rhetorical question reveals her struggle to articulate the horror of what has happened.
Her love for her husband: The endearments she uses to refer to Collatine highlight the depth of her connection to him, making Tarquin's act all the more heinous.
The urgency of the situation: The repetition of "bid" and the emphasis on "haste" underscore the need for immediate action. She understands the gravity of her situation and is intent on addressing it swiftly.

The stanza effectively conveys Lucrece's emotional state—a mix of grief, determination, and a burning desire for justice. Shakespeare uses language and literary devices to create a vivid picture of a woman grappling with the aftermath of a horrific crime.

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← Stanza 185📚 OverviewStanza 187 →

Stanza 186 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 186 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify literary devices, and then discuss the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Her maid is gone, and she prepares to write,"

Meaning: The maid has left Lucrece alone. Lucrece is now getting ready to write something down, presumably to record the events of the night. This signifies her intention to take action, to
document and potentially seek redress for the wrong done to her.
Literary Device: Sets the scene and creates a sense of isolation for Lucrece.

"First hovering o’er the paper with her quill."

Meaning: Before she actually puts pen to paper, she hesitates, hovering the quill above the surface. This suggests internal conflict, uncertainty, and the weight of what she is about to do. Literary Device: Imagery - the visual of the quill hovering creates tension and suspense. Alliteration - "hovering" and "her"

"Conceit and grief an eager combat fight;"

Meaning: Two opposing forces - her reason/thought (Conceit - idea, thought) and her emotional pain (grief) - are battling within her. "Eager combat" emphasizes the intensity of this internal struggle.
Literary Device: Personification - Conceit and grief are given human qualities of combatants. Metaphor - The internal conflict is presented as a physical fight.

"What wit sets down is blotted straight with will;"

Meaning: Anything that her intellect (wit) manages to write is immediately crossed out or erased because of her strong emotions (will, in this case meaning passionate desire, impulse or determination arising from extreme grief). This underscores the dominance of emotion over reason in her current state.
Literary Device: Contrast - wit vs. will. Alliteration - "wit", "with"

"This is too curious-good, this blunt and ill."

Meaning: She is judging her own writing, finding it either overly clever ("curious-good") or too plain and inadequate ("blunt and ill"). She is not satisfied with any way she is trying to articulate her experience.
Literary Device: Antithesis - "curious-good" contrasts with "blunt and ill". Asyndeton - the lack of conjunctions creates a sense of hurried thought.

"Much like a press of people at a door,"

Meaning: This introduces a simile to describe the chaos of her thoughts. "Press of people at a door" evokes an image of a crowd struggling to get through an entrance all at once.
Literary Device: Simile - "Much like" indicates a comparison. Imagery - vivid image of a crowd pushing and shoving.

Her maid is gone, and she prepares to write,
First hovering o’er the paper with her quill.
Conceit and grief an eager combat fight;
What wit sets down is blotted straight with will;
This is too curious-good, this blunt and ill. Much like a press of people at a door,
Throng her inventions, which shall go before.

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"Throng her inventions, which shall go before."

Meaning: Her "inventions" (thoughts, ideas, ways of phrasing her experience) are crowding and pushing each other, struggling to be the one that comes out first – to be the way she expresses what has happened. "Go before" alludes to the challenge of deciding what to write first.
Literary Device: Metaphor - "inventions" are personified as being able to "throng".

Overall Meaning:

This stanza depicts the tumultuous and confused mental state of Lucrece as she attempts to write about the rape. The overwhelming trauma she experienced has thrown her into a state of internal conflict where reason and emotion clash violently. She is unable to articulate her experience clearly or effectively because her thoughts are jumbled, contradictory, and constantly being overridden by her grief. The image of the crowd at the door powerfully conveys the feeling of being overwhelmed by too many conflicting ideas, none of which feel adequate to express the enormity of her situation. It highlights her paralysis and the struggle to find the right words or approach to deal with the violation.

In essence, the stanza shows the difficulty of translating intense trauma into language. Lucrece is struggling not just with what to say, but how to say it, and the act of writing becomes another form of torment in itself.

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Stanza 187 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, and then discuss its overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: “At last she thus begins: “Thou worthy lord"

Meaning: After some delay (implying she's been struggling with how to word her letter), Lucrece begins to speak to her husband, Collatine, with a formal address.
Literary Devices: Setting the Scene. This line prepares the reader for the content of the letter, emphasizing the gravity of Lucrece's message.

Line 2: "Of that unworthy wife that greeteth thee,"

Meaning: She immediately undermines herself. She calls herself unworthy, acknowledging a perceived disparity between her (now defiled) state and her husband's worthiness. She is
greeting him in the sense of sending a message.
Literary Devices: Self-Deprecation. This is a key element, showing Lucrece's internalized shame and guilt after being raped. This phrase highlights how the crime has changed her perception of herself. Irony: Lucrece is arguably more worthy than ever because of her moral fortitude and determination to seek justice, yet she feels unworthy.

Line 3: "Health to thy person! Next vouchsafe t’ afford,"

Meaning: She offers him a customary greeting of health. Then she beseeches him. The word 'vouchsafe' shows her deference to him.

Literary Devices: Formal Tone. This continues the formal, almost stilted, language, emphasizing the seriousness of the situation and the distance between them. Alliteration: The repetition of the 't' sound in "to thy" and "t'afford" adds a subtle emphasis.

Line 4: "If ever, love, thy Lucrece thou wilt see,"

Meaning: This is the heart of the plea. She suggests that whether he will ever see her again depends on what happens next. The word "love" is placed poignantly in the centre of the line, emphasizing the loss of intimacy due to Tarquin's actions.
Literary Devices: Conditional Clause. The "if ever" clause adds a sense of urgency and foreboding. Ambiguity. This line hints at Lucrece's suicidal ideation without being explicit.

Line 5: "Some present speed to come and visit me."

Meaning: She urges him to come to her immediately and in haste. The word 'present' signifies a need for urgent action.
Literary Devices: Urgency. The phrase "present speed" underscores the immediate nature of
the crisis. Imperative Mood. The command "come and visit me" conveys a sense of desperation.

Line 6: "So I commend me from our house in grief."

Meaning: She entrusts herself to him (commends) and indicates that she's writing from their home, which is now a place of grief.

At last she thus begins: “Thou worthy lord
Of that unworthy wife that greeteth thee,
Health to thy person! Next vouchsafe t’ afford,
If ever, love, thy Lucrece thou wilt see,
Some present speed to come and visit me.
So I commend me from our house in grief.
My woes are tedious, though my words are brief.”

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Literary Devices: Euphemism. "I commend me" is a polite way of saying "I leave you" or "I entrust myself." Pathetic Fallacy: The house is now a place of grief because of what has happened to her.

Line 7: "My woes are tedious, though my words are brief.”

Meaning: She states that her sorrows are long-lasting and wearisome, but her written message
is concise.
Literary Devices: Paradox. The contradiction between the length of her woes and the brevity of
her words emphasizes the difficulty she has in articulating the depth of her suffering. Metaphor:
"My woes are tedious" is a metaphor that compares her sorrows to something drawn out and boring.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza encapsulates Lucrece's agonizing attempt to communicate the horror of her rape to her husband, Collatine. She is deeply ashamed and feels unworthy of him. Her letter is marked by formal language, self-deprecation, and a desperate plea for his immediate presence. She implies that her life, or at least their relationship, hangs in the balance. She wants him to know that something terrible has happened that affects them both, and it's something that must be dealt with swiftly. The stark contrast between the briefness of her words and the overwhelming nature of her suffering highlights the trauma she has endured and the difficulty she faces in articulating it. The stanza foreshadows the tragic consequences that will follow, including her suicide and the subsequent rebellion against the Tarquins. The use of conditional language creates a sense of foreboding, and the overall tone is one of desperation and despair.

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Stanza 188 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 188 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Here folds she up the tenor of her woe,"
Breakdown: "Here" indicates location, which in this case is a letter Lucrece has written to
Collatine. "Folds she up" means she is folding something (the letter). "Tenor of her woe" refers to the main point, the substance, or the underlying meaning of her suffering. So, Lucrece is folding
up the letter that contains the essence of her sorrow.
Meaning: She finishes writing the letter conveying the core of her grief.

"Her certain sorrow writ uncertainly."
Breakdown: "Certain sorrow" means that her sorrow is real and definite. "Writ uncertainly" suggests that although the sorrow is very real, the letter expresses it in a veiled, ambiguous, or unclear manner. This can happen due to a mix of her shame and fear of what Collatine will do. Meaning: Her true sorrow is real, but her letter doesn't express it directly. It is written in a way that keeps some secrets hidden and only gives hints about the extent of the grief.

"By this short schedule Collatine may know"
Breakdown: "Short schedule" implies the letter is brief, or that the amount of detail provided is minimal. "Collatine may know" suggests that the letter will give Collatine some information. Meaning: From this brief message, Collatine will be able to get a basic idea of the situation.

"Her grief, but not her grief’s true quality;"
Breakdown: "Grief" refers to her suffering. "Grief's true quality" suggests the intensity, depth, or nature of her grief. She cannot express the full horror of what she has experienced.
Meaning: He will know she is suffering, but he won't grasp the full extent or the horrific nature of what happened to her.

"She dares not thereof make discovery,"
Breakdown: "She dares not" emphasizes her fear. "Thereof make discovery" means she doesn't dare to fully reveal or disclose everything.
Meaning: She does not dare to tell him everything that happened.

"Lest he should hold it her own gross abuse,"
Breakdown: "Lest" means "for fear that." "Hold it her own gross abuse" means that she fears that Collatine will blame her for what happened, believing that she somehow provoked or consented
to the rape. "Gross abuse" emphasizes the severity of the perceived blame.
Meaning: She's afraid that Collatine will accuse her of having been complicit or responsible for
the act.

"Ere she with blood had stained her stained excuse."
Breakdown: "Ere" means "before." "With blood had stained her stained excuse" This is a complex line. "Stained excuse" refers to her reason for telling him, or her explanation (the letter itself).
Her "excuse" is already stained, by the rape, and the shame of it. "With blood" refers to her anticipated suicide. So, she needs to kill herself (shed blood) to prove her innocence, and that
her "excuse" is real.

Here folds she up the tenor of her woe,
Her certain sorrow writ uncertainly.
By this short schedule Collatine may know
Her grief, but not her grief’s true quality;
She dares not thereof make discovery,
Lest he should hold it her own gross abuse,
Ere she with blood had stained her stained excuse.

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Meaning: Before she can prove her innocence, through suicide, he will accuse her. Her only way
of proving that she didn't consent is by killing herself; she feels she must commit suicide to prove that the stain (of the rape) was not of her making.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece finishes writing a letter to her husband, Collatine, to inform him of the rape. She folds the letter containing her grief. She writes of the event in a way that is unclear. Though her sorrow is real, she cannot bring herself to describe the true horror of the rape for fear that Collatine will blame her, believing that she provoked or consented to the act. She fears that, if she doesn't kill herself to prove her innocence, he will always believe her responsible. She must stain her already stained excuse, meaning her explanation for the rape, with her own blood through suicide, to prove that she was a victim and not culpable.

Literary Devices:

Irony: There is a strong element of situational irony. Lucrece, the victim of a violent crime, feels compelled to prove her innocence through suicide. The societal standards of the time place the burden of proof on the victim, not the perpetrator.
Metaphor: "The tenor of her woe" is a metaphor for the core meaning of her suffering. "Stained excuse" is a metaphor for her sullied reputation and the justification she must provide. Euphemism: The language used is often euphemistic, as Shakespeare avoids directly stating the act of rape and instead uses indirect references to grief and stains.
Alliteration: The repetition of consonant sounds adds emphasis. For example, "certain sorrow," which highlights the real nature of her grief.
Paradox: "Her certain sorrow writ uncertainly" is a paradox, highlighting the contradiction between the reality of her suffering and the way she's forced to express it.
Foreshadowing: The line "Ere she with blood had stained her stained excuse" foreshadows her eventual suicide.

This stanza is powerful because it captures the complex emotions of a rape victim in a society where women were often held responsible for their own victimization. It is a dark and poignant reflection on the themes of honor, shame, and the devastating consequences of sexual violence.

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Stanza 189 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 189 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Besides, the life and feeling of her passion": This line sets the stage. It introduces the fact that Lucrece is actively suppressing the intensity of her emotional distress. "Life and feeling of her passion" refers to the depth and vitality of her suffering.

"She hoards, to spend when he is by to hear her;": Lucrece is not letting her emotions flow freely. Instead, she hoards them, saving them up like a miser saves money. She intends to spend them – express them fully – when he is by to hear her. "He" refers to her husband, Collatine. This hints at her concern with public perception and the importance of her husband witnessing her suffering.

"When sighs and groans and tears may grace the fashion": This is a crucial line. It suggests a calculated element to Lucrece's grief. She envisions a scene where her sighs, groans, and tears will grace the fashion of her disgrace. This means she wants to present her suffering in a way that is both emotionally powerful (the sighs, groans, tears) and socially acceptable ("grace the fashion"). The word "fashion" here implies a carefully constructed presentation, almost a performance.

"Of her disgrace, the better so to clear her": The purpose of this performance is to clear her from the disgrace. Lucrece understands that she will be seen as dishonored by the rape, but she hopes that by presenting her suffering in a particular way, she can mitigate the damage to her reputation. The "better so to clear her" suggests she believes a demonstrative display of grief will be more effective in proving her innocence and unwillingness.

"From that suspicion which the world might bear her.": Lucrece fears that the world will suspect her of consenting to the rape, or at least of not resisting strongly enough. She is intensely aware of the societal stigma attached to sexual assault and the possibility that she will be blamed or ostracized. This line highlights the vulnerability and powerlessness of women in that era.

"To shun this blot, she would not blot the letter": This line uses a clever wordplay on the word "blot." Lucrece wants to avoid the "blot" of suspicion and dishonor on her reputation. She is careful not to "blot the letter" – meaning she does not want to write down her thoughts in a rash or unconsidered way. The "letter" could refer to the story of her shame, or perhaps a literal letter she might write.

"With words, till action might become them better.": She will not use words hastily. She
wants her actions to speak louder than words. She will wait for the right moment and context so that her actions can convey the full extent of her grief, outrage, and innocence. This line emphasizes the importance of outward behavior as a way to communicate and reclaim her honor. "Action might become them better," implies that her actions will provide context and credence to the meaning behind her words, making them even more impactful.

Overall Meaning:

Besides, the life and feeling of her passion
She hoards, to spend when he is by to hear her;
When sighs and groans and tears may grace the fashion
Of her disgrace, the better so to clear her
From that suspicion which the world might bear her. To shun this blot, she would not blot the letter
With words, till action might become them better.

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The stanza reveals Lucrece's calculated approach to dealing with the aftermath of the rape. She is acutely aware of the societal implications and the potential damage to her reputation. She understands that her words and actions will be scrutinized. Therefore, she carefully plans how to express her grief, aiming to convince her husband and the world of her innocence and to regain control over her narrative. This stanza demonstrates the immense pressure placed upon Lucrece to manage her image and to navigate a patriarchal society that holds her responsible for the actions of her attacker. She's not simply grieving; she's strategically managing her grief as a form of self-preservation.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: "She hoards, to spend" is a metaphor. Lucrece's emotions are compared to something valuable that can be saved and used later.
Irony: There's a hint of situational irony. Lucrece, the virtuous woman, is forced to consider how to "grace the fashion" of her disgrace. Her integrity is challenged, ironically, by the very act that violated her.
Wordplay/Pun: The use of "blot" in "To shun this blot, she would not blot the letter" is an example of wordplay. The double meaning of the word ("stain" and "mark") adds depth to the line. Alliteration: "Bear her" in "From that suspicion which the world might bear her" is alliterative, which adds a subtle emphasis to the line.
Imagery: "Sighs and groans and tears" evokes vivid imagery of Lucrece's suffering. Foreshadowing: The emphasis on action in the final line may subtly foreshadow her eventual suicide. She believes that only a dramatic action can truly "clear" her name.
Personification: "Action might become them better." Action is given human attributes by "becoming" something.

In essence, this stanza offers a complex and nuanced portrait of Lucrece, a woman caught in a web of societal expectations and personal trauma. It shows her not only as a victim but also as a strategist trying to navigate a deeply unfair situation.

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Stanza 190 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 190 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"To see sad sights moves more than hear them told,"

Meaning: Experiencing something sad firsthand (seeing it) has a stronger emotional impact than simply hearing about it from someone else.
Literary Devices: Direct Statement, Juxtaposition (seeing vs. hearing).

"For then the eye interprets to the ear"

Meaning: When we see something sorrowful, our eyes communicate (interpret) the intensity of the experience to our ears, enhancing our understanding and feeling. The eyes act as a translator for the ears.
Literary Devices: Personification (eye interprets), Metaphor (eyes as interpreter/translator).

"The heavy motion that it doth behold,"

Meaning: The eyes perceive the weighty, sorrowful action or movement of the scene. "Heavy motion" implies both physical actions and the emotional weight behind them.
Literary Devices: Imagery (heavy motion).

"When every part a part of woe doth bear."

Meaning: When in sorrowful events, every detail, every element, contributes to and reflects the overall feeling of grief. Each individual aspect carries its own share of the sorrow.
Literary Devices: Repetition ("part a part"), Alliteration ("part").

"'Tis but a part of sorrow that we hear."

Meaning: When we only hear about sorrow, we only receive a fraction of the full emotional impact. Hearing is an incomplete experience compared to seeing.
Literary Devices: Direct Statement, contrast with the beginning of the stanza

"Deep sounds make lesser noise than shallow fords,"

Meaning: Profound, deeply felt sorrow is often quieter and less outwardly expressive than superficial or shallow grief. A "shallow ford" (a shallow place to cross a river) makes more noise (splashing) than the depths of the river.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (comparing deep sorrow to deep sounds and shallow grief to shallow fords), Paradox (deep sounds make lesser noise).

"And sorrow ebbs, being blown with wind of words."

Meaning: Sorrow diminishes or fades away when it is merely talked about ("blown with wind of words"). Excessive talking about sorrow can dilute its power. The "wind of words" can dissipate the strength of the grief.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (sorrow as something that ebbs like the tide), Personification (sorrow being blown), Alliteration ("wind of words").

To see sad sights moves more than hear them told,
For then the eye interprets to the ear
The heavy motion that it doth behold,
When every part a part of woe doth bear.
’Tis but a part of sorrow that we hear.
Deep sounds make lesser noise than shallow fords, And sorrow ebbs, being blown with wind of words.

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Overall Meaning:

The stanza explores the profound difference between witnessing sorrow firsthand and merely hearing about it. Sight offers a more complete and intense understanding of suffering because the eye conveys the emotional weight of the experience more effectively to the mind. Conversely, simply hearing about sorrow provides only a partial understanding and its impact can be lessened by excessive or empty talk. Deep, true sorrow is often expressed quietly, while shallow grief may be more outwardly demonstrative. By comparing sorrow to sounds and water, Shakespeare uses imagery to underscore the depth and intensity of experienced pain versus the superficiality of mere reports. Ultimately, the stanza suggests the limitations of language in fully conveying the complexities of human suffering and the power of visual experience.

Summary of Literary Devices:

Metaphor: Used extensively to compare sorrow to sounds, water, and the act of interpreting. Personification: The eye is given the human ability to interpret.
Imagery: "Heavy motion," "deep sounds," "shallow fords," "wind of words" create vivid pictures in the reader's mind.
Repetition: "Part a part" emphasizes the role of each element in contributing to the overall sorrow. Alliteration: "Wind of words" creates a subtle musicality.
Juxtaposition: The stanza uses seeing and hearing to contrast how we perceive and process
sorrow.

Paradox: "Deep sounds make lesser noise" highlights the counterintuitive nature of grief.

This stanza provides a crucial insight into the psychological impact of the events unfolding in the poem, and the importance of visual and emotional understanding in experiencing sorrow.

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Stanza 191 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 191 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line, identifying literary devices and then providing an overall interpretation.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "Her letter now is sealed, and on it writ"

Meaning: Lucrece has finished writing her letter to her husband, Collatine, and has sealed it. It's ready to be sent.
Literary Devices: Simple, direct statement. Sets the scene and initiates the action. The passive voice ("is sealed," "on it writ") emphasizes Lucrece's lack of control, even in initiating this action.

Line 2: "“At Ardea to my lord with more than haste.”"

Meaning: This is the address written on the letter. Ardea is where Collatine is stationed with the Roman army. The phrase "with more than haste" indicates extreme urgency.
Literary Devices: Direct speech (within the poem) adds immediacy. The hyperbole of "more than haste" underscores the frantic nature of Lucrece's plea.

Line 3: "The post attends, and she delivers it,"

Meaning: The messenger is ready, and Lucrece hands him the letter.
Literary Devices: Straightforward action; the "post attends" uses personification.

Line 4: "Charging the sour-faced groom to hie as fast"

Meaning: Lucrece commands the gloomy-looking servant (the groom, referring to a servant, often associated with horses) to hurry ("hie") as quickly as possible.
Literary Devices: Characterization - "sour-faced groom" gives us a quick visual and hints at the emotional atmosphere. The use of "hie" is slightly archaic, lending a formal, almost biblical tone, even in a moment of urgency.

Line 5: "As lagging fowls before the northern blast."

Meaning: She tells him to go as fast as birds fleeing a strong, freezing north wind. The birds are "lagging" indicating the wind is already impacting their progress.
Literary Devices: Simile. The comparison to fleeing birds vividly illustrates the speed and desperation Lucrece wants the messenger to achieve. The "northern blast" is a powerful image of force and threat, mirrored by Lucrece's situation.

Line 6: "Speed more than speed but dull and slow she deems;"

Meaning: Even the fastest possible speed seems insufficient to her. She perceives even
incredible speed as "dull and slow."
Literary Devices: Paradox and exaggeration. "Speed more than speed" is logically impossible, highlighting the intensity of Lucrece's anxiety. The subjective nature of time and speed is emphasized; her fear distorts her perception.

Her letter now is sealed, and on it writ
“At Ardea to my lord with more than haste.”
The post attends, and she delivers it,
Charging the sour-faced groom to hie as fast
As lagging fowls before the northern blast.
Speed more than speed but dull and slow she deems; Extremely still urgeth such extremes.

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Line 7: "Extremely still urgeth such extremes."

Meaning: Despite the impossibility of exceeding speed, she relentlessly urges him to go faster. The word "extremely still" contrasts and emphasizes the impossible request she's making.
Literary Devices: Paradox again - "Extremely still urgeth" sounds self-contradictory. It
highlights Lucrece's inner turmoil. She is urging the groom while at the same time the circumstances are not changing.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza focuses on Lucrece's desperate attempt to communicate her plight to her husband and her frantic impatience. She has written the letter and is now utterly consumed by the need to get it to Collatine with the utmost speed. Her urgency is so extreme that even the fastest possible conveyance seems inadequate. The language is filled with exaggerations, similes, and even paradoxes to emphasize Lucrece's state of panic and the distorted perception of time that arises from her fear. The stanza illustrates the power of the rape in distorting Lucrece's mind and the complete collapse of her agency. Despite the urgency, she is still "extremely still" and unable to move forward from what has occurred. The impossibility of her request mirrors the impossibility of undoing the violation she has suffered. The urgency underscores the dire situation and foreshadows the tragic outcome.

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← Stanza 191📚 OverviewStanza 193 →

Stanza 192 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 192 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line and then provide an overall interpretation.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"The homely villain curtsies to her low,"

"The homely villain": This refers to Tarquin. "Homely" here doesn't necessarily mean
unattractive in a conventional sense. It can also mean "plain" or "ordinary-looking," underscoring the idea that evil can hide behind a commonplace exterior. He's not some monstrous figure; he could be anyone.
"curtsies to her low": The verb "curtsies" is odd, as it is more commonly associated with women. This suggests Tarquin is being overly submissive, perhaps trying to appear innocent or to disarm Lucrece with false respect. The word "low" emphasizes the depth of his deference, suggesting insincerity.

"And, blushing on her with a steadfast eye,"

"blushing on her": This is a crucial and ambiguous detail. Is Tarquin blushing because he feels shame, or is he using the blush strategically to mislead Lucrece? It highlights the complexity of his character and the deceptive nature of his actions.
"with a steadfast eye": This detail is also significant. A "steadfast eye" suggests confidence and resolve, a determined gaze. It could contradict the blush, suggesting his shame is a facade. It also suggests a kind of predatory focus.

"Receives the scroll without or yea or no,"

"Receives the scroll": Lucrece has given Tarquin a note of some sort, presumably indicating something or granting him permission for something relatively innocuous. This scroll will be the means by which he enters Lucrece's chamber later.
"without or yea or no": He takes the scroll silently, without speaking "yes" or "no." This silence is pregnant with meaning. It shows his intent to deceive; he offers no indication of his true plans. He is not truthful in his communication with her.

"And forth with bashful innocence doth hie."

"forth with bashful innocence doth hie": He quickly leaves, seemingly acting with "bashful innocence." This is a deliberate performance on his part. "Hie" means to hasten or hurry. He wants to leave quickly to continue his planned assault.
Personification: "Innocence doth hie" is a personification, giving the abstract concept of innocence the ability to move.

"But they whose guilt within their bosoms lie"

"they whose guilt within their bosoms lie": This is a general statement about the nature of guilt, but it also applies specifically to Tarquin.
Metaphor: "guilt within their bosoms lie" is a metaphor, comparing guilt to something buried or hidden inside one's chest.

The homely villain curtsies to her low,
And, blushing on her with a steadfast eye,
Receives the scroll without or yea or no,
And forth with bashful innocence doth hie.
But they whose guilt within their bosoms lie Imagine every eye beholds their blame,
For Lucrece thought he blushed to see her shame,

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"Imagine every eye beholds their blame,"

"Imagine every eye beholds their blame": A key insight into the psychology of the guilty. They become paranoid, believing everyone sees their wrongdoing, even if it's carefully concealed. This reflects Tarquin's possible discomfort, which Lucrece misinterprets.

"For Lucrece thought he blushed to see her shame,"

"For Lucrece thought he blushed to see her shame": Lucrece misinterprets Tarquin's blush. She believes he is ashamed on her behalf, perhaps because she thinks she has somehow
offended him or caused him discomfort with the note. She projects her own sense of honor and social obligation onto him. This misinterpretation is critical to Tarquin's success.

Overall Meaning and Literary Devices:

This stanza explores the themes of deception, guilt, and misinterpretation. Tarquin is portrayed as a master manipulator, capable of disguising his true intentions behind a facade of humility and even apparent shame. The stanza highlights the power of appearance versus reality. Tarquin's actions are a calculated performance designed to lower Lucrece's guard.

Lucrece's fatal flaw, at least in this moment, is her inability to recognize Tarquin's true nature. She projects her own sense of honor and decency onto him, leading her to misinterpret his behavior. The stanza emphasizes how easily the innocent can be deceived by the guilty.

Key Literary Devices:

Irony: There's dramatic irony, as the reader knows Tarquin's true intent, while Lucrece remains ignorant. The "bashful innocence" is also ironic, given his planned crime.
Ambiguity: The meaning of Tarquin's blush is deliberately ambiguous, adding to the tension and highlighting the difficulty of discerning truth from falsehood.
Psychological Insight: The stanza provides insight into the psychology of both the guilty (Tarquin) and the innocent (Lucrece).
Foreshadowing: The stanza foreshadows the coming tragedy by emphasizing Tarquin's deceptive nature and Lucrece's vulnerability.
Personification: "Innocence doth hie" is an example of personification.
Metaphor: "Guilt within their bosoms lie"

In short, this stanza masterfully sets the stage for the unfolding tragedy by revealing Tarquin's deceptive cunning and Lucrece's tragic misjudgment. It is a powerful exploration of the human capacity for both evil and innocence.

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← Stanza 192📚 OverviewStanza 194 →

Stanza 193 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 193 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then look at the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"When, silly groom! God wot, it was defect"

"When...": This sets up a contrast or realization that the speaker is about to make.
"silly groom!": "Silly" means foolish or innocent. "Groom" here is a general term for a man or young man, but in this context, it could be referring back to Collatine, Lucrece's husband, or
more broadly, any man who trusts too easily. The speaker is scolding a naive or foolish man. "God wot": An archaic phrase meaning "God knows" or "God understands." It adds a tone of certainty and perhaps a bit of rueful regret.
"it was defect": The main point here is that the foolishness stemmed from a flaw.
In this line, we see an apostrophe with the phrase "silly groom!" and some archaic language in the phrase "God wot."

"Of spirit, life, and bold audacity."

This line specifies what that "defect" consists of: a lack of spirit (courage, energy), life (vitality, awareness of danger), and bold audacity (shameless daring). In essence, a lack of the very qualities that Tarquin does possess and that allow him to commit the crime.
Here, we see an example of triadic structure, in the use of 'spirit, life, and bold audacity'. It is a list of three, which is a common feature in literature.

"Such harmless creatures have a true respect"

"Such harmless creatures": Refers back to the "silly groom" and men who lack the boldness to suspect evil.
"have a true respect": They value honor and keeping their word. They believe in honest dealings.

"To talk in deeds, while others saucily"

"To talk in deeds": Their actions speak louder than words. They are men of integrity who do what they say.
"while others saucily": In contrast, other men (like Tarquin) act "saucily," meaning impudently, presumptuously, or with arrogance.

"Promise more speed, but do it leisurely."

"Promise more speed": These deceitful men are quick to make promises but slow to deliver on them. Their words are empty.
"but do it leisurely": The implication is that they don't intend to keep their promises at all; they drag their feet or never follow through. This highlights their insincerity and hypocrisy.

"Even so this pattern of the worn-out age"

"Even so": Meaning "in the same way" or "similarly".

When, silly groom! God wot, it was defect
Of spirit, life, and bold audacity.
Such harmless creatures have a true respect
To talk in deeds, while others saucily
Promise more speed, but do it leisurely.
Even so this pattern of the worn-out age
Pawned honest looks, but laid no words to gage.

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"this pattern of the worn-out age": "Pattern" suggests a recurring type of person or behavior. "Worn-out age" refers to a corrupt or degenerate time. This phrase connects Tarquin's actions to a broader societal problem of moral decay.

"Pawned honest looks, but laid no words to gage."

"Pawned honest looks": He presented a façade of honesty and trustworthiness ("honest looks" as collateral). This is deceptive; he only seemed virtuous.
"but laid no words to gage": He didn't back up his appearance with a solid commitment to his
word. To "lay...to gage" means to put something of value down as a pledge or guarantee. Tarquin didn't put his words to the test of sincerity. His word means nothing.
This line uses a metaphor comparing Tarquin's deception to a financial transaction.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza contrasts the naive honesty of well-meaning men with the deceptive nature of men like Tarquin. The speaker laments the "silly groom" who is too trusting and lacks the "spirit, life, and bold audacity" to suspect or prevent evil. Men of integrity "talk in deeds," meaning their actions match their words. However, the stanza argues that the current age is corrupt, filled with men like Tarquin who "pawned honest looks" – they present a false appearance of virtue but lack genuine commitment to their word. Tarquin is presented as a representative of a decadent society where appearances are valued over genuine morality and honour. This stanza sets the stage for understanding how Tarquin's deceitful facade enabled him to commit his heinous act.

Literary Devices Summary:

Apostrophe: "silly groom!"
Archaic Language: "God wot"
Triadic Structure: "spirit, life, and bold audacity"
Metaphor: "Pawned honest looks, but laid no words to gage"

The stanza is rich in imagery and rhetorical devices, all contributing to its overall message about the contrast between genuine virtue and deceptive appearances in a corrupt age.

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← Stanza 193📚 OverviewStanza 195 →

Stanza 194 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 194 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line, then look at the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"His kindled duty kindled her mistrust,"

His kindled duty: Tarquin is trying to appear dutiful, respectful, and perhaps even chivalrous.
He's trying to cloak his lust under the guise of polite concern for his hostess. "Kindled duty"
suggests this "duty" is forced, manufactured, and brought to life for this specific moment.
kindled her mistrust: This "duty" has the opposite effect on Lucrece. It ignites her suspicion.
She becomes wary of his intentions. The repetition of "kindled" is polyptoton, using the same root word in different forms to emphasize the causal relationship, however ironically reversed.

"That two red fires in both their faces blazed;"

two red fires: This is a metaphor for blushing. Both Tarquin and Lucrece are experiencing
intense emotion, causing their faces to flush red.
in both their faces blazed: The redness is visually vivid and intense, suggesting shame, fear, and/or guilt. The fact that both are blushing is significant.

"She thought he blushed, as knowing Tarquin’s lust,"

She thought he blushed: Lucrece interprets Tarquin's blush as evidence that he knows the truth about Tarquin's lecherous nature. She assumes he's ashamed of his host's behavior, feeling guilty by association.
as knowing Tarquin's lust: This reveals Lucrece's growing awareness of the danger she's in. She's beginning to suspect Tarquin's true motives.

"And, blushing with him, wistly on him gazed."

blushing with him: Lucrece herself is blushing. This is crucial. Her blush is likely a mix of fear, embarrassment, and the growing realization of Tarquin's intent.
wistly on him gazed: "Wistly" means attentively, with concern, and perhaps a touch of anxiety. Lucrece is carefully observing Tarquin, trying to decipher his intentions. The word "wistly" conveys a sense of foreboding.

"Her earnest eye did make him more amazed."

Her earnest eye: Her sincere, serious gaze.
did make him more amazed: Lucrece's intense observation unsettles Tarquin. He's surprised
by her scrutiny and perhaps feels exposed, making him feel uneasy and further fuels his lustful obsession. "Amazed" here means confused, disconcerted, and perhaps even a little frightened.

"The more she saw the blood his cheeks replenish,"

The more she saw the blood his cheeks replenish: As Lucrece observes Tarquin's deepening blush, confirming her suspicions, the more convinced she becomes that she is correct.

His kindled duty kindled her mistrust,
That two red fires in both their faces blazed;
She thought he blushed, as knowing Tarquin’s lust,
And, blushing with him, wistly on him gazed.
Her earnest eye did make him more amazed.
The more she saw the blood his cheeks replenish, The more she thought he spied in her some blemish.

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"The more she thought he spied in her some blemish."

he spied in her some blemish: This is a crucial turning point. Lucrece projects her own growing sense of vulnerability and potential dishonor onto Tarquin. She fears that he sees something in
her that makes her seem like an easy target or that he has already begun to sully her honor with
his gaze. "Blemish" isn't necessarily a physical flaw; it's a moral flaw or a vulnerability. This is the moment when Lucrece begins to feel like she is already damaged, as if the violation has already begun, even before the physical act.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a powerful depiction of the escalating tension and miscommunication between Lucrece and the disguised Tarquin. Lucrece interprets Tarquin's (presumed) blushing and behavior as evidence of his knowledge of Tarquin's lustful intent, sparking her mistrust. However, her own fear and awareness of the danger lead her to believe that Tarquin sees her as vulnerable or flawed, making her a target for his vile intentions. The stanza is steeped in irony, as both characters misread each other's emotions, contributing to the tragic trajectory of the narrative. This stanza reveals the moment Lucrece realizes that her honor is in danger, a sense of dread and defilement descends upon her.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: "two red fires" for blushing
Polyptoton: "kindled duty kindled her mistrust"
Irony: The "duty" is actually fueling mistrust.
Dramatic Irony: We, the audience, know Tarquin's true intentions, which heightens the tension. Imagery: The vivid descriptions of blushing ("red fires," "blood his cheeks replenish") create a strong visual impact.
Foreshadowing: The stanza hints at the impending tragedy and the corruption of Lucrece's innocence.
Psychological Realism: Shakespeare masterfully captures the complex and shifting emotions of both characters, particularly Lucrece's growing fear and self-doubt.

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Stanza 195 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this stanza from The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices, and then summarize the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"But long she thinks till he return again,"

But: Indicates a contrast with the previous events (Lucrece's initial dismissal of Tarquin).
long she thinks: She perceives the time until Tarquin returns as stretching out interminably. Her anxiety makes time feel slow.
Literary Device: Inversion (the normal word order would be "she thinks long"). This emphasizes "long" and Lucrece's anxious anticipation.

"And yet the duteous vassal scarce is gone."

And yet: A further contrast. Even though the messenger has barely left, Lucrece already feels the weight of Tarquin's impending return.
the duteous vassal scarce is gone: The messenger, who was sent on his assigned task with loyalty, has hardly departed.
Literary Device: Understatement: "scarce is gone" implies the messenger has only just left, highlighting Lucrece's impatience and dread.

"The weary time she cannot entertain,"

The weary time: The tedious, burdensome period of waiting. The time itself is personified as "weary".
she cannot entertain: She cannot find any way to occupy or distract herself during this time. She is completely consumed by her anxiety.
Literary Device: Personification: "weary time" imbues time with a human quality, emphasizing its oppressiveness.

"For now ’tis stale to sigh, to weep, to groan;"

For: Explains why she can't entertain the time.
’tis stale to sigh, to weep, to groan: Her usual expressions of grief and sorrow (sighing, weeping, groaning) have become ineffective and meaningless. They no longer provide any relief.
Literary Device: Tricolon: The listing of three similar actions (sigh, weep, groan) creates a rhythmic emphasis on the exhaustion of her grief. Metaphor: the grief is now "stale" implying it is beyond freshness and therefore is impotent.

"So woe hath wearied woe, moan tired moan,"

So: Indicates a consequence of the previous line.
woe hath wearied woe, moan tired moan: Her grief has become so intense that it has exhausted itself. Her expressions of sorrow have lost their power to comfort her.
Literary Device: Repetition and Personification: The repetition of "woe" and "moan" emphasizes the overwhelming nature of her sorrow. The verbs "wearied" and "tired" further personify the grief, giving it a life of its own.

But long she thinks till he return again,
And yet the duteous vassal scarce is gone.
The weary time she cannot entertain,
For now ’tis stale to sigh, to weep, to groan;
So woe hath wearied woe, moan tired moan,
That she her plaints a little while doth stay, Pausing for means to mourn some newer way.

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"That she her plaints a little while doth stay,"

That: Introduces the result of her exhaustion.
she her plaints a little while doth stay: She stops her complaining and lamenting for a short period.
Literary Device: Inversion: "she her plaints" is an archaic construction.

"Pausing for means to mourn some newer way."

Pausing: She takes a break from her expressions of grief.
for means to mourn some newer way: She is contemplating and seeking new ways to express her overwhelming sorrow, since the old ways are no longer effective. This implies a deeper, more profound grief than she has experienced before.
Literary Device: Foreshadowing: This line hints at the extreme actions Lucrece will eventually
take (suicide) as a "newer way" to mourn and seek justice.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza captures Lucrece's mounting anxiety and despair as she awaits Tarquin's return. The time stretches out torturously for her. Her usual expressions of grief – sighs, tears, and groans – have become insufficient to express the depth of her present anguish. Her sorrow has reached a point of exhaustion, leading her to pause her plaints and seek out a new, more powerful means of expressing her pain. This stanza foreshadows the radical act of suicide that Lucrece ultimately commits, as the ultimate "newer way" to mourn and seek revenge. The language is filled with personification, repetition, and inversion to emphasize the overwhelming nature of Lucrece's emotional state. The stanza is a crucial turning point, moving Lucrece from passive anxiety to active consideration of how she will respond to the impending violation.

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← Stanza 195📚 OverviewStanza 197 →

Stanza 196 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 196 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then look at the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"At last she calls to mind where hangs a piece": This sets the scene within Lucrece's chamber, after the rape. She is remembering something that exists in her house. She is thinking, in desperation, and is now remembering something significant. "At last" stresses the build-up of emotions preceding this moment.
"Of skillful painting, made for Priam’s Troy,": This tells us the "piece" is a painting, and its subject matter relates to the Trojan War, specifically events concerning King Priam. Troy was the capital city of the Trojans.
"Before the which is drawn the power of Greece,": "Before the which" is an archaic way of saying "in front of which" or "depicted on it." This indicates that the painting depicts the Greek army and its might. The word "power" implies both their military strength and perhaps their moral force in this context (even though their cause is rooted in Helen's abduction).
"For Helen’s rape the city to destroy,": This clarifies why the Greeks are depicted: they are there to destroy Troy as revenge for the abduction (rape) of Helen by Paris. This directly parallels Lucrece's situation, being a rape that will result in the destruction of a family. This line strongly connects the imagery to the overarching theme of the poem.
"Threat’ning cloud-kissing Ilion with annoy;": "Ilion" is another name for Troy. The painting shows Troy, whose towers are so high they seem to kiss the clouds, being threatened with "annoy," which is a mild word for the impending destruction and suffering the Greeks will inflict. Shakespeare is highlighting the immanence of the threat, how it is just about to burst. "Cloud-kissing" is a powerful visual.
"Which the conceited painter drew so proud,": "Conceited" here means skillful or ingenious (not necessarily vain, although there's a hint of that too). The painter depicted the scene with such artistry and force. "Proud" suggests the grandeur and imposing nature of the scene.
"As heaven, it seemed, to kiss the turrets bowed.": This line concludes the description of the painting, emphasizing the visual perspective that the painting shows the turrets of Troy so bowed, as though they were trying to kiss the heavens. This is a hyperbole to emphasize the height of the towers, but also shows the destruction that has brought them so low.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece recalls a painting depicting the siege of Troy due to Helen's rape. The painting is intensely vivid, showing the Greek forces poised to destroy the seemingly invincible city. The artist has captured the grandeur and impending doom of Troy so effectively that the towering walls seem to reach and then bow to the heavens.

The significance of this stanza lies in its parallel to Lucrece's own situation. Just as the rape of Helen led to the destruction of Troy, Lucrece's rape threatens to bring about the destruction of her family and her own life. The painting serves as a visual representation of the devastating consequences that can stem from a single act of sexual violence. Lucrece identifies with the Trojans in the painting, helpless against an external force that will destroy them.

At last she calls to mind where hangs a piece
Of skilful painting, made for Priam’s Troy,
Before the which is drawn the power of Greece,
For Helen’s rape the city to destroy,
Threat’ning cloud-kissing Ilion with annoy;
Which the conceited painter drew so proud,
As heaven, it seemed, to kiss the turrets bowed.

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Literary Devices:

Allusion: The entire stanza is an allusion to the Trojan War, a well-known story from classical literature. This adds layers of meaning and resonance to the poem.
Imagery: The stanza is rich in visual imagery: "cloud-kissing Ilion," "power of Greece," and the description of the painting's perspective. These images create a vivid picture in the reader's mind. Hyperbole: "Cloud-kissing Ilion" is a hyperbolic description of Troy's height, emphasizing its former glory and the magnitude of its impending fall. The towers "bowed" in the last line are also a hyperbole.
Personification: The towers of Troy are given the human characteristic of being able to "kiss." Irony: There's a subtle irony in the use of the word "annoy" to describe the destruction of Troy. It's a massive understatement, highlighting the disparity between the word and the reality of war. Foreshadowing: The painting foreshadows the destruction that will follow Lucrece's rape. It sets a precedent for the devastating consequences of sexual violence.

In conclusion, Stanza 196 is a crucial section of The Rape of Lucrece because it uses the image of a painting depicting the Trojan War to mirror the impending destruction facing Lucrece and her family as a result of her rape. Through powerful imagery and allusions, Shakespeare connects personal tragedy to historical events, demonstrating the far-reaching impact of sexual violence.

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Stanza 197 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 197 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then analyze its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"A thousand lamentable objects there,"

Breakdown: This line sets the scene, describing a multitude of sad and pitiable things (objects) present. The word "lamentable" immediately establishes a tone of sorrow and grief. "There"
implies a specific location, likely a depicted scene or image being observed.
Literary Devices: Hyperbole - a thousand feels like an exaggeration to convey the overwhelming
sorrow.

"In scorn of Nature, Art gave lifeless life."

Breakdown: This is a key line that encapsulates the power and the limitation of art. "In scorn of Nature" suggests that Art challenges or imitates Nature. "Art gave lifeless life" is an oxymoron. The art depicts life, yet it is inherently inanimate or "lifeless." The phrase hints at the ability of art to capture the essence of life, albeit in a static form.
Literary Devices: Oxymoron, Personification (Art is given the ability to "give life"), Alliteration on "lifeless life"

"Many a dry drop seemed a weeping tear,"

Breakdown: This focuses on a specific detail. The painted or drawn representation of a drop looks so realistic that it evokes the feeling of a tear, a sign of sorrow and grief. The word "seemed" is crucial - it's an appearance of a tear, not an actual tear.
Literary Devices: Imagery (a visual of a tear), Metaphor (the dry drop is acting like a tear)

"Shed for the slaughtered husband by the wife."

Breakdown: This provides context for the tear (or the seeming tear). It's shed by a wife grieving for her murdered husband. It directly links the image to themes of death, loss, and marital tragedy.
Literary Devices: Allusion (to a story, probably that of the Trojan War)

"The red blood reeked to show the painter’s strife,"

Breakdown: The depiction of blood is so intense and vivid that it almost seems to emit a foul odor ("reeked"). This line also hints at the painter's own struggle to capture the horrific reality of the scene. The painter's own effort and suffering are reflected in the image. "Strife" here likely refers to the painter's creative struggle.
Literary Devices: Synecdoche (blood represents death), Imagery (sensory depiction of blood), Metaphor (painter's strife)

"The dying eyes gleamed forth their ashy lights,"

Breakdown: The eyes of the dying person in the artwork still retain a certain light, but it is a pale, fading "ashy" light, signifying the extinguishing of life. It highlights the detail and skill of the
artist.

A thousand lamentable objects there,
In scorn of Nature, Art gave lifeless life.
Many a dry drop seemed a weeping tear,
Shed for the slaughtered husband by the wife.
The red blood reeked to show the painter’s strife, The dying eyes gleamed forth their ashy lights, Like dying coals burnt out in tedious nights.

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Literary Devices: Imagery (visual of dying eyes), Juxtaposition (gleamed and ashy), Alliteration (ashy and lights)

"Like dying coals burnt out in tedious nights."

Breakdown: This line completes the stanza with a simile, comparing the fading light in the dying eyes to the embers of a fire slowly going out after a long, exhausting night. The "tedious nights" suggest a prolonged period of suffering or a long wait for death. The image is one of exhaustion and finality.
Literary Devices: Simile (using "like" to compare the eyes and coals), Imagery (visual and
tactile of dying coals)

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza describes an artwork (most likely a painting or tapestry) depicting a scene of immense sorrow and violence, likely related to the Trojan War. The stanza explores the power of art to imitate life, even in its most tragic forms. The speaker is deeply moved by the artwork's ability to evoke strong emotions of grief, loss, and horror. The art, despite being "lifeless," manages to capture the essence of suffering and death so vividly that it seems almost alive. The stanza also subtly suggests the artist's own emotional involvement in the creation of the artwork. The level of detail is so great that even the smallest nuances of the scene are depicted with such precision, the viewer is overcome with sadness.

Key Literary Devices Summary:

Imagery: Creates vivid pictures in the reader's mind.
Oxymoron: "Lifeless life" highlights the paradox of art.
Simile: Compares dying eyes to dying coals for a strong visual effect.
Metaphor: "Dry drop seemed a weeping tear"
Personification: Art is given human-like qualities.
Alliteration: Creates a musical quality and emphasizes certain phrases.
Hyperbole: Overstatement to emphasize the quantity of sadness
Synecdoche: Blood is part that represents the whole of violence and death

This stanza is a powerful example of Shakespeare's ability to use language to evoke strong emotions and explore complex themes related to art, life, and death.
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← Stanza 197📚 OverviewStanza 199 →

Stanza 198 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' piece by piece and then put it all together.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "There might you see the labouring pioneer"

Meaning: "There" refers to the imagined scene of the Trojan War. "Pioneer" here means a soldier who is doing the hard, often dangerous, work of digging trenches, building fortifications, or
clearing paths. The phrase "labouring pioneer" emphasizes the strenuous effort involved.
Literary Devices: Imagery (visual - the image of a working soldier)

Line 2: "Begrimed with sweat and smeared all with dust;"

Meaning: This line elaborates on the condition of the "pioneer" described in the previous line. "Begrimed" and "smeared" both mean dirtied/covered in something, emphasizing the harsh conditions of war. The use of "sweat" and "dust" is not only descriptive but evokes a sense of exertion and the environment of a siege.
Literary Devices: Imagery (tactile/visual - you can almost feel the dirt and sweat). Alliteration (repetition of the "s" sound in "sweat" and "smeared").

Line 3: "And from the towers of Troy there would appear"

Meaning: The perspective shifts. We're now looking at the defenders of Troy, specifically those positioned in the high towers of the city. The phrase "there would appear" suggests a possible scenario rather than a certainty; a conditional mood.
Literary Devices: Imagery (visual - the towers of a city).

Line 4: "The very eyes of men through loop-holes thrust,"

Meaning: This gives us a more detailed view of the defenders. "Loop-holes" are the small openings in castle walls or towers, used for observation and defense. The phrase "very eyes of men" is a synecdoche, where "eyes" represent the men themselves (a part representing the whole). "Thrust" indicates the urgency and intensity of their vigilance.
Literary Devices: Imagery (visual - close-up of eyes peering through a hole). Synecdoche (eyes representing men).

Line 5: "Gazing upon the Greeks with little lust."

Meaning: "Lust" here is not sexual desire, but rather eagerness, excitement, or enjoyment. The Trojans are watching the Greeks, but without enthusiasm. They are not enjoying this situation at all. The line implies fear, dread, or weariness.
Literary Devices: Irony (because "lust" commonly refers to passion)

Line 6: "Such sweet observance in this work was had,"

Meaning: "Observance" means "attention" or "watching". "Sweet" is used ironically; there is nothing sweet about the horrors of war. The line acts as a bridge between the scene and the emotional state of the viewers. The word "work" refers to the grim business of siege and war. Literary Devices: Irony (the juxtaposition of "sweet" with the context of war).

There might you see the labouring pioneer
Begrimed with sweat and smeared all with dust;
And from the towers of Troy there would appear
The very eyes of men through loop-holes thrust,
Gazing upon the Greeks with little lust.
Such sweet observance in this work was had, That one might see those far-off eyes look sad.

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Line 7: "That one might see those far-off eyes look sad."

Meaning: This line emphasizes the emotional impact of the war. The "far-off eyes" (from the Trojans in the towers) look sad. The stanza culminates in portraying the grief, despair, and trauma of war on both sides.
Literary Devices: Imagery (visual/emotional - the image of sad eyes).

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza offers a glimpse into the grim reality of the Trojan War. It depicts the harsh labor of the soldiers on the ground and the weary, apprehensive vigilance of the Trojan defenders in the towers. The overarching theme is the lack of glory or excitement in war; instead, there is only hard work, fear, and sadness. Shakespeare uses the image of sad eyes to convey the emotional toll that war takes on those involved, painting a picture of shared suffering and despair on both sides of the conflict. It's a humanizing moment in the midst of a grand, legendary battle. The use of irony and juxtaposition contributes to this sense of the grim, unromantic reality of war. The stanza suggests that the Trojans (like Lucrece later) are victims caught in a situation not of their own making, inspiring sympathy in the reader.

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← Stanza 198📚 OverviewStanza 200 →

Stanza 199 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 199 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"In great commanders grace and majesty":

Meaning: This line suggests that one would typically observe grace and kingly dignity (majesty)
in the faces of great military leaders.
Literary Devices: Abstract Nouns: "Grace" and "majesty" evoke qualities associated with leadership. It sets up the expected image of valiant individuals.

"You might behold, triumphing in their faces;":

Meaning: You would see triumph displayed upon the faces of these commanders; a display of victory and success.
Literary Devices: Personification: "Triumphing" gives human characteristics to an abstract concept, implying the emotions are visible in their countenance.

"In youth, quick bearing and dexterity;":

Meaning: In young men, you would observe agility (quick bearing) and skillful movement (dexterity). This line focuses on the physical attributes expected of young soldiers.
Literary Devices: Abstract Nouns: "Bearing" and "dexterity" describe qualities and abilities, continuing the depiction of expected traits.

"And here and there the painter interlaces":

Meaning: Now the poem takes a turn. "The painter" is a metaphor for the creator of a scene. Here and there, this painter (or the scene itself) includes...
Literary Devices: Metaphor: The painter is a representation of either a real painter depicting this scene, or a more metaphorical "painter" of the scene through the poet's words. It represents art imitating life, or life being represented through art.

"Pale cowards marching on with trembling paces,":

Meaning: Pale, cowardly soldiers are depicted marching with shaky or unsteady steps. This contrasts sharply with the previous images of strength and confidence.
Literary Devices: Juxtaposition/Contrast: This line creates a strong contrast with the earlier lines about commanders and youth. Imagery: The description paints a vivid picture of fear and weakness ("Pale," "trembling").

"Which heartless peasants did so well resemble,":

Meaning: The cowardly soldiers looked very much like peasants who lacked courage, suggesting
a similar demeanor and fear. "Heartless" could mean lacking courage, but also that they are just ignorant.
Literary Devices: Simile: The line implies a comparison between the cowards and peasants
("did so well resemble"), even if it's not explicit with "like" or "as".

In great commanders grace and majesty
You might behold, triumphing in their faces;
In youth, quick bearing and dexterity;
And here and there the painter interlaces
Pale cowards marching on with trembling paces,
Which heartless peasants did so well resemble, That one would swear he saw them quake and tremble.

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"That one would swear he saw them quake and tremble.":

Meaning: One would believe they actually saw these figures shaking and trembling because their fear was so palpable. This emphasizes the convincing depiction of cowardice.
Literary Devices: Hyperbole: The exaggeration of one swearing they saw them quake and
tremble heightens the feeling of cowardice. Sensory Imagery: The words "quake and tremble" appeal to a visual and almost tactile sense of fear.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza uses a comparison and contrast structure to highlight the theme of appearance versus reality and the deceptive nature of outward displays. It begins by describing the expected traits of leaders (grace, majesty, triumph) and youth (agility, skill). However, it then introduces the disturbing image of "pale cowards" who are indistinguishable from fearful peasants. This juxtaposition underscores the idea that outward appearance can be deceiving, and that even in a context of war or heroic narrative, fear and weakness can be present and even pervasive. It suggests a breakdown in the expected social order, where soldiers, who are supposed to be brave, resemble the very bottom of the social ladder, the peasants.

In the context of The Rape of Lucrece, this stanza likely sets up a theme of how appearances can be deceiving, and it may foreshadow the vulnerability of individuals, even those in positions of power or expected strength. It could also be seen as a commentary on the fragility of courage, and the potential for fear to undermine even the most seemingly steadfast individuals. The stanza emphasizes the inner turmoil and potential cowardice that can lurk beneath a facade of strength, thus setting the stage for the tragic events to follow, as the seemingly powerful Tarquin succumbs to his lust and commits his heinous act.

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← Stanza 199📚 OverviewStanza 201 →

Stanza 200 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 200 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, and then give an overall interpretation.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"In Ajax and Ulysses, O, what art"

"In Ajax and Ulysses": Establishes the subjects of the stanza: the Greek heroes Ajax (also
known as Ajax the Great) and Ulysses (also known as Odysseus). These are figures from the
Trojan War, well-known for their contrasting personalities.
"O, what art": An exclamation expressing wonder and perhaps admiration (though possibly
tinged with something else, as we'll see). "Art" here refers to the skill or ability to discern character from appearance. Shakespeare is suggesting that there's a clear and discernible skill at play in reading character.

"Of physiognomy might one behold!"

"Of physiognomy": Physiognomy is the (now largely discredited) practice of judging a person's character or personality from their outer appearance, especially their face. This is the art that Shakespeare refers to in line 1.
"might one behold!": A rhetorical question that is asking of the audience how obvious would the art of physiognomy be.

"The face of either ciphered either’s heart;"

"The face of either": Referring to the faces of Ajax and Ulysses respectively.
"ciphered either's heart": This is the core of the stanza. "Ciphered" means "encoded" or "revealed". The line states that each man's face held the key to unlocking their inner self (their heart = their character, their emotions, their intentions). The face served as a code or sign that revealed the man's true nature. Shakespeare uses metaphor here as face and heart are not literally ciphers.

"Their face their manners most expressly told."

"Their face": Restates the emphasis on outward appearance.
"their manners": Refers to their behavior, actions, and way of conducting themselves.
"most expressly told": "Expressly" means clearly, directly, and unmistakably. The face revealed their manners in a very clear way. This line reinforces the idea that their outward demeanor perfectly mirrored their inner character.

"In Ajax’ eyes blunt rage and rigour rolled,"

"In Ajax' eyes": Focus shifts to specific features. The eyes are often considered the "windows to the soul."

"blunt rage and rigour rolled": Describes Ajax's nature. "Blunt rage" suggests unrefined,
direct anger. "Rigour" indicates harshness, inflexibility, and severity. The verb "rolled" implies that these qualities were not static but actively present and dynamic in his eyes. Alliteration on
"rage" and "rigour" emphasises the intensity.

In Ajax and Ulysses, O, what art
Of physiognomy might one behold!
The face of either ciphered either’s heart;
Their face their manners most expressly told.
In Ajax’ eyes blunt rage and rigour rolled, But the mild glance that sly Ulysses lent Showed deep regard and smiling government.

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"But the mild glance that sly Ulysses lent"

"But": A contrasting conjunction, signalling a shift to a different character.
"the mild glance": Suggests gentleness, calmness, and perhaps even a deceptive innocence in Ulysses' gaze.
"that sly Ulysses lent": The word "sly" immediately qualifies the "mild glance" with a hint of cunning and deceptiveness. The verb "lent" suggests the glance is something that is offered superficially, a constructed image rather than a genuine reflection of his character.

"Showed deep regard and smiling government."

"Showed deep regard": Suggests a thoughtful, considered, perhaps even calculating attention. "Regard" here could mean consideration, but also a sense of control and command.
"and smiling government": The phrase is more complex. "Smiling" hints at diplomacy, charm, and perhaps manipulation. "Government" suggests control, leadership, and the ability to rule (oneself and others). The combination evokes a sense of calculated control masked by a pleasant exterior. The phrase 'smiling government' is an oxymoron.

Overall Meaning and Literary Devices:

The stanza argues that a person's character is clearly visible in their face, especially in their eyes. It uses the contrasting figures of Ajax and Ulysses to illustrate this point. Ajax, the warrior, is portrayed as straightforward and aggressive, his inner rage and harshness plain to see. Ulysses, the strategist, is portrayed as subtle and manipulative, hiding his cunning behind a facade of mildness and controlled authority.

Key Literary Devices:

Physiognomy: The underlying principle of reading character from appearance.
Contrast: The entire stanza is built on the contrast between Ajax and Ulysses.
Imagery: Strong visual imagery is used to describe the eyes and facial expressions of each man ("blunt rage and rigour rolled," "mild glance," "smiling government").
Metaphor: Face described as a cipher.
Alliteration: "Rage and Rigour"
Oxymoron: 'Smiling Government'
Rhetorical Question: The question in lines 1 and 2 helps to engage the reader.

Interpretation in the Context of The Rape of Lucrece

In the context of the poem, this stanza serves as a commentary on the deceptive nature of appearances and the difficulty of judging character. Tarquin, the rapist, presents himself as a noble guest, but his true intentions are hidden. The stanza raises questions about how well Lucrece (or anyone) can truly know another person and foreshadows the dangers of misjudging character based on outward appearances. The poem will then go on to show how flawed physiognomy is. It's also important to note that Ulysses, though portrayed as intelligent, is also "sly," hinting at a potential for deceit and moral ambiguity. This foreshadows the moral complexities that the poem explores.
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← Stanza 200📚 OverviewStanza 202 →

Stanza 201 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 201 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line:

Line 1: "There pleading might you see grave Nestor stand,"

Meaning: In that painting (implied from the context of the poem - Lucrece is looking at a
tapestry depicting the Trojan War), you could see the dignified and serious Nestor standing and pleading. "There" indicates the location on the tapestry. "Grave" emphasizes Nestor's solemnity
and importance.
Literary Device: Enjambment (the sentence continues uninterrupted into the next line) creates a sense of continuation and flow.

Line 2: "As ’twere encouraging the Greeks to fight,"

Meaning: He looked as if he was urging the Greek soldiers to fight. "As 'twere" is an archaic way of saying "as if it were."
Literary Device: Simile (comparing Nestor's appearance to someone encouraging soldiers).

Line 3: "Making such sober action with his hand"

Meaning: He was making such serious and restrained gestures with his hand. "Sober" reinforces the idea of Nestor's dignified demeanor. "Action" refers to his hand movements.
Literary Device: Alliteration with "sober" and "such" subtly enhances the effect.

Line 4: "That it beguiled attention, charmed the sight."

Meaning: These gestures were so captivating and beautiful that they captivated the viewer and held their gaze. "Beguiled attention" means it deceived and captured the viewer's focus. "Charmed the sight" suggests a spellbinding visual effect.
Literary Device: Assonance in "sight" and "beguiled" creates a subtle musicality.

Line 5: "In speech, it seemed, his beard, all silver white,"

Meaning: It appeared as if his silver-white beard was speaking. This is a personification of his beard.
Literary Device: Personification (giving the beard human-like qualities). Imagery - The visual of a silver-white beard conveys age and wisdom.

Line 6: "Wagged up and down, and from his lips did fly"

Meaning: It looked like his beard was moving up and down, and a thin breath was coming from his mouth.
Literary Device: Inversion - "from his lips did fly" is an inverted sentence structure (the normal order would be "did fly from his lips") to emphasize the breath. This is typical of Shakespearean writing.

Line 7: "Thin winding breath, which purled up to the sky."

Meaning: The light, spiraling breath seemed to rise and swirl upwards, as if it were ascending to the heavens. "Purled" means to move with a swirling motion.

There pleading might you see grave Nestor stand,
As ’twere encouraging the Greeks to fight,
Making such sober action with his hand
That it beguiled attention, charmed the sight.
In speech, it seemed, his beard, all silver white,
Wagged up and down, and from his lips did fly Thin winding breath, which purled up to the sky.

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Literary Device: Imagery: "thin winding breath, which purled up to the sky" creates a striking visual picture of the ethereal breath rising upward. Hyperbole or Exaggeration: The breath reaching the sky amplifies the impact of Nestor's speech and his importance.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza describes a powerful depiction of Nestor in the tapestry. The scene is so vividly painted with words that it gives the impression of movement and life within the still image. Nestor, a symbol of wisdom and experience, is portrayed as a compelling orator whose age and gravitas command attention. The passage focuses on the power of speech and the visual impact of his presence, emphasizing his ability to inspire and persuade through both his words (implied) and his gestures. Shakespeare uses vivid imagery, personification, and slight exaggeration to elevate the depiction, suggesting the profound impact this historical figure had and is having on Lucrece as she views the tapestry. The stanza highlights the persuasive power of wisdom and the enduring significance of heroic figures from the past. It adds to the overall theme of the poem by drawing parallels between the moral struggles of the past and the present situation of Lucrece.

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← Stanza 201📚 OverviewStanza 203 →

Stanza 202 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 202 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line, then put it all together:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"About him were a press of gaping faces,"

Meaning: Around him (referring to a speaker, likely Tarquin who is being compared to a figure in
a painting) was a large crowd of people with their mouths open. "Press" suggests a crowd
pushing closely together.
Literary Devices: Imagery. The word "press" evokes a physical sense of crowding.

"Which seemed to swallow up his sound advice,"

Meaning: The gaping mouths gave the impression that they were eagerly consuming his wise counsel.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The advice is not literally being swallowed. The image highlights the intense absorption of the audience.
Personification: Faces can't swallow.

"All jointly list’ning, but with several graces,"

Meaning: They were all listening together, but each person exhibited a different type of charm or attractiveness (in the way they were listening).
Literary Devices: Juxtaposition/Contrast. "Jointly" suggests unity, while "several graces" hints
at individual distinctiveness.

"As if some mermaid did their ears entice;"

Meaning: Their rapt attention was so complete, it was as though they were being lured by the enchanting song of a mermaid.
Literary Devices:
Simile: The "as if" construction makes it a simile. Compares the persuasive power of the speech to a mermaid's seductive song.
Allusion: Mermaids are mythical creatures known for their captivating voices.

"Some high, some low, the painter was so nice."

Meaning: Some faces were positioned higher (in the painting), some lower; the painter was so skillful/precise in his depiction. "Nice" here means meticulous, careful.
Literary Devices:
Antithesis: "Some high, some low" creates a balanced contrast.
Metonymy: High and low refers to the placement of the faces.

"The scalps of many, almost hid behind,"

Meaning: The tops of many of their heads were partially hidden by the people in front of them. Literary Devices: Imagery.

About him were a press of gaping faces,
Which seemed to swallow up his sound advice,
All jointly list’ning, but with several graces,
As if some mermaid did their ears entice;
Some high, some low, the painter was so nice. The scalps of many, almost hid behind,
To jump up higher seemed to mock the mind.

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"To jump up higher seemed to mock the mind."

Meaning: The attempt of those in the back to appear taller seemed foolish, and perhaps almost deranged. The phrase "mock the mind" suggests that this ridiculous behavior is the result of the powerful persuasive speech that causes them to act illogically.
Literary Devices:
Personification: The action of "jumping up higher" (motivated by vanity or a desire to be
seen) is presented as something that "mocks the mind," imlying illogical or unreasonable
behavior.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza describes a crowd of people listening intently to a speaker who is being compared to a figure in a painting (possibly Tarquin himself or another persuasive orator). Their rapt attention is likened to being lured by a mermaid's song, emphasizing the speaker's powerful influence. The diversity in the crowd and their reactions, including the somewhat absurd attempts to be seen, highlight the persuasive power of the speaker's words. The image suggests that the speaker's advice is so captivating, it causes the listeners to lose some of their sense of reason, engaging in almost desperate attempts to absorb his message. The image of a "press of gaping faces" portrays the seductive and manipulative power of words, as the speaker is able to entice his audience in order to fulfill his own intentions. The stanza ultimately explores the theme of manipulation and the seductive power of persuasion. It also subtly comments on the human tendency to be easily swayed by rhetoric, even to the point of absurdity.

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← Stanza 202📚 OverviewStanza 204 →

Stanza 203 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 203 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, and then analyze its overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Here one man’s hand leaned on another’s head,"

Meaning: Describes a chaotic, crowded scene where people are physically pressed together. One man is so close to another that he's using the other's head for support, likely in a struggle. This emphasizes the lack of order and respect for personal space.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Creates a vivid picture of the jostling crowd.

"His nose being shadowed by his neighbour’s ear;"

Meaning: Continues the description of the crush. The men are packed so tightly that one man's nose is literally in the shadow of another's ear. It's a graphic and somewhat absurd image, emphasizing the claustrophobia and discomfort.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Further reinforces the chaotic and claustrophobic scene.
Hyperbole: Exaggerates the closeness of the men.

"Here one being thronged bears back, all boll’n and red;"

Meaning: Describes another individual being pushed back by the crowd, his face swollen ("boll'n") and flushed ("red") from the pressure and exertion. He's struggling against the force.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: The words "boll'n and red" vividly portray the physical effects of the crush, emphasizing the men's distress.
Alliteration: The repetition of the 'b' sound in "being," "bears," and "boll'n" subtly reinforces
the idea of struggle and burden.

"Another smothered seems to pelt and swear;"

Meaning: Another person is being suffocated by the crowd and is reacting by striking out ("pelt") and cursing ("swear"). He's trying to fight his way out of the suffocating press.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: The word "smothered" evokes a powerful sense of panic and desperation. Onomatopoeia: The word "pelt" is partially onomatopoeic, suggesting the sound of hitting or struggling.

"And in their rage such signs of rage they bear"

Meaning: Reinforces the idea that the people in the crowd are exhibiting clear signs of their anger and frustration. The repetition of "rage" emphasizes the intensity of their emotions.
Literary Devices:
Repetition: Emphasizes the overwhelming feeling of rage.

Here one man’s hand leaned on another’s head,
His nose being shadowed by his neighbour’s ear;
Here one being thronged bears back, all boll’n and red;
Another smothered seems to pelt and swear;
And in their rage such signs of rage they bear
As, but for loss of Nestor’s golden words,
It seemed they would debate with angry swords.

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"As, but for loss of Nestor’s golden words,"

Meaning: Introduces a hypothetical contrast. "Nestor" is a reference to the wise old counselor from Homer's Iliad. The line suggests that if they didn't lack Nestor's persuasive and calming eloquence (his "golden words"),...
Literary Devices:
Allusion: Refers to a figure known for his wisdom and ability to calm tempers.
Metaphor: "Golden words" is a metaphor for eloquent and persuasive speech.

"It seemed they would debate with angry swords."

Meaning: ...then these men would have already resorted to violence. The chaos and fury are so intense that the only thing preventing a full-blown brawl is the absence of someone capable of reasoned discourse.
Literary Devices:
Synecdoche: "Swords" stands in for armed conflict or violence.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

The stanza depicts a scene of intense chaos and rising tension within a crowd. The physical discomfort, claustrophobia, and frustration have brought the men to the brink of violence. The allusion to Nestor highlights the importance of reason and eloquence in preventing conflict. Without a voice of reason to calm them, the men are ready to explode into a literal sword fight.

Key Themes and Observations:

The Destructive Power of Uncontrolled Emotion: The stanza illustrates how pent-up frustration and rage can quickly escalate into violence.
The Importance of Reason and Diplomacy: The allusion to Nestor emphasizes the need for wise counsel and persuasive communication to prevent conflict.
The Physicality of Emotion: The stanza vividly portrays how emotional states manifest in
physical ways (flushed faces, jostling, being smothered).
Foreshadowing: Given the context of The Rape of Lucrece, this stanza can be seen as foreshadowing the larger conflict and violence that will erupt as a result of Tarquin's actions. It suggests the breakdown of social order and the potential for widespread chaos.
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← Stanza 203📚 OverviewStanza 205 →

Stanza 204 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece and analyze its meaning and literary devices:

Breakdown of Each Line:

Line 1: "For much imaginary work was there,"

Meaning: The tapestry or picture (implied context) contained a great deal of artifice, requiring
the viewer to use their imagination to fill in the gaps. It wasn't a literal or photographically
realistic depiction.
Literary Devices: This line sets the stage for the stanza's central theme of imagination and representation.

Line 2: "Conceit deceitful, so compact, so kind,"

Meaning: "Conceit" refers here to the artistic concept or idea behind the image. It's described as "deceitful" because it's a trick or illusion. It's "compact" meaning it's tightly constructed, well-organized and “kind” meaning well-suited or appropriate for the subject. The deceit is that it is not real but merely a representation.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the 'c' sound in "conceit," "compact," and "kind" adds emphasis. Paradox: The juxtaposition of "deceitful" and "kind" creates a subtle paradox, highlighting the dual nature of art – it's a lie that can reveal truth.

Line 3: "That for Achilles’ image stood his spear"

Meaning: The spear, tightly grasped in an armed hand, was a substitute or stood in place of the entire figure of Achilles. The spear becomes a metonymic representation of the warrior.
Literary Devices:
Metonymy: The spear stands in for Achilles, associating the warrior with his weapon, highlighting his martial prowess.

Line 4: "Griped in an armed hand; himself, behind,"

Meaning: The hand holding the spear is clearly visible, but Achilles himself is positioned behind the spear or is somehow obscured.
Literary Devices: Creates a sense of mystery and incompleteness.

Line 5: "Was left unseen, save to the eye of mind."

Meaning: Achilles' full figure is not directly visible; he can only be fully perceived through the viewer's imagination. The artwork requires the viewer to participate in the creation of the image. Literary Devices:
Emphasis on imagination: Reinforces the idea that art relies on the viewer's active engagement.

Line 6: "A hand, a foot, a face, a leg, a head,"

Meaning: This line lists individual body parts, suggesting that the artist presented fragmented representations of the whole figure.

For much imaginary work was there,
Conceit deceitful, so compact, so kind,
That for Achilles’ image stood his spear
Griped in an armed hand; himself, behind,
Was left unseen, save to the eye of mind. A hand, a foot, a face, a leg, a head, Stood for the whole to be imagined.

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Literary Devices:
Synecdoche: A list of parts representing a whole, emphasizes the fragmentary nature of the artwork.

Line 7: "Stood for the whole to be imagined."

Meaning: These individual body parts, though incomplete and disjointed, were intended to evoke the complete image of Achilles in the viewer's mind. The parts are representative of the whole. Literary Devices:
Repetition: Reinforces the idea that the fragments are meant to represent the whole.
Emphasis on imagination: Reiterates the importance of the viewer's active participation in completing the image.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is about the power and limitations of artistic representation. It describes a painting or tapestry depicting Achilles, but it emphasizes that the image isn't a realistic portrayal. Instead, it's a carefully constructed illusion that relies heavily on the viewer's imagination. The artist doesn't show Achilles in full detail but uses fragments – a spear, a hand, a foot – to suggest the whole. The stanza highlights the idea that art is not about perfectly replicating reality but about evoking it through suggestion and stimulating the viewer's imagination. The "deceitful conceit" is that art, while an illusion, can still convey powerful truths and ideas, but only if the viewer is willing to engage with it actively. The fragmented representation also speaks to the potentially destructive and incomplete nature of human experience and memory, which can only be pieced together through imagination.

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← Stanza 204📚 OverviewStanza 206 →

Stanza 205 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 205 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then analyze its overall meaning and identify literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"And from the walls of strong-besieged Troy,"

Meaning: Sets the scene - we are in Troy, during the Trojan War, and the city is under siege. The emphasis on "strong-besieged" immediately indicates the precarious situation.
Literary Device: Allusion - reference to the Trojan War, a well-known story in classical literature.

"When their brave hope, bold Hector, marched to field,"

Meaning: The key event - Hector, the greatest Trojan warrior and the city's primary hope, is going out to fight. "Brave hope, bold Hector" showcases his importance.
Literary Device: Epithet - descriptive phrase ("brave hope, bold Hector") used repeatedly to characterize him.

"Stood many Trojan mothers, sharing joy"

Meaning: The Trojan mothers are watching. Initially, they are experiencing "joy." They are presumably watching their own sons as well, or celebrating Hector's strength.
Literary Device: Alliteration - "sharing joy" creates a euphonious sound.

"To see their youthful sons bright weapons wield;"

Meaning: The source of their joy is seeing their young sons brandishing shining weapons, ready to fight. They're proud of their sons.
Literary Device: Imagery - "youthful sons bright weapons wield" is visually striking, evoking a sense of both strength and vulnerability.

"And to their hope they such odd action yield"

Meaning: "Odd action" is deliberately vague, but suggests that the Trojan mothers react strangely to seeing their sons preparing for war. They are acting in a way that is inconsistent with pure joy.
Literary Device: Ambiguity - "odd action" is intentionally unclear, creating suspense and foreshadowing.

"That through their light joy seemed to appear,"

Meaning: The joy these mothers are experiencing is superficial. It is being undermined or overpowered by something else. It's a "light joy," suggesting it's not deeply felt or secure. Literary Device: Juxtaposition - "light joy" contrasts with the heavier feelings coming.

"Like bright things stained, a kind of heavy fear."

Meaning: This is the crucial line. Their joy is compared to "bright things stained" - something beautiful but corrupted. The "heavy fear" lurking beneath the surface is what truly dominates their emotions. The fact that is 'heavy' illustrates how strong this feeling is.

And from the walls of strong-besieged Troy,
When their brave hope, bold Hector, marched to field,
Stood many Trojan mothers, sharing joy
To see their youthful sons bright weapons wield;
And to their hope they such odd action yield
That through their light joy seemed to appear,
Like bright things stained, a kind of heavy fear.

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Literary Device: Simile - "Like bright things stained" draws a direct comparison. Oxymoron - "heavy fear" - fear is an emotion, and it is being described as a tangible weight. Imagery -
"bright things stained" and "heavy fear" both create strong visual and emotional impressions.

Overall Meaning and Interpretation:

The stanza describes the Trojan mothers witnessing their sons preparing for battle alongside Hector. On the surface, there's a sense of pride and joy in seeing their young men armed and ready to defend their city. However, this joy is superficial and tinged with a deep-seated fear. The joy is only light, and is barely concealing the "heavy fear" that is truly felt.

Shakespeare uses the analogy of "bright things stained" to illustrate this duality. The joy is like something beautiful, but it's been corrupted by the knowledge of the impending danger, the high stakes of war, and the potential loss of their sons and Hector.

The Purpose of the Stanza in Lucrece

This stanza, while seemingly tangential, serves multiple purposes within the broader context of The Rape of Lucrece:

Foreshadowing: It foreshadows the eventual downfall of Troy and, more importantly, the tragic consequences of violence and lust that will unfold in the main narrative.
Theme of Appearance vs. Reality: The stanza highlights the theme of appearance versus reality, where outward displays of joy can mask deeper, more troubling emotions and truths. This theme resonates with Lucrece's own internal struggles and the deceptive nature of Tarquin's actions. Emotional Complexity: It demonstrates Shakespeare's ability to portray complex and conflicting emotions. The mothers aren't simply happy or simply afraid; they experience a tangled mix of both, reflecting the complexities of human nature.
Historical and Mythological Context: By referencing the Trojan War, Shakespeare elevates the poem and draws parallels between the epic events of the past and the personal tragedy of Lucrece. He subtly suggests that even seemingly small actions can have profound consequences, just as the lust of one man can lead to the destruction of an entire city.

In essence, Stanza 205 is a microcosm of the larger themes and concerns of The Rape of Lucrece, setting a tone of foreboding and underscoring the destructive power of unchecked desire and the fragility of innocence.

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← Stanza 205📚 OverviewStanza 207 →

Stanza 206 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 206 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"And from the strand of Dardan, where they fought,"

Meaning: The blood flowed all the way from the beach of Dardanus, the area associated with the Trojan War. "Strand" refers to the shoreline, and "Dardan" is a reference to Troy (Dardanus was
an ancestor of the Trojan kings). "Where they fought" alludes to the immense battles fought at
Troy.
Literary Devices: Allusion (to the Trojan War). The historical setting of Troy adds depth and weight to the description.

"To Simois’ reedy banks the red blood ran,"

Meaning: The blood made its way to the banks of the river Simois, a river near Troy, noted for its reeds.
Literary Devices: Imagery: Vivid image of the red blood flowing. Specific details: The river Simois, and it's reeds.

"Whose waves to imitate the battle sought"

Meaning: The waves of the river seemed to try to imitate the chaos and violence of the battle at Troy.
Literary Devices: Personification: Giving the waves human-like motivation (to imitate). This is a crucial device.

"With swelling ridges, and their ranks began"

Meaning: The waves rose up in "ridges" (high crests) and began to organize, like soldiers forming lines ("ranks").
Literary Devices: Metaphor: Comparing waves to ranks of soldiers. Imagery: The word "swelling" gives a visual sense of the water rising.

"To break upon the galled shore, and then"

Meaning: The waves crashed onto the "galled" shore (a shore rubbed raw, wounded). Literary Devices: Imagery: The description of the shore as "galled" adds to the sense of suffering and violence. "Galled" connects the shore's condition to the feeling of pain.

"Retire again till, meeting greater ranks,"

Meaning: The waves retreated (like a defeated army) until they merged with larger waves (larger ranks).
Literary Devices: Metaphor: Continuing the metaphor of waves as soldiers retreating to regroup.

And from the strand of Dardan, where they fought,
To Simois’ reedy banks the red blood ran,
Whose waves to imitate the battle sought
With swelling ridges, and their ranks began
To break upon the galled shore, and then
Retire again till, meeting greater ranks,
They join, and shoot their foam at Simois’ banks.

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"They join, and shoot their foam at Simois’ banks."

Meaning: The re-formed waves combined and crashed violently onto the banks of the Simois
River, throwing their foam.
Literary Devices: Imagery: The image of "shooting foam" is dynamic and emphasizes the force
of the water.

Overall Meaning and Interpretation:

This stanza is a powerful analogy. Shakespeare uses the flowing blood from the Trojan War and the actions of the river Simois to mirror the emotions and events surrounding Lucrece's rape.

The blood flowing from Dardan represents the originating event, a violation (whether physical or metaphorical).
The river's actions represent the turmoil and chaos caused by the act of violence. The river is not simply flowing, it's imitating battle, which suggests an unnatural and violent disruption of the natural order.
The "galled shore" represents Lucrece's violated body and her suffering. The waves attacking the shore are a symbolic representation of the ongoing pain and trauma she experiences.
The ebb and flow of the waves, their retreat and regrouping, can be seen as representing the recurring and overwhelming nature of trauma.

Key Literary Devices Summary:

Allusion: To the Trojan War (Dardan, Simois).
Personification: Giving the river waves human-like motivations and actions.
Metaphor: Comparing the waves to soldiers (ranks, breaking, retiring, shooting).
Imagery: Vivid descriptions that appeal to the senses (red blood, swelling ridges, galled shore, shooting foam).
Pathetic Fallacy: The natural world (river and waves) reflecting and amplifying human emotions (suffering, violence). While technically close to personification, pathetic fallacy specifically applies to nature mirroring emotions.

The stanza is effective because it moves beyond a simple description of a river. It uses the natural world to powerfully evoke the chaos, pain, and lasting impact of a violent act. The connection to the Trojan War also elevates the poem, associating Lucrece's tragedy with a grand historical context of war and suffering.
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← Stanza 206📚 OverviewStanza 208 →

Stanza 207 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 207 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece':

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

Line 1: "To this well-painted piece is Lucrece come,"

Meaning: Lucrece has approached a painting. The painting is described as "well-painted,"
implying it's a skilled and perhaps emotionally charged artwork.
Literary Devices: None immediately obvious, but the phrase sets the scene and emphasizes the artificiality/representation of suffering, a contrast to Lucrece's very real suffering.
Line 2: "To find a face where all distress is stelled."

Meaning: She's looking for a face within the painting that embodies complete distress. "Stelled" means fixed, settled, or imprinted. Lucrece wants to find a representation of complete and utter anguish. This may be a metaphor comparing the emotional distress of the painting to something from the stars.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Distress is being compared to a fixed or settled object.
Word Choice: "Stelled" is an unusual and poetic word that adds to the intensity of the image.

Line 3: "Many she sees where cares have carved some,"

Meaning: She sees many faces in the painting that show signs of worry and hardship ("cares have carved some"). This suggests that the painting is complex and populated with figures who have experienced suffering. However, these people have only felt "some" pain.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "Cares have carved" gives human-like actions to abstract anxieties.
Contrast: Implicitly contrasts the partial suffering of these figures with the complete suffering she's searching for.

Line 4: "But none where all distress and dolour dwelled,"

Meaning: But she doesn't find anyone whose face truly embodies the totality of suffering and grief ("dolour"). None of the other faces seem to embody complete and intense grief.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: the 'd' sounds in "distress" and "dolour" emphasize the intensity of these emotions.

Emphasis: Use of "all" suggests a complete or comprehensive grief.

Line 5: "Till she despairing Hecuba beheld,"

Meaning: Until she notices Hecuba, who is in despair. This marks a turning point. She finds the personification of complete grief.
Literary Devices:
Epithet: "Despairing Hecuba" - a description of Hecuba through one of her qualities.
Allusion: Reference to Hecuba, queen of Troy.

To this well-painted piece is Lucrece come,
To find a face where all distress is stelled. Many she sees where cares have carved some,
But none where all distress and dolour dwelled,
Till she despairing Hecuba beheld,
Staring on Priam’s wounds with her old eyes, Which bleeding under Pyrrhus’ proud foot lies.

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Line 6: "Staring on Priam’s wounds with her old eyes,"

Meaning: Hecuba is staring at the wounds of her husband, King Priam, with her aged eyes. The image is immediately powerful, depicting the depth of loss and trauma.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Creates a visual image of the aged Queen staring at the wounds of her husband. Allusion: Continues the reference to characters from the Trojan war, specifically the death of King Priam.

Line 7: "Which bleeding under Pyrrhus’ proud foot lies."

Meaning: These wounds are bleeding and lying under the foot of Pyrrhus (also known as Neoptolemus), the son of Achilles and a brutal warrior. The final line emphasizes the humiliation and complete defeat of Priam and, by extension, Hecuba.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: Bleeding wounds under a foot create a powerful image of violence and desecration. Allusion: Continues the reference to the Trojan war.
Juxtaposition: Puts together a tragic image of death and the "proud foot" of the violent
Pyrrhus, highlighting the power dynamic.
Metonymy: "Proud foot" is used as a metonymy of Pyrrhus himself.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

Lucrece, grappling with her own trauma of rape, looks at a painting to find an image that reflects the depth of her suffering. She sees many figures in distress, but none that seem to capture the entirety of the pain she feels. Finally, she discovers Hecuba in the painting, staring at her murdered husband, King Priam, lying bleeding under the foot of their enemy. Hecuba, a symbol of ultimate loss and grief due to the Trojan War, provides Lucrece with a mirror for her own devastating emotional state. The stanza suggests that Lucrece finds a connection and a validation of her own suffering in the image of Hecuba's tragedy. The image of Hecuba is especially tragic because it combines the death of a husband with the image of his humiliation. Lucrece feels she can empathize with Hecuba and that her own distress might be validated by someone else.

Key Themes and Significance:

The Power of Representation: The stanza highlights how art can be a mirror for human experience, particularly in times of suffering. Lucrece is seeking a visual representation of her own internal turmoil.
Empathy and Connection: Despite the difference in their situations, Lucrece finds a connection with Hecuba's grief, suggesting a universal aspect of human suffering.
The Depth of Grief: The vivid and brutal imagery emphasizes the profound depth of grief that Lucrece is experiencing and seeks to identify with.
The Nature of Trauma: The allusion to Hecuba, a woman who has witnessed and endured immense loss, suggests that trauma can leave lasting scars and fundamentally alter a person's perception of the world.
Foreshadowing: The violence and horror of Priam's death under Pyrrhus's foot may foreshadow the violence and dishonor Lucrece herself has suffered.

In essence, the stanza establishes a thematic parallel between Lucrece's personal tragedy and the epic tragedy of the Trojan War, using Hecuba as a visual representation of the profound grief and despair Lucrece is grappling with.

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← Stanza 207📚 OverviewStanza 209 →

Stanza 208 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 208 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"In her the painter had anatomized": This sets the scene. The "painter" is not a literal artist,
but rather Time or Grief personified as a painter. To "anatomize" means to dissect and examine meticulously. The painter has thoroughly deconstructed Lucrece's beauty. This could also be read as a metaphor for Tarquin having destroyed her purity and spirit during his assault.

"Time's ruin, beauty's wrack, and grim care's reign.": This line lists the things the painter has dissected. Note the alliteration with the 'r' sound in "ruin," "wrack," and "reign," emphasizing the harshness of these destructive forces.

"Time's ruin": The effects of time, its tendency to decay and destroy.
"Beauty's wrack": The wreckage or destruction of beauty. "Wrack" suggests a violent,
catastrophic event.
"Grim care's reign": "Care" here means worry, sorrow, and deep distress. "Grim care's reign" suggests that worry has taken over, ruling her like a tyrannical monarch.

"Her cheeks with chops and wrinkles were disguised;": Here, we begin to see the physical effects of the "grim care." "Chops" are deep cracks or fissures, indicating a face ravaged by distress and age (though Lucrece is not actually old). The "wrinkles" further emphasize the destruction of her former beauty. The word "disguised" suggests that her true self is hidden beneath this mask of grief.

"Of what she was no semblance did remain.": This is a powerful and devastating statement. There's no trace of her former self left. The ravages of grief are so profound that she is unrecognizable.

"Her blue blood, changed to black in every vein,": "Blue blood" typically refers to noble lineage, but here it's likely literal blood. The change to "black" symbolizes death, despair, and a fundamental corruption. It emphasizes how deeply the trauma has affected her, even on a physical level. It could also be a reference to the "black bile" of Melancholy, one of the four humours.

"Wanting the spring that those shrunk pipes had fed,": "Wanting" here means lacking. The "spring" is the vital force, the life energy, the joy, and hope that once sustained her. The "shrunk pipes" are her veins, now withered and contracted because the life-giving "spring" is gone. The metaphor of the body as a plumbing system is striking.

"Showed life imprisoned in a body dead.": This is the climax of the stanza. Though her body is technically alive, her spirit, her true self, is trapped, unable to escape the overwhelming grief and shame. The imagery is of a living tomb.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza paints a horrific picture of the devastating effects of trauma and grief on Lucrece. It shows how profound suffering can physically and spiritually destroy a person. The "painter" (personified

In her the painter had anatomized
Time’s ruin, beauty’s wrack, and grim care’s reign.
Her cheeks with chops and wrinkles were disguised;
Of what she was no semblance did remain.
Her blue blood, changed to black in every vein,
Wanting the spring that those shrunk pipes had fed, Showed life imprisoned in a body dead.

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Time and Grief) has meticulously dismantled her beauty, her vitality, and her very essence. The image is of a body still breathing but essentially dead inside, her spirit trapped by the enormity of her suffering. This is crucial because the stanza underscores the depth of the violation she has suffered, which ultimately drives her to suicide as the only way to reclaim her honor and escape this living death.

Literary Devices:

Personification: Time and Grief are personified as a painter.
Alliteration: "Time's ruin, beauty's wrack, and grim care's reign" uses alliteration of the 'r' sound for emphasis.
Metaphor:
The "spring" that fed the "shrunk pipes" (veins) is a metaphor for vital life force.
The "painter" is a metaphor for the destructive power of grief and time.
The "body dead" is a metaphor for the spirit being broken despite physical life.

Imagery: The stanza is rich in visual imagery: the cracked cheeks, the black blood, the shrunk pipes, the imprisoned life.
Hyperbole: The line "Of what she was no semblance did remain" is likely a hyperbole to emphasize the depth of her suffering, but it adds to the drama and reinforces her feelings of hopelessness. Juxtaposition: "Life imprisoned in a body dead" is a powerful juxtaposition that captures the essence of Lucrece's tragic state.
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← Stanza 208📚 OverviewStanza 210 →

Stanza 209 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 209 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece piece by piece and then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"On this sad shadow Lucrece spends her eyes,"

Meaning: Lucrece focuses intently on the painting she is observing. "Sad shadow" refers to the painting, which depicts the fall of Troy, a scene filled with sorrow and suffering. "Spends her
eyes" suggests she is investing all her attention and emotion into looking at it. The words "sad shadow" create a feeling of melancholy and impending doom.
Literary Devices: Metaphor ("sad shadow" for the painting); Alliteration ("sad shadow").

"And shapes her sorrow to the beldam’s woes,"

Meaning: Lucrece molds (shapes) her own grief to match the sorrow of the old woman (beldam) depicted in the painting. She identifies with the old woman's suffering. This highlights Lucrece's empathetic nature and her ability to project herself into the emotions of others.
Literary Devices: Imagery, Empathy

"Who nothing wants to answer her but cries"

Meaning: The old woman in the painting lacks nothing to express her grief besides weeping and uttering curses against her enemies. The woman's response is purely emotional.
Literary Devices: Hyperbole ("nothing wants").
"And bitter words to ban her cruel foes."

Meaning: A continuation of the previous line, elaborating on the beldam's response: she wants bitter words to curse (ban) her cruel enemies. This emphasizes the depth of the woman's anger and desire for revenge.
Literary Devices: Imagery (bitter words)

"The painter was no god to lend her those,"

Meaning: The painter, being only a human, could not grant the woman in the painting the power to actually speak and curse her foes. He could only depict her sorrow and rage, not give her the ability to express it verbally.
Literary Devices: Allusion (to the power of gods), Understatement (the painter was "no god").

"And therefore Lucrece swears he did her wrong,"

Meaning: Lucrece, feeling deeply connected to the woman's suffering, believes the painter has wronged her (the woman in the painting, and by extension, Lucrece herself). This is a somewhat irrational reaction driven by intense emotion.
Literary Devices: Personification (Lucrece swearing).

On this sad shadow Lucrece spends her eyes,
And shapes her sorrow to the beldam’s woes,
Who nothing wants to answer her but cries
And bitter words to ban her cruel foes.
The painter was no god to lend her those,
And therefore Lucrece swears he did her wrong, To give her so much grief, and not a tongue.

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"To give her so much grief, and not a tongue."

Meaning: Lucrece's complaint is that the painter has depicted so much grief in the woman's face, but he has not given her the means to express that grief through speech or action. It's a sense of frustration that the sorrow is locked within, unable to be fully released.
Literary Devices: Irony (a painting cannot literally give someone a tongue), Juxtaposition (grief/tongue).

Overall Meaning:

This stanza reveals Lucrece's profound emotional connection to the painting of the fall of Troy. She identifies intensely with the suffering depicted, particularly that of the old woman. She feels the painter has failed by portraying such deep sorrow without providing a means for its expression. This empathy and frustration foreshadow Lucrece's own situation: she is about to be subjected to a horrific act that will leave her burdened with immense grief, and she will struggle to find the words and actions to adequately express the injustice she has suffered. Her empathy for the woman in the painting is a reflection of her own powerlessness and impending tragedy. The stanza highlights the limitations of art in fully capturing and conveying the depths of human suffering, and foreshadows the tragic outcome of Lucrece's ordeal.

Key Literary Devices Summary:

Metaphor: "Sad shadow" for the painting
Alliteration: "sad shadow"
Imagery: Description of the sorrowful painting, "bitter words"
Empathy: Lucrece projecting herself into the beldam's feelings. Hyperbole: "nothing wants"
Allusion: To the power of gods.
Understatement: The painter was "no god".
Personification: Lucrece swears.
Irony: A painting cannot literally give someone a tongue.
Juxtaposition: grief/tongue

In essence, the stanza is a powerful exploration of grief, empathy, and the limitations of art, all of which contribute to the tragedy that will befall Lucrece.
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Stanza 210 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 210 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Poor instrument,” quoth she, “without a sound,"

"Poor instrument": This refers to the dagger that Lucrece is holding. She sees it as a tool, but
also pitiable because it's currently inert, without a sound. It hasn't yet served its purpose.
"quoth she": Archaic way of saying "said she."
Meaning: Lucrece is addressing the dagger, recognizing it as the means by which she will exact
her revenge or find her release from shame.

"I’ll tune thy woes with my lamenting tongue,"

"tune thy woes": A metaphor. She will give voice to the dagger's (implied) suffering. The woes it carries represent the injustices and tragedies it is meant to resolve (i.e., her rape).
"lamenting tongue": Her voice, filled with sorrow and complaint, will be the accompaniment to the dagger's silent mission.
Meaning: She will express the pain and injustice surrounding her situation through her mournful words, acting as a conduit for the emotions associated with the act.

"And drop sweet balm in Priam’s painted wound,"

"sweet balm": Refers to something soothing.
"Priam's painted wound": An allusion to the Trojan War and the wounds of Priam, the king of Troy. "Painted" might suggest the wounds are metaphorical, representing the long-lasting trauma and grief of the Trojan War. It also connects the painted scenes on tapestries with the wounds that the Trojans have suffered over a long period of time.
Meaning: This is a metaphorical act of consolation. She will attempt to offer some relief,
however small, to the lingering pain of past injustices, even those as ancient as the Trojan War. She will align herself with the victims of violence.

"And rail on Pyrrhus that hath done him wrong,"

"rail on Pyrrhus": She will vehemently denounce Pyrrhus, the son of Achilles, who brutally murdered Priam during the sack of Troy. "Rail" means to speak against angrily.
"that hath done him wrong": Emphasizes the injustice of Pyrrhus's actions.
Meaning: She vows to condemn the perpetrators of violence and injustice, drawing a parallel between Pyrrhus's cruelty and the actions of her rapist, Tarquin.

"And with my tears quench Troy that burns so long,"

"quench Troy that burns so long": A hyperbole (exaggeration) and metaphor. Her tears are so copious and potent that they could extinguish the flames of the (metaphorical) burning Troy. Troy represents long-suffering and destruction.
Meaning: She expresses the depth of her grief and sorrow, suggesting it's powerful enough to undo even the most devastating historical events. This is hyperbolic; her sorrow is vast.

“Poor instrument,” quoth she, “without a sound,
I’ll tune thy woes with my lamenting tongue,
And drop sweet balm in Priam’s painted wound,
And rail on Pyrrhus that hath done him wrong,
And with my tears quench Troy that burns so long,
And with my knife scratch out the angry eyes
Of all the Greeks that are thine enemies.

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"And with my knife scratch out the angry eyes"

"scratch out the angry eyes": A violent image.
"angry eyes": Represents the vengeful gaze of the Greeks, particularly those who caused the fall of Troy. Metaphorically, it suggests the judging and accusatory gaze of society.
Meaning: She will symbolically blind the sources of hostility and judgment, seeking to nullify the power of those who would condemn her or perpetuate violence. She is turning the violence back on the original aggressors.
"Of all the Greeks that are thine enemies."

"thine enemies": Refers to the dagger's enemies, which are implicitly those who have caused suffering and injustice. It also connects to all the injustice from The Rape.
Meaning: Reinforces the idea that the dagger is a weapon against all forms of oppression and wrongdoing.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece, holding the dagger, embarks on a powerful speech. She connects her personal tragedy to larger historical injustices, particularly the fall of Troy. She promises to use her voice to lament, condemn, and offer solace, drawing parallels between her own situation and the suffering of others. The dagger becomes a symbol of her resolve to fight back against violence and oppression, both literal and metaphorical. She connects her personal tragedy to the larger historical context of violence and injustice, positioning herself as a champion of the wronged. This intensifies the moral weight of her impending suicide.

Literary Devices Highlighted:

Metaphor: "tune thy woes," "Priam's painted wound," "quench Troy."
Allusion: To the Trojan War, Priam, Pyrrhus.
Hyperbole: "quench Troy that burns so long."
Personification: The dagger as an "instrument without a sound" that has "woes."

The stanza is full of dramatic irony, as we (the readers) know that she will use the dagger on herself, but the Greeks would want her to do that to Tarquin. In this stanza, she has an active intention, but she will use the dagger passively.
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← Stanza 210📚 OverviewStanza 212 →

Stanza 211 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 211 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss its overall meaning, paying attention to literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

“Show me the strumpet that began this stir,”

Meaning: The speaker (Lucrece, in her mind, imagining the aftermath of a similar catastrophe)
is demanding to be shown the "strumpet" (a derogatory term for a promiscuous woman) who is responsible for starting the conflict. The "stir" refers to a major upheaval or conflict, in this case,
the Trojan War.
Literary Device: Metaphor/Synecdoche: "Strumpet" functions as a metaphor for the underlying lust and betrayal that initiated the war. It can also be considered synecdoche - using a part to represent the whole, with the adulterous act representing all the violence and destruction.

“That with my nails her beauty I may tear.”

Meaning: The speaker expresses a violent desire to physically assault the "strumpet," specifically to tear at her beauty with her nails. This highlights the rage and vengeful feelings associated with betrayal and the devastation it causes.
Literary Device: Imagery: The line provides a graphic and visceral image of violence, emphasizing the speaker's passionate anger. Alliteration: The repeated 't' sound in "tear"
creates a sharper, more forceful sound.

“Thy heat of lust, fond Paris, did incur

Meaning: This line directly addresses Paris, the Trojan prince whose abduction of Helen, the wife of Menelaus, sparked the Trojan War. The phrase "heat of lust" blames Paris's uncontrolled desire for Helen. "Fond" means foolish or infatuated. "Incur" means to bring upon oneself.
Literary Device: Direct Address (Apostrophe): The stanza directly addresses Paris, even though he is not present. Allusion: Refers to the mythological story of Paris and Helen.

“This load of wrath that burning Troy doth bear;”

Meaning: Paris's lust has brought about the immense "load of wrath" that the city of Troy is now suffering. The city is actively burning as it bears the burden of the consequences of Paris's actions.

Literary Device: Metaphor: The "load of wrath" represents the suffering, destruction, and ultimately, the fall of Troy. Personification: "Burning Troy doth bear" gives the city human characteristics by saying it is "bearing" the load.

“Thy eye kindled the fire that burneth here,”

Meaning: This line continues to blame Paris, stating that his lustful "eye" (his desire for Helen) started the destructive "fire" that is consuming Troy.
Literary Device: Metaphor: The "fire" represents the war and its associated destruction. Synecdoche: "Eye" represents Paris's entire lustful desire.

“Show me the strumpet that began this stir,
That with my nails her beauty I may tear.
Thy heat of lust, fond Paris, did incur
This load of wrath that burning Troy doth bear;
Thy eye kindled the fire that burneth here,
And here in Troy, for trespass of thine eye, The sire, the son, the dame, and daughter die.

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“And here in Troy, for trespass of thine eye,”

Meaning: Reinforces that in the city of Troy, the devastation is occurring solely because of the transgression, the sin, of Paris's "eye" (his lust).
Literary Device: Repetition: Reinforces the culpability of Paris. Synecdoche: "Eye" again represents Paris's lustful desire.

“The sire, the son, the dame, and daughter die.”

Meaning: This line lists the victims of the war, emphasizing the indiscriminate nature of the destruction. "Sire" is father, "son" is male child, "dame" is mother, and "daughter" is female child. Literary Device: Polysyndeton: The use of multiple conjunctions ("and") creates a sense of overwhelming loss and the sheer number of casualties. Synecdoche: "Sire, Son, Dame,
Daughter" is using a group of representative family members to signify the entire population of Troy.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

The stanza is a powerful condemnation of lust and its devastating consequences. Through the imagined voice of a woman wronged, Shakespeare uses the example of the Trojan War to illustrate how unchecked desire can lead to immense suffering, not just for individuals but for entire societies. The stanza places the blame squarely on Paris, whose "heat of lust" is portrayed as the spark that ignited a conflagration of violence and destruction. Importantly, the stanza doesn't just focus on the romantic relationship; it emphasizes the social and political ramifications of uncontrolled desire. The use of vivid imagery, direct address, and rhetorical devices underscores the passionate and accusatory tone, emphasizing the destructive power of unchecked desire and the innocence of those who become its victims. This connects directly to Lucrece's own situation, as she's contemplating the devastation that Tarquin's lust has brought upon her and her family's honor.

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← Stanza 211📚 OverviewStanza 213 →

Stanza 212 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 212 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line and then discuss the overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Why should the private pleasure of some one": This line poses a rhetorical question that frames the entire stanza. The core question is, "Why should one person's selfish, secret enjoyment..."

"private pleasure": This refers to Tarquin's lust and gratification in raping Lucrece. It's called "private" in the sense that it originates in his individual desires, even though it obviously has devastating public consequences.

"Become the public plague of many moe?": "...become a widespread disaster affecting many more people?"

"public plague": Strong metaphorical image. Rape is not merely an individual crime; it is depicted as a contagion that spreads and infects the entire community. It suggests widespread suffering, moral decay, and social disruption.
"many moe": An archaic way of saying "many more." The archaic language lends a formal, elevated tone and reinforces the historical setting.

"Let sin, alone committed, light alone": "Let the sin, since it was committed by one individual, fall only..."

Alliteration: "Let sin, alone, light alone" The repetition of the 'l' sound emphasizes the idea of isolating the sin and its consequences.
Parallelism: The repetition of "alone" reinforces the desire to confine the sin to the individual who committed it.

"Upon his head that hath transgressed so;": "...upon the head of the person who committed the transgression." This is a biblical idiom (referring to the idea that one's sins come back to haunt them) implying that Tarquin should bear the sole responsibility and punishment.

"Let guiltless souls be freed from guilty woe.": "Let innocent people be spared from suffering that is actually related to sin." This is a plea for justice, suggesting that the consequences of Tarquin's actions are unfairly affecting those who did nothing wrong.

Juxtaposition: "Guiltless souls" vs. "guilty woe" contrasts the innocence of the victims with the suffering that stems from guilt.

"For one’s offence why should so many fall,": "Why should so many people suffer and be ruined because of the crime committed by one individual?"

Rhetorical question: Reinforces the injustice and unfairness.

“Why should the private pleasure of some one
Become the public plague of many moe?
Let sin, alone committed, light alone
Upon his head that hath transgressed so;
Let guiltless souls be freed from guilty woe.
For one’s offence why should so many fall,
To plague a private sin in general?

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"To plague a private sin in general?": "...so that a sin that was originally a secret individual transgression ends up causing widespread suffering?"

Paradox: "Private sin in general" This is a paradox. A private sin, by definition, is meant to be individual and confined. However, the question asks why this private sin is causing a "general" or widespread plague. This highlights the profound impact that one person's actions can have on an entire society.
Repetition: The word "plague" is repeated from line 2, tying the individual act to the overall
effect.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza grapples with the devastating consequences of Tarquin's rape of Lucrece. Lucrece questions why one person's act of selfish lust should bring ruin and suffering to so many. She advocates for justice, arguing that the blame and punishment should be confined solely to the perpetrator (Tarquin) and that innocent people should be spared the burden of his guilt. The stanza expresses the tragic reality that a private sin can often have far-reaching public consequences, disrupting the lives of countless innocent individuals and even leading to the downfall of entire societies (as foreshadowed in the poem's broader context, where Lucrece's death leads to the overthrow of the Roman monarchy).

Literary Devices Summary:

Rhetorical Questions: Used to emphasize the injustice of the situation and to prompt reflection on the consequences of sin.
Metaphor: "Public plague" powerfully portrays the widespread devastation caused by Tarquin's actions.
Alliteration: "Let sin, alone, light alone" emphasizes the idea of isolating the sin and its consequences.
Parallelism: The repetition of "alone" in line 3 reinforces the desire to confine the sin to the individual who committed it.
Juxtaposition: "Guiltless souls" vs. "guilty woe" highlights the innocence of the victims compared to their suffering.
Paradox: "Private sin in general" illustrates the conflict between the individual nature of the crime and its widespread consequences.
Biblical Allusion/Idiom: "Upon his head" connects to the idea of accountability for one's sins.

In essence, this stanza is a powerful indictment of the ripple effects of sin and a plea for a just world where the guilty bear the sole responsibility for their actions, and the innocent are protected from the resulting devastation.

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← Stanza 212📚 OverviewStanza 214 →

Stanza 213 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 213 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices, and then piece together the overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Lo, here weeps Hecuba, here Priam dies,"

Lo: An archaic word meaning "behold" or "look." It directs our attention.
Hecuba: Queen of Troy, wife of Priam, known for her immense suffering during the Trojan War.
Her weeping symbolizes the overwhelming grief.
Priam: King of Troy, father of Hector, Paris, and Troilus, killed during the sack of Troy. His death represents the fall of Troy.
Repetition: The "here" emphasizes the immediacy and pervasiveness of the tragedy.

Interpretation: This line sets the scene by introducing the prominent figures of Troy. It establishes a tone of mourning and finality, alluding to the destruction of Troy.

"Here manly Hector faints, here Troilus swounds;"

Hector: Troy's greatest warrior, killed by Achilles. His "fainting" is a euphemism for death or extreme weakness, highlighting his heroic fall.
Troilus: A prince of Troy, known for his love for Cressida (although that's not emphasized here, his youth and vulnerability are). "Swounds" means faints or swoons, again suggesting a loss of strength and life.
Repetition: The continued use of "here" again emphasizes the immediacy and pervasiveness of the tragedy.

Interpretation: This continues to paint the picture of Troy's downfall through the demise of its valiant figures.

"Here friend by friend in bloody channel lies,"

Bloody channel: A metaphor for the war-torn streets of Troy, now filled with blood, a grotesque parody of a life-giving waterway.
Friend by friend: Highlights the close-knit bonds that are now broken by violence and death. The loss is not just of individuals, but of relationships and community.

Interpretation: This line emphasizes the widespread carnage and the breakdown of societal bonds as a consequence of the war.

"And friend to friend gives unadvised wounds,"

Unadvised wounds: Suggests that even in the midst of war, the attacks are sometimes unintentional or misdirected; it also highlights the chaos. It can also mean rashly given wounds without thinking of consequences. It portrays the brutality of war where even friends become enemies, albeit perhaps unintentionally.

Interpretation: This line emphasizes the indiscriminate nature of war and the breakdown of order. Even friends turn on each other.

“Lo, here weeps Hecuba, here Priam dies,
Here manly Hector faints, here Troilus swounds;
Here friend by friend in bloody channel lies,
And friend to friend gives unadvised wounds,
And one man’s lust these many lives confounds.
Had doting Priam checked his son’s desire,
Troy had been bright with fame and not with fire.”

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"And one man’s lust these many lives confounds."

One man's lust: A direct reference to Paris, whose abduction of Helen sparked the Trojan War. Confounds: Means destroys, ruins, or brings to ruin.
Alliteration: of the "m" sound.

Interpretation: This line identifies the root cause of the tragedy: Paris's desire for Helen. This desire has catastrophic consequences for the entire city and its people.

"Had doting Priam checked his son’s desire,"

Doting Priam: Suggests that Priam's love for his son (Paris) blinded him to the potential consequences of Paris's actions.
Checked his son's desire: If Priam had controlled or prevented Paris from taking Helen.

Interpretation: This presents an "if only" scenario. It suggests that the tragedy could have been averted if Priam had been a more responsible leader and restrained his son's recklessness.

"Troy had been bright with fame and not with fire."

Bright with fame: Contrasts with the reality of Troy being destroyed.
Fire: Symbolizes the destruction of Troy by burning.
Contrast: The line is built on a stark contrast, emphasizing the lost potential.

Interpretation: This line concludes the stanza with a final, regretful statement about what could have been. It highlights the devastating consequences of unchecked lust and the importance of responsible leadership.

Literary Devices:

Allusion: The entire stanza is an extended allusion to the Trojan War, drawing on the audience's knowledge of this famous story to amplify the themes of tragedy and loss.
Anaphora: The repetition of "Here" at the beginning of several lines emphasizes the widespread and immediate nature of the tragedy.
Metaphor: "Bloody channel" is a metaphor for the war-torn streets.
Euphemism: "Faints" and "Swounds" soften the reality of death.
Contrast: The last line relies heavily on contrast: "fame" vs. "fire."
Alliteration: of the "m" sound in the fifth line.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza serves as a powerful commentary on the destructive consequences of unchecked lust and the importance of responsible leadership. Shakespeare uses the story of the Trojan War as an allegory to illustrate how one man's selfish desire (Paris's lust for Helen) can lead to the destruction of an entire city and the tragic loss of countless lives. The stanza also critiques Priam's weakness as a leader, suggesting that his failure to control his son's actions ultimately led to Troy's downfall. The stanza is a meditation on the tragic waste of war and the potential for even great societies to be brought down by individual failings and a lack of moral restraint. It reinforces the idea that unchecked desires can have devastating repercussions, and that leaders have a responsibility to protect their people from such dangers. In the context of The Rape of Lucrece, it serves as a cautionary tale, highlighting the potential for male lust to lead to violence and destruction, which foreshadows the events that befall Lucrece herself.

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← Stanza 213📚 OverviewStanza 215 →

Stanza 214 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Here feelingly she weeps Troy’s painted woes,"

feelingly: Deeply, emotionally, with sincere feeling.
Troy's painted woes: Refers to the depiction of the suffering of the city of Troy, likely in a tapestry
or painting. "Painted" not only describes the visual representation but also suggests that the suffering is artfully presented, perhaps even stylized or idealized in a way that makes it more accessible to emotion.
Meaning: Lucrece weeps intensely over the images of the suffering and tragedy of the Trojan
War depicted in art. This shows her capacity for empathy and her sensitivity to suffering.

"For sorrow, like a heavy-hanging bell,"

Literary Device: Simile. This line starts a simile, comparing sorrow to a bell.
heavy-hanging bell: The image is of a large, heavy bell hanging in a tower, suggesting the weight and burden of sorrow.
Meaning: This introduces the idea that sorrow, like a heavy bell, has momentum and inertia.

"Once set on ringing, with his own weight goes;"

Once set on ringing: Once started (experiencing sorrow)
with his own weight goes: The bell, due to its own weight, will continue to swing and ring once it is set in motion. "Goes" here means continues to move/ring.
Meaning: Once sorrow begins, it has a self-sustaining momentum. It's difficult to stop the grieving process once it has started because it feeds on itself.

"Then little strength rings out the doleful knell."

little strength: Very little effort or force.
doleful knell: A mournful sound, often associated with death or tragedy. The "knell" refers specifically to the ringing of a bell at a funeral.
Meaning: After the initial impetus, only a small amount of energy is needed to continue the mournful process. The bell continues to toll, even with minimal prompting. Sorrow needs very little to keep ringing.

"So Lucrece set a-work, sad tales doth tell"

set a-work: Engaged, activated, set in motion.
sad tales doth tell: Tells sad stories; expresses her grief.
Meaning: Just like the bell, Lucrece is now activated by her sorrow and begins to express her grief in stories and laments.

"To pencilled pensiveness and coloured sorrow;"

pencilled pensiveness: Sadness and deep thought depicted in the painting she is looking at

Here feelingly she weeps Troy’s painted woes,
For sorrow, like a heavy-hanging bell,
Once set on ringing, with his own weight goes;
Then little strength rings out the doleful knell.
So Lucrece set a-work, sad tales doth tell
To pencilled pensiveness and coloured sorrow;
She lends them words, and she their looks doth borrow.

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coloured sorrow: The painted or represented sorrow in the artwork, emphasizing the visual aspect of her grief.
Meaning: She is directing her grief towards the representation of sorrow in the painting, engaging with it as a form of catharsis. She's essentially talking to the artwork.

"She lends them words, and she their looks doth borrow."

lends them words: Lucrece gives the painted figures her own words to express their suffering.
she their looks doth borrow: She internalizes the expressions of sorrow from the artwork,
reflecting them in her own face and demeanor.
Meaning: There's a reciprocal exchange between Lucrece and the artwork. She gives the painted figures her voice, and they, in turn, give her their visual representation of grief, allowing her to embody and express her own pain. She is both projecting onto the art and being influenced by it.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza describes how Lucrece, overwhelmed by her rape, finds a conduit for her grief in a painting of the Trojan War. The opening lines establish a powerful simile likening sorrow to a heavy bell: once it starts ringing, it continues with minimal effort, its own momentum sustaining it. This metaphor explains how Lucrece becomes immersed in her grief, unable to stop the process.

She empathizes with the depicted suffering of Troy, projecting her own pain onto the images. A reciprocal relationship develops: she gives words to the painted figures' sorrow, giving them voice, and in turn, she embodies their expressions, visually representing her own internal suffering. This highlights the power of art to both evoke and reflect profound human emotions. It emphasizes the cyclical and self-perpetuating nature of grief and the way it can consume someone once it takes hold. Ultimately, it shows Lucrece grappling with her trauma, seeking a language and a form to express the unspeakable.

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← Stanza 214📚 OverviewStanza 216 →

Stanza 215 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 215 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices, and then give an overall interpretation of the stanza within the context of the poem.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"She throws her eyes about the painting round,"

Meaning: Lucrece is frantically looking around at the artwork that is decorating the room where she was raped.
Literary Devices: Alliteration with "about" and "about"; Visual imagery - we can picture her frantic gaze.
"And who she finds forlorn she doth lament."

Meaning: She feels sympathy for the figures in the painting that appear sad and despondent. She identifies with their sorrow.
Literary Devices: Empathy - shows Lucrece's sensitive and compassionate nature.

"At last she sees a wretched image bound,"

Meaning: Finally, her attention is drawn to a specific picture of a miserable figure who is tied up (bound).
Literary Devices: Suspense - the word "At last" makes the reader wonder who it is she sees. Visual Imagery - The image of someone bound evokes feelings of powerlessness and entrapment.

"That piteous looks to Phrygian shepherds lent."

Meaning: This figure is depicted with a pitiful expression that is directed towards the Trojan (Phrygian) shepherds.
Literary Devices: Allusion - The mention of Phrygian shepherds is an allusion to the story of Paris, who was raised as a shepherd but was really a prince of Troy. Imagery - "Piteous looks" further reinforces the emotion of the scene.

"His face, though full of cares, yet showed content;"

Meaning: Despite the anxiety and suffering evident in his face, he seems to be at peace or resigned to his fate. This is a crucial point, as it seems contradictory.
Literary Devices: Paradox/Oxymoron - The combination of "full of cares" and "showed content" is paradoxical; they are contrasting elements. This highlights the character's inner strength and resilience (or perhaps resignation).

"Onward to Troy with the blunt swains he goes,"

Meaning: He is headed toward Troy with the simple (blunt) shepherds.
Literary Devices: Visual Imagery - we can picture the journey to Troy.

"So mild, that patience seemed to scorn his woes."

Meaning: He is so gentle and accepting of his suffering that even patience itself seems to think he is not bothered by it. He endures with such tranquility.

She throws her eyes about the painting round,
And who she finds forlorn she doth lament.
At last she sees a wretched image bound,
That piteous looks to Phrygian shepherds lent.
His face, though full of cares, yet showed content; Onward to Troy with the blunt swains he goes,
So mild, that patience seemed to scorn his woes.

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Literary Devices: Personification - "Patience" is given a human attribute (scorn). Hyperbole -
The exaggeration that "patience seemed to scorn his woes" emphasizes his extraordinary level of endurance.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza describes Lucrece's attempt to distract herself from her trauma by observing a painting. The image she fixates on is that of Paris being led to Troy. Paris is shown with a face full of cares yet also displaying content, suggesting he accepts his fate. The image of Paris, a prince raised as a shepherd, going to Troy despite his implied knowledge of the doom that awaits his city, offers a parallel to Lucrece's own situation. She, too, is a victim facing an impossible situation, grappling with pain and a sense of impending doom.

The Significance of Paris: The allusion to Paris is significant because his actions ultimately led to the Trojan War and the destruction of Troy. By focusing on Paris, Shakespeare is suggesting that Lucrece is also at the center of a tragic event, one with potentially devastating consequences. The "cares" on Paris' face may be anticipation of that future suffering.

Lucrece's Identification: Lucrece identifies with Paris's suffering and perhaps sees in him a model of how to face her own ordeal – with a kind of stoic acceptance, even though she's deeply affected. The stanza suggests that Lucrece might strive to emulate this character's ability to endure hardship with a semblance of serenity.

Foreshadowing: The focus on a character associated with the fall of Troy may also foreshadow Lucrece's own tragic end and the turmoil that will erupt as a result of her rape.

In essence, this stanza offers a brief respite from the intense emotional turmoil of Lucrece, but it also serves to deepen the tragic mood and foreshadow the devastating events to come. The image of Paris functions as a mirror reflecting Lucrece's own predicament and providing her (and the reader) with a glimpse of the qualities needed to endure such a profound crisis.

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← Stanza 215📚 OverviewStanza 217 →

Stanza 216 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 216 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"In him the painter laboured with his skill":

Meaning: "In him" refers to Tarquin. A "painter" is figuratively used here to represent someone trying to create a false impression. The phrase suggests a deliberate and skillful effort to
construct a deceptive façade. Tarquin is, in essence, painting a false image of himself.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (Tarquin is compared to a painter), Personification (skill is a quality applied to the painter).

"To hide deceit and give the harmless show":

Meaning: The purpose of this "painting" is to conceal his true, deceitful intentions and present an innocent or harmless outward appearance. "Show" refers to the external image or performance he is putting on.
Literary Devices: Alliteration ("harmless show")

"An humble gait, calm looks, eyes wailing still":

Meaning: Describes the specific elements of the façade. "Humble gait" means a modest or submissive way of walking. "Calm looks" suggests a composed and peaceful expression. "Eyes wailing still" is a powerful image of feigned sorrow, indicating a false empathy. The word "still" suggests a quiet, simmering sorrow, adding to the deceptive effect.
Literary Devices: Imagery (creates a vivid picture of his deceptive appearance).
"A brow unbent that seemed to welcome woe":

Meaning: An "unbent brow" indicates a lack of worry or stress. He's projecting an attitude of accepting sorrow as if it were a natural part of his being. This adds to the false impression of innocence or resignation.
Literary Devices: Irony (he's the cause of the woe, yet appears to welcome it).

"Cheeks neither red nor pale, but mingled so":

Meaning: His complexion is carefully modulated, not betraying the obvious signs of guilt (redness) or fear (paleness). The mixture is carefully controlled to avoid revealing his true emotions.

Literary Devices: Imagery, Balance (the "neither...nor" structure emphasizes the deliberate control).

"That blushing red no guilty instance gave":

Meaning: There is no flush of embarrassment or guilt to give him away, indicating a controlled facade.
Literary Devices: Alliteration ("guilty gave")

In him the painter laboured with his skill
To hide deceit and give the harmless show
An humble gait, calm looks, eyes wailing still,
A brow unbent that seemed to welcome woe, Cheeks neither red nor pale, but mingled so That blushing red no guilty instance gave,
Nor ashy pale the fear that false hearts have.

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"Nor ashy pale the fear that false hearts have.":

Meaning: There is also no pallor of fear betraying a conscience wracked with guilt. "False hearts" refers to those with deceptive intentions.
Literary Devices: Imagery, Alliteration ("false fear").

Overall Meaning:

The stanza describes Tarquin's deliberate and skillful attempt to create a deceptive outward appearance to mask his true, malevolent intentions. He carefully cultivates an image of humility, calmness, and sorrow to gain Lucrece's trust and disarm her suspicions. He avoids any physical or emotional cues that might betray his guilt or fear, presenting a meticulously crafted façade of innocence. The stanza emphasizes the duplicity and cold calculation behind Tarquin's actions, foreshadowing the terrible events to come.

In essence, the stanza is a powerful commentary on the art of deception and how appearances can be meticulously crafted to conceal the darkest of intentions.

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← Stanza 216📚 OverviewStanza 218 →

Stanza 217 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 217 of Shakespeare's 'The Rape of Lucrece' line by line, identify literary devices, and then synthesize it into an overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"But, like a constant and confirmed devil,"

Constant and confirmed – emphasizes the fixed and unwavering nature of his evil.
Devil – a powerful and direct metaphor for Tarquin. It establishes him as a personification of evil
and temptation.
Simile: He is being compared to a devil.

"He entertained a show so seeming just,"

Entertained a show – He put on an act. This suggests deception and calculated behavior. Show is a metaphor for his outward appearance of respectability.
So seeming just – The act was very convincing. Seeming just is an appearance of moral rectitude.
Alliteration: the repetition of the 's' sound in 'show so seeming' creates a smooth, almost deceptive sound effect, mirroring Tarquin's deceptive behavior.

"And therein so ensconced his secret evil,"

Therein – Referring to the "show so seeming just."
Ensconced – Meaning hidden or sheltered. His evil was deeply embedded and concealed within this facade of justice.
Secret evil – The nature of his evil intentions, which are yet to be revealed fully, is hidden. Alliteration: the repetition of the 's' sound in 'so ensconced his secret' creates a smooth, almost deceptive sound effect, mirroring Tarquin's deceptive behavior.

"That jealousy itself could not mistrust"

Jealousy itself – Jealousy is personified here. Jealousy is often suspicious and mistrustful, but even it would not suspect what Tarquin is plotting.
Could not mistrust – Even the most suspicious of emotions would be fooled by Tarquin's deception.

"False-creeping craft and perjury should thrust"

False-creeping craft – Deceptive and insidious tactics. False-creeping is an alliterative phrase suggesting slow, stealthy movement of evil.
Perjury – Lying under oath, or more broadly, a betrayal of trust and vows.
Thrust – A violent and sudden action. It foreshadows the act of rape that is to come.

"Into so bright a day such black-faced storms,"

So bright a day – Represents Lucrece's innocence, virtue, and the peaceful setting. It also suggests a clear and unsuspecting atmosphere.

But, like a constant and confirmed devil,
He entertained a show so seeming just,
And therein so ensconced his secret evil,
That jealousy itself could not mistrust
False-creeping craft and perjury should thrust Into so bright a day such black-faced storms,
Or blot with hell-born sin such saint-like forms.

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Black-faced storms – Represents the evil, corruption, and violence that Tarquin is about to unleash. The contrast between "bright" and "black" emphasizes the shocking nature of his
actions.
Metaphor: Lucrece's innocence and virtue are being compared to a bright day, while Tarquin's evil is being compared to a black-faced storm.

"Or blot with hell-born sin such saint-like forms."

Blot – To stain or defile.
Hell-born sin – Evil that originates from hell. It further emphasizes the diabolical nature of
Tarquin's intentions.
Saint-like forms – Refers to Lucrece's appearance of purity and goodness.
Alliteration: the repetition of the 's' sound in 'sin such saint-like' emphasizes the shock of tainting something pure and innocent with evil.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza paints a picture of Tarquin as a master deceiver. He meticulously crafts an outward appearance of honor and righteousness, so convincing that even the most suspicious of minds (personified as jealousy) would not suspect the evil he harbors. His intentions are to corrupt and defile something pure and innocent ("bright day," "saint-like forms") with his diabolical ("hell-born sin") actions. The stanza builds tension by foreshadowing the act of violence and betrayal to come, highlighting the contrast between Tarquin's facade and his true, evil nature. The language is deliberately dramatic and evocative, using powerful imagery to convey the magnitude of the impending tragedy.

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← Stanza 217📚 OverviewStanza 219 →

Stanza 218 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 218 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then synthesize the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"The well-skilled workman this mild image drew"

Meaning: A talented artist depicted a gentle, innocent-looking image (of Sinon).
Literary Devices:
Epithet: "Well-skilled workman" is a descriptive adjective phrase used to characterize the
artist.
Imagery: The word "drew" suggests a visual image.

"For perjured Sinon, whose enchanting story"

Meaning: The artist created the image to represent Sinon, who was a liar and a deceiver, but whose tale was captivating and persuasive.
Literary Devices:
Epithet: "Perjured Sinon" identifies Sinon with his deceitfulness.
Allusion: Sinon is a reference to a character from Greek mythology (Trojan War), known for tricking the Trojans into accepting the Trojan Horse.

"The credulous Old Priam after slew;"

Meaning: Old King Priam, being easily deceived, believed Sinon's lies, which ultimately led to his own death (after the sack of Troy, he was killed).
Literary Devices:
Epithet: "Credulous Old Priam" emphasizes Priam's gullibility and age.
Allusion: Refers to Priam, the king of Troy.

"Whose words like wildfire burnt the shining glory"

Meaning: Sinon's deceptive words spread rapidly and destructively, consuming the magnificent and glorious city.
Literary Devices:
Simile: "Words like wildfire" compares the destructive power of Sinon's lies to the uncontrolled spread of a fire.
Metaphor: Sinon's words are metaphorically seen as fire.
Imagery: "Burnt," "shining glory" evoke vivid images of destruction.

"Of rich-built Ilion, that the skies were sorry,"

Meaning: The destruction of the beautifully constructed city of Troy (Ilion) was so catastrophic that even the heavens mourned it.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "The skies were sorry" gives human emotions to the natural world.
Allusion: "Ilion" is another name for Troy.
Hyperbole: Exaggeration to emphasize the severity of the city's destruction.

The well-skilled workman this mild image drew
For perjured Sinon, whose enchanting story
The credulous Old Priam after slew;
Whose words like wildfire burnt the shining glory
Of rich-built Ilion, that the skies were sorry,
And little stars shot from their fixed places,
When their glass fell wherein they viewed their faces.

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"And little stars shot from their fixed places,"

Meaning: The universe itself was disrupted by the tragedy, with stars seemingly falling from the sky in response to the devastation.
Literary Devices:
Imagery: "Stars shot from their fixed places" creates a striking visual image of cosmic disturbance.
Hyperbole: The stars falling from the sky is obviously an exaggeration, serving to emphasize the magnitude of the tragedy.

"When their glass fell wherein they viewed their faces."

Meaning: The "glass" is likely a metaphor for the heavens itself, reflecting the beauty and order of the world. When Troy fell, this reflection was shattered, representing a loss of harmony and a distortion of reality. The stars and other celestial bodies are seen as having their own reflections, and the destruction of Troy shattered these reflections.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Glass" represents the cosmos, the heavens.
Symbolism: The shattering of the glass symbolizes the shattering of order, beauty, and the
proper reflection of reality.
Imagery: The image of a shattered mirror is powerful and evokes a sense of loss.

Overall Meaning:

Stanza 218 uses the well-known story of Sinon and the fall of Troy to illustrate the power of deception and the catastrophic consequences that can result from it. The artist who drew Sinon's "mild image" inadvertently contributed to the tragedy by portraying a deceptive figure in a way that concealed his true nature. Sinon's lies, like a wildfire, consumed the glorious city of Troy, causing such profound devastation that even the heavens mourned, and the cosmos itself seemed to be disrupted. The shattered "glass" symbolizes the utter destruction of Troy's beauty and order, and the distorted reflection represents the triumph of deception over truth. This stanza serves as a cautionary tale about the dangers of credulity and the far-reaching consequences of deceit. It connects to the larger themes of The Rape of Lucrece by highlighting the destructive potential of lies and injustice, and foreshadows the tragic events that will unfold as a result of Tarquin's actions.

Key Takeaways:

Deception's Power: The stanza emphasizes how persuasive lies can be and how easily they can lead to destruction.
Consequences of Gullibility: Priam's credulity is directly linked to the fall of Troy, demonstrating the dangers of naiveté.
Cosmic Significance: The imagery of the skies and stars underscores the magnitude of the tragedy, suggesting that the destruction of Troy had profound implications beyond the human realm.
Loss of Innocence and Order: The broken "glass" symbolizes the shattered beauty and harmony of the world due to deceit and violence.

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← Stanza 218📚 OverviewStanza 220 →

Stanza 219 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 219 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then synthesize it for an overall meaning:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"This picture she advisedly perused,"

"This picture": Refers to a picture Lucrece is looking at, depicting the Trojan War. Specifically, it portrays Sinon deceiving the Trojans to let the wooden horse into the city.
"she advisedly": "Advisedly" means thoughtfully, carefully, deliberately. Lucrece is not just glancing at the picture; she is studying it intently and with purpose.
"perused": Examined in detail; scrutinized.
Meaning: Lucrece carefully and thoughtfully examined the picture.

"And chid the painter for his wondrous skill,"
"chid": Scolded or rebuked.
"the painter": The artist who created the picture.
"wondrous skill": Amazing artistic ability.
Meaning: Lucrece scolds the painter for being so good at his craft. This is ironic; she is not truly angry with the painter's skill, but rather with the depiction of evil he has captured.

"Saying some shape in Sinon’s was abused;"

"some shape in Sinon's": A certain aspect of Sinon's physical appearance (in the painting). "abused": Misrepresented or wrongly used.
Meaning: She says that something about the way Sinon is portrayed in the picture is wrong. His image has been misrepresented.

"So fair a form lodged not a mind so ill."

"So fair a form": Such a beautiful or handsome appearance. "Form" refers to his physical shape and features.
"lodged not a mind so ill": Could not contain such an evil mind. The physical appearance does not reflect the evilness within.
Meaning: She believes that someone with such a handsome face couldn't possibly have such a wicked mind. This is a statement about the perceived relationship between outward appearance and inner character. It plays on the common (but often incorrect) assumption that beauty reflects goodness.

"And still on him she gazed, and gazing still,"

"still": Continuously, constantly.
"gazed, and gazing still": She continues to stare at him.
Meaning: She continues to gaze at the portrait of Sinon. The repetition of "still" emphasizes the intensity and duration of her gaze.

This picture she advisedly perused,
And chid the painter for his wondrous skill,
Saying some shape in Sinon’s was abused;
So fair a form lodged not a mind so ill.
And still on him she gazed, and gazing still, Such signs of truth in his plain face she spied, That she concludes the picture was belied.

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"Such signs of truth in his plain face she spied,"

"signs of truth": Evidence or indications of honesty and sincerity.
"plain face": Sinon's face is described as plain, suggesting a lack of overt evil in his features. It could also indicate a certain perceived innocence or lack of artifice.
"spied": Saw or detected.
Meaning: She thinks she sees signs of truthfulness and sincerity in his simple, unassuming face.

"That she concludes the picture was belied."

"concludes": Decides; comes to the judgment.
"belied": Falsely represented or misrepresented.
Meaning: Because of what she sees in his face, she decides that the picture has misrepresented Sinon's true nature. She believes the picture is lying about him.

Overall Meaning and Literary Devices:

The stanza is about Lucrece's internal struggle as she looks at a painting of Sinon. She is grappling with the idea that someone who appears outwardly handsome and perhaps even innocent could be capable of such deception and evil.

Here are the key takeaways and literary devices:

Appearance vs. Reality: This is the central theme. Lucrece struggles to reconcile Sinon's seemingly "fair form" with his evil deeds. The stanza explores the deceptive nature of appearances. Irony: The second line presents situational irony. She scolds the painter for his "wondrous skill,"
but she is actually disturbed by the accurate portrayal of evil.
Character Development: This stanza provides insight into Lucrece's character. She is portrayed as someone who instinctively believes in the goodness of people, or at least struggles to accept that outward appearance can mask inner depravity. Her reaction shows her naivety and virtue, which will ultimately make her fall even more tragic.
Foreshadowing: While Lucrece thinks the picture is lying about Sinon, we, the audience, know that it isn't. Sinon was deceptive and evil. This creates dramatic irony and subtly foreshadows Lucrece's own deception by Tarquin. She is projecting her own desire to see goodness onto Sinon, which mirrors how she will be deceived by Tarquin's seemingly honorable exterior.
Repetition: The repetition of "still" emphasizes the intensity and duration of Lucrece's gaze and
her preoccupation with the picture.
Juxtaposition: The juxtaposition of "fair form" and "mind so ill" highlights the contradiction that Lucrece is struggling with.

In essence, this stanza reveals Lucrece's innocent perception of the world and sets the stage for her own tragic encounter with deception and evil. She is unable to comprehend that outward appearances can be deeply misleading, a flaw that Tarquin will exploit. This moment reveals a critical aspect of her character and foreshadows her tragic fate.
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← Stanza 219📚 OverviewStanza 221 →

Stanza 220 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 220 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then analyze the overall meaning, paying attention to literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"It cannot be," quoth she, "that so much guile—":

"It cannot be": This is the start of Lucrece's thought process. She is resisting the idea that someone who looks so noble (Tarquin) could be capable of deceit.
"quoth she": A standard Elizabethan way of saying "said she."
"that so much guile—": "Guile" means cunning, deceit, treachery. She's halting mid-sentence, about to express her disbelief that such a deceptive nature could exist. The em-dash indicates an interruption.
She would have said "can lurk in such a look.":

This line reveals the original intention of Lucrece's thought. She intended to say that "guile can lurk in such a look," meaning someone who looks innocent/trustworthy could be deceiving.

But Tarquin’s shape came in her mind the while,:

"Tarquin's shape": Refers to the image of Tarquin, probably his physical appearance (handsome, powerful) and the impression he gives off.
"came in her mind the while": While she's speaking, his image floods her thoughts, disrupting her initial line of thinking. This suggests he's more insidious than she first thought, as her mind's eye is already associating Tarquin with guilt.

And from her tongue "can lurk" from "cannot" took.:

This is a crucial and clever line, showing the shift in Lucrece's thinking and the power of the image of Tarquin. Because his image has taken over her mind, the words "can lurk" come forth from the words she had already said, "cannot be." In other words, the image of Tarquin has literally altered the words as they left her lips.

"It cannot be" she in that sense forsook,:

"It cannot be" she in that sense forsook She abandons the initial meaning of “It cannot be,” and the line's repetition emphasizes her internal struggle. It shows she actively rejects the initial meaning. "Forsook" means abandoned or rejected.

And turned it thus: “It cannot be, I find,:

She re-contextualizes what she's saying, pivoting to a different conclusion.
"It cannot be, I find": She's still using the same initial words ("It cannot be"), but giving them
a new meaning.
But such a face should bear a wicked mind.

"But such a face should bear a wicked mind": This is the final, transformed statement. She's now saying: "It is inevitable that such a beautiful (or imposing, noble-seeming) face should

“It cannot be,” quoth she, “that so much guile”—
She would have said “can lurk in such a look.”
But Tarquin’s shape came in her mind the while,
And from her tongue “can lurk” from “cannot” took.
“It cannot be” she in that sense forsook,
And turned it thus: “It cannot be, I find,
But such a face should bear a wicked mind.

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conceal a wicked mind." She has convinced herself that Tarquin's appearance is merely a mask
for his evil intentions.

Overall Meaning and Literary Devices:

This stanza encapsulates the crucial shift in Lucrece's perception of Tarquin. She begins with a naive (or hopeful) resistance to believing that someone who looks good could be evil. But the vivid image of Tarquin overwhelms her, and the very words she utters are altered by his influence. She ultimately accepts that his outward appearance is a deceptive facade for a wicked heart.

Here are some key literary devices at play:

Apostrophe: The stanza is addressed to the reader, allowing a more immediate understanding of Lucrece's thoughts.
Repetition: The repeated "It cannot be" highlights the internal conflict and the dramatic change in meaning.
Internal Conflict: The entire stanza is a representation of Lucrece's internal struggle. She grapples with her initial disbelief and her growing realization of Tarquin's capacity for evil. Imagery: The "shape" of Tarquin, which disrupts her train of thought, is powerful visual imagery. Wordplay/Pun: The line "And from her tongue 'can lurk' from 'cannot' took" is a clever play on words. The phrase "can lurk" is literally extracted from the word "cannot," mirroring the extraction of her innocence and peace of mind by Tarquin.
Irony: The fact that she starts by denying the possibility of guile in a handsome face, but ends by accepting it, is deeply ironic, especially given the tragic events to come.
Foreshadowing: The shift in her perception foreshadows the tragic events of the poem, hinting that Tarquin's evil nature will be revealed. It's a moment of dramatic irony, as the reader already knows what Tarquin is capable of.

In essence, this stanza is a masterclass in Shakespeare's ability to portray psychological complexity. It shows how quickly a person's perception can be altered and how appearances can be deceiving. It highlights the corrupting influence of Tarquin and the tragic fate awaiting Lucrece.

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← Stanza 220📚 OverviewStanza 222 →

Stanza 221 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"For even as subtle Sinon here is painted,"

Literal Meaning: Just as the cunning Sinon is depicted in this painting (presumably a painting
that is present in Lucrece's house).
Literary Devices:
Allusion: This line refers to Sinon, a Greek character from the Trojan War. Sinon tricked the
Trojans into bringing the Trojan Horse inside their city walls. He pretended to be a deserter and claimed the horse was an offering to the gods. This allusion immediately sets up a parallel between Sinon's deception and Tarquin's.
Imagery: The word "painted" creates a visual image and suggests that Sinon's deceit is not
just a matter of words, but also of carefully crafted appearance.

"So sober-sad, so weary, and so mild,"

Literal Meaning: Sinon appears to be serious, sad, tired, and gentle. These are all characteristics that mask his true intentions.

Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the "s" sound in "sober-sad" creates a soft, deceptive effect. Asyndeton: The omission of conjunctions (like "and") between "sober-sad, so weary, and so mild" creates a sense of quick accumulation of deceptive qualities.
Imagery: These adjectives paint a picture of a man who inspires pity and trust.

"As if with grief or travail he had fainted,"

Literal Meaning: He looks as though he's exhausted and weak from sorrow or hard work. This emphasizes his vulnerability, which is part of his trickery.
Literary Devices:
Simile: The use of "as if" creates a comparison, suggesting that Sinon's appearance is deliberately misleading.

"To me came Tarquin armed too, beguiled"

Literal Meaning: Tarquin, like Sinon, arrived at Lucrece's home wearing a mask. He was seemingly tricked by (or tricked people into thinking) he was honest.
Literary Devices:
Parallel Structure: The connection between Sinon and Tarquin is reinforced. "To me came Tarquin" mirrors the implied arrival of Sinon through the painting.
Juxtaposition: "Armed" is a key word, juxtaposed with "beguiled". This highlights the hidden threat beneath the surface of innocence.

"With outward honesty, but yet defiled"

Literal Meaning: He presented an appearance of honesty, but was actually corrupted and morally tainted inside.

“For even as subtle Sinon here is painted,
So sober-sad, so weary, and so mild,
As if with grief or travail he had fainted,
To me came Tarquin armed too, beguiled
With outward honesty, but yet defiled
With inward vice. As Priam him did cherish, So did I Tarquin; so my Troy did perish.

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Literary Devices:
Antithesis: "Outward honesty" and "inward vice" create a direct contrast, emphasizing the hypocrisy of Tarquin.

"With inward vice. As Priam him did cherish,"

Literal Meaning: Just as King Priam of Troy trusted and welcomed Sinon into his city,
Literary Devices:
Allusion: Continues the allusion to the Trojan War, solidifying the parallel between Sinon's deception and Tarquin's actions.
Simile: "As Priam him did cherish" uses "as" to draw a direct comparison.

"So did I Tarquin; so my Troy did perish."

Literal Meaning: So too, did I (Lucrece) trust and welcome Tarquin; and as a result, my virtue (my "Troy") was destroyed/ruined.
Literary Devices:
Parallel Structure: Mirrors the previous line ("As Priam him did cherish / So did I Tarquin"). Metaphor: Lucrece's virtue/honor/chastity is equated with the city of Troy. The destruction of
Troy symbolizes the loss of her honor.
Anaphora: The repetition of "So" emphasizes the parallel between Priam's mistake and
Lucrece's.
Irony: The destruction of Troy came from within, from misplaced trust. Similarly, Lucrece's destruction comes from within her own household, from a guest she trusted.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece draws a parallel between herself and the Trojans, and between Tarquin and Sinon. The painting of Sinon reminds her that she, like Priam, was deceived by outward appearances. Tarquin, like Sinon, pretended to be trustworthy, but was secretly harboring evil intentions. Just as Sinon's deception led to the fall of Troy, Lucrece's misplaced trust in Tarquin led to the destruction of her own personal "Troy," meaning her virtue and honor. The stanza highlights the dangers of trusting appearances and the devastating consequences of deception. It underscores Lucrece's sense of responsibility (or at least, her perception of responsibility) for the tragedy that has befallen her. She sees herself as having made a fatal error in judgment. The stanza is filled with a sense of foreboding and tragic irony.

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← Stanza 221📚 OverviewStanza 223 →

Stanza 222 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 222 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece," line by line, and then consider the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Look, look, how listening Priam wets his eyes,"

Breakdown: This line starts with an urgent call to attention ("Look, look!"). It then describes Priam, the king of Troy, being moved to tears as he listens to Sinon. "Wets his eyes" means he's crying.
Literary Device: Repetition ("Look, look") emphasizes the urgency. Imagery is created with the visual of Priam's tearful eyes.

"To see those borrowed tears that Sinon sheds!"

Breakdown: This line reveals the source of Priam's sadness: he's moved by the tears that Sinon is shedding. The key word here is "borrowed," meaning that Sinon's tears are fake, insincere, and being used to deceive.
Literary Device: Metaphor: Sinon's tears are described as "borrowed," highlighting their artificiality.

"Priam, why art thou old and yet not wise?"

Breakdown: This is a direct address to Priam. It's a rhetorical question lamenting his lack of wisdom, especially considering his age. The implication is that Priam should be experienced enough to see through Sinon's deception.
Literary Device: Rhetorical Question: The question doesn't seek an answer but is meant to emphasize Priam's folly. Apostrophe: Direct address to someone not present.

"For every tear he falls a Trojan bleeds."

Breakdown: This line highlights the disastrous consequence of Priam's credulity. Each tear that Sinon sheds, because it convinces Priam, leads to the death and suffering of a Trojan. The cost of the deception is emphasized, as the tears directly cause the death of Priam's people.
Literary Device: Metaphor: The connection between Sinon's tears and Trojan bloodshed is metaphorical. Alliteration with "For" and "Falls".

"His eye drops fire, no water thence proceeds;"

Breakdown: This provides a more direct description of Sinon. His tears are not water, but rather fire. It emphasizes the burning intent to destroy.
Literary Device: Metaphor: Eye drops fire, meaning that Sinon's words are destructive, not sorrowful.

"Those round clear pearls of his that move thy pity,"

Breakdown: This line describes the tears again, this time using a contrasting image of "round clear pearls". The language is beautiful and alluring, but is juxtaposed with the destructive intent of the tears.

“Look, look, how listening Priam wets his eyes,
To see those borrowed tears that Sinon sheds!
Priam, why art thou old and yet not wise?
For every tear he falls a Trojan bleeds.
His eye drops fire, no water thence proceeds;
Those round clear pearls of his that move thy pity, Are balls of quenchless fire to burn thy city.

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Literary Device: Metaphor: The tears are compared to "round clear pearls," emphasizing their apparent beauty and value, which is ironic given their falseness. Imagery is evoked with the description of the pearls.

"Are balls of quenchless fire to burn thy city."

Breakdown: This is the final and most forceful statement. The "pearls" of tears are revealed to
be something deadly: "balls of quenchless fire" that will destroy Troy. "Quenchless" emphasizes
the unstoppable nature of the coming destruction.
Literary Device: Metaphor: The tears are once again "balls of quenchless fire," solidifying the image of destruction.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza, in the context of "The Rape of Lucrece", is a lament and a warning. It expresses outrage at Priam's foolishness in believing Sinon's lies. It foreshadows the destruction of Troy as a direct consequence of this gullibility. The stanza uses powerful imagery and metaphors to convey the deadly nature of deception, contrasting the beautiful appearance of Sinon's tears with their fiery and destructive reality.

The overarching message is that appearances can be deceiving, and that a lack of wisdom, especially in leaders, can lead to catastrophic consequences. It is a cautionary tale about the importance of discernment and the devastating power of manipulation.

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← Stanza 222📚 OverviewStanza 224 →

Stanza 223 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 223 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line and then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Such devils steal effects from lightless hell,"

Analysis: This line establishes the demonic nature of deceit. "Lightless hell" emphasizes the utter darkness and absence of goodness from which these evil influences originate. "Effects" is vague
but most probably refers to things or people which have been affected by the devilish deception. Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The devils are symbols of falsehood and evil, metaphorically stealing influence from hell.

Imagery: "Lightless hell" provides a stark and vivid image of darkness and despair.

"For Sinon in his fire doth quake with cold,"

Analysis: This introduces Sinon, the Greek who tricked the Trojans into accepting the Trojan Horse. The phrase "in his fire doth quake with cold" describes an unnatural and paradoxical state. Sinon is consumed by the "fire" of his deceit and malicious intent, yet he simultaneously "quakes with cold," possibly indicating his own internal guilt, fear, or the chilling nature of his deception. Literary Devices:
Allusion: Sinon is a well-known figure from classical literature (the Aeneid).
Paradox: The oxymoronic phrase "fire doth quake with cold" highlights the self-contradictory nature of Sinon's actions and perhaps his own internal state.

"And in that cold hot-burning fire doth dwell."

Analysis: This line is a reiteration and expansion of the previous line, further emphasizing the paradoxical nature of Sinon's situation. It suggests that the "cold" fear or calculation and the "hot-burning fire" of his malice are intertwined and inseparable.
Literary Devices:
Paradox: Continues the paradox of opposing elements existing together.
Repetition (of the concept): The rephrasing of the previous line amplifies the paradoxical image.

"These contraries such unity do hold,"

Analysis: This line generalizes the specific case of Sinon, stating that such contradictions and oppositions (like cold and fire, honesty and deception) can, strangely, exist in a state of unity. This unity is the deceptive appearance that hides the true evil.
Literary Devices:
Abstract Language: "Contraries" and "unity" are abstract concepts.

"Only to flatter fools and make them bold;"

Analysis: This explains why these contradictions can exist in unity: to deceive and embolden the foolish. The purpose of the illusion, the unified appearance of opposites, is to manipulate those

“Such devils steal effects from lightless hell,
For Sinon in his fire doth quake with cold,
And in that cold hot-burning fire doth dwell.
These contraries such unity do hold,
Only to flatter fools and make them bold;
So Priam’s trust false Sinon’s tears doth flatter, That he finds means to burn his Troy with water.”

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who are naive and make them confident in their false beliefs. "Bold" here likely means reckless or overconfident.
Literary Devices:
Irony: It's ironic that the goal is to make fools "bold," as boldness should be based on truth,
not deception.

"So Priam’s trust false Sinon’s tears doth flatter,"

Analysis: This line brings the argument back to the specific example of Sinon and Priam. Priam, the king of Troy, "trusts" Sinon (believes his lies). Sinon's deceptive "tears" ("flatter" in this context means to deceive or beguile) lull Priam into a false sense of security. The tears are a performance.
Literary Devices:
Allusion: Continues the allusion to the Trojan War.

"That he finds means to burn his Troy with water."

Analysis: This is the final consequence of the deception. Because Priam trusts Sinon's false tears, Sinon finds a way to destroy Troy. The phrase "burn his Troy with water" is another paradox. Water is typically used to extinguish fire, not cause it. It represents the deceptive means (the tears, the false story) by which Sinon achieves his destructive goal. It alludes to the Trojan Horse.
Literary Devices:
Paradox: "Burn his Troy with water" is a final, powerful paradox encapsulating the deceptive nature of the events.
Imagery: The burning of Troy is a powerful image of destruction.
Metonymy/Synecdoche: "Water" stands in for Sinon's deceitful actions.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza explores the deceptive power of appearances. It argues that evil forces can create a false unity between contradictory elements in order to manipulate and deceive those who are foolish and trusting. The example of Sinon and Priam serves as a cautionary tale about the dangers of taking things at face value and highlights the devastating consequences of being blinded by deception. The paradoxes within the stanza underscore the unnatural and perverse nature of deceit, demonstrating how falsehood can twist and pervert the natural order.

Key Literary Devices Summarized:

Metaphor: To convey abstract ideas and create imagery.
Allusion: To the classical story of Sinon and Priam, providing context and weight.
Paradox: To highlight the self-contradictory nature of deception and evil.
Imagery: To create vivid mental pictures that reinforce the themes.
Irony: Highlighting the contrast between what is expected and what actually happens. Repetition (of concepts): Amplifies the core idea.
Metonymy/Synecdoche: "Water" standing in for deceitful actions.

Shakespeare uses these literary devices to create a powerful and insightful exploration of the destructive nature of deception and its ability to exploit human weaknesses.
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← Stanza 223📚 OverviewStanza 225 →

Stanza 224 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 224 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Here, all enraged, such passion her assails,"

Meaning: Lucrece, confronted with the image of Sinon, is overwhelmed by intense anger and emotions. The word "passion" here signifies intense suffering and feeling, more than just happiness or love. The word "assails" is a military term, suggesting the emotions are attacking and overpowering her.
Literary Devices: Personification (passion "assails" her, as if it were an attacker)

"That patience is quite beaten from her breast."

Meaning: Lucrece loses all composure and control. Her ability to endure the situation calmly is completely destroyed.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (patience is personified as something that can be "beaten" and driven away).

"She tears the senseless Sinon with her nails,"

Meaning: She attacks the tapestry or painting of Sinon, tearing at it with her fingernails. Sinon
is referred to as "senseless" because he is not real but an image. This physical action reflects her inner turmoil.
Literary Devices: Imagery (vivid picture of her violent act).

"Comparing him to that unhappy guest"

Meaning: She equates Sinon with Tarquin, who has violated her. She identifies them as similar in their deceitful and destructive nature.
Literary Devices: Simile/Analogy (Comparing Sinon to Tarquin).
"Whose deed hath made herself herself detest."

Meaning: Tarquin's act (the rape) has caused Lucrece to despise herself. She feels tainted and responsible somehow for what happened. It highlights the deep shame and self-loathing she experiences.
Literary Devices: Repetition (herself herself) to emphasize the intensity of her self-hatred.

"At last she smilingly with this gives o’er;"

Meaning: Finally, she stops tearing at the image, seemingly with a faint smile. This smile is probably one of bitter irony or even bordering on madness, not genuine happiness. She gives over/stops the physical violence.
Literary Devices: Oxymoron (smilingly with the previous emotions of rage). Juxtaposition of intense emotion and this seemingly strange calmness or ironic acceptance.

"'Fool, fool!' quoth she, 'his wounds will not be sore.'"

Meaning: She dismisses the fact that she's tearing at the tapestry of Sinon, recognizing that it won't actually hurt him or Tarquin, who she equates him with. She knows her physical actions are

Here, all enraged, such passion her assails,
That patience is quite beaten from her breast.
She tears the senseless Sinon with her nails,
Comparing him to that unhappy guest
Whose deed hath made herself herself detest.
At last she smilingly with this gives o’er;
“Fool, fool!” quoth she, “his wounds will not be sore.”

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futile in addressing the real harm that has been done. The repetition of "Fool, fool!" emphasizes
her frustration and self-awareness of the inadequacy of her actions.
Literary Devices: Apostrophe (addressing Sinon directly). Irony (she knows tearing the image
is meaningless, but does it anyway). Repetition "Fool, fool" (highlights her inner turmoil).

Overall Meaning:

This stanza portrays Lucrece's overwhelming rage and despair after the rape. She channels her emotions into a physical attack on the image of Sinon, whom she equates with Tarquin and all that he represents. The act of tearing the tapestry is symbolic of her desire to strike back at her attacker. However, she ultimately realizes the futility of her actions, and her fleeting, almost mad smile and ironic exclamation emphasize the depth of her despair. The stanza explores the themes of rage, shame, self-hatred, and the inadequacy of physical revenge against the profound psychological damage she has suffered. The stanza highlights the internal conflict she is facing. Her actions are a manifestation of her helplessness and the crushing weight of her shame.

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Stanza 225 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece and analyze its meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Thus ebbs and flows the current of her sorrow,"

"Thus": Indicates a continuation of a thought, summarizing the preceding events/Lucrece's state
of mind.
"ebbs and flows": A metaphor comparing her sorrow to the tide. The tide goes in and out, and
so does her sorrow, suggesting its fluctuating nature. It isn't a constant, unyielding state of grief, but rather a cyclical one.
"the current of her sorrow": The intensity of her sadness is personified as a flowing current. Meaning: Her sorrow comes in waves, sometimes receding, sometimes overwhelming her. The "ebb and flow" implies the inconsistent and fluctuating nature of deep grief.

"And time doth weary time with her complaining."

"Time doth weary time": Personification and polyptoton. Time is given the human quality of being wearied or fatigued. The repetition of "time" emphasizes the drawn-out, monotonous nature of her suffering. Polyptoton is the repetition of a word in a different inflection to create emphasis.
"with her complaining": Her constant lamenting is so intense it seems even time itself is becoming exhausted.
Meaning: Her suffering is so pervasive that even time, normally an impartial and relentless
force, seems to grow weary and sluggish from her endless grieving.

"She looks for night, and then she longs for morrow,"

"She looks for night": She anticipates the darkness, potentially as a respite from her pain or as a veil to hide her shame.
"then she longs for morrow": Almost immediately after desiring night, she wishes for
morning.
Meaning: This highlights her inner turmoil and restlessness. She finds no peace or satisfaction in either day or night, trapped in a cycle of longing and discontent. It shows her instability.

"And both she thinks too long with her remaining."

"both": Refers to both night and morrow from the previous line.
"too long with her remaining": The day and night each feel endless.
Meaning: Neither the night nor the day offers solace, and both periods feel excruciatingly drawn out because she's so deep in despair. It emphasizes the subjective experience of time when suffering.

"Short time seems long in sorrow’s sharp sustaining."

"Short time seems long": A paradox. Logically, short time cannot be long, but in her grief, even brief moments feel extended and unbearable.
"sorrow's sharp sustaining": Grief is described as "sharp," implying a piercing pain, and "sustaining" suggests that it's a constant, unrelenting burden.

Thus ebbs and flows the current of her sorrow,
And time doth weary time with her complaining.
She looks for night, and then she longs for morrow,
And both she thinks too long with her remaining.
Short time seems long in sorrow’s sharp sustaining.
Though woe be heavy, yet it seldom sleeps,
And they that watch see time how slow it creeps.

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Meaning: Even a short period of suffering feels like an eternity. The pain of her grief distorts her perception of time.

"Though woe be heavy, yet it seldom sleeps,"

"woe be heavy": A metaphor where woe (sorrow) is described as a heavy weight.
"it seldom sleeps": Woe is personified as something that does not sleep.
Meaning: Although her suffering is a heavy burden, it's a constant, relentless presence. She finds no rest from her pain.

"And they that watch see time how slow it creeps."

"they that watch": Those who are alert, vigilant, and aware of their surroundings. In Lucrece's case, she is constantly aware of her pain and shame.
"see time how slow it creeps": Those who are actively enduring pain or suffering perceive
time as moving incredibly slowly.
Meaning: Those who are suffering and are constantly aware of their pain experience time as dragging on endlessly. This is the feeling of enduring a traumatic event.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

The stanza vividly illustrates the debilitating and distorted experience of time when one is consumed by profound grief and trauma. Lucrece is trapped in a cycle of despair, where even fleeting moments feel like an eternity. Time, usually an objective measure, becomes subjective and agonizingly slow for her. The "ebb and flow" of her sorrow, the weariness of time itself, and the relentless nature of her pain all contribute to a powerful depiction of her suffering. The stanza emphasizes the mental anguish and the crushing weight of her shame, showing how it warps her perception of reality. It highlights the psychological toll of her rape, portraying her as trapped in a prison of her own mind, with no escape from the torment.

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Stanza 226 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 226 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Which all this time hath overslipped her thought,"

Meaning: This refers to Lucrece’s immediate reaction after the rape where she has been
obsessing with imagined imagery rather than directly processing her trauma. The trauma of the
rape has been present in her mind the whole time, but her thought (conscious awareness, focus) has bypassed or "overslipped" the direct reality of it.
Literary Devices: Suggests how the mind can try to avoid facing harsh reality

"That she with painted images hath spent,"

Meaning: Lucrece has been focusing her attention on "painted images." These are not literal paintings, but rather vivid mental pictures. In the context of the poem, these images are her memories and reflections on other figures in the tapestry in her room, like Hecuba grieving over her lost family in the Trojan War. She is using these images as a way to distract herself from the horror.

Literary Devices: Metaphor (the "painted images" are mental pictures). Suggests the power of art and imagination to provide escape.

"Being from the feeling of her own grief brought"

Meaning: She is deliberately bringing herself away from directly experiencing her own grief. She is consciously, or perhaps semi-consciously, diverting her attention.
Literary Devices: Reinforces the idea of avoidance.

"By deep surmise of others’ detriment,"

Meaning: This line tells us how she's diverting her attention. She's doing it through "deep surmise of others' detriment." "Surmise" means guessing or conjecturing, and "detriment" means harm or suffering. So, she is deeply imagining, thinking about, and empathizing with the
suffering of others.
Literary Devices: Alliteration (deep, detriment). Emphasis on the effort Lucrece is putting into thinking about other's suffering.

"Losing her woes in shows of discontent."

Meaning: By focusing on the suffering of others, she manages to temporarily "lose" (or at least suppress) her own woes. She expresses "shows of discontent" – outward displays of unhappiness or dissatisfaction – about the situations of others. In other words, she is acting distraught about the plight of Hecuba or other tragic figures, as a way to avoid truly grappling with her own
tragedy.
Literary Devices: Paradox (losing her woes in shows). It's a paradox because she is outwardly expressing unhappiness while inwardly trying to avoid feeling it.

Which all this time hath overslipped her thought,
That she with painted images hath spent,
Being from the feeling of her own grief brought
By deep surmise of others’ detriment,
Losing her woes in shows of discontent.
It easeth some, though none it ever cured,
To think their dolour others have endured.

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"It easeth some, though none it ever cured,"

Meaning: This is a general statement about the human condition. Focusing on the troubles of others can provide temporary relief ("easeth") from one's own suffering, even though it doesn't offer a true, lasting solution ("cured").
Literary Devices: Aphorism (a general truth or observation about life, expressed concisely). Highlights the universal tendency for individuals to seek comfort in the misfortunes of others,
albeit without achieving complete healing.
"To think their dolour others have endured."

Meaning: It can be comforting to know that others have experienced similar pain ("dolour"). The knowledge that one is not alone in suffering can be a source of solace.
Literary Devices: Consonance (think, their). Reinforces the idea of shared experiences.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza explains Lucrece's initial reaction to the rape: a form of psychological defense mechanism. Instead of confronting the full horror of her experience directly, she initially diverts her attention by focusing on the suffering of others, particularly as depicted in the "painted images" (the tapestry) in her room. She finds a temporary, superficial solace in considering the pain endured by others, but the stanza also acknowledges that this is a temporary fix, not a lasting cure. Shakespeare is making a broader observation about human nature - how humans often avoid painful truths by finding distractions or rationalizations in the suffering of others, even though it ultimately doesn't truly heal them. This suggests a complex psychological understanding of trauma.

Key Literary Devices Used:

Metaphor: "Painted images" representing mental pictures/reflections.
Aphorism: "It easeth some, though none it ever cured, / To think their dolour others have endured."
Paradox: "Losing her woes in shows of discontent."
Alliteration: "Deep, detriment"
Consonance: "Think, their"
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Stanza 227 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 227 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"But now the mindful messenger, come back,"

Meaning: The messenger who was sent to bring Lucrece's husband, Collatinus, returns. The messenger is described as "mindful" meaning aware of the gravity of the situation or diligent in his duty.
Literary Devices: This is a relatively straightforward introduction of the return of Collatinus.

"Brings home his lord and other company;"

Meaning: The messenger brings Collatinus (Lucrece's husband) and his companions. This emphasizes that Collatinus isn't returning alone; he has support or witnesses with him.
Literary Devices: Again, fairly direct exposition.

"Who finds his Lucrece clad in mourning black,"

Meaning: Collatinus sees Lucrece dressed in black, the traditional color of mourning. This immediately indicates something terrible has happened.
Literary Devices: Imagery: The stark image of Lucrece in black creates a visual impact and foreshadows the tragic news.

"And round about her tear-distained eye"

Meaning: Her eyes are swollen and marked by the effects of excessive crying. "Tear-distained" implies the tears have left their mark, physically altering her appearance.
Literary Devices: Imagery: Emphasizes the extent of Lucrece's suffering.
Alliteration: The 't' sound in "tear-distained" adds emphasis.

"Blue circles streamed, like rainbows in the sky."

Meaning: The dark circles under her eyes are compared to rainbows in the sky. This comparison, while seemingly beautiful, is actually quite disturbing in context. It highlights the unnatural and unsettling appearance caused by her distress.
Literary Devices: Simile: The comparison using "like" connects the blue circles to rainbows. Irony: The use of a beautiful image like a rainbow to describe a sign of grief creates a jarring contrast and underscores the unnaturalness of the situation. The beauty of a rainbow is associated with hope and happiness, which is starkly contrasted with Lucrece's despair.

"These water-galls in her dim element"

Meaning: "Water-galls" is an archaic term for broken or disturbed patches of the rainbow, often seen as harbingers of stormy weather. "Dim element" refers to Lucrece's weakened and sorrowful state (her eyes are her "element", a source of light and beauty, now dimmed by grief). So, the dark circles (water-galls) within her distressed eyes (dim element).
Literary Devices: Metaphor: "Water-galls" is used metaphorically to describe the dark circles and the signs of impending trouble. "Dim element" is another metaphor for Lucrece's current state.

But now the mindful messenger, come back,
Brings home his lord and other company;
Who finds his Lucrece clad in mourning black,
And round about her tear-distained eye
Blue circles streamed, like rainbows in the sky.
These water-galls in her dim element
Foretell new storms to those already spent.

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"Foretell new storms to those already spent."

Meaning: The physical signs of her grief (the dark circles) are a warning that more suffering (new storms) are to come, even after the terrible event (the rape) that has already occurred. This line suggests that the consequences of the rape will continue to unfold and cause further pain.
Literary Devices: Foreshadowing: Hints at future suffering and tragedy.
Metaphor: The "storms" represent further trials and tribulations.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza describes the arrival of Collatinus and his companions to find Lucrece in a state of intense mourning. The description of her tear-stained face and the dark circles under her eyes, compared to disturbed rainbows, foreshadows that the rape is not the end of the tragedy. Her grief is a sign of more trouble to come, indicating the lasting and devastating impact of Tarquin's actions. The stanza emphasizes the gravity of the situation and sets the stage for the revelations and consequences that will follow. It highlights not only the immediate shock and grief but also the long-term damage the rape will inflict.

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Stanza 228 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 228 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line:

Line 1: "Which when her sad-beholding husband saw,"
Breakdown:
"Which" - Refers back to Lucrece's appearance, likely her disheveled and sorrowful state after the rape.
"when her sad-beholding husband saw" - When her husband, who is sadly observing her, saw. "Sad-beholding" - This is a compound adjective emphasizing the husband's melancholic and observant state.

Literary Devices:
Epithet: "Sad-beholding" is an epithet describing the husband.

Line 2: "Amazedly in her sad face he stares."
Breakdown:
"Amazedly" - He is in a state of bewilderment and shock.
"in her sad face he stares" - He is fixated on her sorrowful countenance.

Literary Devices:
Alliteration: Repetition of the "s" sound in "sad" and "stares."

Line 3: "Her eyes, though sod in tears, looked red and raw,"
Breakdown:
"Her eyes, though sod in tears" - Her eyes, soaked and saturated with tears (implying excessive weeping).
"looked red and raw" - Appeared inflamed and irritated from the crying.

Literary Devices:
Imagery: Vividly describes the physical appearance of her eyes, appealing to the senses. Line 4: "Her lively colour killed with deadly cares."
Breakdown:
"Her lively colour" - Refers to her usual complexion, indicating health and vitality.
"killed with deadly cares" - The "deadly cares" (her overwhelming sorrow and the trauma of the rape) have extinguished her natural radiance.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Killed" is used metaphorically; her color isn't literally dead, but it has been diminished by her emotional state.
Personification: "Deadly cares" are given the power to "kill," as if they are an active force. Line 5: "He hath no power to ask her how she fares;"
Breakdown:
"He hath no power" - He is rendered unable to.
"to ask her how she fares" - to ask her how she is doing, how she feels.

Which when her sad-beholding husband saw,
Amazedly in her sad face he stares.
Her eyes, though sod in tears, looked red and raw,
Her lively colour killed with deadly cares.
He hath no power to ask her how she fares;
Both stood like old acquaintance in a trance,
Met far from home, wond’ring each other’s chance.

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Literary Devices:
Irony: He would be expected to ask her how she is, but he is so stunned that he cannot.

Line 6: "Both stood like old acquaintance in a trance,"

Breakdown:
"Both stood" - Both Lucrece and her husband remained motionless.
"like old acquaintance in a trance" - They are behaving like people who know each other distantly, frozen and stunned, as if in a dreamlike state. This suggests a distance and disconnection, even though they are husband and wife.

Literary Devices:
Simile: Comparing their behavior to that of "old acquaintance in a trance" using "like."

Line 7: "Met far from home, wond’ring each other’s chance."

Breakdown:
"Met far from home" - This reinforces the sense of unfamiliarity and distance; they are
emotionally and psychologically separated.
"wond’ring each other’s chance" - Each is bewildered by what has happened to the other, as if it's
a strange and unexpected turn of fate. "Chance" in this context implies misfortune or fate.

Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Far from home" is a metaphor for the emotional and psychological distance between them.
Alliteration: "Wond'ring" and "what".

Overall Meaning:

This stanza captures the immediate aftermath of Lucrece revealing (or at least hinting at) her trauma to her husband, Collatinus. He is stunned and overwhelmed by her appearance. The stanza highlights the breakdown in communication and connection between them. They are husband and wife, but they are rendered almost strangers by the enormity of the situation. The rape has created an unbridgeable gap, leaving them both in a state of shock and bewilderment. The use of similes and metaphors emphasizes the profound emotional and psychological distance that has suddenly appeared between them, making them seem as if they have met unexpectedly in a foreign land, unsure of how the other came to be in such a state. Collatinus is rendered speechless and impotent, unable to offer comfort or even understanding in the face of such a devastating change in his wife. The vivid imagery paints a picture of Lucrece's ravaged state, both physically and emotionally. The stanza underscores the isolating and destructive power of the rape.

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← Stanza 228📚 OverviewStanza 230 →

Stanza 229 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down stanza 229 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify the literary devices, and then discuss the overall meaning within the context of the poem.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"At last he takes her by the bloodless hand":

Meaning: Collatine, Lucrece's husband, finally takes her hand, which is described as "bloodless." Analysis: The "bloodless hand" is a significant detail. It symbolizes Lucrece's loss of vitality, innocence, and even life force after the rape. Blood is often associated with passion, vigor, and health. Its absence here underscores her emotional and physical devastation. Imagery is used to show what Lucrece looks like.

"And thus begins: “What uncouth ill event":

Meaning: Collatine starts to speak, wondering about the bad thing that has happened to her. The word uncouth suggests something foreign or unknown.
Analysis: This line introduces Collatine's questioning and his initial lack of understanding about the severity of what has occurred. There is alliteration here as well in 'Uncouth ill event'.

"Hath thee befall’n, that thou dost trembling stand?":

Meaning: "What terrible thing has happened to you, that you are standing there trembling?" Analysis: Collatine notes Lucrece's physical state, emphasizing her fear and vulnerability. The archaic language ("hath thee befall'n," "dost trembling stand") adds to the poem's formal and elevated tone. 'thou dost trembling stand' is a use of alliteration.

"Sweet love, what spite hath thy fair colour spent?":

Meaning: "My dear, what malice (spite) has taken away your beautiful complexion/colour?" Analysis: Collatine expresses his concern and uses the term "Sweet love" to address Lucrece. The question focuses on the alteration of her appearance, suggesting that something malicious has robbed her of her beauty and vivacity. "Fair colour spent" is a euphemism for her loss of health and vitality, implying that the event has stolen her life force. Again, imagery is shown here.

"Why art thou thus attired in discontent?":

Meaning: "Why are you dressed in such a way that shows unhappiness?"
Analysis: Collatine questions Lucrece's appearance, noting that her clothing and demeanor reflect her profound unhappiness. "Attired in discontent" suggests that her very being is saturated with sorrow. The word choice contributes to the overall atmosphere of tragedy and despair. Imagery is evident within this line.

"Unmask, dear dear, this moody heaviness,":

Meaning: "Take off the mask (reveal), my dear, this sad and oppressive mood."
Analysis: "Unmask" is a metaphorical plea for Lucrece to remove the emotional barrier that she has erected. Collatine implores her to reveal the source of her "moody heaviness," suggesting a

At last he takes her by the bloodless hand,
And thus begins: “What uncouth ill event
Hath thee befall’n, that thou dost trembling stand?
Sweet love, what spite hath thy fair colour spent?
Why art thou thus attired in discontent?
Unmask, dear dear, this moody heaviness,
And tell thy grief, that we may give redress.”

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weight of sorrow that she is carrying. The repetition of "dear" emphasizes his concern and affection.

"And tell thy grief, that we may give redress.”:

Meaning: "And tell us what is making you sad, so that we can fix it."
Analysis: Collatine offers a solution, stating that once he knows her grief, he and others can "give redress." This implies that he believes the situation can be resolved or rectified, which is tragically ironic, since the rape is irreversible and leads to Lucrece's suicide. This line indicates
the theme of justice, which is important in the poem.

Literary Devices:

Imagery: The "bloodless hand," "fair colour spent," and "attired in discontent" all create vivid images that contribute to the stanza's emotional impact.
Archaic Language: The use of phrases like "hath thee befall'n" and "dost trembling stand" adds to the formality and gravity of the scene.
Metaphor: "Unmask, dear dear, this moody heaviness" is a metaphor that suggests Lucrece is hiding her true feelings behind a mask of sorrow.
Alliteration: "Uncouth ill event", "thou dost trembling stand"
Euphemism: "Fair colour spent"

Overall Meaning:

The stanza serves as a poignant illustration of Collatine's initial reaction to Lucrece's trauma. He is deeply concerned about her distress and puzzled by her changed appearance. His words are filled with affection and a genuine desire to help. However, he fails to grasp the true nature and magnitude of the violation she has suffered. This is because the very nature of rape makes it unspeakable, and Lucrece is struggling to articulate what has happened to her. Collatine's promise of "redress" is also deeply ironic, as the only "redress" Lucrece can imagine for such a profound violation is her own death. The stanza underscores the tragic gap between Collatine's well-intentioned concern and the insurmountable horror that Lucrece is grappling with. It sets the stage for the revelation of the rape and the subsequent events that lead to Lucrece's suicide. The language and imagery used portray her as helpless and completely changed after the rape.

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← Stanza 229📚 OverviewStanza 231 →

Stanza 230 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identifying the literary devices and then offering an overall interpretation.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Three times with sighs she gives her sorrow fire,"

Meaning: Lucrece sighs deeply three times, and these sighs are so intense they seem to fuel her sorrow, making it even stronger. Instead of reducing her sorrow, the sighing intensifies it as if it were stoking a fire.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Sorrow is compared to "fire." This suggests a burning, consuming pain. Personification: Sorrow is given the ability to be "given fire," implying it's a thing that can be fed and intensified.

Hyperbole: "Three times" could be an exaggeration to emphasize the intensity of her suffering and hesitation.

"Ere once she can discharge one word of woe."

Meaning: Before she can even utter a single word to express her grief and suffering, she has already sighed three times. It emphasises that she is trying to speak but the words are unable to be discharged as she is in shock.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the "w" sound in "word of woe" emphasizes the sorrow she is trying to express.

"At length addressed to answer his desire,"

Meaning: Eventually, compelled to respond to the men's longing and expectation to hear her story, she prepares to speak. "Addressed to" implies both physically facing them and feeling compelled to speak to their shared desire for answers.
Literary Devices:
Implied Motivation: "His desire" references the collective desire of Collatine and the other
lords to know what has happened. This underscores their eagerness and the pressure Lucrece feels.

"She modestly prepares to let them know"

Meaning: Lucrece, with appropriate modesty and shame, gets ready to reveal the terrible truth to the men. The word "modestly" is key here, highlighting her virtuous nature even in this moment of intense suffering.
Literary Devices:
Emphasis on Virtue: "Modestly" continues to emphasize Lucrece's character. It highlights the tragic irony that she, a virtuous woman, has been subjected to such a violation.
Understatement: "Let them know" softens the blow. The reality is far more horrific than
simply "letting them know."

Three times with sighs she gives her sorrow fire,
Ere once she can discharge one word of woe.
At length addressed to answer his desire,
She modestly prepares to let them know
Her honour is ta’en prisoner by the foe;
While Collatine and his consorted lords
With sad attention long to hear her words.

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"Her honour is ta’en prisoner by the foe;"

Meaning: Her reputation and virtue (her "honour") has been captured and defiled by the enemy (Tarquin). This is the central revelation she is about to make.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: "Honour" is personified as something that can be taken prisoner. This highlights the intangible yet vital nature of reputation and virtue in the society of the play.
Euphemism: "Ta'en prisoner by the foe" is a veiled way of referring to the rape. It avoids
explicit language but makes it clear that she has been violated.

"While Collatine and his consorted lords"

Meaning: All the men accompanying Collatine.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the "c" sound in "Collatine" and "consorted" emphasizes the
group of men awaiting Lucrece's story.

"With sad attention long to hear her words."

Meaning: Collatine and the other lords are listening with solemn attentiveness and are anxious to hear what she will say. They are ready to hear about the "foe" and how the matter can be avenged.
Literary Devices:
Irony: Their "sad attention" is tinged with a sense of anticipation. They do not yet understand
the full horror of what Lucrece is about to reveal, and their desire for information is a form of dramatic irony. They are long to hear a tragic story that will impact them all in a way they do
not foresee.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza captures the agonizing moment before Lucrece reveals the horror of her rape. She is overcome with shame and grief, struggling to find the words to describe what has happened. Her sighs become an outlet for her deep suffering. The men, eager and attentive, wait to hear her explanation, unaware of the full extent of the violation that has occurred. The language employed in this stanza creates a sense of dramatic tension and emphasizes the weight of Lucrece's words, highlighting the importance of reputation and virtue in the context of the story. Her honour is described metaphorically as having been taken prisoner by the enemy. The stanza prepares the reader for the devastating consequences of Tarquin's actions and sets the stage for Lucrece's subsequent suicide.

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← Stanza 230📚 OverviewStanza 232 →

Stanza 231 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 231 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then discuss the overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"And now this pale swan in her wat’ry nest"

"And now": Transition, signals a shift to the present moment.
"this pale swan": A metaphor comparing Lucrece to a swan. Swans are traditionally symbols
of beauty, purity, and grace. "Pale" emphasizes her weakened and sorrowful state after the rape. The 'pale' also foreshadows her impending death.
"in her wat'ry nest": The "wat'ry nest" is a metaphorical description of her bed, which is soaked with her tears. The 'nest' reinforces her vulnerability and defenselessness. The image evokes a sense of confinement and entrapment. It's also slightly ironic, since nests are usually associated with protection and new life, while Lucrece faces destruction and death.

"Begins the sad dirge of her certain ending:"

"Begins the sad dirge": "Dirge" is a funeral song, a lament for the dead. This phrase foreshadows Lucrece's suicide. She is about to deliver a speech that is effectively her own eulogy.
"of her certain ending": This clarifies the subject of the dirge – her own death, which she now accepts as inevitable. The word "certain" underlines the finality and hopelessness of her situation.

“Few words,” quoth she, “shall fit the trespass best,"

“Few words,” quoth she: A standard Shakespearean way to introduce dialogue ("quoth" means said). The brevity of her opening statement shows her resolve to keep things succinct.
"shall fit the trespass best": "Trespass" here refers to the rape. She believes that no amount
of words can adequately describe or address the magnitude of the crime committed against her. "Fit" implies a perfect correspondence, which she deems impossible to achieve.

"Where no excuse can give the fault amending."

"Where no excuse": Emphasizes the lack of justification or mitigation for Tarquin's actions. He has committed an unforgivable act.
"can give the fault amending": The rape is a "fault" that is beyond repair or redemption. "Amending" suggests restoration or correction, which Lucrece believes is impossible in this case.

"In me more woes than words are now depending;"

"In me more woes than words": The antithesis here highlights the imbalance between the overwhelming suffering she feels and her ability to articulate it. She's overwhelmed by her grief. "are now depending": The word "depending" implies that the woes are weighing heavily on
her, like a burden or a sentence hanging over her head.

"And my laments would be drawn out too long,"

"And my laments": Refers to her expressions of sorrow and grief.

And now this pale swan in her wat’ry nest
Begins the sad dirge of her certain ending:
“Few words,” quoth she, “shall fit the trespass best,
Where no excuse can give the fault amending.
In me more woes than words are now depending;
And my laments would be drawn out too long,
To tell them all with one poor tired tongue.

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"would be drawn out too long": She implies that if she were to try to fully express her sorrow, it would take an excessively long time. She wants to be brief and focus on what's necessary.

"To tell them all with one poor tired tongue."

"To tell them all": Acknowledges the sheer volume of her suffering.
"with one poor tired tongue": Emphasizes her physical and emotional exhaustion. Her tongue
is "tired" both from speaking and from the emotional weight of her experience. The word "poor"
also evokes pity and vulnerability. The personification of the tongue reinforces the idea of her limitations.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza depicts Lucrece at the moment she decides to speak about her rape before committing suicide. She acknowledges the inadequacy of words to fully express the horror and depth of her suffering. She recognizes that no explanation or excuse can justify Tarquin's actions, and she believes the damage is irreparable. She feels overwhelmed by her sorrow, and her speech is framed as a "dirge," a lament for her impending death. The stanza emphasizes her resignation, her exhaustion, and the tragic weight of the crime that has been committed against her. She feels trapped and unable to escape the consequences of the rape. She's preparing to take her own life.

Literary Devices Used:

Metaphor: Comparing Lucrece to a "pale swan" and her bed to a "wat'ry nest."
Foreshadowing: The "sad dirge" foreshadows her suicide.
Antithesis: "More woes than words" highlights the imbalance between her suffering and her ability to express it.
Personification: "One poor tired tongue" gives human qualities to her tongue.
Imagery: The stanza is filled with vivid imagery, especially the "pale swan," "wat'ry nest," and "tired tongue," which help the reader visualize Lucrece's state.

In conclusion, Stanza 231 of 'The Rape of Lucrece' is a powerful and poignant depiction of a woman facing her own demise. It sets the stage for her confession and suicide, emphasizing her profound suffering, her sense of hopelessness, and the irreparable damage caused by Tarquin's crime. The use of literary devices enhances the emotional impact and underscores the tragedy of Lucrece's fate.

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Stanza 232 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this poignant stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece and then discuss its overall meaning and literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Then be this all the task it hath to say:"

Meaning: Let this be the complete message, the only thing that needs to be said. "It" refers to
the confession or explanation Lucrece is about to deliver to her husband. "Task" implies the
difficult and painful nature of the communication.

"Dear husband, in the interest of thy bed"

Meaning: This directly addresses her husband, Collatinus, in a very intimate way. "In the interest of thy bed" is a euphemism, meaning in relation to their marital sexual relationship, fidelity and marriage. She's hinting that what she's about to say has affected their marriage bed (and therefore their relationship).

"A stranger came, and on that pillow lay"

Meaning: This is a more direct statement. A "stranger," meaning Tarquin, invaded their marriage and slept where her husband should have been. The "pillow" symbolizes intimacy, safety, and the sanctity of their marriage.
Literary Device: Metonymy - "pillow" is used to represent the shared intimacy and marital bed.

"Where thou wast wont to rest thy weary head;"

Meaning: A reminder of Collatinus's absence. It emphasizes his rightful place in the marriage
bed and highlights the betrayal by reminding him of how he usually rests his head there. "Wast wont" means used to.

"And what wrong else may be imagined"

Meaning: She's being somewhat indirect, yet powerfully suggestive. She's implying that the worst imaginable thing occurred, but is not explicitly stating it.

"By foul enforcement might be done to me,"

Meaning: "Foul enforcement" refers to the rape. The phrase is a euphemism for the act itself, adding to the sense of horror and unspeakableness. "Might be done" is intentionally ambiguous to imply that she cannot bring herself to describe the act directly.

"From that, alas, thy Lucrece is not free."

Meaning: This is the heartbreaking conclusion. She's not free from the violation, from the horror, from the shame. "Alas" expresses her deep sorrow and despair. "Thy Lucrece" reminds her
husband that what happened to her has consequences for both of them.
Literary Device: Irony - "not free" is understatement. Lucrece's experience has imprisoned her
and ruined her sense of self.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

“Then be this all the task it hath to say:
Dear husband, in the interest of thy bed
A stranger came, and on that pillow lay
Where thou wast wont to rest thy weary head; And what wrong else may be imagined
By foul enforcement might be done to me, From that, alas, thy Lucrece is not free.

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In this stanza, Lucrece begins to deliver the agonizing news of her rape to her husband, Collatinus. She struggles to articulate the horror she has endured, using euphemisms and indirect language to convey the unspeakable act of violation. She confesses that a stranger has usurped her husband's place in their bed, and that she is now forever tainted by the "foul enforcement" that has occurred. She concludes by lamenting that she is no longer free from the shame and trauma of the rape, emphasizing the devastating consequences for herself and her marriage. The stanza is filled with a profound sense of loss, shame, and despair.

Literary Devices Recap:

Euphemism: Used to soften the direct impact of the horrific event (e.g., "in the interest of thy
bed," "foul enforcement").
Metonymy: "Pillow" represents the intimacy and sanctity of the marriage bed. Understatement/Litotes: "Not free" is a gross understatement of the degree to which the rape has imprisoned her.
Irony: "Not free" when in reality she is forever bound by the rape.

The use of these literary devices contributes to the emotional intensity and the overall tragic impact of the scene. Lucrece's struggle to articulate her experience highlights the profound psychological and emotional damage inflicted by the rape.

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← Stanza 232📚 OverviewStanza 234 →

Stanza 233 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, focusing on its individual parts and then putting it all together:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"For in the dreadful dead of dark midnight,"

For: Sets the stage for the event being described, introducing the why or when it happened. dreadful dead of dark midnight: Establishes a tone of terror and foreboding.
Alliteration: Repeated 'd' sounds emphasize the darkness and fear.
Imagery: "Dark midnight" is a powerful image evoking mystery, danger, and a time when evil deeds often occur.

Personification: The dead of night is personified as being 'dreadful'.
Superlative Adjective: Dreadful emphasises the fear and apprehension felt by Lucrece

"With shining falchion in my chamber came"

shining falchion: A "falchion" is a type of sword, often curved. "Shining" suggests it's new, sharp, well-maintained, and adds an element of menacing glamour.
Imagery: The shining falchion evokes violence and threat. The contrast between the shining blade and the darkness of the night intensifies the sense of menace.

in my chamber came: This is a simple statement of the intruder's (Tarquin's) entry into Lucrece's private space.
Inversion: The verb "came" follows the subject "shining falchion" which adds to the dramatic and unnatural feeling of the scene.

"A creeping creature with a flaming light,"

creeping creature: This dehumanizes Tarquin, comparing him to something base and vile. "Creeping" suggests stealth, secrecy, and a lack of honor.
Metaphor: Tarquin is being implicitly compared to a creature.
Imagery: The term “creeping creature” gives the impression of something sneaky and unpleasant.

flaming light: Represents the literal torch Tarquin carries, but also symbolizes his passion, desire, and the deceptive nature of his intent. The light, meant to illuminate, is instead used to facilitate a horrific act.
Symbolism: The flaming light could symbolise the danger he poses to Lucrece.
Juxtaposition: The flaming light contrasts with the dark midnight, suggesting that it’s not a comforting light, but a frightening one.

"And softly cried ‘Awake, thou Roman dame,"

softly cried: The contrast between the violence implied by the sword and the "soft" cry adds to the unsettling nature of the scene. It suggests Tarquin is trying to be seductive or manipulative, even as he threatens.
Oxymoron: The phrase “softly cried” is unexpected and unsettling, highlighting the contrast between his supposed gentleness and the threat of violence.

“For in the dreadful dead of dark midnight,
With shining falchion in my chamber came
A creeping creature with a flaming light,
And softly cried ‘Awake, thou Roman dame,
And entertain my love; else lasting shame
On thee and thine this night I will inflict, If thou my love’s desire do contradict.

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Awake, thou Roman dame: A formal and somewhat theatrical address to Lucrece. "Roman dame" elevates her status, but also underscores the violation of Roman honor that is about to occur. Allusion: Reference to Roman values of honour and virtue.

"And entertain my love; else lasting shame"

entertain my love: A euphemism for yielding to his lustful desires. It’s a stark contrast to the reality of his intentions, which are far from loving.
lasting shame: Threatens to permanently ruin Lucrece's reputation and honor. Foreshadowing: Hints at the consequences of Tarquin's actions and Lucrece’s eventual suicide.

"On thee and thine this night I will inflict,"

On thee and thine: Extends the threat to her entire family, emphasizing the far-reaching consequences of her refusal.
I will inflict: A forceful and direct verb, revealing the violence underlying his supposed "love."

"If thou my love’s desire do contradict."

my love’s desire: Another euphemism that attempts to cloak his lust in the guise of affection.
do contradict: Highlighting her lack of power and the threat of dire consequences if she does not give in to his wishes.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza encapsulates the moment of Tarquin's intrusion and the initial stages of his coercion of Lucrece. It emphasizes the atmosphere of terror, the contrast between Tarquin's deceptive words and violent intentions, and the immense pressure he places on Lucrece. The imagery is dark and menacing, highlighting the violation of her personal space and the threat to her honor and family. Tarquin is presented as a predatory and dishonorable figure who uses a combination of soft words and brutal threats to achieve his goals. The stanza is thick with foreshadowing, hinting at the tragic events to come.

Literary Devices Summary:

Alliteration: Emphasizes the darkness and fear.
Imagery: Creates a vivid and disturbing picture of the scene.
Metaphor/Simile: Tarquin is implicitly compared to a creature.
Symbolism: The "flaming light" represents lust and deception.
Euphemism: "Entertain my love" disguises the true nature of Tarquin's intentions. Foreshadowing: Hints at the tragic consequences.
Juxtaposition: Tarquin’s soft words and violent intentions are contrasted to create a disturbing effect.
Personification: Giving the night human qualities.
Inversion: Changed sentence structures for dramatic effect.
Allusion: Reference to Roman values of honour and virtue.

In essence, this stanza is a chilling portrait of the moment when Lucrece's fate is sealed, capturing the horror and injustice of the situation. It masterfully uses language to create a sense of dread and anticipation, drawing the reader into the unfolding tragedy.
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← Stanza 233📚 OverviewStanza 235 →

Stanza 234 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 234 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

“‘For some hard-favoured groom of thine,’ quoth he,”

"For some hard-favoured groom of thine": This means "Because of some ugly/unattractive servant of yours." "Hard-favoured" is an euphemism for ugly or plain looking.
"quoth he": This is an archaic way of saying "he said."

“Unless thou yoke thy liking to my will,”

"Unless thou yoke thy liking to my will": Unless you bind/submit your desires and
preferences to my will. "Yoke" is a metaphor comparing Lucrece's will to an animal being yoked to a plough, forced to follow Collatine's direction.

“I’ll murder straight, and then I’ll slaughter thee”

"I'll murder straight": I will murder immediately.
"and then I'll slaughter thee": And then I will brutally kill you. There is a slight distinction in the language that signifies brutality; "slaughter" carries more weight than "murder" alone.
This line shows a progression/escalation of violence.

“And swear I found you where you did fulfil”

"And swear I found you where you did fulfil": And I will swear/testify that I found you in the act of...

“The loathsome act of lust, and so did kill”

"The loathsome act of lust": The disgusting/revolting act of sexual desire. It highlights his perceived corruption of Lucrece.
"and so did kill": And so I killed...

“The lechers in their deed. This act will be”

"The lechers in their deed": The lustful men/adulterers in the act of committing adultery. "This act will be": This act (of killing them) will be...

“My fame and thy perpetual infamy.’”

"My fame": My reputation, my claim to glory.
"and thy perpetual infamy": And your everlasting shame/disgrace. The "perpetual"
emphasizes the never-ending consequence of Lucrece's alleged action.

Literary Devices:

Metaphor: "Yoke thy liking" - comparing Lucrece's will to an animal being forced into submission. Euphemism: "Hard-favoured groom" - a softened way of saying ugly or unattractive servant. Imagery: The language evokes violent images - "murder," "slaughter," "loathsome act of lust," which contributes to the overall atmosphere of threat.

“ ‘ For some hard-favoured groom of thine,’ quoth he,
‘ Unless thou yoke thy liking to my will,
I’ll murder straight, and then I’ll slaughter thee
And swear I found you where you did fulfil
The loathsome act of lust, and so did kill
The lechers in their deed. This act will be
My fame and thy perpetual infamy.’

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Alliteration: The repetition of the 'l' sound in "loathsome" and "lust" emphasizes the revulsion of the act.
Contrast/Juxtaposition: The contrast between "fame" and "infamy" highlights the different outcomes that Tarquin envisions for himself and Lucrece.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Tarquin lays out his horrifying ultimatum to Lucrece. He threatens to murder one of her servants and then Lucrece herself. He then explains his plan to claim he caught her in the act of adultery with the murdered servant and that he killed them both in righteous anger. He claims this false narrative will become his source of glory, while simultaneously, ensuring Lucrece's name will be forever tarnished in shame. The stanza showcases Tarquin's manipulative and cruel nature, as well as the social constraints and consequences faced by women accused of sexual transgression. It highlights the power imbalance between Tarquin and Lucrece and the horrific choice she is being forced to make.

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← Stanza 234📚 OverviewStanza 236 →

Stanza 235 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 235 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece piece by piece:

"With this, I did begin to start and cry,"

Meaning: This line indicates Lucrece's initial reaction to the threat. "With this" refers to the culmination of Collatine's increasingly aggressive demands and threats. She starts (jumps) in
fright and begins to cry. This is the beginning of her abject terror.

"And then against my heart he sets his sword,"

Meaning: Collatine reinforces his threat by physically pressing his sword against Lucrece's chest, aiming for her heart. This is a vivid image of imminent violence and forces Lucrece to understand the full extent of his threat.

"Swearing, unless I took all patiently,"

Meaning: Collatine demands that Lucrece passively accept his advances (i.e., submit to the
rape) without resistance or complaint. The use of "patiently" is a cruel irony, suggesting she should be calm and accepting of this heinous act.

"I should not live to speak another word;"

Meaning: This is the direct threat of death. If Lucrece resists or tells anyone, Collatine will kill her. He is silencing her, taking away her voice and agency.

"So should my shame still rest upon record,"

Meaning: Here, Collatine is suggesting the consequences of Lucrece's non-compliance. If he kills her, he'll be able to make sure that her perceived infidelity would become a written story that lasts, permanently damning her reputation. Record is a metaphor for public reputation, or the stories about her that people will remember.

"And never be forgot in mighty Rome"

Meaning: This emphasizes the enduring nature of the shame. Collatine suggests that the scandal surrounding Lucrece's "adulterate death" would be a lasting stain on her name, forever remembered throughout the city of Rome.

"The adulterate death of Lucrece and her groom."

Meaning: This line is the culmination of Collatine's blackmail. He's threatening to kill both
Lucrece and one of her servants (her "groom"). Collatine frames Lucrece's murder as an
adulterous act.
Using the word "adulterate" suggests that Lucrece was committing adultery and that the consequences are deserving of her actions.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza is a crucial moment in the poem where Collatine uses extreme threats and physical violence to coerce Lucrece into submission. He holds a sword to her heart, threatening to kill her and frame her death as a scandalous act of adultery if she does not comply. His words are designed to

“With this, I did begin to start and cry,
And then against my heart he sets his sword,
Swearing, unless I took all patiently,
I should not live to speak another word;
So should my shame still rest upon record,
And never be forgot in mighty Rome
The adulterate death of Lucrece and her groom.

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break her spirit and leave her with no other option but to endure the rape. The stanza highlights the themes of power, control, and the violation of innocence that permeate the entire poem.

Literary Devices:

Imagery: The visual of the sword against Lucrece's heart creates a vivid and terrifying image for the reader.
Irony: The word "patiently" is ironic, given the situation Lucrece is in.
Allusion: The reference to "mighty Rome" sets the scene and reminds the reader of the importance of reputation and honor in Roman society.
Threat and Coercion: This is the overarching device used, with Collatine explicitly threatening Lucrece's life and reputation.
Metaphor: The use of record suggests public perception and written accounts that have an
enduring impact on people's perspectives.

This stanza powerfully encapsulates the central conflict of the poem, emphasizing the vulnerability of Lucrece and the ruthless cruelty of Collatine.
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← Stanza 235📚 OverviewStanza 237 →

Stanza 236 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 236 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identifying literary devices, and then arrive at the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Mine enemy was strong, my poor self weak,"

Meaning: This line establishes the power imbalance between Lucrece and Tarquin. "Mine enemy" clearly refers to Tarquin, and "my poor self" is Lucrece. It is a statement of simple, stark contrast. Literary Devices:
Antithesis: The contrasting words "strong" and "weak" emphasizes the vast difference in
power.

"And far the weaker with so strong a fear."

Meaning: Her fear amplifies her weakness. It's not just that she's physically weaker, but her terror further debilitates her.
Literary Devices:
Alliteration: The repetition of the "w" sound ("weaker with") emphasizes her emotional state. "My bloody judge forbade my tongue to speak;"

Meaning: Tarquin, who acts as her oppressor (and effectively her judge), prevents her from defending herself. The phrase "bloody judge" highlights his merciless and violent nature. Literary Devices:
Metaphor: Tarquin is not literally a judge in a courtroom, but he assumes that role of judgement and power over her life.
Imagery: "Bloody judge" evokes a vivid image of violence and injustice.

"No rightful plea might plead for justice there."

Meaning: Justice is impossible in this situation. There is no opportunity for a fair hearing or for her innocence to be recognized.
Literary Devices:
Repetition: "Plea plead" creates emphasis on the futility of her situation.
Alliteration: The 'p' sound in 'plea plead' adds emphasis.
"His scarlet lust came evidence to swear"

Meaning: Tarquin's overwhelming lust is presented as if it is providing evidence against her. "Scarlet" is often associated with sin, shame, and strong emotions like lust. His lust is now an active force that incriminates Lucrece.
Literary Devices:
Personification: Lust is given the agency to "swear" against her, as if it were a witness. Metaphor: Lust is a metaphor for the false accusations and the twisted logic Tarquin is using. Symbolism: "Scarlet" symbolizes his passionate, overwhelming, and destructive desire.

“Mine enemy was strong, my poor self weak,
And far the weaker with so strong a fear.
My bloody judge forbade my tongue to speak;
No rightful plea might plead for justice there.
His scarlet lust came evidence to swear
That my poor beauty had purloined his eyes;
And when the judge is robbed, the prisoner dies.

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"That my poor beauty had purloined his eyes;"

Meaning: He is twisting the situation to make it seem as if Lucrece is responsible for his actions. He claims that her beauty stole his eyes, implying that she seduced him and is therefore to blame for his lust.
Literary Devices:
Irony: This is a perversion of justice. He is shifting the blame onto the victim.
Metaphor: Her beauty is presented as a thief, "purloining" his eyes.
Hyperbole: Overexaggeration of the impact of her beauty.

"And when the judge is robbed, the prisoner dies."

Meaning: This line sums up the complete corruption of justice. If the "judge" (Tarquin) feels wronged or robbed (by her beauty, as he claims), then the "prisoner" (Lucrece) is doomed. This
is a stark statement about the lack of fairness and the inevitability of her destruction.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The Judge refers to Tarquin and the prisoner refers to Lucrece
Aphorism/Proverb: The line sounds like a well-known saying, but it's a warped version that reflects the unjust situation.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza describes the utter helplessness and injustice faced by Lucrece. It portrays a situation where power is absolute, and innocence offers no protection. Tarquin, driven by his uncontrollable lust, has become both her attacker and her judge, making any possibility of justice impossible. He blames her for his own actions, twisting the truth to justify his violent crime. The stanza culminates in a chilling statement about the consequences of such corruption: in this perverse "court," the accused is condemned simply because the "judge" (Tarquin) believes he has been wronged (by her beauty, which is a complete fabrication). The overall message is one of deep despair and the tragic triumph of evil over good. It highlights how vulnerability and lack of power can lead to devastating outcomes when confronted with unchecked and perverse authority.

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← Stanza 236📚 OverviewStanza 238 →

Stanza 237 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 237 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, then synthesize an overall meaning, paying attention to literary devices.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

“O, teach me how to make mine own excuse,”

Meaning: Lucrece cries out, pleading to be shown how to justify or defend herself in the wake of her rape. She desires a way to explain her situation, likely to her husband, Collatine, and to
Roman society, without being utterly condemned. She seeks an acceptable narrative.
Literary Devices: Apostrophe (addressing an abstract "teacher" or personification of wisdom), Exclamation (expresses strong emotion).

“Or at the least, this refuge let me find:

Meaning: She begs for some kind of solace or justification. If she can't wholly excuse her situation, she prays to find at least one comforting idea or defense that will shelter her from total despair.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (a "refuge" represents an emotional haven).

“Though my gross blood be stained with this abuse,”

Meaning: Here, "gross blood" refers to her physical body or, more generally, her outward, material self. She acknowledges that her body has been violated ("stained") by the "abuse" (the rape). The rape has irrevocably marked her physicality.
Literary Devices: Metonymy ("gross blood" standing for the body), Metaphor ("stained" representing moral corruption or dishonor), Alliteration ("gross blood").

“Immaculate and spotless is my mind;”

Meaning: This is the key line in justifying herself: Lucrece insists that her mind – her thoughts, her will, her inner self – remains pure and untainted by the act of violence perpetrated against her.

Literary Devices: Juxtaposition/Contrast (directly opposes the "stained" blood with the "immaculate" mind), Alliteration ("Immaculate...is my mind"), Imagery (visual image of purity, "immaculate", "spotless").

“That was not forced; that never was inclined”

Meaning: She emphatically states that her mind was not forced, nor was it ever drawn to or tempted by the idea of yielding to Tarquin's advances. Her will remained resistant throughout the ordeal.

Literary Devices: Anaphora (repetition of "that"), Emphasis (the repetition reinforces her lack of consent).

“To accessary yieldings, but still pure”

Meaning: She further clarifies that her mind never gave any sort of consent or assistance to the rape, even in the slightest degree. It remained entirely pure and innocent. "Accessary yieldings" refers to any sort of cooperation.

“O, teach me how to make mine own excuse,
Or at the least, this refuge let me find:
Though my gross blood be stained with this abuse,
Immaculate and spotless is my mind;
That was not forced; that never was inclined
To accessary yieldings, but still pure
Doth in her poisoned closet yet endure.”

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Literary Devices: Imagery (again, reinforces her "pure" state), Alliteration ("still pure").

“Doth in her poisoned closet yet endure.”

Meaning: Even though her "closet," i.e., her innermost being or mind, is now "poisoned" by the memory of the rape and the shame associated with it, her essential purity still persists within her. Despite the trauma, she maintains a core of moral integrity.
Literary Devices: Metaphor ("closet" represents her mind), Imagery ("poisoned" evokes the corrupting influence of the rape), Personification ("Doth endure" gives agency to her mind).

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece struggles to reconcile the violation of her body with her internal sense of self. She desperately seeks a way to articulate that, while her physical body has been "stained" by the rape, her mind, her will, her inner self, remains untouched and pure. She asserts that she never consented, never desired, and never yielded to Tarquin's advances, and that her integrity endures despite the trauma she has experienced. This is her attempt to salvage her honor, her reputation, and her sense of self-worth in the face of a devastating event. The stanza highlights the crucial distinction she draws between the physical act of violence and the enduring purity of her will, as well as the psychological torment she is suffering.

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Stanza 238 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 238 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line, identify literary devices, and then summarize the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Lo, here the hopeless merchant of this loss,"

Lo: An archaic interjection meaning "behold" or "look." This immediately draws attention to the subject.
Hopeless merchant of this loss: This is a metaphor. Collatine, Lucrece's husband, is not
literally a merchant. The loss of Lucrece, her honor and her life, is treated as a valuable item he has lost. He is "hopeless" in recovering this loss.
Literary Device: Metaphor

"With head declined and voice dammed up with woe,"

Head declined: Indicates grief, shame, and despair. His head is bowed in defeat.
Voice dammed up with woe: His grief is so overwhelming that it blocks his ability to speak. "Dammed up" is a vivid image of something powerful (his voice, emotions) being forcefully contained.
Literary Device: Imagery

"With sad set eyes and wretched arms across,"

Sad set eyes: Implies a fixed, unwavering gaze of sorrow. "Set" suggests a firmness, reflecting the permanence of his grief.
Wretched arms across: Arms crossed are often a gesture of defensiveness, closure, or simply misery. The adjective "wretched" emphasizes the depth of his suffering.
Literary Device: Imagery

"From lips new-waxen pale begins to blow"

Lips new-waxen pale: "New-waxen pale" is a striking image suggesting a deathly pallor. "Waxen" evokes the image of a wax figure or a corpse, highlighting his shock and near-death experience.
Begins to blow: He's trying to force out words, trying to articulate his grief.
Literary Device: Imagery

"The grief away that stops his answer so."

The grief away that stops his answer so: He's attempting to verbally express his grief, hoping to alleviate it, but it's also the grief that's preventing him from speaking clearly or coherently. The grief itself is the obstacle. This emphasizes the paralyzing nature of intense sorrow.

"But wretched as he is, he strives in vain;"

But wretched as he is: Reinforces the intensity of his suffering.
He strives in vain: Highlights the futility of his efforts. He is making an effort to speak, but his attempt is ultimately fruitless. This emphasizes the overwhelming power of grief.

Lo, here the hopeless merchant of this loss,
With head declined and voice dammed up with woe,
With sad set eyes and wretched arms across,
From lips new-waxen pale begins to blow
The grief away that stops his answer so.
But wretched as he is, he strives in vain;
What he breathes out his breath drinks up again.

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Literary Device: Alliteration ("strives in vain")

"What he breathes out his breath drinks up again."

What he breathes out his breath drinks up again: This is a powerful and somewhat paradoxical image. His breath, which should be carrying his words and grief outward, is instead being absorbed back into himself. This suggests a cycle of trapped sorrow, where his attempts to express himself are thwarted. It's a visual representation of suffocation.
Literary Device: Paradox, Personification (breath "drinks up")

Overall Meaning:

This stanza describes Collatine's initial attempts to respond to the tragedy that has befallen him and his family. He is overwhelmed by grief, so much so that he is physically affected. His body language (head bowed, arms crossed) communicates his despair. He tries to speak, but his sorrow is so profound that it stifles his voice, rendering his efforts futile. The final lines emphasize the paralyzing and all-consuming nature of his grief; he cannot even articulate his sorrow, as his very breath seems to be choked by it. The stanza depicts a man utterly consumed and immobilized by loss.

The stanza does a brilliant job of illustrating the almost physical manifestation of grief and its power to silence and immobilize. Shakespeare uses vivid imagery and metaphorical language to portray the depth of Collatine's despair.

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Stanza 239 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 239 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, examining each part and its literary devices, and then synthesize the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"As through an arch the violent roaring tide"

Meaning: The image is a powerful, aggressive tide surging through a narrow archway. This establishes a sense of force, pent-up energy being unleashed.
Literary Devices:
Simile: The stanza begins with "As," immediately establishing a comparison between Tarquin's emotional state and the tide.
Imagery: "Violent roaring tide" is strong auditory and visual imagery that vividly depicts the tide's force.

"Outruns the eye that doth behold his haste,"

Meaning: The tide moves so quickly that it surpasses the ability of the observer to follow it. It's unstoppable and uncontrolled.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "Eye that doth behold" gives a human quality to observation. "His haste" also personifies the tide.
Hyperbole: The tide outrunning the eye is an exaggeration to emphasize its speed and power. "Yet in the eddy boundeth in his pride"

Meaning: Despite its outward rush, the tide creates swirling eddies (circular currents) and appears to be full of pride (perhaps meaning unrestrained power). It's not just a linear force; it's complex and self-involved.
Literary Devices:
Personification: "Pride" is attributed to the tide.
Imagery: The "eddy" provides visual imagery of turbulent, circling water.

"Back to the strait that forced him on so fast,"

Meaning: The tide eventually reverses direction, moving back towards the narrow passage that initially propelled it forward.
Literary Devices:
Personification: The "strait" is described as forcing the tide.
Alliteration: The repetition of the 'f' sound in "forced" and "fast" emphasizes the strength of the force.

"In rage sent out, recalled in rage, being past:"

Meaning: The tide's initial surge and subsequent retreat are both driven by rage or violent emotion. The retreat occurs once its initial force has been spent.
Literary Devices:
Repetition: The word "rage" is repeated, highlighting the intensity of the emotion driving the tide's actions.

As through an arch the violent roaring tide
Outruns the eye that doth behold his haste,
Yet in the eddy boundeth in his pride
Back to the strait that forced him on so fast,
In rage sent out, recalled in rage, being past: Even so his sighs, his sorrows make a saw,
To push grief on, and back the same grief draw.

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Parallelism: "Sent out, recalled" creates a sense of balance and mirrored action.

"Even so his sighs, his sorrows make a saw,"

Meaning: This transitions the simile to the real subject: Tarquin's emotions. His sighs and sorrows act like a saw, a tool that cuts back and forth.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor: The sighs and sorrows are equated to a saw, not just compared.
Imagery: A saw evokes a violent, cutting, and painful action.

"To push grief on, and back the same grief draw."

Meaning: Tarquin's grief is intensified by his internal struggles. His sighs and sorrows both
amplify and revisit the same feelings of remorse and guilt. He is tormented by his actions.
Literary Devices:
Repetition: The repetition of "grief" underscores its central role in Tarquin's suffering.
Paradox: The idea of "pushing grief on" and drawing it "back" suggests a cycle of self-torment.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza uses the simile of a powerful, turbulent tide to describe the emotional turmoil of Tarquin after raping Lucrece. Like the tide that rushes forward and then recedes, driven by an underlying force, Tarquin is consumed by waves of grief and remorse. His sighs and sorrows act like a saw, constantly intensifying and revisiting the same pain. He is caught in a cycle of self-torment, unable to escape the guilt and consequences of his actions. The powerful imagery of the tide emphasizes the uncontrollable and destructive nature of Tarquin's emotions. The back-and-forth action of the tide mirrors the internal conflict Tarquin experiences, highlighting his inability to find peace or resolution. The stanza is thus a powerful description of psychological anguish and the destructive power of guilt.

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← Stanza 239📚 OverviewStanza 241 →

Stanza 240 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece, line by line, and then look at the overall meaning and literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Which speechless woe of his poor she attendeth,"

Meaning: Lucrece is watching Tarquin's silent suffering and distress. "She" is Lucrece, and she is paying attention to ("attendeth") Tarquin's "speechless woe" (silent grief). "Poor he" indicates Tarquin is the subject.

"And his untimely frenzy thus awaketh:"

Meaning: Tarquin's wild and inappropriate (because it's happening at the wrong time and in the wrong place - "untimely") agitation is being brought to life and made apparent. It's as if his silence is building into a visible madness or despair.

“Dear lord, thy sorrow to my sorrow lendeth"

Meaning: Lucrece addresses Tarquin, acknowledging his sorrow, but stating that his sorrow is just adding to hers. His pain does not comfort her; it compounds her suffering. This is a crucial turning point: Lucrece is not moved to pity, but rather finds her own suffering intensified.

"Another power; no flood by raining slaketh."

Meaning: His sorrow adds "another power" or layer to Lucrece's grief. The metaphor of a "flood" is used to represent her woe. "No flood by raining slaketh" refers to how rain does not diminish the severity of a flood. Instead, it intensifies it.

"My woe too sensible thy passion maketh"

Meaning: Her existing pain ("My woe too sensible") is made even more deeply felt ("thy passion maketh") by his dramatic display of emotion. "Sensible" here means she is acutely aware and feeling the depth of her pain.

"More feeling-painful. Let it then suffice"

Meaning: Her pain now feels heightened due to Tarquin's behaviour. Lucrece is saying his emotions increase hers, making her pain too hard to bear, thus urging him to leave her alone.

"To drown one woe, one pair of weeping eyes."

Meaning: Lucrece is stating that one source of grief should be enough for one person. She only
has "one woe" or source of pain (the rape). Likewise, she is only one person, which is symbolised
by "one pair of weeping eyes." This is almost a plea for mercy, a suggestion that he should be satisfied with the pain he has already caused her.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece directly addresses Tarquin, expressing how his sorrow is not diminishing her own, but rather amplifying it. His distress doesn't comfort her, nor does it make her feel pity. Instead, it increases her own pain and makes her realize the full extent of her suffering. She suggests that he should be content with the immense pain he has already inflicted upon her, and that he should stop,

Which speechless woe of his poor she attendeth,
And his untimely frenzy thus awaketh:
“Dear lord, thy sorrow to my sorrow lendeth
Another power; no flood by raining slaketh.
My woe too sensible thy passion maketh
More feeling-painful. Let it then suffice
To drown one woe, one pair of weeping eyes.

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as her capacity for sorrow is at its limit. This highlights her suffering, and it establishes that she is not going to be sympathetic to Tarquin or try to comfort him.

Literary Devices:

Apostrophe: Lucrece addresses Tarquin directly, even though he may not be truly "listening" or capable of understanding her pain.
Metaphor: The comparison of her sorrow to a "flood" is a powerful metaphor that emphasizes the overwhelming nature of her grief.
Paradox: "No flood by raining slaketh" is a paradoxical statement, as rain would be expected to cause a flood but not cease one. This highlights the irrationality of her pain and Tarquin's actions. Alliteration: The repetition of the 's' sound in "My woe too sensible thy passion maketh" creates a subtle musicality and emphasizes the word "sensible".
Synecdoche: "One pair of weeping eyes" represents the whole person, Lucrece.
Irony: There is a subtle layer of irony here. Tarquin is likely motivated by lust and a desire to assuage his guilt or justify his actions by making Lucrece complicit in some way. Lucrece is pointing out the futility of his emotional display and is attempting to assert her own autonomy in the face of his actions.

This stanza is crucial in revealing Lucrece's state of mind and her increasing determination to take control of her situation. It highlights her immense suffering and sets the stage for her eventual act of suicide.

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Stanza 241 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down this powerful stanza from The Rape of Lucrece.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"And for my sake, when I might charm thee so,"

Literal Meaning: Consider my sake, the time I could have charmed you.
Analysis: Lucrece is addressing her husband, Collatinus, and reminding him of the time when she was alive, unviolated, and a source of charm and pleasure for him. This highlights what he
has lost and the emotional damage done to him.

"For she that was thy Lucrece, now attend me:"

Literal Meaning: Because the Lucrece you knew is gone, listen to me now.
Analysis: Lucrece emphasizes the radical transformation she has undergone through the rape. She is no longer the same woman. This emphasizes the gravity of Tarquin's crime – he has essentially killed her old self. "Attend me" is a demand for his attention and obedience to her final wish.

"Be suddenly revenged on my foe,"

Literal Meaning: Take swift revenge on my enemy.
Analysis: This is the core command of the stanza. She calls for immediate action, not measured or delayed justice, but swift retribution. "Suddenly" underscores the urgency and intensity of her demand.

"Thine, mine, his own. Suppose thou dost defend me"

Literal Meaning: He is your enemy, mine, and his own (Tarquin's) too. Imagine that by seeking revenge, you are defending me.
Analysis: This line employs tricolon, a series of three parallel clauses, to emphasize the multifaceted nature of Tarquin's treachery. He is an enemy to Collatinus (for violating his wife), to Lucrece (for the rape), and even to himself (because his actions are self-destructive and lead to his downfall). The phrase "Suppose thou dost defend me" acts as a motivation, implying that by avenging her, Collatinus will be protecting her honor in death. This is a subtle attempt to transfer agency and responsibility.

"From what is past. The help that thou shalt lend me"

Literal Meaning: (defend me) from what already happened. The help you are about to offer. Analysis: Lucrece acknowledges the finality of what has happened. Revenge can't undo the rape, but it can provide a form of justice and retribution. This shows her awareness that her death and the revenge are not truly about her in the present, but about shaping the future.

"Comes all too late, yet let the traitor die,"

Literal Meaning: The help comes too late to save me, but still, let the traitor die.
Analysis: There's a crucial concession here. She admits the futility of revenge in saving her life or restoring her purity. "All too late" highlights the tragedy. Despite this, she still insists on

“And for my sake, when I might charm thee so,
For she that was thy Lucrece, now attend me:
Be suddenly revenged on my foe,
Thine, mine, his own. Suppose thou dost defend me
From what is past. The help that thou shalt lend me
Comes all too late, yet let the traitor die,
For sparing justice feeds iniquity.

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Tarquin's death. This reinforces the idea that revenge is not about her personal salvation but about justice and preventing future atrocities.

"For sparing justice feeds iniquity."

Literal Meaning: Because not enacting justice allows wickedness to flourish.
Analysis: This is a powerful statement about the consequences of inaction. "Sparing justice"
(i.e., failing to punish the guilty) is seen as actively enabling further wrongdoing. This acts as a strong justification for her demand, positioning revenge as a moral imperative, not just a
personal desire. It's also an example of a gnomic statement, a proverb-like expression of a general truth. "Feeds iniquity" employs personification, giving iniquity the quality of being fed
and growing stronger.

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece, facing imminent death after her rape, implores her husband Collatinus to seek immediate and total revenge on Tarquin. She acknowledges that this revenge cannot undo the harm done to her, but it is still essential to ensure justice and prevent future atrocities. She argues that failing to punish Tarquin will only encourage further wickedness, making revenge a moral imperative rather than a selfish act. She uses a combination of appeals to his love for her, his sense of honor, and his civic duty to motivate him to action, framing her death as a catalyst for a greater good.

Literary Devices Summary:

Tricolon: The repetition of "thine, mine, his own" for emphasis.
Concession: Acknowledging the futility of revenge in saving her life, but still demanding it.
Gnomic Statement: "For sparing justice feeds iniquity" – a proverb-like expression of a general truth.
Personification: "Feeds iniquity" - giving iniquity the ability to be fed.
Rhetorical Question (Implied): She doesn't ask outright, but she directs a forceful command which strongly implies that the answer should be 'yes'.

This stanza is a key moment in the poem, highlighting Lucrece's strength, her commitment to justice, and her desire to use her tragic fate to prevent future suffering. It is a powerful call to action that sets the stage for the political upheaval that follows.

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← Stanza 241📚 OverviewStanza 243 →

Stanza 242 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 242 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece piece by piece and then discuss its overall meaning.
Breakdown of each line:

"But ere I name him, you fair lords," quoth she:

"But ere I name him" - This means "But before I tell you his name..." It creates suspense and emphasizes the gravity of Lucrece's situation.
"you fair lords" - This is a direct address to the noblemen who have come to her side with her husband, Collatine. "Fair" is used here in the sense of noble and honorable.
"quoth she" - This is an archaic way of saying "said she." It's a common device in narrative poetry to indicate the speaker.
Literary Devices: Direct Address (to the lords).

"Speaking to those that came with Collatine,"

This line clarifies who Lucrece is addressing. It's important to note that her husband is present, which adds to the drama and weight of her words.
Literary Devices: None

"Shall plight your honourable faiths to me,"

"Shall plight your honourable faiths" - This means "You must pledge your honorable promises/oaths." "Plight" suggests a solemn commitment. "Honourable faiths" reinforces the idea that she is speaking to men of high standing and expects them to act according to their principles. Literary Devices: Alliteration of "faiths" and "fair" (although 'fair' is in the previous line).

"With swift pursuit to venge this wrong of mine;"

"With swift pursuit" - She wants them to act quickly. Urgency is key.
"to venge this wrong of mine" - She wants them to avenge the wrong that has been done to her, namely, the rape. This line clearly states her desire for revenge.
Literary Devices: Alliteration of "swift pursuit".

"For ’tis a meritorious fair design"

"For 'tis a meritorious fair design" - This means "Because it is a worthy and just plan." "Meritorious" means deserving of praise or reward. "Fair" here means just or good. "Design" means purpose or plan.
Literary Devices: Metaphor (Revenge is portrayed as a 'design', highlighting its planned and deliberate nature).

"To chase injustice with revengeful arms."

"To chase injustice" - To pursue and drive out injustice.
"with revengeful arms" - This means through the use of force and violence motivated by revenge. It emphasizes the active and aggressive nature of the required response. "Arms" are not necessarily literal weapons but represent power and action.

“But ere I name him, you fair lords,” quoth she,
Speaking to those that came with Collatine,
“Shall plight your honourable faiths to me,
With swift pursuit to venge this wrong of mine;
For ’tis a meritorious fair design
To chase injustice with revengeful arms.
Knights, by their oaths, should right poor ladies’ harms.”

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Literary Devices: Metaphor (Injustice is described as something that can be 'chased'). Personification (Injustice is treated like an entity that can be chased)

"Knights, by their oaths, should right poor ladies’ harms.”

"Knights, by their oaths" - Knights are the epitome of chivalry, and they are bound by oaths to protect the weak and innocent.
"should right poor ladies’ harms" - This means that knights should correct the wrongs done to defenseless women. "Right" means to correct or set right. "Harms" refers to the injuries and damages she has suffered.
Literary Devices: None

Overall Meaning:

In this stanza, Lucrece, before revealing the name of her attacker, demands a solemn oath from the noblemen present. She insists that they swear to avenge the wrong that has been done to her. She frames the act of revenge as a "meritorious fair design," implying that it is a just and honorable cause. She reminds them that as knights, they are sworn to protect and defend women, particularly those who have been harmed.

The stanza is a call to action. Lucrece uses powerful language to manipulate their sense of duty and honor. She presents her revenge as not just a personal matter, but as a moral imperative, a way to uphold the chivalric code and restore justice. The lines are charged with emotion and a sense of urgency, reflecting Lucrece's desperate desire for retribution. The stanza sets the stage for the revelation of Tarquin's name and the ensuing pursuit of justice (or, more accurately, revenge) by the noblemen. The emphasis on oaths and vows will be relevant later in the poem as it highlights the importance of keeping one's word.

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← Stanza 242📚 OverviewStanza 244 →

Stanza 243 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 243 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece line by line and then provide an overall interpretation, highlighting the literary devices:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"At this request, with noble disposition"

Meaning: In response to Lucrece's plea (likely for revenge or assistance in seeking justice), the noblemen present were inclined to help. "Noble disposition" suggests they were inclined to act honorably and with compassion.
Literary Devices: Alliteration of "noble" and "disposition" gives emphasis to the lords' characteristics.

"Each present lord began to promise aid,"

Meaning: Every nobleman who was there started to offer his help to Lucrece.
Literary Devices: None particularly stand out here, this is a straightforward statement of action.

"As bound in knighthood to her imposition,"

Meaning: They felt obligated by their chivalric oaths and the moral duty that knighthood entailed to fulfill her demand or command (her "imposition"). The idea of "imposition" is somewhat interesting. It suggests that helping her isn't just a charitable act, but almost an obligation, something she is laying upon them because of the horror inflicted upon her.
Literary Devices: Allusion to the code of Knighthood that governed their behavior and actions.

"Longing to hear the hateful foe bewrayed."

Meaning: They eagerly wanted to hear the identity of her attacker (Tarquin) revealed, so that justice could be served. "Bewrayed" means revealed, betrayed, or exposed.
Literary Devices: Alliteration of "hateful" and "hear." The use of the word "foe" builds suspense, and "bewrayed" adds a layer of dramatic effect.

"But she, that yet her sad task hath not said,"

Meaning: But Lucrece, who has not yet finished the complete account of her suffering.
Literary Devices: Parenthetical phrase - "that yet her sad task hath not said" interrupts the main sentence to emphasize her unfinished story.

"The protestation stops. “O, speak,” quoth she,"

Meaning: The lords' eagerness to help is halted, and Lucrece interrupts their promises, saying,
"O, speak." "Quoth she" is an archaic way of saying "she said."
Literary Devices: Caesura (a pause) in the line due to punctuation emphasizes the interruption.

“How may this forced stain be wiped from me?”

Meaning: She is asking how her honor, which has been defiled by this rape, can be restored or cleansed.

At this request, with noble disposition
Each present lord began to promise aid,
As bound in knighthood to her imposition,
Longing to hear the hateful foe bewrayed.
But she, that yet her sad task hath not said, The protestation stops. “O, speak,” quoth she, “How may this forced stain be wiped from me?

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Literary Devices: Metaphor - The rape is referred to as a "forced stain," indicating the defilement and dishonor it has caused. The question, rather than being literal, is rhetorical, highlighting her despair and concern for her reputation.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza depicts the initial reaction of the noblemen to Lucrece's revelation of her rape. They are moved by her plight and, motivated by their code of chivalry, are quick to offer their assistance and express their desire to bring her attacker to justice. However, Lucrece cuts them off, showing that their eagerness for revenge is not what she is most concerned with. Her primary focus is on the irreparable damage that has been done to her honor and reputation. She is less interested in punishment of the perpetrator than in her own purification. The stanza highlights the societal importance of honor and reputation, particularly for women in this period, and underscores the depth of Lucrece's anguish. It reveals that revenge, which the lords initially presume is her goal, is secondary to her own personal struggle with shame and dishonor.

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← Stanza 243📚 OverviewStanza 245 →

Stanza 244 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down stanza 244 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" line by line, then consider the overall meaning.

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"What is the quality of my offence,"

Analysis: Lucrece begins by questioning the nature or severity of her sin/crime/transgression.
She is pondering how much blame she actually bears. "Quality" is not about how she committed
it, but how bad it is.
Literary Device: This is a rhetorical question. She isn't necessarily expecting an answer, but posing a question to prompt deeper reflection.

"Being constrained with dreadful circumstance?"

Analysis: She emphasizes that her actions were "constrained," meaning forced or compelled, by terrible (dreadful) circumstances. The circumstance being her rape.
Literary Device: Alliteration ("dreadful circumstance"). This draws emphasis to the horrifying nature of the situation she was in. The line functions as an explanation to the previous line, as to why she is asking what the quality of her crime is.

"May my pure mind with the foul act dispense,"

Analysis: Can her innocent and virtuous (pure) inner self be separate (dispense) from the disgusting/evil (foul) deed that was forced upon her. She is asking if she should be judged simply on the fact that the act happened, or if she should be judged on her intentions (to remain pure.) Literary Device: Juxtaposition of "pure mind" and "foul act" highlights the internal conflict and the contrast between her inner virtue and the external defilement.

"My low-declined honour to advance?"

Analysis: She asks whether performing a further act can restore her honor, which has been diminished by the rape. It is important to note that her honor is "low-declined" -- it has been knocked down by the circumstance.
Literary Device: "Low-declined honour" is a somewhat euphemistic way of describing her dishonored state. It softens the bluntness.

"May any terms acquit me from this chance?"

Analysis: Can any agreement (terms) or conditions clear (acquit) her of this misfortune (chance)? Chance here refers to the random event that brought about the rape.
Literary Device: This line uses an archaic legalistic tone to frame the situation, as though she is pleading to a judge.

"The poisoned fountain clears itself again,"

Analysis: A powerful metaphor: If a spring of water, even if poisoned or polluted (poisoned fountain), can purify itself, shouldn't the same be true for her? She uses this as an argument to support the idea of her own redemption.
Literary Device: Metaphor. The "poisoned fountain" symbolizes her defiled state.

“What is the quality of my offence,
Being constrained with dreadful circumstance?
May my pure mind with the foul act dispense,
My low-declined honour to advance?
May any terms acquit me from this chance?
The poisoned fountain clears itself again, And why not I from this compelled stain?

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"And why not I from this compelled stain?"

Analysis: This echoes the previous line, solidifying her argument. If a fountain can clear itself, why can't she be cleansed from the stain (the rape) that was forced upon her? The "compelled stain" is an example of how she views the situation -- she was forced into a situation, and it
created a stain.
Literary Device: Rhetorical Question (similar to the first line of the stanza).

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza reveals Lucrece's agonizing internal conflict as she grapples with the aftermath of her rape. She is desperately seeking a way to reconcile the physical act with her inner sense of purity and honor. She questions the nature of her "offence," arguing that she was "constrained" by circumstances beyond her control. She hopes that her mind, which remained uncorrupted, can somehow mitigate the foulness of the act. The stanza builds to a powerful analogy of a "poisoned fountain" purifying itself, suggesting that she too should be able to cleanse herself of the "compelled stain."

Essentially, Lucrece is in the midst of trying to figure out if she is still considered to be pure, despite the fact that the rape occurred. If the rape has forever tarnished her honor, she needs to figure out how to restore it. She ponders whether a further act is necessary to restore it. This stanza demonstrates her struggle to determine whether she is at fault, how much of the blame she bears, and whether there is a path to redemption or restoration of her honor.

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Stanza 245 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Shakespeare's stanza 245 from The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-line breakdown:

"With this, they all at once began to say," This line sets the scene. "With this" refers to some preceding event (Lucrece's declaration of her rape). A group of people, likely her family and friends, attempt to console her. The word "all at once" emphasizes their simultaneous, perhaps slightly overwhelming, attempt at comfort.

"Her body’s stain her mind untainted clears," This is a crucial line, demonstrating a complex moral dilemma present in the poem. "Body's stain" refers to the physical violation she suffered. "Mind untainted clears" suggests that her virtue and moral integrity remain unsullied despite the physical assault. This is a common sentiment of the time, differentiating between bodily defilement and moral corruption. This is a paradox - how can a physical act not stain the mind? It shows the limitations of the societal understanding of rape and female virtue.

"While with a joyless smile she turns away" Lucrece's reaction is described. The "joyless smile" is an oxymoron, highlighting the forced nature of her response. She's trying to appear composed, but her inner turmoil is evident. The act of turning away shows her rejection of their attempts at comfort.

"The face, that map which deep impression bears" This line employs a metaphor. Lucrece's face is compared to a "map" that bears the "deep impression" of her suffering. The "map" metaphor suggests the lasting, visible scars of her trauma. The choice of "map" emphasizes the profound and indelible nature of her emotional and psychological wounds.

"Of hard misfortune, carved in it with tears." This continues the "map" metaphor. The "hard misfortune" is the rape, and the "tears" are the agents that have etched the suffering onto her face. The verb "carved" emphasizes the permanence and severity of her trauma.

“No, no,” quoth she, “no dame, hereafter living” Lucrece emphatically rejects the attempted consolation. "Quoth she" is an archaic phrasing meaning "she said". She declares that no other woman should use her experience as an excuse for similar behavior.

“By my excuse shall claim excuse’s giving.” This is the climax of the stanza. Lucrece refuses to let her experience justify the actions of others. She will not offer an excuse for future victims, nor will she accept an excuse for her own violation. It shows her strength of character and
unwillingness to let the act define her or excuse others. This is a very important idea,
foreshadowing her suicide: she won't allow others to justify their crimes with her example.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza depicts Lucrece's resolute refusal to accept the societal comfort offered to her. While others attempt to minimize her trauma by separating her physical violation from her moral character, Lucrece recognizes the profound and lasting impact of the rape. The stanza highlights the limitations of the patriarchal worldview of the time while showcasing Lucrece's strength, integrity, and determination to avoid setting a precedent that would excuse future acts of violence against women.

With this, they all at once began to say,
Her body’s stain her mind untainted clears,
While with a joyless smile she turns away
The face, that map which deep impression bears
Of hard misfortune, carved in it with tears.
“No, no,” quoth she, “no dame, hereafter living By my excuse shall claim excuse’s giving.”

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The literary devices used underscore the depth of her suffering and the complexity of her response, making it a pivotal moment in the narrative.
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Stanza 246 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 246 of Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Part-by-Part Analysis:

"Here with a sigh, as if her heart would break,"

"Here": Indicates a shift in focus, perhaps bringing the reader to Lucrece's current state or the climax of her suffering.
"with a sigh, as if her heart would break": Sets the emotional tone. The sigh is a physical manifestation of her immense grief and suffering. The phrase "as if her heart would break" uses simile (comparing her state to a heart breaking), emphasizing the depth of her anguish. It foreshadows the imminent end.

"She throws forth Tarquin’s name: “He, he,” she says,"

"She throws forth Tarquin's name": A powerful verb "throws" suggests an explosive release, perhaps of the information, or a desperate attempt to name her violator. It could also represent her inability to hold back the truth.
"“He, he,” she says,": This is a fragmented and emotionally charged response. The repetition of "He" (a type of anaphora) reveals Lucrece's inability to fully articulate what happened. She is in shock and her articulation is failing.

"But more than “he” her poor tongue could not speak;"

"But more than “he” her poor tongue could not speak": Reinforces the idea of her distress and trauma. Her "poor tongue" is almost paralyzed by the horror she has experienced. The very act of speaking the name seems to be all she can manage at this point.

"Till after many accents and delays,"

"Till after many accents and delays": This clause introduces the difficulty and effort involved in the remainder of her speech. "Accents" could refer to the stress or emphasis in her words, indicating her physical difficulty in speaking. "Delays" highlights the pauses and hesitancy, reflecting her mental state.

"Untimely breathings, sick and short assays,"

"Untimely breathings": Implies that her breathing is irregular and possibly labored.
"sick and short assays": "Sick" suggests weakness and vulnerability. "Short assays" means brief attempts at speech. This builds a strong image of Lucrece's physical and emotional breakdown. The phrases use alliteration, further adding to the intensity and dramatic effect, "sick and short".

"She utters this: “He, he, fair lords, ’tis he,"

"She utters this": After significant struggle, she finally manages a complete phrase. The action is a momentous release.

"He, he, fair lords, 'tis he,": This repetition of "he" (again, anaphora) emphasizes Tarquin's culpability, the "fair lords" being the witnesses who are present to hear her confession. The repetition makes it plain to all present who committed the crime.

Here with a sigh, as if her heart would break,
She throws forth Tarquin’s name: “He, he,” she says,
But more than “he” her poor tongue could not speak;
Till after many accents and delays,
Untimely breathings, sick and short assays,
She utters this: “He, he, fair lords, ’tis he,
That guides this hand to give this wound to me.”

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"That guides this hand to give this wound to me.”
"That guides this hand to give this wound to me": The culmination of the stanza. Lucrece accuses Tarquin of forcing her to commit suicide (the "wound"). This statement reveals not only
the rape but also the final act - her self-inflicted death. The use of "guides" could be seen as a metaphor, suggesting that Tarquin has manipulated her to such an extent that she now believes the only honorable course of action is self-inflicted death. This is where she places blame
squarely where it belongs.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza marks a crucial moment in the poem. It is the culmination of Lucrece's immense suffering. It is her attempt to communicate the horrific act of rape and its devastating consequences. It conveys her struggle to articulate her pain and shame, as well as her determination to reveal the truth of Tarquin's actions. The stanza showcases her physical and emotional breakdown as she reveals Tarquin's role in her rape and suicide. It is her confession and final act of defiance.

Literary Devices Summary:

Simile: "as if her heart would break"
Anaphora: Repetition of "He" in several places.
Alliteration: "sick and short"
Metaphor: "That guides this hand"

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← Stanza 246📚 OverviewStanza 248 →

Stanza 247 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line by Line Breakdown and Literary Devices:
"Even here she sheathed in her harmless breast"

Meaning: Lucrece, in this very moment, plunges a knife into her body.
"Even here": This phrase emphasizes the immediacy and finality of the action.
"sheathed": This is a strong verb choice; it typically describes putting a weapon into its
container. The unexpected use of the word here highlights the violence of her act.
"harmless breast": This is ironic. The breast, the seat of life, is described as "harmless" before being tragically violated.

"A harmful knife, that thence her soul unsheathed."

Meaning: She uses a knife (a weapon) to take her own life and free her soul.
"A harmful knife": Obvious - this shows how the action will affect Lucrece.
"unsheathed": This is a metaphorical extension of "sheathed". Just as the knife was "sheathed" in her body, the knife now "unsheathed" her soul, separating it from her body. This emphasizes the dual nature of the act - physical violence and spiritual release.
Literary Device: Antithesis (juxtaposition of contrasting ideas), as the first line mentioned a 'harmless breast', and now there's a 'harmful knife'. It also uses personification.

"That blow did bail it from the deep unrest"

Meaning: The stab freed her soul from the turmoil of her experience (specifically, from her shame and the violation she suffered).
"That blow": Direct reference to the act of suicide.
"bail it from the deep unrest": "Bail" suggests setting free, and "deep unrest" conveys the emotional and psychological torment Lucrece endures.
Literary Device: Metaphor of a prison, as she's 'bailed' from a place of unrest.

"Of that polluted prison where it breathed."

Meaning: The body itself, where her soul once lived, is now a "polluted prison" because of the rape and its subsequent moral decay and shame.
"polluted prison": This harsh image symbolizes the degradation and violation of her body. The corruption is internal, not external; she feels her body is ruined.
"where it breathed": This implies that her body was once a place of life, before this tragedy. Literary Device: Metaphor: The body is described as a "polluted prison". This is a strong metaphor for the degradation and violation Lucrece has suffered.

"Her contrite sighs unto the clouds bequeathed"

Meaning: Her deep, sorrowful sighs are given to the heavens (the clouds).
"contrite sighs": Highlights her remorse and regret, likely not only for the rape, but for the dishonor she fears she has brought to her family.

Even here she sheathed in her harmless breast
A harmful knife, that thence her soul unsheathed.
That blow did bail it from the deep unrest
Of that polluted prison where it breathed.
Her contrite sighs unto the clouds bequeathed
Her winged sprite, and through her wounds doth fly Life’s lasting date from cancelled destiny.

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"bequeathed": This is a legal term, usually used to describe giving something to someone after death. It further emphasizes the finality of the action and the soul's departure.
Literary Device: Personification: The sighs are "bequeathed," giving them agency and a sense of communication with the heavens.

"Her winged sprite, and through her wounds doth fly"

Meaning: Her soul ("winged sprite") flies away from her body through her wounds.
"winged sprite": Refers to her soul, using the idea of a spirit or essence.
"through her wounds doth fly": This emphasizes the physical reality of her death and the soul's escape. The wounds are the gateway.
Literary Device: Metaphor (soul as a winged sprite).

"Life’s lasting date from cancelled destiny."

Meaning: Suicide has abruptly ended her life (the "date" she was meant to live) and has, in effect, cancelled the future she might have had.
"Life’s lasting date": Refers to the length of her life.
"cancelled destiny": Emphasizes the ending of her fate - how the act of suicide has changed her trajectory.
Literary Device: Metaphor: "Life's lasting date" is a metaphor for her life.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a powerful description of Lucrece's suicide. It highlights the following key themes:

Loss of Honor and Purity: The rape has utterly violated Lucrece. She views her body as "polluted," a prison, and believes her honor is irretrievably lost.
Suicide as an Act of Freedom: Lucrece sees suicide as a way to escape the pain and shame, a way to "bail" her soul from its torment.
The Finality of Death: Shakespeare emphasizes the act of suicide, with the use of strong verbs, metaphors and imagery.
The Aftermath: Lucrece's spirit departs, and her death has changed her destiny.

Shakespeare masterfully uses language and imagery to convey the depth of Lucrece's despair, the violence of her act, and the finality of her death. The metaphors create vivid pictures, while the use of personification adds emotional weight.
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Stanza 248 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

1. "Stone-still, astonished with this deadly deed,"

"Stone-still": A simile, comparing the men to statues, emphasizing their utter lack of movement. This highlights their shock and paralysis.
"astonished": Means extremely surprised and horrified.
"this deadly deed": Refers to Lucrece's suicide, the act of self-slaughter.
Overall: The initial reaction of the men present (Collatine and his crew) is one of frozen, dumbfounded horror. They are unable to process what has just happened.

2. "Stood Collatine and all his lordly crew,"
"Collatine": Lucrece's husband.
"lordly crew": The other noblemen who accompanied Collatine.
Overall: Simply states who is present and reinforces their stunned state.

3. "Till Lucrece’ father that beholds her bleed,"

"Lucrece's father": Her father, a prominent man in their society, likely a senator or a high-ranking official.
"beholds her bleed": Sees the blood flowing from her self-inflicted wound, highlighting the visual horror of the scene.
Overall: Introduces Lucrece's father, and emphasizes the devastating impact of seeing his daughter's blood.

4. "Himself on her self-slaughtered body threw,"

"Himself...threw": Indicates that her father collapses, possibly in grief or to hold her. "self-slaughtered body": A direct and stark description of Lucrece, emphasizing her suicide. Overall: Depicts the father's grief and physical response to his daughter's death.

5. "And from the purple fountain Brutus drew"

"Brutus": Lucius Junius Brutus, a key figure in the overthrow of the Tarquins and the founding of the Roman Republic.
"purple fountain": This is a metaphor for Lucrece's blood, the color linking it to royalty and nobility. The wound gushing with blood is described as a fountain.
"drew": Brutus likely takes the knife from Lucrece's body.
Overall: Brutus now takes action. The blood evokes a sense of beauty and destruction, indicating her high social status and the violence that is being inflicted.

6. "The murd’rous knife, and, as it left the place,"

"murd'rous knife": An example of personification, as the knife is given the attribute of killing. "as it left the place": Emphasizes the instant reaction of blood.
Overall: Describes Brutus taking the knife from her body.

Stone-still, astonished with this deadly deed,
Stood Collatine and all his lordly crew,
Till Lucrece’ father that beholds her bleed,
Himself on her self-slaughtered body threw,
And from the purple fountain Brutus drew
The murd’rous knife, and, as it left the place, Her blood, in poor revenge, held it in chase;

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7. "Her blood, in poor revenge, held it in chase;"

"Her blood... held it in chase": Personification. The blood is depicted as actively pursuing the knife, almost as if the blood wants revenge on the instrument of death.
"poor revenge": The revenge of blood is futile, since Lucrece is already dead. It underscores the tragedy and the pointlessness of her death.
Overall: The blood seems to be actively seeking vengeance on the knife. It also indicates an overwhelming of blood and suffering.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a vivid portrayal of the immediate aftermath of Lucrece's suicide. The men are initially paralyzed by shock. We see the raw grief of her father, and Brutus begins to take control of the situation by removing the knife, perhaps as a symbol of taking action to seek justice. The overwhelming bloodshed is described in vivid detail, as Shakespeare uses metaphors and personification to emphasize the tragedy and the futility of revenge at this moment. The stanza sets the scene for Brutus's decision to avenge Lucrece and rouse the Romans against the Tarquins, which is a key turning point in the poem.

Key Literary Devices:
Simile: "Stone-still"
Metaphor: "purple fountain"
Personification: Giving human qualities to non-human things (e.g., "murd'rous knife", "held it in chase" of her blood)
Imagery: The visual descriptions of the blood and the reactions of the characters create powerful images in the reader's mind.
Alliteration: "self-slaughtered" and "poor revenge"
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← Stanza 248📚 OverviewStanza 250 →

Stanza 249 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 249 from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece":

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"And bubbling from her breast, it doth divide"

"And": Conjunction, connecting this line to the previous description of Lucrece's suicide.
"bubbling": A vivid, onomatopoeic word, suggesting the sound and appearance of blood emerging from her chest wound.
"from her breast": Specifies the origin of the blood, emphasizing the violence.
"it doth divide": The blood, initially a single flow, is now splitting into two separate streams.

"In two slow rivers, that the crimson blood"

"In two slow rivers": Compares the flowing blood to rivers, using imagery of breadth and scale. "Slow" emphasizes the methodical nature of her death.
"that the crimson blood": Further specifies the nature of these rivers. "Crimson" is a powerful word for red, describing the color of blood.

"Circles her body in on every side,"

"Circles her body": The rivers of blood are now flowing around her, encompassing her.
"in on every side": Reinforces the idea of complete encirclement.

"Who, like a late-sacked island, vastly stood"

"Who": Referring back to Lucrece.
"like a late-sacked island": A simile comparing Lucrece to an island that has just been pillaged. This is a key image. "Sacked" implies destruction, violation, and loss.
"vastly stood": Emphasizes the stark, isolated, and desolate appearance of Lucrece.

"Bare and unpeopled in this fearful flood."

"Bare and unpeopled": Describes the island (Lucrece). "Bare" suggests her vulnerability and exposure; "unpeopled" emphasizes the absence of life.
"in this fearful flood": Refers to the blood, highlighting the terrifying nature of the scene.

"Some of her blood still pure and red remained,"

"Some of her blood still pure and red remained": Describes a portion of the blood as still vibrant, untouched by any outside influence.

"And some looked black, and that false Tarquin stained."

"And some looked black": This indicates that another portion of the blood is now dark, suggesting that it has been tainted.
"and that false Tarquin stained": The contrast between the pure and tainted blood highlights the impact of Tarquin. Tarquin's guilt has "stained" her blood.

And bubbling from her breast, it doth divide
In two slow rivers, that the crimson blood
Circles her body in on every side,
Who, like a late-sacked island, vastly stood
Bare and unpeopled in this fearful flood.
Some of her blood still pure and red remained,
And some looked black, and that false Tarquin stained.

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Literary Devices:

Onomatopoeia: "bubbling"
Simile: "like a late-sacked island"
Metaphor: "two slow rivers," "fearful flood" (both comparing the blood to something else) Personification: While not explicit, the blood "circles" and "stains" can be considered a subtle personification.
Imagery: The entire stanza is rich in visual imagery, creating a powerful and graphic depiction of Lucrece's suicide.
Alliteration: "b" in "bubbling from her breast"

Overall Meaning:

This stanza vividly portrays the aftermath of Lucrece's suicide. The blood, described in graphic and symbolic terms, emphasizes the violence and violation she has suffered. The "two slow rivers" of blood expanding and circling her body creates an image of overwhelming destruction and loss. The simile of the "late-sacked island" underscores her desolation and vulnerability. The contrast between the pure, red blood and the black, stained blood powerfully highlights the irreversible act and Tarquin's corruption of Lucrece's innocence. The stanza emphasizes the physical and emotional destruction wrought by the rape, transforming Lucrece into an object of ruin. It is a powerful visual representation of her death and the impact of Tarquin's actions.

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← Stanza 249📚 OverviewStanza 251 →

Stanza 250 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 250 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Analysis:

"About the mourning and congealed face"

"About": Around, surrounding.
"mourning": Lamenting, sorrowful, as if in grief.
"congealed face": The solidified, clotted blood, often described as the color black. This personifies the blood as having a "face" experiencing grief.
This introduces the visual imagery, and sets the scene of the blood that has clotted.

"Of that black blood a wat’ry rigol goes,"

"Of that black blood": Referring to the clotted blood mentioned previously.
"a wat’ry rigol goes": A circular or watery trace, a ring or halo. It refers to a watery fluid that has separated from the blood.
This continues the visual imagery, suggesting a circle of clear fluid surrounding the dark, clotted blood.

"Which seems to weep upon the tainted place;"

"Which": Referring to the "wat'ry rigol."
"seems to weep": Personification. The watery circle appears to shed tears.
"upon the tainted place": Over the spot where Lucrece was violated and suffered, adding a tone of sadness.
This deepens the sense of sadness and the atmosphere of tragedy.

"And ever since, as pitying Lucrece’ woes,"
"And ever since": From that moment on.
"as pitying Lucrece’ woes": Because of pity for Lucrece's suffering.
This introduces a temporal perspective, suggesting the ongoing effects of the tragedy. "Corrupted blood some watery token shows,"

"Corrupted blood": Referring to the blood that was shed as a result of the rape.
"some watery token shows": It shows a watery sign or indication. This could be interpreted as a physical sign of the event, or it could refer to tears.
This focuses on the physical changes the blood has undergone, reinforcing the image of decay and sorrow.

"And blood untainted still doth red abide,"

"And": Introduces a contrasting idea.
"blood untainted": Blood that is not involved in the trauma or the rape, or in this case, a good person.
"still doth red abide": Remain red. "Abide" means to remain or stay. This highlights the contrast in color between pure and corrupted blood.

About the mourning and congealed face
Of that black blood a wat’ry rigol goes,
Which seems to weep upon the tainted place;
And ever since, as pitying Lucrece’ woes,
Corrupted blood some watery token shows,
And blood untainted still doth red abide, Blushing at that which is so putrified.

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This contrasts the pure blood with the tainted blood, offering a moral commentary.

"Blushing at that which is so putrified."

"Blushing": Another instance of personification, as if the untainted blood is ashamed.
"at that which is so putrified": At the corrupted or rotten state of the tainted blood.
This draws a parallel between purity and shame, and corruption.

Literary Devices:

Personification: Giving human qualities to inanimate objects or concepts (blood "mourning," "weeping," "blushing").
Imagery: Vivid descriptions appeal to the senses, especially sight (the visual description of the blood).
Metaphor: The blood itself becomes a metaphor for the purity of Lucrece and the corruption she suffers. The "tainted place" is a metaphor for the act of rape.
Contrast: The stanza contrasts the corrupted, "tainted" blood with the untainted, pure blood. Alliteration: the repeating use of the "w" sound in the first three lines "About the mourning and congealed face / Of that black blood a wat’ry rigol goes, / Which seems to weep upon the tainted place;"

Overall Meaning and Interpretation:

The stanza presents a highly visual and emotional depiction of the aftermath of Lucrece's rape, focusing on the physical state of her blood and the symbolic implications. The clotted blood, described as having a "mourning" and "congealed face," is encircled by a "wat'ry rigol," which "seems to weep," creating an image of profound sorrow and loss. The stanza also uses personification to add to the overall sorrow of the poem.

The contrast between the "corrupted" blood and the "untainted" blood emphasizes the violation and the lasting impact of the trauma. The "blushing" of the untainted blood suggests shame and moral revulsion at the corruption. The visual description underscores the devastating effect of the act, turning the tragedy into something tangible and almost sentient. The blood itself becomes a physical manifestation of her loss of innocence and purity, the degradation of her body, and the moral corruption of her tormentor.

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← Stanza 250📚 OverviewStanza 252 →

Stanza 251 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Okay, let's break down Stanza 251 from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece":

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Daughter, dear daughter,” old Lucretius cries,
"Daughter, dear daughter": Direct address. Lucretius, Lucrece's father, speaks to her, using affectionate language. The repetition of "daughter" emphasizes his grief and shock.
"old Lucretius cries": Identifies the speaker and action. The word "cries" sets the tone of sadness.

“That life was mine which thou hast here deprived.
"That life was mine": Lucretius claims a sense of ownership over his daughter's life. He feels he, essentially, has been robbed of it.
"which thou hast here deprived": Focuses on the action that led to Lucrece's death (suicide). This is an allusion to Lucrece's suicide, which ended her life.

“If in the child the father’s image lies,
"If": Begins a conditional statement that expresses uncertainty.
"in the child the father's image lies": A metaphorical idea: children reflect their parents, sharing physical features, personality traits, etc.
"Where shall I live now Lucrece is unlived?"
"Where shall I live": A rhetorical question. It implies that Lucretius's world has been destroyed. "now Lucrece is unlived?": A vivid phrase, using the neologism "unlived" (meaning dead). This highlights the idea that life has been taken from his daughter.
"Thou wast not to this end from me derived."
"Thou wast not to this end": She was not meant to have this fate; her death was not the purpose of her existence.
"from me derived": Referring to her being born through him. Her death seems to defy the natural order of life (that the children should not outlive their parents.)

"If children predecease progenitors,
"If": another conditional statement
"children predecease progenitors": The situation where the children die before the parents. This line makes an objective statement about the unnatural loss.

"We are their offspring, and they none of ours."
"We are their offspring": Parents become the "children" of their children, and this makes the parents dependent on them.
"and they none of ours": The children no longer are, because they are dead. This final line captures the tragedy: parents depend on the children for the continuation of life, but if the
children are dead, the parents no longer have anyone to rely on.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a lament by Lucretius, Lucrece's father, expressing the immense grief and disorientation caused by her suicide. He feels a sense of loss that goes beyond his daughter's death, as though his own life has been taken away. He questions the natural order of things. He is struggling to understand

“Daughter, dear daughter,” old Lucretius cries,
“That life was mine which thou hast here deprived.
If in the child the father’s image lies,
Where shall I live now Lucrece is unlived?
Thou wast not to this end from me derived.
If children predecease progenitors,
We are their offspring, and they none of ours.

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how to live without his daughter. This stanza shows the destruction of the family caused by rape and suicide and shows that Lucretius struggles to grapple with the fact that he has to live in a world without his daughter.

Literary Devices:

Direct Address: "Daughter, dear daughter" – This creates a sense of intimacy and highlights Lucretius's emotional connection.
Rhetorical Questions: "Where shall I live now Lucrece is unlived?" – These questions express deep anguish and a lack of understanding.
Metaphor: "If in the child the father's image lies" - Comparing children to the reflection of the parent
Neologism: "unlived" - This is a word that Shakespeare most likely created to emphasize the state of her death.
Conditional Statements: "If" appears in lines 3 and 6, creating a sense of reflection and questioning the fate of his daughter.
Antithesis: The contrasting ideas of life and death are emphasized through the entire stanza, but most notably in line 4.
Imagery: The entire stanza creates a powerful image of grief, loss, and the disruption of the natural order.

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← Stanza 251📚 OverviewStanza 253 →

Stanza 252 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 252 from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece," line by line:

"Poor broken glass, I often did behold": This introduces the speaker (Collatine, Lucrece's husband) comparing Lucrece to "broken glass." This is a metaphor, immediately setting a tone of loss and destruction. The use of "poor" humanizes the glass, making the reader feel pity. "I often
did behold" suggests a past of looking at Lucrece with fondness and care.

"In thy sweet semblance my old age new born;": "Semblance" means appearance or likeness. Collatine saw in Lucrece's youthful beauty a reflection that rejuvenated his own aging. He found a connection to youth in her. This line is a metaphor with the idea that Lucrece's youth was a source of renewal, offering him a glimpse of an age he had left behind.

"But now that fair fresh mirror, dim and old,": "Mirror" is another metaphor for Lucrece. "Dim and old" contrasts sharply with the previous line's "sweet semblance." The use of "but now" signals a change, indicating the transformation of the speaker's outlook due to the act of rape.

"Shows me a bare-boned death by time outworn.": This is a striking metaphor and personification. "Bare-boned death" represents the end, a reminder of mortality. The "time outworn" reinforces the passage of time. Collatine sees his own mortality in her changed face/body, and she now appears as death to him.

"O, from thy cheeks my image thou hast torn,": Here, Collatine directly addresses Lucrece. "Image" refers to the youthful reflection he once saw in her. He feels that his reflection of youth is now gone. This is an apostrophe, a direct address to an absent person or personified thing.

"And shivered all the beauty of my glass,": Continuing the glass metaphor, her beauty is shattered. This is another metaphor. The destruction of the glass mirrors the destruction of their relationship and her former beauty.

"That I no more can see what once I was!": The final line emphasizes the irreversible loss. Collatine can no longer see his youth reflected in Lucrece. This is a powerful statement of despair and the profound impact of the rape.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza conveys Collatine's overwhelming grief and despair over the violation of Lucrece. He mourns the loss of the idealized image he held of her, an image which represented his own connection to youth and beauty. He equates her ruined appearance to a shattered mirror, in which his own future is now bleak and foreshadows death. The stanza is saturated with the pain of betrayal, loss, and the irreversible damage inflicted by the act of rape. It underscores the tragic disruption of their connection and the devastation caused by Tarquin's actions. The imagery vividly paints a picture of shattered beauty and the bleak vision of a future dominated by the awareness of mortality.

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“Poor broken glass, I often did behold
In thy sweet semblance my old age new born;
But now that fair fresh mirror, dim and old,
Shows me a bare-boned death by time outworn.
O, from thy cheeks my image thou hast torn, And shivered all the beauty of my glass, That I no more can see what once I was!

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← Stanza 252📚 OverviewStanza 254 →

Stanza 253 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this powerful stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece.

Line-by-Line Analysis:

"O time, cease thou thy course and last no longer,"

"O time,": Direct address; the speaker is speaking to time itself, personifying it.
"cease thou thy course and last no longer,": A command, an imperative statement,
imploring time to stop its relentless forward movement.
Literary Device: Personification (giving human qualities to time).

"If they surcease to be that should survive!"

"If": Conditional clause, setting up a hypothetical situation.
"they": Refers to the virtuous, the strong, the innocent – Lucrece and, by implication, others like her.
"surcease to be": Stop existing, die.
"that should survive": Those who deserve to live, implying an injustice in their death.
Literary Device: Antithesis (contrast between who dies and who should live).

"Shall rotten death make conquest of the stronger,"

"Shall": Rhetorical question.
"rotten death": Death is personified, described as "rotten" – decaying and vile, an adjective highlighting death's unpleasantness.
"make conquest of the stronger": Conquer, defeat, overcome those who are powerful and worthy.
Literary Device: Personification, alliteration (repetition of "c" sound).

"And leave the falt'ring feeble souls alive?"

"And": Continues the rhetorical questioning started in the previous line.
"the falt'ring feeble souls": Those who are weak, morally and physically, and struggling. "alive": Surviving, continuing to exist.
Literary Device: Antithesis (contrast between strong and weak).

"The old bees die, the young possess their hive."

"The old bees die": A reference to the natural order; old bees are replaced.
"the young possess their hive": The younger generation takes over. This sentence implies that a change in the natural order is abnormal.
Literary Device: Metaphor (comparing the situation to bees, a natural example.)

"Then live, sweet Lucrece, live again and see"

"Then": A consequence of the previous lines, hoping for a different reality.
"live, sweet Lucrece, live again": A direct plea to Lucrece to recover.
Literary Device: Direct Address (Lucrece is spoken to directly).

“O time, cease thou thy course and last no longer,
If they surcease to be that should survive!
Shall rotten death make conquest of the stronger,
And leave the falt’ring feeble souls alive?
The old bees die, the young possess their hive.
Then live, sweet Lucrece, live again and see
Thy father die, and not thy father thee!”

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"Thy father die, and not thy father thee!"

"Thy father die": An expression of the correct order of events: the father should precede the daughter in death.
"and not thy father thee!": A wish that the current order, where Lucrece might die before her father, be reversed.
Literary Device: Antithesis (contrast between dying).

Overall Meaning:

The stanza is a cry of outrage and despair in the face of injustice. The speaker (presumably the person narrating, and therefore reflecting on Lucrece's state), is grappling with the seeming randomness and unfairness of death. They are horrified that the strong (Lucrece) might be defeated by "rotten death," while the weak (implied, those who are perhaps responsible for the act of Lucrece's rape) might continue to live.

The speaker calls for time to stop its relentless march, recognizing that the natural order is perverted if those who deserve to live are taken before those who do not. The bee analogy underlines the point that death usually occurs in the elderly and that the young replace them, but here, a different order is present: the death of the innocent before the guilty.

The final lines express a desperate hope for Lucrece's survival. The speaker longs for a restoration of the natural order where a father outlives his child, rather than the other way around, which feels unnatural and tragic to the speaker. The speaker is imploring for a change and a reversal of the current terrible state. It's a powerful expression of grief, outrage, and a longing for justice and a return to what "should" be.

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← Stanza 253📚 OverviewStanza 255 →

Stanza 254 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 254 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"By this starts Collatine as from a dream,"

"By this": Referring to the act of Lucrece's suicide (which occurs just before this stanza). "starts Collatine": Collatine begins to react.
"as from a dream": Implies a stunned, disoriented state, as if awakening from a nightmare. Literary Device: Simile.

"And bids Lucretius give his sorrow place;"
"And bids": And commands.
"Lucretius": A friend of Collatine and Lucrece's family, likely there as a witness or mourner. "give his sorrow place": Tells Lucretius (presumably) to step back, or perhaps not to be overcome by grief. Implies Collatine is taking charge.

"And then in key-cold Lucrece’ bleeding stream"

"And then": Referring to the next action.
"key-cold": Very cold. Literary Device: Descriptive adjective used to emphasize coldness. The coldness is also symbolic of death and the end of feeling.
"Lucrece' bleeding stream": The blood flowing from Lucrece's wound. This paints a vivid and brutal picture. Literary Device: Metaphor (blood as a stream).

"He falls, and bathes the pale fear in his face,"

"He falls": Collatine falls, either physically or metaphorically in grief.
"bathes the pale fear in his face": His face is pale with fear and grief, as though he is washing it in the blood (and associated emotions). Literary Device: Personification (fear as a thing that can be bathed), Metaphor.

"And counterfeits to die with her a space;"
"counterfeits to die": Pretends to die.
"with her a space": For a short while. He briefly acts as though he will die as well.

"Till manly shame bids him possess his breath,"
"Till": Until.
"manly shame": The shame of not avenging her, or a shame linked to his perceived inability to protect her. Shame for being there, alive, while she is dead. Literary Device: Personification (shame "bids" him).
"bids him possess his breath": Commands him to live. He is reclaiming his life, so he can act. "And live to be revenged on her death."

"And live to be revenged": He decides to live in order to seek vengeance.
"on her death": For her death; to punish Tarquin. The core of his resolve.

By this starts Collatine as from a dream,
And bids Lucretius give his sorrow place;
And then in key-cold Lucrece’ bleeding stream
He falls, and bathes the pale fear in his face,
And counterfeits to die with her a space;
Till manly shame bids him possess his breath, And live to be revenged on her death.

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Overall Meaning:

This stanza vividly portrays Collatine's immediate reaction to Lucrece's suicide. Initially, he is stunned, then overwhelmed with grief and perhaps even a sense of guilt. He acts as though he will die as well, overwhelmed by the tragedy. However, the "manly shame" associated with his helplessness and the lack of vengeance on the rapist (Tarquin) forces him to regain control and resolve to live. He embraces the need for revenge as his primary purpose. It marks a crucial turning point, showing the shift from despair to a determined resolve. It sets the stage for the action that will follow, the pursuit of justice, and ultimately, the fall of the Roman monarchy.

Key Literary Devices and their significance:

Simile ("as from a dream"): Emphasizes Collatine's initial disorientation and shock.
Descriptive Adjective ("key-cold"): Creates a visceral image of death, and symbolizes the end of life.
Metaphor ("bleeding stream"): Intensifies the horror and provides a visual image of Lucrece's fatal wound.
Personification ("shame bids"): Allows Shakespeare to personify and dramatize shame, a powerful emotion that drives Collatine's actions.
Imagery: The stanza is rich with vivid imagery, such as "key-cold Lucrece' bleeding stream" and "bathes the pale fear." This makes the scene incredibly affecting.

The stanza is a powerful and succinct summary of Collatine's psychological journey from shock and grief to a resolute commitment to vengeance.

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← Stanza 254📚 OverviewStanza 256 →

Stanza 255 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece":

Line-by-Line Analysis:

"The deep vexation of his inward soul"

Meaning: This establishes the source of Tarquin's inability to speak. "Vexation" means distress, annoyance, and agitation. "Inward soul" refers to his deepest feelings and emotions.
Literary Device: Alliteration ("deep" and "soul").

"Hath served a dumb arrest upon his tongue;"

Meaning: The intensity of his distress has caused his tongue to be unable to speak. "Dumb arrest" is a metaphorical way of saying silence has been forced upon him.
Literary Device: Metaphor (silence is an "arrest").

"Who, mad that sorrow should his use control"

Meaning: Now that he is struggling to speak, he is angered by the fact that his sorrow is preventing him from expressing himself. He is angry that his emotion "controls" him.
Literary Device: Personification (sorrow is given the agency to "control").

"Or keep him from heart-easing words so long,"

Meaning: He's also angry because his sorrow is preventing him from speaking words that would ease his emotional suffering. He longs to speak and release his pain.
Literary Device: None stand out.

"Begins to talk; but through his lips do throng"

Meaning: He tries to speak, attempting to overcome the silence, but the words come out in a rush, jumbled, and confused. "Throng" means to crowd or swarm.
Literary Device: None stand out.

"Weak words, so thick come in his poor heart’s aid"

Meaning: The words that emerge are weak and fragmented, but they come out in a rush, as if desperately trying to help him express himself. "Poor heart's aid" means words are trying to help his heart.
Literary Device: None stand out.

"That no man could distinguish what he said."

Meaning: Because of the rush of words and his emotional state, no one could understand what
he was trying to say.
Literary Device: None stand out.

Overall Meaning of the Stanza:

This stanza portrays Tarquin's emotional turmoil and the physical manifestations of his guilt and distress after raping Lucrece. The deep shame and regret he experiences are so overwhelming that they physically impede his ability to speak clearly. The stanza emphasizes the immense pressure he is

The deep vexation of his inward soul
Hath served a dumb arrest upon his tongue;
Who, mad that sorrow should his use control
Or keep him from heart-easing words so long,
Begins to talk; but through his lips do throng
Weak words, so thick come in his poor heart’s aid That no man could distinguish what he said.

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under, the struggle to express his feelings, and the resulting failure to communicate effectively. It highlights the power of emotional intensity to both paralyze and distort one's ability to communicate. The jumbled and incoherent words symbolize the chaos and confusion within Tarquin's heart.

In the context of the poem, this stanza foreshadows Tarquin's downfall and the eventual consequences of his actions. The inability to articulate his feelings and the ensuing incoherence represent his inability to contain his inner conflict and the inevitable unraveling of his control.

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← Stanza 255📚 OverviewStanza 257 →

Stanza 256 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 256 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line by Line Breakdown & Literary Devices:

"Yet sometime “Tarquin” was pronounced plain,"
"Yet sometime": Introduces a contrast or a change in behavior.
"“Tarquin” was pronounced plain": Refers to Tarquin's speaking of his own name. The use of quotation marks indicates emphasis on the name itself. Implies that Tarquin would, in the past,
say the name with ease.

"But through his teeth, as if the name he tore."
"But": Contrasts the ease of the past with the present.
"through his teeth": Indicates the difficulty and constrained way in which he now says the
name.

"as if the name he tore": A simile, comparing the way Tarquin says his name to the act of tearing something. This emphasizes his inner turmoil, anger, and perhaps a sense of self-loathing. He's struggling to even utter his own name.

"This windy tempest, till it blow up rain,"
"This windy tempest": A metaphor for Tarquin's emotional state, which is described as a "tempest" or storm of wind. This evokes a sense of agitation, restlessness, and concealed fury. "till it blow up rain": The storm is about to unleash its full potential. Suggests an inevitable release of emotions – specifically, weeping or grief.

"Held back his sorrow’s tide, to make it more."
"Held back his sorrow’s tide": Another metaphor, likening his sorrow to a tide. This implies a powerful and overwhelming force being suppressed.
"to make it more": By holding back the sorrow, it intensifies. The longer he suppresses his emotions, the more powerful and destructive the eventual release will be.

"At last it rains, and busy winds give o’er."
"At last it rains": The moment of emotional release has arrived. The "rain" is the tears or grief. "busy winds give o’er": The wind, representing his internal turmoil and agitation, subsides. This signifies the climax of his emotions, and the beginning of some form of resolution.

"Then son and father weep with equal strife"
"Then son and father weep": Lucrece's father and husband are crying.
"with equal strife": Suggests they are equally overcome by grief and despair.

"Who should weep most, for daughter or for wife."
"Who should weep most": A rhetorical question, highlighting the unbearable nature of their shared loss.

"for daughter or for wife": Refers to Lucrece; the father grieving for his daughter, the husband for his wife. The shared tragedy brings both characters together in their grief.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza depicts Tarquin's internal struggle and the devastating aftermath of his act. It moves from a sense of restrained agitation to a full emotional release. The first part focuses on Tarquin's internal

Yet sometime “Tarquin” was pronounced plain,
But through his teeth, as if the name he tore.
This windy tempest, till it blow up rain,
Held back his sorrow’s tide, to make it more.
At last it rains, and busy winds give o’er.
Then son and father weep with equal strife
Who should weep most, for daughter or for wife.

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conflict. He can barely bring himself to say his name, a clear sign of his disgust and guilt. The metaphors of the "windy tempest" and the "sorrow's tide" illustrate the power of his emotions, which he initially suppresses, thereby intensifying them. The second part of the stanza shifts to the shared grief of Lucrece's family (her father and husband). They are overcome with grief and their struggle to bear the loss of Lucrece is reflected in the rhetorical question about who should grieve more. The stanza emphasizes the profound suffering and the tragic consequences of the rape, as it destroys more than just Lucrece's life, but also the lives of those around her.

Key Literary Devices:
Simile: "as if the name he tore"
Metaphor: "windy tempest," "sorrow's tide," "it rains"
Rhetorical Question: "Who should weep most, for daughter or for wife."
Imagery: Creates a vivid mental image of both Tarquin's internal turmoil and the weeping of the two men.

Contrast: Between Tarquin's past and present, the emotional release vs. the suppression
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← Stanza 256📚 OverviewStanza 258 →

Stanza 257 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece" step-by-step:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"The one doth call her his, the other his,"

"The one": Refers to Tarquin, the rapist.
"The other": Refers to Collatine, Lucrece's husband.
"doth call her his": Both men are claiming ownership of Lucrece. The archaic "doth" is a Shakespearean way of saying "does."
Meaning: Both Tarquin and Collatine are, in different ways, claiming Lucrece as their own. Tarquin has done this with the act of violence and Collatine by virtue of marriage.

"Yet neither may possess the claim they lay,"
"Yet": Introduces a contrast or contradiction.
"neither may possess": Neither can actually have the claim they are making. Tarquin cannot own Lucrece because his "possession" was a violation, and Collatine's claim is now marred by the event.

"the claim they lay": The claims they are making, of possession or ownership.
Meaning: Despite claiming her, neither man can truly possess Lucrece. Tarquin cannot have her in a legitimate way (the rape leaves the claim null and void), and Collatine's possession is tainted by the violation. This highlights the tragedy of the situation, where the act has destroyed the concept of rightful ownership.

"The father says “She’s mine.” “O, mine she is,”"

"The father": Refers to Lucrece's father. This line highlights the grief of all those who loved Lucrece.

"says 'She's mine'": He is claiming her to belong to him by blood/inheritance.
"O, mine she is,”: Is Collatine's immediate response.
Meaning: The father (or the family, in general) mourns for her as she is part of them, and the father feels a sense of ownership. Collatine responds by reinforcing his claim to her through marriage.

"Replies her husband. “Do not take away"

"Replies her husband": Collatine is speaking.
"Do not take away": Emphasizes the possessive nature of Collatine's sorrow.
Meaning: Collatine responds to the father by reiterating his claim and imploring others not to lessen the pain of his loss and that of ownership.

"My sorrow’s interest; let no mourner say"

"My sorrow’s interest": A complex phrase. "Interest" here means a stake or share. Collatine feels that his sorrow is his exclusive right, as it results from his loss. He is "investing" or claiming ownership of this grief.
"let no mourner say": He doesn't want anyone else to claim similar grief.

The one doth call her his, the other his,
Yet neither may possess the claim they lay,
The father says “She’s mine.” “O, mine she is,”
Replies her husband. “Do not take away
My sorrow’s interest; let no mourner say
He weeps for her, for she was only mine,
And only must be wailed by Collatine.”

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Meaning: Collatine demands to be the exclusive owner of the grief caused by Lucrece's death.
He doesn't want others to share in the mourning.

"He weeps for her, for she was only mine,"

"He weeps for her": Refers to any other mourner.
"she was only mine": Reinforces the idea of exclusive possession.
Meaning: Collatine claims that other mourners' grief is less important, as she "only" belonged to him, solidifying the concept of the exclusive claim.

"And only must be wailed by Collatine.”

"And only must be wailed by Collatine": Emphasizes the finality of his claim. The implication
is that no one's grief is as valid.
Meaning: Collatine concludes by insisting that only he has the right to mourn and wail for
Lucrece.

Literary Devices:

Repetition: The repetition of "mine" and the possessive claims throughout the stanza underscores the central theme of ownership and loss.
Irony: The irony lies in the fact that Collatine's claim of ownership is being made after the violation. His claim rings hollow after the rape, highlighting the tragedy. Metaphor/Personification: The stanza personifies sorrow as something that can be "claimed"
and possess "interest." This emphasizes how he is claiming the pain as well as Lucrece.
Climax: The ending of the stanza is the climax of Collatine's claims, as he insists that only he can
mourn.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza encapsulates the devastating consequences of the rape of Lucrece. It reveals the breakdown of order and the utter destruction of the traditional concept of ownership, as it is no longer based on proper conduct. It shows the raw grief and possessiveness of the people who were close to Lucrece, while also highlighting their confusion. Collatine, in his grief, tries to lay exclusive claim to her memory and the pain caused by her death. It is an attempt to regain some semblance of control in a situation that has stripped him of all power. The stanza's focus on the possessive "mine" reinforces the destructive nature of the violation and highlights the tragedy of the situation. It is important to note that Shakespeare is also portraying the idea of grief as a very personal and intimate experience.

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← Stanza 257📚 OverviewStanza 259 →

Stanza 258 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 258 from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"O," quoth Lucretius, "I did give that life"

"O": An expression of grief or anguish.
"quoth Lucretius": "Said Lucretius" - This names the speaker. (Lucretius is Lucrece's father)
"I did give that life": Lucretius is acknowledging that he gave Lucrece her life. He implies responsibility or a deep sense of loss because her life has been unjustly taken.

"Which she too early and too late hath spilled."
"Which": Refers to "that life."
"she": Refers to Lucrece.
"too early and too late": This is a paradox. It means both that Lucrece's death came too soon, and yet, it came at a time after she had already suffered the torment of the rape.
"hath spilled": "Has spilled," meaning lost or wasted. Lucretius mourns that his daughter, who was once alive, has "lost" that life, due to her death.

“Woe, woe,” quoth Collatine, “she was my wife,"

"Woe, woe": Repeated expression of sorrow and grief.
"quoth Collatine": "Said Collatine" - Names the speaker. (Collatine is Lucrece's husband.)
"she was my wife": Collatine states his relationship to the deceased, and in doing so, asserts the nature of their bond and his pain.

"I owed her, and ’tis mine that she hath killed.”

"I owed her": This is a complex statement. Collatine likely means he "owed" Lucrece love, loyalty, and protection. He feels a debt to her that he could not repay.
"and ’tis mine that she hath killed": This means that she has destroyed something of Collatine's, something valuable, namely their marital bond, and life. It suggests a sense of ownership and the devastation of her death. Collatine may be referring to the suicide.

“My daughter” and “my wife” with clamours filled

"“My daughter” and “my wife”": The subject of the sentence, the words representing their relationship to Lucrece.
"with clamours": "Clamours" is plural, and it means a loud and confused noise of people, typically shouting.
"filled": The verb "filled" describes what the clamors did.

The dispersed air, who, holding Lucrece’ life,

"The dispersed air": Metaphorically, the air which is receiving their words, and, by extension, the world, as though these cries of grief were being broadcast.

“O,” quoth Lucretius, “I did give that life
Which she too early and too late hath spilled.”
“Woe, woe,” quoth Collatine, “she was my wife,
I owed her, and ’tis mine that she hath killed.”
“My daughter” and “my wife” with clamours filled
The dispersed air, who, holding Lucrece’ life, Answered their cries, “my daughter” and “my wife”.

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"who, holding Lucrece’ life,": The air metaphorically "holding Lucrece’s life," her life being taken away, implying how she is being taken away from the world. This further emphasizes the finality of her death.

Answered their cries, “my daughter” and “my wife”.

"Answered their cries": This is a personification of the air; It implies a response, even though the response itself is just a repetition.
“my daughter” and “my wife”: The cries repeated, reinforcing the fact that she was both a
daughter and a wife. It's a poignant echo, as the air is "answering" with Lucrece's own
connections. The use of quotation marks suggests this is what Lucrece's spirit would say, if it
could speak again.

Literary Devices:

Personification: The "dispersed air" is given the ability to hold, and then "answer" their cries. Repetition: The phrase "my daughter" and "my wife" is repeated, emphasizing the loss and the shared grief. This repetition creates an effect of increasing lament. The "woe, woe" also is a form of repetition.
Paradox: "too early and too late" creates a contrast, conveying the complex nature of Lucrece's death.
Metaphor: The air can be viewed as a metaphor for the world.
Imagery: The stanza paints a picture of grief and chaos through the use of sound (clamours, cries) and the visual image of the air.

Overall Meaning:

The stanza depicts the raw and devastating grief of Lucretius and Collatine over Lucrece's death. They express their individual relationships to her (father and husband) and their sense of loss. Lucretius acknowledges he gave Lucrece life, which has been "spilled." Collatine, the husband, feels responsible because he could not protect her. The repetition of "my daughter" and "my wife" intensifies the emotional impact, emphasizing the significance of Lucrece's roles in their lives. The air, "holding" and answering their cries, symbolizes the enduring echo of their pain. It serves as a reminder of the lasting impact of her death. This stanza captures the tragic aftermath of the rape and Lucrece's subsequent suicide. It emphasizes the profound sorrow, loss, and a deep-seated sense of betrayal and failure.

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← Stanza 258📚 OverviewStanza 260 →

Stanza 259 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's The Rape of Lucrece:

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"Brutus, who plucked the knife from Lucrece’ side,"

"Brutus": Refers to Lucius Junius Brutus, a Roman nobleman and a key figure in the events following Lucrece's death.
"who plucked the knife from Lucrece' side": This sets the scene, highlighting Brutus's immediate action after Lucrece's suicide. It emphasizes the act of discovering her death.

"Seeing such emulation in their woe,"

"Seeing": Implies observation and awareness.
"such emulation": Suggests a competition or comparison.
"in their woe": Referring to the other men (likely her husband Collatinus, her father, and perhaps other male relatives) mourning Lucrece. It could also mean a competitive display of grief.

"Began to clothe his wit in state and pride,"

"Began to clothe": A metaphor signifying Brutus's deliberate change in demeanor.
"his wit": His intelligence or cleverness.
"in state and pride": This means he started to present himself with dignity, seriousness, and a sense of self-importance. He is shedding his previous mask of foolishness.

"Burying in Lucrece’ wound his folly’s show."

"Burying": Another metaphor. It's about hiding his foolishness.
"in Lucrece’ wound": This is the focal point - it is the tragic event of Lucrece's death that hides his folly, and is now the point of attention.
"his folly’s show": The display of his previous foolish behavior.
"He with the Romans was esteemed so"

"He with the Romans": The people of Rome.
"was esteemed so": Was previously regarded as.

"As silly jeering idiots are with kings,"

"silly jeering idiots": Foolish, mocking, and perhaps harmless characters.
"are with kings": This simile compares Brutus's previous standing to that of a court jester or someone unimportant in the presence of royalty. It means he was looked upon as foolish.

"For sportive words and utt’ring foolish things."

"For sportive words": Because he used to make jokes or play.
"utt'ring foolish things": Saying foolish, empty things.

Brutus, who plucked the knife from Lucrece’ side,
Seeing such emulation in their woe,
Began to clothe his wit in state and pride,
Burying in Lucrece’ wound his folly’s show.
He with the Romans was esteemed so
As silly jeering idiots are with kings,
For sportive words and utt’ring foolish things.

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Literary Devices:

Metaphor: "Began to clothe his wit," "Burying in Lucrece' wound his folly's show."
Simile: "As silly jeering idiots are with kings,"
Alliteration: "woe" and "wound"
Imagery: The visual of Brutus at the scene with Lucrece's dead body.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza marks a pivotal moment in the narrative. It describes Brutus's transformation from a seemingly foolish, harmless individual (who was underestimated by the other Romans) to someone who strategically uses the tragedy of Lucrece's death to his advantage. The stanza explains how Brutus was perceived - as a jester. However, he used the event as an opportunity to hide his true personality, while hiding his foolishness in the attention on Lucrece's tragedy, and revealing a more serious and dignified persona. He has calculatedly chosen this moment, the scene of grief and outrage, to shed his mask and make his intentions known. The stanza is a set-up for the rebellion to follow and lays the foundation for his eventual role in overthrowing the Tarquin monarchy. The poem emphasizes the depth of deception and planning behind Brutus's character.

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Stanza 260 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 260 of Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece":

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"But now he throws that shallow habit by,"

"But now": A transitional phrase, indicating a shift in Tarquin's behavior or intent.
"he": Referring to Tarquin, the rapist.
"throws that shallow habit by": Metaphorically, Tarquin is discarding a pretense or a disguise. "Shallow habit" implies a superficial or inadequate facade. He's dropping the act he was putting
on.

"Wherein deep policy did him disguise,"

"Wherein": Referring to the "shallow habit" mentioned previously; the means by which he was disguised.
"deep policy": Suggests cunning, craftiness, and strategic thinking; the method of disguise. "did him disguise": Indicates that his policy, his cunning, had previously hidden his true intentions.

"And armed his long-hid wits advisedly,"

"And": Continues the thought, adding to Tarquin's shift.
"armed his long-hid wits": A metaphor. Tarquin's intelligence and ability to think strategically ("wits") are "armed," meaning he is now actively employing them for a specific purpose. "Long-hid" implies that these wits were concealed until now.
"advisedly": He is acting deliberately and with forethought. He is planning his actions.

"To check the tears in Collatinus’ eyes."

"To check": To stop, control, or stem.
"the tears in Collatinus' eyes": Collatinus, Lucrece's husband, is in grief, and this is a direct indication of his suffering.
Overall meaning: Tarquin is now using his intelligence to hide or prevent his true reason for being in this situation and to change the tears he has caused.

“Thou wronged lord of Rome,” quoth he, “arise!

“Thou wronged lord of Rome,”: Tarquin addresses Collatinus and is attempting to sound consoling and concerned. It is ironic because Tarquin is the one who has wronged him.
"quoth he": Shakespearean way of saying "said he."
"arise!": An imperative command; an order for Collatinus to stand up, indicating Tarquin's desire to take control.

"Let my unsounded self, supposed a fool,"

"Let": Imperative, meaning that Tarquin wants to allow the following to occur.
"my unsounded self": Implies that Tarquin hasn't been fully explored or tested; he's been underestimated.

But now he throws that shallow habit by,
Wherein deep policy did him disguise,
And armed his long-hid wits advisedly,
To check the tears in Collatinus’ eyes.
“Thou wronged lord of Rome,” quoth he, “arise! Let my unsounded self, supposed a fool,
Now set thy long-experienced wit to school.

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"supposed a fool": Others believe that Tarquin has been considered foolish.
"Now set thy long-experienced wit to school."
"Now": Emphasizes that the action is taking place in the present.
"set thy long-experienced wit to school": A metaphor. Tarquin is implying that Collatinus,
with his long experience, needs to learn from Tarquin's supposed folly. This is an insulting way of trying to show that Collatinus' wit is now going to be taught to him.
Overall Meaning:
This stanza depicts a pivotal moment in Tarquin's manipulation. He discards the mask of deception ("shallow habit"), revealing his true, cunning self ("deep policy"). He actively and consciously uses his intelligence to control the situation and manipulate Collatinus, using flattery and insults to try to hide the fact that Tarquin did something wrong. Tarquin wants to take control of the situation and is trying to hide his motives from Collatinus.
Literary Devices:
Metaphor:
"throws that shallow habit by" - The mask of deception.
"armed his long-hid wits" - The employment of his intelligence.
"set thy long-experienced wit to school" - To have Collatinus learn from Tarquin. Personification:
"wits advisedly" - giving a characteristic to wits
Irony:
"Thou wronged lord of Rome" - Tarquin is the one that wronged Collatinus. Alliteration:
"deep policy"
Imperative Mood/Command:
"Arise!" "Let..."
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← Stanza 260📚 OverviewStanza 262 →

Stanza 261 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 261 from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece":

1. "Why, Collatine, is woe the cure for woe?"

"Why, Collatine,": This is an address to Collatine, Lucrece's husband. The "Why" begins a rhetorical question, drawing attention to the following statements.
"is woe the cure for woe?": This is a rhetorical question. The speaker (likely someone close to Collatine or Lucrece) is asking whether sadness or grief can heal sadness or grief. It implies that Collatine's despair is not the answer.

2. "Do wounds help wounds, or grief help grievous deeds?"

"Do wounds help wounds...": Another rhetorical question, using a simple, visceral analogy. Physical wounds cannot heal other physical wounds.
"...or grief help grievous deeds?": A continuation of the analogy. Grief, in this context, cannot undo or alleviate the heinous deed (the rape). "Grievous deeds" refers to the act of the rape and the resulting shame and suffering.

3. "Is it revenge to give thyself a blow"

"Is it revenge...": Another rhetorical question that questions the nature of Collatine's actions or planned actions.
"...to give thyself a blow": This could refer to self-harm, or the grief that Collatine feels. It is not a productive answer in this scenario.

4. "For his foul act by whom thy fair wife bleeds?"

"For his foul act": This refers to the act of Tarquin, the rapist. The word "foul" highlights the depravity of the act.
"by whom thy fair wife bleeds?": This continues the thought, emphasizing that this act is the cause of his wife's suffering, both physically and emotionally.

5. "Such childish humour from weak minds proceeds."

"Such childish humour": Refers to the emotional response (likely the rage, despair, and possible suicidal thoughts) that the speaker disapproves of.
"from weak minds proceeds": This is a judgement, implying that these immature emotional responses are the result of a lack of strength or fortitude.

6. "Thy wretched wife mistook the matter so,"

"Thy wretched wife": This acknowledges Lucrece's suffering.
"mistook the matter so": This is a direct condemnation of Lucrece's suicide, suggesting that she did not understand the correct course of action.

7. "To slay herself, that should have slain her foe."

"To slay herself": This refers to Lucrece's suicide.
"that should have slain her foe.": This strongly implies that Tarquin, the perpetrator, should have been the one to suffer the consequences, not Lucrece.

“Why, Collatine, is woe the cure for woe?
Do wounds help wounds, or grief help grievous deeds?
Is it revenge to give thyself a blow
For his foul act by whom thy fair wife bleeds?
Such childish humour from weak minds proceeds.
Thy wretched wife mistook the matter so,
To slay herself, that should have slain her foe.

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Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a critical assessment of both Collatine's and, especially, Lucrece's reactions to the rape. It argues that grief and self-inflicted suffering (Collatine's anguish or potential for self harm, Lucrece's suicide) are not appropriate responses to the crime. Instead, the speaker implies that the proper response is one of strength, action, and retribution directed at the perpetrator, Tarquin. The speaker views Lucrece's suicide as a tragic misunderstanding, an incorrect reaction to the crime.

Literary Devices:

Rhetorical Questions: Used throughout to provoke thought and challenge the characters' perspectives. The questions guide the reader/listener toward a particular conclusion.
Analogy: "Do wounds help wounds, or grief help grievous deeds?" compares emotional pain to physical harm to highlight the futility of self-inflicted suffering as a solution.
Metaphor: Woe is being compared to wounds.
Juxtaposition: Contrasting Collatine and Lucrece with the act of rape shows the effect of the action.
Diction: Shakespeare chooses emotionally charged words such as "foul," "wretched," "childish," and "weak" to shape the reader's understanding of the situation and the speaker's viewpoint. Irony: The speaker highlights an ironic situation: the victim (Lucrece) is dead, while the perpetrator lives.
Understatement: The act of suicide is downplayed compared to the crime of rape.
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Stanza 262 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece":

Individual Breakdown:

"Courageous Roman, do not steep thy heart": This is a direct address to Lucius Junius Brutus,
a Roman nobleman, urging him to stop being overwhelmed by grief. "Steep" means to soak or immerse, implying he's drowning in his sorrow. The use of the word "Courageous" is a flattering
way to encourage him and draw him in.

"In such relenting dew of lamentations": This explains what he shouldn't "steep" his heart in. "Relenting dew of lamentations" is a metaphor, comparing Brutus's tears and grief to a soft, yielding moisture. "Lamentations" refers to expressions of grief, sorrow, and mourning. "Relenting" suggests that the tears are making him weak.

"But kneel with me, and help to bear thy part": This is a call to action, urging Brutus to join the speaker in their efforts. "Kneel with me" is a literal act of supplication, signifying a request for help and seeking divine intervention. "Bear thy part" means to fulfill his role in the forthcoming actions.

"To rouse our Roman gods with invocations": This specifies their immediate action: praying to the Roman gods. "Rouse" implies awakening the gods from a state of indifference. "Invocations" are prayers or calls for help, a plea to the gods.

"That they will suffer these abominations,": This explains the purpose of the invocations: to persuade the gods to intervene against the "abominations," referring to the rape of Lucrece and the resulting disgrace.

"Since Rome herself in them doth stand disgraced,": This provides the reasoning behind the invocation, explaining why the gods should act. It states that the heinous acts dishonor Rome itself, not just Lucrece. This uses the literary device of synecdoche, where "Rome" represents the Roman people and the entire state, while "them" refers to the actions of Tarquin and the other corrupt individuals.

"By our strong arms from forth her fair streets chased.": This outlines the ultimate goal: to drive the perpetrators, specifically the perpetrator, Tarquin, and anyone who enables him, from Rome. "Her fair streets" emphasizes the beauty and innocence of the city that is being violated. "Chased" implies swift and forceful expulsion.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza is a rallying cry. It's a call to action for Brutus to overcome his grief and join the speaker (likely a close companion of Lucrece or a key figure in the plot) in seeking vengeance. The speaker urges Brutus to turn from private sorrow to public action. They will appeal to the Roman gods for help and then take matters into their own hands, driving out those who have disgraced Rome. This highlights the shift from personal tragedy to a political and moral imperative to act. The stanza is filled with emotional intensity and a sense of urgency, setting the stage for the revolt against Tarquin and the establishment of the Roman Republic.

“Courageous Roman, do not steep thy heart
In such relenting dew of lamentations,
But kneel with me, and help to bear thy part
To rouse our Roman gods with invocations,
That they will suffer these abominations,—
Since Rome herself in them doth stand disgraced,—
By our strong arms from forth her fair streets chased.

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Literary Devices Highlights:

Metaphor: "relenting dew of lamentations" (comparing tears to a yielding substance) Synecdoche: "Rome" (representing the Roman people and state)
Direct Address: "Courageous Roman"
Alliteration: "But kneel with me, and help to bear thy part"
Imagery: "fair streets" evokes visual image
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Stanza 263 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 263 from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece":
Individual Parts Breakdown:

"Now, by the Capitol that we adore,"

"Now": Indicates the beginning of a solemn declaration or oath.
"by the Capitol that we adore": The Capitol was the most important temple in Rome, housing the temples of the gods and the seat of the government. The phrase emphasizes the sacredness
of the location and the oaths being sworn.
Literary Device: Apostrophe: The speaker addresses the Capitol as if it can hear and witness their oath.

"And by this chaste blood so unjustly stained,"

"And by": Continuation of the oath-taking.
"this chaste blood": Refers to Lucrece's blood, spilled due to her suicide after being raped. The adjective "chaste" emphasizes her purity and the injustice of her violation.
"so unjustly stained": Highlights the unfairness and the violation of Lucrece's innocence. Literary Device: Personification: Blood is often personified to carry the weight of innocence and the brutality of the crime.

"By heaven’s fair sun that breeds the fat earth’s store,"

"By heaven’s fair sun": Swearing by the sun, a symbol of life, warmth, and the divine.
"that breeds the fat earth’s store": The sun is attributed with giving the earth fertility and thus supporting life and abundance.
Literary Device: Metaphor: The sun's life-giving properties are metaphorically linked to the sustenance of their ideals.

"By all our country rights in Rome maintained,"

"By all our country rights": Refers to the laws, customs, and principles of justice and order that form the foundation of Roman society.
"in Rome maintained": Emphasis that the principles are to be upheld.
Literary Device: Synecdoche: "Country rights" represents the entirety of the Roman legal and social system.

"And by chaste Lucrece’ soul that late complained"

"And by": Continuing the list of oaths
"chaste Lucrece' soul": Directly appeals to Lucrece's spirit, making her a witness to their vow. "that late complained": Indicates the soul of Lucrece that complained of the injustice of her situation, now is appealing for revenge.
Literary Device: Personification: The soul is described as though it is able to be present and complain.

“Now, by the Capitol that we adore,
And by this chaste blood so unjustly stained,
By heaven’s fair sun that breeds the fat earth’s store,
By all our country rights in Rome maintained,
And by chaste Lucrece’ soul that late complained
Her wrongs to us, and by this bloody knife,
We will revenge the death of this true wife.”

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"Her wrongs to us, and by this bloody knife,"

"Her wrongs to us": Referencing the injustice and harm Lucrece suffered, directly affecting those taking the oath.
"and by this bloody knife": Swearing by the instrument of Lucrece's death.
Literary Device: Symbolism: The bloody knife is a potent symbol of the violence, Lucrece’s death, and the act of vengeance they seek.

"We will revenge the death of this true wife.”

"We will revenge": The vow itself – to take revenge.
"the death of this true wife": Focuses on Lucrece’s status as a faithful wife and emphasizes
the gravity of her loss.
Literary Device: Repetition: The repetitive "by" structure reinforces the solemnity of the vow.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza contains a powerful oath sworn by the witnesses to Lucrece's suicide. It expresses their determination to avenge her death. They call upon everything sacred and important to them – the Capitol, Lucrece's chaste blood, the sun, their country's rights, Lucrece’s soul, and the knife itself – as witnesses to their commitment. The oath paints a picture of outrage, grief, and a deep sense of responsibility to restore justice and honor. The stanza effectively sets the stage for a plot driven by vengeance and righteous fury.
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Stanza 264 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down Stanza 264 from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece":

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"This said, he struck his hand upon his breast,"
"This said": This refers to something that has just been spoken or done (likely a declaration of vengeance or a commitment to action).
"he struck his hand upon his breast": This is a gesture, a physical act of demonstrating sincerity and conviction. It's a symbolic oath.

"And kissed the fatal knife, to end his vow;"
"And": Connects this action with the previous one.
"kissed the fatal knife": The knife is what Lucrece used to commit suicide, making it "fatal". The kiss is another act of reverence and a further sign of the commitment to avenge Lucrece's death. "to end his vow": Implies a vow or oath has been made and that this action is to confirm it. The vow is implied; the actions speak for themselves.

"And to his protestation urged the rest,"
"And": Connects this action with the previous one.
"to his protestation urged the rest": This suggests that Brutus, or whoever "he" is, is urging the others to join him in his declaration/oath. "The rest" refers to the other men present.

"Who, wond’ring at him, did his words allow."
"Who": Relates back to "the rest"

"wond’ring at him": The others are astonished or amazed by what Brutus has said/done.
"did his words allow": They agreed with what he was saying; they accepted his oath and its implications.

"Then jointly to the ground their knees they bow,"
"Then": Indicates the following happens after the previous lines.
"jointly to the ground their knees they bow": The men kneel together, showing reverence and further emphasizing their solemn commitment.

"And that deep vow which Brutus made before,"
"And": Connects this action with the previous one.
"that deep vow": Implies a serious and binding promise.
"which Brutus made before": Indicates that Brutus had already made a vow, which he is repeating.

"He doth again repeat, and that they swore."
"He doth again repeat": Brutus repeats his vow, reinforcing it.
"and that they swore": The others also took the oath; they swore together, committing to the
vow.

This said, he struck his hand upon his breast,
And kissed the fatal knife, to end his vow;
And to his protestation urged the rest,
Who, wond’ring at him, did his words allow.
Then jointly to the ground their knees they bow, And that deep vow which Brutus made before,
He doth again repeat, and that they swore.

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Literary Devices:

Symbolism:
Kissing the knife: The act of kissing the knife, which caused Lucrece's death, is highly symbolic.
It represents respect for Lucrece's sacrifice, and a commitment to the revenge.
Striking the breast: This is a symbolic gesture of self-commitment.
Kneeling: Kneeling symbolizes respect, submission to their cause.

Repetition:
The vow: The repetition of the vow (Brutus repeats it and the men repeat it) emphasizes its importance and commitment.
Alliteration:
"fatal knife"

Personification:
"fatal knife" - this implies the knife itself is responsible.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza describes the moment of a sacred oath being taken, likely to avenge Lucrece's death. The emphasis is on solemnity, commitment, and unity. Brutus, the leader, shows his dedication through physical actions (kissing the knife, striking his breast), which inspires the others to follow. The repeated vow, the kneeling, and the shared swearing all solidify the group's resolve and create a powerful image of loyalty and shared purpose. This establishes the men's dedication to the cause of revenge.

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Stanza 265 - Explanation

Original Stanza

🔍 Line-by-Line Analysis

Let's break down this stanza from Shakespeare's "The Rape of Lucrece":

Line-by-Line Breakdown:

"When they had sworn to this advised doom,"
"When they had sworn": Referring to the oath taken by Lucrece's family and friends.
"to this advised doom": This is the plan they had come up with after discussing what to do, it's a plan they thoughtfully considered. "Doom" here means a decision, or a planned fate.

"They did conclude to bear dead Lucrece thence,"
"They did conclude": They decided.
"to bear dead Lucrece thence": To carry the body of dead Lucrece away from where it was. "Thence" means from that place.

"To show her bleeding body thorough Rome,"
"To show her bleeding body": Their purpose was to display her corpse that was still bleeding. "thorough Rome": Throughout Rome. (Note the archaic spelling of "through.")

"And so to publish Tarquin’s foul offence;"
"And so to publish": With the purpose of making public.
"Tarquin's foul offence": Tarquin's wicked deed. The rape of Lucrece.

"Which being done with speedy diligence,"
"Which being done": After they carried out their plan.
"with speedy diligence": Quickly and efficiently.

"The Romans plausibly did give consent"
"The Romans plausibly": The people of Rome with convincing arguments (from the plan they made).
"did give consent": Agreed to something.

"To Tarquin’s everlasting banishment."
"To Tarquin's everlasting banishment": They consented to Tarquin being banished forever.

Literary Devices:

Alliteration: "speedy diligence" - the repetition of the "s" sound.
Irony: The irony lies in the fact that the initial act of violence (Tarquin's rape) leads to a chain of events, including the suicide, that result in a positive outcome (the banishment of the tyrant) for Rome.

Figurative Language: The stanza's effectiveness comes in its ability to represent the action of the poem, the events of the rape of Lucrece and its aftermath, which sets the scene for the exile of Tarquin, and the end of the Roman monarchy.

Overall Meaning:

This stanza describes the immediate aftermath of Lucrece's suicide and the plan her family and friends devise to avenge her. They decide to:

Carry Lucrece's body through Rome.

When they had sworn to this advised doom,
They did conclude to bear dead Lucrece thence,
To show her bleeding body thorough Rome,
And so to publish Tarquin’s foul offence; Which being done with speedy diligence,
The Romans plausibly did give consent
To Tarquin’s everlasting banishment.

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Publicly display her wounds to reveal Tarquin's crime.

Their actions, presented with speed and efficiency, ultimately led to the Romans agreeing to banish Tarquin. This stanza is a turning point, setting the stage for the end of Tarquin's reign and the eventual establishment of the Roman Republic. It encapsulates the plan, its execution, and the resulting consequence: the removal of the tyrant.

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